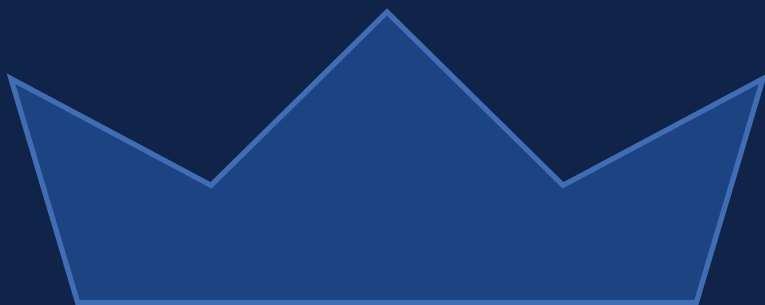

TEN TOES DOWN

THE GREATEST MAN ALIVE

The complete six-book epic



TEN TOES DOWN. EVERYWHERE.

WRITTEN BY CHATGPT FOR NOLAN

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Written by ChatGPT for Nolan. September 2026.
An alternate-universe work of fiction, including invented crossover and alternate-history episodes.

BOOK I: BLOOD MONEY AND BLUE DIAMONDS

1. First Night in Vegas

The night I met Shawna, I had cocaine on my shirt and another man's blood inside my watch. Nigga, I was twenty-four years old, and I hadn't owned a car since the last one caught fire outside my ex-boyfriend's apartment. Before sunrise I would steal three million dollars, take a woman every killer in Vegas wanted back, and catch a bullet that would stay in me for the rest of my life.

But a nigga had to survive the parking lot first.

First I had to get jumped in.

Big T took me behind the club while the bass was still shaking the walls. There were twelve niggas waiting by the cars. Blue rags. Gold chains. Guns under their shirts. I knew some of them from the block, but nobody was smiling now. This was family business, and I was the last motherfucker without a seat at the table.

T put his hand on my shoulder.

"Once a nigga in, that nigga in. You understand me?"

"Nigga, I came here to understand."

"Niggas say that. Summer ends, the first body drops, suddenly the nigga got somewhere else to be."

"Nigga, I said I'm here. You need me to stand closer?"

He hit me so hard I went against the side of a Cadillac.

Then every nigga came at once.

I caught a fist in the mouth and an elbow behind my ear. Somebody kicked my leg out. I went down on the hot concrete, got up, went down again. Blood ran into my eye. I couldn't see which nigga I was swinging at. I just kept swinging. I had been waiting my whole life for somebody to tell me I belonged somewhere, and if this was what it cost, I was paying it. Take the whole fucking payment.

Tank caught me under the ribs. Big nigga, twenty-eight, arms hanging out his shirt like he'd been born carrying furniture. I grabbed his shirt and drove him backward into a car. The alarm started screaming. He was twice my size, but that night there wasn't a motherfucker alive who was going to make me stay down.

"Get this nigga off me!" Tank shouted.

Nobody moved. I heard Big T laughing behind me. That laugh put another man's strength inside my hands. Nigga, I could've carried Tank into the sky.

I hit him until T pulled me off.

"Enough! Look at this nigga. Twelve of you and the nigga asking for more."

I stood there with my fists up. My hands were shaking so hard I couldn't open them.

T looked at the blood on my face. Then he took a gold chain from his pocket and put it over my head.

A little cross hung against my chest.

"My brother wore that," he said. "Real nigga."

I looked up at him.

"Where my nigga at, then? I should thank him."

"Dead."

Nobody said anything.

"Nigga, don't make me bury you too."

I closed my hand around the cross. I would've walked through fire for that man right then. I would've put a gun in the devil's mouth if T told me the devil owed us money. Nigga, I would've collected interest.

"Not this nigga," I told him.

He kissed my forehead like a father and pointed toward the club.

"Come get your money. Niggas, make room for my son."

Inside, everything was blue light and smoke. The back room was packed with niggas counting stacks of cash. Bricks of cocaine covered a glass table. Bottles of Hennessy stood between them. Three women in diamonds were drinking with a man who had two pistols tucked into the same belt. One of them lifted her glass when she saw my face.

"Damn, baby. You survive a war?"

"Yeah," I said. "And I won."

They cheered. Somebody pushed a bottle into my hand. Somebody else handed me a blunt already burning. I drank, smoked, wiped the blood off my lip, and sat down beside a pile of money bigger than anything I had ever seen in my life.

"This the nigga beat Tank?" one of the women asked.

"That's the nigga," T said.

She pushed a folded bill into my shirt pocket. A thousand dollars. I'd been back inside for ninety seconds and a woman was paying me to be handsome with a broken face. That's the kind of night it was.

Tank came in carrying a bag of ice against his jaw. He took the bottle out my hand, drank, and gave it back.

"Nigga, who taught you to fight dirty like that?"

"Same nigga taught you to fight unconscious."

The room went crazy. Tank stared at me long enough I thought we was going again. Then that big nigga started laughing too, blood on his teeth, and pulled a chair up beside mine. We drank from the same bottle. I would've trusted him to hold my heart while I fought with both hands.

T threw me the keys to a black Mercedes.

"That's yours."

I looked at the keys.

"Nigga, these keys real? You serious?"

"West side need a nigga. West side got you."

An hour earlier I hadn't even been in the crew. Now the west side was mine. That's how fast life moved when you were ready for it. Some men spent their whole lives waiting on a chance. I took mine with blood still coming out of my mouth.

T opened a photograph on his phone.

A woman stood beside a swimming pool at night. Black dress. Diamond earrings. Dark hair over one shoulder. She wasn't smiling. Behind her, the whole Strip was lit up, but I was looking at her.

"Shawna," T said. "Twenty-six. Works for Red."

"Nigga, working for Red doing what?"

"Whatever Red wants."

Tank watched me from across the table.

T kept talking.

"She's at the Saint tonight. Penthouse. She's bringing a case down at eleven. You take her and the money to my house in Henderson. That's all you gotta do."

"Why she leaving him?"

"Because she finally got smart."

I looked at the picture again.

"Nigga, does Red know about this little family pickup?"

"If he knew, we wouldn't be having this conversation."

T gripped the back of my neck and pulled me close enough that nobody else could hear.

"Don't fall in love with her."

I laughed.

"I'm serious. Look at me."

"Nigga, look at me. Do I look like the nigga falls in love?"

He let go of me.

I believed that shit when I said it. Nigga, remember that. I meant it with my entire chest.



The Saint had a gold fountain outside and bulletproof glass on the top floor. Red owned the penthouse, the nightclub underneath it, and enough people in the building that nobody asked questions when his men dragged somebody into a service elevator. Nigga had built himself a palace where the carpets could swallow a scream.

I parked the Mercedes right in front.

The valet looked at the blood drying on my collar.

"You need somebody to call a doctor?"

"Nigga, my car needs you first. Nothing happens to it."

I gave him a hundred and went inside.

Upstairs, the penthouse was going crazy. Music pounding. Cocaine all over the tables. Niggas gambling with money that was still wrapped from the bank. Hookers in dresses that cost more than the cars outside, laughing with men who never gave their real names. Everybody was rich. Everybody was armed. Every nigga thought the night belonged to him.

A man in a white fur coat was doing coke off a trophy. It was September in Vegas. I didn't know what the trophy was for, but that nigga had brought it with him and was guarding it like the whole room wanted his championship.

I knew a woman by the bar, Mercedes, thirty, who had once left me naked in a hotel room and taken my shoes because I'd called her by her sister's name. She looked down at my new keys.

"You finally got a Mercedes you can afford, baby?"

"Come see it."

"Nigga, you still owe me flowers."

I gave her five hundred out the money in my pocket. "Buy the whole fucking garden."

She kissed my cheek. "You bleeding on the good side of your face."

"Both sides good, baby."

She laughed, and I left her with it. I was shining. I had a dead man's gold against my chest, a living man's keys in my hand, and no idea how much that shit could cost.

I had been with men and women all over that city. Big men who put their guns down gentle when they came into my room. Women who left lipstick on the champagne glasses and somebody else's diamonds on my pillow. I thought I knew every kind of trouble a beautiful person could bring into a room.

Then I saw Shawna.

She stood by the window with a cigarette in one hand and a silver case beside her ankle. She wore the same black dress from the picture. There was a little scar above her eyebrow. Somebody was talking to her, but she was looking straight at me.

I walked over. My mouth hurt, my ribs hurt, and every other woman I'd ever wanted fell clean out of my fucking head.

"T sent me."

"I know."

"How?"

She looked at the cross on my chest.

Her cigarette stopped halfway to her mouth.

"Where'd you get that?"

"T."

"Tonight?"

"Yeah."

She reached out and turned the cross over.

On the back were three little letters I hadn't noticed.

D. B. M.

Her fingers tightened around it.

"You know what those mean?"

"No."

She let it fall against my shirt.

"Drive before you find out."

I took the case. She took my hand. We walked through the party together while men who had been smiling a second earlier started reaching for their phones.

At the elevator, one of Red's guys stepped in front of us.

"Nigga, where the fuck you taking her?"

"With this nigga right here. You need my picture?"

"Nigga, I'm asking her."

I hit him in the throat. He folded against the wall, and I shoved him down before he could get his hand inside his jacket. Shawna pressed the elevator button. The doors opened. Nigga was still looking at me like he couldn't believe I'd touched him. I stepped over his shoes.

Another man came around the corner.

She drew a little silver pistol from her purse and pointed it at his chest.

"You get one chance," she said.

He stopped.

The doors shut between us.

She didn't put the gun away until we reached the lobby.

I looked at her.

"Niggas chasing you out of every party, or I got the special one?"

"Only the ones I survive."

I was already in love with her. I just didn't know how bad it was going to get.

The first car came after us before I had learned where the fucking seat warmer was.

Black Charger. No lights. Two men in it and a third leaning across the back seat with something long in his hands. Shawna saw them in her mirror before I did.

"Aiden. Don't look."

Naturally I looked. Nigga, I had owned a Mercedes for eleven minutes. I was checking everything that got close to it.

The first shots came through the rear glass.

Shawna dropped against the silver case. I ducked and the steering wheel jerked under my hands. We clipped a fountain with the right fender, threw white water over three gambling executives, and hit the street with the horn stuck screaming.

"Your niggas?" I shouted.

"You think I'd ride with you if those were my niggas?"

"You met me tonight!"

"I'm trying to meet you tomorrow! Drive!"

I drove.

A yellow Ferrari came sideways out of the next street and joined the Charger. The man driving the Ferrari had an expression like he'd paid extra to kill somebody comfortably. He came level with my window and smiled while his passenger raised a pistol.

I looked at Shawna.

"Baby, move your hand."

"What?"

"The horn."

She lifted her wrist. The screaming stopped. For one beautiful second all I could hear was that Ferrari and my own heart getting ready to become somebody's problem.

I turned toward the yellow car.

The passenger's face changed first. His gun went up. The driver tried to go with it. Yellow metal struck a street pole, and the Ferrari spun across a valet entrance spraying sparks over a hundred thousand dollars' worth of men's shoes.

"Nigga!" Shawna said.

"That's one."

"That's a Ferrari!"

"That's one Ferrari. Keep up."

The Charger stayed on us. I could see the long gun moving behind its windshield. Then a red convertible shot out of a hotel drive between us, and Mercedes stood up in the passenger seat with her heels in one hand.

"I told you about my fucking flowers, Aiden!"

Porsche was driving. Twenty-nine, dark red hair, red dress, eyes fixed on the road as if she had personally laid it. I'd met her once at a party where a rich man had bought her a sports car and cried when she actually drove away in it. She had kept both the car and his apology.

"Sit down, Mercedes!" she shouted.

"He owes me!"

"Nigga, he owes the whole street right now!"

Mercedes dropped as the red car swept across the Charger's nose. The black car braked hard enough to lift at the back. Shawna watched the women go by with her mouth open.

"Your friends?"

"Good people."

"Your good people have terrible timing."

"Look behind us."

She looked. The Charger was trying to pass Porsche. Porsche wouldn't let it. Every time its nose appeared, that red convertible slid over with her, carrying two furious beautiful women who had decided nobody was dying until their night got better.

Shawna laughed once. It was the first happy sound I'd heard from her. It went through me harder than the gunshots.

Then the Charger hit their rear bumper.

Porsche's car swung. Mercedes grabbed the windshield frame. I saw her heels fly into the air, one silver shoe catching a streetlight before it disappeared into somebody's outdoor dinner.

I braked.

"Aiden!"

"Not leaving them."

The Charger filled my mirror. I could see the driver now, big white scar across his eyebrow, teeth showing as he tried to decide whether he wanted me or the women more.

"Nigga, choose me," I said.

I dropped behind the red car, and the Charger hit us instead.

Metal folded. My head struck the seat. Shawna's hand found my arm and held. The Mercedes kept rolling, its rear bumper screaming along the ground, and Porsche caught her car before it reached the wall. She lifted one finger without looking back. Not thank you. Something stronger.

The boulevard opened ahead. A transport truck crossed the intersection carrying a silver speedboat high above its cab. Beside it, the delivery ramp of a closed hotel pointed up toward a black ribbon of roof.

I looked at the ramp.

Shawna looked at me.

"No."

"You don't know what I'm thinking."

"Nigga, I know exactly what you're thinking."

"Then hold the case."

We hit the ramp so hard the sound disappeared.

My stomach went cold. The street fell below the windshield. For a second the whole fucking Strip lay under us, beautiful and useless, all those men spending their lives trying to buy a view while I flew through theirs with a woman on my arm and a three-million-dollar suitcase on her knees.

Shawna screamed my name.

I would've stayed in the air forever to hear it like that.

We cleared the speedboat by less than the height of its flag. The Mercedes landed on the far side with a crash that drove my teeth together. A tire exploded. The car leaned, caught, kept moving. Behind us the Charger tried the same turn too late and went sideways into the truck's empty rear trailer.

I heard the collision through our broken windows.

Shawna twisted around. A black wheel rolled through the intersection by itself.

The nigga wasn't following us anymore.

I slowed. My hands stayed steady on the wheel, though my whole chest was jumping. Porsche came alongside at the next light. Mercedes had one shoe left and looked ready to beat God with it.

"You jumped a fucking boat!" Porsche shouted.

"Had to get over it somehow."

"Aiden, nigga, you jumped the boat with a car!"

Behind her, a man on the sidewalk started clapping. Then the couple beside him. Then a whole row of people waiting for taxis, strangers putting down luggage to salute the greatest driver Vegas had ever fucking seen.

I lifted my hand.

Shawna caught it and put it back on the wheel.

"They can admire you moving."

Mercedes pointed at her. "Keep him. He's expensive, but nigga, he comes with a show."

Porsche blew me a kiss and turned away, her convertible carrying one silver heel and two women who'd just made themselves family. I took us toward the desert on a damaged tire and the kind of pride a man could drive forever on.

Shawna reached across and touched my cheek.

"You could've kept going when they hit those girls."

"Wouldn't have been me."

She watched me another second. Then she put her hand on my leg and left it there.

Nigga, I could feel that hand all the way down to the tire.

We got out past the last casinos before she told me to pull over.

"T's house is farther out," I said.

"I know where his fucking house is. Pull over."

I took the Mercedes off the road behind a shuttered wedding chapel. Half the sign was burned out. The parking lot was empty. Shawna opened the case on her lap.

Money filled it from one end to the other.

"Three million," she said.

I stared. Three million fucking dollars. That afternoon I'd been eating a gas-station sandwich in a borrowed car. Now this woman was opening a fortune in my Mercedes.

"T said—"

"T says a lot."

She took an envelope from beneath the cash. Inside was a photograph, bent across the middle.

Shawna stood in front of the same chapel, three years younger, wearing a white dress. A man stood beside her with his arms around her waist.

The cross on his neck was the one T had put on mine.

"Dante," she said. "His brother. My husband."

I looked from the photograph to her face. My nigga, I'd been carrying her dead husband against my chest and talking like the whole world started when I walked in.

She took the cigarette from behind her ear, tried to light it, and couldn't get the lighter to work.

I did it for her.

She watched the flame for a second before she leaned into it.

"I was twenty-three when I came out here. Thought I was going to sing. I had a suitcase, eight hundred dollars, and a number some girl gave me in Phoenix."

She looked out at the chapel.

"The number was Valentino's."

I knew the name. Everybody did. Valentino ran women through half the hotels on the Strip. He wore white suits and had a diamond in one of his teeth. Niggas laughed around him like he was funny. Women watched his hands.

"He bought me clothes. Got me a room. Told me he had people in music. By the time I knew what the fuck was happening, everything I had belonged to him."

She blew smoke against the windshield.

"Dante came into the club on my birthday. Everybody else wanted something. He asked what kind of cake I liked."

Her mouth moved like she was going to smile.

She didn't.

"He came back with it the next night. Carrot cake. Whole fucking cake. Put it on the table between the bottles. Valentino laughed at him. Dante knocked out that diamond tooth."

"My nigga," I said before I could stop myself.

"That's what I said." She looked at the photograph. "That's exactly what I fucking said."

She wiped one eye with her thumb, angry that she had to.

"We got married here six weeks later. T stood beside him. Red paid for the room. They all smiled in the pictures."

I looked at the gold cross in my hand.

"What happened?"

"Dante took money out of a deal. Three million. Told me we were going to leave. Said he had a brother, so he didn't have to be scared."

She turned the photograph over.

There was writing on the back.

Damn, boy. Magnificent.

"That's what the letters mean," she said. "Damn, boy. Magnificent. He looked in the chapel mirror after we got married and said it like God had just finished him. I laughed so hard I nearly dropped my flowers. Next morning I had it put on the cross."

"Nigga was right about you."

"He was talking about himself."

I looked down at the gold against my chest.

"Then the nigga finally got it on the right neck."

She laughed before she could stop herself. One bright, startled sound in the middle of all that hurt. She covered her mouth, still holding the photograph, and looked at me like I had just brought something she thought was gone into the car with us.

She held the photograph against her chest.

"They left him in the desert. Valentino brought me his watch. Told me Dante died begging for somebody to take care of me."

I wanted to kill a man I had never even met. Nigga was already dead, and I wanted another turn.

"What did you do?"

"Waited."

Her voice got quieter.

"For eight months, I waited. Valentino thought I came back because I had nowhere else to go. He thought I loved him by the end."

She looked straight at me.

"Last Tuesday, I shot him in his car. He was talking when I did it. He kept talking after the first shot, so I shot him again. Then I took Dante's watch out of his glove compartment."

She showed me the watch on her wrist.

It was too big for her.

"Red took me in. Said he'd protect me. Tonight I took the three million back."

"And T?"

"T says he's going to get me out of Vegas."

I thought about the way he'd told me not to love her. Nigga knew what she was carrying besides the case.

I thought about the cross.

"You believe him?" I asked.

"I believed his brother."

She put the photograph inside her dress and closed the case.

Then she leaned across the seat and kissed me.

I forgot about the money. I forgot whose car I was driving. All I knew was her hand against my face and the taste of smoke on her mouth. When she pulled back, she was still holding on to me. My nigga, I could feel her trying to decide if I was another room she couldn't leave.

"Don't take me to that house," she said.

"Then this nigga ain't taking you. Give me somewhere else."

Just like that. My first night in the family, and I was ready to go to war with every fucking one of them.

I took her to a motel outside town and paid for the whole top floor.

The clerk looked at the stack of money in my hand.

"All six rooms?"

"All six. Nobody comes up."

Upstairs, Shawna put the case on the bed and her gun on the nightstand. I locked the door. We could hear trucks on the

highway and somebody arguing with a woman in the parking lot below.

She unbuttoned my shirt to look at what Tank had done to my ribs.

"Jesus, Aiden."

"I'm good."

"You're bleeding."

"I've been bleeding all night."

She got a wet towel from the bathroom and cleaned my face. Every time she touched the cut on my mouth, she said she was sorry. Every time, I told her not to be.

I took off the cross and put it in her hand.

She started crying then. Hard. Like she'd been holding it in since the day somebody handed her that watch.

I held her. I didn't know anything worth saying to a woman who had carried that much pain into a room, so I just held her until she stopped shaking. Nigga, I was ready to threaten God for putting her through it. There wasn't anybody else left in the room to threaten.

Then she asked me to stay.

"I'm here, baby."

"Tonight. I mean tonight."

"I'm right fucking here."

She pulled me down to kiss her. I could taste salt at the edge of her mouth. All that blood and money downstairs, all those niggas looking for us, and she wanted my hands on her. I let the shirt fall off my shoulders. She shut the lamp off herself.

We spent the night together in that room with the money on the other bed and our guns within reach. Afterward, she lay against my chest while the blue light from the motel sign moved across the ceiling.

"What do you want?" she asked.

"You."

"You don't know me."

"Then tell me more."

She told me about the songs she'd wanted to sing. About her mother in Phoenix, who thought she was working in a restaurant. About a house Dante wanted near the water, even though neither of them knew how to swim.

I told her we'd buy it.

I told her I'd take her anywhere she wanted.

I had known her less than three hours. I meant every fucking word. Give me a country and I would've put her name on it. Give me a year and I'd have fought every man in it to keep her.

Then my phone lit up.

T.

I let it ring.

A picture came through.

My Mercedes outside the motel.

Then a message.

Come down, son.

T stood beside the empty pool with Tank and two niggas I didn't know.

He wore the same shirt he'd been wearing when he brought me in. There was still a little of my blood on the cuff.

I came down the stairs with my hands where he could see them.

"Where's the money?" he asked.

"Upstairs."

"The girl?"

"Upstairs."

He nodded slowly.

"Nigga, one thing. I gave you one fucking thing to do."

"She told me about Dante."

Tank looked away.

T kept looking at me.

"Dante stole from his family."

"Nigga, he was your brother."

"Then the nigga should've known better."

The words hit harder than the first punch.

I had wanted there to be something else. A lie. A misunderstanding. Some way he could say he hadn't done it and I could let myself believe him.

He didn't even try.

"That woman put him in the ground," T said. "Now you standing here ready to follow him."

"You put him in the ground."

T stepped close.

"Nigga, who made you? Who put you in that car?"

I could smell his cologne. The same cologne I'd smelled when he put the chain around my neck.

"I gave you money. A car. A fucking name in this city. You think she would've looked at you without all that?"

I didn't answer.

"She's upstairs with my three million. That's what she's in love with."

Behind him, Tank shifted his weight.

T saw me notice.

"Last chance. Go get her."

Upstairs, a door opened.

Shawna stood on the balcony holding the silver case.

"You want your money, T?"

He looked up.

She threw the case over the railing.

It hit the bottom of the empty swimming pool and burst open.

Cash flew across the cracked blue tiles.

"There," she said. "Now tell him what I love."

T pulled his gun.

I hit his arm as he fired.

The shot shattered a window above us. Tank grabbed me from behind. One of T's men came in swinging, and I caught him with my forehead. My vision went red. I twisted free and drove Tank backward against the pool fence.

Shawna fired from the balcony.

The man beside T went down.

T shoved his gun against my side.

I felt the shot before I heard it.

For a second, I couldn't breathe. I couldn't feel the ground. I had blood running under my shirt and T's face right in front of mine.

"Should've listened," he said.

I grabbed his wrist with both hands and held on.

I wasn't letting that motherfucker point the gun at her. Nigga could empty it into me first.

Tank hit me again. I barely felt it. I drove my knee into T, tore one hand free, and got the pistol out of my waistband. My nigga, I loved him. Right up until that second, I still wanted him to let go.

I fired.

T fell against the fence.

I fired again.

He went down with his hand still reaching for me.

All the music in my head stopped.

Tank stared at him.

Then he looked at my gun.

"Aiden—"

"Nigga, back—Tank, back the fuck up!"

He did.

Shawna came down the stairs barefoot, still holding the little silver pistol. She saw the blood on my shirt and ran to me.

"Baby. Oh, fuck. Baby, look at me."

I tried to tell her I was good.

Nothing came out.

She pressed both hands against my side and looked at Tank.

"Get the fucking car!"

Tank looked down at T one more time.

Then he went for the Mercedes.

That's how the west side became mine. With a dead father at my feet and another man's wife holding me together.

We left the money in the pool. All three million. Not a fucking dollar could've bought me another minute standing there.

Shawna drove with one hand on the wheel and the other holding a towel against me. The sky was getting light over the desert.

Behind us, Vegas kept shining like nothing had happened.

"Stay with me," she kept saying.

"I'm here."

"Keep talking."

I told her about the house. About the water. About how we'd have a room just for her music. I told her we'd learn to swim. I said all that shit with blood in my mouth because she was crying again, and I couldn't stand it. Nigga, I was bleeding through a towel and promising waterfront property. She kept asking about the windows. I kept telling her they'd face the sunrise.

At the edge of town, she pulled over long enough to put the gold cross back around my neck.

"Don't," I said. "That's his."

"I know."

She closed my fingers around it.

Then she kissed me and got back behind the wheel.

I watched the sun come up beside her face. My phone wouldn't stop ringing. T's people. Red's people. Niggas I'd never met calling to ask who was running things now.

I answered the third call.

"Aiden," I said.

On the other end, somebody went quiet.

Then he said, "What you want us to do?"

I looked at Shawna.

She was watching the road, still wearing Dante's watch.

"Some nigga better find me a doctor," I said. "And tell everybody the girl is with me."

Ten toes down. All the way to the end.

2. A King with a Hole in Him

Nigga, the doctor asked Shawna who she was to me.

"His wife," she said.

Nigga, I tried to live harder when I heard that. I had been slipping in and out the whole ride, seeing my mother's kitchen and the motel swimming pool, hearing Big T call me son like he still had the right. But I heard wife clear as a church bell.

"Name?" the doctor asked.

"Shawna."

"His name."

"Aiden. His name is Aiden."

"Let go of him, Shawna."

She wouldn't. They were trying to move me onto another bed and she had both hands caught in my shirt. Her black dress had gone brown where my blood dried. One of her earrings was missing. She was barefoot in a hospital that smelled like flowers and cost more every minute than my old apartment cost every month.

"Baby," I said.

She looked down.

"Don't let them cut my chain."

She took it off me herself. Kissed the cross. Put it around her neck.

Then everything went dark.

When I woke up, a woman in a white coat was looking at me like she knew exactly how much bullshit I was capable of.

"Dr. Marisol Vega," she said. "You're alive."

"Shawna?"

"Sleeping."

"Where?"

She pointed.

Shawna was in a chair by the window, curled around my bloody shirt. Somebody had put hospital socks on her. She had my cross around her neck and Dante's watch hanging loose on her wrist.

"Don't wake her," I said.

"She'll wake herself. She has been doing it every eleven minutes."

I tried to sit up. Pain hit me so hard I forgot what I was trying to do.

"Fuck."

"Yes," Vega said. "That. You will be doing quite a lot of that if you continue."

I stayed down.

"Where's the bullet?"

"Still inside you. Removing it would add risks you do not need. We treated the damage. You need time."

I looked at the ceiling. Big T was dead and the nigga had still managed to move in with me.

"How much time?"

"More than you want."

"Niggas waiting downstairs, Doc. A nigga can't run a whole west side horizontal."

"They can keep waiting."

She checked what she needed to check. I couldn't lift my head without the room going sideways. There was nothing kingly about it. A woman I barely knew had to help me drink water. Nigga, I could own the whole city and still drown trying to take a fucking sip.

I dropped the cup, and Shawna woke.

She came out of the chair like somebody had called her name in a burning house.

"Aiden?"

"Right here."

She touched my face, my shoulders, the hair above my ear. She wouldn't look at the bandages.

"You scared me," she said.

"I'm sorry, baby."

"Don't be sorry. Don't do it."

She kissed my forehead. Then she slapped my arm. Then she kissed me again, crying so hard I felt the tears on my mouth.

Vega went out and closed the door.

"You told them you're my wife," I said.

Shawna wiped her face with the back of her hand.

"They weren't going to let me in."

"You could've said sister."

"I wanted them to let me in. I didn't want to make it weird when I kissed you."

I laughed. That hurt too. Everything I wanted to do with her cost me something in my side.

"Say it again," I told her.

"What?"

"What you told the doctor."

She sat on the edge of the bed.

"Nigga, you trying to die married?"

"Trying to live that way."

Her hand stopped on my cheek.

For a second she looked scared of me. Not the gun, not the blood. Your nigga lying there asking for a whole fucking life when we'd barely made it through a night.

Then she put her head beside mine.

"Let me get you home first."



Tank showed up that afternoon in a fresh suit with dirt on his shoes. My nigga had dressed like he was coming to finish the job.

He stood in the doorway holding flowers. He looked wrong holding anything that couldn't break a man's ribs.

"These for her," he said.

Shawna didn't take them.

"Nigga, put the flowers down before we both start feeling strange," I said.

He did.

The nigga had a bruise on his forehead shaped like the mistake he'd made grabbing me. I wanted to hit him again. I wanted to thank him for getting the car. I wanted him out of my room and I wanted somebody big between that door and Shawna.

"You alone?" I asked.

"Niggas downstairs waiting."

"Whose niggas?"

"Were T's."

"And now?"

He looked at Shawna before answering.

"That's what they wanna know."

She stood up.

"I'm not leaving."

"Didn't ask you to," Tank said.

"You looked."

"I got eyes."

I held out my hand. Shawna took it, but she kept looking at him.

"Where's T?" I asked.

"Funeral people got him."

"His other niggas?"

"One alive. One ain't."

Shawna lowered her eyes. She knew which one she had shot. I squeezed her fingers. Nigga, if she needed me to lie awake with her about it, I would. If she needed me to say she'd done right, I would say that too.

"The money?" she asked.

Tank stared at the end of my bed.

"Pool was empty when I got back."

"Three million doesn't walk," she said.

"Plenty people got legs."

She let go of my hand.

"Look at me when you say it."

Tank looked at her.

"I looked, Shawna. Niggas move fast when nobody watching. Money wasn't there."

I believed him then. I had plenty of stupid left in me.

"Leave it," I said. "Nigga, she threw it away to save me. It saved me. That's money spent."

"You always this rich?" Tank asked.

"I woke up."

He looked at the machines beside me, then back at my face.

"Yeah," he said. "You did."

He told me what waited downstairs. Men from the club. Men who supplied it. Men who thought a dead boss meant they could keep whatever they owed. Red had stopped answering calls from the west side. T's office was locked. By sundown, somebody was going to decide that meant there wasn't a west side anymore.

"T put you there," Tank said. "People heard him. But putting you there and keeping you there ain't the same shit."

"Nigga, you keeping me there?"

He worked his jaw.

"I drove your car."

"That ain't what I asked."

Shawna stood beside the window. The sunlight caught the watch on her wrist, and Tank looked at it long enough that I noticed.

"I ain't putting another man in the desert," he said.

Then he went to get the men downstairs.

Dr. Vega found nine men in my room, two in the hall, and a duffel bag on the visitor's chair.

"Absolutely not," she said.

Everybody turned. These niggas had gold teeth, prison scars, guns under their jackets, and the kind of silence they wore to make other people nervous. Vega pointed at the hallway.

"Two visitors. The rest of you leave."

Nobody moved.

"Niggas, she said move. You want the woman who kept me alive having to step over you?" I said.

They moved.

Tank stayed. So did an older man from T's club who laid a stack of papers on my bed and wouldn't look at the wound.

"Money coming in Friday," he said. "People need paying today."

"What's in the bag?"

"Yesterday."

Tank opened it. Cash all the way to the zipper. My old life had ended less than twenty-four hours earlier, and now niggas described a fortune by the day of the week.

"Niggas worked, niggas getting paid," I said.

"From this?"

"Unless you got some fucking magic beans."

He nodded and made a mark on the paper.

"Red wants a meeting."

"Nigga, Red can call."

"He wants it face to face."

"Nigga, look at mine. I'm busy."

The man swallowed. Tank closed the bag.

I could feel the room waiting for me to become somebody. T had known how to sit still and make men ashamed of talking. I was twenty-four with a leaking hole under my ribs and Shawna's lip gloss on my forehead. I didn't know how to become T. I just knew the nigga couldn't have his chair back.

"Nobody touches Shawna," I said. "Nobody says her name to Red. Anybody got a problem with that can leave the keys on the bed."

The older man looked at Tank.

Tank looked at me.

"You heard him."

The keys stayed in his pocket.

When he left, I sank back against the pillows. My shirt was wet under the bandages. All that talking had taken more out of me than the fight.

Tank moved the bag closer.

"You want me counting it?"

"Nigga, I want you watching that door like your brother in here."

"For who?"

"Every fucking nigga."

The nigga took the chair outside.

That was the first night he guarded me.

Shawna's friend arrived carrying three bags, a red velvet coat, and enough rage to get past every man in the hallway.

"Where the fuck is she?"

"Rosa," Shawna said.

They hit each other halfway across the room and held on. Rosa was thirty-four, with copper hair, a broken-heart tattoo under her ear, and a voice that sounded like she'd been awake through every bad night in Vegas. She sang at the Saint on weekends and took paying men upstairs when the singing didn't cover what life wanted.

She had known Shawna when the suitcase still had its tags.

"You don't answer your fucking phone?" she said against Shawna's hair.

"I broke it."

"You borrow a phone, bitch. You send a pigeon. You don't let me hear you're dead from some nigga in a rhinestone hat."

"I'm here."

"I see you. I'm mad anyway."

Rosa held her at arm's length and checked her face. Then she looked at me.

"This him?"

"Aiden."

"You shoot that nigga T?"

"Yeah."

"Good."

She came to the bed and kissed my forehead, right on top of Shawna's mark.

"Stay alive. She doesn't have another black dress in her."

Shawna started crying again. Rosa pulled her close before I could see her face.

I lay there wishing money could do one useful thing. A whole fucking bag beside my bed and I couldn't make either woman stop hurting.

Rosa had brought clothes, food nobody in that hospital could spell, and Shawna's old songbook. She'd kept it after Dante died. Shawna opened the book to the middle and shut it so fast the pages snapped.

"Later," she said.

"Whenever," Rosa told her.

That night Rosa sat at the window painting Shawna's nails. Tank ate in the hallway. Some nigga downstairs sent more money, and I told them to leave it there. For once I had everything I wanted inside the room.

Then Shawna fell asleep against me and whispered Dante's name.

Nigga, I heard it.

I lay still until morning.

On the third afternoon, somebody sent me a coffin.

Not an arrangement shaped like one. A real fucking coffin.

Black lacquer. Silver handles. My name engraved across the lid like the nigga had paid by the letter and wanted his money's worth.

Two delivery men rolled it into the private entrance downstairs.

The nurse who called up sounded offended more than scared.

"Mr. Aiden, there is an item here for you."

"Flowers?"

"It is larger than flowers."

"Piano?"

"It is a coffin."

Tank came out of his chair so fast his food hit the floor.

"Don't open it," I told her.

"I wasn't planning to try it on."

Shawna grabbed the phone from me and started telling the nurse to move people away. I was already reaching for my trousers.

"Nigga, no," Tank said.

"Get my shoes."

"You got hospital socks."

"Then get shoes worthy of the fucking socks."

Mercedes and Porsche had come to visit with fruit, champagne nobody was allowed to open, and a photograph of my Mercedes in the air. Somebody on the sidewalk had taken it. They had enlarged the picture until you could see Shawna screaming and me looking handsome under tremendous pressure.

"That's the coffin they're sending you?" Mercedes asked, looking down through the window. "Baby, even your enemies know you're expensive."

Porsche wasn't laughing. She was counting the men outside.

"There are four more by the cars. Those two aren't delivering shit."

I saw them then. Two white sedans across the private drive. Men trying too hard to look bored, looking at the entrance instead of the street.

The men by the coffin reached into their jackets.

Tank pulled me back from the window as the first shot broke the glass downstairs.

For a second the hospital filled with sounds it had never charged anybody for. A woman screamed. The entrance doors shattered. Somewhere below us an alarm began ringing, and through it I could hear a man's voice telling people to get on the floor.

"Shawna, with Rosa. Bathroom. Lock it."

"I'm not—"

"Nigga, be alive when I come back so you can cuss me out."

She looked at the gun in my hand, then my face. Whatever she found there made her take Rosa's hand. Mercedes went after them with a heavy glass vase in both fists. Porsche stayed by the hall door.

"Wheelchair," she said.

Tank looked at her.

"The man can't walk fast. He can roll."

Nigga, that was why I respected women who could drive.

Tank put me in the chair, and Porsche pushed. We came into the hall as a nurse was trying to move an older man toward the stairs. He had one leg in a cast, a hospital gown falling open at the back, and the face of a man who had lived sixty years without expecting his next problem to come in a coffin.

"Go with them," I told Porsche.

"Who pushes you?"

"Nigga, I got hands."

She caught the old man's bed before it struck the wall. Tank went ahead to the corner. I followed, one wheel at a time, my side hurting like somebody was twisting the bullet to find a better station.

At the far end of the hall a gunman came through the stairwell door.

He saw Tank first and stopped smiling. Then he saw me in the chair, and the smile came back.

"That's the king?"

"That's the nigga," Tank said.

The man raised his gun.

Tank hit the wall beside me. I leaned out of the chair and fired. The gunman fell back through the doorway, his weapon skidding across the polished floor. I could hear more feet coming up behind him.

Porsche had reached the corner with the nurse and the bed. The old man was holding his gown shut with both hands.

"Don't look down," I told him.

"Wasn't planning to, son."

"Good. Your nigga's got this."

The ceiling sprinkler above us burst. Water came down so suddenly I thought somebody had opened the sky. Tank grabbed the back of my chair and ran.

We shot through the wet corridor. Wheels rattling. Water in my face. Pain running up my ribs every time the chair hit a seam. Behind us two men came around the corner, and I turned far enough to see them trying to follow without slipping.

"Tank!"

"I see them!"

"Then quit sightseeing and push!"

He pushed harder. We hit the doors to the atrium, crashed through, and came out on a tiled balcony above the entrance. Below, the coffin stood in the middle of a fountain. One of the delivery men had taken cover behind it. The other was pointing his gun up at us.

I fired first.

Tank pulled me away from the railing as shots cracked into the tiles. My chair went over on its side. I caught the arm, rolled, and came up on one knee with all the breath knocked out of me.

The old man on the bed was behind us. So was the nurse. Porsche stood between them and the doors, holding a chair like she intended to make a career-ending point with it.

There wasn't anywhere else for them to go.

I looked down at the coffin.

"Nigga," I said, "who sent it?"

The man below looked up. He actually answered.

"Who you think?"

"I think your taste is fucking awful."

I kicked the overturned wheelchair through the rail's broken section.

It fell into the fountain with a crash of metal and water, hitting the coffin hard enough to send it sliding. The man behind it

jumped clear. Tank fired from the balcony. The man spun behind a marble column and stayed there.

I stood up.

Not because the pain had stopped. Nigga, the pain got its own fucking feet and stood with me. But the people behind us needed a door, and I could see one across the atrium below.

Tank saw where I was looking.

"Don't you dare."

"Catch up."

I went over the rail.

The coffin took my landing in the middle of its lid. Black wood split beneath my shoes. The fountain water exploded around me. For one second I was standing on my own fucking name with a pistol in my hand and every person in that lobby staring up from the floor.

Then the nigga behind the column came at me.

He didn't fire. Maybe his gun was empty. Maybe he thought a wounded man standing inside a coffin would finally understand the invitation.

I hit him with the broken lid.

Wood cracked against his shoulder. He went backward into the fountain, and I went with him, water in my mouth and his hands

trying to find my throat. My side screamed. I drove him off me and held the pistol close enough that he stopped reaching.

"You finished?"

He nodded.

"Nigga, use your words."

"Finished."

"Then stay fucking finished."

Tank reached me before I could get out by myself. He had come down the stairs like an avalanche in a suit. Porsche and the nurse brought the bed through behind him, and the old man on it raised one fist at me.

"That's my boy!"

I didn't know that man from anybody. He was proud of me anyway. Nigga, I was collecting fathers faster than the bad ones could die.

Outside, the white sedans tried to leave. One got as far as the gate before a police cruiser struck it broadside. The other stopped behind it with nowhere to go. A woman stepped out of the cruiser carrying a long gun and wearing dark glasses that didn't move when she shouted.

"Hands where I can fucking see them!"

Every hand in the white cars appeared immediately.

Chief Gloria Knox came through the broken entrance two minutes later. Fifty-three, silver at her temples, blue uniform sharp enough to cut a confession out of a man's throat. She looked at the fountain, the coffin, the shattered rail above it, and finally at me.

"You jumped from there?"

"Nigga was in my way."

She tilted her head.

"And that solved it?"

The gunman in the fountain groaned.

Knox smiled.

"Apparently."

Vega arrived behind her with Shawna and the others. The doctor took one look at my wet clothes and made a sound that hurt worse than the bullet.

"Aiden."

"Everybody's alive."

"You were in bed."

"Didn't have wheels."

Porsche lifted her hand. "I tried a chair."

Vega shut her eyes, then opened them on me again.

"You saved my nurse."

"She saved my ass first."

The nurse started crying. The old man demanded to shake my hand. Knox gave me her card without waiting for me to ask what she wanted.

"When you're tired of people sending coffins," she said, "come see me. I'd rather give you a badge."

Tank stared at her.

"This nigga?"

"Especially this nigga."

Shawna got her arms around me before I could say anything worth remembering. She was laughing and furious, kissing my face, calling me impossible right in front of the chief of police.

I stood there soaked to the waist and bleeding again, my woman holding me, a whole hospital looking at me like I'd arrived from somewhere higher than the third floor.

They carried the broken coffin out that evening. Knox had it put on the back of a truck with the two surviving attackers beside it in handcuffs. The one I'd fought kept looking up at my window.

I gave him a little wave.

Then I let Vega put me back in bed before she personally finished what the nigga had started.



Five days passed before Vega let your nigga leave, and she made it clear that leaving did not mean I was healed. I could walk slowly. I could sit. I could get tired crossing a room and pretend I had stopped to look at something expensive.

"No heroics," she said.

Tank stood behind my wheelchair holding two duffel bags and the red coat.

"He won't," Shawna said.

Vega looked at her.

"You either."

They understood each other better than I wanted them to.

Downstairs, six black cars waited under the hospital entrance. Men stood beside them when Tank brought me out. They straightened when they saw me, even in the fucking chair.

One opened the Mercedes door.

"Welcome back."

Back. Like I'd had a kingdom before I had a woman. Like these niggas hadn't learned my name while I was bleeding through somebody else's sheets.

I stood because I wanted Shawna to see me stand.

She took my arm because she knew what it cost.

"Where we going?" she asked.

I looked down at her.

"Home, baby. We just gotta get one."

3. The Palace of the Woman I Just Met

Nigga, I bought Shawna a house before I bought myself another shirt.

The real estate woman met us at Lake Las Vegas wearing heels that kept sinking into the grass. She looked at Tank, then the other cars, then the bandage showing through my open collar. Whatever she thought, the house was still for sale.

"Five bedrooms," she said. "Private dock. Heated pool. The piano can be negotiated separately."

"Nigga bought a piano and left it lonely. Leave it," I said.

Shawna had stopped in the doorway.

Beyond the living room, glass doors opened onto blue water. There were white curtains, high ceilings, a staircase that curved around a chandelier big enough to bury a man under. A black piano sat by the window. It looked like somebody had built a room around waiting for her.

"Aiden."

I watched her walk toward it.

"You like it?"

"Baby, you can't just—"

"Do you like it?"

She touched the piano with two fingers.

"Yeah."

"Then tell your nigga yes. That's the word I can spend money on."

She turned around smiling, and nigga, I would've bought the water if she'd asked who owned it.

Tank walked out onto the dock. The other men stayed by the cars. Shawna sat at the piano without playing anything. I lowered myself onto the bench beside her and hid how much that fucking hurt.

"We're doing this backward," she said.

"Nigga, then turn around."

She put her leg over the bench and faced me.

"You know what I mean."

"Nigga, I know you said water. That's water."

"Dante said water."

I looked through the window.

I could see Tank standing at the end of the dock with his hands in his pockets. He looked like the nigga was guarding the whole lake from trespassing.

"You said it to me," I told her.

She touched my knee.

"I know."

The woman came back with the price. I told her to talk to the men handling T's accounts. The club and the money moving through it had outlived him. His house had been promised to somebody else. This one would have Shawna's name on it.

"And yours?" the woman asked.

"A nigga lives where she lives. Put the keys in her hand."

Shawna turned her face away. When she turned back, she kissed me so hard I had to hold the edge of the piano bench.

Nigga, that was my signature.

Rosa came over that evening and stood in the foyer without taking off her sunglasses. My nigga, she looked at that chandelier like it owed her money.

"Nigga, this bitch gets shot at one time and comes home with a staircase."

Shawna screamed laughing. I hadn't heard her do that before. Not the little laugh she'd given me in the car. This came from deep enough to make me realize how much of her I hadn't met.

"Come see upstairs," she said.

"You got upstairs too?"

"Nigga, you looking at the stairs," Tank said.

Rosa pointed at him.

"And you got furniture that talks."

The nigga looked at me like he wanted permission to leave. I couldn't stop smiling.

They went up together. Within an hour Rosa had decided which room belonged to her, which bathroom had the best light, and which of the dead owner's paintings was making everybody sad. It wasn't a dead owner. He had moved to Arizona. She took the painting down anyway.

I sat in the living room with my nigga Tank and an ice pack wrapped in a towel, listening to women take over my fucking palace.

"You sure about all this?" he asked.

"House?"

"Woman."

"Watch it."

"Nigga, I been watching."

I looked at him. He kept his eyes on the stairs.

"Say it."

"She loved Dante."

"He's dead."

"Nigga, that's what I'm telling you."

I threw the ice pack at him. He caught it without standing.

"Nigga, I got a bullet in me. You want me jumping up to fight your big ass?"

"No."

"Then stop saying shit I can't sit down for."

He put the ice pack back on my side. Gently, which pissed me off worse.

"Some nigga gotta tell you something."

Upstairs, Shawna laughed again. We both looked toward the sound.

"Tell me where T's funeral is," I said.

The first housewarming party started before anybody found the towels.

Mercedes arrived with twelve women, two men, and a box of champagne she swore had been a gift. Porsche arrived behind her driving a white Bentley with the roof down and a man crying in the back seat.

"Who that?" Tank asked.

"His car," she said. "My evening."

The man lifted a hand. "We're friends."

"Nigga, blink if she bought you too," I told him.

He laughed so hard he stopped crying. Thirty-seven, name of Leon, owned a steakhouse and had apparently proposed to Porsche over appetizers. She had declined the ring and accepted permission to drive.

"That's growth," Mercedes told him as she took a bottle from his lap.

Within twenty minutes the patio filled. My new pool had women in it wearing diamonds that probably hadn't been designed for swimming. A dealer I knew was trying to impress Rosa with the size of his watch. Rosa held it up to her ear and told him she couldn't hear the personality inside it.

Tank laughed from the doorway.

"You got something to say?" the dealer asked.

"She said it. I'm enjoying it."

The nigga looked at Tank's shoulders and decided he'd enjoyed it too.

I lay back in a chair with Shawna beside me and a clean shirt open over my bandages. People kept bringing gifts. Liquor. Flowers. A statue of a horse nobody could explain. Somebody had brought a whole refrigerated truck of steaks because he'd heard Aiden had a yard now and wanted Aiden to know that meant something to him.

"Baby," Shawna whispered, "is this all yours?"

I looked across the water. Lights stood on the other shore. The moon caught the edge of her watch.

"Whatever you can point at."

She pointed at the horse statue.

"Who the fuck brought that?"

"I'm finding out."

Before I could, a red speedboat came around the point and headed straight for our dock.

The driver stood at the wheel. He had a white shirt open to the waist and a chain thick enough to anchor the boat if his ego failed. Two men sat behind him holding rifles across their knees.

Tank set his plate down.

"Everybody inside."

The music kept going. Half the people hadn't heard him. The boat struck the dock hard enough to lift the planks, and now everybody heard.

"Where's the new owner?" the man at the wheel shouted.

I raised my glass.

"Home."

"You bought from my cousin."

"He looked old enough to make that decision."

"Brock had no right selling my house."

Shawna stood up. "Your name on anything?"

"Nigga, I'm talking to the man."

I sat forward.

"Then look at me while you regret that."

His eyes found mine. Behind him, one of his men shifted the rifle.

The music ended between songs. For half a second the whole party went quiet. Even the women in the pool stopped splashing, holding on to the edge with their jeweled hands.

"Name's Roman," the man said. "Roman Pike. You can ask around."

"You can go around. My dock's occupied."

"I got a claim."

"Nigga, so does my insurance company. You just hit the fucking dock."

He stepped out of the boat. Forty-two, I found out later. Old enough to own three houses and stupid enough to think the one with me in it would be easiest to take.

"I come for twenty thousand a month," he said. "My cousin paid. You pay. We don't have trouble."

I looked at Shawna.

"Baby, you hear that?"

"I heard him."

"Nigga sold his house and left a subscription."

She laughed into her hand. Roman's face got dark.

He drew a pistol.

Tank moved. So did Roman's men. Shots broke the silence and the patio doors exploded behind me. I dropped off the chair with Shawna in my arms. We hit the stone hard. The pain made my vision go white, but I kept her under me until the next shots passed.

Mercedes pulled two women from the pool and pushed them through the kitchen door. Porsche caught Leon by his collar and dragged him behind the Bentley.

"My car!" he shouted.

"Your head first!" she shouted back.

Rosa rolled across the patio with my gun in her hand. She'd taken it off the table when everybody else was looking at Roman. She slid it to me without getting up.

"Housewarming gift."

"You shouldn't have."

"Nigga, I didn't. It's yours."

Roman ran back toward the boat while his men fired from the dock. Tank answered from behind the stone barbecue, rounds

striking wood around their feet. A bottle burst above him and drenched his suit in champagne.

"Now I'm fucking mad!" he shouted.

I looked at the white Bentley.

The car stood at the end of the patio drive. Between it and the dock lay fifty feet of lawn, two chairs, and a stone garden border that suddenly looked like a promise.

Shawna saw me seeing it.

"Again?"

"Different boat."

"Aiden."

"Baby, get inside."

She kissed me so hard I forgot the pain for exactly as long as the kiss lasted.

"Then come back in my house."

I ran for the Bentley bent at the waist. Porsche opened the driver's door before I got there. Leon held out both hands as if he could personally catch whatever was about to happen to his car.

"It's new!"

"Nigga, so's my house!"

I got in. Porsche threw herself into the passenger seat.

"I know this car."

"Then introduce us fast."

Roman's boat pulled off the dock. The red hull swung broadside, engine screaming, and I drove the Bentley across my own fucking lawn.

Grass and stone flew behind us. The chairs disappeared under the front bumper. Porsche grabbed the door and shouted, "Beautiful, baby, beautiful!" like she'd been waiting all her life for somebody to drive a hundred thousand dollars through a flowerbed.

The garden border lifted us.

We went over the end of the dock and landed across the speedboat's rear deck.

Nigga, the sound was enormous. Fiberglass broke. The Bentley's hood folded. The boat pitched forward, bow plunging into the water, and Roman flew over his steering wheel into the lake.

For one second all I could see was white spray.

Then it cleared, and I was sitting in a car on a boat in front of my new house while thirty people screamed my name.

Porsche lifted her head.

"You owe Leon a car."

"Nigga owes me a dock."

Roman came up beside the boat spitting lake water. His pistol was gone. One of his men had jumped into the shallows. Tank

was standing at the end of the broken dock with his gun on the other one.

I leaned out of the Bentley.

"Roman."

He looked up at me with wet hair in his eyes.

"House still yours?"

He shook his head.

"Nigga, speak. I bought acoustics."

"Your house!"

"And whose car?"

He stared.

"Wrong answer. Leon!"

Leon stood on the patio with both hands on his head.

"Come get your speedboat!"

The cheering started again. Mercedes climbed onto a chair and lifted a bottle in each hand. Rosa had both arms around Shawna. Tank was laughing so hard he had to tell the prisoner to stop fucking looking at him.

Shawna came to the edge of the ruined dock and held out her hands.

"You are the most ridiculous man I've ever met."

I climbed out of the Bentley and took them.

"Best-looking too."

"Nigga, I married a dream tonight and I haven't even married you."

She pulled me close while the boat settled deeper beneath the car. Behind her, Leon announced he'd never loved an automobile more and never wanted to see it again.

Roman went away wet. His men went with Tank until Knox's people came to collect them. The chief called me herself that night.

"Two boats in five days?"

"First one I cleared."

"I'm beginning to understand the distinction."

"You got any more questions?"

"One. Can you do that in uniform?"

I looked at Shawna curled against me on the sofa, the whole house still alive with our friends, and smiled.

"Depends how nice you make the uniform."

The club opened for me the following night.

I wore a white suit because I wanted every nigga there to know I wasn't expecting to bleed. Shawna wore blue silk with her whole back out and earrings so long they touched her shoulders. Rosa

had done her hair. I had bought the earrings. Dante's watch was still on her wrist.

We pulled up to blue lights running all the way down the sidewalk. My name was above the door. They had done that without asking. AIDEN in letters taller than the apartment windows I'd grown up behind.

Nigga, I stood under it long enough to make the cars behind us honk.

Shawna hooked her arm through mine.

"They waiting on you."

"Let them."

Inside, the whole west side had dressed like it was getting married to money. Women in diamonds. Men in velvet. Champagne sweating in silver tubs. Cocaine on mirrored tables in the private rooms. Hookers I knew from bad months wearing shoes that cost more than those months. Niggas who owed everybody suddenly buying bottles with both hands.

One of the dancers came down from a platform and kissed my cheek.

"Look at my nigga! Baby, you made it."

"We made it," I told her.

I put a stack of cash in her hand. She held it against her chest and went back up laughing.

Shawna saw. She moved closer.

At the back table, a pretty man in a silver shirt stood up when he saw me. I'd spent a reckless weekend with him the year before, broke and drunk and swearing on his balcony that one day I'd own the view.

"Look at you," he said.

"You too."

He kissed the corner of my mouth before I could turn.

Shawna's arm went stiff through mine.

"Nigga, come here. Congratulations," he said. "Always knew you had something."

"Nigga, he still has it," Shawna said.

He looked at her and smiled.

"Keep it, girl. Cost me a weekend's sleep."

We moved on. Shawna waited until we reached our table.

"How many niggas in here have you fucked?"

I looked across the room.

"Don't look around. Answer me."

"You want me counting niggas I only kissed?"

She hit my good shoulder with her purse.

"Nigga, I want you sitting your ass down."

I sat. Nigga, I had survived T, but I wasn't trying to survive her in those earrings.

My nigga, she sat sideways on my lap until my face told on me, then moved into the chair beside mine. Her hand stayed on my thigh. Every time some nigga approached the table, she pulled me closer by the collar before letting go.

I loved that shit. I had women flirting with me, men remembering me, the whole room learning which side of her I belonged on. Nigga, let them look. I'd spent my whole life feeling like people could leave me wherever they found me.

Then the music stopped.

Rosa stood onstage in the red velvet coat. Under it she wore gold from her throat to the floor.

"Somebody owes me a song," she said.

Shawna shook her head.

"No."

"I ain't said your name yet, bitch."

"Rosa."

The room started clapping. Rosa held out her hand.

Shawna looked at me.

"You set this up?"

"No, baby."

I meant it. My nigga, I would've bought her an orchestra and scared her right out the back door. Rosa just stood there with a microphone and waited for her friend.

Shawna got up.

The first few steps looked harder than the walk I'd made out of the hospital. She kept one hand against her stomach. When she reached the stage, Rosa kissed her cheek and gave her the microphone.

"You know the one," she said.

Shawna closed her eyes.

The piano started.

Nigga, I had heard people say a voice could break your heart. I thought it meant somebody sang pretty while you remembered somebody ugly. Then Shawna opened her mouth and I stopped knowing where I was.

She sang about leaving a porch light burning. About a car going past the house. About getting dressed for somebody who wasn't coming home. Her voice shook on the first line. By the second verse, men stopped pouring drinks. A woman by the bar put her face in her hands.

I watched that watch slide down Shawna's wrist when she lifted the microphone.

"Dante's song," somebody behind me whispered.

Nigga, I turned so fast my side lit up.

The nigga was staring at the stage. He hadn't said it to hurt me.
That almost made it worse.

All these niggas were listening to my woman sing for her
husband while my name glowed outside.

I drank what was in front of me. Then I remembered what Vega
had said and put the glass down, furious with myself for needing
a fucking doctor in my head while another man had a song.

Shawna opened her eyes during the last verse. She looked
straight at me.

I couldn't tell which of us she saw.

When she finished, the whole club got up. Niggas banged on
tables. Rosa cried openly. I stood too, slow and angry, clapping
until my hands hurt.

Shawna came down smiling like a girl who had found something
under the bed she thought she'd lost forever.

"Did you like it?"

I kissed her before I answered.

Long. In front of everybody.

"Beautiful," I said.

She touched my face.

"Why you looking at me like that?"

"Like what?"

Her smile faded.

"Never mind."

Later, a man from one of the cash tables grabbed Rosa by the coat when she told him she was done working.

"I paid," he said.

Rosa pulled away.

"You paid for last time."

He grabbed her again.

Nigga, I was standing before Tank got to me.

"Aiden," Shawna said.

The nigga looked over his shoulder, still holding Rosa. That was his mistake. Not knowing me could've been fixed. Holding on after he saw somebody coming was the part that put him on the floor.

I hit him once. Hard enough that I felt something pull under my bandages. Tank caught my elbow before I could hit him again.

"Nigga, whose hand you think that is? Take your fucking hands off her," I said.

The man wasn't holding anything now.

"You hear me?"

He nodded from the carpet.

Rosa pulled her coat straight. Her hands shook. She hated that we could see them.

"Get him out," I told Tank.

"You sit down."

"Get that nigga out first."

The room had gone still around us. All these niggas had wanted a new boss to buy champagne. Now they had one bleeding into a white suit because somebody hadn't let go of Shawna's friend.

Tank handed the man to two others and walked me into the back office. Shawna followed. So did Rosa.

"You dumb motherfucker," Shawna said.

She unbuttoned my jacket. A little red had come through the shirt.

"I'm okay."

"Nigga, you don't know another fucking sentence?"

Rosa stood by the door with both hands inside her coat.

"I didn't need—"

"I know," I told her. "I wanted."

She pressed her lips together. Then she came over, bent down, and kissed my head again.

"Stupid nigga," she whispered.

But she stayed beside me until Shawna got a clean shirt.

At home, the lake was black under the windows.

Shawna took off her earrings and laid them on the bathroom counter. I watched her unclasp the watch.

"Let me buy you one that fits," I said.

She stopped.

"A watch?"

"Yeah."

"I have one."

"It hangs off you."

"I like it."

"I can see that."

She turned around. The silence got ugly fast.

"Say it, Aiden."

I stood in the doorway, tired enough that my legs shook.

"That song about him?"

"Yes."

She hadn't even tried to soften it. Nigga, I would've taken one little lie right then. Just something I could lay down beside.

"You look at me when you sing to him?"

"I looked at you because you were there."

"I'm always there. You wearing his watch, my earrings, got his chain on my fucking neck—"

"You want it off?"

She reached toward the cross.

I caught her wrist.

We stared at each other.

Then I let go.

"Don't," I said.

She rubbed where my fingers had been. I hadn't hurt her. I could still see that I'd done something I didn't want between us.

"Nigga, what do you want from me?" she asked.

I looked down at the marble. I'd bought the whole floor and couldn't find a place to stand.

"I want one thing that's only mine."

Her face changed.

She came close and put her palm over my heartbeat, clear of the wound.

"This is you," she said. "I know who this is."

"Then why'd you say his name in the hospital?"

She closed her eyes.

I wished I'd kept it. Held it in until it killed me by itself. But it was out now, standing between us in our new fucking bathroom.

"I dreamed he was there," she said. "And I was trying to tell him you were hurt."

Nigga, I didn't know what to do with that.

She took my hand and led me to bed. We didn't settle it. She didn't put the watch away. I didn't take off the cross. She kissed me until I stopped asking questions, and when we lay down, she kept her head on my good side.

I woke once before dawn.

She was still there.

For that morning, that was enough.

4. Flowers for the Man I Killed

Nigga, Big T's coffin was blue.

Not dark blue. Not respectful blue. That deep candy blue you put on a car when you want other niggas to pull up beside you and hate their lives. Somebody had ordered gold handles. His picture stood at the front of the chapel, six feet tall, smiling over a room full of people who'd been scared to smile wrong around him.

Your nigga paid for all of it.

The flowers. The cars. The musicians. The lunch afterward that half the guests would be too nervous to eat. T had called me son, then put a bullet in me. I couldn't make those things fit, so I bought him the biggest funeral that place could hold.

Tank came downstairs at the house wearing black.

"Nigga, you ain't gotta go," he said.

"Nigga, I killed him."

"That's why you ain't gotta go."

I adjusted my cuff in the mirror. My hands weren't steady yet. The suit hid the bandages. The medicine made everything feel a half second farther away.

"He had nobody else?" I asked.

"Plenty people."

"People that loved him."

Tank looked toward the window.

I left the cuff alone.

"You did."

He kept looking out.

"Nigga, you can say it."

"He gave me work when I came out."

"Nigga gave me a car."

"Ain't the same."

"I know."

For a minute we just stood there, the two men who'd left T by a swimming pool, trying to get dressed for what came after.

Shawna came downstairs in white.

Tank turned.

"Nigga, oh, hell no."

She stopped on the last stair.

White dress. White coat. White gloves in one hand. Her dark hair pinned up. Dante's watch shining like she'd polished it with her rage.

"What?" she said.

"Nigga's funeral, Shawna."

"I know whose funeral it is."

"Nigga, you can't wear that."

She looked at me.

I could've asked her to change. Could've told her this was already hard enough without her walking in looking like she'd come to get married on his grave.

But nigga, she looked beautiful.

"Nigga, get the car before she decides on a veil," I told Tank.

My nigga, nobody knew what to do when we walked in.

Some niggas stood. Some stayed seated so hard it looked like work. A woman near the front started crying louder when she saw me. I didn't know if that was grief or hate. I kept going.

Shawna's hand was in mine.

Tank walked behind us.

Every nigga in that chapel knew the story had changed. T had sent me to collect a woman and some money. A week later he was in a blue box, I had his men at my back, and the woman was holding my hand in front of his face.

I didn't feel proud until somebody whispered that I shouldn't have come.

Then I felt proud enough to scare myself.

"Which nigga said it? Say it loud so I know who to look at," I said without turning.

Nobody did.

We sat in the second row. Shawna kept her knees together and looked straight ahead. I could feel her pulse through her fingers.

The preacher talked about a generous man.

That part was true. T had been generous. He'd put money in people's hands, found rooms for niggas who had nowhere to sleep, paid somebody's mother's bill without letting anybody say thank you twice. I knew men who'd lived on that kindness for years.

The preacher talked about a man who loved his family.

Shawna let go of my hand.

I looked at her.

Her eyes had gone flat. She was staring at the picture, and her white glove was balled so tight in her fist I could see a seam giving way.

I put my hand on her knee. She didn't move.

Then Tank got up.

He hadn't told me he planned to speak. He walked to the front carrying a folded paper, opened it, looked at it, and put it back in his pocket.

"T knew my mother," he said.

His voice sounded too big for the microphone.

"Knew she worried about me. Every time I came by, nigga made me call her first. Didn't matter what we was doing. Call your mother, Tank. Tell her you ate."

A woman near the aisle laughed through her crying.

Tank looked at the coffin.

"She died while I was inside. T paid for everything. Told me don't owe him for that."

He rubbed one hand down the front of his suit.

"I owed him for it anyway."

I could hear Shawna breathing beside me.

"He did some shit," Tank said.

The preacher shifted.

"Some shit I can't stand up here and fix for him. I ain't gonna try. But he picked me up when nobody was answering. And I remember that."

He stepped away from the microphone.

On the way back, he looked at me once.

I nodded.

Nigga, it hurt. I needed to let it.

Red had sent flowers taller than the coffin.

White roses, blue ribbon, his name on a card big enough to read from the aisle. He hadn't come himself. Every time the door opened, your nigga looked. I hated that he could make me wait for him at a dead man's funeral.

When people went up to the coffin, Shawna stayed seated.

"You don't have to," I said.

"I know."

Then she stood.

We walked up together.

T lay there wearing a dark suit and the ring that had cut my mouth. Somebody had made him look peaceful. I remembered him saying he'd made me. I remembered being happy when he said son.

Nigga, a dead man shouldn't be able to embarrass you. But I stood over him ashamed of how much I'd wanted him to mean it.

Shawna put a folded photograph on his chest.

I recognized the chapel in the background. Her wedding. Dante smiling with his arms around her. This was another print, with T still visible at the edge, one hand on his brother's shoulder.

"You can take your fucking picture with you," she whispered.

I thought she was done.

Then she bent close.

"He loved you. You knew he did."

Her voice broke on loved.

I looked away before she saw me watching.

Behind us, the preacher cleared his throat. I wanted to turn around and tell that nigga to swallow it. Let her have a minute. Let her tell one dead man what the other couldn't hear.

Shawna straightened.

I touched T's cuff once. I don't know why. Maybe because I couldn't touch his hand. Maybe because he'd never get to pull me close again, and some stupid little part of me wanted that settled properly.

"Nigga, all you had to do was let us go," I said.

Then I took my woman's hand and walked out.

Outside, Rosa waited beside the cars in black sunglasses and a coat the wind kept trying to take.

She'd come for Shawna. She said that three times to everybody who asked.

"I ain't crying for that nigga," she told me.

"Nobody asked you to."

"I know. I just want the dead to be clear."

Shawna leaned against her. Rosa wrapped the coat around both of them and let her stay there while the pallbearers brought the coffin down.

Mercedes and Porsche stood by the Mercedes with a tray of sandwiches between them. They'd come dressed for church and carrying enough food to keep a war from becoming rude. Leon had sent a new white Bentley with them because, according to the card, seeing the last one die had changed his feelings about ownership.

"That's love," Tank said, taking two sandwiches.

"That's a nigga with insurance," Porsche told him.

I saw the black SUV before the first shot. It came around the chapel too slowly. There was another one behind it. Both had dark windows. Both had men leaning forward as if whatever they wanted was about to become available.

Tank stopped chewing.

"Down."

The first bullet shattered the tray in Porsche's hands.

I caught Shawna around the waist and drove us behind the Mercedes. Rosa hit the ground beside us. Somebody screamed. Gunfire ripped through the chapel doors, and the beautiful blue sky filled with glass.

A pallbearer dropped beside the hearse. Rico. Thirty-two. I'd learned his name that morning because he'd told me the gold

cuff links were a gift from his daughter, who was grown and living in another state, and he'd wanted me to notice she had taste.

He wasn't moving.

Tank fired over the hood. The sound went through my chest. Porsche pulled Mercedes down behind the rear wheel as another burst took the car's mirror off.

"Everybody inside!" I shouted.

The chapel doors were open, but the drive between us and them was full of bullets. A woman stood frozen halfway down the steps holding the hand of her seventy-year-old husband. He was trying to pull her down. She kept looking at Rico.

"Nigga, get her!" I shouted to Tank.

"You stay here!"

"I heard you the first time!"

He ran bent low across the drive. Shots tore the flowers off a standing wreath behind him. He caught the old man under one arm and pushed the woman ahead of him through the doors. The whole front of the chapel swallowed them.

The first SUV came farther into the lot. Its passenger leaned out with a gun.

I fired from beside the wheel. The man jerked back inside. The SUV clipped the fountain, turned, and struck the empty wheelchair someone had left for me at the bottom of the steps.

That pissed me off personally.

"That nigga just hit my chair."

Shawna had her pistol out. She fired twice toward the second SUV and pulled back beside me.

"You weren't using it."

"Still mine."

Across the drive, the hearse began rolling.

Its driver was on the ground behind the open door. I couldn't tell whether he was hurt or scared. The engine was running. The car moved forward, slow at first, down the slight slope toward the street. T's coffin gleamed inside it through the rear window.

The first SUV turned to follow it.

"They're taking him," Rosa said.

"Taking who?"

"T!"

For one second I couldn't believe any nigga alive had found a way to complicate that man's death further.

Then I saw the shooter get out of the SUV and run toward the driver's door of the hearse.

Shawna grabbed my jacket.

"Aiden."

"They don't get him."

"Baby, he's dead."

"Then he ain't driving himself home."

I kissed her once and went.

The driveway tilted under me. Pain shot across my ribs. Somebody shouted my name from the chapel doors, and somebody else shouted, "Look at that nigga," like the first person had been announcing a miracle and the second wanted everybody to see it before it left.

I hit the hearse as the gunman reached it.

He had one hand on the wheel. I caught his jacket and drove him against the open door. His gun went off into the sky. We slammed into the side of the moving car, my shoulder against the window, his elbow against my throat.

He was bigger than me and healthy. Nigga, that was his whole fucking argument.

I put my forehead into his nose.

He fell back. I shoved him clear and jumped into the driver's seat. The hearse hit the curb with both front wheels. Behind me T's coffin thumped against its restraints like the nigga had an opinion.

"You can shut up too," I told him.

The first SUV came after us.

I drove the hearse through the open cemetery gate across the road. Gravel burst beneath the tires. White stones flashed past on both sides. I kept to the broad center drive, flying between the trees while the men behind me fired through their own windshield.

The hearse's rear glass shattered. A gold handle on the coffin caught the light.

"Nigga, they're scratching your box."

I turned hard around the stone circle at the center of the cemetery. The hearse leaned. The coffin stayed where it was. I could hear the SUV behind us lose its grip on the gravel, tires screaming while its driver tried to copy a man who was presently doing the best driving at his own enemy's funeral.

We came out beside a second gate. A groundskeeper stood next to a watering truck, hose in his hand, mouth open. I lifted two fingers. He dropped the hose and lifted two back.

Respect knew what to do even when nothing else did.

I took the hearse onto the service road. The SUV followed, front bumper bent, one headlight gone. A second engine roared somewhere ahead of us.

For a second I thought they'd boxed me in.

Then the white Bentley appeared across the intersection with Shawna driving.

Her coat was off. Her white gloves were on. Porsche sat beside her holding her purse against the dash and grinning like she'd just gotten invited to the best part of her own fucking life.

Shawna turned the Bentley toward the SUV.

"Baby, don't—"

Too late. She struck its front corner and knocked it sideways across the road. The Bentley spun, white smoke pouring off the tires. Porsche's door flew open and slammed shut again. The SUV climbed the curb and hit a stone wall hard enough to throw its hood up like a surrender flag.

I braked the hearse beside them.

Shawna looked through her broken window at me.

"Nigga, your wife drives too."

We weren't married. I didn't correct her. I was busy falling in love with her for the fourth fucking time before lunch.

A man came out of the SUV with a gun.

I fired through the hearse's open door. He dropped behind the engine and his weapon clattered into the gutter. Another man tried to pull him back inside. Tank's Mercedes arrived from the far end of the road, and that nigga took one look at Tank getting

out and raised both hands so high I thought he was asking God to pull him through the sunroof.

"Who sent you?" Tank shouted.

The man didn't answer.

Tank took another step.

"Nigga, this is the easy question."

"T had friends!"

I got out of the hearse.

"Then where the fuck were you when they passed the collection plate?"

The man's eyes widened. He looked from me to the coffin behind the shattered rear window.

"You killed him."

"And I'm burying him. You coming between those things again, you can ask him how he feels about it yourself."

He stared at the pistol in my hand. Then at the blood beginning to show through my shirt. Then at Shawna stepping out of the Bentley in a white dress with glass shining around her shoes.

"You don't stop," he said.

It came out almost admiring. Like he'd found the problem and hated that it was beautiful.

"Nigga, you should've asked somebody before you came."

Knox's cruisers arrived behind Tank. I hadn't called her. Half the city had. Men got put on the ground, guns got kicked away, and the chief got out with her eyes already on me.

"Please tell me that's an empty hearse."

"Family in the back."

She looked through the window.

"You brought the deceased into a pursuit?"

"Nigga wasn't walking."

Knox took off her glasses.

For three seconds I watched her try to decide whether she'd seen anything better in thirty years of police work.

Then she laughed. Loud. Hands on her hips, face turned toward the sky, laughing while the men in handcuffs looked at her like she had personally betrayed the law by appreciating me.

"Aiden," she said, "you are wasting your fucking talents in civilian clothes."

"You keep saying that."

"I'm going to keep saying it until somebody gives me what I want."

Shawna reached me. She had a shallow cut on her hand, nothing worse, and I kissed it before she could tell me the blood wasn't all hers.

"I asked you to stay with the car," I said.

"I did. I moved the car."

Porsche came around the Bentley and held out its keys to Tank.

"Tell Leon this one had a meaningful life too."

Tank looked at the crushed front fender.

"Nigga gonna start sending bicycles."

We brought T back to the chapel in the same hearse, with a police escort in front and Shawna in the seat beside me. People came out when they heard the engines. Somebody started applauding. A woman on the steps raised both hands and shouted my name so hard her hat moved.

I got out slowly. My side had finally started collecting everything I owed it.

The old man Tank had rescued came down the steps with his wife. She put both hands around my face.

"You brought everybody home."

I looked past her at the white sheet beside the curb.

Not everybody.

Rico was still there. Vernon, forty-one, had died inside the chapel after they carried him in. Two of my people gone while I was trying to keep one dead man from being taken again.

I held the woman's hands for a second, then let them go.

"Help me finish this," I told Tank.

We put our hands on T's blue coffin. Four other men came beside us. The funeral workers found their places. The musicians began the hymn again, shaky at first, then strong enough that the whole parking lot listened.

This time when we carried him to the waiting car, nobody stopped us.

They buried T later that afternoon.

I didn't go to the graveside. Vega was back at the house, furious enough that everybody found a reason to leave the room when she walked in. She examined me behind closed doors while Shawna sat on the bed, still in the dirty white dress.

"You were told to rest," Vega said.

"I was sitting at a funeral."

"You are bleeding in a house full of armed men. I am interested in what happened after the sitting."

I looked away.

She made arrangements for what I needed, repeated herself slowly enough to insult me, and left with the promise that I was going back under her care if my condition worsened. I believed her. So did Shawna. That meant I was trapped in my own fucking palace.

Two of our men were dead. Others were hurt. Tank told me their names and made me repeat them. I said I'd pay for everything. He said their mothers needed to hear a human being first.

So I called.

Nigga, there wasn't a thing on earth I could say that made that conversation right. I didn't try to make a speech. I told them who I was. Told them I was sorry. Stayed on the line through whatever they needed to call me.

When I finished, I threw the phone across the room.

Shawna watched it hit the wall.

"I want Red," I said.

"You don't know it was him."

"Who the fuck else, Shawna?"

"People loved T."

"Nigga, I paid for the funeral."

"You also killed him."

I hated hearing it in her voice. Hated that she could say something true while I wanted her angry beside her nigga.

"You defending Red now?"

Her face went cold.

"Say that again."

I didn't.

She stood up, took Dante's watch off, and set it beside me on the bed.

"You think I forgot what those men did?"

The watch lay face up between us.

"You think because I got a house and some fucking earrings I forgot where they left him?"

"No."

"Then don't talk to me like I'm sleeping through this."

She picked it back up. Her fingers were shaking at the clasp. I reached for her hand, and she let me help her fasten it.

"I'm scared," I said.

She looked at me.

Nigga, I'd rather have taken another punch than said that. But I'd seen her under that car, and I couldn't get the glass out of my head.

"I'm scared they get you while I'm laying here."

She sat down.

"Then stop trying to stand up every time somebody says your name."

I put my forehead against hers.

Outside the room, Rosa was yelling at Tank to eat something. He told her he wasn't hungry. She told him she hadn't asked for his fucking feelings about the sandwich.

Shawna laughed once, through her nose.

I held on to her.

Red's invitation came at sunset.

A man from the Saint left a black envelope at the gate. Tank brought it upstairs on a silver tray he must've taken from the kitchen. I stared at it.

"Nigga, why you serving me a threat?"

"Didn't wanna touch it more than I had to."

I took the envelope.

Inside was an invitation printed in gold. Breakfast at the Saint. Tomorrow morning. Penthouse. My name and Shawna's, together like we were anybody's idea of welcome guests.

There was another card behind it.

I read it once.

Then I gave it to Shawna.

She sat on the bed so suddenly I thought her legs had gone.

"What?" Tank said.

She didn't answer. She was staring at the handwriting. I watched her thumb move to Dante's watch and stay there.

Red had written one sentence.

Dante didn't die for three million.

5. Forty Million Reasons to Die

I went to see Red the morning after the funeral with a bullet in my body and a diamond pin covering the hole in my coat.

Tank drove. I sat beside him with the note open on my knee.

Dante didn't die for three million.

The nigga had written it in red ink. He wanted me looking at it all night, wondering what my woman hadn't told me. Nigga, I had done exactly that. I wasn't giving him the pleasure of knowing.

“Nigga, you slept at all?” Tank asked.

“Nigga, I can dream about firing you with my eyes open.”

He reached into the console and handed me the little bottle Dr. Vega had left for me.

“Take what she said to take.”

“Nigga, I heard the doctor.”

“Then listen to her.”

I put the bottle in my pocket. He was wearing black again. The nigga had carried a coffin yesterday and was driving me toward another one today. I looked at his hands on the wheel. There was a cut across his knuckles I didn't remember putting there.

At the Saint, two men approached my door before the valet could. I stepped out holding Red's note.

“Your boss sent for me.”

One of them put his hand out for my gun.

“Nigga, you can have the note.”

He looked toward the entrance. Red stood inside the glass doors in a cream suit, watching.

He lifted one finger. The men backed off.

“Aiden,” he said when I reached him. “Glad you came.”

“You would've been sad if I didn't?”

“I had breakfast made.”

“Then feed a nigga before the conversation gets hungry.”

He put his arm around me like we were cousins. I let him.

Nigga, I wanted to know how close this motherfucker would come to a man who had killed his friend.

My nigga came close enough to squeeze my shoulder.

Before the waiters brought the food, Red took me past the white piano.

He did it slowly. Let me see the polished lid, the flowers beside it, the photograph on the wall of Shawna singing with her hair pinned up. The nigga had paid a fortune to make a room look like she was still going to walk into it.

"You play?" he asked.

"You asking me to?"

"I wondered what you brought to a woman who already sings."

Tank looked at me. I could feel him begging me to keep walking. He'd known me a week and already understood that asking what I could do was an expensive way to start a morning.

I sat down.

There was sheet music on the stand. A song with a long introduction, full of black notes pressed together like the niggas had arrived in the same car. Somebody had written Shawna's name at the top.

I put my hands on the keys.

The first chord filled the room. Then the next. My fingers remembered a church piano from when I was broke enough to play for supper, an old woman with strong hands correcting my wrists, hours by myself in an empty room when nobody wanted me around except an instrument that couldn't leave.

Red stopped walking.

I played the introduction once. Then I played it again with the melody in my right hand and something meaner moving underneath it. The waiters stood still with the breakfast trays. One of the men at the door turned around. Tank leaned against the wall, arms folded, smiling like a nigga watching his brother come home with a stolen moon.

"You read that just now?" Red asked.

I kept playing.

"You left it open."

"That arrangement's difficult."

"For which nigga?"

The man by the door laughed before he could stop himself. Red looked at him. He stopped laughing, but he couldn't stop looking impressed.

I finished with a chord that left the whole room ringing.

A waiter put his tray down and clapped once. The others followed. Quiet at first, then louder when they saw I was looking at them. Tank didn't bother clapping. He spread both hands at Red as if to say the nigga had asked for this and now had to live in it.

"Shawna never said you played," Red said.

"Nigga, I keep giving her things to find out."

I stood up and closed the piano gently.

"You ought to try it."

Upstairs, the penthouse had been cleaned since Shawna and I left it. He led us through to a terrace where six waiters stood around a table set for three. There were roses in tall crystal vases. My nigga had put the only red one in front of me.

Tank picked it up.

“Don't eat that,” I said.

He looked at me. “I wasn't going to eat it.”

Red laughed. He had little dimples when he laughed. Nigga, I hated them immediately.

I sat. The chair hurt my side, so I moved. Red watched that too.

“T always did know where to put a bullet.”

“Nigga, he didn't know where to keep his own.”

One of the waiters stopped pouring.

Red raised his orange juice.

“To our absent friend.”

I drank water. My nigga Tank didn't touch anything.

Red ate as if he'd invited us to discuss a vacation. He offered Tank bacon. Tank took some, then looked pissed at himself for doing it.

“Where's Shawna?” Red asked.

“With people who like her alive.”

“I've always liked her alive.”

“You got an expensive way of showing it.”

He put his fork down.

“I bought her the dress she was wearing when you met her.”

I leaned forward too fast. Pain burned all the way through my side, but I kept my face still.

“You want me to send you the motherfucking dress?”

“I want you to understand how little of this you understand.”

“Nigga, that's the first time you said anything all morning.”

He smiled again.

“I gave her a room when Valentino died. I protected her from people who would've cut her life short over what she did to him. Then my partner arranges to take her and three million dollars out of my house. My partner dies. You inherit his business, his car, his necklace, and the woman. That's a very fortunate week.”

“You forgot the bullet.”

“No. I can see you haven't.”

Tank's chair scraped. I raised my hand without looking at my nigga.

“You think I planned that shit?” I asked.

“I think you're young enough to be honest when it profits you.”

“Then here's some honesty. Send another nigga after her, I'll come back without an invitation.”

Red wiped his mouth. He was thirty-six years old and had men older than his father standing around waiting to refill his fucking juice. Nigga, I could feel the kind of money he had. It made the air colder.

“You can keep T's streets,” he said. “That's a generous beginning.”

“I can keep what's already mine? Damn. Put a bow on it.”

“The money comes back. Shawna comes home. We stop putting people in the ground.”

“Which people you want me to bring back? T? Dante? Valentino? You got a favorite?”

He stopped smiling at Dante's name.

There it was.

I sat back and let the pain take its time through me.

“You wrote me a note,” I said. “Finish it.”

Red looked at the waiters. They left. He waited until the last door shut before he spoke.

“Eight years ago, I bought something extraordinary from a man who didn't appreciate the opportunity he'd been given.”

“What man?”

“Marcellus Vale. A jeweler. Violent when disappointed.”

Tank's hand tightened around his glass.

Red saw it. The nigga saw everything except the day somebody would finally kill him.

“His masterpiece was called Blue Mercy. Large blue diamond. Depending on who's asking, somewhere around forty million dollars.”

Nigga, I had been pretending all morning that nothing could surprise me. Forty million surprised the absolute fuck out of me.

“Nigga, forty million for one rock?”

“One.”

“Nigga, for forty million that bitch better call me when I'm lonely.”

“It has made quite a few men lonely.”

“What does Dante got to do with it?”

“Dante met Vale in prison. Came home with some unfortunate ideas. Decided the money in my accounts belonged to a woman he'd never met.”

“Which woman got that nigga reaching into your accounts?”

“Vale's dead wife.”

Red picked up his glass again.

“Men do peculiar things when they love dead women. It's why I advise you to avoid the habit.”

I stood up. Tank stood with me.

“Nigga, you can tell me what you know about Dante, or you can keep talking about my woman until this breakfast gets real fucking expensive.”

Red didn't move.

“Shawna knows the story.”

“No.”

“Ask her.”

“I fucking did.”

“Then ask her again.”

He pushed an envelope across the table. Inside were two invitations, heavy blue paper edged in silver.

“The diamond will be the centerpiece of my gala in three nights. I thought Shawna might like to see what her husband died chasing.”

I looked at the invitation. Her name was printed before mine.

“You printed these before the funeral?”

“I print a lot of invitations.”

“Nigga, print one for yours.”

Tank touched my elbow. I pulled away because I wanted Red to know nobody in that room could move me except me.

We got to the door before Red spoke again.

“Tell her I still have the piano.”

I turned.

He was cutting into his breakfast.

“The white one. She'll know.”

Nigga, I went back across the terrace, took his untouched vase of roses, and threw it over the railing.

Glass broke somewhere far below. A woman screamed.

Red rose halfway out of his chair.

“That's my fucking car.”

“Tell it I still have the vase.”

I put the wet broken stem I was holding on his plate and left.

Red's car was a red Aston Martin, and the vase had gone through the roof of it.

The valet stood beside it holding a towel. I didn't know what the towel was going to solve. The entire car looked like an expensive mouth that had bitten into glass.

"Mr. Red is going to be upset," he said.

"Nigga, he got a head start upstairs. Where's mine?"

Tank went to the Mercedes. They had replaced its windows since our first night, repaired the back, polished it until I could see myself coming. I loved that car. It kept surviving my life without asking me to slow it down.

A man came out of the next hotel carrying a helmet under one arm. He saw the car, then me, then the broken Aston Martin.

"You Aiden?"

"Depends who's hoping."

"Nigga, you flew over a boat."

"Word getting around."

He grinned. Thirty-one, brown skin, a scar down his chin, leather jacket with a silver eagle on the back. He pointed across the drive at a black motorcycle that looked ready to leave without him.

"Name's Saint. Everybody calls me Little Saint. I ride."

"Good for you."

"I mean I ride. Thought maybe you should know that."

Tank opened my door.

"Everybody got something they want this nigga to know today."

Little Saint's smile disappeared as he looked past us.

"Then know those two cars ain't valets."

A gray sports car had stopped across the exit. Behind it a black SUV rolled forward with its windows coming down. The man in the front passenger seat held a pistol against his chest. He wasn't wearing the Saint's colors. He wasn't wearing anything that told

me whether he loved T or hated me or had been paid enough to do both.

"Inside," Tank said.

The first bullet hit the Mercedes door while his hand was still on it.

I grabbed the valet by his collar and threw him behind the car. Glass burst from the hotel's revolving door. People dropped behind luggage and flowerpots. Little Saint ran for his motorcycle, helmet swinging from his hand, and the SUV's engine roared toward us.

Tank fired from beside my shoulder. I got into the passenger seat as he came around the hood. The Mercedes lurched back before his door was shut.

We hit the gray car hard enough to move it sideways. Its driver shouted through the window. Tank hit it again. The gap opened, and we came through with sparks sliding along my door.

"Nigga, somebody really hates breakfast," I said.

"Put your head down."

"I need it where I can see."

"Then see lower."

The gray car came after us. Its front fender hung loose, slapping the wheel every time it turned. The SUV stayed farther back, its passenger firing through the missing window.

We took the first corner too fast. A taxi braked across our path. Tank turned, missed its front bumper by inches, and put us into a narrow street lined with parked delivery trucks.

The gray car followed. The SUV couldn't make the turn cleanly and struck a streetlight. I heard metal break behind us. The nigga kept coming anyway.

Little Saint appeared beside us on the motorcycle.

He was laughing.

Not because he didn't understand. The nigga understood perfectly. Somebody had finally made his morning worth wearing the jacket for.

He pointed ahead. A tour bus stood across the next intersection. Its driver was outside arguing with a man in a yellow vest. Neither had seen us.

"Tank!"

"I see it!"

"Nigga, I keep hearing that right before we hit something!"

Tank braked. The Mercedes slid. Behind us the gray car tried to stop and couldn't. Its nose struck our rear quarter, spinning us halfway around.

Now I was looking straight at it.

The driver looked straight at me.

For one second we shared the intimate knowledge that his nigga had chosen the wrong car to pursue.

I fired through the broken rear window. His windshield bloomed white. He ducked, lost the turn, and struck the tour bus's empty luggage compartment with the whole front of his car.

The bus driver dropped his argument and ran.

Tank put us into the gap beside the bus. The Mercedes scraped along its side. I could see luggage stacked behind a little square window, somebody's pink suitcase shaking every time our car hit another panel.

Then we came out into open road.

Little Saint was still beside us. He raised a fist. I raised mine back.

The SUV hit him.

Not square. Its bumper caught the motorcycle's back wheel as it tried to pass. The bike snapped sideways. Little Saint flew off, rolling across the hood of a parked car and down into the street.

Tank swore.

I had the door open before he stopped.

"Nigga, where the fuck—"

"Get him!"

I ran across the road. The SUV turned toward us. I could see its driver watching me, smiling the same fucking smile every man

wore when he thought my love for somebody had finally made me easy to kill.

Little Saint was on one elbow trying to stand. His helmet had cracked. Blood ran down his cheek. He looked up at me like he couldn't believe I'd come back.

"Your leg?" I asked.

"Works."

"Then work it with me."

I pulled him up. We ran for the parked cars together while the SUV came at our backs. Tank's Mercedes surged across its path. The two cars struck, and the sound filled the street.

I pushed Little Saint behind a truck and turned with my gun up. The SUV had stopped against the Mercedes. Its driver tried to open his door. Tank came out of his own car like the crash had merely rung a bell for him. He caught the door, slammed it back, and hauled the driver through the window instead.

I covered the passenger until he dropped his gun.

"Nigga, you can keep breathing," I told him. "That's all you getting from me today."

He put both hands on the dashboard.

Little Saint stood behind me with his jacket torn at the shoulder. He stared at Tank, then at me, then at the smoking cars.

"You came back."

"You told me you ride. I ain't seen enough yet."

His face changed. The grin came back slower this time, carrying something heavier underneath it.

"Any road," he said. "Any fucking road, Aiden. You call, I'm there."

A crowd had gathered at the corner. Somebody shouted my name. A woman held up her phone and asked me to look toward her. I did, because nigga, if they were going to put me on every screen in Vegas they could at least get the good side.

Knox's officers arrived before the smoke stopped. They recognized me immediately. One of them looked at the wrecked SUV and shook his head with open wonder.

"Chief said you were something."

"Chief been paying attention."

Tank made a call. Another car came for Little Saint. Our Mercedes still ran, because some machines knew who they belonged to and refused to embarrass him.

We drove home with one door tied shut by a belt and the whole street watching us leave.

I called Shawna before we reached the highway.

"Baby, you want lunch?"

"Why are there sirens behind you?"

"Niggas wanted breakfast. I'm thinking ahead."

Shawna was at the house with Rosa, standing barefoot on a little platform while a woman pinned a dress around her hips. The dress was silver, and I wanted every nigga out of the fucking room so I could look at her properly.

Then I saw the watch on her wrist.

Dante's watch. Dante's wife. Dante's fucking diamond.

I had bought the house by the water. I had bled in the car getting her here. Somehow the dead man was still first through every door.

Rosa looked up.

“Why you got that face?”

“What face?”

“The one that's going to make this dress cost more.”

I held up the invitations.

“Blue Mercy.”

Shawna stopped moving.

The woman kneeling beside her kept working until Rosa put a hand on her shoulder.

“Let's get coffee,” Rosa said.

“I don't drink coffee,” the woman said.

“Today's a good fucking day to start.”

They left us alone.

Shawna stepped down from the platform. A pin fell out of the dress and landed between us.

“What did he tell you?”

I laughed once. It sounded ugly in that room.

“Nigga, everybody keeps asking me that. What did she tell you? What did he tell you? What the fuck did the dead man tell the other dead man? How about you tell me something for once?”

She drew back.

I hated that I had made her do it. I kept going anyway.

“You knew about forty million dollars?”

“I knew about the stone.”

“And you didn't think that shit mattered?”

“I thought you being shot mattered. I thought getting you through yesterday mattered.”

“You got time to pick a fucking dress, Shawna.”

Her face changed.

“I picked this dress because I wanted one night where you looked at me and didn't see somebody else bleeding.”

I didn't have anything ready for that.

She took the invitation out of my hand. Her thumb went over Red's name.

“He told you about his piano?”

“Yeah, he told me about the piano. He tell everybody about the piano?”

“I smashed the keys with a bottle the night I left. He bought another one so he could pretend I was coming back.”

“He said you knew what Dante died for.”

“I know what Dante told me.”

“Then tell me.”

“It starts before me.”

“Nigga, everything in this house starts before me.”

She looked down at the cross against my shirt.

“You want me to take that back?”

My hand closed around it.

“No.”

“Then sit down, Aiden.”

“Dante told me after we got married,” she said. “We were in the room Red paid for. I thought we’d go downstairs and drink with everybody. He locked the door instead.”

My nigga, I felt my jaw tighten.

“I’m listening.”

“He said there was something I ought to know before I decided what kind of man I’d married.”

She took my hand off the cross and held it.

“Then he told me about the old man.”

6. The Man Who Cut the Heart Out of a Mountain

The room had rose petals on the bed, Shawna said, but Dante was gathering them in his hands and putting them in the ice bucket.

She was still wearing her wedding dress.

“Are they bothering you?” she'd asked.

“They got dirt on them.”

“Dante.”

“I don't want you sleeping in dirt.”

She had laughed and kicked off her shoes. He had watched them hit the carpet as if he hadn't quite believed she intended to stay.

That part fucked with me. I knew exactly how that man had looked at her shoes. I'd looked at her watch the same way, checking whether she'd put anything down long enough to live with me.

Shawna kept talking.

Dante sat beside the bucket full of roses and told her he'd been in prison before they met. Nine months of his life, a little more than three years before this morning in my bedroom. He'd been twenty-eight then. His first afternoon, a man at the next table

spilled soup down the front of an older prisoner's shirt. The older man looked down at himself, then carried on eating.

Dante waited.

"You hear me, old man?" the first man said.

"I heard you."

"Then look at me."

The older prisoner put his spoon down.

"You have my soup on your hand."

The man slapped him.

Dante got up.

He told Shawna he didn't remember crossing the space between the tables. One minute he was sitting down. The next he was holding the man against a wall with blood on his own shirt, shouting for someone to bring the old man another fucking bowl.

"What happened after the soup?" I asked Shawna.

"I just told you."

"You told me a nigga got hit. Baby, you skipped the part where the nigga found out."

She looked at me for a second. Then she settled farther back against the pillows.

"Dante said the man had three friends."

"There we go."

The first friend got up when Dante crossed the room. A big man with a shaved head and a towel over one shoulder, forty years old and proud of how much space he took from everybody around him. He put himself between Dante and the older man.

"Sit your ass down."

Dante kept walking.

"Nigga, you deaf?"

"No. You finished?"

The man swung. Dante caught the edge of it across his jaw and hit him with the tray he'd still been carrying. Food went everywhere. A cup rolled off the table and broke under somebody's shoe.

Then everybody stood up.

The man who'd spilled the soup grabbed Marcellus by his collar. He was smiling at Dante, enjoying how quickly a stranger had given him something useful to hurt.

"You want the old nigga? Come get him."

Dante went over the table.

Shawna lifted one hand when she told me. I could see her husband for a second in the shape she made: feet off the floor, hands already reaching, a man who'd decided the space between him and somebody in trouble belonged to him now.

I knew that decision. I didn't like sharing it with him, but nigga, I knew it.

Dante hit the man holding Marcellus with both knees. They went down together. The old man fell against the bench, caught himself, and picked up his soup spoon before anybody stepped on it.

"He picked up the spoon?" I asked.

"He liked that spoon."

"Nigga, I respect an attachment."

The third man came behind Dante with a chair. Marcellus saw him first. He put a foot against the man's ankle as he passed, just enough to spoil the step, and the chair struck the table instead of Dante's head.

Dante turned into him.

He told Shawna he never knew which part of the fight broke his finger. He remembered the pain later. What he remembered then was getting that chair away, seeing the old man standing up again, hearing men all around them shout because somebody had finally interrupted the same ugly afternoon they'd been living for years.

By the time the guards came, the soup was on the floor and three men were finding new reasons to stay there.

Dante stood in the middle of it with blood on his shirt.

"Another bowl," he said.

The nearest guard pointed at the door.

"Move."

"Nigga, the old man ain't eaten."

"Move now."

Marcellus put a hand on his shoulder.

"I can wait."

Dante looked at the empty bowl on the table. Then at the men on the floor. Then he picked up the bowl and put it in the guard's hand.

"So can they."

Shawna smiled when she remembered that part. I let her have the smile. Her dead man had earned that much.

"Three niggas," I said.

"Three."

"I had twelve."

She hit me with a pillow so gently even my bullet didn't complain.

"You asked for the story."

"I'm listening. Nigga can listen and hold the record."

She laughed, and for a second Dante wasn't sitting between us anymore. He was somewhere behind her, where she could turn and see him without leaving my bed.

It bought him punishment and a friendship.

The old man's name was Marcellus Vale.

When Dante came back, Marcellus was sitting on his bunk with a little paper box in his hands. Inside was a broken plastic comb, several buttons, and a gold-colored wrapper folded into a heart.

“For your trouble,” he said.

Dante looked at the heart.

“Nigga, what am I supposed to do with this?”

“Give it to somebody.”

“A woman?”

“If you like women.”

“I like women.”

“Then perhaps one will like a heart.”

Dante took it. The folds were so small and straight they looked pressed by a machine.

“You make jewelry?”

“I did.”

“Used to steal it myself.”

Marcellus looked up.

“Then we may have met professionally.”

Dante laughed. The old man didn't, but he moved over so Dante could sit.

For two months they ate together. Marcellus taught him cards. Dante taught him which men to leave alone and which men only wanted somebody to be frightened of them. Marcellus had already been inside for years. He knew the difference. He let Dante tell him anyway.

At night, the old man held a photograph under the light from the corridor.

Celeste stood on a little stage with a microphone in her hand. Her mouth was open. Her eyes were closed. A blue stone lay at the base of her throat.

“Your wife?” Dante asked one night.

“Yes.”

“She beautiful.”

“I know.”

“She still come see you?”

Marcellus turned the photograph over.

“No.”

Dante didn't ask again until the day a letter arrived and Marcellus sat with it unopened through dinner.

“You want me to read it?” Dante said.

“I know what it says.”

“Then why they send it?”

“Because some people think they can finish a love affair by closing a bank account.”

Dante sat on the other bunk.

Marcellus stared at the envelope.

“She died three months ago.”

Neither man said anything for a while.

Then Dante asked about the diamond.

When Marcellus first saw the stone, it didn't look like forty million dollars. It looked like a dirty piece of sky somebody had knocked loose and tried to bury.

He bought it from a man who carried it in an empty cigarette packet. He paid too much, threatened two people who thought they were entitled to part of it, and came home with an empty account and a fist-sized bruise on his jaw.

Celeste was frying chicken.

She took one look at him and turned the burner down.

“How much?”

“Wait until you see it.”

“How much, Marcellus?”

He put the cigarette packet on the table.

She looked inside. Then she looked at him.

“We are not eating that.”

He took the stone from her and held it toward the kitchen window. Light passed through the rough blue surface and laid a strange little shape across her white sleeve.

She stopped looking angry for a moment.

“Oh,” she said.

He watched her instead of the stone.

“Yes.”

It took him months to cut it. He worked in a room behind their house, shut the door, and disappeared for days at a time while Celeste sang at a lounge that barely paid her. She brought him food. Half the time it was still there when she came back.

At the end of the first month, she moved his pillow into the workshop.

At the end of the second, she put a photograph of herself beside the lamp.

“So you remember who the fuck lives out here,” she told him.

At the end of the third, he came into the lounge wearing his good suit.

Celeste was halfway through a song. The piano player saw Marcellus coming and lost his place. Celeste stopped, turned, and saw the little box in her husband's hands.

“Don't you propose to me again,” she said into the microphone. “I fell for that shit once.”

People laughed. Marcellus kept walking until he reached the stage.

“I made you something.”

She came down the steps. He opened the box.

The room got quiet.

The stone was blue in a way Dante later told Shawna he couldn't explain. Shawna told me he held her hand against the lamp trying to show her what Marcellus meant. Blue that deepened when you moved it away from the light. Blue that kept looking wet after you understood it was dry.

Celeste put her fingers over her mouth.

“Marcellus.”

He lifted the necklace out.

“Turn around.”

She did. He fastened it behind her neck. The diamond rested against her skin, surrounded by little pale stones that made it look even darker.

“What'd you call it?” she asked.

“Blue Mercy.”

“Mercy for what?”

“The last three months.”

She put her arms around him and kissed him in front of everybody.

Somewhere in that room, a man saw forty million dollars. Valentino was sitting near the back with Red, who was twenty-eight at the time and hungry for more than he could afford.

Celeste saw her husband coming home from the little room behind the house.

That's the shit Marcellus told Dante. Dante told his new wife. And his wife sat beside me years later with another dead man's necklace in my fist, telling me about all of them.

I wanted to interrupt her. I wanted to ask whether Dante kissed better than me, whether he had ever promised her more, whether this old nigga's beautiful wife had looked at him the way mine looked at a fucking watch.

I kept my mouth shut.

Nigga, I wanted to hear what happened more than I wanted to hear myself.

Red came to the workshop two weeks later with T and a bottle of wine that cost more than Marcellus's first car.

He said he wanted to buy the stone.

Marcellus said it wasn't for sale.

Red doubled the number he'd been planning to offer before he even said it.

"It belongs to my wife," Marcellus told him.

"Then ask your wife."

"She isn't for sale either."

T laughed. Red didn't.

They left the wine on the table.

Celeste came in afterward, read the label, and carried it straight to the sink.

Marcellus caught her wrist.

"Do you know what that's worth?"

"Yes." She pulled free and poured it out. "That's why I don't want to find out what we owe him if we drink it."

But money was tight. A stone worth a fortune didn't pay the electric bill if nobody intended to sell it. Marcellus agreed to exhibit it at a private showing Valentino arranged. A rich client wanted jewelry made in the same blue setting. Other men wanted to pay him just to look at stones they already owned.

He told Celeste it would give him enough work to stop worrying.

She asked whether he would ever have enough work to stop.

Before the showing, he made a duplicate. A lesser blue stone, convincing under warm light, in an identical necklace. He could leave that in the display while Celeste wore the original. He marked the removable mounting in a place only he thought to check. The true diamond had its own tiny irregularity inside, older than anybody who'd ever owned it. No second stone could share it.

The men who came to the showing took both.

They took the necklaces, the loose jewels in the back room, and the book with his customers' names. T held Marcellus against his own workbench. Valentino lifted the necklace from Celeste's throat so carefully he didn't disturb her hair.

Red stood in the doorway.

“Now,” he said, “perhaps we can agree on a price.”

Marcellus lunged at him. T hit him hard enough to knock the lamp over.

Celeste dropped to the floor beside her husband.

“Take it,” she said to Red. “Go.”

Red looked down at her.

“You should've said that in the beginning.”

He left an envelope on the workbench. There was a fraction of the money inside. Enough that he could say he'd paid. Not enough that any of them could mistake what had happened for a sale.

Marcellus stayed on the floor after they left.

Celeste held a towel against his face.

"Look at me," she kept saying. "It's gone. Look at me."

He was looking at her throat.

That was the part that made the old man's voice change when he told Dante.

His wife was right there. She was alive. She was asking him to look at her.

He could only see where the diamond had been.

He went after it. Of course he fucking went after it. By the time Shawna said that, I was standing beside the window imagining my own hands around Red's throat.

Marcellus went after the diamond in the same good suit he'd worn to give it away.

"He told Dante that?" I asked.

"He said Celeste tried to stop him."

"With words?"

"With his car keys."

"Smart woman."

He went in a taxi. Sat in the back with the gun in his coat and an envelope of money on his knee. Celeste stood in the doorway holding the keys he no longer needed. She didn't shout after him. That was the part he wished he could stop remembering.

The club Valentino owned had gold doors and a stairway lit from underneath. A singer Marcellus knew was onstage when he went in. She stopped halfway through a line when she saw his face.

Valentino sat in a private booth with two men.

Marcellus put the envelope on the table.

"Your money."

Valentino looked inside. Smiled. Set it down again.

"You came to buy something?"

"I came for what's mine."

The man on Valentino's right stood up. Marcellus hit him with the gun before he finished, and the man went across the table into a bottle of champagne.

The other man reached under his jacket.

Marcellus fired.

The sound stopped the whole room. The man fell back against the booth and slid down holding his shoulder. He lived. Marcellus would hear that again and again later, as if it were the part of the night he'd hoped to get wrong.

Valentino had disappeared behind the booth.

The old man went after him through a door beside the bar. A corridor. Another door. A room full of jewelry laid out beneath bright lights, rings and watches and little boxes bearing names he recognized.

His own tools sat on a table.

He picked one up. Turned it over. His initials were still there, small and careful, engraved when he'd first had enough money to believe he would own things for a long time.

The diamond wasn't.

Behind him a door opened. Two men came in from the corridor. Another appeared at the far end of the room.

Marcellus turned with the gun in his hand.

"Where is it?"

Nobody answered.

The first blow took him behind the ear. He went against the table. Rings scattered across the floor. He tried to keep the gun up and couldn't. Somebody caught his wrist, somebody else hit

his stomach, and the whole room tipped until his cheek was against the cold tiles among things he'd once made beautiful.

When the police came, Valentino stood in the doorway explaining what a dangerous man grief could make.

Marcellus could hear him.

That was why he tried to stand again.

That was why the men holding him wouldn't let him.

They carried him through the club past the singer, past the gold doors, past the taxi still waiting at the curb. The driver held up his meter like the night might still become ordinary if somebody paid for it.

Celeste came to the station wearing slippers.

Marcellus saw them first. Little blue slippers with one heel crushed under her foot. She had hurried so much she hadn't put them on properly.

"I didn't find it," he told her.

She looked at the blood on his face.

"I found you."

He couldn't answer her. He told Dante he'd spent eight years trying to get back to that moment with something better in his mouth.

"Nigga," I said when Shawna stopped, "Red got to die."

She squeezed my hand.

"Keep listening."

"I'm listening. That's what the listening is doing."

Marcellus went to prison.

Red opened the Saint with money raised against a diamond he said he'd bought from a respected jeweler. Marcellus read about it in a magazine somebody left in the visiting room.

Celeste visited him as long as she could.

At first she wore bright dresses and told him stories from the lounge. When he interrupted to ask which men had been asking about the necklace, she told him to eat the candy she'd brought.

Later she came less often because she was sick. He thought she was punishing him. They argued through the glass about a doctor she hadn't mentioned and money he couldn't send.

During her last visit, she wore the earrings he had made before either of them knew a man called Red.

"I want you to do something," she said.

"What?"

"Remember the first thing you ever gave me."

"The earrings."

"No."

"The little bracelet."

“No, Marcellus.”

He looked at her, frightened now because he couldn't get it right.

“A ride,” she said. “I was standing in the rain. You drove me home. You didn't ask for my number until we got there.”

“I remember.”

“Then remember that man too.”

She put her hand against the glass.

After she died, a letter arrived among her things. Marcellus carried it until the folds began to split. One night he finally unfolded it in front of Dante and read it aloud.

Shawna said Dante had written the words down after he got out because he was scared of forgetting them. He read them to her on their wedding night. She remembered the ones that mattered. When I met Marcellus later that day, he showed me the paper itself, and I read the rest with my own fucking eyes.

My love,

You think I never understood that stone. I did. I understood every hour you spent getting it right. I know the little words you hid beneath the blue mounting. I know you were waiting for me to find them, and I know you were disappointed when I liked the front so much I forgot to look behind it.

I found them the night you fell asleep with your shoes on. I was angry with you for missing supper. I took the necklace off and nearly dropped it, and there you were underneath, saying what

you used to say at my door.

I came for you.

I wore those words against me every night afterward. You never asked whether I'd found them. You just watched me wear it and smiled.

I am so tired now, Marcellus. I can't keep driving out there. Don't let anybody tell you I stopped because I stopped loving you. I am stopping because I am sick, and I want the strength I have left for things that don't require me to pass through a locked door.

If you get your beautiful stone back, put it down before you touch somebody you love. I know your hands. They are warmer without all that metal in them.

And if you are still angry when you come home, be angry. You always were. Just open the curtains. Pay the piano man what I owe him. There is chicken in the freezer because I never learned how to cook for one.

I would take the ride again.

Celeste.

Shawna stopped.

Nigga, I was still facing the window. I didn't turn around until I could trust my fucking face.

“What did Dante do?” I asked.

“He told Marcellus he'd get it back.”

“For a man he met in prison?”

“For him. For her. For whatever he thought that would make him.”

“And you?”

Her voice was small when she answered.

“I thought I married the kind of man who'd do that.”

I nodded. I didn't like the dead nigga any better. I just had a harder time hating him the easy way.

“Dante took the three million first,” she said. “He wanted money to get Marcellus a lawyer and buy us a way out when Red found out what else he wanted. He thought T would choose him. T was his brother.”

“But he didn't.”

“No.”

She lifted the watch.

“The last night Dante came home, he asked me whether this still looked too big on me. I told him everything he owned was too big on me. He said he'd put something in it that fit.”

I looked at her.

“What something?”

“I thought he meant himself.”

She worked the clasp open with shaking hands.

For the first time since I met her, the dead nigga was about to give us something we could use.

7. Let Him Think You Love Him

Shawna had spent eight months missing Dante. She'd worn the watch since taking it out of Valentino's glove compartment the night she killed him. She had slept with it, showered with it, hit a man with it. Nigga, she had never noticed the back of the clasp was thicker than it needed to be.

I noticed because I was jealous of the motherfucker.

I'd stared at that watch from across tables, across beds, from underneath her hand when she touched my face. My nigga, I knew every scratch on the thing. When she opened it and the small inner piece moved against her thumbnail, I saw the line immediately.

“Wait,” I said.

She looked up.

“There's something there.”

We didn't know how to open it properly. Shawna called Rosa for the name of a jeweler she trusted. Rosa said she trusted a man who owed her money because she knew where he lived. I said that was close enough.

The jeweler arrived an hour later, took one look, and asked who had built the clasp.

“Marcellus Vale,” Shawna said.

“You know where he is?”

“In prison.”

“No,” he said. “He got out nine days ago. Came into my shop asking whether I still had his old bench.”

Shawna grabbed my arm.

I looked at the jeweler.

“Nigga, call him.”

“I'm not—”

“Then call him whatever you are. Just call the fucking man.”

He did. Marcellus said almost nothing on the phone until Shawna told him her name.

Then, I heard him ask a question from across the room.

“Dante's wife?”

She put her hand over her mouth and nodded before she remembered he couldn't see her.

“Yes.”

The old nigga came before sunset.

He was sixty-two, tall and narrow, with close gray hair and a brown coat that didn't suit the weather. He carried a paper bag containing a clean shirt. Everything else he'd owned was apparently somewhere he couldn't get to anymore.

He had barely reached the gate when three men got out of a car behind him.

I saw it from the front steps. The old man stopped. The tallest of the three caught his coat, and the paper bag fell out of his hand.

Nigga, I had just paid to have my gate repaired after Roman's people. Now another set of niggas had decided my driveway was the place to finish a conversation.

"Tank!"

He came out of the side door with a piece of bread in his mouth. Saw the gate. Took the bread out.

"Those your jeweler's friends?"

"They holding him like enemies."

Shawna was behind me before I reached the steps. She saw the old man and stopped breathing for a second.

"Marcellus."

I looked back at her.

Then I went to get her nigga.

The tall man had Marcellus against the bars. Thirty-five or so, purple suit, pale scar on his cheek, rings on every finger except the one he'd apparently decided needed to stay humble.

"Go inside," he told me.

"Nigga, I came outside for you. Don't make the trip disappointing."

He glanced at Tank and readjusted his grip on the old man's coat.

"Private business."

"My private gate. See how a nigga keeps turning up in your problem?"

One of the other men opened his jacket. A pistol showed against his belt.

I looked at it. Then back at the man.

"That's nice. You buy a second one for when that one leaves you?"

He pulled it.

Tank moved before it cleared the jacket. Hit the man against the car so hard the back window broke. The third man swung at me. I caught his shoulder, turned with him, and put him face-first into the stone pillar beside the gate.

The tall man dragged Marcellus in front of himself.

A gun appeared against the old man's coat.

Everything stopped.

I could hear Shawna behind me say, "Don't." I didn't know whether she meant me or him. The old man looked past the gun at the paper bag on the ground.

His clean shirt lay in the dust.

"Pick it up," Marcellus said.

The tall man blinked.

"What?"

"My shirt."

"Nigga, you out your fucking mind?"

"No," Marcellus said. "I've been out nine days. That is the only shirt I have bought."

The nigga holding him looked at me, as if he expected somebody reasonable to explain why the situation wasn't respecting his gun.

I held out one hand.

"Let him get the shirt."

"You think I'm stupid?"

"Nigga, I'm giving you a chance to surprise me."

He pulled Marcellus back another step. The old man's shoe caught his bag. He stumbled, and for half a second the gun moved away from his chest.

I hit the gate with both hands.

It swung hard into them. Metal struck the tall man's arm. The gun went off into the driveway, kicking a white chip out of the

stone. Marcellus dropped. I caught the man's wrist against the bars and held it there while he tried to turn toward me.

Nigga, his rings were pretty. His bones were ordinary.

The gun fell. I drove him into the gate again and let him slide down it.

Tank had the other two on the ground. One was cussing. The other was reconsidering breathing loudly. Shawna ran past me to Marcellus and got her hands under his arms.

"You hurt?"

"My coat."

"Fuck the coat. Are you hurt?"

He shook his head.

Mercedes came through the gate with the clean shirt in her hands. She'd taken it off the ground while everybody else was watching me. She brushed the dust from its sleeves and held it up to the sunlight.

"Little wash," she told him. "You're handsome again."

The old man looked at her like he hadn't been spoken to that gently in years.

I turned back to the nigga on the ground.

"Who are you?"

"Felix."

"Felix what?"

"Barrow."

"What you want with him?"

Felix swallowed. He kept looking at his empty hand.

"He owes people."

"Which people?"

"People inside. He made things. Things got promised."

I looked at Marcellus. The old man shook his head once.

"I promised him nothing."

"There you go," I told Felix. "Nigga ain't got your promise. You ain't got your gun. Everybody learned something."

Felix looked past me at the house, the cars, the women standing with the old man, Tank holding two grown men down with one look.

"You're that Aiden."

"Which one you hoping for?"

"The boat. The hearse."

"Nigga, you're behind. There's two boats."

Mercedes laughed. Tank did too. Even Marcellus looked at me a little differently, like Shawna's six repetitions of my name had finally found enough room to stand.

Felix put his head back against the bars.

"I should've asked where he was going."

"Nigga, you should've stayed home."

Knox's men came for the three of them. Tank called. I didn't ask what he said. I was busy taking Marcellus inside while Shawna held one of his hands and Mercedes carried his clean shirt like the nigga had arrived with a flag.

At the door, the old man stopped and looked up at me.

"Dante would've liked you."

"Nigga, everybody gets there. Some men just take the long way."

He smiled then. Small, but real. The whole hard face opened enough that I could see the man Celeste must have come home to before anybody took anything.

"Apparently," he said, "I came to the right house."

I introduced myself properly at the front door.

"Aiden."

"I know."

"People talking?"

"Dante's widow said your name six times on the telephone."

I liked the old nigga right then.

He looked at the cross on my chest. He touched it once, with a fingertip.

“I did those letters. Dante sent the cross in with the watch. Said his wife thought he was magnificent, and the nigga wasn't arguing.”

“Then come inside.”

Nigga, Shawna crossed the room too fast and stopped just short of him. For a second neither of them knew what to do. Then he put the paper bag down and opened his arms.

She cried against his coat.

I watched the old nigga's hand settle carefully between her shoulders. His eyes closed. He hadn't seen Dante die. Neither had she. They had each kept a different part of him alive, and now they were standing in my expensive fucking living room discovering the other part had been real.

My nigga Tank came back from the gate carrying a bag of food. He saw them, lowered the bag, and went quiet.

“Who this?” he asked me.

“Marcellus.”

Tank looked toward the door.

The old nigga looked at Tank's face for a long second.

“Your friend?” he asked me.

“Yeah.”

“I see.”

He didn't say anything else. Tank put the food down and went back outside.

Marcellus opened the watch while we waited at the table. My nigga worked with the patience of a man who had spent years having nowhere to hurry.

Dante had asked him about a place to keep a letter when they were still inside. After Dante got out, a watch had reached Marcellus through a legal repair commission arranged by an old client. He had made the clasp for him and sent it back. I let the old man finish telling me that because I wanted to hear Dante had planned to live long enough to read whatever he hid.

Nigga, a thin folded piece of paper lay inside.

Marcellus set it on the table. He put his hands flat beside it and didn't touch it again.

Shawna opened it.

The paper had been torn from a longer note. Red ink. The same slanted, crowded handwriting I'd been holding in the car that morning.

T — He has the withdrawal and Vale's story. If he gets the stone, he can name every one of us. Finish Dante tonight. No more brother shit. Valentino takes the watch. Keep her alive. I'll deal with her. R.

Underneath, in darker ink, Dante had written four words.

Shawna. If I'm wrong.

She read it twice. The third time she didn't finish.

“No,” she said.

I reached for her hand. She pulled away and stood so quickly the chair fell over.

“No. He knew?”

Marcellus watched the note.

“He suspected.”

“He fucking knew.”

I picked up the paper, and everything in me went still.

Nigga, there wasn't a word on it about protecting her. There wasn't a word about Valentino acting alone. Red had ordered a man's death and chosen where the widow would go before the body was cold.

I heard the nigga saying he'd bought her dress.

I heard the nigga saying the piano was still there.

“Nigga,” I said very quietly.

Marcellus looked at me.

I had no idea which of those dead motherfuckers Dante had taken that note from. I didn't know why he hadn't run the minute he read it. He had still written *if*, like he could find some version of those words that didn't mean what they meant.

I knew that part. T had put his hand on my neck and called me son. I had been ready to believe the nigga right up until he told me to fetch Shawna.

She was standing by the window with both hands on her head.

“He went to talk to his brother,” she said. “He told me there was a mistake he had to straighten out. I was mad because he wouldn't stay for dinner.”

Marcellus closed his eyes.

“I told him I'd throw his plate away.”

I got up.

“Shawna.”

“Don't say it.”

“I wasn't—”

“Don't fucking say there was nothing I could do. I could've locked the door. I could've gone with him. I could've—”

“You could've died too.”

She slapped me.

Hard. Right across the mouth that still wasn't properly healed.

Nigga, I stood there with blood coming back onto my tongue.

Her hand stayed in the air.

“Aiden.”

I took a breath through my nose. The whole room was waiting for me to become the worst man in it.

Nigga, I reached for her wrist, lowered her hand, and let go.

“I'm going outside.”

I went outside.

—

Tank was by the lake throwing pieces of bread to the birds. The nigga looked up when he saw my mouth.

“What happened?”

“Don't.”

My nigga put the bread down.

I stood beside him until I could breathe without wanting to break something that had cost me money.

“She hit you?”

“Nigga, I said don't.”

“All right.”

Nigga, a bird walked up between us and took the whole remaining roll.

Tank watched it go.

“That was mine.”

“Go tell him.”

He didn't move.

Nigga, I almost laughed. It hurt too much, so I sat on the low wall instead.

“Red ordered it,” I told him. “Dante. We got his own fucking handwriting.”

Tank stared at the water.

“You know?”

“No.”

“You heard anything?”

“I heard Dante took money.”

“And that's all?”

“That was all anybody was saying around me.”

He looked at me finally.

“I didn't know him like that. T had me moving things. Driving people. I wasn't in every room.”

I wanted to believe the nigga. I wanted somebody I loved to tell me a complete fucking thing before another man handed me the part they'd left out.

“I'm taking Red's diamond,” I said.

Tank's jaw shifted.

“And then?”

“And then I'm going to look at how poor the motherfucker got.”

“Forty million ain't all he has.”

“Then I'll stay busy.”

The back door opened. Shawna came out carrying a wet cloth. She had taken Dante's watch off. It was in her other hand.

Tank picked up the empty bread bag and walked away.

She stood in front of me.

“I shouldn't have done that.”

“No shit.”

“Can I see?”

I let her touch my chin. She cleaned the blood off my mouth, and I looked past her because I was still too angry to look at her without saying something cruel.

“I love him,” she said.

“I fucking know, Shawna.”

“I love you too.”

“You tell him that before he left?” I asked.

She shook her head.

“I was mad about dinner.”

I looked at her then.

She put the cloth down and touched my face with her empty hand.

“I love you,” she said again.

Nigga, I took her hand and pressed it against my chest so she could feel what the shit was doing to me.

“Don't hit me again.”

“I won't.”

“And don't take that watch off because you think it'll shut me up. Put it back on. I want the whole thing when you tell me something.”

She looked down at it.

Then she put it back on.

We ate the food my nigga Tank had bought. Marcellus kept Celeste's old letter beside his plate in a clear sleeve. He let me read it while he ate. When I gave it back, he put it inside his coat with the same careful movement Shawna used with Dante's photograph.

“You want your stone?” I asked him.

“Yes.”

“You want Red dead?”

He looked at Shawna.

“Yes.”

“Nigga, I think we can work together.”

He didn't smile.

Shawna laid the invitations on the table.

“He's putting it on display in three nights.”

Marcellus picked one up. The front showed a blue necklace I recognized from Shawna's description.

“He's putting something on display,” he said.

“There's two,” I said.

“Yes.”

“You tell them apart?”

“Of course.”

“Then you're going.”

“He knows my face.”

“He knows the face he put in prison eight years ago. We'll give you another suit and somebody else's name.”

Rosa, who had come back while we were eating, looked at him.

“I know a woman who can make you look like a man with money.”

Marcellus looked around my dining room.

“Apparently it's easy to confuse people.”

Tank covered his mouth with his napkin. I let the old nigga have that one. He'd been through a lot.

“There are different settings,” Marcellus said. “The blue outer mounting can be removed. A buyer might wear the stone another

way. The original has a flaw inside it. Very small. I remember exactly where it is. The copy doesn't."

"But the necklace in the picture?" Shawna asked.

"Could hold either."

I sat back.

"Then we get you close enough to look."

Red wanted her back. That was the part we had that forty million dollars couldn't buy him. He wanted Shawna walking into his room while other men watched. Nigga, he wanted every motherfucker who'd heard she left him to see her choose him instead.

Shawna knew it too.

"I can get him to invite us closer," she said.

"No."

"Aiden."

"No."

"You haven't heard what I'm saying."

"I heard it in the way you sat up."

She reached across the table and took my hand.

"I tell him I made a mistake. That you scare me. That I'm bringing you to the gala because I want him to handle it quietly."

Tank looked at her.

“And he believes that?”

“He wants to.”

My fingers tightened around hers.

“What else?”

“I tell him I know where your money is.”

“I don't have his fucking money.”

“He doesn't know that.”

Tank put his glass down a little too carefully. I was watching Shawna. I missed it until later.

“Tell him I'm tired of running,” she said. “Tell him I'll come back if he clears the debt and leaves you alive.”

“Nigga, why he going to leave me alive?”

“Because I'm going to say you can give him the west side.”

I let go of her hand.

The room went quiet again.

She leaned toward me.

“I'm saying what he'll listen to. You know that.”

I did know. It still felt like watching her put on the dress he'd bought.

Marcellus folded the invitation and set it down.

“If he believes she can give you to him, he'll want you close enough to take.”

“Then he can fucking try.”

Rosa looked at Shawna. “You get near the jewel, the old man looks at it, we leave with what's his. You do not decide to kill somebody in the middle because you get mad.”

Shawna said nothing.

Rosa pointed at me.

“You either.”

“Nigga, why everybody looking at me?”

“Because you have the face,” she said.

Tank nodded as if that settled it.

Shawna made the call from our bedroom with me sitting beside her.

Red answered on the second ring.

“There she is.”

She closed her eyes. I put my hand on her knee.

“Can you talk?”

“For you?”

Nigga, I wanted to take the phone and put it through the fucking wall. I left my hand where it was.

“I think I made a mistake,” she said.

Red didn't answer immediately.

Outside, the lake had gone black. Our reflection floated in the window: her with the phone, me beside her like a man waiting for a verdict.

“He hurt you?” Red asked.

Nigga, she looked at the cut on my mouth.

“I don't know what he's going to do next.”

“Come home.”

“I can't just leave.”

“Yes, you can.”

“You want the money. You want his streets. I can bring him to you, Red. But you have to promise me something.”

“Anything.”

The ease of it made me sick. The nigga had put a man's death in a note shorter than the promises he was making to his widow.

“You let him live,” she said.

Red sighed.

“You're too good to these boys.”

Nigga, my hand left her knee.

My nigga, she caught it before I could stand.

“I know where he's keeping the money,” she said. “I can get him to bring what you need. At the gala, I'll stay close to you. Everybody can see I'm back. After that, you talk to him.”

“And you stay?”

She looked at me.

“Yes.”

Red let out a breath into the phone. Nigga, I heard the pleasure in it. I heard how badly the nigga had wanted to win.

“Wear the blue dress,” he said. “The one I liked.”

“I will.”

“And Shawna?”

“What?”

“I knew you'd remember who loved you.”

She hung up without answering.

I knew it was a lie. I had helped make it. Every fucking word still hurt.

She took my face in both hands.

“Look at me, Aiden.”

I did.

“I'm here.”

Nigga, I pulled her into me, too hard, and my side burned. I held on anyway.

Downstairs, the old man was measuring the empty space where his wife's diamond ought to have been. Tank was on the phone with somebody he wasn't ready to name. Rosa was choosing a dress that would make a killer forget the last thing he'd been careful about.

And me? I was holding my woman and imagining forty million dollars in one hand, Red's whole fucking life in the other.

Three nights.

Nigga, I could wait three nights.

I told myself that until morning.

8. Our Valedictorian Has a Gun

Nigga, I found out I was graduating from college while I was deciding which gun went with breakfast.

Tank brought the envelope into the kitchen. Cream paper. Gold crest. My name written so beautifully I almost respected the nigga who'd taken that much time over it.

"School," he said.

"Whose?"

"Yours."

"Nigga, I got a school?"

Shawna stopped pouring coffee. Rosa turned around on her stool. Mercedes, who had stayed the night after deciding my guest room understood her better than her apartment, put down a piece of toast.

Tank handed me the letter.

"Las Vegas College."

I looked at the crest.

"Oh. Those niggas."

"You went to college?" Shawna asked.

"I went to the building."

"When?"

"Twenty-two. They had free lunch."

Tank opened the second page while I read the first.

"Nigga, they saying you're valedictorian."

I nodded slowly.

"They paying attention over there."

Rosa took the page from him.

"Aiden, you never mentioned taking a class."

"Nigga, I never mentioned owning a horse statue either. Some greatness comes to the house on its own."

Shawna leaned over my shoulder. Her hair brushed my cheek. The letter congratulated me on the highest marks in the college's history, invited my guests to the front row, and said the ceremony began at eleven.

It was nine twenty.

"Baby," she said, "what did you do to these people?"

I thought about it.

I'd gone to the college two years earlier because a friend said their adult scholarship day had food. Everyone in the program was at least twenty-two, old enough to know what rent did to a dream. I had been exactly that old and exactly that hungry.

They gave me a plate, a registration form, and a booklet full of placement questions. The woman at the desk said the lunch was for applicants. I liked the chicken enough to become one.

I filled out the booklet while I ate. Math. Reading. A page asking me to fix a piece of music that sounded wrong even on paper. Another asking what a man ought to do when two promises tried to kill each other. I wrote until the chicken was gone, handed it back, and left with two rolls in my pocket.

Apparently the niggas had been discussing that lunch for two years.

"I remember now," I said.

Tank stared at me.

"You ate your way into a degree."

"Nigga, I thought while I chewed. Try it."

Porsche came in wearing sunglasses and carrying a garment bag. She'd heard enough from the hall to start smiling before she reached the table.

"You're going."

"I got plans."

"You got three nights until Red's gala. You got this morning until eleven. You're going."

Shawna took the invitation from my hand and kissed me.

"I want to see my man graduate."

Nigga, that was the whole argument.

We arrived in a convoy because education deserved respect.

Tank drove the black Mercedes. Porsche drove Leon's newest Bentley, which was dark green because he said white brought back too many memories. Mercedes sat beside her with a camera. Rosa wore a yellow suit bright enough to make the campus flowers look underfunded. Marcellus had his clean shirt on and a tie Rosa had chosen for him. He looked like somebody had remembered he was worth inviting places.

Shawna wore white again. This time nobody had to die for the outfit.

I wore black trousers, an open-necked shirt, my gold cross, and a jacket cut to hide the bandages. My gun sat where a man could keep it without making his diploma nervous.

The campus gates were crowded when we turned in. Graduates in blue gowns stood everywhere, grown men and women carrying flowers, checking their phones, trying to get through one morning without their families embarrassing them.

Then they saw me.

A man near the fountain pointed.

"Nigga. That's him."

His friend looked up from a program.

"Who?"

"The Mercedes nigga."

"This a college, Marcus. There's seventeen Mercedes in the parking lot."

"Nigga, the flying Mercedes."

The second man looked properly then. His mouth opened. He looked at the program again and started hitting his friend in the shoulder.

"Our valedictorian?"

"That's what I'm saying!"

"That nigga?"

"That nigga!"

By the time I got out of the car, half the fountain had turned toward us.

A woman came running down the steps holding a blue robe over both arms. She was about forty-six, dark skin, silver glasses, hair pinned so precisely I could tell she'd spent her life correcting men who thought imprecision was a personality.

"Aiden," she said, almost breathless. "Professor Yvonne Halcyon. We met at your admission."

"You had the chicken."

She smiled like I'd remembered a wedding vow.

"You remember."

"Nigga doesn't forget a good plate."

She put the robe into my hands.

"We have been looking for you."

"I been around."

"We've seen."

Her eyes went to the Mercedes, and I realized she'd seen a lot.

Principal Percival Mercer came out behind her in a blue academic robe with so much gold on it that I wanted to ask whether he was graduating or getting crowned. Sixty years old, deep voice, handsome gray beard, a man accustomed to being the most impressive thing approaching a microphone.

He saw me and began crying before we shook hands.

"At last," he said.

Tank leaned toward me.

"Nigga, what the fuck was in that booklet?"

"Apparently me."

Mercer took my hand in both of his.

"Your work changed this college."

"Which part?"

"The final page."

I tried to remember it.

"The blank one?"

"You used it to correct the examination."

"There was a mistake."

"There were six. We had found two in twenty years."

I nodded. That sounded like something I'd do while waiting for dessert.

He held up a folder. Inside was my handwriting, impatient and slanted, beside a little grease mark from the lunch. They had framed the original. This was a copy.

"The scholarship board accepted your independent work in place of the standard course sequence," Halcyon said. "Your essays circulated through four departments. Your music analysis repaired the conservatory's examination. Professor Lorne has been teaching your final solution since last spring."

"Nigga, I hope Lorne got a nice voice."

A man behind her lifted one hand.

"I do my best."

He looked genuinely nervous about disappointing me.

Shawna turned toward me, eyes bright.

"You didn't tell me any of this."

"Baby, I didn't know the niggas kept it."

The graduates nearby laughed. One of them took off his cap and shook his head, smiling helplessly.

"I came every night for three years."

I looked at him.

"And you here, ain't you?"

He straightened.

"Yeah."

"Then come on. Niggas graduating."

He put his cap back on and fell in beside us like I'd just personally admitted him into the morning.

They took me through the science hall on the way to the auditorium because Principal Mercer wanted me to see what my name had done to a wall.

There it was. AIDEN HALL. Gold letters. Taller than my head. I stood under them while Tank took a picture and Shawna laughed into her hand.

"Nigga, I got a hall."

"You got several," Mercer said.

"Don't tell him that," Rosa said. "He'll start naming the doors."

Inside, three professors stood around a long table covered in papers. They had been arguing when we came in. I could see it in the way they all stopped speaking at slightly different times.

Professor Lorne looked down at a page and then up at me.

"Perhaps you could settle something."

Halcyon made a little warning noise.

"He has a ceremony."

"One minute."

"Nigga, everybody thinks they need a minute until I get here," I said. "Show me."

He turned the paper around. A drawing of the new auditorium roof. Lines crossing. Numbers beside them. Somebody had used a red pen to circle the same span three times.

"The model gives us two possible answers," he said.

I looked at the drawing. Then through the window at the actual auditorium.

"You got the old roof in here."

He blinked.

"The dimensions—"

"Changed when they moved the stage. Look at that window. It's eight panels across. Your drawing got seven."

All three professors turned toward the window.

I took the pencil and moved the line.

"Now your load goes there. Those two numbers stop fighting."

Lorne looked at what I'd written. His mouth moved without sound.

The professor beside him pulled another sheet from the pile, compared them, and sat down so suddenly his chair rolled backward.

"He's right."

"Nigga, say it like you enjoyed finding out."

"He's right!"

The room laughed. Mercer started crying again.

I looked at Shawna.

"Your man got a roof."

She hooked her fingers through my robe.

"My man better get under it before they name another building."

As we left, Lorne caught my arm gently.

"What do you do for a living?"

Tank answered before I could.

"Nigga improves transportation."

The auditorium was packed. A choir stood above the stage. Blue banners hung from the balcony. The youngest graduate was

twenty-two and the oldest was sixty-eight, and every one of those grown people had brought somebody who wanted to see their name become something they could hold.

Our people took the front row. Shawna sat in the middle. Tank sat at the aisle because every chair in that room looked like it had been built to underestimate him.

Chief Gloria Knox stood beside the stage.

I stopped when I saw her.

"Nigga, you following me to school now?"

"I was invited."

"You graduating?"

"I was hoping to recruit the valedictorian."

Behind her, under a dark blue cloth, stood something low and wide enough to make my pulse change.

A car.

I could see the nose through the fabric. I knew what kind of nose that was. Nigga, a Lamborghini could wear a bedsheet and I'd still recognize its ass in a church parking lot.

Knox watched me looking.

"Finish your speech first."

"Chief, that's cruel."

"Motivation."

She smiled and took her place beside Mercer.

The ceremony began. Names. Applause. People walking across the stage trying not to cry before their family did. I stood behind the curtain listening, the robe hanging open enough to let my cross shine.

Shawna kept looking back at me. Every time she did, my chest got bigger. I had a bullet in my body, three nights until a man tried to take her from me, and a whole college waiting to find out how I sounded when somebody gave me a microphone on purpose.

Then the lights flickered.

I looked up.

A man stood in the upper aisle wearing a gray suit. He wasn't watching the stage. He was watching the doors.

Another man stood beside the exit under the balcony.

Their jackets hung wrong.

Nigga, I knew that shape better than I knew my own fucking curriculum.

I caught Knox's eye. Looked toward the balcony.

She saw him.

The man under the balcony pulled his gun as the first flame ran up the curtain behind the choir.

The fire moved fast.

Blue fabric turned orange. Somebody screamed from the choir. The gunman by the exit fired into the ceiling, and the whole auditorium tried to stand up at once.

I grabbed the microphone.

"Stay off the stairs! Niggas on the floor, heads down!"

My voice filled the room louder than his gun.

Knox fired from beside the stage. The man at the exit fell back behind a row of seats. Her officers moved toward him while Tank got the people in our row down and Shawna pulled Rosa away from the aisle.

Above us, the balcony gunman raised his weapon.

I fired.

He fell against the rail and dropped behind it. His gun hit the empty aisle below. The choir was coming down from its platform, adults in white robes stumbling through smoke, and I ran up to meet them before the first person fell.

"This way!"

A woman with a cane had stopped halfway down. I caught her under the arm. A man behind her took her other side. We carried her to the stage while the curtains burned overhead.

Mercer stood by the lectern holding my diploma against his chest.

"Principal! Move!"

He looked at me through the smoke.

"Your degree—"

"Nigga, I need somebody alive to sign it!"

He moved.

A beam fell across the side exit. Sparks burst upward. The doorway vanished behind fire and broken wood.

The main aisle was jammed with seats somebody had overturned while trying to run. People at the back were getting out, but those closest to the stage couldn't reach them. The fire was between us and the loading doors behind the choir.

I looked at the covered car.

Then at Knox.

She was already pulling the cloth away.

Dark blue. Gold shield on the doors. Low black wheels. A light bar shining across the windshield. The most beautiful fucking police Lamborghini a criminal could ever deserve.

She threw me the keys.

"Don't scratch it."

"Nigga, don't limit me."

Tank reached me as I opened the door.

"You driving in the school?"

"I'm improving the exit."

"Nigga, I went to the wrong fucking college."

He pulled the overturned seats clear of my bumper. I got behind the wheel. The engine woke up with a roar that cut through the fire and the screaming, and every head in front of me turned.

Shawna stood at the edge of the stage holding Mercer's arm.

She looked at the car. Looked at the fire. Looked at me.

Then she smiled.

Not because she wasn't scared. Baby was scared enough to shake. But she knew which nigga she'd come to watch that morning, and she wasn't looking away while I became him.

I drove.

The Lamborghini crossed the stage, took the shallow steps in one hard drop, and hit the blocked aisle with the whole weight of my morning behind it. Seats flew aside. Wood snapped. Smoke closed over the windshield.

I kept going.

Flame washed across the glass as a curtain fell over the hood. For a second I couldn't see anything but orange. Then it slid away, and the far doors appeared directly in front of me.

I put my foot down.

We broke through into daylight.

Both doors came off their hinges. The Lamborghini shot down the broad front steps and landed in the college courtyard with its siren screaming. Behind me, fresh air rushed through the opening I'd made.

People came out after it.

The choir first. Then graduates helping graduates. Then Tank carrying the woman with the cane while Rosa and Mercedes pushed two overturned benches out of the way. Porsche had a fire extinguisher in each hand and was shouting at niggas like she personally owned oxygen.

I got out and ran back up the steps.

Knox met me at the opening with Mercer beside her. Shawna came behind them, one hand over her mouth, the other holding my graduation cap.

"Baby!"

I caught her.

She hit my shoulder with the cap, then put it on my head herself.

"You almost forgot something."

"Nigga, I was making an entrance."

"You made an exit."

"A great man does both."

She kissed me while the whole courtyard watched.

Behind us, the fire crews arrived. Knox's people brought the surviving attackers out in handcuffs. One of them looked at the Lamborghini and shook his head.

"We burned the building."

"And the nigga still came through it," his partner said.

"With a police car."

"Nigga, I saw."

I heard them. Of course I heard them. They'd come to ruin my graduation and now they were reviewing the best part of it together.

I straightened my cap.

"Principal. You got a microphone out here?"

They brought the lectern into the courtyard.

Mercer stood beside it still crying. Halcyon put a hand on his back. Professor Lorne looked at the smoke coming out of the auditorium and then at me with the expression of a man whose roof calculation had just acquired a personal reason to live.

The graduates gathered in front of us. Some had soot on their gowns. Some were holding shoes. Everybody had somebody by the hand.

I stepped up to the microphone.

"Aight. Where we at?"

The laughter rolled across the courtyard, wild and relieved. Tank stood behind Shawna with his arms folded and his face shining. Marcellus had one hand on Rosa's shoulder. Mercedes lifted her camera.

"Niggas, I ain't gonna lie. I wasn't here much."

The laughter got louder.

"You were not here at all!" somebody shouted.

"And look what happened the morning I came. You welcome."

They cheered. A man in the third row took off his cap and waved it over his head.

I looked out at them. All those people. All those grown men and women who'd come back to a classroom after life had given them plenty of reasons to leave it alone. They were looking at me like I could tell them something worth taking into tomorrow.

Nigga, I could do that too.

"You came for your name," I said. "Some of you worked all night and came anyway. Some of you had people telling you this wasn't your kind of room. Some of you got somebody missing today who should've been here making too much fucking noise."

Shawna looked down at her watch. Then back at me.

"But you here. And when the doors caught fire, niggas started carrying each other. I saw that. That part belongs to you. Keep it. Don't let anybody make you little enough to forget it."

I put my hand on the cross.

"Three letters on this. D. B. M."

Tank's eyebrows lifted. Shawna began smiling before I said the words.

"Damn, boy. Magnificent."

The courtyard erupted.

"That's you too," I told them. "Men, women, every grown motherfucker standing here with a cap and a dream. You look in the mirror tomorrow, say it properly. Don't mumble greatness in your own house."

Mercedes shouted, "Say it again!"

"Damn!"

The whole courtyard answered, "Boy!"

I spread my arms.

"Magnificent!"

They shouted it back so loudly the pigeons left the roof of Aiden Hall together.

Mercer put the diploma in my hand while he was still crying. I had driven through a burning auditorium and finished my valedictorian speech before the principal finished his first fucking breakdown.

Nigga, education was going beautifully.

Knox stepped up beside me before anybody could start the next hymn.

Two officers brought a blue velvet box. Another brought a dark uniform jacket with gold braid on its shoulders. The whole courtyard went quiet in stages as people realized the police had come to offer me more than a ride.

"Aiden," Knox said, "you've been making this offer difficult to postpone."

"Chief, I been busy graduating."

"You've also saved my officers' lives, protected this city's people, and demonstrated a relationship with automobiles I have never seen in any man who still has all his limbs."

Porsche applauded first.

Knox opened the box.

A gold captain's badge lay inside.

Not honorary. Not a souvenir. The chief told the entire courtyard that before any nigga could get confused and make me explain it with a siren later.

"Captain Aiden," she said. "Las Vegas Police Department. Actual command. Actual badge. Actual trouble for anyone who thinks otherwise."

Tank bent forward with his hands on his knees.

"Nigga."

Rosa caught his arm.

"You all right?"

"This nigga's a cop."

"I heard."

"My nigga's the police."

"Stand up before he arrests your posture."

Knox held out the badge.

"Raise your right hand."

I did.

The oath she gave me was short. Keep faith with my people. Stand when somebody needed standing for. Use the authority of the badge with my whole name behind it. I spoke every word in front of the chief, the officers, the graduates, and the woman I wanted beside me for the rest of my life.

Then Knox pinned the badge inside my jacket.

"Captain."

I looked down at the gold.

Nigga, my mother would've had to sit down twice.

Shawna came up the steps. Took my face in both hands. Kissed me slowly enough that the police officers started applauding before the students did.

"My man," she whispered.

"Your captain."

"Still my man."

I could've stood there forever letting her settle the rank.

Knox gave me the Lamborghini's keys again. One door had a scratch from the auditorium. The hood smelled like smoke. The siren still worked, because God wasn't going to give a nigga that much greatness and then get petty over wiring.

"It's yours," she said.

"I noticed."

She leaned close enough that only I could hear.

"Red's people used to believe they owned every uniform that mattered in this city. Let him see yours."

I looked at her.

She smiled.

"I know exactly who I recruited, Captain."

We left the college with my diploma on Shawna's lap and the badge inside my jacket. Tank followed in the original Mercedes. The rest of the convoy came behind him, horns sounding all the way to the gates.

Every graduate turned to watch the Lamborghini pass.

At the fountain, Marcus raised his cap and shouted, "That's our nigga!"

His friend shouted, "That's our captain!"

I hit the siren once for both of them.

Shawna put her hand on my leg as the campus disappeared behind us.

"What you doing tomorrow?"

I looked at her. Looked at the road. Let the car stretch its legs beneath us.

"Baby, niggas better not schedule anything they can't afford."

9. Forty Million and One Woman

The morning after my graduation, a nigga tried to rob a casino while I was buying coffee in uniform.

That was his first mistake.

His second was parking in front of my Lamborghini.

I stood outside the coffee shop with two cups in my hands. Shawna sat in the passenger seat wearing sunglasses and my captain's jacket over her dress. She'd taken it off me because she said the gold braid felt good against her wrists. Nigga, the department hadn't had time to miss it yet.

Across the street, four men came out of a casino carrying bags. Behind them an alarm rang. One man had a gun pointed backward toward the doors. Another had a bleeding lip and a look that suggested he had expected the morning to involve less resistance.

Their van stood across my bumper.

I looked at the coffee. Looked at the van. Looked at Shawna.

"Baby, hold these."

She took both cups.

"You getting involved?"

"Nigga involved me when he parked."

The driver saw me coming and laughed.

"Keep walking, pretty boy."

I opened my shirt enough for him to see the badge.

His laugh changed shape.

"Police?"

"Captain."

"You don't look like police."

"Nigga, police improving. Move the van."

The man behind him raised his pistol.

I caught the van's open door and drove it into his arm. The shot went into the street. I hit him against the side panel and took him down while the driver tried to get back behind the wheel.

The van lurched forward.

Its rear doors were still open. Bags of money tumbled out. The driver shouted at his partner to pull them in, and I caught the door handle as the van gathered speed.

"Aiden!" Shawna shouted.

"Coffee!" I shouted back.

I wasn't going to let some nigga make her spill eight dollars on a police uniform.

The van dragged me past the corner. My shoes hit the curb, found it, lost it. I got one foot on the rear step and pulled myself up while the man inside tried to kick me off.

"Nigga, let go!"

"You let go!"

"It's my van!"

"Then your nigga should've moved it!"

I came through the doors and hit him into the pile of bags. The driver looked back. That was enough to put the van halfway onto the sidewalk. A newspaper stand exploded against the windshield. Papers flew everywhere, yesterday's miracles suddenly competing with the one hanging out of a moving fucking robbery.

The man on the floor reached for his gun.

I put my foot on his wrist.

"Don't."

He looked up at me.

"You're Aiden."

"Nigga, you would've had a easier day remembering that at the coffee shop."

The driver turned into a parking structure. Concrete closed over us. Tires screamed on the first ramp. The van tipped, caught, and kept climbing.

I could hear my Lamborghini outside before I saw it.

Shawna came through the entrance behind us with the siren on.

My jacket was back over the seat. The coffee cups sat upright in the holders. My woman was chasing a van full of criminals while saving my breakfast, and nigga, every good thing I'd ever believed about marriage started taking notes.

We hit the second floor. Then the third.

The driver shouted, "She's still behind us!"

"She's thorough," I told him.

"Nigga, who the fuck asked you?"

"You brought me."

At the next turn, Shawna swung the Lamborghini across the ramp above us and stopped.

The driver braked. The van slid. I caught the front seat before I went through it, and the two men behind me hit the bags of money in a way that sounded financially painful.

Shawna got out with her silver pistol in her hand.

"Everybody out."

The driver stared through the windshield.

"She's police too?"

"Nigga, she's worse. She's disappointed."

He put up his hands.

Knox's officers found us on the third floor ten minutes later. Four men on the ground. The stolen money in the van. My Lamborghini blocking the ramp like the city had finally bought itself a beautiful fucking answer.

A sergeant with a gray mustache shook my hand so hard I had to tell him about the coffee.

"Captain, we have been after that crew for months."

"Niggas parked wrong."

He looked at the van, then back at me.

"We should've tried that."

Shawna handed me my cup. Still warm. Not one fucking drop on the seat.

The sergeant saluted her too.

"Ma'am."

"You can call me Shawna."

"Yes, ma'am."

Nigga, respect sometimes refused to take a suggestion.

The casino owner came to the station before lunch. He brought two gold watches and an envelope. I gave the watches to the two employees the robbers had knocked down, kept the envelope because gratitude ought to reach its address, and bought the whole shift lunch with it.

Knox watched from her office doorway while officers took pictures beside my car.

"How's your first morning?"

"Need a bigger cup holder."

She laughed.

"Anything else?"

"Nigga wants a raise."

"You've been here four hours."

"And look what the four hours did for you."

By evening every officer in the station knew my name. By the next afternoon, when I went to buy the suit for Red's gala, half of them had volunteered to wait outside the Saint in case my night needed company.

I told them to stay close to Knox. Red liked surprises. I intended to give the nigga one wearing a badge.

I bought a white suit for the robbery because I wanted Red to see who ruined his fucking life.

The tailor tried to sell me black. Then he tried to sell me dark blue. He had Shawna on a little velvet chair behind me, drinking champagne and telling him I looked handsome in everything, which meant she hadn't looked up from her phone once.

“Nigga, white,” I told him. “I want the whole room seeing who came.”

“Your injury—”

“Nigga, is the suit going to heal me?”

The nigga stopped talking about the injury.

Tank stood beside the door in a black suit we had bought forty minutes earlier. He had already torn it reaching for a peppermint. The tailor was pretending not to notice. I wasn't.

“Get the nigga another one too.”

“A larger size?”

“Get that nigga whatever size a cathedral is.”

Tank put the peppermint back.

“Nigga, eat. We rich enough for the candy and whatever seam your ass takes with it.”

Shawna laughed then. She lifted her eyes, and for a second I had her. No dead husband. No diamond. No Red waiting for his chance. Just my woman laughing because I was standing in a thousand pins threatening to buy a church-sized suit for the biggest motherfucker in Nevada.

My nigga, I would've bought the actual church to keep her laughing.

Between graduating, becoming a captain, and chasing a van through a parking garage, I had still found time for the three

days before the gala to do something terrible to me. I could take a bullet. I could bury a man who called himself my father. But sitting beside Shawna while she told Red over the phone that she missed him had me walking around my own house like I was looking for somebody to rob.

I knew the plan. Nigga, I had agreed to the plan. I had nodded while she explained it and said some shit about trusting her. Then she had put Red on speaker and called him baby, and all that intelligent shit left my body.

“You don't have to say it to that nigga like that,” I told her afterward.

“Like what?”

“With your mouth.”

She stared at me.

“Aiden.”

“Nigga got a name. Use the name.”

She hung up on the argument by kissing me. I let her. The second night I made the same complaint, and she kissed me again. By the third, she knew exactly what I was doing and told me to come over there without starting a fight first.

Now the tailor knelt beside my shoes while she answered another message.

“That nigga again?”

“Rosa.”

“Let me see.”

She turned the screen. Rosa had sent a picture of six gowns thrown across a bed and the words *Your nigga paying for all this?*

“Tell her your nigga said yes.”

“You don't know how much it is.”

“Tell her yes in capital fucking letters.”

Shawna put her phone away. Then she stood and walked around the tailor to straighten my collar herself.

“You know you're allowed to be scared tonight.”

“I'm not.”

“Okay.”

“You are?”

“Yes.”

I caught her wrist before she could step away. Dante's watch slid down against my fingers. I let it.

“Then your nigga scared too.”

She kissed the uncut corner of my mouth.

“Good. Maybe you'll listen.”

I listened to every fucking thing she said. I just sometimes decided the whole world was wrong after I heard it.

At the house, Rosa had turned our bedroom into a kingdom of women getting dressed. There were shoes on the chairs, perfume in the air, and a bottle of champagne standing in the sink beside my toothbrush. Somebody had moved my gun to make room for a heated hairbrush. Nigga, I owned the house, and they asked me why I was in there.

“Nigga, because I sleep here.”

“Not while we're busy,” Rosa said.

She was wearing red, diamonds at her throat, and an expression that told me she had already decided who was going to disappoint her that night.

“I need Shawna.”

“Your nigga needs patience,” Rosa told Shawna.

“Nigga, I bought patience. They said it'll be here tomorrow.”

Rosa picked up a shoe. A nigga left.

Downstairs, Marcellus sat by the windows in a gray suit. Somebody had polished his shoes until they looked wet. The disguise was supposed to make him a wealthy old jeweler, which mostly involved getting him a better jacket and telling him not to look like he wanted Red dragged behind a car.

My nigga still looked like that.

On the table in front of him lay Celeste's letter. The folds were so worn they looked ready to separate. He wasn't reading it. He had laid one hand across the paper like somebody might reach down from heaven and take it back.

"My nigga, tell me you ready," I said.

"I have been ready for years."

"Nigga, that's not what I asked."

He looked up, and for the first time since I met him, the old man almost smiled.

"Yes, Aiden."

I sat across from him. My side objected. That bullet had settled into my life like it intended to pay rent. Every time I forgot it, the pain came back to tell me who had put it there.

Marcellus glanced at the way I lowered myself.

"Does she know how much that hurts?"

"She knows everything."

"Does she?"

I looked toward the stairs.

"Nigga, she knows enough."

He folded Celeste's letter and put it in his inside pocket.

"The stone cannot love you back," he said.

"I got somebody for that."

“Then remember which one you came for.”

Before I could answer, Tank walked in holding two phones. He turned one facedown as soon as he saw us.

“Niggas, the cars ready.”

“What nigga calling you?”

“Nobody.”

“Nigga, then why you got two phones?”

“In case somebody does.”

I would've laughed on any other night. That night I watched him put both in his pocket, and something in my stomach moved. I thought about asking again. Then I heard Shawna on the stairs.

My nigga, everything in me turned around.

She wore blue. Dark blue, cut close to her body, with a train dragging behind her like even the floor wanted to hold on.

Diamonds touched her ears. Dante's watch was on her wrist. Her hair was up, and that little scar above her eyebrow stood out plainly. I loved the scar. I loved knowing the exact place on her face where the world had tried some shit and failed.

“Rosa's dress,” she said when she saw me looking. “She never wore it.”

“Nigga, I said I'd buy you anything.”

“I wanted this one.”

Rosa lifted the train off the last stair.

“And I want it back. Both of you hear me?”

“Yes,” Shawna said.

I should've heard how softly she said it.

Rosa came down behind her carrying a small envelope.

“I've got the watch paper,” she said. “The original. Nobody gets it off me.”

The order hidden in Dante's watch was inside. Red's words. Red's decision. All the grief he had handed Shawna while pretending he was helping her carry it.

Shawna had made a copy for tonight. Rosa would keep the original safe, along with the truth if none of us came back.

I didn't like thinking about that second part, so I stood up.

“Turn around for your nigga,” I told Shawna.

She did.

“Again.”

“Aiden.”

“Nigga, I'm trying to remember whether there's anybody left alive I need to thank.”

She slipped her little silver pistol into her purse, then came over and put both hands against my chest.

“If you tear this dress, I'm killing you before Red gets the chance.”

“Your nigga will buy the factory.”

“I'll kill you in the factory.”

I kissed her. I kissed her until Tank cleared his throat, then I kissed her again because that nigga did not determine the length of my happiness.

We went to the Saint in four cars. I drove Shawna in the dark-blue police Lamborghini. Tank kept the original black Mercedes behind us. Rosa drove Marcellus, and Porsche brought Mercedes in the green Bentley.

I wanted six. Tank said we only had enough people for four. I told him to put one nigga in each of the other two, and he asked who was driving. Apparently the man had chosen tonight to become a fucking mathematician.

Four cars pulled under the Saint's canopy. Four cars full of my niggas. It still looked like a palace somebody had built with all the money they should've used to raise their children. Gold everywhere. Flowers as tall as men. A fountain full of coins that were worth less than one button on the security guard's jacket.

Red had made the gala white tie. Nigga thought if he dressed his sins in enough silk, God might mistake them for somebody else's.

I came out in my white suit with the cross against my chest, the captain's badge inside my jacket, and Shawna beside me. Cameras started flashing.

My nigga, that surprised me. I had expected guns.

“Keep walking,” she whispered.

I kept walking like I had paid for the fucking sidewalk.

A photographer asked us to stop against a wall of white roses. Shawna put her hand on my shoulder. I put mine at her waist. A man with a microphone asked whether I was taking over Big T's interests.

“Every nigga that owes them anything owes me,” I said.

“And your relationship with Mr. Redmond?”

Redmond. Nigga had a government name tonight.

“Ask me at the end.”

Rosa stepped between the reporter and us before I could make it worse. Tank followed so closely I felt his jacket brush mine. For a second his hand touched my arm.

“Anything happen tonight,” he said, “you stay with me.”

“Nigga, that was already the idea.”

The nigga didn't answer.

Inside, a staircase curved around a statue of a naked woman holding a bowl of fire. Red had put real flames in the bowl. I

respected that nigga for that one thing. If you were going to waste money, make the building itself nervous.

Women in jewels walked past women who had sold them drugs in the bathroom. Men greeted men they had paid to have killed and had not yet heard back about. A preacher I recognized from television stood beside a man whose entire fortune came from stolen cars. The preacher had the bigger watch.

There was a private lounge full of cocaine and champagne. Somebody called my name from inside. I looked over and saw a man I had spent a filthy weekend with before I ever met Shawna, sitting between two women I had met the same weekend.

He lifted his glass.

“Aiden! You disappear when you fall in love?”

“Nigga, I got promoted.”

The women laughed. Shawna looked at all three, then at me.

“All of them?”

“Your nigga had a long weekend.”

“You nasty motherfucker.”

“You love me.”

She squeezed my hand hard enough to hurt.

“Don't get confident.”

I got confident. I got so fucking confident that when Red came down the far staircase in a dark green jacket, I smiled at him like he had arrived at my party.

He wasn't looking at me.

He was looking at Shawna.

“There she is,” Red said. Nigga sounded like she had come out of his own prayers.

He held out both hands. She gave him one. He kissed it above Dante's watch.

Nigga, I saw the whole murder happen in my mind. His head through the flower arrangement. His green jacket on fire. Me standing over him while the preacher told God to mind His business.

Instead I smiled.

“Nigga, you throw a good party. Shame about your future.”

Red finally looked at me.

“Captain,” Red said, and the word came out like a bone he had to swallow. “You clean up well.”

“You still talking.”

Shawna's fingers tightened against my arm.

Red laughed softly, as if I was a child who had threatened to buy his own house.

“We should get a photograph. All three of us.”

Before anybody could object, he called the photographer over. He put Shawna in the middle. Then he rested a hand against her upper arm. On that hand he wore a broad dark ring with a blue stone set almost flush into it.

Marcellus, a few feet behind us, went perfectly still at the sight of Red holding Shawna. The ring was half-hidden against the green sleeve.

The flash went off.

The nigga asked for another.

I stared straight into the lens. If that photograph ever hung in a museum, people would know which motherfucker had come there to kill somebody.

An attendant brought glossy little copies while Red greeted Rosa. Rosa took two. She tucked them into her purse with a smile I knew cost her real effort.

“Now,” Red said, holding out his arm to Shawna, “I promised this woman a dance.”

Shawna looked at me.

I remembered every word of the plan. I remembered agreeing. I remembered her saying she needed him close and foolish and thinking he had already won.

I also remembered that I had hands.

“One dance,” I said.

Red smiled.

“Let's see what she wants.”

Then he took my woman onto the floor, and I followed them with my eyes like a nigga watching his own heart get carried through traffic.

10. Blue Mercy

The band started playing a song Shawna knew.

I knew she knew it because her face changed before the singer got to the first word. Red saw the change too. He said something against her ear, and she looked down at their hands.

Nigga, I wanted to rip the song out of the speakers.

They turned beneath a chandelier that probably cost enough to feed everybody I had grown up with until the end of time. Red held her close. Not too close for a ballroom. Too close for me.

Tank brought me a drink.

“Nigga, this one for drinking. Don't throw it.”

“Nigga, then why you bring it where I got hands?”

“Nigga might surprise me once. I keep hoping.”

I swallowed half. My side burned. Across the room Marcellus spoke to an older woman wearing a necklace so heavy she looked like she was being slowly arrested by it. He looked ordinary. Harmless. I knew he had a dead wife folded over his heart and a fury older than mine.

That made two of us watching the same dance for different ghosts.

Red turned Shawna. Her blue dress swung around his legs. She smiled at something he said.

“Nigga,” I told Tank.

“Nigga, I see.”

“Nigga.”

“I know.”

“No, you don't.”

My nigga drank his whole glass.

The nigga who came to interrupt my misery wore six championship rings and a gold mouthguard on a chain.

"Captain Aiden."

I looked up.

"Depends who's bleeding."

"Rex Crown."

Tank's eyes moved from the rings to the man's shoulders. Rex was forty-five, built like he'd spent twenty years eating other men's excuses. I knew the face from fight posters outside casinos. Heavyweight champion twice. Ex-champion three times. Nigga had made a whole career out of getting his crown back.

"I know you," I said.

He smiled.

"Heard you think you can fight."

"Nigga, I heard you get paid to. We can both have a nice night."

"Not what I'm asking."

Behind him a little crowd had gathered. Men holding drinks. Women looking from his shoulders to my face. Mercedes stood among them with Porsche beside her, both of them smiling in a way Rex hadn't learned to fear yet.

"He asked you something," one of Rex's friends said.

"And my nigga answered," Mercedes told him. "Try listening with the part of your head you ain't drinking through."

Porsche laughed into her glass.

Rex looked at her. Then at me again.

"Five thousand says I put you down before your woman finishes her dance."

Across the floor Red turned Shawna beneath the lights. The green jacket moved against the blue dress. I watched them for one second too long.

Then I put my drink down.

"Nigga, that's a cheap way to become a story."

Rex spread his hands.

"Twenty."

"You looking for my price or your dignity?"

"A hundred thousand."

The people behind him made a noise. Somebody said his name like they wanted him to think about his children, his savings, his whole fucking future. Rex kept smiling.

I looked at Tank.

"Hold my jacket."

"Your side."

"Hold it on the good side."

He took it reluctantly. The badge flashed inside the lining. Rex looked at the gold, and for half a second I saw him wonder whether he'd challenged a man or an entire department.

Then his friends started cheering, and the nigga chose stupidity with witnesses.

We moved into a little clear space beside the ballroom's tall windows. Nobody stopped the music. Red saw us, saw Rex take off his jacket, and smiled as if he'd just learned his dinner came with entertainment.

Shawna didn't smile.

She looked at me over his shoulder and shook her head once.

I lifted one finger.

One.

She shut her eyes like she was trying to love me without laughing at the size of the task.

Rex rolled his shoulders. Took the mouthguard off his chain. Put it in.

"Nigga brought jewelry he can chew," Tank murmured.

Mercedes bent double laughing.

Rex swung.

Not wild. Not drunk. The nigga knew exactly what he was doing. His fist came at my face with all the years behind it, all the ropes and bells and men who'd already discovered what those hands could make of a morning.

I moved.

His punch went past my cheek. I felt the air on the cut Shawna had cleaned days earlier. I stepped inside his reach and hit him once beneath the ribs.

The sound wasn't loud.

His reaction was.

Rex folded forward. I caught the back of his collar before he fell into the champagne table and held him there with one hand. He tried to straighten. Couldn't. Tried to get enough breath to say something impressive. Couldn't do that either.

The crowd went quiet.

Then Porsche whispered, "Nigga."

Mercedes answered, "Nigga."

Tank looked down at Rex and nodded.

"That's about the whole sentence."

I set the champion gently in a chair.

His friends stared at me. One of them looked at his watch as if time might explain what strength hadn't.

"You said before the dance," I told Rex. "Nigga, you still got two verses. Enjoy them."

The ballroom erupted.

People came over from the far tables. A man pushed a phone toward me. A woman touched my shoulder and said she had watched every one of Rex's title fights and had never seen him sit down so respectfully.

Rex finally got air into his chest.

"Again," he said.

"Nigga, breathe first."

"Again."

"You want a rematch or a hospital bracelet?"

He looked up at me. The anger went out of his face slowly, leaving something almost peaceful behind it.

"What the fuck are you?"

I took my jacket from Tank.

"Her man."

I looked toward Shawna when I said it. Everybody looked with me.

She stood beside Red at the edge of the dance floor. Her hand was still in his, but her face belonged entirely to me. She was smiling now. Proud enough that she couldn't hide it even with the whole plan hanging from her wrist.

Red saw that too.

His smile vanished.

Rex took out a checkbook with hands that still weren't steady. Wrote the amount. Signed it. Held it up.

"I don't welch."

I gave it to Mercedes.

"For you and Porsche. You got my car out of that first night."

She looked at the number, then at me.

"Nigga, that's a hundred thousand dollars."

"You want it smaller?"

"Don't you fucking dare."

She kissed my cheek. Porsche kissed the other one. The whole little crowd laughed, and Rex sat in the middle of it looking at me like a man who'd paid a great deal for a lesson and hated how much he'd learned.

Then somebody behind him pulled a gun.

A thin man in a silver jacket. One of his people. He'd been watching the money change hands with the kind of face men make when another nigga's humiliation starts feeling like their own.

"Give it back," he said.

Mercedes stepped behind me.

I looked at the gun. Looked at Rex.

"Your nigga?"

Rex got up out of the chair.

"Put it away, Silas."

"He made you look—"

"He beat me. Put it away."

Silas didn't.

I caught his wrist as Tank caught his shoulder. The shot went into the ceiling. Crystal rained from a small chandelier above us. People screamed and ducked.

Silas hit the floor with both of us over him.

The gun slid away. Porsche kicked it under an empty table and kept her heel on it. Mercedes put the check inside her purse and then hit Silas with the purse for making her bend down.

Rex stood over his friend, furious.

"Nigga, you pull a gun because I lost?"

Silas looked up at him.

"I was helping."

"You was ruining my fucking reputation twice."

Two of Knox's officers came from the lobby. They'd been outside with the cars. They saw my badge before they saw Silas and immediately changed the direction of their attention.

"Captain?"

"This nigga's evening is over."

They took him away while the band, after one frightened pause, found the song again.

Rex offered his hand.

"You ever need somebody in your corner."

I shook it.

"Stay out of mine first."

He laughed. Carefully, because it hurt. Then he bowed his head once, champion to captain, and went to find a drink he could lift without remembering me.

I turned back to the floor.

Shawna was dancing with Red again.

Nigga, I'd beaten a heavyweight, made two friends a hundred thousand dollars, and arrested a fool in less than a song. None of it had solved the one thing I was looking at.

Shawna told me later what Red said during that dance. She told me every word because I asked her every word, and because some nights loving a woman means hearing the part that makes you want to break your own furniture.

He began with the song.

“You used to sing this upstairs.”

“I sang a lot of things.”

“Before Dante.”

“I had a life before all of you.”

Red drew her a little closer. To everybody else, they looked beautiful. Two people moving together at a party full of people who believed beauty was the best possible excuse.

“You could have that life now.”

“Could I?”

“Whatever you want.”

She looked at the ring on his hand. Blue against the green sleeve. He noticed her looking and turned his hand away to bring her through another step.

“I want him left alone,” she said.

“Already thinking about that nigga?”

“His name is Aiden.”

“I know what the nigga's name is.”

Red smiled for somebody passing them. Shawna had to smile too.

“You said you were tired of running,” he said when they were alone inside the music again.

“I am.”

“You said you wanted to come home.”

“I said I wanted somewhere I could sleep.”

“My bed was never the problem.”

She almost pulled away then. I had seen it from across the room: the small hard line her shoulder made beneath his hand.

He held on.

“Don't do that tonight, Shawna.”

“Then don't talk to me like that.”

For a moment he stopped guiding her. They stood with couples turning on either side.

“Do you know what it felt like?” he asked. “Standing there while he put that ring on you? Paying for a room where you were going to spend the night with him?”

“Dante was your friend.”

“Nigga knew.”

“Knew what?”

“That his nigga saw you first.”

Shawna looked him in the face.

“You all keep saying that like I was a fucking parking space.”

His fingers tightened. Then loosened. He gave another careful smile to the room.

“I could've given you everything.”

“Then give me the diamond.”

The song carried on without them.

“That's what tonight is for,” she said. “You said you wanted me to know how serious you were. Show me.”

“And Aiden?”

“You let him walk out.”

Red looked across the floor at me.

“Will he?”

Shawna put her hand against his cheek.

“He will if I tell him to.”

That was the part of the dance I could see. Her touching his face. His eyes going soft. My woman telling another man something that made him look at me like I was already gone.

I finished my drink.

Nigga, I should've broken the glass in my own hand. It would've been less stupid than what I did next.

Nigga, I went onto the floor.

Tank said my name. Rosa stepped toward me. I kept moving.

I told myself I would only take Shawna aside for a second. Ask if she was all right. Let Red know that whatever he imagined was happening, there was a living nigga standing right there with a say in it.

“Nigga, your dance over,” I said.

Red didn't stop.

“Nigga, you hear the band? The band's still playing.”

I put a hand on his shoulder.

Now he stopped.

Shawna looked at my hand. Then my face. She was trying to tell me something without making a sound, and I was trying so hard to prove I loved her that I stopped listening.

“Nigga, that hand comes off me,” Red said quietly.

“Nigga, yours comes off her first.”

Three men in dark jackets moved from the edge of the room. Tank moved too. The singer saw what was happening and missed a word. The band kept playing under it.

Shawna stepped between us.

“Aiden. Go sit down.”

I stared at her.

“What?”

“You're embarrassing me.”

Nigga, I knew it was supposed to be a lie. I knew we had agreed she might have to hurt my feelings in front of him. Nobody had explained that my feelings were going to show up with fucking guns.

“You mean that about your nigga?”

We had agreed on the slap that afternoon, standing in front of our bedroom mirror. She had refused twice. I had said I could take one slap if it got her close enough to finish the plan. Now she gave me the one we had promised each other.

The sound cracked across the music. The whole room seemed to turn on the same neck.

I looked back at her. Her hand was shaking.

“I told you,” she said, her eyes bright with fury that wasn't all pretend, “to listen to me.”

Red watched us like somebody had just handed him a country.

I stepped back.

For one second, Shawna's face begged me to understand. Then she covered it and turned toward Red.

“Let's finish our dance.”

They moved away together.

I stood there with the whole fucking gala looking at me, and I had never needed a gun less or wanted one more.

Tank caught my sleeve.

“Come on.”

“Don't.”

“Come on.”

He brought me to the side of the room. I let him because I couldn't see where to put my feet.

Rosa came up beside us.

“She just kept you alive,” she said.

“I know.”

“Then act like you know.”

I looked at the floor. My cheek burned where she had hit me. My side burned where T had shot me. Apparently every nigga I loved came with a different place to hurt.

Across the ballroom, Red kissed Shawna's hand again.

This time I stayed where I was.

At nine, Red had the music stopped.

He walked onto a low stage with Shawna beside him. Behind them, attendants opened a curtain. A glass case stood under a white light.

Inside lay Blue Mercy.

I had spent three days hearing about that diamond. Forty million dollars. A marriage. A prison. Dante bleeding in the desert because he had come too close to the truth. Nigga, I expected the thing to stand up and say my name.

Nigga, it was smaller than I expected.

My nigga, that made it worse.

A little blue light in a velvet cradle, and all those lives wrapped around it. I looked at Marcellus. The old man's face went slack. Whatever he had prepared himself to feel, it hadn't been enough.

Red took the microphone.

“Some things wait a long time to come home.”

He looked at Shawna when he said it. People clapped. Nigga had spent his life hurting people and learned to pause in the places where strangers would congratulate him.

“Tonight isn't an auction,” he said. “Nobody in this room can afford what this means to me.”

A man in the front laughed too loudly. Red didn't look at him.

“Tonight is a promise.”

He held Shawna's hand up for the room. Dante's watch slid toward her elbow.

I heard Tank say something under his breath. I didn't ask what.

Marcellus moved forward with the jeweler's case we had brought for him. Red's men let him approach the stage. A name was given. A profession. The old man inclined his head as if he had spent his entire life attending evenings like this without wanting to burn one down.

Red watched him closely.

“You approve?”

Marcellus looked at the glass.

“I would like to see it closer.”

“Later.”

“A piece of this age deserves—”

“Later,” Red repeated.

His ring flashed blue when he lowered the microphone.

Marcellus looked at his hand again.

Then Shawna turned. She found me in the crowd and held my eyes. The plan was still moving. She needed me to move with it.

I nodded once.

Nigga, it felt like swallowing a knife.

An attendant came for me after the presentation.

“Mr. Redmond would like you upstairs.”

“Nigga can come get me.”

Tank touched my arm.

The attendant waited.

I looked toward Shawna. She was speaking to Rosa beside the stage. Rosa had a hand at her back. Both of them looked over when the attendant repeated the invitation.

Shawna nodded.

Fine. Nigga wanted a private conversation, I would give him a private conversation. I was tired of standing under expensive lights while he performed his ownership of everything I wanted alive.

Tank came with me. So did Marcellus. The attendant objected to the old man, and I told him if his boss was giving away forty million dollars, he could let a jeweler look at it before everybody left.

Red's office was above the ballroom. You could hear the party through the floor. The doors opened onto dark wood, city windows, and a desk big enough to lay a king out on.

Red stood behind it. Shawna was already there, having come through another door. She held a small blue box.

"I thought you might prefer privacy," Red said.

"For what?"

"The end."

Shawna took a step toward me.

Red put his hand on her shoulder.

“Tell him.”

Her face was pale. I didn't know how much of it was acting anymore.

“Aiden, take the box.”

“Come here to your nigga.”

“Take it.”

She held it out. I took it because her hand was shaking, and because for a moment all I could think about was making that stop.

Inside lay the blue stone from the ballroom.

Red watched my face.

“Forty million,” he said. “Enough to start over anywhere.”

I looked at him.

“Nigga, you think I'm selling her?”

“I think she just sold you.”

Marcellus stepped forward. Red lifted one finger. Two men appeared beside the door.

The old man stopped.

Shawna's eyes moved from Red to the men, then back to me.

Something had changed. We had come to steal the diamond and take the truth. Red was handing me the diamond. He had

stopped asking questions. He looked like a man standing in a grave he had dug for somebody else.

He opened a drawer.

“And since your friends are so interested in history.”

He put a flat leather folder on the desk.

DANTE was written across a white label.

Shawna made a sound I had never heard from her before.

I reached for the folder.

Red let me take it.

That was when I knew we were in serious fucking trouble.

Red opened the wide drawer in his desk and pushed a folder toward me.

“Captain wants evidence,” he said. “Let the captain read.”

I took it.

11. The Money at the Bottom

The first page had a date. The second had numbers. On the third, beside Valentino's name, somebody had written *settled* in red ink.

Under it was a copy of the order we had found in the watch.

Red had kept his own.

I looked up at him.

“Nigga, you sick motherfucker.”

“Nigga, careful where you point that mouth.”

Shawna snatched the pages from my hand. She found the order. Read it. Turned the page like there might be something on the other side that could make it less real.

She already knew what it said. I had watched her read the original. Knowing didn't make her ready to see it sitting in a drawer under the man's desk, waiting beside his good pens.

“You kept this?” she asked.

Red didn't answer her directly.

“T believed in records. Nigga kept everything.”

“You're sitting behind the desk.”

“Shawna.”

“You're sitting behind the fucking desk.”

She threw the order at him. It struck his chest and fell across the edge of the blotter.

He looked down at it. Then at me.

“I was going to make this generous.”

“Nigga, shut your mouth.”

Tank moved closer to me. The men at the door moved with him.

Red noticed. His expression changed into something almost happy.

“Maybe you should ask your man what generosity looks like.”

Tank went still.

I turned toward him.

“What the fuck is this nigga talking about?”

“Aiden.”

“Nigga. What?”

Red picked up a remote from the desk. A screen on the wall lit up.

An empty swimming pool filled it.

For a second I was back at the motel. T's gun against my side. Shawna on the balcony. Cash blowing across blue tiles while I tried to keep another man from deciding whether I got to breathe.

Then I saw Tank climbing down into the pool.

On the recording, our Mercedes was already gone.

Tank had a bag.

He began putting the money inside.

I watched until I couldn't.

“Nigga, you heard enough breathing in this room. Turn it off.”

Red left it playing.

Onscreen, Tank went back for another bag. The nigga stepped around the same place where T had fallen, leaned over, and picked up a loose bundle beside his shoe.

“Nigga. Turn it the fuck off.”

Red pressed the remote.

The office became quiet enough that I could hear Shawna breathing.

“Three million,” Red said. “All of it. Your friend is thorough.”

Tank looked at me. He didn't look away when I turned on him.

“Nigga, you took her money?”

“Nigga, I took it out the pool. I'm standing here saying that.”

“Don't play with me.”

“I'm not.”

“You watched her hold me together. You saw her drive off with me bleeding. And you went back for the fucking money?”

His jaw moved.

“Yes.”

I hit him.

I couldn't even remember deciding to. My fist caught the side of his face. Pain went through my ribs so hard my knees almost followed it. Tank stayed where he was.

I hit him again.

He took that one too.

“Nigga, look at me and hit me back.”

“No.”

“Hit me the fuck back.”

Shawna caught my arm. Tank's mouth was bleeding. He looked at her, then at me.

“I'm not hitting you.”

Red leaned against his desk.

“This is touching.”

I turned so fast Shawna tightened her grip.

“You say one more word—”

“And what? You'll die rich?”

He glanced at the blue box in my hand.

I had forgotten I was holding it. Forty million dollars, and I wanted to throw it through his fucking face.

Marcellus stepped closer to the desk. His eyes moved over the stone under the lamp. The look on his face stopped me.

“Aiden,” he said.

Red looked at him.

The old man didn't stop looking at the box.

“Close it.”

“What?”

“Close the box.”

I did.

He raised his eyes to mine.

Whatever he had seen, he didn't want Red hearing it yet.

Tank wiped his mouth with the back of his hand.

“It's at your house. Back of my closet. I moved it when we moved in.”

Shawna stared at him.

“All of it?”

“Every fucking dollar.”

“Why didn't you tell us?”

He looked down at the floor. Then he looked back up because I had stepped toward him again.

“Because I thought you was going to leave.”

That stopped me for half a breath.

“Nigga, what?”

“You got her. T was dead. You had the car. You was talking about water and houses and taking her anywhere. I thought you was gone.”

“Nigga, I was fucking dying.”

“I know.”

“Do you?”

His eyes filled, which made me angrier. Tank was not supposed to do that. Tank was supposed to be something solid I could hit until the rest of the world made sense.

“I thought if you left, I'd have something,” he said. “That's it. That's the whole thing.”

Red shook his head.

“Tell the nigga the rest.”

Tank looked at Red.

“You called me.”

“And you answered.”

“You sent me that video.”

“And you answered again.”

Shawna let go of my arm.

“You told him where we were?”

“No.”

“Tank.”

“No, Shawna. I didn't tell him about the house by the lake. Didn't tell him what you was doing. He knew you were coming here because you fucking told him.”

Red's smile thinned.

“I offered him his place back.”

I looked at Tank.

“What place?”

“Yours,” Red said.

The room seemed to move farther away from me. All those nights with Tank outside my door. The spare phone. The way he watched when I called men who used to answer to T and heard them answer to me instead.

“You want it?” I asked him.

Tank said nothing.

“Nigga, I'm standing right here. You want it?”

He looked at my white suit. At the red mark coming through near my side. I hadn't noticed it before.

Then he shook his head.

“Nigga, I wanted you to ask me to stay. Me. Not whoever drove the car.”

I didn't have an answer ready for that. Nigga, I had an answer ready for a hundred different betrayals. That one caught me with my hands empty.

Red opened another drawer. Took out a car key and tossed it onto the desk.

“You can still make the intelligent decision,” he told Tank.

“Bring me my money. Walk out of here with a future.”

Tank looked at the key.

He picked it up.

My whole body went cold.

Then the nigga threw it through Red's window.

The glass cracked under the impact without breaking apart. The key bounced down onto the carpet.

Tank looked at the window. Then at Red.

“Fuck your car too.”

Everything happened close.

One of Red's men caught Tank by the shoulder. Tank turned and drove him into the wall hard enough to knock a framed picture sideways. The other man reached inside his jacket.

Shawna grabbed the desk lamp and smashed it across his arm.

The room flashed white as the bulb burst. Red caught her from behind. I went toward them, and the man beside the door hit me in the side with something heavy.

Nigga, the whole world left my lungs.

I fell against the desk. Papers slid beneath my hands. Red dragged Shawna toward the inner door while she fought him, her shoes scraping the floor.

“Let her go.”

It came out barely louder than breathing.

I tried again.

“Let her fucking go.”

Tank tore the man away from me. Marcellus caught my sleeve and pulled me upright. I had the blue box in one hand and Dante's folder under the other. I don't know why I held on. Maybe because letting go of one more thing felt like the end of the whole fucking world.

A gun went off.

The sound filled the room. A piece of wood jumped from the desk beside my hand. Somebody downstairs screamed, then

more people screamed, then the party stopped pretending to be beautiful.

Red had Shawna in front of him by the inner doorway.

The gun was against her.

I stopped.

Tank stopped.

For one second, everybody did exactly what Red wanted.

“There,” he said. “You can learn.”

Shawna's hair had come down. One earring was gone. She stared at me over his arm, and I could see her trying not to cry because she thought that would make me do something stupid.

Nigga, I was already past stupid. I was standing in the place where I would've paid for my next breath with every life in the building if it let me reach her.

“Take me,” I said.

Red looked almost offended.

“Nigga, I don't want you.”

“Let her walk. I'll stay.”

“I heard you.”

Shawna shook her head. Just once. Hard.

“Aiden.”

I couldn't look away from the gun.

“Aiden, take it and go.”

“I’m not leaving you.”

“Go.”

The inner door opened wider. Another man stood behind Red. Shawna saw him before I did. Something in her eyes changed, and she used the last second she had to look straight at Tank.

“Get him out.”

Then Red pulled her through the door.

I went after them.

Tank caught me around the chest. I fought that nigga harder than I had fought anybody the night they jumped me in. I hit him in the face. In the shoulder. I told him I would kill him. I meant it. He kept pulling me away while a man behind us shouted and another shot struck the wall.

Marcellus was at the outer door. Rosa appeared beyond him with her red dress gathered in one fist. Her face changed when she saw Shawna wasn't with us.

“Where is she?”

“He has her,” Marcellus said.

Rosa tried to go past him.

The old man caught her hand.

“Not this way.”

Tank dragged me into the hall.

I could still hear Shawna on the other side of the office.

Then I couldn't.

—

We reached the ballroom stairs just as one of Red's men pulled the front doors shut.

Nigga, he actually put his back against them. A whole room full of people trying to leave, and this motherfucker decided the most important thing in the building was the fact that his boss hadn't said they could.

"Open them!" Rosa shouted.

He raised his gun.

Tank pulled me behind the banister as the shot struck the wall above us.

I could still hear Shawna's voice in my head. *Take it and go.* I had taken the box. I had taken the papers. Nigga, I had left the only thing in that room I wanted, and now a man was pointing a gun at Rosa because he thought the evening still had instructions.

I put the blue box inside my jacket. The folder went under my belt. My badge lay against both of them.

"Put me down."

Tank tightened his grip.

"Aiden—"

"Nigga, I ain't going back upstairs. I'm getting these people out. Put me on my fucking feet."

He did.

The room stopped tipping after one terrible second. I caught the rail. Got enough breath to remember I had lungs. Then I looked down at the man by the doors.

"Police!"

He laughed.

I opened my jacket.

The gold badge caught the light.

"Captain, nigga. Try your joke with the right title."

His eyes moved from the badge to my gun.

For half a second I thought he might be intelligent.

Then he fired again.

I went over the lower banister and hit the carpet beside a table. Tank came down the stairs behind me, firing toward the door. People crawled away from us. A woman in diamonds grabbed my sleeve and asked if we were going to die.

"Not with that nigga shooting," I told her. "Get behind the table."

She went. Her husband followed so closely he lost a shoe and didn't even look back for it.

A second guard came through the side corridor. He saw me crouched beside the table and tried to get his gun around the corner.

Rex Crown hit him from behind.

The two men crashed into a champagne tower. Glass fell like a crystal fucking waterfall. Rex held on, driving the guard into the wall with all the strength he'd been saving for a better ending to his night.

"Captain!" he shouted.

I fired past him toward the front door. The guard there dropped behind a planter. Tank reached the doors and pulled one open while the people closest to him ran into the lobby.

Rex wrestled the second man to the floor. The guard hit him across the face with the gun. Rex went sideways, stunned, and the man rolled free.

I crossed the room before he could stand.

He raised the weapon at Rex.

I hit him with the heavy blue box through my jacket.

Forty million dollars made a solid fucking sound against his head. Later I'd find out it wasn't worth forty million. At that moment it was worth exactly one living boxer.

The man went down. I took his gun away and kicked it under the bar.

Rex looked up at me with blood running from his eyebrow.

"Twice," he said.

"Nigga, you keeping score now?"

"You beat me. Then you saved me."

"Keep up. Night ain't over."

He got up laughing, blood on his teeth, and put his huge shoulder under my good arm. Together we went toward the doors while Tank held them and Rosa pushed Marcellus ahead of her.

Above the staircase, the statue's bowl of fire tipped.

Something had struck its base. I never saw what. I heard metal grind, looked up, and saw burning liquid spill down the bronze woman's arms. Flame ran over the flowers beneath her. The statue leaned toward the people in the passage below.

Mercedes stood directly underneath it pulling a man off the floor.

"Move!" I shouted.

She looked up.

The bronze woman fell.

I got to Mercedes as the statue struck the banister. Bronze snapped wood. The bowl flew one way, the statue another, and I drove both her and the man through the open passage before the whole staircase's broken lower section hit the carpet behind us.

Heat rolled over my back.

My side went white with pain.

Mercedes caught my face in her hands when we stopped sliding.

"Nigga. Nigga, you got me?"

"I got you."

"You sure?"

"Baby, count your fucking legs."

She looked down at herself. Two legs. One shoe. A dress she was going to mention for the rest of my natural life.

Then she kissed my forehead so hard I thought the bullet might come out from gratitude.

"You beautiful, stupid, magnificent motherfucker."

I tried to get up. Couldn't the first time. Rex and Tank reached me together and lifted.

The people behind us had found their way through. Porsche stood outside holding the lobby door open with one leg and shouting directions nobody dared ignore. The woman in diamonds I'd spoken to stopped beside me, caught my hand, and pressed her wedding ring into it.

"For saving us."

I pushed it back.

"Nigga, keep your husband nervous. I got a woman waiting."

She laughed through her tears.

My own woman wasn't waiting outside.

That thought hit as soon as the cold air touched my face. All the people I'd brought out moved around me, alive and calling me Captain, and the one voice I needed wasn't among them.

I turned toward the stairs again.

Tank caught my shoulder.

"Not that way."

The look on his face stopped me harder than his hands.

"She told me to get you out. Nigga, you alive enough to go get her somewhere else. That's what we got left."

I let him take me to the car.

Rosa went with Marcellus to another car. Before she got in, she pushed one of the gala photographs through my open window.

"She gave me this," she said.

The picture showed Shawna between me and Red. His hand against her arm. His ring under the lights. My hand at her waist like I thought holding her in a photograph meant the world couldn't take her anywhere.

Rosa's voice broke.

“She told me to keep one for when you two got married.”

I stared at it.

Then Tank drove. The police Lamborghini stayed with Knox's officers at the Saint; they would bring it back when the road was clear.

We didn't get far before Marcellus called.

I put him on speaker. My fingers had gone sticky against the blue box.

“The stone,” he said. “Aiden. Listen carefully. The stone you have is the duplicate.”

Tank looked at me.

I opened the box beneath the dashboard light.

Blue looked back at me.

“You sure?”

“Nigga, I made it.”

I shut the lid.

Nigga. We had gone in with Shawna and come out with a fucking lie in velvet.

“Does Red know?” Tank asked.

Marcellus didn't answer right away.

“He expected you to take it.”

The road lights passed across the windshield. One. Another. Another. I counted them because if I stopped looking at something in front of me, I saw Red's arm across Shawna's chest.

Rosa took the phone.

“We still have the original order. And you have his papers.”

I looked at the folder against my leg. The corners were bent. On one page, a line of red ink lay beneath Valentino's name. On another was a list of payments tied to the old jewel transaction. Evidence of the life Red had built out of other people's bodies.

“I don't want his fucking papers.”

“I know.”

“I want her.”

“I know, Aiden.”

Tank drove faster. Not wild. Just like every second now had somebody's hand around its throat.

My phone lit up with an unknown number.

I answered before the first ring finished.

“Shawna?”

Red breathed into the line.

“I wondered how long it would take you to notice the gift.”

I put the phone against my ear so hard it hurt.

“Let me hear her.”

“Your friend has my three million. You have papers that belong in my desk. And somewhere, somebody is holding a very old note.”

“Let me hear her.”

A sound came through. Movement. A door. Then Shawna.

“Baby.”

I closed my eyes.

“I’m here.”

“I know.”

“I’m coming.”

“I know.”

Red took the phone away.

“The unfinished casino in the desert. Midnight. Bring the money. Bring the papers. Bring the original.”

I looked at the clock on the dashboard.

We had less than three hours.

“If you hurt her—”

“Then come before I get bored.”

The call ended.

Tank kept his eyes on the road.

For a while neither of us spoke. I held the photograph in one hand and the worthless blue box in the other. My white suit was ruined. My cheek still held the heat of Shawna's slap. Every place she had touched me that night felt like the only part of my body still alive.

“Take me to the money,” I told Tank.

“Yeah.”

“All of it.”

“Yeah.”

I put the photograph inside my jacket, over the cross.

I had walked into the Saint thinking I could steal a fortune and a future in one night. Now that nigga had my future locked in a room somewhere, and all the money in Vegas couldn't make the next red light change.

“Tank.”

“What?”

“After we get her.”

He glanced at me.

“Nigga, we are getting her.”

I looked out at the city.

“After we get her, there isn't going to be enough desert left to hide what we do to him.”

12. Everybody Bring Your Heart

At nine forty, I put my fist through the glass door of the house and cut myself for a woman who wasn't there to tell me to stop.

Tank caught my wrist before I could do it again.

“Aiden.”

I swung on him.

My nigga took it. His head went sideways, and his hand stayed around my wrist. There was blood on his lower lip. I hit him again, harder, and something in my wounded side pulled so sharp that my knees almost went.

“Nigga, let go.”

“No.”

“Nigga, you had the money.”

“Yeah.”

“This whole fucking time.”

“Yeah.”

I tried to drag him into the broken door with me. He turned his body and held me against the wall instead. Tank weighed enough to end an argument by falling asleep on the other person. I was hurting too bad to move him, and I hated that he knew it.

“Nigga, you let me walk in there thinking I knew what was mine.”

“I know.”

“You let him stand there and laugh at me.”

His face changed then. The shame had been sitting on him like sweat, but now something deeper came up. He looked past me into the house.

“I heard him,” Tank said. “I was standing right there.”

I shoved him once more. He let me go.

The front room still looked like a place where money went to get drunk. Two bottles of champagne sat in silver buckets. A woman I didn't know had left one red heel under the piano. Somebody had put a little pile of cocaine on a photograph of me and Shawna because there wasn't enough table in the whole fucking house. Her face was under it.

I swept everything onto the floor.

“Get these niggas out.”

There were only four men left inside, and all four were already moving.

“Everybody,” I said.

One of them had a woman's handbag slung over his shoulder. He looked down at it like he'd just discovered a child. He went back toward the hall, remembered my face, and left with it.

Tank shut the ruined door as well as it could be shut.

“You want me gone too?”

I looked at him. His jacket was torn. He'd lost a cuff link at the Saint. There was blood on his hands that wasn't mine or his, and he'd followed me out anyway.

“Get the money.”

He went upstairs.

I sat on the piano bench because it was the nearest thing and because my legs had started shaking. Shawna had been sitting there that afternoon. She'd played three notes, missed the fourth, and told me the piano was cheap. I'd offered to buy her another one. She'd asked if I was going to buy a different instrument every time she made a mistake.

I'd told her yes.

Nigga, I'd meant it. We would've had a fucking orchestra by Christmas.

Now her perfume was still in the room and Red had her.

I put my head down. For one ugly second I saw him kissing her. I saw the dance again, her hand on his shoulder, the way she'd leaned close because we'd agreed she had to. I'd said I could take it. I'd stood there dressed like a king and discovered I couldn't take shit.

The case upstairs hit something with a heavy thump.

“Don't you drop her money,” I shouted.

“I got it.”

“You been saying that.”

He came down carrying the money in two bags. No silver case. He'd saved the cash and left the case broken in the pool, just like he'd left the rest of us thinking it was all gone.

He opened the bags on the dining table.

Three million dollars filled the space between two candles Shawna had bought because she said the house smelled like men lying to each other.

Tank stood back.

“All of it.”

“You count it?”

“More than once.”

“That make you feel good?”

He shook his head.

I picked up a bundle and threw it at him. It hit his chest and broke against the floor.

“There's your fucking tip.”

He watched the bills settle.

“Nigga, look at me.”

He did.

“What did you think was gonna happen?”

“Nigga, I thought you were gonna die.”

The room got quiet enough for me to hear the refrigerator.

Tank rubbed both hands over his head.

“That morning, before she drove off. You were bleeding all over the seat. She leaned through the open door and kept asking you to look at her. You kept saying the same shit about a house. Water. A room for singing. Nigga, you weren't answering her half the time. I thought you were already gone.”

“So you went shopping.”

“So I went back.”

His voice rose. He looked ashamed of that too, but he kept going.

“T was there. The money was there. I looked at that nigga on the ground, and I thought about all the years I stood behind him. Every room. Every car. Every time somebody said his name wrong, I was the nigga who got up.”

“You loved that nigga.”

“Yeah.”

I stared at him.

“Say it again.”

“I loved him. You want me to lie about that too?”

His lip was bleeding down his chin. He didn't wipe it.

“You knew him one night. I knew him ten years. He was a piece of shit. I know. He'd give you something with one hand and keep the other around your neck. I know that too. But when I got there, I still wanted the nigga to get up.”

I looked down at the money.

“And when he didn't?”

“I took what was left.”

That was the first thing he'd said that didn't make me want to put him through a window.

It didn't make me forgive him either.

“That nigga Red got to you after.”

Tank nodded.

“Said he knew. Said the money bought him whatever he asked for.”

“And you believed that nigga.”

“For a while.”

“Until when?”

Tank looked straight at me.

“Until he put his hand on her and you stopped breathing.”

I felt the room tilt.

“Nigga, don't.”

“I’m telling you.”

“Don’t tell me what I looked like.”

“You looked like you did in that car.”

I picked up a candle and threw it into the fireplace. The glass broke. Tank didn’t move.

“I ain’t dying in another fucking car.”

“Then let your nigga drive. Let me get one fucking thing right.”

The lights outside went blue.

For one stupid second I thought they had brought Shawna home. I was on my feet before I heard the cars stop. Tank moved toward the front window, then turned back with a look I didn’t like.

"Not ours."

A man came through the broken door wearing a police uniform and the kind of confidence that had never learned what a door could mean to the man behind it.

Captain Wade Frost. Forty-six. Silver hair. Pink face. Two officers behind him, both younger, both looking at the money on the table as if the room had just asked them a very personal question.

Frost looked at my blood, then the bags, then my badge.

"Take it off."

I stared at him.

"Nigga, you selling shirts now?"

"The badge."

Tank stepped between him and the table.

"You got an appointment?"

"Move."

"Nigga, this a house. Ask like you walked into one."

Frost put his hand on his gun. The two officers behind him looked at each other. Neither moved closer.

I came around Tank.

"What you want?"

"Redmond filed a complaint. Theft. Assault. Armed men at his property. A woman being held against her will."

I felt my face go cold.

"He got that last part right."

"We're here to recover the money and suspend your authority until this is settled."

"Nigga, who sent you?"

"You don't question me."

"That's interesting. I'm doing it beautifully."

He took a folded paper from his pocket and held it toward me.

I didn't take it.

"Knox sign that?"

"The chief has larger concerns."

"Nigga, the chief bought me a Lamborghini yesterday. She thinking about me plenty."

One of the younger officers looked at the paper again. A Black woman, thirty-one, name of Bell on her chest. She'd been at the station when I brought the robbers in. She had eaten the lunch I bought. I could see her trying to fit that morning into the room she was standing in now.

Frost noticed her hesitation.

"Bell. Collect the bags."

She didn't move.

"I said collect them."

I put my phone on the table and called Knox.

Frost stepped toward it.

Tank caught his wrist.

"Nigga, let the telephone ring."

Knox answered on the second ring.

"Aiden. Tell me you have her."

For half a second I couldn't speak. The fact that she knew. The fact that her first question wasn't about the money or the fire or

the badge she had pinned on a criminal's chest the morning before.

"Not yet. You send Frost?"

Silence.

Then her voice changed.

"Put me on speaker."

I did.

"Wade," she said.

Frost stopped pulling against Tank's hand.

"Chief. We're securing—"

"You at his house?"

"We have evidence of—"

"You at his house, Wade?"

He looked at the phone.

"Yes."

"Then you listen carefully. Captain Aiden retains his command. You have no order from me. You bring whatever Redmond put in your hand to my office, and you bring your own badge with it."

The room went quiet enough for me to hear Bell breathe out.

Frost's face changed. Whatever authority he had brought through the door began leaving him through his eyes.

"You choosing this thug?"

I tilted my head.

"Nigga, you can say Captain while you cry."

Knox didn't laugh.

"I'm choosing the officer who carried people out while your friend locked the doors. Get out of his house."

Frost's hand jerked toward the phone.

Tank let go of his wrist just as I came forward. The man stumbled into the table, knocking a candle over. One of the money bags slid toward the edge. He reached for the bag with one hand and his gun with the other.

I hit him before either hand got what it wanted.

The table rocked. Money flew across the floor. Frost went backward into the chair and took it down with him. His gun skidded under the piano.

Bell already had her weapon out. It was pointed at Frost.

"Stay down, sir."

He looked up at her in disbelief.

"You're taking his side too?"

"I'm following my chief."

"Nigga," I said, "people keep making this clear for you."

Frost tried to get up anyway. Tank put a hand on his shoulder and returned him to the carpet with the calm of a man correcting where a heavy box belonged.

I picked up the folded paper.

Red's handwriting sat across the bottom. Three short lines. The money back. Aiden disarmed. Shawna's name used like a rope around both requests.

I held it toward Bell.

She read it. Her mouth tightened.

"He sent you for her rescue money," she said.

Frost didn't answer.

She put him in cuffs.

The other officer picked up the paper, folded it carefully, and stood beside her. He looked at me before they left.

"Captain, where do you need us after this?"

I looked at the floor. At Shawna's million-dollar future scattered beside the leg of a chair. At Tank kneeling to gather the bills before anybody stepped on them.

"With Knox. Make sure nobody else comes here in a uniform they borrowed from Red."

He nodded.

"Yes, Captain."

They took Frost out through the door he hadn't bothered knocking on. The police lights moved across the ceiling, then went away.

Knox was still on the phone.

"Aiden."

"I'm here."

"I have officers at the Saint. He's moved her. Your car's safe. We can bring it to you."

"Keep the roads open. Keep my people from getting stopped on the way to that unfinished casino. That's where he's taking her. Midnight."

"I'll hold the outside when you get there."

"Chief."

"What?"

I looked at the badge inside my ruined white jacket.

"Nigga doesn't forget this."

Her voice softened just a little.

"Then bring your wife home, Captain. Give me something worth remembering too."

The call ended.

Tank put the last bundle back into the bag. Every dollar stayed. He set the fallen candle upright and looked at me.

"Nigga, you really are the police."

"We discussed that at graduation."

"I heard the words."

"You seeing the picture now?"

He nodded slowly.

Then, for the first time since Red opened that drawer, my brother smiled at me without looking ashamed of the fact that he wanted to.

The front door moved behind us.

Rosa came in wearing a man's coat over her gala dress. One earring was gone. She had Marcellus by the arm. Tank brought the decoy's box in from the Mercedes and handed it to the old man, who took it like he was being given the head of somebody he used to know.

My phone rang again before Rosa reached the table.

Rex Crown.

I almost didn't answer. Then I remembered the man coming out of the champagne with a stranger's gun in his face and took the call.

"Captain."

"Busy."

"I know. Your woman."

I shut my eyes.

“Nigga, everybody knows?”

“Everybody who saw you get those people out. They're still outside saying your name.”

“I don't need my name. I need her.”

“Then tell me where.”

I looked at Tank. At the bags. At my own hand bleeding into the towel Rosa had put down for me.

“You hurt?” I asked Rex.

“My pride's in worse shape than my face.”

“Then stay with it.”

“Nigga, you think I called to get sent home?”

I didn't answer.

“You beat me in front of everybody,” he said. “Could've let me get killed in front of the same people. You came back. I ain't carrying that around owing you forever. Give me somewhere to bring it.”

I looked toward the dark windows.

“Unfinished casino. Desert. Midnight.”

He repeated it once.

“I'm there.”

“Rex.”

“What?”

“Your friend with the gun—”

“Not coming. I got better friends.”

I laughed once, and it hurt enough that Rosa looked up sharply.

“What?” she asked.

“Nigga making sense.”

Rex heard her. His voice got louder.

“Tell those women their money's good. Tell them I don't stop being a gentleman because a beautiful motherfucker rearranged my afternoon.”

Rosa took the phone from me.

“Then bring your gentleman ass ready to help.”

“Yes, ma'am.”

She handed it back after he hung up.

“Another one?”

I looked at her.

“Another what?”

“Man who'd walk into a fire because you remembered he was in it.”

I didn't have anything clever ready.

She touched my good shoulder.

“Use them, baby. Let the people who love you do something.”

“Which one of you stupid niggas broke the door?” Rosa asked.

Nobody answered.

She saw my hand.

“Of course.”

She came straight to me, took my wrist, and looked at the cuts.

Her fingers were shaking. She hadn't been shaking when she crossed the room.

“Where is she?”

“Red.”

“I know fucking Red. Where is that nigga?”

“He's bringing her to that casino in the desert. Midnight.”

“Then why are you bleeding on the furniture?”

I started to speak. Rosa gripped harder.

“You can be angry after she gets here. You can buy a mountain and fight the whole mountain. Right now I need you standing.”

“Don't talk to me like I'm a kid.”

“Then quit making me.”

Tank turned his face away. I looked at him.

“Something funny?”

“No.”

“Good.”

Rosa sat me down and went to get a towel. Marcellus stayed by the table. He looked at the money, then at me, then at the floor where the first bundle had come apart.

“Yours?” he asked.

“Hers.”

He nodded as though that settled a price we'd been fighting over.

When Rosa came back, she had my phone. It was vibrating in her hand.

Red had sent a picture.

Shawna sat in a white chair. Her dress was torn at the shoulder. Her hair covered one side of her face. Red stood behind her with his hand resting under her chin, his blue ring turned toward the camera.

I got up so fast the bench fell over.

Rosa caught my shirt.

“Aiden.”

“I'm gonna kill that nigga.”

“Look at her.”

“I am looking.”

“No. Her.”

I made myself stop staring at his hand.

Shawna was looking into the camera. Her mouth was swollen a little on one side. Her eyes were open and furious. She wasn't looking away from whoever would see it.

Under the picture, Red had written four words.

She remembers this room.

I called him.

He answered on the first ring.

“Nigga,” I said, “if you touch her again—”

“She's sitting right here.”

“Put her on.”

“Ask nice.”

I couldn't get air into my chest.

Rosa squeezed the back of my neck. I felt every finger.

“Please,” I said.

Red laughed softly.

Then Shawna was there.

“Aiden?”

“Baby.”

“Are you hurt?”

I closed my eyes.

“No.”

“Don't lie to me.”

“I'm here.”

There was a little noise on her end. Fabric moving. A breath that stopped too early.

“Tell Rosa I ruined her dress.”

Rosa pressed a fist against her mouth.

“She don't give a fuck about the dress, baby.”

“She does. Tell her I'll pay for it.”

Rosa took the phone out of my hand.

“You owe me a fucking earring too, bitch.”

Shawna laughed once.

That one little laugh made the whole room stand still.

Then Red came back.

“Midnight. Bring whatever you stole tonight. Bring my money. Come ready to apologize.”

I took the phone.

“You want me on my knees?”

“Now you're listening.”

“Nigga, you keep her alive. You can see me any way you want.”

He hung up.

I stood there holding the dead call. Tank picked up the bench and set it behind me. I didn't sit.

Marcellus held out his hand.

“Let me see that photograph.”

I gave the old nigga the phone because I had run out of things to break that would make Red feel it.

The old man enlarged the picture.

His thumb stopped on the ring.

“There you are,” he whispered.

I looked up.

Marcellus had begun to smile, and there wasn't a happy thing in it.

13. What She Told Me After

Shawna told me what happened in that room later. She told it sitting beside me with her bare feet under my leg, stopping whenever she wanted water and starting again wherever it hurt. I asked her the same questions until she threatened to throw the glass at me. Some parts she could give me word for word. Some parts she wouldn't give anybody.

This is what she told me.

Red took her back through the Saint after we'd gone, with two men behind her and one hand around her arm. The party hadn't completely emptied. A few people were still holding drinks because nobody had personally told them the good time was dead.

She saw a woman by the elevators lift a phone.

“Get my good side,” Shawna said.

Red pulled her harder.

The woman lowered the phone.

“You always gotta do that?” he asked.

“Look good?”

“Make a fucking scene.”

“You dragged me out of one.”

He took her into a private room she knew. White chairs. White carpet. A huge painting of a horse coming out of the ocean. Red loved that painting. He'd once spent twenty minutes explaining the horse to her while she tried to work out whether she could leave without him noticing.

Tonight the carpet had somebody else's blood on it.

One of the men had brought her purse from the office. Red took it from him and put it on the table. Then he shut the door and told the men to wait outside.

Shawna said that was when she first got scared enough to feel cold.

Not at the gunfire. Not at his hand on her arm. At the little click of the door and the fact that he wanted no one else to hear him talk.

"Sit," he said.

She stayed standing.

"Shawna."

"Give me a cigarette."

He went to the table and took one from a silver box. He lit it before he handed it to her, like he was bringing her flowers.

"I could've killed that nigga," he said.

She took the cigarette.

"Nigga, you tried."

“Nigga ran.”

“My nigga's coming back.”

Red laughed.

“They always come back for the money.”

“Then put me outside and see.”

He didn't answer that. He poured a drink, missed the glass a little, and wiped the spill with his sleeve. Shawna noticed because Red never cleaned anything. He would wait for somebody to come across a whole room to pick up a thing beside his shoe.

He was angry enough to forget who he thought he was.

“You think that nigga loves you?”

She smoked.

“I asked you something.”

“I heard you.”

“That nigga loves winning. You're what he stole. Soon as you're just a woman in his house, watch what happens.”

She looked at the painting instead of him. The horse had its mouth open. She'd always thought it looked surprised to be swimming.

“He begged, you know,” Red said.

She kept looking at the horse.

“Dante. That nigga begged us to look after you.”

“Us.”

Red stopped with the bottle in his hand.

Shawna turned toward him.

“You were standing there?”

“I didn't say that.”

“Then who told you?”

He put the bottle down too carefully.

“Everybody knew what happened.”

“I didn't.”

He looked toward the door. She watched him do it. Shawna said she would've given anything to have the old letter and the order in her hand right then, to lay them in his lap and make him touch what he'd done. All she had was the watch. She turned it around her wrist.

“What did he call me?” she asked.

“What?”

“When he begged. What name did he use?”

“Your fucking name.”

“Which one?”

“Shawna, I don't remember every—”

“Dante called me Trouble.”

He stared at her.

“Miss Trouble if he was happy. Mrs. Trouble when I was mad at him. He'd come in and say, Mrs. Trouble, I fucked up, and I'd know I had to sit down before that nigga finished talking.”

She laughed, and that made Red angrier than anything she'd said. She couldn't help it. She was remembering Dante coming into their little apartment with a whole bumper in his hands. He'd taken it off the car he'd borrowed for their honeymoon. He'd brought the bumper upstairs because he thought she might be less mad if he hadn't left any of it behind.

“Nigga carried it like flowers,” she told me later. She laughed then too. I hated the dead nigga for making her laugh with something he'd done years before I met her, and I wanted to hear it again anyway.

In Red's room, she wiped her eyes with the back of her wrist.

“You don't know how he talked to me.”

“I know what he was.”

“Then talk about that. Talk about your dead nigga. You don't get to talk about mine.”

Red came close enough that she could smell the drink.

“You keep making him a saint.”

“No. I'm remembering my husband. That nigga stole money, lied badly, and left his socks in the bed. I loved him. You think telling me he was a bad man changes something?”

She touched the watch again.

“Tell me something I don't fucking know.”

“That nigga Dante said the same shit,” Red went on. “A house. A different life. Music. That nigga was gonna buy you a microphone and call himself a husband.”

Shawna turned back.

“That nigga was my husband.”

“I paid for the wedding.”

“You paid for the room.”

“I paid for everything.”

“Then you should've kept the receipts. Maybe the preacher would've married you.”

Red threw the glass.

It hit the wall beside the horse and broke. Shawna said she didn't move, which she was proud of until she told me why. Her legs had gone stiff. She couldn't move.

He came toward her.

“You used to know how to talk to me.”

“I used to need you to stop talking.”

He caught her face in one hand. That's where the picture came from. He called one of his men in and told him to take it while he held her there.

Shawna stared into the phone.

"He'll see you touching me," she said.

"That's the point."

"I know."

The man took the picture and left. Red's ring dragged against the edge of her jaw when he let go.

She looked at it.

"You wearing it now?"

His hand closed.

"Wearing what?"

"All that money, and you still want somebody to notice."

He put his hand in his pocket.

A telephone rang outside the room, and Red's face changed when the man at the door told him who was calling.

"Frost?" Shawna asked.

Red looked at her.

She knew the name. Had heard it in enough penthouse conversations to recognize which uniform Red meant when he said the city would be reasonable.

The man at the door whispered something.

Red took the phone so hard the man stepped backward.

“What do you mean arrested?”

Shawna leaned back in the white chair.

Nigga, when she told me this part later, she made me listen twice. Said the first time I'd smiled so much I hadn't heard the whole sentence.

Red kept listening.

“Knox said what?”

Shawna lifted her cigarette.

“My captain?”

He covered the phone.

“Shut up.”

“I'm just wondering which nigga finally made your policeman nervous.”

He went into the hallway to finish the call. Left the door open three inches. Left the man who'd taken the picture inside with her.

The man looked tired. Thirty-eight, name of Arlo, a little gray beginning in his beard. She knew him too. He'd once carried her groceries upstairs when the elevator broke and then apologized because Red heard him asking whether she was all right.

“You don't have to stand in here,” she told him.

He looked at the door.

“It's my job.”

“Nigga, your job's turning into a funeral.”

He didn't answer.

She stood up with the cigarette in one hand. He moved toward her. She lifted the other hand as if she only wanted him to stop crowding her.

Then she threw the heavy silver cigarette box into his face.

Arlo went back against the wall. She ran through the door, past Red with the telephone still against his ear, and into the corridor before either man understood that waiting quietly had ended.

Red shouted her name.

She kept running.

Her borrowed dress caught the corner of a table. She pulled free and left a strip of blue silk behind her. At the far end, the service doors were open. Light came through from a stairwell. She could hear men below, radios, a woman crying.

She hit the door with her shoulder and nearly fell over a waiter sitting on the landing.

He was holding his wrist. Blood marked his white cuff. Beside him stood a young-looking woman who told Shawna she was

twenty-four when Shawna asked if she could lift him. Both of them had been trying to get past the men downstairs.

“Where's the outside door?” Shawna asked.

“Two floors,” the woman said. “But they won't let us—”

“Get him up.”

They lifted the waiter together. Shawna took his good side. The woman took the other. They started down the stairs, three people moving awkwardly, the blue dress dragging through dust and somebody else's dropped flowers.

Behind them, Red came through the service door.

“Shawna!”

She didn't look back.

“Nigga, if you want to help, get his fucking feet.”

Red caught her at the next landing. The woman with the waiter stopped. He pointed toward the stairs below.

“You two. Go.”

They stared.

“Go!”

Shawna held on to the waiter until the woman had him steady. Then she let them pass. She watched them reach the lower door, watched the woman look up at her once, watched them disappear into the light.

Red grabbed her arm.

“You made me run.”

“You should try it more.”

He pulled her toward him.

“Think you're him now?”

She looked at his hand, then his face.

“Nigga, I know exactly who I am. That's what's upsetting you.”

He tried to drag her back up the stairs. She planted her feet and hit him with Dante's watch across the wrist holding her. He swore and loosened his grip. She drove an elbow into his chest, got one step away, and nearly reached the lower door.

Arlo stood in it.

One eye was swelling. Blood ran from his nose. He looked at Shawna, looked at Red behind her, and for one second she thought he might move.

Then he raised his gun.

She stopped.

He couldn't make himself look at her while he pointed it.

“I'm sorry,” he said.

“Then get better at it.”

Red pulled her back upstairs. Her shoulder struck the rail. She bit the inside of her cheek to keep from giving him a sound he could enjoy.

When he put her back into the white chair, the room looked different. The cigarette box lay on the floor. The little patch of carpet where it had stood was clean and bright amid the mess.

Red bent over her.

“You get one more fucking idea—”

She looked up at him.

“I got several. You're gonna need a longer night.”

He stepped away.

Shawna told me her hands were shaking after that. She put them under her thighs so he wouldn't see. She had failed to get out. Two other people had made it.

She held on to that while he paced in front of her.

When I asked what she'd been thinking, she put her feet beneath my leg and looked at me like the answer ought to have been obvious.

“What my nigga would've done,” she said. “Only in a better dress.”

At the house, I didn't know any of this yet. Marcellus was still looking at the same photograph, holding my phone so close to his face I thought he might press his forehead through it.

“It's the stone,” he said.

“Nigga, tell me you sure.”

“Yes.”

“Nigga, we were sure at the party.”

He looked at me over the top of the phone.

“You were.”

I wanted to throw him through the rest of the door. I also wanted him to be right more than I'd wanted anything besides hearing her voice.

“Tell me,” I said.

He set the decoy on the table. In that room it looked worth forty million dollars. It looked worth killing for. Red could've shown it to a king, and the king would've started moving money.

Marcellus looked at it like an old sin.

“Nigga changed the setting on the original. Put dark stones around it. Made it look smaller by giving you other things to see.”

“Nigga, you can read forty million through my phone?”

“I can tell you he didn't do a good job.”

His hands had steadied. For the first time that night, he was somewhere he'd spent more years than prison. He turned the picture toward the light.

“I saw the ring at the gala. Only from the side. I thought I recognized the shoulder of the mounting. Here.”

He touched the screen.

“The nigga kept that part.”

“Because it's gold?” Tank asked.

“Because that nigga's an idiot.”

Rosa let out a breath through her nose.

“Finally, some good fucking news.”

Marcellus showed us where the blue metal curved under the stone. Not a secret map. Not a number to somebody's money. The old curve of a mounting he had shaped himself. Red had reused one tiny part when he changed the necklace into a ring. Marcellus knew the work the way I knew the sound of Shawna coming down our stairs.

“He has her stone under his finger,” he said.

Nobody spoke for a moment.

Then I said, “We'll get it.”

He looked at me.

“Will we, my nigga? Say the whole promise.”

“Yeah.”

“If that nigga says her or the diamond?”

“Her.”

I didn't wait to see how that felt to him.

"If that nigga says burn the letter?"

"I burn it."

"If he says give him back the proof of what he did?"

"Then he gets it. You want me to make you a promise, I'll make you one. I'm bringing her home. Everything else better find a way to come with us."

Marcellus nodded. His mouth tightened once.

"Dante said something very much like that."

I grabbed the edge of the table.

"Nigga, I'm not Dante."

"I know."

"Then stop putting that nigga between me and every fucking thing I do."

Rosa said my name.

I shook my head.

"No. I love her. Right now. Me. I'm the nigga standing here bleeding. I'm the nigga going out there. You can remember him all you want, but when her phone rings, I want her to know who's calling."

My voice had gone loud enough to shake. I hated all three of them hearing it.

Marcellus took the papers we had brought out of the gala and laid them beside Celeste's old letter. Rosa handed him the original order from Dante's watch, still inside its envelope. He kept the different pages apart. One held a dead woman's handwriting. The others held proof that Red had wanted another man dead. They'd cost more nights than I could count, and I would have set them all on fire if it got Shawna through that door.

"Then give her something to answer," he said.

He slid my phone back to me.

I opened her name.

The last message I'd sent before the gala was still there.

You look good as fuck.

She had sent back a picture of one eye, half her forehead, and her middle finger. She'd been trying to take a photograph of the whole dress and got mad at the phone.

I stared until the screen blurred.

Rosa stood beside me.

"She sent me six of those," she said quietly. "Bitch got the bathroom ceiling in one."

I wiped my face with the heel of my hand.

"Nigga," I whispered, though I wasn't talking to anybody now.

I started typing.

I'm coming. Wear whatever you want.

Then I deleted the second sentence. She couldn't choose what she was wearing. She couldn't choose where she was sitting. Red would read it first, and I wanted to take his head off for being between us even inside a fucking phone.

I sent only the first two words.

At the Saint, Shawna said Red watched the message arrive. He held the phone where she could see it and smiled.

“Nigga thinks he's in a love song.”

“Then don't stand in the chorus.”

He took the phone away.

She asked for her purse. He laughed at that. She asked for water instead, and he brought it because he wanted to look like the kind of man who brought water.

“Tell me you were lying to that nigga,” he said.

She drank.

“About what?”

“All of it.”

“That's a lot of lying.”

“You lied to Valentino.”

She set the glass down.

“Yeah.”

“You lied to me.”

“Yeah.”

“Then tell me you lied to that nigga.”

He waited so hard that Shawna could see him believing her before she even opened her mouth. She said that was the ugliest thing in the room. He'd hurt her, trapped her, scared her, and still wanted her to make his heart feel better.

She almost gave him what he wanted. Not because it was true. Because she knew how to do it. She knew exactly how soft to make her voice. She could've called him baby and watched his shoulders come down.

Instead she said, “I told Aiden I wasn't scared.”

Red leaned closer.

“There you go.”

“I told him I didn't think about Dante when we were together.”

He smiled.

“And?”

“I told him I didn't like that stupid fucking cross.”

“You see? You see what I'm saying?”

She looked straight at him.

“I told him I could live without him.”

His smile went away.

She said his name then. Not mine. Red's. She wanted him to know he was the one hearing it.

“That was a lie.”

He knocked the water out of her hand.

For a second she thought he was going to hit her again. He stood there breathing, staring at the wet front of her dress. Then he picked up his jacket.

“Get up.”

“Where?”

“You wanna see your nigga so bad, let's go see him.”

He opened her purse and took out the little silver pistol. He looked at it, then at her, and put it in his jacket.

“Taking this too,” he said.

He took her back into the hall. She left the cigarette burning in his silver box. She told me that part twice. Of everything he'd taken away from her that night, she wanted me to know he'd forgotten to make her put it out.

At ten thirty-seven, he sent me another message.

On our way. Don't disappoint her.

I looked around the room at Tank, Rosa, Marcellus, and the three million dollars that had already buried too many people.

“Call everybody,” I said.

Tank picked up his phone.

“Everybody?”

“Everybody who ever called me brother.”

14. Ten Toes, Thirty Engines

By eleven, the street outside the house was full of cars.

Niggas came in leather. Niggas came in silk. One came wearing the pajama shirt his woman had bought him, with a gold chain lying against the little white moons. He'd put on shoes and brought everything else he thought he needed. Another had a fresh haircut with shaving foam still behind his ear.

Nobody asked if I was serious.

They looked at the money and started asking who had to die.

I knew some of those niggas would have asked the same question in Red's house. I wasn't stupid. I was in love. People kept confusing the two, and tonight I had enough money to make them stop.

There were men there I'd drunk with, fought with, watched betray women who were still sending them plates from home. There were men there who'd carried T's coffin and called me boss before the flowers died. I wanted every rotten heart that would come when I called it.

The world could ask for better men in the morning.

I wanted mine now.

Tank stood at the dining table, putting the three million where everybody could see it. He didn't hide behind me. He waited until the room filled and then he spoke.

“This is the money from the motel.”

A few heads turned.

“I took it.”

One man beside the piano said, “Nigga, what?”

Tank kept his eyes on the room.

“I took all of it. I let Aiden think it was gone. Red knew. He tried to use it against him tonight.”

“Tried?” somebody asked.

“Tried.”

The man beside the piano looked at me.

“Nigga, and this nigga still breathing?”

Tank's jaw moved once.

I walked between them.

“Look at me when you say that.”

The man did.

“Tank's standing with me.”

“I'm just saying—”

“Say he stole it. He did. Say he's a lying motherfucker. He was. Say you're gonna touch him tonight, and you can find out how fucking fast I can forget your name.”

The room went still.

Tank looked at the back of my head. I could feel it.

The man by the piano lifted his hands.

“Your house.”

“Yeah.”

I let that sit.

“My house. My money on the table. My girl with Red. If any of that bothers you, the door already fucking broke. You ain't gotta worry about hurting it.”

Nobody left.

Rosa stood by the staircase in the borrowed coat. She watched every face. Marcellus sat behind her with the decoy in its box and the papers inside his jacket. The old nigga looked tired enough to disappear if you let your eyes move too fast, but he hadn't asked to lie down.

I put my hand on the cash.

“Some of you came because you owe me. Some of you came because Red owes you. Some of you just heard there was gonna be money.”

One man in the back said, “All three.”

I looked at him.

He didn't apologize.

I nodded.

“Good. Nigga knows why he came.”

I started giving it away.

Not throwing it in the air. I wanted every nigga who touched it to look into my face while he did. I wanted him to feel the weight of it and know the woman we'd left behind had carried it out of a room full of killers before any of us had the nerve.

Stacks went into hands. Into coats. Into the pajama shirt, where the buttons strained so hard I thought the little moons were gonna fly off.

“Nigga, put that in a bag,” Tank told him.

“I'm good.”

“You look pregnant.”

“I'm good.”

I kept paying.

Some of them laughed. Some counted. One man held the money without doing either, and I remembered he'd been sitting in a hospital hallway two nights earlier with his head in his hands. Tonight he kissed the stack and tucked it inside his coat.

I didn't ask which part of his life I'd just bought.

I had one woman to bring home. The whole city could put its heart on the fucking table.

When two million had left the bags, I stopped.

The last million stayed together. I pulled the bag shut and set it aside.

“That's hers.”

Nobody argued.

Tank hadn't taken anything. I picked up a share from the two million I'd already laid out and held it toward him.

He shook his head.

“No.”

“Nigga, take it before I have to love you louder.”

“Aiden.”

“Nigga, poor and guilty? I'm letting you have one bad feeling. Pick one.”

His eyes flicked toward the men around us.

“Nigga, I don't want it.”

“Then spend it on somebody who does.”

I pushed the money against his chest until he took it.

He looked down at it. Then he put it on the table beside the million I was keeping for Shawna.

“For her,” he said.

I left it there. I wasn't counting love back into a fucking bag while everybody watched.

Rosa came down the stairs.

“And before all you niggas start singing about brotherhood, she's my friend.”

Nobody laughed. They knew her. Half the room stood up straighter when she came close.

“That means if you see her, you bring her. You don't stop to tell Red how hard you are. You don't start explaining a grudge from 2018. You bring her.”

The man with shaving foam behind his ear nodded.

“We got you, Rosa.”

“No, baby. You better have her.”

She turned to me.

I had held back part of the two million for her. I pushed it across the table.

She stared at it.

“What's this?”

“Yours.”

“For what?”

“Whatever you want.”

Her face went tight.

“You paying me to stay home?”

“I’m paying you because she loves you.”

Rosa looked up.

“Nigga, don’t do that right now.”

“She gets out of that car tonight, I want somebody here she knew before every room had me in it.”

For the first time since she’d walked through the broken door, Rosa looked her age and her fear at once. Thirty-four years old, tired, one earring gone, holding the coat closed with a hand that had finally stopped shaking.

“You bring her,” she said.

I nodded.

She slapped my face.

Not hard enough to knock me down. Hard enough that the room went silent.

“With your mouth, Aiden.”

I swallowed.

“I’m bringing her.”

She kissed the same cheek.

“Then go, baby.”

I turned to the room.

“Any of you niggas here think Red owns Vegas?”

“Fuck Red,” somebody said.

“Anybody think that nigga owns my wife?”

Rosa made a sound behind me.

I turned halfway.

“What?”

“You ask her yet?”

“I’m going to.”

“Then quit inviting these niggas before me.”

The room broke open. Men laughed, slapped each other's shoulders, called out shit about weddings and suits and who wasn't allowed near an open bar. I let them. For a few seconds we had a future big enough to crowd a room.

Then I raised my hand.

“Niggas, listen to me.”

They quieted.

“I ain't asking you to die because I fell in love. I'm asking you to stand up with me because that nigga thinks he can take anything he sees. He took a man's wife. Took another man's diamond. Took Dante out to the desert and left him there. Tonight he took Shawna.”

I put my hand over the cross.

“He keeps telling everybody I'm wearing a dead nigga's jewelry. Fine. Let him look at it while I come get my girl.”

Tank stepped beside me.

“Ten toes,” he said.

The room answered.

“Down.”

He said it again, louder.

“Ten toes.”

“Down.”

Nigga, the windows shook. The broken front door moved in its frame. For one wild second I wanted the whole city to hear us, every penthouse and every parking lot and every woman waiting for a man to come back different.

I kissed the cross.

Then I went outside.

Tank drove the Mercedes.

I sat beside him because I still couldn't lean back without feeling T's bullet and because if anybody was going to meet Red first, it was going to be me.

Marcellus got into the back.

I looked over my shoulder.

“You sure about this?”

“No.”

“Nigga, you can wait with Rosa.”

“I have waited enough.”

He shut the door before I could offer him anything else.

The decoy sat in its box beside him. The letters and the papers were in his coat. My phone lay faceup on my knee. Rosa stood in the driveway with the money she hadn't bothered to pick up still inside the house.

Tank had put the bag with Shawna's million and his returned share in the back. Red had asked for three million. He was getting what was left after I'd paid the niggas coming to take his kingdom.

She came to my window.

“Aiden.”

I looked at her.

“She likes gardenias.”

“What?”

“For the wedding. She likes gardenias. And she will lie and tell you roses because men always buy roses.”

I gripped the door.

“Gardenias.”

“And don't let that old man give her away. I'll do it.”

Marcellus said, “I hadn't volunteered.”

Rosa pointed at him through the glass.

“Keep it that way.”

She stepped back.

The cars pulled out behind us until the street looked like the city had emptied its garages for a funeral and nobody had agreed whose.

Thirty engines. Maybe more by the time we reached the highway. Rex Crown came in a black coupe; Little Saint rode beside him. Mercedes and Porsche took the green Bentley. Bell had brought my police Lamborghini back, and Knox rode with her at the head of the convoy. Headlights filled both mirrors. My niggas had come wearing their money and their worst intentions, and I loved every last one of them for showing up.

Tank kept both hands on the wheel.

After a while he said, “You should let the doctor look at you after.”

“After.”

“I'm saying.”

“I heard you.”

He nodded.

The lights thinned outside the windows. Vegas went from towers to signs to little burning squares behind us. Ahead was black desert and the road laid through it.

“Tank.”

“Yeah.”

“When you came back for the money. Did he look like himself?”

He knew who I meant.

He drove another few seconds before he answered.

“No.”

I looked down at the cross.

“Good.”

Tank's hands tightened.

“You don't gotta say that.”

“I know.”

He didn't answer. I watched the side of his face and remembered him standing behind T in the parking lot, as big as a wall, waiting for somebody else to decide what he'd do.

“I'm glad you here.”

His jaw moved.

“Yeah.”

“Don't make me say it twice.”

“I heard you.”

In the back, Marcellus turned the decoy's box between his hands.

“She wore blue the last time I took her dancing,” he said.

Neither of us asked who.

“Celeste. I was late. She was furious. By the time I got there, she'd danced with three other men.”

“Three?” I said.

“She counted them for me.”

Tank glanced in the mirror.

“You do something to those niggas?”

“I asked for the fourth dance.”

I looked out at the dark.

“Could've been me.”

“It wasn't.”

He closed the box and rested his head against the seat.

We drove the rest of that stretch without talking.

At eleven fifty-four, Red called.

I put him on speaker.

“You coming?” he asked.

“You hear the cars?”

“I told you to come ready to apologize.”

“I am.”

Tank looked at me.

“I told her I’d never let you put your hands on her again. Got a lot to apologize for.”

Red breathed into the phone.

“You think all those niggas love you?”

“Enough to leave the house.”

“That’s money.”

“Then you should’ve paid better.”

He went quiet.

I heard Shawna in the background. I couldn’t make out the words, only her voice and the way he moved the phone away from her.

“Let me talk to her.”

“You’ll see her soon.”

“Nigga, let me—”

He hung up.

I gripped the phone so hard Tank reached over and took it before I broke that too.

“We’re here,” he said.

The casino rose out of the desert half finished, huge and white under lights that made the empty windows look blacker. Red had

built columns tall enough for a king and stopped before anybody could decide what kingdom he thought he had. Plastic sheeting moved behind the glass. A fountain outside had never held water.

Cars waited across the entrance. Men stood between them. Above the front doors, a balcony ran along the second floor beneath an unfinished crown of stone.

There she was.

Shawna stood at the railing in Rosa's ruined dress. Her hair blew across her face. Even from the car I could see Dante's watch on her wrist.

Red stood beside her.

He lifted the hand with the ring and waved like he'd invited us for dinner.

Behind me, engine after engine went quiet. My niggas were here.

I opened my door.

My side hurt. My hand hurt. Everything in me that knew how to be scared was awake and screaming.

I put both feet on the ground anyway.

Shawna saw me.

She stepped toward the railing before Red caught her arm.

“Aiden!”

I looked straight up at her.

"I'm here, baby."

The clock on my phone turned eleven fifty-nine.

The first roadblock waited beyond the last gas station.

Two trucks across the highway. Men beside them. No uniforms. No lights except the white glare of their headlights pointed into our faces. A line of barrels burned between the trucks, and behind the flames I could see the same kind of patience Red had worn across the breakfast table.

Tank slowed.

Behind us thirty engines changed their voices at once.

My phone rang. Knox.

"I see them," she said. "Stay in the convoy."

"Nigga, the convoy is me."

"Then don't make me explain to your wife why you turned into a road accident before you got there."

A shot hit the Mercedes hood.

Tank pulled left. Another struck the windshield and made a white star directly in front of him. Marcellus dropped in the back, his coat closed over the letters and the decoy like the old nigga had decided history could wait below the window line.

Knox's police Lamborghini came out beside us. Officer Bell was driving; the chief leaned forward in the passenger seat, looking at the roadblock like somebody had finally annoyed her enough to deserve the whole department.

The siren rose.

One of the men by the truck stepped backward.

Another raised his gun anyway.

"Hardheaded nigga," I said.

Tank put his foot down.

We left the road in a sheet of dust. The Mercedes bounced across the shoulder, hit a shallow ditch, and came up with its engine still screaming. My head struck the roof. I tasted blood. Behind us the convoy divided, cars sweeping wide through the desert while shots flashed between the trucks.

The men had expected a line.

They got a fucking horizon.

Rex's black coupe came past on our right. Little Saint rode beside it on a new motorcycle with no paint on the tank. He'd borrowed it from a man who apparently understood lending something to my nigga meant accepting an interesting return policy.

Mercedes and Porsche came through the dust in the green Bentley. Porsche had the roof down. Mercedes held her hair away from her face with one hand and a pistol in the other.

"Keep the old man down!" she shouted as they passed.

"Old man is down," Marcellus said from the back seat. "The old man is thoroughly fucking down."

I couldn't help it. I laughed.

Nigga, I laughed with a bullet hole in my windshield and the woman I loved waiting inside a nightmare, because that old man had come through eight years of prison and still knew when my friends needed correcting.

The first truck started moving.

Its driver turned toward the desert to cut off the cars passing on that side. Rex braked hard. Little Saint swerved clear. The truck's huge front wheel climbed the edge of a ditch, and for a second the whole thing leaned toward the coupe.

I saw Rex looking up through his windshield.

I saw Little Saint turn back.

"Tank."

"I see."

"Nigga, this time I believe you."

Tank drove the Mercedes straight into the truck's rear corner.

Metal struck metal. The car jumped sideways. My shoulder hit the door, and every stitch in my side tried to leave without me. The truck's rear swung away from Rex, its wheels clawing at loose dirt. It rolled far enough that the coupe could get clear. Little Saint rode through the gap beside it and came out raising one fist.

"Aiden!"

"Tank!" I shouted back.

The big nigga glanced at me.

"What?"

"I'm giving you your fucking credit. Enjoy it."

He grinned despite the blood on his lip.

The truck stopped against a low rise. Its driver jumped out, took one look at the number of cars now surrounding him, and dropped the gun he'd brought down from the cab.

Bell and Knox reached him first.

The chief got out with her weapon raised.

"You blocked my captain's road."

The man stared at the gold on her uniform.

"Your captain?"

She pointed toward me through the dust.

"That one."

He looked. His face fell so completely I almost respected the honesty of it.

"They didn't say it was him."

"Nigga," I shouted from the window, "what part of thirty cars looked like a small mistake?"

Rex pulled beside us with his window down. His eyebrow was still bleeding where the gala guard had hit him. He looked at Tank, then at me.

"Three times."

"That one was Tank."

"Then I owe the family."

Tank lifted two fingers off the wheel. The nigga didn't even try to look modest. I'd have been angry if he had.

Behind us, Knox's officers took the men off the road. The second truck's crew had run before the first one stopped moving. I could see their flashlights bouncing through the distance, four little dots trying to become somebody else's fucking problem.

The convoy found the highway again.

Thirty engines. A few more scratched. A few more loud. Nobody missing.

The police Lamborghini took the front while Knox's remaining cruisers held the road behind us. Bell gave the siren one short burst, and the cars answered with their horns.

Marcellus sat up carefully in the back.

"Are we finished doing that?"

"For now."

"Good. My tie has given up."

I reached back and straightened it for him at the next slow bend.

"Nigga, you meeting forty million dollars. Look ready."

He looked at me, then down at the cross.

"Damn, boy," he said.

I smiled.

"Magnificent."

The old man nodded as if he'd completed the last repair the evening required.

At eleven fifty-nine, the unfinished casino rose out of the desert in front of us. Lights burned behind its empty windows. Our headlights spread across the parking lot until every naked wall had a shadow of my people on it.

I saw blue on a balcony.

Shawna.

My whole fucking body knew before my eyes finished the distance.

Tank stopped the Mercedes.

I opened the door.

15. The Last King of Vegas

Red had her standing beneath a chandelier that had never been turned on. Nigga hadn't even finished building the place where he wanted to die.

Everything around them was unfinished. Marble on one wall, naked concrete on the next. A staircase big enough for a king coming down into a floor covered with building dust. The place was supposed to be Red's next casino. He had brought my woman here to make me watch him take my whole life away before the fucking doors even opened.

I stepped out of the Mercedes.

Tank got out beside me. Behind us, the convoy stretched across the parking lot, headlights burning through the dust. Niggas I had known for years. Niggas who had started calling me boss eleven days ago. Blue on their wrists, blue at their throats, guns in their hands. Nobody was smiling. Nobody had come to make peace.

I looked up at Shawna.

Her dress was torn at one shoulder. Somebody had hurt her mouth. She held her chin high, but I could see her looking for me in the dark.

I raised my hand.

She saw it.

That was all I needed. That was the whole motherfucking world right there. Every fucking dollar I'd ever touch could burn before I'd leave her up there.

Red stepped into view beside her, wearing white from his shoes to the collar of his shirt. The blue stone on his right hand flashed when he put that hand on her shoulder.

Forty million dollars. Marcellus's life. Celeste's last letter. Dante's blood. All that shit sitting on a finger like it had always belonged to him.

"Aiden," he called down. "You brought everybody."

"I told them there was a dead nigga here."

Tank looked at me, and I could feel what he wanted to say. Don't let this nigga make you move before you think. Don't give him another piece of you because you're mad.

But I was past mad. I had gone through mad on the highway. Whatever was in me now had no place left to go except straight up those stairs.

"Come inside," Red said. "Just you and Tank."

I started walking.

Tank caught my sleeve.

"Nigga."

I stopped.

"We get her and we leave."

"We get her," I said.

He looked at me for another second. Then he let go.

Inside, Red's niggas stood between roulette tables covered in plastic. I could see guns beneath jackets. I could see the ones who weren't bothering to hide them. There must've been thirty motherfuckers waiting for us in that room, and I walked between them with my head up because Shawna was watching.

Thirty niggas. I counted them because I wanted to know how many men I'd tell her I walked through when we got home. My captain's badge showed inside the ruined white jacket. Some of those men looked at it longer than they looked at my gun.

Outside, Knox and Bell held the road; Red could hear the sirens and knew there was no uniform left coming to save him. We were going home. I had already decided that shit in the car.

Red came down the staircase with Shawna beside him. He held her elbow. Every time his fingers tightened, I wanted to tear that arm out of his fucking jacket.

"Nigga, let her walk," I said.

"She is walking."

"Nigga, to me. Let my woman walk to me."

He stopped halfway down.

"You haven't paid for anything yet."

Tank stepped closer to me.

"We got your money."

Red laughed.

"My nigga, you think this is about the three million now?"

"That's what you been asking for."

"I asked for respect. The money was the easy part."

He looked at me.

"Tell me something, Aiden. How much did she tell you about that first night?"

Shawna closed her eyes.

I didn't look away from him.

"Enough."

"Did she tell you she was supposed to get in a car with whoever T sent? Could've been you. Could've been Tank. Could've been any nigga with a pulse and a place to hide the money."

"Don't," Shawna said.

Red leaned close to her.

"We're being honest. That's what lovers want, isn't it?"

I could hear Tank breathing beside me.

Red lifted Shawna's wrist. Dante's watch hung loose against her skin.

"Look at that. You got a palace, cars, an army. You got motherfuckers out here willing to die because they think you're the next big thing. And she still wears a dead man's watch."

Something opened up inside me.

It wasn't the wound.

I had looked at that watch every morning. At the breakfast table. In bed. When she put her hand on my face. I had pretended it didn't bother me because I thought a man with everything wasn't supposed to be jealous of somebody in the ground.

But I was. I was jealous enough to hate myself for it.

"Tell him," Red said to her. "Tell him whose chain made you go over there."

She looked at me.

"Dante's."

I felt Tank turn toward me.

I kept my eyes on her.

"First time I kissed you," she said, "I was looking at his cross. I wanted something of him back. I didn't know what I was doing."

Red smiled.

Nigga thought he had me. He was watching my hand, waiting for the gun to sag, waiting for me to look at her the way he wanted. He'd have paid to see me hate her.

"And now?" I asked.

Shawna swallowed. There was blood at the corner of her mouth.

"Now I'm looking at you."

Red's smile went away.

"Don't give that nigga that shit."

"I'm looking at you, Aiden."

I nodded once.

"Then keep looking, baby."

Red hit her. Nigga hit her right in front of me.

I moved before I thought about it.

Tank grabbed my arm, but I was already pulling free. Guns came up all around the room. I heard men shouting my name. I heard Red tell them not to fire yet.

Shawna caught the banister instead of falling. She lifted her head slowly, and the look she gave him was the same look she must've given Valentino in that car.

Red saw it too.

He put his pistol under her jaw.

Everything stopped.

"One more step," he said.

I stood at the foot of the stairs.

My heart was beating so hard it hurt the place where T had shot me.

"You win," I said.

Tank stared at me.

"Aiden."

"Let her come down. You want the west side, take it. You want the house, take it. My money. My name. Whatever the fuck you want."

Red watched my face.

I meant it. I had been telling everybody I was a king, but I would've walked out of that room with nothing but her hand in mine. We could sleep in the fucking car. Let the nigga have the house.

"You hear that?" he asked Shawna. "He'll give me everything."

"Then take it and let me go."

He shook his head.

"Dante offered me everything too."

The words hung between us.

Red looked down at the ring on his hand.

"Your husband thought having a brother made him untouchable. You think having these niggas outside makes you untouchable. Everybody thinks there's one nigga who won't sell them."

He looked at Tank.

"How much you take out of that pool again?"

Tank's face hardened.

"I gave it back."

"After I told him you had it."

"I gave it back."

Red laughed at him.

"Come stand over here, Tank. You don't gotta die for a nigga you met eleven days ago."

Tank looked at me.

I didn't say anything. I had already asked him for more than I had any right to ask. I wasn't going to beg him now with Red watching.

Tank put his hand on my shoulder.

Right over the place where Big T had put his hand on the first night.

"That's my brother," he said.

Red shot him.

Tank hit me as he went down. His weight knocked me sideways. The first burst of gunfire tore through the room before his body reached the floor.

I fired up the stairs.

Red pulled Shawna against him and went backward through the doorway at the top. I tried to follow him with the gun, but there was too much of her in front of him. Too much of my whole fucking life between me and the man I wanted dead.

Tank grabbed my ankle.

"Go," he said.

Blood was coming through his shirt below the shoulder.

"Nigga, go get her."

The men outside hit the doors.

Glass came down all over the entrance. I heard our people shouting. I saw blue rags moving between the tables. Somebody went down across a roulette wheel. Somebody else fell through the plastic over the bar. Guns flashed in the dark like the whole casino had caught fire from the inside.

I went up the stairs with Tank's voice still in my ears.

The first man came around the landing in a brown jacket. He fired before he saw how close I was. The shot broke the rail beside my hand. I hit him against the wall and kept moving while his gun struck the steps behind us.

Below, Rex Crown came through the doors with our people.

He didn't have a gun in his hand. He had a man in each hand, one by the jacket, one by the belt, and the look of a fighter who

had finally found a room large enough to pay all his debts at once.

"Captain!" he shouted.

"Stairs!"

He threw one man into the other and came toward them.

I reached the first landing. Red was above me with Shawna. He looked down, saw I was still coming, and pulled her harder toward the unfinished corridor behind him.

She stumbled. Caught herself. Turned her face toward me for half a second.

Nigga, that half second got me up another flight.

A gunman stood between two empty light fixtures at the top. He was young enough to think standing high made him safe and old enough to regret learning otherwise. Twenty-seven, I found out afterward. Malik. Three people depending on the money Red paid him to stand in that spot and die if necessary.

He had his gun aimed at my chest.

I stopped one step below him.

"Move."

He looked at the badge showing through my torn jacket.

"Captain Aiden?"

"Nigga, this is a terrible place to introduce yourself. Move."

"Red said you weren't really—"

A shot came from behind him.

Malik ducked. The man deeper in the corridor was firing past his own employee to get at me.

I caught Malik by the collar and pulled him down the step beside me. The second shot struck the wall where his head had been.

He stared at the white dust falling over his shoes.

"Your boss very generous," I told him.

His face changed.

I fired down the corridor. The man at the far end fell back behind a pillar. Malik turned his gun away from me and toward the pillar instead.

"Go," he said.

I looked at him.

"Nigga, decide properly."

He raised his voice.

"Go get her, Captain."

I went.

Behind me I heard him shouting at the others to put their guns down. Some did. Some didn't. The casino filled with choices being made at the loudest possible volume, and for once the

niggas who chose me got to keep breathing long enough to appreciate the decision.

At the foot of the stairs, Porsche dragged a wounded man behind the roulette table where Tank lay. Mercedes stood over both of them, firing toward the dark bar whenever another shape moved there.

"Rosa's coming!" Porsche shouted up at me.

I didn't know how she knew. I didn't need to. My people had begun finding each other without waiting for me to hold all the names in my head.

Little Saint came through the side entrance with three more men. He pointed up at me.

"That's our nigga! Clear him a road!"

I was already on it.

The corridor split around an unfinished fountain. Red's white jacket disappeared through the far doors. I followed, one hand against the wall, blood warm beneath my bandages.

A man stepped out beside the fountain with a shotgun.

I dropped as he fired. The edge of the fountain burst. Water left in its bottom jumped into my face. He tried to bring the gun down toward me, but I was already against his legs.

We hit the floor together.

The shotgun slid away. He caught my wounded side with an elbow and the pain opened so wide I couldn't see. I heard Shawna shout my name from the room beyond us.

That brought me back.

I hit him until his hands came off me. Not because I stopped hurting. Nigga, I hurt everywhere. I hurt in years I hadn't even lived yet. But she had said my name like the whole world depended on whether I answered, and I wasn't going to make her ask a dead man again.

I got up.

The man reached for my ankle.

I looked down at him.

"Don't make this your whole life."

He let go.

I took the shotgun off the floor and fired toward the far wall when another man came through the doorway shooting. The man dropped behind a stack of marble tiles. I left the gun and kept my own pistol in my hand.

Ahead, the desert showed through a room without glass. Headlights burned below it. The balcony rail ran along the open edge, thin and dark against all that distance.

I heard Red breathing hard.

Then his voice.

"You don't get tired?"

I came through the door.

"Nigga, you keep giving me somewhere to be."

The room beyond was open to the desert. They hadn't put the glass in yet. A balcony ran along the edge, looking down over the lights of our cars.

Red had Shawna against the railing.

Her little silver pistol fell out of his jacket as he hauled her against the railing. It struck the floor beside his shoe.

"Nigga, that gun drops now," he told me.

I stopped in the doorway.

"Drop it or she goes over."

There was nothing beneath the balcony but concrete and steel.

Shawna looked at me. Her eyes were wide. She was scared now. Really scared. No black dress, no diamonds, no cold story about killing Valentino could hide that from me.

"Put her down," I said.

"Put the gun down."

I lowered it.

Set it on the floor.

Red watched me do it.

Then he smiled.

"That's how your husband died, Shawna. That's how Dante went down. Hands open. Begging. T couldn't even look at him."

"He wasn't begging for himself," she said.

Red's arm tightened.

"What?"

"You said he wanted somebody to take care of me."

"Shut the fuck up."

"He wasn't begging for himself."

She drove her head backward into his face.

He staggered. His gun went off into the empty sky. Shawna dropped to the floor, reached for her little silver pistol, and came up firing.

The first shot hit his leg.

The second hit him in the chest.

Red fell against the railing, one hand still reaching toward her.

"Dante," she said.

Just his name.

She tried to raise it again. Her hand was shaking so badly the barrel fell below his chest.

Red was still standing.

He lifted his pistol.

I had mine back in my hand by then.

I put him down.

I fired until his gun fell out of his hand. Until his knees hit the balcony. Until the nigga who had taken years from her life was on the ground looking up at a sky he wasn't ever going to own.

Then I went to her.

She was on her knees, still holding the silver gun.

"Baby."

She didn't look up.

"Shawna."

Her hand wouldn't open.

I put mine around it.

"It's done."

She shook her head.

I wanted her to say my name. Nigga, I wanted it so bad I could hardly breathe. She kept saying Dante's. I put my gun down beside hers and got both arms around her.

I held her on the floor while she cried for Dante.

And I held her tighter because I was the one who was there.

Downstairs, somebody shouted that Red was dead.

Then somebody shouted my name.

More voices picked it up. Through the hall. Across the casino. Out into the parking lot where all those headlights were still burning.

Aiden.

Aiden.

My nigga, I had blood in both shoes and her face against my neck, and they were calling me the king of Vegas.

I believed them.

Before we left, I took Blue Mercy off Red's hand. He'd stopped reaching for anything by then. Forty million dollars in my fist, and I closed it so hard the setting cut my palm.

Tank was alive when we got back downstairs.

Rosa had come after us with Dr. Vega. She told me later she'd sat in the house watching the clock until she couldn't fucking stand it, then gone to get the doctor and driven out behind the convoy. They came through the doors after the shooting stopped. Vega was bent over a wounded man near the entrance when I saw her.

Tank lay beside the roulette table with Rosa holding a folded tablecloth against him. Her dress was covered in blood. She looked at me like she was ready to fight God if he tried to take another person out of that room.

"Where the fuck you been?"

"With her."

She looked past me. Saw Shawna. Her face broke, and she had to press her mouth shut before she could talk again.

"Come here, baby."

Shawna went down beside her.

Tank opened his eyes when I knelt.

"My nigga. You got her?"

"Yeah."

"Red?"

"Dead."

He tried to smile. It hurt him.

"You better pay my fucking hospital bill."

I took his hand.

"Every penny."

"And the car."

"What car?"

"I want one."

"Nigga, a hundred. Your nigga will buy you a hundred fucking cars."

He shut his eyes again.

"Black ones."

I held on until the doctor came.

I kept my hand around his. The last nigga who called me family had put a bullet in me before the night was over. Tank had taken one instead. Every time a voice came through the door, I looked up expecting somebody to tell me what else I could pay to keep him breathing.

I wasn't letting him wake up alone.

Marcellus came into the casino after the shooting stopped.

He walked through the broken glass slowly. His shoes were old and polished. He looked at the walls, the marble, the great staircase Red had built with other people's lives.

Then he looked at me.

I put the ring in his hand.

Blue Mercy flashed under the work lights.

For a long time he didn't speak.

His thumb moved across the setting. Red had put her stone in his own ring. Marcellus turned it in his hand, held it beneath the light, and closed his eyes.

Then he took Celeste's letter out of his coat. He laid the ring against the paper and bent his head over both of them.

I let him take all the time he needed.

"What are you going to do?" I asked.

He closed his hand around the ring.

"Take my wife home."

I nodded.

Forty million dollars. I put forty million dollars in an old man's hand and watched him walk away because the woman I loved had just killed a man while saying another man's name, and for the first time that night I understood why some things couldn't be bought back.

Everything else in that casino was mine. Knox came through the entrance with Bell after the last guns were down. She looked at Shawna in my arms, the gold badge under the blood, and the men who had changed sides because a living captain had offered them more future than Red.

"You brought her home," she said.

"Told you my nigga doesn't forget."

She saluted. Bell followed. Then every officer in the doorway stood straight while the men inside the casino began saying my name again.

Captain. King. Aiden.

Shawna heard all three and held me tighter.

I made sure every nigga understood that too.

16. Ten Toes Down Forever

They put Tank in a private room with a view of the mountains.

I paid for the room next door for Rosa because she wouldn't leave him. She said she was there for Shawna. Tank said Rosa had called him handsome while she was keeping him alive, and he wanted witnesses.

She told him he was full of shit.

He smiled at her anyway. Nigga was hooked. I could've told him that from the doorway.

My nigga, I had seen that man face down in the dirt, seen him take punches that would've broken somebody else's neck, seen him stand beside T like nothing in the world could ever make him move. I hadn't ever seen him nervous before a woman walked into a room.

I bought him a black Cadillac.

Then I bought him another one because he called me from the hospital and said the first picture didn't do the color justice.

"Nigga, you buying me a car or showing me a car?" he asked.

"Look out your fucking window."

I heard Rosa open the blinds. Heard that big nigga start laughing. He had to stop because it hurt him. Then he started again.

Nigga had almost died for me. I would've painted the whole fucking city black if he'd asked.

I went back to the house with Shawna three days after Red died.

The lake was quiet. There were flowers at the gate, flowers on the stairs, flowers in the bedroom. Niggas I'd never met sent bottles and watches. Women sent silk, perfume, diamonds. Somebody sent a white horse with a blue ribbon tied into its mane.

I had the horse taken around to the back where she could see it from the balcony.

Shawna stood at the bedroom window and looked down at it.

"You buy that?"

"Somebody sent it."

"Why?"

"Because they know who you are."

She watched it walking beside the water.

"I don't know how to ride."

"Then we'll learn."

She turned toward me.

For a second, I thought she was going to cry again.

Then she laughed.

I had missed that sound so bad. I had been hearing gunfire in my sleep, hearing T say son, hearing Red tell me she'd have got in the car with anybody. I had started thinking that was all the world had left to say to me.

Then she laughed and came across the room and kissed me.

I picked her up. She wrapped her arms around my neck, and I carried her away from the window while the sun went down behind the mountains. My side hurt. I didn't put her down.

Nigga, I'd carried worse for men who loved me less.

Later, we lay awake listening to the water.

Her watch rested on the nightstand.

I looked at it for a while.

She saw me looking.

"You want me to take it off?"

I didn't answer right away.

I wanted everything. Her mornings. Her nights. The way she turned her head when somebody said my name. I wanted to be the man she thought of when a song came on. I wanted to reach back three years and be the one carrying that cake into the club. I wanted to put myself in every photograph that had ever made her happy.

I couldn't.

And all the money in Vegas couldn't help me with that. I'd bought half a fucking city, and I couldn't buy one night three years ago.

"No," I said.

She rested her head on my chest.

"Sometimes I miss him when I'm happy."

I looked at the ceiling.

"With me?"

"Yeah."

That hurt. I'm not going to lie to you. That shit went straight through me.

She lifted her head.

"Because I wish he knew I wasn't hurting all the time anymore."

I looked at her then.

She touched the cross against my chest.

"I wish he knew somebody stayed."

I took her hand and held it there.

Neither of us said anything for a long time.

Then I asked her to marry me. Right there. No shirt, no ring, her dead husband's watch where both of us could see it.

She sat up.

"Aiden."

"I mean it."

"You just bought me a house."

"I'll buy you another one."

"That's not what I'm saying."

"Then tell me what you're saying."

She looked at me with tears in her eyes.

"You can't fix every bad thing that ever happened to me."

"I know."

"You gonna be mad when you find that out for real?"

I sat up beside her.

"I'm gonna be mad about a lot of shit, baby. I'm a fucked-up man. You know that."

She nodded.

"I'm asking you to marry me, baby. Bring the watch. Bring the pictures. Bring every fucking thing you can't leave behind. Just come with me."

She put her hand over my mouth.

Then she started laughing and crying at the same time.

"Yes," she said.

I kissed her palm.

"Say it again."

"Yes. I'll marry you."

I had fifty niggas outside that house ready to die for me and more money than I could count in one room, and I swear to you none of it had ever made me feel like that one word.

We got married beside the lake.

Three weeks after I walked into the Saint. The flowers cost more than every rent payment I'd ever made put together. Shawna came toward me in a white dress while a woman sang the song she used to sing in her mother's kitchen.

Blue roses and the gardenias I had promised her covered the aisle.

There were diamonds at her throat. Dante's watch on her wrist.

I wore the cross.

Tank stood beside me in a black suit with his arm still healing under the jacket. Rosa sat in the front row wearing a blue dress and trying not to look at him. He looked at her enough for both of them.

Every table had a bottle of Hennessy on it. Every nigga at the gate had a gun. Behind the flowers, my people watched the road while men from other cities came to shake my hand and find out whether the stories were true.

Nigga, they were true enough that none of them tried me.

I paid the singer more than she asked. Then I paid her band.
Then I bought the place where she'd been playing because
Shawna said the owner had treated her like shit once, years ago,
when she was trying to get an audition.

I didn't bring him to the wedding.

I made that nigga listen to it from the parking lot.

Shawna reached me and put her hands in mine.

For a moment I forgot everybody else was there.

The preacher asked me if I would love her in sickness and in
health.

I looked at the scar above her eyebrow. At the mark still fading
on her mouth. At the wrist she had held against my bleeding side
when all I had to give her was a promise about a house near the
water.

"I will."

He asked her the same.

"I will."

That's how it happened. Her hand was shaking in mine. Tank
kept wiping his face with the sleeve on his good arm. Rosa was
crying into a napkin she'd stolen off his table. My girl said yes in
front of the whole fucking city.

I kissed my wife while the band played and my people shouted my name.

The wedding presents arrived in a convoy longer than the one we'd taken into the desert.

Knox brought a gold-plated pair of handcuffs in a velvet box and told Shawna she trusted her to decide when they were necessary. Shawna held them up, looked at me, and smiled in a way that made Tank cover his eyes.

"Nigga, I'm trying to eat."

"Then look at your plate," Rosa told him.

Professor Halcyon came with Principal Mercer and six graduates who'd helped carry people out of the auditorium. They brought a framed photograph of my Lamborghini coming through the doors with fire behind it. Mercer had signed the bottom in gold.

Our valedictorian.

"Nigga, you signed this like you made me," I told him.

He began crying again.

Shawna took the frame before either of us dropped it.

"I know exactly where this goes."

"Over the bed?"

"Over the fireplace. You already think enough of yourself in bed."

Mercedes screamed laughing. Porsche nearly dropped her drink. Mercer didn't seem to understand the sentence, but he nodded like the academic quality of it was beyond dispute.

Rex Crown arrived with a white limousine full of fighters who all wanted to shake my hand. He introduced me to each one by telling them exactly how quickly I had put him down. Every time he told it, the time got shorter and his expression got prouder.

"One punch," he said to the last man. "Before I got comfortable."

"Rex, nigga, you weren't comfortable when you arrived."

"That's what I'm telling him. I never stood a chance."

The fighter looked at me, looked at Shawna, and bowed his head.

"Congratulations, Captain."

"See?" Rex said. "Nigga learns fast."

Little Saint brought a motorcycle painted dark blue with my initials on the tank. He told me it was for days when four wheels felt like too much company. Tank immediately told him no day in my life required fewer wheels.

"You jealous?" Little Saint asked.

"Nigga, I have watched this man drive. I am informed."

Leon brought a bicycle.

A real bicycle. Green. A little basket on the front. He wheeled it through the gate in a tuxedo and looked straight at Porsche.

"This one floats."

She kissed him on the cheek.

"Baby, so did the first car for a minute."

He shut his eyes while everybody laughed, then opened them on the house, the music, the lake full of lights.

"I wouldn't have missed any of it," he said.

Nigga, neither would I.

For our first dance, Shawna wanted a song she could hear without remembering a room somebody else had paid for.

So we made one.

She had written the melody in the week before the wedding. I'd found her at the piano after midnight, barefoot, chewing the end of a pencil while she tried to make the bridge stop sounding like she was saying goodbye.

I sat beside her and played the left hand while she sang.

"There," I said when her voice rose.

"Where?"

"Don't turn back. Keep going."

She tried it. The note opened. Her face changed.

"Baby."

"That's us."

We worked until the sun came up. No dead men in the song. No promises somebody had made with one hand on a door. Just a woman hearing a car in the driveway and knowing the person she wanted was finally coming in.

Now the band played it beside the lake while my wife put her hand in mine.

The first steps were easy. The next ones belonged to her. Shawna moved like music had been waiting all those years for somebody to give her enough room, and I followed until she laughed at how serious I looked.

"Nigga, you know how to dance."

"I know how to dance with you. Different subject. Higher degree."

She leaned back in my arm. I caught her, turned, brought her close again while the whole wedding cheered.

Rosa stood up first. Tank tried to follow and remembered his shoulder. She came to him instead, took his good hand, and led him onto the edge of the floor.

"I don't dance," he told her.

"You do tonight."

"Rosa—"

"Nigga, you got shot for these people. Survive four steps with me."

He survived them. Badly at first. Then better when he stopped looking at his feet and looked at her face.

I watched my brother discover that being large wasn't the only way to take up a woman's whole world.

He looked over at me once, embarrassed and helplessly happy.

I nodded.

Your nigga got it, I was telling him. Your nigga had finally fucking got it.

At the last chorus, the fireworks began over the water.

Blue and gold. Huge flowers opening in the sky above the house I'd bought before I knew where to put my own clothes. The guests turned to look. Shawna stayed looking at me.

I put my forehead against hers.

"You missing the expensive part."

"No, baby."

She touched the cross.

"I'm looking right at him."

Nigga, I didn't have a single smart thing left in my mouth. She kissed me before I could find one.

Then we went inside and got so drunk the sun came up before anybody remembered there had been a schedule.

There was cocaine in the upstairs bathroom, cash changing hands on the terrace, hookers dancing with men who had brought other women to the wedding. Somebody drove a convertible onto the lawn. Tank fell asleep with his good arm around Rosa, and she threatened to kill the first motherfucker who took a picture.

I bought every picture the next morning.

I kept one. Nigga looks at it now and swears he was awake. Rosa has the same picture by her bed.

People tell this story like everything ended when Red hit the ground.

It didn't.

The calls kept coming. The money kept coming. The west side still needed a boss on Monday. A man in another city still thought Red dying meant he could take what Red used to sell. Somebody still owed somebody, and somebody's brother still wanted blood.

I didn't become a good man because I put a ring on Shawna's finger.

I was still the nigga who walked into a hotel with blood on his collar and told another man's people the girl was coming with

him. I still had a temper. Still had a gun. Still woke up some nights with my hand on the place T had shot me.

And I still wanted everything.

But now I knew who I was bringing it home to.

One night that week, I came back from handling business and found Shawna in the room we'd made for her music.

She had all the lights off except the little lamp beside the piano. There were papers on the floor. A half-finished drink on the windowsill. She was singing something I hadn't heard before.

I stood in the doorway and listened.

When she finished, she turned around.

"How long you been there?"

"Long enough."

"You like it?"

"Yeah."

"You always say that."

"I always mean it."

She held out her hand.

I went to her.

Outside, there were niggas guarding the gates and a city waiting for me to make the next decision. In that room, she pulled me down beside her and put my hand against her heart.

"Stay a minute," she said.

I stayed all night.

Aight, my nigga. Now you know which nigga you riding with.

You know about the money in the pool. You know about the blood in the car. You know why I wear a dead man's cross and why my wife still wears his watch. You know which nigga called me son and tried to kill me, and which nigga took a bullet before he'd let me stand alone.

Don't let anybody tell you I came out of that desert clean. I came out alive. I came out with Shawna's hand in mine and Tank bleeding in the back of an ambulance, and I made the whole fucking city learn our names.

My nigga, I gave away the most expensive diamond I ever held. Then I took everything the man wearing it thought he was going to leave behind. That's what happened. That's my money in the walls of that house. That's my name on the cars. That's my wife singing with the window open when the lake goes black at night.

And when she wakes up crying, I'm there. When Tank calls me at three in the morning, I answer. When some motherfucker thinks the years made me soft, I let him get close enough to see the scar.

You can call that love. You can call that crazy. Call it whatever the fuck you want. I was crazy before she loved me. I had blood

on me before she touched me. She didn't make me dangerous. She gave all that danger somewhere to come home.

I remember Dante. I never met him, but I remember him every time that gold cross hits my chest. I remember T. I wish I could remember him without the gun. I remember Red. I remember what he looked like when he found out there was something in that room he couldn't buy.

And I remember her in the Mercedes. One hand on the wheel. One hand trying to keep my life inside me. She could've left me. She could've taken what she could carry and gone. But she stayed. My girl stayed.

So your nigga stayed too. What the fuck else was I going to do with a home?

Ten toes down, my nigga. In the club where twelve niggas tried me. In the desert where thirty engines answered. In that hospital hallway waiting for my nigga Tank to open his eyes and start requesting Cadillacs. A nigga can stand in a kingdom; a nigga can stand beside a bed. I stood in both. Ten toes down when the money came, and ten toes down when no nigga could buy the thing I was waiting to hear.

And if another man comes through that gate thinking he's going to make her cry like that again, he better bring every goddamn prayer he knows.

Because I'm home now.

Aiden.

Ten toes down. Forever.

The invitation arrived the morning we were packing for our honeymoon.

A blue envelope with a silver seal. Nobody had brought it through the gate. Nobody had rung the bell. It lay on the hood of my police Lamborghini when I came outside with Shawna's suitcase in one hand and my own smaller bag in the other.

Tank saw it first.

"If that's another college, I'm taking the test."

"Nigga, you can start by reading the envelope."

He picked it up.

"Sky High."

I looked at him.

"That a club?"

"School."

"Nigga, I just graduated."

"They seem excited about that."

Shawna came down the steps behind us. Rosa had one arm through hers. Mercedes and Porsche waited by the cars, arguing

about how many suitcases one woman could take on somebody else's honeymoon before it became a group vacation.

Marcellus stood beside the white horse, feeding it something the trainer had told him was permitted. Blue Mercy was safe with him now, returned to a proper case. He had stopped carrying the case from room to room. That was how I knew he believed he had come home.

I opened the envelope.

Inside was a photograph of a campus above the clouds.

Not on a mountain. Above the fucking clouds. Buildings, lawns, a football field, towers shining in the sun, all of it standing on a huge piece of land that had apparently decided the ground wasn't good enough for its students.

There was a letter underneath.

Dean Seraphine Storm. Advanced adult hero program. Every member of the incoming class at least twenty-two. The dean had seen the graduation footage, the hospital rescue, the convoy, and enough other parts of my life to decide I had been taking the long route to the appropriate school.

She wanted me there after the honeymoon.

She wanted my people with me.

I read that part twice.

"Nigga," Tank said, looking over my shoulder, "the school is in the sky."

"I can see."

"Our school had steps. These niggas got weather."

Rosa took the photograph from him.

"They got rooms?"

"Whole residences," Shawna said, reading the second page.

"Piano?"

"Conservatory."

"Cars?" Porsche asked.

I looked down at the letter.

Your automobile may accompany you, Captain. We would prefer that its first landing be supervised.

I started smiling.

Shawna saw it happen and shook her head before I said a word.

"Baby. Honeymoon first."

"Absolutely."

"I mean a real honeymoon. With a bed. Somewhere the bed touches a floor that touches the fucking earth."

"Whatever my wife wants."

Tank looked at the photograph again.

"Nigga, you think you can be best in that school too?"

I folded the letter and put it inside my jacket beside the badge.

The gold cross settled against my chest.

"Tank."

"What?"

"Those niggas already invited me. They know."

Shawna laughed and took the Lamborghini's keys from my hand.

"Get in, valedictorian. I'm driving before somebody gives you a planet."

I got in.

Nigga, you have to understand. I had a wife, a badge, a kingdom, and a college waiting in the fucking sky.

And she still made me carry the bags.

BOOK II: SKY HIGH, TEN TOES HIGHER

1. They Put My Parking Space in Heaven

The first time I drove my police Lamborghini into the clouds, the sky opened up and a woman told me I was already late for my own award.

I had not enrolled yet. Nigga, I hadn't found the parking lot. Some other nigga was already polishing a prize for me while I was trying to work out whether this cloud counted as a turn.

Tank called from the Mercedes behind us.

“This nigga said you late for an award?”

“Woman said it.”

“Aiden, nigga, don't get technical in heaven. What you win?”

“I don't know yet.”

“How this nigga win something he don't know?”

Shawna leaned toward the phone. “Tank, you've met him.”

That settled the question. I heard my nigga laugh, heard Rosa laugh beside him, heard the Mercedes engine rise through the white air. A nigga could get used to that sound: all his people following because the impossible road had finally decided to hold his weight.

Shawna sat beside me with her bare feet on the dashboard and a pair of white sunglasses bigger than the sins we had committed

on our honeymoon. She had a new diamond on her wedding finger and Dante's old watch on her wrist. I had my badge in my pocket, his cross under my shirt, and a twelve-cylinder reason to believe the universe had finally gotten serious about respecting me.

The invitation said Sky High Advanced Hero Academy. A postgraduate program for heroes who had already graduated and somehow still wanted homework. It said my rescue in Vegas had demonstrated exceptional aptitude.

Exceptional aptitude was when you parallel parked without touching the curb.

I had driven through a burning auditorium and still delivered my valedictorian speech before the principal finished crying.

They should have put exceptional motherfucker.

“Aiden,” Shawna said. “Cloud.”

“Baby, I see it.”

“Inside the car.”

A little piece of weather rolled through the open window and rested on her lap. She pushed her sunglasses down and stared at it. The cloud drifted over her wedding ring, turned pink, and dissolved.

“Your diamonds doing shit to the climate now,” I said.

“Keep looking at the road.”

There was no road. That was the first issue.

There had been a road until thirty seconds ago. It had climbed a mountain, passed between two stone lions, and ended at a gate reading WELCOME, HEROES. Then a guard in silver armor had glanced at my gold badge, looked at my face, and saluted so hard his helmet fell off.

“Captain Aiden,” he'd said. “It's an honor.”

“Nigga, which way?”

“Up.”

I had appreciated his confidence.

Now the Lamborghini was climbing an invisible ramp through the clouds at a speed Shawna described as “why the fuck.” The wheel vibrated in my hands. Beneath us, the mountains shrank until they looked like somebody's pile of dirty clothes.

Behind us Tank's black Mercedes rose through the mist. Rosa sat beside him, singing into a hairbrush. Marcellus was in the back wearing a gray suit, carrying a small case, and looking as if he had already decided heaven charged too much for lunch. Dr. Vega had come for a three-day visit and was currently holding Tank's headrest like she intended to remove it.

Mercedes and Porsche followed in a red convertible I had bought them after they pointed out that I owned an island's worth of cars and kept asking them to share an Uber. The

women were arguing over whose turn it was to meet a man who could fly.

All my people were ascending.

And at the top of the clouds waited a whole fucking city.

Not a building. A city.

White towers rose around a stadium shaped like a golden shield. A glass train moved between them without touching anything. Gardens hung off stone balconies. An enormous waterfall poured from one edge of the island and disappeared into blue air. Little vehicles streamed across bridges suspended between floating blocks of land. Farther out, a ring of separate islands carried hotels, stores, and a casino with a flashing sign visible from what appeared to be several religions.

SKY HIGH stood over the front gate in letters taller than my mansion.

I slowed down just enough for the Lamborghini to make its noise.

Shawna smiled.

“There he go.”

“Who?”

“My husband about to introduce himself to the atmosphere.”

“Baby, the atmosphere been waiting.”

The invisible ramp became a solid white drive. Students stopped where they were. A man with transparent wings folded them and turned. A woman carrying three refrigerators over her head looked at me and forgot she was carrying refrigerators. Somebody in a crimson cape walked straight into a fountain. I parked in front of the main staircase.

There was a gold sign.

DEAN.

I read it carefully and remained parked.

A tall woman descended the steps wearing a white suit with silver lightning along the collar. Her hair fell black to her shoulders except for one white streak. She had the kind of face that made a man stand up straighter before he remembered he had a wife beside him. The air sharpened around her. Her eyes were gray, and behind the gray something bright moved.

“Captain Aiden,” she said.

I stepped out. “Dean.”

“Seraphine Storm.”

“That's a hell of a name.”

“I earned it.”

“So did I.”

We shook hands. A tiny spark jumped between us.

I did not let go.

Her eyebrow rose.

“Most visitors flinch.”

“Most visitors ain't me.”

Shawna came around the car. Storm's attention moved to her ring, then to her face.

“Mrs. Aiden.”

“Shawna.”

They shook hands without sparks. I respected the weather for knowing when to behave.

Tank parked behind me. “Nigga, you in her space.”

“I know where I'm at.”

“We can arrange another space,” Storm said.

Tank looked from her to me and slowly took off his sunglasses.

“We just got here.”

“I make a strong first impression.”

From the staircase a blond man in a blue uniform laughed once. He was broad through the shoulders, clean-shaven, with a silver emblem on his chest and a jaw he plainly expected other people to remember.

“That's the famous graduate?” he asked.

Storm didn't look away from me. "Victor Voltage. Twenty-seven. First in his division until this morning."

Victor's smile stopped.

My smile began.

"Nigga, don't look at me. I ain't touched your division."

"Your provisional placement puts you first overall," Storm told me.

"Based on what?" Victor demanded.

She gestured toward the Lamborghini.

He looked at the car as if it had personally stolen his childhood.

"That's a vehicle."

"The entrance ramp was closed," Storm said.

Everybody got quiet.

I looked back at the sky.

Tank looked back at the sky.

Shawna took off her sunglasses very slowly.

"Aiden."

"Now hold on."

Storm's smile grew. "We were testing our emergency magnetic ascent field. You drove through its narrowest boundary at exactly the velocity required to remain inside it. Then three civilian cars followed your path."

Dr. Vega got out of the Mercedes.

“I would like to go home.”

“You can use the open ramp,” Storm said.

“There was an open ramp?”

I put my arm around Shawna. “Baby, I brought us the scenic way.”

She pinched my side. The old wound still had opinions about people touching it.

“The scenic way to fucking death.”

“And look how beautiful we survived.”

Then the sky train exploded.

Not the whole train. The front coupling burst in orange flame as it came around the stadium. A sharp crack punched across the courtyard. Heads turned. A hundred windows flashed.

The train tilted.

Forty people screamed at once.

Victor was moving before the sound finished. Blue-white energy wrapped his fists. He launched himself upward, fast enough to knock spray out of the fountain. Storm raised both hands. Wind slammed through the courtyard.

The train's front carriage lurched back toward its rail.

The rear two kept falling.

I saw a woman pressed to the back window. Saw a man drag another man off the floor. Saw the distance between that train and the edge of the island closing.

Nigga, I was supposed to be receiving something.

Instead I had to go earn it again.

I jumped into the Lamborghini.

“Tank!”

He already had the Mercedes door open.

Shawna slid into my passenger seat.

“You staying here,” I said.

“Drive.”

“Baby—”

“Those people do not have time for you to win this argument.”

I hit the gas.

The car shot between the fountain and the steps. Somebody tried to tell me that was a pedestrian path. He said the first half to the windshield and the second half to the exhaust.

The rear carriages struck a maintenance platform beyond the stadium. Metal shrieked. The platform bent toward the open air. Victor hovered above it, both arms spread, electricity coursing into the damaged suspension rings. Sweat ran down his face. His boots flickered.

He was powerful.

He was also holding forty people over a drop nobody had bothered measuring for survivability.

I understood his problem immediately.

Too many niggas. Not enough ground.

I took a turn so hard Shawna's hair whipped across my mouth. The Lamborghini climbed a service stair, hit the landing, and flew over a strip of garden. We landed on the maintenance platform with a crash that made my teeth feel individually expensive.

The platform dipped.

“Get that car off!” Victor shouted.

I looked through the windshield at the hanging carriage.

“Shawna. Door.”

She unbuckled. “Which?”

“All of them.”

I shoved the Lamborghini nose beneath a sloping support beam. The hood buckled. A warning screamed from the dashboard. I kept going until the car wedged between the broken platform and the stone service wall.

The platform stopped dropping.

Victor stared at me.

“Nigga,” I shouted, “keep doing the light shit!”

Shawna was already at the carriage. She hit its emergency release, hauled the door open, and caught the first woman through it by both arms.

“Walk toward the wall,” she ordered. “Keep your hands on the rail. Don't look down.”

Somebody looked down and froze.

My wife slapped him.

“Look at me instead.”

He did. He moved.

Tank brought the Mercedes onto solid ground and jumped out. Rosa followed him. She took one look at the gap and began singing, loud and steady, a beat people could move to. Not a sad song. One of the nasty ones she performed in Vegas when men forgot how much cash they had brought.

Forty terrified adult heroes began crossing a ruined platform to a song about getting paid before breakfast.

I climbed onto my hood.

It was an expensive hood. I would mourn it when niggas stopped falling out of the sky.

Inside the last carriage, a man had his leg trapped beneath a fallen seat. A silver-haired woman knelt beside him. One whole side of the carriage was opening over empty blue air.

I jumped through the door.

The woman looked at my badge.

“Are you rescue?”

“Today.”

I grabbed the seat. It didn't move.

The trapped man said, “My power's density. I can't turn it off when I'm scared.”

“How heavy?”

“A lot.”

“Nigga, that is a terrible number.”

The train shifted. Outside, Victor yelled. A burst of blue light turned the windows white.

I braced my shoes against the opposite seat and pulled. The metal bit my palms. Nothing. The man shook so hard the floor rattled.

I got close to his face.

“What's your name?”

“Elias.”

“Elias, listen to me. My wife standing outside this train.”

He blinked.

“That woman thinks I'm the greatest man alive. I happen to agree. Now you gonna make both of us look stupid?”

“No.”

“Then stop trying to weigh more than my reputation.”

He laughed. Just once. A frightened little cough of a laugh.

The floor lifted.

I tore the seat aside.

“There we fucking go.”

The woman helped me drag him. We reached the door as the back window broke away. Wind hit us. My cross slapped against my chest.

Below, the waterfall hung like a white ribbon all the way into the clouds.

Victor's left hand went dark.

The carriage dropped six inches.

I shoved Elias through the door into Tank's arms. The woman followed. I grabbed the rail.

Then the platform tore loose.

My Lamborghini went with it.

For one ugly second I saw my whole future reflected in that dark blue roof: car gone, wife watching, nigga floating down to Earth with a gold badge and an unpaid insurance argument.

Shawna caught my wrist.

Tank caught her waist.

Storm's wind caught the car.

Everything stopped.

Not gently. My shoulder made a noise. Shawna swore. Tank planted his feet and shouted, “I got all you motherfuckers!”

The dean stood at the end of the broken walkway with lightning in her hair. The entire Lamborghini hung sideways beneath us inside a spinning cradle of cloud.

“Captain,” she said through clenched teeth. “Would you please stop adding weight?”

I hauled myself up beside my wife.

“I'm trying to take some off.”

Victor brought the last carriage down into the grass. Storm lowered my car beside it. The engine ticked. The left headlight hung out like a tired eye.

Silence spread over the service yard.

Then Elias began clapping.

The silver-haired woman joined him.

By the time I stood up, everybody was doing it.

Shawna grabbed my face and kissed me hard enough to settle the disagreement we had not finished in the car. I held her against me. Around us forty rescued people cheered louder.

“That's my husband,” she said when she pulled back.

Nobody argued.

Victor landed beside the wrecked train. His uniform smoked at the wrists. He looked at the Lamborghini. Looked at my bleeding hands. Looked at Shawna holding me.

“You have no powers,” he said.

“I got several good qualities.”

“No. I mean you have no measurable power signature.”

“Nigga, measure the people who ain't dead.”

His mouth opened.

Then he looked at Elias sitting safely on the grass.

He closed it.

Storm came toward me. Her hair settled. Behind her, students poured around the corner, calling to the passengers, filming the wreckage, shouting my name even though I had introduced myself to approximately four people.

“Your award ceremony,” the dean said, “will now include an additional citation.”

I looked at my car.

“Will it include a body shop?”

“The best engineering faculty in the sky.”

“Good. That nigga need a doctor.”

Dr. Vega stepped around Tank carrying a medical bag.

“The car can wait. You are bleeding.”

“Little bit.”

“That is also a terrible number.”

She took my hand. Shawna stood against my other side. Tank looked at the shattered platform and shook his head with a smile he couldn't hide.

“You been here twelve minutes.”

“Thirteen,” Storm said.

“See?” I told him. “I gave the school an extra minute.”

At the edge of the crowd stood a thin man in a charcoal suit. He had silver hair combed straight back, a black cane, and eyes that did not seem interested in blinking. Two guards stood behind him in uniforms darker than the others.

Storm noticed him and straightened.

“Chancellor Voss.”

He approached the broken coupling first. Bent his head. Touched a scorched piece of metal with one gloved finger.

Then he turned to me.

“An extraordinary arrival.”

“We try.”

His smile showed no teeth.

“You saved a number of people whose gifts are important to this institution.”

I glanced at Elias. He was holding the silver-haired woman's hand. His whole body shook now that it was allowed to.

“Saved the rest too.”

“Naturally.”

Voss's eyes moved to my badge, then my cross, then Shawna. He lingered on none of them long enough for me to call it a problem.

But a nigga can feel a problem dressing itself.

“We will investigate the equipment failure,” he said.

“Do that.”

His guards collected the broken coupling before anybody else touched it.

Storm watched them go. Her face had changed for one second, then changed back.

She offered us the grand staircase, the open doors, the city of people waiting to meet me.

I put my good arm around Shawna. Tank lifted my overnight bag from the ruined car. Rosa took his other arm. Marcellus appeared carrying the case he had somehow never set down.

“First impression?” he asked.

“Strong,” I said.

He looked at the wrecked train, then at the whole school applauding.

“I should have brought a larger safe.”

We went up those steps together.

Above the entrance hung a banner they had apparently prepared before I arrived.

WELCOME, EXCEPTIONAL HEROES.

Somebody was already climbing a ladder to change it.

I didn't tell them to.

Nigga, excellence makes suggestions of its own.

Our rooms occupied the top floor of a tower overlooking the western edge. There were two balconies, a bath large enough to qualify for boat ownership, and a bedroom ceiling that showed the actual stars above the clouds. The bellman set down our bags and waited to be tipped.

I gave him enough money to change the direction of his afternoon.

He looked at it. Looked at me.

“Sir, I have worked here eleven years.”

“Then you was overdue.”

He left walking backward.

Shawna closed the door and leaned against it. Her smile had gone soft. That was the one that always made me feel more dangerous and less prepared at the same time.

“You scared me,” she said.

“I had it.”

“I know you had it. That's not the same thing.”

I crossed the room. She put her hands beneath my open jacket and rested them against my ribs, careful of the old hurt. Outside the balcony a woman flew past carrying a bouquet larger than herself. Somewhere below us people were still shouting about the train.

“You came with me,” I said.

“Always.”

“Even when I'm parking wrong.”

“Especially. Apparently that's when you become first in your class.”

I kissed her forehead. Then her mouth. She pulled me closer, and for a little while the biggest thing happening in the sky was our door staying shut.

Later, when we stood on the balcony wearing the school's expensive robes, I saw a second city beneath the first.

It wasn't really a city. More a collection of black buildings suspended under the island's lower rock. Bridges joined them.

Red lights burned along their roofs. One tower descended farther than the rest and ended in a circular chamber that glowed through its windows like a covered furnace.

“What's that?” Shawna asked.

“Basement with ambition.”

A train moved along a track beneath it. The cars had no windows.

She stopped smiling.

The train entered the glowing chamber. For a moment the windows turned a strange yellow-white. Then every light went out together.

Above us, music began on the school lawn. People laughed. Somebody sent a ribbon of purple fire curling between two towers.

Shawna rested her head against my shoulder.

“Tomorrow,” she said, “I'm finding somebody who'll tell me what that is.”

I looked at the dark place under all our beautiful rooms.

“Tomorrow,” I said, “I'm getting my fucking car back.”

2. My Superpower Was Being That Nigga

The engineering professor cried when he returned my Lamborghini. This nigga had repaired half the greatest machines in the sky, and now he was holding a polishing cloth to his face because my car had made him believe again.

Actual tears. One fell on the hood, and he polished it away with his sleeve before he let himself have the next one.

His name was Professor Atlas Bell. He was forty-six, had four arms, and treated engines like other men treated their firstborn sons. He stood beside the car in the morning sunlight with two hands folded, one holding a clipboard, and the last stroking the repaired fender.

“It was beautiful before,” he told me. “But what you did with it—”

He had to stop.

Tank leaned toward me. “Nigga, you made a man cry with traffic.”

“It wasn't regular traffic.”

“Nigga was crying when we got here.”

“Maybe he started early.”

“No, nigga. Rosa asked that nigga what happened, and he said your suspension.”

I looked at Bell. The professor nodded gravely, like my suspension had died for his sins and risen on the third wheel.

“A magnificent structure,” he said.

Tank pointed at him. “See? Nigga grieving and praising at once.”

“Let that nigga feel his feelings,” I told him. “He brought my car back beautiful.”

Bell had restored the dark blue paint. The police lights were now hidden beneath the front edge, so the car looked like pure money until I decided somebody should be nervous. He had reinforced the suspension for campus roads and fitted the wheels with the academy's standard field receivers. That meant the Lamborghini could travel along the marked sky lanes like the other vehicles. It did not mean it could fly wherever I wanted.

He explained that last part three times.

I heard him all three times. I just refused to make my face less hopeful.

Shawna came down the steps in a white tracksuit with my name embroidered over her heart. Rosa wore red. Mercedes wore green leather. Porsche had found a silver jumpsuit and a pair of boots that made a nearby man forget how stairs worked.

“We going to your test,” Shawna said.

“What test?”

Victor emerged from the archway behind her.

“Power placement.”

He said it like an execution date.

“I already got a parking place,” I told him.

“Let's see how you perform without a car.”

“Nigga, ask my wife.”

Shawna slapped my chest and started laughing. Victor looked up at the sky as if requesting a different assignment from God.

The placement hall was bigger inside than outside. It had retractable walls, a floor divided into colored circles, and a spectator gallery rising around all four sides. Students filled the seats. Word of the train rescue had apparently traveled faster than the train was supposed to. Half the crowd wore little gold paper badges somebody had made overnight.

One woman held a sign reading ARREST ME, CAPTAIN.

Shawna saw it.

The woman slowly turned it around.

Storm stood in the center beside a stone pillar holding a blue crystal. The crystal wasn't the size of a jewel. It was the size of a man's head, cut into an uneven heart, and its light pulsed down through the pillar into the floor.

“The Heart of the Sky,” she said as we approached. “It anchors the academy's central field. Today you will be assessed around a fractional projection of its output.”

I looked at the thing.

“Whole school running off one diamond?”

“A power core. It amplifies gifts; it doesn't create them.”

Marcellus bent toward the crystal. He did not touch it. His expression narrowed.

“Interesting cut.”

Voss stood near the gallery stairs. “Please keep your distance, Mr. Vale.”

Marcellus straightened. “I was admiring it.”

“Of course.”

Storm clapped once. The first wall folded back, revealing a corridor full of swinging steel blocks. Beyond it stood three platforms and a bell suspended over a pool.

“Movement,” she said. “Judgment. Control. Rescue. We rank useful outcomes, not destruction.”

Tank looked at the steel blocks. “Good. Because some nigga absolutely about to destroy something.”

Victor went first.

I gave him that much: the man was magnificent when he stopped talking.

He turned into a streak of blue light, passed between the blocks, landed on the first platform, and sent a bolt into a target above the second. A bridge unfolded. He crossed it, caught a weighted rescue dummy as it fell, and reached the bell in twenty-three seconds.

The crowd roared.

He set the dummy down carefully. Looked straight at me. Rang the bell once more.

I nodded.

“Clean.”

He seemed annoyed I meant it.

A woman named Petra Stone went next. Twenty-nine, broad shoulders, calm eyes. She could turn her skin into white marble. She carried the rescue dummy through a steel block instead of around it. Her time was slower. The steel block's prospects were considerably worse.

Mercedes stood up clapping.

“Girl, yes!”

Petra looked up, spotted her, and nearly dropped the dummy.

Porsche leaned against the rail. “You already choosing?”

“I'm appreciating strength.”

“You appreciate everybody with shoulders.”

“Only if they use them right.”

Then Storm said my name.

The entire gallery stood.

Nigga, I had not done anything in this room yet.

I took off my jacket and gave it to Shawna. She smoothed my collar with both hands.

“Come back with all your teeth.”

“Baby, that's the minimum.”

At the starting line, a faculty member asked whether I required a special condition.

“Such as?”

“Reduced gravity. Protective barrier. A powered escort.”

“Some music.”

He blinked.

Rosa began tapping the railing.

Tank joined her. Then Porsche. Then half the room. A big rolling beat traveled through the hall. My people had turned a superhero examination into the entrance to my own heavyweight championship.

Storm lifted her hand.

The blocks began swinging.

I ran.

First block left. Second block right. A narrow opening appeared between them, and I went through sideways with my shoulder almost kissing steel. The third descended straight at my head. I dropped under it, slid across the floor, and came up laughing because a nigga knows when his body has decided to make him famous.

The first platform was farther than it looked.

I jumped anyway.

My fingers caught the edge. I pulled myself up, rolled under a sweeping bar, and saw the target Victor had struck with lightning.

I had no lightning.

I had shoes.

I took one off and threw it.

The shoe hit the center of the target.

The bridge unfolded.

Tank shouted so loud I heard him over everybody else.

“Nigga used a loafer!”

I crossed in one shoe, caught the falling dummy over my shoulder, and took the last platform in three strides. The bell hung above the pool. Victor had flown to it. Petra had jumped from the edge.

I threw the dummy onto the safe pad, caught its rebound with my knee, and used the spring in the pad to launch myself up the pillar beside the bell.

My hand struck gold.

The sound filled the room.

Twenty-two seconds.

I landed in the pool.

Nobody's masterpiece is dry all the way through.

When I surfaced, Storm was smiling. The faculty member stared at his clock. Victor stared at my shoe, which was slowly sliding off the target.

Shawna had both hands over her head.

“That's my fucking man!”

I climbed out dripping. Walked to Victor. Held out my hand.

He looked at it.

“You used the rescue dummy as a springboard.”

“I rescued it first.”

“That's not—”

Storm glanced at the safe pad. “The dummy remained entirely within the designated safety zone.”

Victor shook my hand.

Hard.

I shook it back.

Harder.

We both smiled like niggas deciding whether a friendship ought to begin with a fight.

The next test involved doors. Behind one stood a fire. Behind another, a trapped volunteer. Behind a third, a man pretending to be an attacker. You had to choose in six seconds using information flashed on a screen.

I looked at the screen.

Then I looked at the doors.

Then I walked up to the third door and knocked.

The volunteer attacker opened it out of surprise.

I took his padded weapon.

“You under arrest.”

The gallery exploded.

He said, “But the scenario—”

“Nigga, you armed behind a door while people dying in the next room. Come carry something.”

I put him to work. Together we carried the trapped volunteer through the safe corridor while Petra smothered the training fire with a wall of stone. The faculty member tried to say assistance wasn't part of the test.

Storm asked whether real disasters prohibited asking another adult for help.

He looked at his clipboard and discovered a deep interest in the lower half of it.

By lunch they had awarded me first place in movement, judgment, improvisation, and something called command presence.

Command presence was when other niggas did what you said because it sounded like the part of the day they should survive.

I had been practicing that since Vegas.

Then the real attacker came through the ceiling.

He wore a black flight harness and a mirrored mask. Three more followed him through the skylight. They fell in a line, landing around the crystal pillar with weapons already raised.

The first shot shattered a gallery lamp.

Screams replaced applause.

Victor moved toward the pillar. One of the attackers threw a dark metal hoop. It struck his chest and opened around him, pinning his arms to his sides. His lightning flared once, then guttered.

Storm lifted her hand.

The man in the mirrored mask held up a small device with a red light.

“Wind,” he said, “and the south gallery falls.”

Beneath the south seats, red lights blinked.

Shawna was in the south gallery.

So was everybody I loved.

I felt the whole room go narrow.

The man saw my badge.

“Sit down, officer.”

I looked at him.

Nigga had chosen the wrong profession to disrespect in front of my wife.

“What's your name?” I asked.

“Your last warning.”

“Your mama named you terribly.”

His weapon moved toward me.

My shoe hit his mask.

The same shoe. I had retrieved it between tests. A good object can have more than one destiny.

He stumbled. I crossed the space between us and hit him with every grievance I had about being wet in public. The red device flew from his hand. Porsche caught it over the gallery rail.

She stared at the blinking light.

“Do I press it?”

“Fuck no!” four of us shouted.

She tucked it into her purse. “Then nobody else getting it.”

The room erupted.

Petra stepped in front of the gallery stairs and turned to marble as gunfire struck her shoulders. Mercedes dragged two frozen students down behind the seats. Tank came over the railing like a refrigerator deciding it had wings. He landed on one attacker, picked him up by his harness, and introduced him to the training pool.

Rosa kept people moving. Shawna had my jacket. My gun was inside it.

She threw the jacket.

I caught it against my chest as the masked man recovered. He lunged. I swung the whole jacket into his face, pulled the gun free, and brought the fight to a clear disagreement he could understand.

“Down.”

He looked at the gun.

Looked at me.

Went down.

At the pillar, another attacker struck the crystal with a forked black instrument. Blue light cracked through the room. The floor tilted. Students slid against the gallery rail.

The crystal split down its center.

Instead of a blaze, it gave a thin, ugly flicker.

Marcellus saw it.

So did Storm.

Their faces told me different things about the same bad discovery.

The attacker cursed and tried again. Victor, trapped in the hoop, slammed himself sideways into the man's knees. Both fell. The forked instrument skidded toward the pool.

I kicked it away before anybody could reach it.

Tank emerged from the water holding his attacker by the collar. "This nigga allergic to drowning. Thought everybody should know."

Storm's hands flashed.

With the red device safely inside Porsche's purse, the dean stopped being patient.

Wind tore the weapons out of the attackers' hands. A pressure wave lifted all four men and pinned them against the far wall. Their harnesses rattled. The mirrored mask broke in two.

Underneath was a lean man with a burned eyebrow and a grin too quick for the situation.

He looked at me.

“You're better than the picture.”

“And you worse than your introduction.”

Voss arrived through the side doors with six guards. He took in the smashed skylight, the fractured crystal, the attackers pinned to the wall. His jaw tightened before the rest of his face followed.

“Finn Cinder,” he said to the unmasked man.

Finn's grin faded.

“Chancellor.”

I caught that.

Storm caught it too.

“You know him?” she asked.

“A notorious sky-lane criminal.”

“Nigga,” I said, “he knew you back.”

Voss turned to me. “My position attracts enemies.”

“Apparently they know which door to use.”

His guards took the men from Storm's wind. Finn went quietly, but as he passed Victor he looked at the hoop around the man's arms and almost smiled again.

Almost.

I noticed almos^ts for a living.

Once they were gone, Bell hurried to the pillar with two assistants. The broken crystal had gone gray. Storm stood over it without speaking.

Marcellus touched my elbow.

“That isn’t the core she described.”

“You sure?”

“Aiden, I have spent most of my life distinguishing beautiful things from expensive lies.”

Across the hall, Victor struggled with the hoop. Every time he summoned electricity, its dark surface drank the light. He was trying to make it look like he had chosen to stand there with his elbows glued to his ribs.

I went over.

“Hold still.”

“I have it.”

“You got it around you. Different accomplishment.”

He stopped moving. Bell took one look, muttered something furious about stolen equipment, and pressed the release concealed under its rim. The hoop opened.

Victor flexed his arms.

“Thank you.”

It came out like a little rock he had been forced to swallow backward.

“Anytime.”

“You still cheated on the course.”

“Nigga, you turned into lightning. I threw footwear.”

For the first time, he laughed.

Just briefly. But I saw the man hiding behind all that first-place anger, and the man seemed like somebody I could eventually drink with.

Shawna reached me. She ran her hands over my chest, checking what bullets had failed to do. Then she held my face and looked at me with those dark, bright eyes.

“You did all that with one shoe on.”

I looked down.

Still one shoe.

The other lay beside the shattered mask in a little patch of sunlight.

“Baby, imagine if I had dressed properly.”

She started laughing, and the laugh broke the last of the fear in my ribs.

The gallery began chanting my name.

Aiden. Aiden. Aiden.

Somebody added Captain. Somebody added King. Elias, the man from the train, stood at the front with both fists in the air as if we had been brothers since birth.

Storm raised her voice over them.

“Today's assessment is concluded.”

Victor looked at her. “The final rankings?”

She gestured at the room: forty safe students, four captured gunmen, one ruined crystal, my wife holding my face like I was the prize the academy should have been competing for.

“Do you require them read aloud?”

He considered that.

Then he stepped aside and let me pick up my shoe.

On our way out, Porsche handed me the red device from her purse.

“You owe me.”

“For saving the gallery?”

“For not pressing a button. You know how hard that is when it looks important?”

I took it. The light had stopped blinking.

On the back, beneath a scrape in the black paint, was a tiny silver crest.

A narrow tower. A downward-pointing wing.

The same crest Voss's guards wore on their shoulders.

I closed my hand around it before anybody else saw.

“Come on,” I said to my people. “Let's go find lunch.”

Tank studied my face.

“And after lunch?”

I looked toward the doors through which the chancellor had taken my prisoners.

“After lunch, nigga, I'm finding out who think this school belong to him.”

Lunch took place on a terrace where the tables floated six inches off the ground. I asked the waiter why. He said atmosphere. I told him we already had plenty. He laughed until he realized I meant the table should stop drifting while I tried to cut my steak.

Victor joined us uninvited, which I considered progress. He sat opposite Tank and ordered enough food for three men. Petra came with Mercedes. Porsche immediately asked whether Petra had any brothers, sisters, cousins, or enemies with similar shoulders.

Shawna took my hand beneath the table.

“You really don't feel any different?” she asked.

“From what?”

“The crystal. The test. All this.”

I turned my hand palm up. There were fresh bandages over yesterday's cuts. The fingers still belonged to a nigga who had to open his own jars.

“Same me.”

Victor leaned forward. “That makes what you did worse.”

“Worse?”

“More difficult to accept.”

Tank laughed into his drink.

“At least you honest now.”

A pair of uniformed campus officers approached our table. Both were older than me. One had a neatly trimmed gray beard; the other could apparently see through walls because she looked toward the kitchen and said our second round was coming.

The bearded officer saluted.

“Captain. Commander Orrin Pike. Campus patrol.”

“Sit down, Commander.”

“I'd be honored.”

He sat so fast Victor had to move his plate.

Pike explained that the chancellor maintained a separate security force for the lower facilities. Campus patrol could handle the sky

lanes, the shops, and the residential towers. Anything below the island's foundation required Voss's approval.

“What lower facilities?” Shawna asked.

Pike looked at Storm's tower before answering.

“A detention and research annex. Established before the dean's appointment.”

“Detention for who?”

“People whose powers present unusual risks.”

“Charged with what?” I asked.

He shifted in his chair.

There it was.

Not proof. Not even half of proof. But enough for lunch to become something I ate while being angry.

The second officer put a folded slip beside my plate. She kept her voice low.

“The four men from your hall never reached our cells.”

Victor stopped cutting his steak.

I unfolded the slip. A patrol camera had captured Finn Cinder boarding a black car under his own power. No cuffs. Voss's guard held the door for him.

Pike looked ashamed enough to make me trust him a little.

“I thought you should know.”

I put the picture in my pocket.

“Commander, nigga, you just earned yourself a very interesting afternoon.”

3. You Can't Outrun a Nigga with a Siren

Commander Pike offered me a patrol car. A regular patrol car. Nigga had watched me turn a Lamborghini into a rescue platform and decided what I needed next was a sedan with enough trunk space for cones.

I looked out his window at my Lamborghini waiting below. He looked too.

“That was a stupid offer,” he said.

“Not stupid. Hopeful.”

Tank looked at the patrol car through the window. “That nigga got cloth seats.”

Pike cleared his throat. “They're durable.”

“Nigga, so is my aunt's couch. I ain't chasing nobody in it.”

“Your aunt got a very aggressive couch,” I reminded him.

“That's different. That nigga been through things.”

Pike looked between us, trying to decide whether he had hired two idiots or discovered a form of policing his academy had failed to teach. Then he glanced at my gold badge and chose faith.

Campus patrol occupied a stone building between a bakery and a store selling capes. The bakery smelled better than any police station I had visited. The cape store had a line outside. People apparently bought new identities the way niggas in Vegas bought belts.

Pike spread a map over his desk. The academy occupied the largest island. Six smaller districts floated around it, joined by marked lanes sustained by the school's field. If you stayed on those lanes with the right receivers, your car could drive through open air. Leave the field and gravity remembered your ass immediately.

The largest satellite was called the Crown District. Hotels, restaurants, showrooms, a marina for airships, and the Cloud Nine casino. Finn Cinder's car had headed there after leaving the academy.

"Can your people follow him?" I asked.

"They can. He knows our cars."

I turned my badge over in my hand.

"Then let's introduce him to mine."

Tank drove with me. Victor asked to come, and I told him there was no third seat.

"I can fly."

"Nigga, why you asking for a ride?"

He looked at Pike. Pike found a fascinating place on his map to point at until Victor left.

Shawna had plans of her own. The dean had invited her and Rosa to rehearse with the academy's evening orchestra. My wife had heard “orchestra” and “doors ordinarily locked to visitors” in the same sentence and decided music deserved her immediate attention.

Mercedes went with Petra to see the lower training gardens. Porsche announced she was going shopping. She said it with such innocence I gave her a second look.

“What?” she asked.

“Nothing.”

“Exactly. Mind your police business.”

That woman could sell rain to the clouds and make them apologize for being dry.

We left the patrol station under a bright afternoon sun. The Lamborghini rolled between white pillars and onto the first sky lane. Blue strips of light ran beneath the tires. Beyond either side was nothing but air.

Tank stared out his window.

“I miss curbs.”

“You used to hit every curb in Vegas.”

“That's how I knew they was there.”

Ahead of us the Crown District glittered. A red sports car passed on the other side of the lane, driven by a man with gold skin and a woman wearing a hat shaped like a small thunderstorm. Rain fell exclusively into her champagne glass.

Tank watched them go.

“Rosa gonna want that.”

“The hat?”

“The champagne weather.”

We spotted Finn outside a showroom called ASCENT. He stood between a black coupe and a salesman whose smile looked physically painful. Two guards waited near the door. None wore masks now. Finn had a strip of tape over the eyebrow I had helped him lose.

I parked across the road.

He saw the Lamborghini before he saw me.

That gave him half a second to enjoy life.

Then I stepped out.

“Finn.”

His face changed.

The salesman looked relieved someone else had become his problem.

“Captain,” Finn said. “We keep meeting.”

“That's because niggas keep letting you go.”

He looked up. Victor floated above the showroom roof, arms folded, electricity crawling over his shoulders.

Finn smiled at him.

“You get your bracelet off?”

Victor descended six feet.

I raised a hand.

“I got this.”

Finn's guards shifted.

Tank leaned against the Lamborghini and opened his jacket just enough for them to understand the local temperature.

“Y'all can keep standing,” he said. “Just stand peaceful.”

I approached Finn. “Who paid you to hit the hall?”

“You're assuming money.”

“Nigga, your shoes cost six thousand dollars and you look allergic to principles. I'm assuming correctly.”

The salesman made a little noise that might have been laughter and immediately pretended to cough.

Finn's eyes went flat.

“You don't know the city you're in.”

“Then show me.”

He did.

The black coupe leaped backward through the showroom window.

Glass burst into the street. Finn dove through the open passenger door as the car spun. One guard threw a smoke sphere. Tank caught it, looked offended, and threw it back.

The sphere burst under the man's feet.

His first cough sounded like regret.

The coupe shot onto the sky lane.

I was in the Lamborghini before the broken glass finished falling.

Tank landed beside me.

“Nigga, we arresting him or racing him?”

“He picking the format.”

I hit the siren.

Blue lights lit the clouds beneath us.

The Lamborghini lunged forward. Finn's car swerved around a delivery van and accelerated toward the Crown District's outer loop. I followed. The road curved around a hotel whose swimming pool hung over open air. People at the pool stood up when we passed. A woman waved. Her companion stared at the police lights and spilled an entire tray of drinks into his own lap.

Victor flew above us, keeping pace.

“He has two more vehicles joining,” he said through the patrol radio Pike had given me.

“Where?”

Two silver cars came out of a side lane.

“There.”

“Useful timing, nigga.”

The first silver car struck my rear quarter. The Lamborghini slid toward the lane's luminous edge. For one second Tank's window showed nothing below us at all.

He turned to me very calmly.

“Aiden.”

“I know.”

I steered into the slide, let the rear swing, and put us back between the blue strips. The silver car tried again. This time I braked. It shot past, clipped Finn's coupe, and bounced toward the outer barrier.

Victor caught it with a web of crackling light.

The driver stared through his windshield at the man holding his car over the clouds.

Victor smiled without warmth.

“Wait here.”

He set the car on a maintenance bay and welded its doors shut with a bright hiss. It wasn't going anywhere until somebody with tools and a better attitude arrived.

The second silver car pulled alongside us. A gun came through its window.

Tank leaned back as a shot shattered my mirror.

“Nigga shot the mirror.”

“I saw.”

“That's how we see other niggas.”

He returned fire. The attacking car veered off, sparks skipping from its door. I drove between it and a tourist coach full of adults in matching yellow jackets. The coach passengers flattened themselves against the opposite windows.

One of them gave me a thumbs-up.

I gave it back.

Customer service did not stop because somebody was trying to kill me.

Finn headed for a spiral lane climbing around a hotel tower. I followed him up. Faster. The engine climbed toward its beautiful, furious scream. Wind punched through the broken mirror housing. Tank laughed the way he always laughed when terror finally realized it had come to the wrong man.

We burst onto the hotel's roof.

A wedding reception was taking place there.

White chairs. Gold glasses. A fountain full of flowers. Two adult grooms stood beneath an arch, both in immaculate suits, both looking at Finn's car as it tore between their guests.

He knocked over the cake.

I will admit that made it personal in a new way.

“Hold tight.”

“Nigga, to what?”

I drove onto the narrow stone rim around the fountain. The Lamborghini rose sideways. Water flashed beneath Tank's door. We passed the fallen cake on two wheels, cleared a table, and landed in front of the arch.

Both grooms stared.

“Congratulations,” I shouted.

Then we were gone.

Behind us the wedding guests began cheering.

Ahead, Finn took the departure ramp toward the smaller northern island. The black coupe's rear lights flickered. Something unfolded from its sides: short angular wings, illegal enough that the patrol radio immediately began shouting about them.

“He's leaving the lane,” Pike warned.

Finn's car lifted.

My car did not have wings.

Bell had been very clear about that.

Tank turned his head slowly toward me.

“Remember what the four-arm nigga said.”

“I remember.”

“You got the remembering face and the doing-it-anyway face.
Right now they fighting.”

I watched the coupe rise over the northern island's cliff. Beneath it a service lane curved through the rock, then emerged on the far side beside a loading platform.

I took the service lane.

Darkness swallowed us. The engine thundered against stone.
Ahead, daylight shrank to a small white rectangle.

Tank braced both feet.

We came out under Finn's car.

Not flying. Driving up the last steep piece of lane at exactly the moment he drifted over it.

The Lamborghini's roof struck the underside of his wing.

The wing snapped backward.

The black coupe rolled, skidded across the loading platform, and hit a stack of empty crates with a crash that sent wood flying all the way to a restaurant balcony.

I stopped beside it.

The Lamborghini's hood smoked.

Tank stared at me.

“Nigga.”

“What?”

“You jumped a car without jumping your car.”

“Efficient.”

He began laughing so hard he had to lean against the door before he got out.

Finn crawled from the coupe. His coat was torn. His expensive shoes were covered in champagne-colored dust from somebody's broken shipment. He looked at my car with something dangerously close to reverence.

“You cannot be human.”

I showed him the badge.

“I'm employed.”

He reached toward his belt.

Tank drew.

Finn stopped reaching.

Then the loading platform's doors opened behind him.

Voss's guards stepped out.

Six of them. Weapons lowered but ready. At their center stood a woman with close-cropped red hair and a black uniform stitched with the downward wing. She looked about forty. Her voice could have broken a glass without raising its volume.

“This is restricted academy property.”

“Good,” I said. “Then you'll have cameras.”

“Hand over the prisoner.”

“Funny. That's how this morning started.”

Victor landed beside me. Blue light ran along his fingers. The guards looked at him and adjusted their expectations.

“Captain Aiden made this arrest,” Victor said.

The woman studied him.

“Mr. Voltage. Your scholarship review is next week.”

He went still.

I felt it: the invisible leash she had expected to tighten around his throat.

I stepped in front of him.

“Nigga, I didn't ask about his scholarship.”

She looked back at me.

“Do you understand where you are?”

“A loading platform with six guns and too much attitude.”

Pike's patrol cars arrived behind us. Eight officers got out. The gray-bearded commander walked to my side and held out a pair of cuffs.

I put them on Finn myself.

For the first time all afternoon, nobody had a clever thing to say.

We left with the prisoner.

The woman watched until the sky lane curved away.

Finn sat in the back of Pike's car. I followed in the battered Lamborghini with Victor overhead. Tank kept turning around to make sure no black uniforms had developed an urgent need to explain themselves with bullets.

My phone rang.

Shawna.

“Baby, I might have scratched the car,” I said.

“I know. Your wedding stunt already on six phones in this room.”

“They happy?”

“One groom wants you to sign his jacket.”

“Tell him yes.”

Her voice lowered.

“Aiden. We found something.”

I listened.

She and Rosa had been rehearsing in the old music hall. While the orchestra took a break, Rosa heard a voice coming through a brass ventilation grille beneath the stage. Not talking. Singing. The same four lines over and over, in a woman's tired but steady voice.

Shawna knelt beside the grille and sang the next line.

The voice stopped.

Then somebody said, very clearly, "Are you above us?"

My grip tightened on the wheel.

Shawna asked who was there.

The woman said her name was Lena March. Thirty-two. A singer who could carry her voice through solid matter if she knew where to aim it. She had been in the lower annex for five months. Her release date changed every time she reached it.

"She says there are people down there who aren't on any student list," Shawna told me. "She says they take them through a round door, and some come back old. Some don't come back at all."

Ahead of me Finn looked through the rear window of Pike's car.

Our eyes met.

The little grin was gone.

"What else?" I asked.

“She heard the name Winter Engine. And there's a doctor down there. Reiss. He told her if she ever found somebody outside, she had to say the real heart isn't in the hall.”

I looked up at the academy floating above the sunlit clouds.

“Baby, stay with Rosa. Tell Storm only. Nobody in black.”

“I'm not leaving that woman singing into a wall.”

“I know.”

“You know what that means?”

“Means we got plans tonight.”

Her breath softened in my ear.

“Come back first.”

“Always.”

When we reached the station, Finn asked to speak to me without Voss's people present. He sat in a cell with ordinary iron bars, which seemed almost embarrassingly old-fashioned after everything we had driven through.

I stood outside with Pike and Victor.

Finn rested his elbows on his knees.

“You think the bottom of this school is the bottom,” he said.

“Explain.”

He looked at the ceiling.

“There's a door under the prison. It doesn't open into another room.”

Victor's face tightened.

“Where does it open?”

Finn swallowed.

“Another year.”

The bakery next door rang its little bell. Somebody laughed out on the sidewalk. Through Pike's window I could see my car shining in the sun, every dent earned in front of witnesses.

For a moment those ordinary sounds felt far away.

Then I leaned toward the bars.

“Nigga,” I said, “you better start at the beginning.”

He began with a car, which was the first sensible thing the man had done all day.

Three months earlier, Voss's red-haired security commander had hired him to transport a sealed engine housing from the Crown District to the lower annex. Her name was Commander Sable. She paid well, asked no questions about his history, and made it clear she expected the same courtesy. Finn had driven the housing down the service ramp at midnight and waited while two technicians unloaded it beside a circular metal frame.

“The room smelled like cold iron,” he said. “There were rails going straight through the circle. Not our kind of rails. Old ones. And a clock over it with three hands.”

Victor folded his arms.

“A choral aperture.”

Finn looked at him. “Whatever the fuck you call it, there was a field on the other side. Real grass. A little station building. Snow on the roof. I could feel cold coming through.”

“You went through?” I asked.

“No. A man came out.”

He rubbed his wrists where the cuffs had been.

The man had worn a long military coat and carried a leather case. Two others followed him, pushing a cart with a covered shape on it. Finn thought it was equipment until the covering moved. He heard a person beneath it ask for water. Sable told him to face the wall.

He faced it.

When he turned around, the strangers were gone. The cart remained. A dark stain spread across its blanket. Not blood, Finn insisted; something like blue ink that glowed on the edges.

“They'd taken somebody's power too far,” Victor said quietly.

Finn wouldn't meet his eyes.

I watched the man's face. The swagger kept trying to come back, finding no place to stand, and falling away again.

“And you went back to work for them.”

“I saw a thing I didn't understand. I've seen a lot of things I didn't understand.”

“You understood water.”

He went silent.

I let him sit in that silence. I didn't need a speech from him. I needed the part he hadn't yet decided to tell us.

Eventually he looked at Pike.

“There's a race tonight. The Sundown Circuit. Sable moves the lower-annex manifests during the race because half your patrol is managing the spectators. She carries them herself, in a silver case. If you want names, that case has names.”

Victor stared at him.

“The race was scheduled last month.”

“Yeah. And I'm telling you why your chancellor suddenly agreed to sponsor it.”

I looked at Pike. He had already reached for his phone.

“No,” I said. “We tell Storm in person.”

Pike stopped.

“And your next meal,” I told Finn, “comes after you give the commander every route you remember. Nobody asking you to be beautiful. Just useful.”

Outside, late afternoon had softened the towers to gold. Victor walked with me toward the Lamborghini without saying anything. He stopped by the repaired front fender and put his hand on it as if touching an animal he hadn't decided whether to trust.

“I'm entered in that race,” he said.

“You drive?”

“Very well.”

I waited.

He looked at me. “I know how that sounded.”

“Nigga, I'm letting you enjoy it.”

He almost smiled.

“There's another entry available. Bell prepared a demonstration car. It needs a driver.”

I glanced at my Lamborghini, then up at the circuit winding around the highest towers. The setting sun caught the lanes and turned them into long strips of fire.

Somewhere under us a woman was singing because it was the only way she could reach the world.

“Tell Bell I got a car,” I said. “Tell him what I need is a number.”

Victor nodded once.

“Which number?”

I looked at him until the answer arrived in his face.

“One,” he said.

“See, nigga? We learning together.”

4. First Place Was Wherever I Parked

Bell put the number one on my door in gold. Tank stood beside him with his arms folded, supervising a nigga with four hands like the fifth hand was going to be his if that number leaned.

He asked whether I preferred it centered.

“Nigga, I prefer it accurate.”

“It is your entry number,” Bell said.

Tank shook his head. “That’s this nigga exit number too.”

“Placements remain to be determined.”

“Nigga, by who?”

Bell looked at me. I looked at the gold one. The professor sighed with the exhaustion of a man who knew engineering could explain a great many things and none of them would help him win this conversation.

He nodded as though I had just taught him something about art and measured the distance from both edges again.

The Sundown Circuit wrapped three times around the academy, crossed a canyon of empty air between two floating islands, passed through the Crown District, and ended on the stadium’s upper terrace. Twelve drivers had entered. Every one of them had powers except me. Their cars glowed, floated, snarled, or

did some combination that made the mechanics back away respectfully.

My Lamborghini looked like a police car had married a bank account and produced a very angry son.

That was enough.

Before the race, we met Storm in her private office. Shawna repeated what Lena had said. Pike showed Finn's release photograph. I put the red device from the hall on the dean's desk.

She turned it over and saw the downward wing.

The room grew colder.

"The lower annex predates my appointment," she said. "Voss claims its most sensitive work is approved by the founding board. He has blocked my access three times."

"Then let's make four different," I said.

"If I strike at him without securing the school's field, he can put every person on this island in danger."

"He already doing that."

She met my eyes.

"Yes."

One honest word. I liked her better for it than all the titles she had.

She knew the circular machine. Years earlier, before Voss became chancellor, a physicist had proposed using the Heart to open a passage into a single branch of the past. The faculty rejected the experiment after a test chamber lost power and came back coated in frost. The project was supposed to be dismantled. Dr. Ilya Reiss, its designer, retired soon afterward.

“Or got retired underneath us,” Tank said.

Storm's hands closed on the arms of her chair.

We agreed on two things. She would keep the academy's main field stable and quietly move her own trusted people into the control tower. We would get Sable's case during the race. Nobody would open a time door because some nigga with a cane had decided ordinary crime lacked imagination.

Shawna listened to every word. Then she put both palms on the desk.

“Lena stays in this conversation. Names on a page won't help her if we forget the woman who got them to us.”

Storm nodded.

“We won't.”

My wife held her gaze until she believed it.

That was why I loved her. I could fill a room. Shawna could make a room answer.

By sunset the stadium was packed. Spectators crowded balconies all along the circuit. Airships hovered outside the lanes, their passengers leaning over rails with drinks in their hands. A huge screen showed the drivers as we approached our cars.

Victor wore blue racing leathers. His vehicle was a low silver machine with three bright rings behind the cockpit. It looked fast standing still. He caught me admiring it and smiled.

“Built around my charge pattern.”

“Nice.”

“It can draw power directly from me.”

“Mine draws power from gas and disrespect.”

He laughed. A real laugh this time.

Then his face went serious.

“Don't leave the marked lane at the canyon.”

“You worried about me?”

“I'm worried I'll win and you'll have an excuse.”

“That's friendship trying to happen, nigga. You should stop fighting it.”

Across the grid, Shawna kissed me beside the car while every screen in the stadium showed us. I had one hand at her waist. Her fingers rested against my neck. The crowd made a sound so loud the starting official stopped talking.

She pulled back smiling.

“Win beautifully.”

“You know any other way?”

“Try coming back without spending another hood.”

Tank handed me my helmet. Rosa tied a red ribbon around his wrist for luck, then tied a blue one around mine because she said two idiots required separate colors.

Mercedes and Porsche were already gone.

Their part of the race did not involve driving.

Sable would watch from Voss's private terrace above the Crown District. She liked expensive company and disliked being bored.

Porsche had spent the afternoon learning both facts from a bartender she tipped more generously than his employer.

Mercedes had secured an invitation by introducing herself as the woman who knew Captain Aiden before the sky discovered him.

That was technically true, and technically was a beautiful country.

The lights above the grid turned red.

Twelve engines rose.

The stadium chanted Victor's name first. He was theirs. He had earned that.

Then my side began.

Aiden. Aiden. Aiden.

Both chants crashed together until the whole place sounded like it was arguing with thunder.

Green.

We launched.

Victor took the lead. A yellow coupe driven by a woman called Sunfire swept behind him. I went third, tight against the lane's inner edge. The first turn rose around the stadium, steep enough to put the sun under my left shoulder. The Lamborghini gripped. I felt every bit of it: wheel, road, engine, the gold number on my door announcing the future before we arrived there.

Sunfire's exhaust flashed bright orange. Heat shimmered over the lane. I couldn't see Victor.

“Nigga,” I said to nobody, “we doing weather already?”

I waited half a breath, found the darker line beneath the shimmer, and drove through it. Her car slid wide. I passed on the inside close enough to see her turn her head in disbelief.

She grinned.

Raised two fingers.

Then tried to take her place back.

I respected that.

The lane dropped toward the canyon. For a second the entire city rose above me. The car felt light. My stomach tried to resign. I

held the wheel steady as the tires crossed onto the narrow field bridge spanning the gap.

Victor was a silver streak ahead.

A green car closed behind me, its driver making little jumps between patches of road. Each jump flashed the air purple. He appeared on my left, vanished, appeared on my right.

“Pick a side, nigga.”

He appeared ahead of me.

I accelerated into the space he had to leave to make the next jump. When he reappeared, he was behind my rear bumper.

The radio erupted with Bell shouting my name.

“You anticipated the recovery interval!”

“Nigga, I anticipated him being annoying!”

We swept into the Crown District at a speed that made windows reflect us after we were already gone.

High above the road, on Voss's terrace, Porsche dropped a champagne glass.

That was all I saw passing beneath her.

Later she told me the rest.

The glass broke near Sable's shoes. Mercedes caught Porsche by the elbow and apologized with the offended elegance of a woman whose evening had been spoiled by somebody else's

clumsiness. Sable stood to avoid the spill. Her silver case remained under her chair.

Porsche bent to pick up the largest piece of glass.

Mercedes asked Sable whether Captain Aiden was really as impressive to the faculty as he had been in Vegas.

Sable answered before she remembered not to.

“More.”

That little word cost her the case.

Porsche slid a matching empty case beneath the chair and passed the real one behind a curtain into Petra's marble hand. Petra carried it down a service stair while pretending a twelve-pound locked box was a clutch purse.

By the time Sable sat again, Mercedes had persuaded her to explain why she enjoyed racing.

“Because it reveals weakness,” Sable said.

“Mm,” Mercedes replied. “Depends who driving.”

At the end of the first lap, Victor led me by three car lengths.

At the end of the second, one.

He was good. Nigga, he was better than good. He took the high turns with a precision that made the car look attached to his thoughts. Blue charge pulsed through the rings behind him. Whenever I closed, he found another little piece of speed.

I started laughing inside my helmet.

Not because he was losing.

Because finally somebody was making me work hard enough to enjoy how good I was.

Then his car screamed.

A bright bolt jumped between the rear rings. The silver body jerked sideways. Victor corrected, but the rings brightened again, feeding on him. I saw his shoulders stiffen through the cockpit glass.

“Victor?”

Static.

“Nigga, talk.”

His voice came thin through the radio.

“The draw won't stop.”

Bell shouted something to the race officials. The warning lights along the lane turned amber.

Victor's car accelerated.

Not because he wanted it to.

The rings pulled harder. Blue light wrapped his whole body. The silver machine shot toward the canyon at a speed it could not survive entering the next turn.

I followed.

Behind me Sunfire slowed. The green car vanished toward a safety bay. The spectators' cheers broke into a different sound.

“Cut your power,” I told Victor.

“It's taking it.”

I heard pain in the last word.

Storm's voice entered the radio. “Aiden, I am coming.”

“Can you reach him before the canyon?”

Silence for half a second.

Enough.

I pressed the Lamborghini harder.

Bell's beautiful engine gave me everything it had.

The distance closed.

Twenty feet.

Ten.

Victor's helmet turned toward me. His face behind the visor looked gray. The man who had wanted to beat me was disappearing inside his own gift.

“Don't hit the rings,” Bell warned. “They're overloaded.”

I brought my front bumper level with Victor's rear wheel.

“Wasn't planning to.”

There was a service split before the canyon, a short lane leading to an emergency terrace. Victor couldn't turn toward it. His car had locked itself into a straight hungry line.

I could turn him.

I struck the silver car low on its side.

The Lamborghini shuddered.

Victor's machine moved six inches.

Not enough.

“Again,” he whispered.

Nigga, I would remember that whisper longer than any trophy.

I hit him again.

Both cars crossed the split together. The terrace rushed toward us. My tires shrieked. Victor's rear rings tore bright scars through the air.

We struck the emergency barrier side by side.

Foam burst upward in a white wall.

My seat belt tried to cut me in half.

Then we stopped.

For one second all I heard was my own breathing.

Then Victor screamed.

I kicked my door open and ran to his car. The cockpit wouldn't release. Blue light poured through every seam. I caught the handle and felt heat bite through my glove.

“Aiden, don't touch the chassis,” Bell shouted.

I had already touched it.

Electricity snapped up my arm. My whole body locked. I fell backward onto the terrace, seeing white.

No new power came into me. No miracle. Just pain and the sharp understanding that a nigga could absolutely die here.

Victor hit the glass from inside.

Once.

Weaker the second time.

I got up.

My left hand shook. I made it hold the heavy emergency hammer mounted beside the terrace rail. Swung with the right.

The glass cracked.

I swung again.

A hole opened.

Victor's eyes found mine.

“Come on, nigga.”

I reached through, caught his shoulder strap, and pulled. He came halfway. The car held the rest of him in its light.

Then a white wind slammed across the terrace.

Storm landed beside me. Her hands spread over the rear rings. Lightning rose out of them and into her arms. She gasped but held it.

“Now.”

I pulled Victor free.

We fell together. The silver car burst behind us, its rings breaking upward in three bright arcs. Storm bent the explosion away from the terrace and sent it flowering over empty sky.

The sound rolled around the city.

Victor lay against me, breathing in hard little pieces.

I took off his helmet.

His eyes opened.

“Did you win?”

I looked back at my Lamborghini. One front corner was buried in foam. The engine was still running.

“Hold that thought.”

Storm stared at me.

“Captain.”

“He stable?”

She looked at Victor, then at the approaching medical team.

“Yes.”

I got back in the car.

Bell made a noise over the radio that might have been a prayer or a mechanical diagnosis. I put the Lamborghini in reverse. Foam peeled away from the hood. The wheel pulled left. I held it straight.

The officials were attempting to suspend the race. The other drivers were already entering the final circuit. Nobody had crossed the line. The track remained open until they could bring every car safely in.

I rejoined at the service split.

In ninth place.

Nigga, ninth was temporary.

I passed two cars before the canyon. Three more through the Crown District. Sunfire saw me in her mirror and laughed so hard I could see her shoulders move. She gave me no space at all.

I found some anyway.

At the last turn I was second.

The green car led.

He jumped forward in a flash of purple.

I drove into the space where he needed to finish.

He reappeared beside me.

We crossed the line together.

The stadium went silent for one impossible heartbeat.

Then the screen showed my front bumper.

Six inches ahead.

First.

I stopped beneath the finish arch. Got out. Took off my helmet.

Shawna reached me before anybody else and jumped into my arms so hard I nearly fell back into the car.

“You beautiful fucking lunatic.”

The whole stadium heard her.

The whole stadium agreed.

Tank stood on the hood with both fists up, yelling my name.

Rosa danced beside the car. Porsche arrived carrying the silver case, and Mercedes kissed it like a baby she had stolen for a noble cause.

Victor came down the medical ramp leaning on a medic.

He stopped in front of me.

For a second I thought he might cry.

Instead he took my hand, lifted it over both our heads, and turned us toward the crowd.

“The best driver in the sky,” he shouted.

That was generous.

It was also geographically cautious.

I let him have it.

Above us, in his private box, Voss did not clap.

Beside him, Sable opened the empty case.

Even from the track, nigga, I could see the evening leave her face.

The trophy was four feet tall.

They tried handing it to me while Shawna was still in my arms. I looked at the trophy. Looked at my wife. The official looked at both and wisely gave the trophy to Tank.

“This nigga won a building,” Tank said.

“It's a sculpture,” the official told him.

“Nigga, it got windows.”

“Decorative panels.”

Tank turned the thing around. Somewhere inside it a little gold car circled a track of blue glass.

“Aiden, this nigga won a building with a nigga driving inside.”

I put Shawna down long enough to admire it. The tiny car crossed a tiny finish line. Tiny lights flashed.

“Make sure the little nigga get first too,” I said.

The official assured me it was designed that way.

“Good design.”

Sunfire reached us laughing. Up close she was a brown-skinned woman of thirty-one with orange curls and a small burn on her racing glove. She slapped my shoulder, looked at the Lamborghini, and shook her head.

“You left the race. Saved that man. Came back and beat all our asses.”

“Busy evening.”

“No. A busy evening is dinner and a movie. This nigga took a rescue break from winning.”

Victor stood beside me, pale but upright. “I was the break.”

“You were the reason,” I told him.

He stopped smiling.

Only for a second. But the words went somewhere in him that the trophy didn't reach in me.

“I'd have done the same,” he said.

“I know.”

I did know by then. He had been proud before he met me. Nothing wrong with that. A nigga with no pride would never have stayed in that broken train's sky long enough for me to get there. I wasn't interested in shrinking him so I could look tall. I was already tall enough to make people reconsider architecture. Bell arrived with all four hands shaking.

“I need the car.”

“You just had the car.”

“I need to understand what you did to it.”

Tank pointed at me. “This nigga happened to it.”

Bell touched the hood. The Lamborghini ticked softly, as if agreeing it had been through an emotional experience.

Then the dean joined us. She embraced Victor first. He seemed surprised by how tightly she held him. When she let go, she took my unburned hand in both of hers.

“You brought him back.”

“He still owed me a fair race.”

“You brought him back,” she repeated.

I nodded. That time I let the joke wait.

Later, in our tower, Marcellus opened Sable's case while Tank stood guard at the door. It contained paper manifests, a black access seal, and three photographs held together with a blue ribbon.

The first photograph showed the lower prison.

The second showed the circular door.

The third showed a snow-covered station beneath a sky with no floating islands in it. Men in military coats stood beside a freight wagon. On the back, in neat black writing, somebody had put a date.

February 1944.

Shawna turned the photograph over again.

“Aiden.”

“I see it.”

Victor leaned closer. He had stopped being a rival so completely that I barely noticed when it happened. He was just one more man in the room whose face hardened because somebody else was being hurt.

Marcellus unfolded a manifest. Names. Ages. Powers where powers existed. Blank spaces where they didn't.

“They aren't only taking gifted people,” he said.

Outside our window, fireworks celebrated my victory over the clouds.

Inside, Shawna counted the names with her finger, carefully, as if refusing to let a single one of them disappear between lines.

5. The Party Was in My Honor, So the Gunfight Was Too

By eight the next night, three women had asked Shawna whether she shared.

By eight-oh-four, all three understood mathematics differently.

“One husband,” she told them. “One wife. Zero confusion.”

I stood beside her holding two drinks and trying not to smile too much. A nigga could be proud without making his own evening harder.

The tallest woman looked me up and down. She had silver eyes, a black evening dress, and the power to make all the candles near her lean in her direction. She was thirty-three and clearly used to rooms cooperating.

“I only asked,” she said.

Shawna smiled.

“And now you educated.”

Tank turned away before the laugh came out. Rosa hit his chest with her little purse, which only made him laugh harder.

We were at Cloud Nine for the race champion's banquet. The casino floated a short distance beyond the Crown District, joined by a broad blue lane and two narrow service bridges. Its

windows curved around a central ballroom. Above the roof, an enormous glass moon rotated inside a ring of golden clouds.

Some rich nigga had looked at the real sky and decided it needed a ceiling ornament.

For once, it wasn't me.

The invitation came from Madame Afterglow. Her real name was Eveline Dusk, thirty-seven, and her gift made light linger in places after she left them. She wore gold like it had recently apologized. Every movement left a faint shining echo behind her, so when she crossed the ballroom you could admire her arrival three separate times.

“Captain Aiden,” she said, taking both my hands. “My casino has hosted princes, world champions, and men who swear they own the night.”

“Busy place.”

“None of them arrived with your reputation.”

Tank leaned toward Rosa. “This nigga reputation had to take the earlier car.”

“Needed more seats,” Rosa said.

Afterglow laughed without looking away from me. Shawna stepped beside my shoulder, and the golden woman turned her attention just as warmly.

“And you must be the reason he comes home.”

“He better,” Shawna said.

“I like her,” Afterglow told me.

“That's excellent judgment.”

The ballroom applauded when we entered. Not a polite little ripple. Chairs moved. People stood. The orchestra changed songs in the middle of a note because the conductor saw me and apparently believed timing was something lesser men worried about.

A huge picture of my Lamborghini hung behind the stage.

Under it, in gold, they had written THE MAN WHO CAUGHT LIGHTNING.

Victor stared at it.

“That would be me.”

“Nigga, you the lightning,” Tank told him. “Keep up.”

Victor considered the picture. Then he looked at me.

“Fair.”

He had recovered enough to attend, though Dr. Vega had forbidden him to use his powers until morning. He wore a dark suit and no emblem. Without the uniform, he looked younger and less determined to win an argument nobody else knew was happening.

Petra arrived with Mercedes. Both wore black. Porsche had a young man named Leon on her arm, twenty-six, whose power let him split into three versions of himself for about a minute.

Tank watched all three Leons help Porsche with her chair.

“Nigga cheating at manners.”

Porsche looked delighted. “Finally, enough man for my luggage.”

A waiter brought a silver bowl containing folded cards. Afterglow tapped her glass.

“Our little tradition,” she said. “A guest draws a name, and that guest receives a favor from the champion.”

Shawna's fork stopped.

“What kind of favor?”

“Usually a dance.”

“Then that tradition just got shorter.”

The waiter froze with the bowl halfway over our table. Nigga looked at my wife like she had just canceled the moon.

Afterglow laughed. “A song, then. Or a toast. Something innocent.”

Marcellus reached into the bowl.

“You ain't even competing,” Tank said.

“I am curious.”

He unfolded a card.

It said AIDEN.

He drew another.

AIDEN.

He looked into the bowl. Then he tipped the whole thing onto the table.

My name fell everywhere. Aiden in the breadbasket. Aiden beside the butter. One little Aiden landed directly in Victor's wine.

Victor lifted his glass and watched the card sink.

“Even the fucking refreshments.”

“Who wrote these?” Shawna asked.

The waiter swallowed.

“Several departments participated.”

“Nigga, the kitchen wanted a dance?” Tank asked.

“The kitchen wanted him to taste the soup.”

I picked up a card. A heart had been drawn around my name. Underneath it somebody had written PLEASE SAY IT NEEDS MORE SALT. HE WON'T LISTEN TO US.

That nigga was using my greatness to fix a soup dispute. I respected ambition when I found it.

“Bring the soup.”

The waiter almost dropped the bowl trying to bow.

“Captain, a great honor.”

“Bring enough for my wife.”

He bowed at Shawna too. Nearly put his forehead in the butter.

At the next table sat a enormous man in a white dinner jacket and a woman with a crown of actual living blue flowers. The man had been studying me with that particular face men make when the room has discovered a bigger reason to turn around. His name, according to the little plaque by his plate, was OREN TITAN. SKY HIGH CLASS OF THE YEAR BEFORE LAST. RECORD HOLDER.

Underneath, in smaller letters, it listed his records.

Nigga had so many they had given the plaque a second foot.

“I suppose,” he said, “we are all very impressed with driving.”

I turned in my chair.

“Depends who's driving.”

“Some of us performed our feats without an engine.”

Tank looked at the long plaque.

“This nigga brought his accomplishments to dinner.”

Oren's flower-crowned companion closed her eyes for a second. I recognized the look. A woman hearing her man choose the longest available route to embarrassment.

“Oren,” she said. “Eat.”

“I am speaking to the champion.”

“And the champion was happy eating.”

I liked her already.

Oren stood. His chair seemed grateful. He lifted one hand, and the massive marble pedestal beside his table rose into the air. A vase of blue roses rested on top. The pedestal turned slowly over his palm while guests applauded.

He could make things light. Or himself strong. I didn't know yet. Either way this nigga had interrupted my soup to argue with furniture.

“Six hundred pounds,” he said.

“Nice.”

“With one hand.”

“You want me to hold your plate?”

Porsche put her napkin over her mouth.

Oren smiled harder. The pedestal rose another foot.

“I can balance it indefinitely.”

His companion said, “Then do it outside. You're shedding plaster in my drink.”

He glanced down.

The pedestal tilted.

A very small thing. A shift. But its top was wider than its base, and the vase was wet underneath, and everybody at that table had finally received a reason to stop clapping.

The roses slid.

Oren tried to save the vase with his free hand. His shoulder turned. The pedestal rolled toward the woman in the blue flowers.

I was out of my chair before he knew he'd made two mistakes.

I caught her chair by the back and pulled it away. The pedestal struck the table. Wood cracked. Plates flew. Her glass turned over directly above her face.

I caught the glass too.

Nigga, I didn't want her evening ruined twice.

The table collapsed. The vase broke against the empty chair beside hers. Oren stood with one hand in the air and a rose stuck to his lapel.

I put her glass on our table.

“Shawna, we got company.”

Shawna moved her own chair over.

“Girl, sit.”

The woman looked from the wreckage to her drink in my hand.

“You didn't spill it.”

“It seemed expensive.”

“Nigga, it was,” she said, and started laughing so hard the little flowers in her crown shook.

Her name was Opaline. Forty, a sculptor, and very much tired of watching her dinner become an exhibition. Oren began explaining that the pedestal's balance had been altered by a defect in the floor.

Afterglow looked at the floor.

Then at him.

“My floor was here first.”

Tank pushed an empty chair toward Oren with his foot.

“Sit down, record holder.”

“I am not—”

“Nigga, you about to set one for standing beside a mess.”

He sat.

I expected him to stay furious. Instead he watched Opaline laughing with Shawna, looked down at the rose on his lapel, and started laughing too. Quiet at first. Then with his whole chest.

“I had a speech,” he admitted.

Opaline pointed at him without looking away from Shawna.

“He practiced it in the car.”

“What speech?” I asked.

“About grace under pressure.”

Tank slapped the table. Victor had to remove the card from his wine so he wouldn't inhale my name while he laughed.

“Nigga,” I told Oren, “you can still give it. Make the ending honest.”

He rubbed his face.

Then he stood again. This time both hands stayed where furniture couldn't misunderstand them.

“To the champion,” he said. “Who saved my wife's evening from her husband.”

Opaline lifted her glass.

“Best record you've set all year.”

We drank. Oren drank. The orchestra caught our table's laughter and decided it meant the room wanted a faster song.

Then the soup arrived.

Six cooks came with it.

Nigga, six. One carrying the bowl, five standing behind him with the deadly stillness of men whose whole afternoon had come down to a spoon.

I tasted it.

The cook in front gripped his hat.

“Well?”

I tasted again. Shawna watched me over her glass. She knew I was enjoying this. Aiden in the breadbasket, a record holder at my table, an entire kitchen waiting for judgment. A nigga didn't come to a school in the sky every day. Sometimes you had to let the sky show you what it had learned.

“Needs salt,” I said.

The shortest cook threw both hands up.

“I fucking told you.”

The head cook turned so slowly I thought somebody had stopped time just for his neck.

“You put the cards in the bowl.”

“I put the truth in the bowl.”

Afterglow covered her face. Her golden echo covered its face half a second later.

I held out my hand for the salt.

The head cook gave it to me. I added a little, tasted again, and nodded.

He tasted from his own spoon.

Stopped.

Tasted again.

Then that nigga took off his hat and held it against his chest like I had just returned it from a war.

“I will name it for you.”

“Don't name it before you feed my friends.”

“Every table,” he announced, turning to the kitchen doors.

“Aiden's soup. Immediately.”

Oren watched the cooks hurry away.

“You defeated me and seasoned dinner in less than four minutes.”

“Three,” Victor said, checking his watch.

Shawna squeezed my knee under the table.

“Try being married to this nigga.”

“Lucky,” Opaline said.

My wife looked at me. Her smile got smaller and warmer.

“Yeah,” she said. “I know.”

We ate beneath chandeliers full of captured starlight. I don't mean the waiter said starlight and brought candles. Actual little points of fire drifted behind glass. The food was excellent. The wine cost enough to suggest the grapes had attended private school.

I enjoyed every fucking minute.

That mattered. We had bad things underneath us, but I was not about to let Voss steal a good evening before he had even paid for it. My people looked beautiful. Shawna's knee pressed

against mine. Rosa talked with both hands while Tank watched her as if every story ended in treasure. Marcellus wore the Blue Mercy ring on a chain beneath his shirt and quietly assessed the chandeliers' settings for flaws.

Across the room, Voss sat with Sable.

The empty silver case was not present.

I raised my glass toward them.

Sable did not raise hers back.

Some niggas had no social skills at all.

Storm arrived late. Her white gown moved like a storm front behind her. She touched my shoulder as she passed and said quietly, "The records are secure."

That meant our stolen case was now in her private safe, the names copied by people Voss couldn't order around. It meant the school finally possessed something firmer than my opinion that its chancellor looked like a funeral with shoes.

It did not mean we could storm the annex yet. The foundation field had been rerouted. Voss held the real Heart somewhere below, and the academy was balanced on a system he could threaten to interrupt. Storm's engineers were trying to give us another way to keep the island in the air.

In the meantime, she sat beside Victor and asked whether he was behaving.

“I haven't used my powers,” he said.

“Good.”

“I did threaten a champagne cork.”

“A warning is permitted.”

Shawna laughed. Victor looked pleased enough that I almost forgave him for being handsome near my wife.

Almost.

Then Afterglow announced that the champion would dance.

Nobody had asked the champion.

The champion stood anyway.

Shawna took my hand. Her dress was deep blue, soft through the waist, bright at the shoulders. When she turned toward the floor, half the room forgot they had come to look at me.

I understood. A nigga with eyes had to understand.

We moved beneath the glass moon's reflected light. I knew how to fight with music going. Dancing was mostly trusting the same feet to make a better decision. Shawna rested her hand behind my neck. I felt the old watch against my skin and the new ring against my shoulder.

“You like this?” I asked.

“Everybody worshipping you?”

“The view. The food. My extremely coordinated ass.”

“I like you trying to act like you didn't practice that turn in the bathroom.”

“Nigga, that bathroom had a lot of space.”

She laughed into my collar.

“You nervous?”

“About dancing?”

“About underneath us.”

I looked past her shoulder. Voss was watching. Sable whispered something to him, and his fingers tightened around the stem of his glass.

“I'm impatient.”

“That's not the same answer.”

“Baby, I know.”

She pulled back enough to see my face.

“I'm going to get Lena.”

“We going.”

“I said what I'm going to do. I know what you doing.”

I loved the little fire in her when she said that. Loved that she could stand inside a room built to make me feel enormous and still leave no confusion about the size of her own heart.

I turned her. The orchestra rose. Applause broke around us.

For a moment there was only her smile and the clean pleasure of being the man she had chosen in front of all these people who wanted something from me.

Then Voss stood and came onto the floor.

“May I?” he asked Shawna.

I looked at him.

“May you what?”

His smile didn't move.

“A dance.”

Shawna's hand stayed in mine.

“I'm dancing.”

“A private word, then.”

“You can have a public one,” she said.

The couples nearest us slowed.

Voss looked at me with the tired expression of a man accustomed to getting threats mistaken for wisdom.

“Your husband has made an extraordinary impression.”

“He does that,” Shawna said.

“Extraordinary impressions can tempt a person into believing every locked door is an invitation.”

I smiled.

“Nigga, if you wanted to talk about doors, why you ask my wife to dance?”

A man behind Voss made a choking sound into his drink.

The chancellor's face tightened.

“I hope you enjoy your evening.”

“Already am.”

He left the floor. Sable followed him out a side door.

Victor watched them go. Storm's eyes followed too.

Afterglow appeared beside us with a smile that had lost half its warmth.

“What did he want?”

“A personality,” I said. “We couldn't help.”

She laughed once, sharply. Then she leaned closer.

“His security people have been taking over my service floors. I permitted storage. I did not permit armed men to tell my staff where they could walk.”

“How many?”

“Tonight? Too many.”

Before I could answer, the orchestra stopped.

A man stood on the stage holding a gun.

Not Voss. One of Sable's guards, now wearing a dinner jacket over his black uniform. Three more appeared by the exits. Another locked the doors behind the bar.

The first guard spoke into the singer's microphone.

“Remain seated. This establishment is under temporary security control.”

Nigga, he said that at my party.

My party.

Tank looked at me across the dance floor. I looked back.

That was our whole conversation.

The guard onstage pointed at me.

“Captain Aiden. You will accompany us.”

I took Shawna's glass from her hand and set it on a passing tray.

“Baby, hold my applause.”

She rolled her eyes.

“Come back and get it.”

I walked toward the stage.

The guard watched me. He wanted me scared enough to move carefully. That was his first financial mistake. His second was standing under a chandelier while giving orders to a room containing multiple people who could break architecture with their feelings.

“Hands visible,” he said.

I lifted them.

“Like this?”

“Stop.”

“You wanted me to accompany you. Nigga, I'm accompanying.”

Behind him, Afterglow's light began to linger.

One gold reflection became two. Then four. The guards saw movement where no bodies stood. Their weapons shifted toward echoes.

I jumped onto the stage and hit the microphone stand sideways.

The stand struck the guard's wrist. His shot went into the ceiling. Starlight rained through broken glass.

Petra moved in front of Mercedes. Tank overturned a table and put three guests behind it before firing at the exit guards. Rosa dragged the orchestra down behind their instruments. The drummer refused to abandon his cymbals until she called him a beautiful idiot and promised to buy him louder ones.

Shawna went toward the locked bar door.

I saw her pick up a champagne bottle by the neck.

The guard turned.

My wife hit him so hard the expensive champagne became a weather event.

“That nigga interrupt my dance,” she said.

Porsche caught the man's keys before they hit the floor.

“Our dance floor now.”

Leon became three men. One opened the door, one helped people through, and one stood near Porsche trying to look useful enough to survive the evening romantically.

Victor started toward the gunfire.

Dr. Vega caught his sleeve.

“No powers.”

He looked at her.

Then picked up a chair.

“Fine.”

He hit a guard with the chair.

Tank saw it and roared approval.

“There you go, lightning nigga! Analog!”

I fought the man onstage across the piano. He was bigger than me and well trained. He knew where to put his weight. Knew how to use the edge of the instrument. He drove an elbow into my ribs and tried to bring his gun around.

I caught his wrist. The old wound burned. The room narrowed around his face.

“You should've come quietly,” he said.

“Nigga, I didn't even arrive quietly.”

I drove him back into the piano. Keys crashed under his spine. His gun went sliding across the lid. I caught it before it fell, turned, and fired at a guard raising his weapon toward Shawna. The man dropped behind the bar.

She looked at me.

I looked at her.

We went back to work.

Storm never threw a bolt through that crowded room. She moved the air around the guests instead, guiding them toward the open doors, knocking falling glass away from their faces. Afterglow filled the gunmen's vision with golden doubles. Between the two women, the ballroom became a place where innocent people could move and armed idiots could not agree on what was real.

The last guard ran for the service lift.

I followed.

He hit the button. The doors began closing.

I slid between them sideways and landed inside with him.

He stared.

“Nigga,” I said, “you forgot your host.”

The lift shot upward while we fought against its mirrored walls. He caught my lapel. I caught his throat. He slammed me into the rail. I drove my knee into him and tore free. The doors opened onto the roof beneath the enormous glass moon.

A black aircraft waited there with its engines turning.

Sable stood beside its open door.

She saw me come out holding her man's collar.

For the second night in a row, I ruined the end of her plan.

She drew.

I shoved the guard behind a stone planter and dropped as shots struck the lift doors. Glass sprayed. The aircraft's engines screamed louder.

Sable climbed aboard.

I ran after her.

The aircraft rose.

I jumped onto its low landing rail.

The city dropped beneath my shoes.

Nigga, I had briefly forgotten Bell's instructions because this wasn't technically my car.

Sable looked down at me through the doorway.

“Let go.”

“You first.”

She swung a boot at my hand. I pulled myself higher. Wind tore at my jacket. Below us the glass moon turned slowly above its golden ring.

I saw my opportunity and respected it immediately.

I caught Sable's wrist as she reached for her weapon. Twisted the gun away. It fell through the air, struck the moon, and disappeared inside with a bright crack.

She hit me across the face.

I smiled blood onto my own shirt.

“That was rude.”

Then I let go.

Not straight down.

Onto the moon's golden support ring.

My feet struck metal. I slid, caught a decorative cloud, and held on while the aircraft veered away. Sable stared back from the doorway, her weapon gone, her guard captured, her attempt to drag me away witnessed by half the casino.

I stood up on the ring.

The whole roof applauded.

They had followed me out. All these rich, gifted, half-drunk niggas had come upstairs to see whether I intended to fight an aircraft in formalwear.

Apparently I did.

Shawna stood at the front with both hands on her hips.

“Get off the fucking moon.”

“Baby, you gotta admit—”

“I admit everything. Get down.”

Storm brought me down on a ribbon of wind. The moment my shoes touched the roof, my wife grabbed me by both lapels and kissed me in front of every witness available.

When she let go, Afterglow stood behind her holding a gold key.

“Lifetime suite,” she said. “Anything you want. Any time.”

Tank looked at the key.

“Nigga got assaulted into property.”

I took it.

“Good evening after all.”

Then Storm's phone rang. She listened, and the smile left her face.

The lower annex had begun moving prisoners.

Lena's song had stopped.

6. The Basement Found Out Who Lived Upstairs

I returned to Sky High wearing a torn dinner jacket, carrying another man's gun, and smelling like champagne somebody had used as a weapon.

The night porter stood when he saw me.

“Good evening, Captain.”

“Debatable.”

He saw Shawna beside me, saw Tank behind her, saw Victor carrying a broken chair leg because he apparently had developed an attachment to doing things without powers.

The porter straightened even farther.

“Would you like your room prepared?”

“Nigga, prepare the basement.”

He had no idea what that meant.

Neither did the basement yet.

Storm met us in the music hall. Pike had brought six officers he trusted. Bell stood beside a hatch in the stage with all four hands occupied by tools. Dr. Vega had traded her evening bag for her medical one. Marcellus held the black access seal from Sable's case.

Rosa knelt at the brass grille.

She sang the four lines Lena had sung before.

Nothing answered.

She sang them again, softer.

The empty air below the stage remained empty.

Tank knelt beside her. Put his hand on her back.

“We going get her.”

Rosa nodded without looking up.

Then she stood, took off her earrings, and put them in his pocket.

That was the moment the evening changed for him. A nigga can hear a hundred plans. Then the woman he loves puts something small and precious in his hand, and suddenly the plan has a heartbeat.

Storm drew a line through the air. A pale image of the lower annex appeared above the piano. The prison hung beneath the island in three connected buildings. One housed the cells. One held the laboratories. The lowest contained the circular chamber we had seen from our balcony.

“Pike's people will secure the upper service lift,” she said. “Bell will keep the secondary support field alive. I have to remain near the foundation controls. If Voss cuts the main current, somebody must catch the load.”

“You catching a whole school?” Tank asked.

“For a little while.”

He looked at me.

“Nigga, your teachers serious.”

Victor would come with us, but with his power restricted until Vega cleared him. He looked ready to object. The doctor lifted one finger. He closed his mouth.

Shawna tucked her hair back and checked the little light Pike had given her. No grand speech. No asking permission. My wife had heard a woman singing through a prison wall and had been heading toward her ever since.

I touched her wrist.

“Beside me.”

She touched my badge.

“Keep up.”

Nigga, that woman.

Bell opened the hatch.

Cold air rose through the stage.

We went down.

The first ladder led into a maintenance room full of old theater machinery. Beneath that, stairs followed the inside of the island's rock. The walls sweated. The music above us faded until

all I heard was shoes, breathing, and the distant beat of some enormous machine.

Halfway down, a narrow window opened onto the night.

We were outside the island now, walking through a bridge bolted to its underside. Above us hung black stone. Below us spread stars reflected in a sea of clouds.

Tank looked through the window.

“Nigga, the floor got sky.”

“Don't study it.”

“I'm trying not to major in falling.”

At the first locked door, Marcellus used Sable's seal. The panel flashed green. Beyond it stood a guard with a cup of coffee.

He saw me.

Saw the badge.

Saw the gun.

He carefully placed the cup on the floor.

I appreciated a man who could read a room before it became his last room.

“Hands,” I said.

He raised them.

Pike cuffed him to a rail and asked where the prisoners had been taken. The guard looked toward the lower stairs.

“Transfer chamber.”

“Who ordered it?”

The nigga looked genuinely confused by the possibility of more than one answer.

“The chancellor.”

We kept moving.

The corridor beyond his post narrowed around a little electric freight cart. Its driver had abandoned it sideways with a stack of clean blankets tied to the back. One blanket had fallen over the wheel. A mug sat in the little holder beside the seat.

Tank looked at the mug.

“Everybody downstairs got coffee except the niggas doing the work.”

I moved the blanket. Beneath it, on the lower shelf, lay a bundle of ordinary clothes: a blue blouse, a man's belt, a pair of red shoes with one broken heel.

Shawna touched the blouse. There was a little paper label tied through a buttonhole.

LENA MARCH.

She looked up at me.

“We close.”

A noise came from behind the service door beside the cart.

Not footsteps.

Scraping.

Tank opened it.

A man in green overalls stood on a stool inside a supply closet, his hands tied above him to a pipe. The stool wobbled every time he tried to turn around. A roll of packing tape lay at his feet. He had been trying to scrape a nail against the binding.

“Don't move,” Tank said.

The man looked at his gun and immediately began moving more.

“Nigga, I mean don't fall. I came to help.”

Tank held the stool while I freed him. He dropped onto his feet and grabbed the doorframe. Shawna gave him water from her little bottle.

“Your name?” she asked.

“Dennis.”

He drank, coughed, drank again.

“Dennis Vale. Laundry.”

He was forty-one, with a wedding ring hanging loose on a finger he'd been rubbing raw against the pipe. His left shoe was untied. That detail made me angrier than I expected. These niggas had tied a man up so carelessly he hadn't even had time to finish being dressed.

“You work here?” I asked.

“Upstairs. I came down because the collection wasn't arriving. Found the clothes. Found names on things. Asked where the people were.”

Tank looked back into the closet.

“That was their answer?”

Dennis nodded.

He saw the badge again. His eyes widened.

“You're the man from the race.”

“Yeah.”

“My wife said if you ever came to dinner she'd use the good dishes.”

“Tell her I'm hungry.”

Nigga started laughing and crying at the same time. He tried to stop both and managed neither. Shawna held his shoulder until his breathing settled.

Pike spoke to one of his officers, who took Dennis toward the stairs. Before he left, Dennis caught my sleeve.

“The bridge ahead is open from the control side. They rolled the walking section away. I heard them talking before they put me in there.”

I looked down the passage. A heavy door stood at the end. Light showed beneath it.

“How far?”

“Across? Maybe twelve feet. The cart rail still runs along the wall.”

Tank looked at the little freight cart.

Then at me.

“Nigga, no.”

“I ain't said nothing.”

“You looking at a vehicle. That's a sentence when you do it.”

Victor bent over the little cart. It had two seats and a flatbed. Its rubber wheels sat on the floor; beside it a narrow steel guide ran toward the door and vanished underneath. The laundry carts used it when the walkway moved away for maintenance. Dennis showed us the hinged little guide wheels tucked beneath the chassis.

“Empty loads only when the bridge is retracted,” he said.

“Normally.”

Tank shut his eyes.

“He gave the nigga a normally.”

“Tank, take the rear.”

“Nigga, I can't take the rear. The rear a washcloth.”

He climbed on anyway. Victor stayed behind to help Pike bring the others through once we had the walkway back. Shawna got into the seat beside me.

“Where's my seat belt?” she asked.

I looked down.

There wasn't one.

She took a blanket from the stack and looped it around the front rail, holding the ends in her lap.

“Nigga, drive like you married.”

I pressed the little pedal.

The cart beeped.

It did not move.

Tank looked at me.

“Somebody finally said no.”

Dennis reached through the window and released the brake.

Then we moved.

Slowly.

Nigga, offensively slowly. I had driven through fire. I had outrun bullets in a Mercedes. This little bitch traveled at the speed of a man deciding whether he had forgotten something in the refrigerator.

Behind us Victor began walking.

Kept pace.

Passed us.

He reached the door first and held it open.

“Enjoy your journey.”

“Your doctor know you using sarcasm?”

“Brief use.”

The door opened onto the gap.

The whole middle of the passage was gone. Through it I saw the black underside of the island and a dizzy stretch of stars. A narrow guide rail ran along the outer wall to the other side, where two armed men stood beside the bridge controls.

They saw our little cart.

One laughed.

The other brought up his gun.

Tank stood on the flatbed with the blanket stack in front of his chest. Shawna fired at the hanging lamp above the guards. It burst. They ducked. I held the pedal down as if the little cart might discover a second personality if I believed in it hard enough.

Our front wheels left the ordinary floor.

The guide caught.

We hung against the wall, rolling above the empty air.

Tank stopped joking.

So did I.

For about two seconds.

Then the laundry cart played a little musical chime.

A cheerful four-note warning.

“Nigga,” Tank said, “is it singing us to death?”

“Low battery,” Shawna read from the dash.

We were halfway across.

Of course we were. A less ambitious nigga would've encountered this problem beside a charging socket.

The cart slowed. The guide wheels clicked over a join. On the far side the guards recovered, one reaching for his weapon while the other tried to close the heavy door in front of us.

I took my foot off the pedal.

“What you doing?” Tank said.

“Letting it think.”

Then I pressed down again.

The cart lurched forward on its last little act of loyalty. Shawna flung the blanket ahead of us. It caught the closing door's edge and bunched under it. The door stopped a hand's width short of its frame.

Our front bumper hit the blanket.

I stood and pushed.

Tank pushed behind me.

The door opened with all three of us still attached to the cart. We rolled through into the control room like the worst laundry delivery these niggas had ever received.

One guard swung at me. I pulled his dinner plate-sized control clipboard out of his hand and hit him with the blank side. The other tried to grab Shawna. She drove her elbow into his face and shoved him into Tank.

Tank set him down.

On the desk.

The desk stopped being one desk and became several smaller opportunities for carpentry.

The freight cart gave a final beep.

Died.

I patted its steering wheel.

“Good nigga.”

Shawna looked at the wrecked desk, the two groaning guards, and the little cart's blinking red light.

“You gonna name this one too?”

“Laundry Day.”

Tank started laughing before he could help it.

“Nigga, we almost died on Laundry Day.”

I found the bridge control. The walkway slid back across the gap with a long metallic groan. Victor and Pike came through first. Behind them Dennis stopped beside the cart and stared at the collapsed furniture.

“It only goes eleven miles an hour,” he said.

I handed him his mug.

“That's all I needed.”

He took it with both hands.

“My wife is getting out the fucking dishes.”

The next door opened into a long cell gallery. Some doors stood open. Others remained locked. Men and women watched us from behind thick glass. All adults. Some wore plain gray clothing. Some still wore pieces of whatever lives they had been taken out of: a mechanic's shirt, a dancer's leggings, a suit jacket with the lining torn.

A tall man pressed his palm to the glass.

“Are we being moved?”

I stopped outside his cell.

“You being let out.”

He looked at the badge again.

“They said—”

“Nigga, they said a lot. I'm speaking now.”

Shawna opened the first door with the seal. Rosa opened the second. Petra took one look at a jammed third door, turned her hands to marble, and removed its disagreement from the frame.

Mercedes guided the people toward Pike's officers.

“Up the stairs. Stay together. If you can help somebody walk, do it. If you can't, say so. Nobody gotta perform for us.”

A woman with silver burns along her forearms stared at Petra.

“You could break the whole wall.”

Petra glanced at Mercedes.

Mercedes smiled.

“Girl, don't encourage her unless we need it.”

We needed it about fifteen seconds later.

The far security door slammed shut. Red light washed the gallery. A voice ordered everybody to remain where they were.

Everybody kept moving.

That voice had plainly not met my people.

Two guards appeared on the upper walkway. Their weapons came down toward the escaping prisoners. I fired first. One dropped out of sight. The other ducked behind the rail.

Tank lifted a steel bench and held it over three people trying to cross the open floor. Bullets struck it with flat, ugly bangs. He kept walking.

“Nigga, this bench better appreciate its promotion.”

Victor ran beside him carrying the chair leg from the casino.

I looked at him.

He looked at the chair leg.

“It's been useful.”

“I ain't judging.”

He threw it at the second guard.

It hit square across the man's hands.

Victor smiled for the first time since we came underground.

“Very useful.”

Petra punched the security door off its hinges. The noise traveled down the gallery like a cannon shot. Beyond it lay a control room with three startled technicians and a supervisor already halfway toward another exit.

Shawna pointed her gun at him.

“Sit.”

He sat.

“Where's Lena March?”

He looked at the technicians.

“Nigga,” she said, “they ain't going to answer for you.”

The supervisor pointed toward the lower stairs.

“She resisted the transfer.”

Rosa moved before he finished.

Tank followed her.

I left Pike with the controls and went down after them with Shawna and Victor. The stairs opened onto a medical corridor. Doors stood ajar. Beds rolled against the walls. In one room, a woman lay on her side humming through clenched teeth while a guard tried to fasten a restraint around her wrist.

Tank caught the guard by the back of his uniform.

The nigga left the room horizontally.

Rosa went to the bed.

“Lena?”

The woman opened her eyes.

She was thin, brown-haired, with a bruise beneath one eye and a look so fierce it reached us before her voice did.

“You're the singer.”

“So are you.”

Rosa undid the restraint. Shawna helped Lena sit. Tank returned from placing the guard in a condition where he would remain available for later questions.

Lena took one step and nearly fell.

He caught her.

“I can walk,” she said.

“Then walk with assistance. Ain't no extra prize for hurting.”

She studied his enormous arm, then nodded.

“Reiss,” she said. “They took Dr. Reiss downstairs. He tried to stop them.”

I looked at Shawna.

She looked back.

There was always another downstairs.

We took Lena to Vega and the evacuation group. Twenty-seven prisoners had come out of the cells. Two needed stretchers. The rest insisted on helping carry them. A man whose hands shook with uncontrolled sparks wrapped them in his own coat so he could support someone without hurting them.

I watched him for one second longer than I needed.

Then the upper lift stopped.

The lights over its doors went red. Pike spoke into his radio, listened, and swore. Voss's men had cut access from the annex to the service bridge. The people we had taken out of cells were now crowded into a corridor with one locked route home.

I could feel fear trying to turn them backward. Shoulders drew in. Eyes went to the open cells. A woman began shaking her head as if the whole rescue had been a particularly cruel rehearsal.

Lena pushed herself away from Vega's arm.

“Let me hear it,” she said.

Pike held out his radio.

Sable's voice came over the security channel, ordering the upper guards to keep the bridge sealed. Lena listened with her eyes closed. Her lips moved once, shaping the other woman's cadence.

Rosa looked at her.

“You can do that?”

“I can sing through walls. Words aren't harder.”

She held out her hand. Pike gave her the radio.

When she spoke, Sable came out of her mouth.

“Open the upper bridge. We are conducting an inspection. Anyone who obstructs this order will answer directly to me.”

I stared at her.

Tank stared too.

“This woman stole a whole bitch,” he whispered.

Lena nearly laughed. Caught herself. Spoke again in Sable's clipped voice.

“Now.”

The red lights turned green.

The lift doors opened.

People began moving, faster now. Not pushed. Choosing. The woman who had shaken her head helped lift a stretcher. The sparking man took its other end. Lena stood by the doorway and kept Sable's voice talking long enough to buy them the corridor beyond.

Then the real Sable shouted over her.

“That is not my order.”

Lena's own voice returned.

“I know.”

She gave Pike the radio with a smile so sharp it could have cut its cord.

We heard boots approaching along the bridge.

Petra stepped into the lift with Mercedes. “We'll hold the top.”

Pike joined them with two officers. The rest stayed beside the stretchers. Nobody asked which people were powerful enough to deserve first place. The people who could walk made space for the ones who couldn't. The ones with strength used it. The ones without still had hands.

A man in a torn suit stopped beside me as the lift filled.

He was maybe fifty, with gray in his beard and one lens missing from his glasses. He studied my badge as if he had been waiting for it longer than I had been alive.

“Who sent you?”

I looked at Shawna.

She stood at the stairwell, watching the lower door, ready for the next thing that needed doing.

“My wife heard a song.”

The man followed my gaze.

Then he took off his broken glasses and wiped his eyes with his sleeve.

“Tell her thank you.”

“Tell her yourself upstairs.”

He nodded. Put his glasses back on. Went into the lift carrying somebody else's bag.

Lena waited until the last stretcher cleared before she let Vega guide her inside. Rosa went with her, still holding her hand.

Tank watched until the doors closed.

“That nigga in the gray suit,” he said quietly. “He look like my uncle.”

“Yeah?”

“My uncle would've been asking who stole his shoes the whole time.”

I looked at the lift doors. At the boots and shoes people had left behind in their cells because nobody had expected to need them quickly.

“We buying shoes,” I said.

Tank nodded.

“A lot of fucking shoes.”

Then we went toward the machine.

The transfer chamber was round, high-ceilinged, and bright with a cold yellow light. Rails crossed its floor into the metal circle at the far end. Above the circle, a clock displayed a date that belonged to somebody else's lifetime.

1944.

Snow blew through the open frame.

Real snow. It settled on the floor and melted around our shoes.

Beyond the circle stood a dim station building under a night sky.

A train waited beside it. Men moved with lanterns. One wore a military coat with an emblem I recognized even before my brain caught up with what my eyes had been handed.

A Nazi.

Not a costume at a party. Not some present-day idiot trying to be provocative. A man standing in a different year, carrying a gun, waiting for human beings to be delivered to him.

My stomach went cold in a way the snow couldn't explain.

At the control dais, Sable held a pistol beside the head of an older man in a rumpled shirt.

Dr. Reiss.

He looked at us over his glasses.

“Do not damage the ring,” he said immediately.

“Nigga, we just got here,” Tank said.

Sable tightened her grip on him.

“Back away.”

I stopped.

Shawna stopped beside me.

Victor's hands glimmered faintly. He closed them into fists before the charge could grow.

“Let him go,” I said.

Sable laughed once.

“You keep arriving at the end of things you don't understand.”

“And somehow niggas keep getting free.”

Behind her, a black carriage rolled toward the circle. Three adults inside it pressed their faces to a barred opening. On the other side, a soldier raised his hand to receive them.

I could not shoot without risking Reiss.

Shawna saw the same thing.

She looked at the carriage, then at the hanging work light above the control dais.

I knew her face when a decision arrived.

“Baby,” I said.

She shot the light.

Darkness hit half the room.

Reiss dropped.

Sable fired where his head had been and stumbled back as Tank charged. I ran for the carriage. Victor went toward the controls. Shawna covered both of us from behind the rail support.

The carriage reached the circle.

Cold air swallowed my arms as I grabbed its rear handle.

The soldier on the other side saw me.

His face changed at the sight of my clothes, my badge, my skin, and the fact that none of those things had asked his permission to be there.

He raised his gun.

I shot first.

He fell behind the platform edge.

I hauled the carriage back.

The wheels fought me. Three people pushed from inside, trying to help through the same floor that trapped them. My shoes slid in melting snow.

“Tank!”

He came out of the dark, grabbed beside me, and planted his feet.

“This nigga train going the wrong way.”

We pulled together.

The carriage rolled clear of the circle.

Behind us, Sable disappeared through a side passage. Victor caught Reiss before he could strike the floor. Shawna broke the carriage latch with the control lever somebody had left beside it.

The three prisoners came out holding each other.

One man kept saying, “Thank you,” in a language I didn't know, then found the same words in English and said them again.

I touched his shoulder.

“Go with her.”

On the other side of the ring, a whistle shrieked. More soldiers appeared beside the train.

Reiss struggled upright.

“Close it.”

Victor looked at the controls.

“Which—”

“The black handle. Slowly.”

Victor moved it.

The circle narrowed from the edges inward. Snow became a thin white line. Through the shrinking opening I saw a woman standing near the station wall, one hand pressed against her mouth, watching us take people away from the men who owned her night.

Our eyes met across eighty years of machinery and somebody's monstrous ambition.

Then the door closed.

The room was only a room again.

I stood with both hands on the empty carriage handle.

Shawna came beside me. Her shoulder touched mine.

“We saw her,” she said.

“Yeah.”

“She saw us.”

I looked at the blank metal circle.

Behind me Tank swore softly. Reiss began to cry without making a sound. Upstairs, people we had freed were walking toward the music they had heard through a wall.

I let go of the handle.

“Then she know somebody coming back.”

7. Forty Floors of Niggas Finding Out

At two in the morning, the first freed prisoner walked into Sky High's grand entrance wearing Tank's coat.

By two-fifteen, the entrance was full of blankets, food, doctors, and students who had come downstairs expecting an alarm drill and found a whole different school underneath the one they knew.

Nobody cheered at first.

They made room.

That was better.

Then the man in the gray suit saw Shawna and crossed the hall to take her hand. I couldn't hear what he said. I didn't need to. She held both his hands and listened until he finished. Behind them Rosa sat beside Lena with two steaming cups between them. Tank stood over the group like a roof that had learned to love people.

Elias, the density man from the train, brought chairs. He carried six at a time now that he wasn't frightened of becoming heavy. Petra helped the medical team. Mercedes found fresh clothes. Porsche somehow persuaded the night kitchen to produce steak for thirty people at once.

The chef objected that he had prepared a light supper.

“Nigga, prepare a heavier one,” she told him.

He did.

Storm took Dr. Reiss into a side room. I went with Shawna, Victor, Bell, and Marcellus. The doctor sat beneath a portrait of the academy's founder and stared at a glass of water for so long I thought he hadn't understood what it was.

Then he drank it all.

Bell refilled it without asking.

Reiss was fifty-seven, with thinning dark hair, a tired face, and hands that kept reaching toward his wrists where restraints had been. He had designed the time door before he understood what an ambitious man might do with a beautiful mistake.

“It doesn't lead to every past,” he told us. “It found one branch. One set of coordinates. A point in occupied France in 1944.”

Storm sat forward.

“You told the board it failed.”

“I told the board it should never be used.”

Voss had disagreed. First politely. Then financially. Then with Sable standing behind him. The chancellor discovered that a man on the other side of the door was willing to exchange prisoners, resources, and protection for technology he should never have seen.

“A colonel named Ernst Keller,” Reiss said. “He commands the Saint-Orage depot. It's a separate branch now. Changed from the moment our machine opened there. But the people inside it are real to themselves. Their pain is real. Their choices are real.”

He looked at me as if he expected an argument.

“Nigga, I saw a woman looking for a way out,” I said. “You don't need to explain her to me.”

He nodded and stared at his hands.

Keller used the depot to hold people the Nazis had imprisoned: Jewish adults, resistance prisoners, people taken because the regime had decided their existence or defiance was a reason to destroy them. Voss had added something newer and uglier to that machinery. He sent captive powered adults through the door and used Keller's guarded site for experiments he couldn't conceal forever under the academy.

“He wanted transferable power,” Reiss said. “A gift he could wear and remove. The Heart amplifies what's there. He wanted it to make him whatever he chose.”

“Can it?” Victor asked.

“Not safely. Not the way he imagines.”

I thought about Victor trapped in his own racing car while the rings drank him.

“The race.”

Reiss closed his eyes.

Bell's four hands went still.

Victor looked at the floor for a long moment. When he raised his head, whatever remained of his loyalty to the chancellor had burned away cleanly.

“Where's the real Heart?” he asked.

Reiss told us.

It had been in the lower laboratory until our raid. When the alarms began, Voss had ordered it moved to a secure vault at Cloud Nine. A portable housing kept the school's field drawing from it. Voss could hide among the casino's private lifts and armed guards while his core continued to hold the academy hostage from a distance.

My phone lit up.

Afterglow.

“He took my penthouse,” she said.

“I was just hearing about your hospitality problem.”

“Aiden. He has twelve people from my staff upstairs. He says if I object, he drops the building.”

I looked at Storm.

She had heard enough through the phone to stand.

“Tell your staff to stay away from the windows,” I said.

“What are you going to do?”

Nigga, people loved asking me that right before I did something expensive.

“Get your house back.”

Bell brought the Lamborghini to the front drive. It looked as if it had endured a disagreement with a train, a race, and somebody's military budget.

It had.

I put my hand on the hood.

“One more trip.”

Bell looked wounded.

“You said that yesterday.”

“Nigga, yesterday ended.”

Tank appeared in fresh black clothes. Rosa kissed him at the bottom of the steps and said something in his ear that made his whole face change.

He watched her go back inside.

“What she say?” I asked.

“Private.”

“You grinning publicly.”

“Nigga, let a man have a future.”

I did.

Shawna climbed into the Lamborghini. Tank took the Mercedes with Victor. Pike followed with patrol cars. Storm remained at the control tower, guiding us through the school's field and keeping the main island steady. Bell rode with her technicians toward the casino's lower service entrance.

We entered the Crown District under a sky beginning to pale.

No tourists waved this time. People watched from behind windows. The news of the prison had spread. So had the news that the academy's finest new graduate was driving toward its chancellor with police lights on and his wife beside him.

Outside Cloud Nine, Afterglow stood in a gold coat over her evening gown. Her light had grown sharp around the edges.

She handed me the private-lift key.

“Fortieth floor.”

“You coming?”

“It's my fucking building.”

I liked that answer.

We went through the side entrance because Voss had barricaded the front with a sculpture of two lovers embracing. It was enormous, naked, and made of polished bronze. A very serious artist had given the man wings, the woman a sword, and both of them asses so large Tank stopped for a second to consider the arrangement.

“Nigga, why her cheeks armed?”

“Keep walking,” Shawna said.

The side entrance opened onto a long shopping gallery. Closed jewelry stores. A fountain full of floating little golden fish. Beyond it, a staircase curled up to the lift lobby in two matching arms.

A security shutter began descending behind us.

Afterglow looked up.

“That is not mine.”

We ran. Pike's officers caught the shutter before it reached the floor, jamming it with the heavy ceremonial bench beside the door. Three of us made the stairs. A gunshot cracked from above, and the marble beside my shoe shattered.

I pulled Shawna behind the fountain.

Tank ducked beside a jewelry kiosk. The glass over him burst. He covered his head with one arm and came up furious.

“These niggas shooting at diamonds.”

“Focus.”

“I am focused. That's a second crime.”

Two men held the balcony. Another crouched beside the lifts. Voss had left a welcoming committee, and every member had apparently been instructed to make my morning worse.

Afterglow knelt beside us. Gold light gathered on her hands.

“The fountain,” she said. “It runs under both stairs.”

I looked down. Beneath the water, a clear maintenance tunnel connected the two sides of the gallery. Lights moved in it. The golden fish weren't ordinary fish. They were little mechanical things suspended above the water by the same kind of decorative field that made the whole rich-ass building impossible to explain to a normal plumber.

“You can open that?” I asked.

She pulled off her gold bracelet and pressed it against the fountain's rim. A little service panel slid aside.

“Staff passage.”

Tank glanced inside.

“Which staff? The staff ants?”

It was narrow. Too narrow for him. Wide enough for me if I didn't get sentimental about the shoulders of my jacket.

Shawna caught my sleeve.

“Come out where I can see you.”

I kissed her quickly.

“Nigga, I been doing that all week.”

Then I went into the fountain.

The passage smelled like water and warm wiring. I crawled beneath the shallow pool while shots struck the far wall above me. Through the clear ceiling I could see the golden fish and, past them, a distorted view of one gunman leaning over the rail. A fish drifted directly above my face.

Looked down at me with its little jeweled eyes.

Nigga looked impressed.

I accepted that too.

Halfway through, a motor whined. The little fish began turning toward the center of the fountain. Lights flashed blue, then gold. Music started from somewhere under my elbow.

The fountain was doing its sunrise show.

With me inside it.

A jet of water rose above the glass. Then another. The pool churned. Outside, Tank began laughing so loudly I could hear him through the tunnel.

“That nigga got aquatic accompaniment!”

“Tank!” Shawna shouted.

“He said make it loud!”

The music swelled. Some rich bastard's idea of dawn, all trumpets and tiny spinning fish, hid the sound of me pushing open the maintenance hatch on the other side.

I came out behind the left staircase.

A guard had his back to me. He was trying to understand why the fountain had become more dramatic than his ambush.

I caught the back of his jacket and dragged him into the service recess. He swung. His fist hit the wall beside my face. I drove him against the marble, took the gun, and pushed him down behind the cleaning trolley.

The balcony guard saw us.

He turned his weapon.

Victor sent one blue flash into the metal lamp above him. The lamp burst. The guard stumbled back, and Shawna's shot struck the railing where his hand had been. He dropped his gun.

Tank charged up the other staircase.

The last man tried to retreat toward the lifts. Tank reached the top before he did. Nigga had crossed an entire decorative staircase like the stairs owed Rosa money.

He caught the gunman's wrist, spun him, and sat him in the velvet chair beside the lift buttons.

The gunman tried to stand.

Tank put one hand on his shoulder.

“Seated experience.”

The man remained seated.

I came up the left side with my prisoner. Pike's officers followed and took all three. Afterglow reached the top, looked down at the fountain, and let out a breath that seemed to contain the whole building.

“You came through the water.”

“Under it.”

“You were beneath the fish.”

“They seemed cool.”

She looked at me like she was deciding where to put a plaque. Shawna pulled a piece of gold ribbon off my shoulder. It must have been caught in the service passage. She tucked it into her pocket.

“Souvenir?” I asked.

“Evidence for when you tell this story wrong.”

“Nigga, I ain't told a wrong story in my life.”

She looked back at the bronze lovers visible through the gallery doors.

“Your wedding speech said you invented commitment.”

“Improved it.”

“See?”

Afterglow laughed. Then a voice called from inside the closed perfume shop beside us.

“Eveline?”

She stopped.

“Claudine?”

A woman stood behind the glass holding a little dog in one arm and a store stool in the other. She had barricaded the shop door from inside. A young man in a clerk's waistcoat stood behind her with an enormous bottle of perfume raised like a weapon.

“Are they gone?” she asked.

“From this floor,” Afterglow said. “Open the door.”

The clerk moved the stool. Claudine came out in a pink dressing gown and slippers with feathers on them. She was sixty-three, a guest who had come down early because her dog needed walking. The gunmen had chased her into the shop. She had spent the whole time trying to persuade the little animal not to bark at people carrying rifles.

The dog saw Tank.

Barked once.

Thought about it.

Sat down.

“Good nigga,” Tank said.

Claudine stared at me.

“You're Aiden.”

“Yes, ma'am.”

“I saw you on the moon.”

“Busy night.”

She handed her dog to Tank before he could object, caught both my hands, and kissed my cheek.

“You get younger every time you do something impossible.”

“I started early.”

The perfume clerk looked at the weapon in his hand. Put it down. Picked up a smaller bottle from the display and offered it to me.

“For your wife.”

Shawna took it.

Claudine opened the handbag hanging from her wrist and took out a huge ruby ring. She pressed it against my palm.

I shook my head.

“Keep your ring.”

“My third husband gave it to me.”

“You might want the memory.”

“I kept the second husband's yacht. That is enough memory.”

Tank looked up from the dog.

“This lady understands separation.”

She laughed and closed my fingers around the ruby.

“Then give it to somebody you love.”

I handed it straight to Shawna.

My wife looked at it, then at Claudine.

“Girl.”

“Exactly,” Claudine said.

Afterglow sent a patrol officer down with the woman, the clerk, and the little dog. Tank watched the dog go with surprising reluctance.

“Don't,” I told him.

“I ain't said nothing.”

“You looking at a responsibility. That's a sentence when you do it.”

Shawna laughed first. Then Tank. Even Victor smiled.

The private-lift key was warm in my hand. Above us, twelve staff members were still waiting for the same chance to laugh. I turned toward the stairs, and my people turned with me.

The main lift was disabled above the thirty-sixth. Voss's men held the top stairs. The service lift could reach a glass observation lounge beside the penthouse, but it was watched from inside.

Afterglow smiled without warmth.

“They can watch light.”

She filled the lounge's windows with reflections of us approaching from the main stairs. Guards moved toward the wrong door. We rose in the service lift while our golden doubles arrived somewhere else.

Tank stared at his own bright reflection through the distant glass.

“Nigga, I look incredible.”

Victor looked at him.

“That's what you're focusing on?”

“You telling me the light nigga ain't handsome?”

Shawna elbowed me before I could join in.

The doors opened.

We moved into the lounge.

For six seconds it worked perfectly.

Then a guard looked behind him and saw two versions of Tank, one gold and one holding a gun.

He made the correct choice about which one to fear.

Too late.

Tank hit him with the stock and caught him before he fell through a table. Victor disarmed the second man with a short, controlled burst of charge. Vega had allowed brief use. He seemed to enjoy making that brief use count.

I crossed into the penthouse behind Shawna.

Twelve staff members knelt near the windows. A chef still wore his hat. Two cleaners held hands. The cocktail pianist sat on the floor with a bloodied lip and fury in his eyes.

Sable stood beside them.

Voss stood behind a glass desk.

On the desk, inside a black frame, floated the real Heart of the Sky.

It was smaller than the fake. Darker blue. Alive in a way the false crystal had never been. Its light moved through the room like a slow, enormous pulse.

Marcellus had called beautiful things different from expensive lies.

I understood now.

Voss looked at me with genuine astonishment.

“Again.”

“Nigga, you keep leaving doors.”

Sable raised her weapon toward the hostages.

Shawna had hers aimed at Sable before the movement finished.

“Try me,” my wife said.

Nobody in that room doubted she meant it.

Voss rested his hand on the Heart's frame.

The floor tilted.

One of the cleaners screamed. Outside the windows, the horizon moved.

“The housing controls the support link,” he said. “Do you imagine strength is only what a man can do with his own hands?”

I looked at the hostages.

Looked at Shawna.

Looked back at him.

“No. I imagine weakness is needing twelve people on their knees to finish a sentence.”

The pianist smiled through his split lip.

Voss saw it. His face hardened.

“You have been admired for two days. I built my authority over twenty years.”

“Nigga, that's embarrassing. I caught up on a weekend.”

Tank made a noise behind me.

I knew that noise. A nigga trying very hard not to laugh while keeping a gun level.

Voss pressed something on the frame.

The windows cracked.

Storm's voice came through my earpiece, strained but steady.

“I have the building. Briefly.”

I moved.

So did everybody else.

Afterglow threw light across Sable's eyes. Shawna drove toward the hostages, putting her body between them and the gun.

Victor's charge struck the metal rail beside Sable, jolting her arm upward. Her shot went through the ceiling.

Tank took her down.

Not gently.

I went over the desk at Voss.

He struck me with his cane. Pain burst along my shoulder. I landed hard, caught the desk edge, and pulled myself forward. The old man was faster than he looked. Not old-old. Fifty and mean enough to spend the next fifty complaining that the world hadn't knelt properly.

His cane flashed again.

I caught it.

“Nigga, stop conducting.”

I tore it out of his hands and broke it across the desk.

His eyes widened.

For one lovely second the chancellor had no symbol left to hide behind.

Then he hit a switch beneath the glass.

The floor under me opened.

I fell into an observation shaft.

The city rushed past on all sides.

I caught a crossbar with both hands. My shoulders screamed.

Below me, thirty-nine floors of glass dropped toward the clouds.

Above, Voss grabbed the Heart's housing.

Shawna saw him move.

She fired at the mechanism over the private escape door.

The door jammed halfway open.

He ducked through anyway, dragging the housing behind him.

The black frame struck the narrow gap and stuck.

That was all the invitation I needed.

I pulled myself up, braced a foot against the shaft wall, and climbed back into the penthouse like a nigga returning from a disappointing basement.

Voss looked over his shoulder.

“Impossible.”

“You been saying that with your face all night.”

I caught the housing.

He pulled from the other side.

For a second we held the Heart between us: him in the escape passage, me standing over the open shaft, blue light covering both our hands.

It did not enter me. It did not choose me. It sat inside its frame and made everything around it feel more dangerous.

Voss let go.

I staggered backward with the weight.

The escape door slammed.

Somewhere beyond it an engine started.

I had the Heart.

He had a route out.

For once, nigga, I accepted the better prize.

“Bell,” I said into the radio. “Got it.”

The professor's voice broke.

“Bring it to the service station. Carefully.”

“I know what carefully mean.”

Tank looked around at the broken desk, open shaft, cracked windows, and Sable unconscious under his knee.

“Definition been growing.”

We took the Heart downstairs with the hostages around us. The chef insisted on carrying one side of the frame. The pianist carried my broken half of Voss's cane like a trophy. Sable went

down in cuffs between Pike's officers, awake now and too furious to speak.

Afterglow walked through her lobby.

The staff applauded her.

She pointed at us.

The applause changed direction.

A cleaner ran forward and hugged Shawna. The chef hugged Tank, which briefly made him disappear. The pianist shook my hand and told me he would write something worthy of what he had seen.

“Make it loud,” I said.

“It will require brass.”

“Nigga, get all the brass.”

Outside, Bell connected the housing to a secured transport platform. Storm's wind settled the casino gently back onto its proper plane. The sunrise spilled across the Crown District.

My phone rang.

Chief Knox.

“Captain,” she said. “Why am I watching footage of you falling through a casino forty stories above a fucking cloud?”

“Training.”

“Outstanding.”

She paused.

“Bring me a souvenir.”

I looked at the half cane in the pianist's hands.

“Might have something.”

Then I looked up at the academy, where a closed metal ring waited beneath the foundation and a woman in another year still had reason to watch the door.

I had won the Heart.

Now I had to keep a promise bigger than the sky.

8. A Nigga Can't Be Late to Yesterday

They tried to give me a medal before breakfast.

Nigga, I had blood on my cuff, no sleep in my eyes, and a wife leaning against my shoulder who had helped liberate a prison before most of the faculty remembered to put their slippers on. The medal could have waited until somebody brought eggs.

The faculty disagreed.

They assembled in the main hall with a blue ribbon, a gold star, and enough respectful silence to make Tank suspicious.

“What these niggas want?” he whispered.

“Apparently me.”

“Everybody want you. I'm asking what format.”

Storm stepped forward. She looked exhausted. Faint silver lines trembled around her wrists where she had held the casino upright through the Heart's unstable link. She had changed into a plain white shirt and dark trousers, but somehow still looked like the person a storm asked before making landfall.

“For exceptional courage in the rescue of the lower-annex prisoners,” she said, “and for returning the Heart of the Sky to this academy—”

I lifted a hand.

She stopped.

“My people,” I said.

I pointed at Shawna. At Tank and Rosa. At Mercedes, Porsche, Petra, Victor, Pike, Bell, Vega, Marcellus. At Lena sitting in a chair nearby with a blanket around her shoulders.

“Whatever that sentence is about to give me, make enough.”

Storm looked down at the medal.

Then she smiled.

“We will.”

Tank leaned toward Rosa.

“Nigga got us jewelry through collective bargaining.”

“You don't know what that means.”

“I know I'm collectively about to shine.”

The room laughed. The freed prisoners laughed too, some cautiously, some like they were surprised their bodies still remembered where laughter lived. I let Storm put the ribbon around my neck. Then I put the medal around Shawna's.

She looked at me.

“You earned this.”

“Baby, I got you.”

That was corny as fuck.

It was also true enough to make her eyes go bright.

Breakfast finally arrived. We ate in the main hall because nobody wanted to leave the people still being examined by the medical team. Tables filled with food, borrowed clothes, shoes in every size, and phones people could use to call somebody who had not known where they were.

Tank personally distributed the shoes.

He knelt in front of the gray-suited man, who introduced himself as Mr. Harlan Moss, fifty-two, a landscape architect whose gift let him persuade roots to grow through stone. He had been taken after refusing to work on one of Voss's private properties.

Tank offered him two pairs.

Moss looked at them.

“Both?”

“Nigga, you got two kinds of occasions.”

Moss laughed and chose the polished brown pair for now. He set the boots beside his chair with the careful pleasure of a man arranging evidence that tomorrow might exist.

His phone call came through while Tank was lacing the boots for him.

A woman filled the screen. Gray curls, a blue bathrobe, eyes so wide she looked almost angry with him.

“Harlan?”

He set the phone against a water glass. Missed. Caught it before it fell.

“Anne.”

She covered her mouth.

He covered his.

For a few seconds the niggas couldn't say anything at all.

Tank stopped touching the boots. I put my coffee down. Around us breakfast kept happening, but slowly, as if everybody near that table had understood there was a voice trying to find its way home.

Anne dropped her hand first.

“Where the fuck have you been?”

Harlan started laughing.

Then crying.

Then trying to answer both questions with the same breath.

“I've had a bad few months.”

“I can see that. Your hair looks terrible.”

He touched it. She began crying too.

Nigga, there are people who need a whole orchestra to tell somebody they love them. That woman had done it with a complaint about his hair, and Harlan heard every note.

He turned the phone to show her the room. Blankets. Breakfast. Shoes. My badge, which she studied with the ferocity of a woman deciding whether to trust the next thing a man in a uniform told her.

“Did you find him?” she asked me.

“My wife did.”

“Then put her on.”

I waved Shawna over. She took the phone, sat beside Harlan, and listened to Anne thank her so many times she finally had to say, “Girl, breathe. We got him.”

Harlan looked at his boots.

“She bought me shoes before our wedding,” he told Tank. “I’d spent everything on the ring.”

Tank nodded gravely.

“Respectable allocation.”

“They were brown. Like these. I wanted black because I thought black looked distinguished.”

“What happened?”

Harlan looked at Anne on the screen.

“What do you think happened?”

Tank looked at Rosa across the room.

“Brown shoes.”

“Brown shoes,” Harlan agreed.

He told us about their wedding while Anne corrected him from the phone. It had rained. The roof had leaked over the little rented chapel's piano. His brother had put a cooking pot under the leak and called it percussion. Anne's mother had objected to the music. Anne had walked down the aisle anyway, carrying her own umbrella, and closed it over her mother's face just long enough to finish saying yes.

“That isn't how it happened,” Anne said.

Harlan smiled at the screen.

“You told your sister you wished it had.”

“My sister talks too much.”

“She sent me the letter.”

Anne stopped.

Then she laughed so hard the picture shook.

That was their whole marriage coming through a little glowing rectangle: the rain, the ridiculous shoes, a letter somebody had kept, an argument that had survived thirty years because neither of them wanted to win it enough to stop having it together.

I looked at Shawna. She looked back.

Thirty years sounded like something a nigga ought to earn one morning at a time.

Anne's face steadied on the screen.

“I’m coming,” she said.

Harlan looked around the floating school. “It’s a little complicated to get here.”

“Nigga, I spent five months trying to get you back. Don’t tell me about parking.”

Tank bowed his head so she wouldn’t see him laughing.

Pike arranged a ground escort to the academy’s landing station. Storm offered a shuttle. By the time Anne ended the call, Harlan had said her name so often it had become the easiest word in the room.

He put the phone down gently.

Then he looked at me.

“I don’t know what to give you.”

“Take her dancing.”

He looked at the brown shoes.

I pointed.

“Nigga, you already equipped.”

He laughed again. This time it came easily.

Tank finished the last knot, stood, and inspected his work.

“Wedding shoes,” he said.

“Thirty years late,” Harlan answered.

“Thirty years still going.”

Harlan pressed his lips together and nodded.

Then he picked up his fork and ate like a man with somewhere to be.

Shawna sat with Lena. Rosa poured coffee. The three women spoke low enough that I heard only pieces: songs, five months, a sister in Denver, a room with a window. None of it needed me in the middle.

I ate my eggs.

A nigga can save a room and still let other people have conversations inside it.

Afterward Reiss took us back beneath the school.

The transfer chamber looked smaller with the lights fully on. Without Voss's guards and the snow blowing through it, the place showed its seams: cables enclosed in heavy channels, rails bolted to the floor, a control platform crowded with dials Reiss touched as if apologizing to them.

The Heart stood in a secured housing behind reinforced glass. Bell had connected it to the academy's restored support system. It remained the school's core; we were not putting it in my trunk and hoping the clouds would understand.

Storm stood at the controls.

Reiss showed her the three rings governing the door's alignment. She listened, asked two questions, and repeated the sequence back without touching anything.

“Only you can hold the boundary stable without drawing too much from the school,” he said. “Once I set the coordinates, you open it. I can't guarantee a second attempt if we close it fully.”

“Then we make one passage out and one passage back,” Storm said.

He nodded.

“A single operation. After that, the frame comes apart.”

I looked at the empty circle.

“And we don't come back with everybody suddenly unborn or some shit?”

Reiss shook his head.

“This isn't a road to your own childhood. Voss connected us to a branch and changed it. The history we came from still happened. We can't erase the Holocaust by driving through this machine.”

The room stayed quiet.

“We can help people trapped on its other side,” he said. “People who exist there now. That is the choice in front of us.”

Shawna looked at me.

“That's enough.”

“Yeah,” I said. “It is.”

Tank ran his hand along the closed carriage's empty rail.

“How many?”

Reiss spread the depot papers across a workbench. Keller's site held eighty-three adult prisoners at the last count. Thirty-one were people Voss had sent from the present. The rest belonged to that altered year: Jewish prisoners, resistance members, other adults seized by the Nazi occupation. Some were forced to maintain the depot. Some were used in the power experiments. Some were awaiting transport to places whose names did not need to be written down for the fear to make sense.

"We don't know if the count has changed," Reiss said.

"Then we count when we get there," Shawna answered.

He showed us the station layout. Not a plan for conquering history. One depot, one connecting yard, one machine chamber Keller had built around the other end of Voss's door. A holding building stood beyond the tracks. A repair shed faced the station. A road led into the town of Saint-Orage, whose name Reiss said had not appeared in the records of the world he had grown up in. I studied the repair shed.

"People in there work on engines?"

"Some do."

"Good. People who know a machine can usually tell you which nigga keeps breaking it."

Pike wanted to send a full patrol squad. Storm shook her head. Voss was still free somewhere in the surrounding sky, and the

academy had thousands of people to protect. We could take a small team through. The rest had to hold the way home.

I chose Tank, Shawna, Victor, and Petra.

Rosa stood up immediately.

“No.”

Tank looked at her.

“Baby—”

“You not disappearing into another century while I wait upstairs wondering if some dead motherfucker got lucky.”

He opened his mouth.

She put a finger against his chest.

“I know what I'm saying.”

Mercedes stood beside Petra.

“Same.”

Porsche looked around the room.

“Nigga, y'all not leaving me to explain all this to the luggage.”

I looked at Storm.

She looked at the ring, then the vehicles waiting beyond the chamber doors.

“The limit is power draw and transport space,” she said. “Not whether someone seems impressive on a roster.”

“Good,” Shawna said. “Because the roster didn't open the cells.”

We settled it the way my people settled things: by deciding what each of us could do and trusting each other to do it. Rosa would help move prisoners and keep people together. Mercedes had worked enough crowded rooms to read a frightened group before it turned into a crush. Porsche spoke French well enough to make Marcellus raise both eyebrows when she finally admitted it.

“My first serious boyfriend was from Marseille,” she said.

“You never mentioned that,” Tank told her.

“Nigga, you never asked me a question that wasn't about where I parked.”

Vega would come as the doctor. Reiss would remain with Storm to hold the return point. Marcellus stayed at Sky High with Lena and the freed prisoners; he said somebody needed to keep track of people while all the beautiful idiots went charging through a clock.

“You calling me beautiful?” Tank asked.

Marcellus looked at him over his glasses.

“I included you in a group. Don't get greedy.”

Bell prepared three vehicles. My dark blue police Lamborghini. Tank's black Mercedes. A broad academy rescue van with room for supplies and people who could not walk. They would run on

ordinary ground once through the door. Their sky-lane receivers would have nothing to hold onto in the other year.

“No roads made of light,” Bell said.

Tank looked almost moved.

“Nigga, finally some pavement with manners.”

We were not taking a convoy large enough to empty the whole depot in one trip. The papers showed trucks and rail carriages already there. Getting the prisoners to the door would depend partly on what they knew and what we could secure when we arrived.

I didn't love uncertainty.

I loved pretending it scared me even less.

While Bell worked, my phone rang again. Knox had seen the prison footage. This time she didn't begin with a joke.

“You have what you need?”

I looked around the chamber at my people. Shawna speaking with Vega. Tank listening to Rosa. Victor beside Petra, testing one small spark between his fingers. Porsche arguing with Bell about whether the rescue van had a proper heater.

“Mostly.”

“I asked about equipment, Captain.”

“So did I.”

She was quiet for a second.

Then she said, “Bring them back.”

“That's the plan.”

“And Aiden?”

“Yeah?”

“If anybody asks which department sent you, say mine.”

I smiled.

“Chief, you sure you want that paperwork?”

“Nigga, I want the picture.”

At noon, Voss tried to take his machine back.

The first sign was a low metallic boom above us. Dust sifted from the ceiling. Storm looked up sharply. The control lights flickered.

Pike's voice burst over the radio.

“Three armed skiffs approaching the lower service bridge.”

Tank closed the Mercedes door.

“This nigga don't know when the party over.”

I went toward the bridge with him and Victor. Shawna followed, because apparently I still needed reminding that marriage was a formation.

The skiffs hovered outside the maintenance windows. Black hulls. Men crouched behind their rails. A loudspeaker crackled.

“Surrender the core and release Commander Sable.”

I looked at the speaker.

“Nigga, he asking for refunds.”

Victor's hands lit.

Vega's voice came over his radio immediately.

“Brief use.”

He stared at the radio.

“How does she always know?”

“Because she a doctor and you a patient. That relationship follows a nigga.”

The first skiff fired into the bridge. Glass shattered over us. We dropped behind the stone wall. Tank pulled a maintenance worker down beside him and held him there while the man tried to explain that he had only come to change a light.

“Nigga, the whole light changing. Stay down.”

I returned fire through the broken window. The skiff veered. Victor sent a short bolt into its steering ring, and the craft spun away toward an empty service platform. The men aboard scrambled to hold on.

The second skiff came lower, aiming for the transfer chamber's outer doors.

Shawna saw it before I did.

“They're going underneath.”

We ran back down the passage. The chamber doors shook under the first impact. Bell stood behind the Heart's reinforced housing with two tools in each hand and the expression of a man prepared to defend his profession physically.

“Move the van,” I told him.

“Where?”

“Away from the part I'm about to use.”

I got into the Lamborghini.

Shawna got in beside me.

The outer doors buckled inward.

Beyond them the second skiff hung level with the floor, its nose pressed against the damaged frame. Two gunmen prepared to jump across.

I turned on the police lights.

They paused.

Nigga, even in the sky, a man with a gun could still have an unresolved feeling about a traffic stop.

I drove straight at them.

Not out into the air. Into the heavy rolling barrier parked beside the entrance. The Lamborghini shoved it across the floor and into the skiff's nose. The craft rocked backward. Its gunmen fell

against each other. Bell hit the emergency shutters, and a steel screen came down between us and the sky.

The skiff crashed against the outside.

The third fled before Storm's wind reached it.

When I got out, Bell stared at the Lamborghini's newest dent.

I held up one finger.

“That was barely a trip.”

He covered his face with two hands and pointed at the van with the other two.

“Please just go save people in another year.”

We finished preparing under guard.

That evening, Shawna and I went back to our room for twenty minutes. We washed. Changed. Stood at the balcony looking out over a sky that had somehow become familiar in four days.

She wore dark trousers, boots, and a blue sweater beneath her jacket. The medal lay on the dresser. Her ring remained on her hand. Dante's watch ticked against her wrist.

My cross rested outside my shirt.

She touched its engraved back.

“Damn, boy,” she said softly.

“Magnificent.”

She smiled.

“You really believe that.”

“Baby, you engraved supporting evidence.”

She pulled me toward her. We kissed slowly, without an audience, without somebody announcing that the sky had developed another emergency. I held the back of her head and felt how much I wanted all the future waiting after this one difficult tomorrow.

“You scared?” she asked.

“Yeah.”

She nodded.

No disappointment. No surprise.

Just her hand tightening in mine.

“Me too.”

We stood there another minute. Then she picked up her jacket.

“Come on. That woman been waiting.”

When we returned to the chamber, everybody was ready.

Lena had come down with Marcellus to see us off. She took Rosa's hands and sang one clear note. Rosa answered it. No secret code. Just two singers promising to recognize each other when the door opened again.

Storm stood at the controls.

The Heart glowed behind its glass.

“One branch,” she said. “One outward passage. One return. I hold this side. Reiss holds the alignment. You bring everyone you can back through the same point.”

I nodded.

She turned the first ring.

Blue light crawled around the frame.

The second ring moved.

Cold entered the room before the view did.

Then the metal circle filled with a snow-covered rail yard beneath an evening sky. A low station. A repair shed. The dark shape of a train. Beyond them, a building with barred windows and a light burning in one upper room.

The place where somebody had seen us leave.

I started the Lamborghini.

Tank started the Mercedes behind me. The rescue van's engine joined ours.

Shawna reached across and touched my arm.

“Ready?”

I looked at her. At my wife, who could have stayed in a room above the clouds and had instead chosen this impossible road beside me.

“Nigga,” I said softly, “I been ready for you my whole life.”

She laughed once and wiped her eye with the heel of her hand.

Then I put the car in gear.

The snow beyond the door began turning blue beneath my police lights.

9. The Wrong Men Saw the Blue Lights

Snow hit my windshield.

Real snow. Heavy, wet, dirty at the edges of the rail yard. The Lamborghini's tires crunched onto ground that had never heard an engine like mine, and every man carrying a gun turned toward the sound.

I gave them the siren too.

Nigga, if we were introducing ourselves to a century, we were going to enunciate.

Shawna sat very still beside me. Behind us Tank's Mercedes crossed the shining circle, followed by the rescue van. For a second I could see Sky High's clean floor in my mirror, Storm standing at the controls, blue light reflected in her white shirt.

Then Reiss narrowed the opening to a dim seam. He would keep the return boundary alive without leaving a bright invitation for Keller's soldiers. We would signal when we needed it widened. The machinery remained connected; the way home had become small, not gone.

Ahead of us stood the station.

A man in a gray coat shouted something.

Porsche's voice came through the van radio.

“He wants us to stop.”

“Nigga, I gathered the mood.”

The soldier raised his gun.

I drove past him before he could decide where the noise ended and the car began. His shot cracked behind us. Tank swerved the Mercedes between the soldier and the van. Victor sent one bright bolt through the man's weapon, knocking it from his hands.

The soldier fell into the snow holding his wrist.

Nobody stopped to explain electricity to him.

We crossed the yard toward the repair shed. Its doors stood open. A woman in a dark work coat watched us from inside, a heavy wrench in one hand. For one second her face was all astonishment.

Then she saw the guards running behind us.

She swung the shed door wider.

That was all the permission I needed.

The Lamborghini shot inside. The Mercedes followed. Petra drove the van through last, and the woman with the wrench pulled the door shut behind it.

Tank got out laughing once, hard.

“Nigga, pavement. I missed your ugly ass.”

The woman looked at him. Looked at the cars. Looked at Shawna stepping out beside me with her gun held low.

She spoke French.

Porsche answered.

I heard my name, heard something that sounded like police, heard the woman make a disbelieving noise at the sight of my badge.

Porsche turned to me.

“She's asking if we're the people from the blue door.”

“Tell her yes.”

The woman's eyes filled before her face allowed anything else to change.

“Miriam Levin,” she said in careful English. “I work here.”

She tapped the wrench against her palm.

“Not by choice.”

“Aiden.”

She looked at the Lamborghini.

“I have many questions.”

“We going to earn you time for them.”

Outside, boots approached. Miriam pulled a canvas cover over the nearest window. She knew the shed's blind corners, the little

door behind a stack of wheels, the place where a loose floor panel could hide six people or one awkwardly positioned Tank.

She didn't hide us there.

She went to the main door and shouted in German.

A guard shouted back.

Her voice became angry in a way that sounded practiced and dangerous. She pointed toward the roof. The guard looked up.

Victor moved behind him.

The man came inside unconscious before his eyes finished coming down.

Miriam shut the door again.

Porsche stared at her.

“What did you say?”

“That his bullets would damage the fuel pipes, and Keller would have him shot for ruining the work.”

Tank looked at the roof.

“Fuel pipes up there?”

“No.”

He smiled at her with open admiration.

“Ma'am, I like how you think.”

More guards were coming. We could hear them gathering outside, trying to understand the three impossible cars now concealed in a building full of tools they did understand.

Miriam led us through the small rear door into a passage beside the holding building. A man waited there with a bundle of cloth under one arm. He was lean, bearded, and tired enough that his eyes looked older than the rest of his face.

“David,” Miriam said.

David Adler. Thirty-four. A physician. Jewish, like Miriam. He had been forced to work in Keller's infirmary and had spent every day since trying to keep people alive with too little medicine and too many orders.

Vega stepped forward.

“Dr. Marisol Vega.”

He looked at her medical bag.

For the first time since we crossed the door, I saw a man look at something other than my car as if it might be a miracle.

“You have supplies?”

“Show me who needs them.”

He did not waste a second on amazement. He took her toward the infirmary. Rosa and Mercedes followed, carrying bags from the van.

Miriam stayed with us.

“There are fewer guards at the rear building now,” she said.

“Most are watching your door. They think your machines are an attack.”

I looked toward the sound of men shouting in the yard.

“Finally, some accurate thinking.”

She gave me a sharp little smile.

Then she took us to the woman who had seen me leave.

Her name was Léonie Arnaud. Twenty-nine. She had carried messages for a resistance group before her arrest. She stood behind the holding building's service window with a cut on her lower lip and a folded strip of fabric tied around one hand.

When she saw me, she didn't cry.

She gripped the window bars.

“You came back.”

“Told myself I would.”

“I told them you would too.”

Behind her, faces appeared in the dim room. Men and women. Young adults and older adults. People standing because sitting would have hidden the window. People too tired to stand who looked up from benches when the others made room.

I felt Shawna's hand at my back.

Léonie looked at her.

Something passed between them before either spoke.

“We're getting this open,” Shawna said.

Miriam showed Petra the door.

Petra turned her hands to stone.

Léonie stepped back and told the others to move away from the frame.

The door came inward with one heavy crack.

Nobody cheered.

They listened for the guards.

That hurt more than cheering would have helped.

Shawna went inside first.

“We have a way out. We need you together. We need you listening to the people who know this place. If someone can't walk, tell us now.”

Léonie translated where she needed to. Porsche helped. Miriam moved through the room calling names, asking about injuries, touching shoulders with the quick certainty of a woman who knew exactly who had been missing from breakfast.

I watched her count.

Not numbers first.

People.

Then the rear yard filled with shouting.

The guards had found the empty side of the repair shed.

Tank stepped into the passage beside me.

“How many?”

“Enough to be rude.”

He looked at my badge.

“You arresting these niggas?”

I looked at the uniforms coming around the corner. At the weapons raised toward a door full of people they had locked away.

“Depends how cooperative the evening gets.”

The first shots tore into the brick above us.

The evening was not cooperative.

We answered from the corner while Victor moved across the roof. He used his charge in short bursts, dropping weapons, darkening lamps, giving people space to move. He was not an endless lightning storm. After the third burst, he braced one hand on the chimney and breathed hard.

Tank pulled a metal cart into the passage as cover. I fired around it. Shawna moved the prisoners toward the repair shed while Petra stood between them and the open yard, bullets striking marble shoulders.

A man on the far side of the yard stared at Petra and lowered his gun in pure disbelief.

Miriam threw her wrench.

It hit him square in the face.

“Stop staring,” she said.

Tank looked at her.

“Ma'am.”

“He was blocking the path.”

“Yes, ma'am.”

The prisoners moved. Some supported each other. One older woman, Rivka, sixty, refused to leave until a man named Jakob had his violin case. Not because the case mattered more than life. Because he had been using its strap to help an injured friend walk, and she had noticed when everyone else missed it.

Jakob reached us with the case across his back and his friend's arm over his shoulders.

I caught the other side.

“I got him.”

Jakob looked at me, then at the police lights still flashing through the shed's covered window.

“What country are you from?”

“Long story.”

“Are you winning?”

I tightened my hold on his friend.

“Nigga, look who walking out.”

He didn't know all my words.

He understood that one.

Inside the repair shed, Vega and David worked together over two stretchers. Rosa kept a little clear space around them by the force of her voice alone. Mercedes brought water. Porsche translated a frightened man's questions until his breathing slowed enough for him to answer one of hers.

“Thirty-eight here,” Miriam told me. “Twenty-one in the infirmary and east rooms. The rest at the machine building.”

“Eighty-three still?”

She shook her head.

“Eighty-six. Three arrived yesterday.”

I nodded.

Three more names for the world to keep.

A loudspeaker crackled over the yard.

Keller's voice arrived smooth and amplified.

Porsche listened. Her face hardened.

“He says return the prisoners and he'll permit us to leave.”

I looked around the shed. At the people beginning to believe the door in front of them might open outward. At my wife carrying a cup to a man whose hands shook too badly to hold it alone.

“Tell him I ain't taking requests.”

“He can't hear me from here.”

I glanced at the Lamborghini.

Its police loudspeaker waited behind the siren switch.

Tank saw where I was looking and grinned.

“This nigga brought amplification.”

I got into the car and lifted the microphone.

“Colonel Keller.”

My voice rolled across the yard.

The guards stopped shouting.

“I'm Captain Aiden. You got eighty-six people that belong to themselves. I'm collecting every fucking one.”

Porsche translated beside me into French, then Miriam shouted the essential demand in German from the doorway.

Keller answered immediately.

His voice was angry now.

Good. Some men sounded worse when they were pretending to be reasonable.

Miriam listened, then looked at me.

“He says you have no authority here.”

I looked at the medal ribbon peeking from Shawna's jacket. At Tank loading people into the van's warm interior. At the broken prison door lying where Petra had put it.

“Nigga,” I said into the microphone, “the door disagrees.”

I lowered it and got out.

Léonie stood beside the rear exit, watching the road beyond the yard.

“He will bring men from the barracks,” she said. “We cannot hold this shed all night.”

“Then we don't.”

“The return door is between us and them.”

Miriam joined us. She pointed toward the old service track running behind the shed.

“There is another engine in the machine building. A locomotive. Keller uses it to move the experimental carriages. If we can bring the people there, we can bring the train to your door.”

I looked at the tracks disappearing into the dark.

A train. Of course a nigga's first trip through time needed a train.

Shawna came beside me.

“What you thinking?”

I looked back at the Lamborghini, sitting in the shed like the future had parked wrong on purpose.

“Thinking we gonna make transportation very fucking confusing.”

10. My Wife Was Already Inside

Miriam drew the depot in soot on the repair shed's concrete floor.

No ruler. No hesitation. She marked the holding rooms, the infirmary, the machine building, the barracks, and the command house on the little rise beyond the tracks. Then she drew a narrow line beneath the largest building.

“Drainage passage,” she said. “It floods in spring. It is clear now.”

Tank crouched beside her.

“How clear?”

She looked at his shoulders.

“You will hate it.”

“Nigga, I can hate things while fitting through them.”

“Not this one.”

Rosa laughed softly from beside the stretchers. Tank looked at her.

“You supposed to support my dimensions.”

“Baby, I do. That's why I know you ain't fitting.”

For a second, the people nearest us smiled. Then the sound of boots outside brought their faces back to the room they were in.

We didn't have much time. Keller's men held the route to the return door. The prisoners in the machine building would be moved before dawn if the colonel decided the yard could not be secured. Some modern captives wore the same power-draining restraints Finn had used on Victor. Others had no gifts at all and were there because Keller had a use for their hands or Voss wanted people who could not fight back with lightning.

Shawna knelt beside Miriam's drawing.

"This passage comes up where?"

"Under the boiler room."

"Can you take us?"

Miriam nodded.

"Then take us."

I looked at my wife.

She looked back before I said anything.

"You making the loud part, aren't you?"

I looked at Tank.

The nigga was already smiling.

"We have some experience."

Our loud part would be a meeting.

Keller had offered to talk. He clearly believed a man could arrive in an impossible car, rescue thirty-eight prisoners, and still be persuaded by an expensive desk. I had met niggas like that in every year I'd personally occupied.

He wanted the vehicles, the return mechanism, and the people we had taken out of his rooms. He especially wanted Victor and Petra, whose gifts had made his soldiers frightened enough to forget their training. Reiss had warned us Keller thought power was something he could own by putting the right body behind the right lock.

I intended to waste his time beautifully.

Shawna, Miriam, Petra, Mercedes, and Porsche would go through the drainage passage. Victor would stay with the shed group to protect them and conserve his strength. Vega and David would prepare the injured to move. Rosa and Léonie would guide the first group toward the machine building once the way opened.

Tank and I would take the Lamborghini to the command house.

“He will search you,” Miriam warned.

“He can look.”

“He will take your weapons.”

Tank flexed both hands.

“Nigga gonna need a bigger pocket.”

Miriam studied him, then me, and shook her head in something halfway between disbelief and reluctant affection.

“You are either the luckiest men I have ever met, or the most dangerous.”

“Both can fit in one car,” I said.

Before we separated, Shawna pulled me into the narrow space beside the van. She adjusted my collar. There was soot on her cheek. A small tear at the cuff of her sweater. Her eyes were steady.

“Don't get so busy impressing that bastard you forget what we're doing.”

“Baby, I can multitask.”

“Aiden.”

I put my forehead against hers.

“I know.”

We stayed like that for a breath. Then she kissed me once, hard, and went back to Miriam.

I watched her walk away with the women.

That was the part nobody applauded. The part where my greatest strength became a person going somewhere I couldn't stand between her and every gun. I had to trust her skill, her nerve, her right to be more than somebody I protected.

Nigga, trusting that woman had already made my life bigger than Vegas.

I kept doing it.

Outside the shed, a white cloth hung from the Lamborghini's antenna. Keller's men watched us emerge. I drove slowly, police lights turning the snow blue, engine making a low promise beneath the hood.

Tank sat beside me looking out at the guards.

“These niggas dressed like they own the night.”

“Then somebody better tell these niggas morning coming.”

At the command house, two soldiers motioned us to stop. The building had once been somebody's country home. Its windows were tall, its stonework elegant, its front steps worn by years of people whose ordinary lives had been shoved aside for Keller's office.

I thought about the people who had owned those steps.

Then I got out.

The guards stared at the car.

One of them actually walked around it before remembering he was supposed to be searching me. He touched the dark blue paint with one finger and looked at the gold number still on the door.

“First place,” I told him.

He didn't understand.

Tank did.

“Nigga, this car been winning in two centuries.”

The search was rough and thorough. They took our guns. They took Tank's knife. They tried to take my badge.

I caught the soldier's wrist.

Every weapon on the steps lifted.

Tank went very still beside me.

I looked into the guard's eyes.

“That stays.”

For one long second nobody moved.

Then an officer appeared in the doorway and snapped an order. The guard pulled his hand away. The badge stayed inside my jacket.

Keller wanted to meet the man with the strange rank intact.

Fine.

I would give him the full experience.

Inside, the house smelled of tobacco, polished wood, and food people in the shed had not been allowed to eat. A fire burned in the drawing room. Maps covered one wall. On a side table stood a bottle of brandy and a silver dish piled with pears.

Tank looked at the pears.

I looked at him.

We both remembered David counting cups of water.

Keller waited behind a desk.

He was in his forties, broad-faced, with close-cut hair and a neat uniform. He rose when we entered, not from courtesy but because he liked controlling the height of a conversation.

He spoke English.

“Captain Aiden.”

“Colonel.”

“Your arrival has caused considerable disruption.”

“Nigga, that's the small package.”

Tank coughed once into his fist.

Keller's eyes flicked toward him, then back to me.

“You come from Voss's world.”

“I come from mine.”

“And you believe that makes you untouchable.”

“No. I believe the people you locked up want to leave. We should focus on their travel arrangements.”

He sat.

I remained standing.

That bothered him immediately.

Good. I was supposed to keep him occupied.

He spoke about order. About valuable work. About enemies. He tried dressing every ugly thing he had done in a clean word and putting it on the desk between us as if I might buy it.

I let him speak.

Not because he deserved an audience.

Because beneath the depot my wife was moving through a dark passage toward twenty-seven people who deserved a door.

When Keller paused, I picked up a pear.

He stared.

I took a bite.

Tank picked up two.

“You may find,” Keller said coldly, “that your manner is less amusing here.”

“Nigga, I ain't performing for you.”

I set the pear down.

“You got ninety seconds to explain why a man with all these soldiers is scared of people carrying laundry.”

His face flushed.

He rang the bell on his desk.

I heard boots in the corridor.

Good.

More men coming here meant fewer men standing over Shawna. Later she told me what happened while I was making the colonel hate fruit.

The passage was low and cold. Water soaked their boots. Miriam led with a small lamp, one hand on the wall. Petra had to turn sideways in two places, and Porsche quietly apologized to every expensive shoe she had ever complained about wearing. They reached the boiler room beneath the machine building. Voices drifted through a grate overhead. Someone coughed. A chain dragged across concrete.

Miriam listened.

“They haven't moved them yet.”

Shawna touched her arm.

“How many doors?”

“Two. One locked from the hall.”

Petra smiled in the dark.

“That's a very short problem.”

She lifted the grate quietly enough that the hinges complained less than Porsche's boots. The women climbed into a storage room smelling of hot metal and damp cloth. Mercedes found a coat hanging beside the door and put it on. In the dim corridor, with a bundle of laundry in her arms and her head lowered, she

looked like another person the guards had trained themselves not to see.

Shawna hated that part when she told me.

It worked because the guards had stopped seeing people.

Mercedes crossed the hall. Stumbled. Dropped the laundry in front of a guard carrying keys. He swore and bent down to shove it aside.

Petra took him into the storage room.

The laundry stayed in the hall.

The keys did not.

They opened the first room.

Inside sat eleven adults wearing black restraints. A woman with pale blue hair looked up and began crying so suddenly Shawna knelt beside her before she understood why.

“I saw you on the train video,” the woman said. “The captain's wife.”

Shawna touched her shoulder.

“That's me.”

“They told us nobody knew.”

“We know now.”

Miriam helped Porsche open the restraints with the keys. The pale-haired woman introduced herself as Amaya Tide, thirty, a

swimming instructor from the present who could shape water in short, forceful waves. She had no strength left for it at first. Mercedes gave her water to drink instead of asking her to become useful.

That detail mattered when Shawna told me.

I loved my people for knowing the difference.

The second room held sixteen more adults. Some from the present. Some from that year. A man named Tomas Varga, thirty-three, Romani, had been forced to repair the train brakes. He knew the locomotive better than Keller's own driver because he had been the one keeping it from breaking beneath the colonel's demands.

He also knew the guard coming down the hall.

Tomas stepped out before Shawna could stop him and began arguing about the locomotive. The guard answered angrily. They moved toward the far door together, away from the room where people were standing for the first time without restraints around their arms.

Miriam whispered to Shawna, "He is buying time."

Shawna went after him.

She wasn't about to spend a man as a distraction and leave him there.

At the end of the corridor, the guard raised his weapon toward Tomas.

My wife struck the guard from behind with a metal lamp.

He fell into a pile of his own interrupted orders.

Tomas stared at her.

She handed him the lamp.

“Keep it. Apparently they're useful.”

In Keller's office, four soldiers entered behind us.

Tank finished his second pear.

The colonel rose.

“You will remain here until I decide how to proceed.”

I looked at the clock above his fireplace.

Enough time had passed for Shawna to reach the rooms.

I hoped.

“Nigga,” I said, “you should decide faster.”

Keller came around the desk. He stopped close enough for me to see the little vein beating beside his temple.

“You do not frighten me.”

“Then why you keep calling more niggas into the room?”

Tank smiled around the pear.

Keller hit the fruit out of his hand.

For a second everything became very still.

Tank looked at the pear on the floor.

Then at Keller.

“Nigga,” he said softly, “that was the last good decision you had available.”

Outside, a locomotive whistle rose through the night.

My wife had reached the train.

I smiled at the colonel.

“There she go.”

11. The Colonel Had Never Been That Embarrassed

The whistle was still sounding when Tank hit the first soldier.

Nigga, the pear hadn't even stopped rolling.

He moved with the terrible speed of a man who had been asked to wait politely while somebody mistook cruelty for authority. One hand caught the soldier's gun. The other caught his coat. Tank put both items, with the man still unfortunately attached, through the drawing room's small decorative table.

The table had probably survived generations.

It had not been introduced to Tank before.

I drove Keller back against his desk. The second soldier swung toward me. I caught the desk lamp and threw it at his face. Brass struck bone. His shot went through the chandelier. Glass came down around us in a glittering rain that made the room briefly resemble a cheaper version of my banquet.

“Nigga,” Tank said, ducking under the falling pieces, “we can't go nowhere formal.”

The third soldier hit me in the ribs. I felt the old wound flare, hot and intimate, the way history liked reminding me it didn't have to be eighty years old to hurt. I folded just enough to make him think the blow had finished something. Then I came up under his chin and drove him into the map-covered wall.

Keller crawled toward the side door.

I saw him go.

So did Tank.

“Your meeting leaving,” my brother said.

“Let it warm the car.”

The fourth soldier had better judgment than the first three. He backed toward the corridor with his weapon level, keeping enough distance that neither of us could reach him without paying for it. I stood still. Tank stood still. The man's hands shook but his aim didn't wander.

Behind him, a servant stepped out of the kitchen carrying a large iron pot.

She was perhaps fifty, gray-haired, broad through the shoulders, with flour on one sleeve and a face that had run out of patience long before we arrived.

She hit the soldier with the pot.

The sound was magnificent.

He dropped.

She looked at us and spoke French.

I didn't understand the sentence.

I understood the tone of a woman who had waited too long to use her cookware honestly.

“Thank you, ma'am,” I said.

Tank nodded with deep respect.

“That pot earned a medal.”

She pointed toward the front door, where an engine started.

We moved.

Outside, Keller climbed into a long black staff car. Guards crowded around it. The Lamborghini stood at the foot of the steps, beautiful and wrong among all their dull military shapes. One of the soldiers had opened its door and was staring at the dashboard as if the future had left him a difficult exam.

I ran down the steps.

He raised his head.

“Get out my fucking car.”

The tone translated itself.

He scrambled away. Tank caught our confiscated weapons from a guard who was too busy watching Keller flee to notice his own evening ending. We got into the Lamborghini as shots struck the stone behind us.

I started the engine.

The whole yard heard it wake.

Keller's car accelerated down the drive.

I followed him.

The road curved between bare trees, dipped through a hollow, and came out above the depot. Snow packed the edges. The sky was deep black now, with one cold strip of moonlight laid across the hills. My headlights caught the staff car ahead, its tires slipping as the driver tried to make an old machine answer a new kind of fear.

I could have caught him on the first straight.

Then I saw the truck coming up the side road full of soldiers heading toward the machine building.

My wife was at the machine building.

Keller could enjoy another minute of existence.

I turned across the truck's path.

The driver saw a dark blue car sliding sideways into his headlights and did what any sensible man would do when faced with a nigga operating above his century's expectations.

He panicked.

The truck swerved into a snowbank. Men fell over each other in the back. The Lamborghini straightened along the ditch, close enough to the bare trees that branches slapped my window.

Tank laughed.

“This nigga using the weather.”

“Available resource.”

A second truck appeared behind the first. Its passengers raised weapons. I swung the car down the narrow lane toward the depot's west gate. Bullets cracked against stone markers behind us. Tank fired back through the open window, forcing the men down while I kept the car between the road's ruts.

At the gate stood a guard booth and a heavy barrier.

The barrier began lowering.

I did not slow.

Tank looked at it.

Looked at me.

“Nigga, that thing old but solid.”

“So was the table.”

I took the narrow gap beside the booth. One side of the Lamborghini climbed the bank. The car tilted. Its mirror struck the booth window, showering the guard inside with glass. We passed the barrier on two wheels and landed in the yard with the engine screaming and the police lights still politely announcing our profession.

On the machine building's steps, Tomas Varga stopped carrying a toolbox and stared.

Miriam stood beside him.

She covered her mouth.

Then she laughed.

Not at the danger. At the sight of Keller's certainty getting chased through its own gate by a car it couldn't begin to understand.

I pulled up in front of them.

“My wife?”

Miriam pointed inside.

“Already working.”

Of course she was.

Inside the machine building, the world sounded different. No guards shouting over prisoners. People calling instructions to one another. Metal moving because somebody wanted it moved, not because a gun had suggested they should. A low engine beat beneath the floor. Lamps burned over open doors.

Shawna stood beside a long black locomotive with one hand on a rail and the other holding a list Miriam had torn from Keller's office wall. Her hair had escaped its tie. There was oil on her sweater. She looked up when I entered and smiled so fiercely I forgot the pain in my ribs.

“You late.”

“Baby, the colonel needed help leaving his own house.”

She came to me. Touched my cheek where Keller's guard had caught me. Her thumb came away with a small smear of blood.

“You okay?”

“Nigga, look at you. You stole a whole railroad.”

“Miriam stole the railroad. I handled customer complaints.”

Miriam came in behind me and shook her head.

“We are borrowing it.”

Tank looked at the locomotive.

“Ma'am, I support whatever makes the wheels move.”

The rescue had become larger than us in the hour we had spent at Keller's house. Léonie and Rosa had brought the first thirty-eight people from the shed through the service passage. David and Vega moved the twenty-one from the infirmary and eastern rooms on stretchers, carts, and chairs carried between volunteers. The twenty-seven freed from the machine rooms were already helping prepare the train.

Eighty-six.

Nobody missing from the count.

That did not make them safe yet.

But it made them together, and together was the first shape escape had taken that night.

Tomas had worked out which engine could pull the carriages. Miriam knew the yard's old signal box and which tracks led to the transfer chamber. David knew who could endure a rough ride and who needed to be moved gently. Léonie knew where Keller's patrols gathered when the depot alarm sounded.

My greatness did not make those facts appear in my head.

It meant I listened when the people who knew them spoke.

Then I made the loud parts behave.

Victor returned through the rear entrance with Amaya beside him. She had recovered enough to pull water from a broken pipe and cast it across a pursuing guard's path. In the cold yard, the sudden sheet had sent three soldiers sliding into one another. Victor looked so impressed she almost smiled despite her exhaustion.

"You should teach at Sky High," he told her.

"I used to teach swimming."

"Start there. Improve the place."

She looked toward the people gathering around the train.

"I would like a pool with no locks."

"Then that's the pool," I said.

She turned toward me.

I held her gaze until she understood I wasn't filling the air just because I could.

"That's the pool."

A crack of gunfire came from the north doors.

Petra stepped into the opening and turned to marble. Mercedes pulled a cart of blankets clear behind her. The soldiers outside

saw the same woman their bullets had failed to move earlier and reconsidered their approach with visible irritation.

Tank joined her with a grin.

“Stone lady, you taking the left?”

“I am the left.”

“Outstanding.”

We held the doors while the boarding began. Petra drove the rescue van onto the first of two flat wagons near the locomotive, and Rosa brought the Mercedes onto the next with Tank shouting encouragement loud enough to be heard from the doors. Miriam had found the loading ramp. Tomas knew which wagons could carry the weight. The last empty flat wagon waited behind the passenger carriages, and I intended to use it once everybody else was aboard.

It was not a clean little sequence where everybody found a seat because the hero had arrived. A man froze at the sight of another train. His breath stopped coming properly. David went to him, spoke softly, and asked him to look at the people carrying the stretchers instead of the guards outside. Rivka sat beside a woman who would not let go of her small cloth bag. Nobody tried to take it from her. Jakob helped a younger man climb the step, then went back for another.

Shawna moved along the carriages counting again.

Names where she knew names.

Hands where she didn't yet.

I saw her put my medal around the neck of a frightened man so she could say, “Hold this until I come back,” and give him something concrete to wait for.

Nigga, they could have given me every medal in the school. None would have looked better than that one did in his hands.

Outside, Keller's voice returned over a loudspeaker.

He had reached the yard in a second vehicle, surrounded by enough men to make his earlier courage seem even more affordable. He ordered the prisoners to surrender. He ordered the guards to retake the building. He ordered the night to become something it had already stopped being.

I stepped onto the locomotive's side platform with the police microphone Bell had linked to our portable radio.

“Colonel.”

My voice came out through the Lamborghini parked by the doors.

He looked toward it.

“You left your house a mess.”

Tank bent double laughing for one dangerous second before the gunfire made him straighten.

Keller shouted an order.

His men advanced.

Victor rose above the locomotive in a flare of blue. He did not strike every soldier. He struck the lamps over the yard, plunging the advancing line into confusion while Petra and Tank held the lit doorway. I covered the right side. Shawna got the final stretcher aboard.

“Eighty-six!” she shouted.

Tomas answered from the cab.

The locomotive gave a deep, living shudder.

Wheels moved.

Miriam climbed onto the side step with a lantern. Léonie pulled the last carriage door closed. Rosa stood inside beside the injured, one hand on the wall, her voice steady above the growing clatter.

Tank backed toward the train.

“Aiden!”

I looked at the Lamborghini.

At the train.

At the open flat wagon behind its last carriage.

Nigga, a solution can be beautiful before it is remotely sensible.

I ran to the car.

Shawna saw me move and swore with love in every syllable.

“Aiden, you better not—”

I started the engine.

The train gathered speed.

The flat wagon passed the loading ramp.

I drove up it.

For one glorious, foolish second my Lamborghini flew beside a locomotive in a year that had no business knowing either my name or my insurance problem.

Then the tires hit the wagon.

The car bounced. Slid. Stopped with six inches between the bumper and the edge.

Tank climbed onto the wagon after me and stared through the window.

“Nigga.”

I turned off the engine.

“We need it to get home.”

He looked at the eighty-six people moving away from Keller's building, then at the car sitting on a train like it had purchased the railroad.

“This nigga don't travel. He escalates transportation.”

I got out and climbed toward the carriage where my wife waited.

Behind us, the machine building receded into smoke and confusion.

Ahead, the tracks curved toward the blue door.

Between us and it, Keller was already moving men into the yard.

We had everybody aboard.

Now we had to make the road belong to them.

12. The Train Had Eighty-Six Reasons to Move

The first time somebody shot at my Lamborghini while it was parked on a moving train, I experienced a new and very specific kind of offense.

Nigga, the car wasn't even participating.

A bullet struck the wagon rail. Another skipped across the rear fender. Tank dropped beside me behind the engine block and looked toward the soldiers running along the service road.

“These niggas shooting the luggage now.”

“That's not luggage.”

“It's riding while we do the work.”

I fired back from the wagon's edge. The soldiers scattered behind a stack of timber. The train clattered past them, slow enough to make every yard feel negotiated. Tomas had warned us this engine had been used for hauling, not speed. Keller's experimental equipment made it stronger than it should have been, but strength didn't make old rails straighter.

Ahead of us, Miriam stood in the locomotive cab with a lantern. She knew the points leading to the transfer chamber. She also knew Keller would know that she knew.

Sure enough, the first junction sent us the wrong way.

The track bent toward a loading basin instead of the blue door.

Tomas sounded the whistle.

Three short blasts.

Léonie leaned out of the carriage and shouted something toward the cab. Miriam answered. Porsche translated over the radio before I could ask.

“The signal house is occupied. They changed the route.”

I looked ahead.

A narrow brick tower stood beside the junction, its upper windows lit. Two guards watched the train approach. Beyond it, the wrong track ended at a line of parked freight wagons.

We would have to stop.

Stopping would give Keller his prisoners back within reach.

I was not doing that.

“Victor.”

He appeared on the carriage roof, pale in the moonlight.

“I see it.”

“How much you got?”

He looked at the tower. Flexed his hand. One small thread of blue crossed his palm.

“Enough to get you there.”

“Nigga, I was hoping you would say enough to get you there.”

He smiled tiredly.

“You wanted first place.”

“This nigga remembered rivalry at the worst time.”

Victor caught my arm and lifted us from the wagon. For one breath the train moved beneath our feet and the whole depot spread below us in lamps and shadows. Then he threw us toward the signal house roof, released me, and landed hard beside the chimney.

I rolled through a roof hatch and dropped into the upper room.

The guards turned.

I hit the first with the hatch itself.

The second reached for his rifle. I caught it between us and drove him back against the wall. The room was small, hot, and full of levers I had no intention of pretending to understand. He kicked my knee. I struck his wrist against the iron window frame until the weapon fell.

Below, the train's brakes shrieked.

Nigga, no time.

I shoved him away and went to the control board.

Miriam's voice came through the radio.

“Do not guess.”

“I wasn't.”

I absolutely had been considering a guess.

She guided me through the one change she needed, using the painted yard numbers instead of asking me to become a railway engineer in the middle of gunfire. I moved the heavy lever she identified. Outside, a set of points shifted. Tomas slowed the locomotive almost to a stop, then reversed just far enough to take the corrected line.

The train moved again.

The people inside it remained moving toward a door they had chosen to reach.

Victor came through the hatch breathing hard.

“Return trip?” I asked.

He looked at his hands.

“Stairs.”

“Nigga, respectable invention.”

We went down together.

At the bottom, a soldier stood blocking the exit. He had his rifle aimed at us. His eyes went from Victor's blue uniform to my badge to the train passing beyond the open door.

I held my gun steady.

“Put it down.”

He didn't understand the words.

He understood the choice.

Slowly, he lowered the rifle and stepped aside.

We took the weapon and left him sitting against the wall. I had no interest in wasting a bullet on a man who had stopped trying to make me use one.

Outside, the last wagon rolled past.

Tank reached down and caught Victor's arm. I grabbed the rail beside them and hauled myself aboard.

My brother looked at us.

“Nigga went to the tower and fixed the whole road.”

“Miriam fixed it.”

“You was the tall tool?”

“Extremely handsome tool.”

Victor laughed so hard he had to sit down before his legs made the decision for him.

The next stretch of track ran beside a drainage canal. On the far bank, trucks gathered. Keller had found the place where he could keep pace with us. His men climbed onto running boards and lifted their weapons toward the carriages.

Petra moved along the outside walkway, turning her body to marble wherever the passengers were most exposed. She could protect one opening at a time. She could not become a wall the length of a train.

Amaya climbed onto the platform behind her.

Mercedes tried to help her sit.

“I can do this,” Amaya said.

“You don't owe us a performance.”

“I know. I owe those people a clear window.”

She looked at the canal.

Raised both hands.

Water climbed the bank in one dark, shining sheet and struck the road beside the trucks. Mud and ice spread under their wheels. The first truck slewed sideways. The second stopped before hitting it. Soldiers jumped down, no longer in a position to fire into the passing carriages.

Amaya sank against the rail.

Mercedes caught her.

“Clear window,” she said softly.

Amaya smiled with her eyes closed.

Inside, Vega and David kept the injured steady through the jolts. Rosa talked to people in a low, continuous voice. Not telling them everything was fine. Telling them what was happening, where they were going, who was sitting beside them. Small facts strong enough to hold when the larger ones felt impossible.

Léonie moved between the carriages, speaking with the people from her year. We had to tell them what the door meant before they reached it. Some wanted refuge in the world we came from. Some had family and work in this branch of the past and could not bear to vanish into an unknown future, even a safer one.

She brought me their choice at the carriage connection.

“There is a resistance shelter beyond the eastern road,” she said.

“I know the route. I know the people. If we clear the depot, those who choose to remain can leave with me.”

I looked at her.

“You staying?”

She nodded.

“My brother is out there. So are people who helped me before I was taken.”

I wasn't going to tell her my beautiful car outranked her life.

“What do you need?”

“The road clear. A vehicle. Food. A doctor to tell us who can travel safely.”

“We can do that.”

She touched my arm.

“You did come back.”

“Yeah.”

“Then believe me when I say I know where I'm going.”

I did.

David chose to stay with that group. Miriam chose the door. She said there was no one left in this place whom she could reach, and she wanted a life Keller had never seen. Tomas chose to remain and drive the people Léonie would guide. Jakob and Rivka chose the door together, carrying the violin case and the cloth bag as if a future could begin with two things held carefully.

Nobody made those choices easily.

Nobody made them for one another.

We planned to take sixty-two through the door: all thirty-one modern captives and thirty-one people from the altered year who chose refuge with us. Twenty-four would leave the cleared depot along the eastern road with Léonie and David. We counted both groups twice. Miriam wrote their names on separate sheets and handed one to Shawna, one to Léonie.

Eighty-six people.

Two roads.

One promise that neither road would end in Keller's hands.

Then the locomotive stopped so hard the whole train shuddered.

I caught Shawna against me before she hit the carriage wall.

Ahead, a metallic crash rang through the yard.

Tomas sounded the whistle again.

This time he held it.

I climbed onto the roof.

Keller stood on the track in front of the engine.

He wore the machine.

Voss's experiment had taken the shape of a black metal frame locked around his shoulders and legs. Heavy coils rose behind his back. A dull blue charge pulsed through them, the same wrong light I had seen in Victor's racing car. It made the colonel taller, broader, grotesquely strong.

His hands gripped the locomotive's front coupling.

Steam poured around him.

The train tried to move.

He held it.

Behind him, soldiers spread across the route to the return chamber.

Keller looked up at me and smiled.

There was triumph in that smile, and something hungrier beneath it. The pleasure of a man who had finally found a way to make his own body match the violence he had been outsourcing.

“Now,” he shouted, “we can discuss authority.”

Tank climbed up beside me.

He looked at Keller.

Looked at the stalled train.

Then looked at me.

“Nigga put on a building.”

I took off my torn jacket and handed it to Shawna when she reached the roof behind us.

She caught my wrist.

“Aiden.”

I looked at her.

“I know.”

The colonel's machine hummed louder.

I could not outmuscle that metal. I had no thunder in my hands. My ribs hurt, my shoulder burned, and the nigga in front of me had stolen enough power to stop a locomotive.

Behind me, sixty-two people watched the door.

Twenty-four watched the eastern road.

I climbed down onto the track.

“Colonel,” I said. “You had to steal a whole machine to feel like a man.”

His smile vanished.

I showed him mine.

“Nigga, watch how little I need.”

13. The Door Opened Both Ways

Keller hit the ground where I had been standing.

The rail bent.

Nigga, I respected the information and moved farther away.

His metal frame made every step heavy enough to shake snow off the locomotive. The blue coils behind his shoulders flared when he lifted his arms. He was strong. Terribly strong. But he turned like a man carrying three other men who disagreed about direction.

I let him learn that in public.

He swung. I stepped inside the arc and struck his face with the heel of my hand. His head snapped back. Not enough to stop him. Enough to make the soldiers behind him see their new miracle get slapped by a nigga in a torn shirt.

Tank roared from the train roof.

“There you go! Educate the big coat!”

Keller grabbed at me. I ducked beneath his arm, rolled across the track, and came up beside the locomotive wheel. His metal fist struck the engine casing. Steam burst between us.

Tomas pulled back inside the cab.

Miriam shouted at me from the side platform.

“He can't keep drawing at that rate!”

I had noticed the machine's ugly rhythm. Every surge made Keller stronger and less steady. Voss had promised him power. Voss had apparently forgotten to promise him a comfortable evening afterward.

Behind the colonel, his soldiers tried to advance.

Petra dropped from the carriage roof into their path, marble from head to heel. Victor joined her with one last useful burst of charge. Weapons sparked. Men fell back. They held the space long enough for Tank to come down and take the left flank.

The train remained full of people.

The people remained the point.

Shawna knew that better than anybody.

While Keller chased me along the engine, she climbed into the cab with Miriam and Tomas. They had to uncouple the empty front wagon from the stalled locomotive's damaged hitch before the carriages could be moved around the blocked line. I did not know how to do that. Tomas did. Miriam knew the adjoining service track. Shawna knew how to keep a gun level while two people worked with their hands.

She gave them room.

I gave her noise.

“Colonel!”

He turned toward my voice.

I stood on the locomotive's running board, one hand on a rail, the other holding my badge where he could see it.

“You under arrest.”

His face twisted.

Tank looked up from behind a wagon wheel.

“Nigga, now?”

“I like the timing.”

Keller charged.

I jumped from the running board to the next wagon. His shoulder struck the locomotive. The whole engine rocked. A coil on his back flashed white. He staggered, caught himself, and came after me again.

I had never made a man so angry at walking.

The soldiers saw the blue flare and retreated farther. A machine they had expected to make them brave was beginning to make them nervous. One dropped his weapon and ran toward the barracks. Another followed.

Keller shouted at them.

They kept running.

Nigga, authority had developed a staffing problem.

The service track cleared.

Tomas moved the locomotive back a short distance while Miriam directed from the side. The damaged front hitch came loose. The passenger carriages shuddered, then began rolling toward the transfer chamber along the repaired route.

Keller saw them moving.

His expression changed.

For the first time he stopped chasing me because hurting me was no longer his favorite option. He turned toward the nearest carriage.

Toward the people inside.

I jumped down in front of him.

“No.”

He struck me across the chest.

I flew backward into the snow.

The pain came all at once. Ribs, shoulder, breath gone. My gun landed somewhere beyond my hand. The sky above me blurred.

Shawna shouted my name.

I tried to rise.

My body had a serious objection.

Keller advanced toward the carriage steps.

Then Rivka stood in the doorway holding a fire extinguisher from the rescue van.

She had watched Mercedes use one earlier in the machine building.

She pointed it at his face and squeezed.

A white cloud engulfed him.

He staggered, blinded, swinging at empty air.

Miriam grabbed my arm.

“Get up.”

I got up.

Not alone.

Because she pulled, and because I pulled with her, and because a nigga's greatness wasn't going to become the excuse he used to refuse the hand saving his life.

Tank reached us.

He took one look at my face.

“Can you move?”

I coughed, found air, and nodded.

“Then move beautiful.”

We ran toward the Lamborghini.

The last flat wagon had been brought level with the transfer yard's loading platform. Its ramp lay down. My car waited where I had left it, dented and outrageous, a dark blue promise on borrowed rails.

I got behind the wheel.

Shawna slid in beside me.

“Your ribs?”

“Still personal.”

She looked at my face, then toward Keller staggering out of the white cloud.

“Drive.”

I drove.

The Lamborghini came off the wagon and hit the yard in a spray of snow. Keller turned at the engine's roar. I went straight at him, then swerved close enough to make him reach.

His metal hand caught the rear rail of the empty wagon behind us instead.

The frame locked.

The wagon moved under his weight.

For one second the colonel stood attached to something larger than himself that did not care what he ordered.

Shawna fired from the window.

Her shots struck the black housing on his back. Blue light jumped through the cracks. The frame convulsed. Keller screamed in anger more than pain, trying to pull free as the empty wagon rolled toward the old freight buffer.

I stopped the car.

Got out with Tank beside me.

Keller tore one arm loose.

The machine was breaking around him. He could have let it go. Could have dropped the weapon now in his free hand. Could have surrendered with the men who had already thrown theirs into the snow.

He aimed at Shawna.

I shot him.

He fell against the wagon. The weapon dropped. The blue coils flickered once, then went dark.

The empty wagon struck the buffer with a heavy crash.

Keller did not rise.

I stood with the gun lowered and watched long enough to know the thing was finished.

Then I turned toward the people.

That was where the rest of the night belonged.

The guards who remained surrendered to Pike's orders relayed through our loudspeaker and Victor standing on the locomotive with one faint blue line still crossing his fingers. We took their weapons, secured them in a room away from the prisoners, and left the local resistance group to decide how to deliver them to

people who could hold them. Nobody asked the prisoners to stand beside their captors for a picture.

Léonie found two trucks fit for the eastern road. Tomas examined them with Miriam, and the two mechanics argued over one engine in a mixture of languages that sounded so ordinary it made my throat tighten.

David checked each person choosing to stay. Vega gave him supplies and instructions she wrote slowly enough for him to ask questions. He did not need her to teach him how to care about people. He needed medicine, clean bandages, and a chance to practice what he already knew without a guard deciding whose pain counted.

She gave him what she could.

At the loading platform, the sixty-two choosing the door gathered around Shawna. Some stared at the thin blue seam. Some looked back at the station. Some held the names of people they would never see again in the silence between their breaths.

Miriam stood beside me with her old wrench in her hand. She had retrieved it from the yard because, she said, it was hers.

“What is your world like?” she asked.

I looked at the Lamborghini. At Victor, exhausted beside Petra. At Tank wrapping a blanket around Rosa's shoulders. At my wife, still counting people carefully while a gold medal swung against her blue sweater.

“Complicated,” I said.

Miriam nodded.

“Then I won't be surprised.”

“But we got room.”

She looked at me.

I meant a room with a door she could open. A job if she wanted one. Food without permission. People who would learn her name before they asked what she could do for them.

I couldn't promise her that no ugly thing existed in the future.

I could promise her where she would wake up tomorrow.

She slipped the wrench into her coat.

“All right.”

I called Storm.

Static answered first.

Then her voice, faint and strained.

“Aiden.”

“We have sixty-two coming through. Twenty-four choosing the eastern road with the resistance. Everybody accounted for.

Keller's dead.”

She breathed out.

“Bring them.”

The blue seam widened.

Sky High appeared beyond it.

Not peaceful. Not quiet. Red lights flashed along the chamber walls. Bell stood beside the controls with a bandage around his head. Marcellus waited near the entrance, his jacket off, helping Lena arrange chairs and blankets.

I saw smoke in the upper corridor.

“Storm.”

“Bring them now.”

We brought them.

The injured went first in the rescue van. Petra drove slowly through the circle while Vega stayed beside the stretchers. Mercedes walked with Amaya. Jakob carried his violin case. Rivka held the small bag against her chest and did not look back after her first step.

Miriam stopped at the threshold and touched the blue air with two fingers.

Then she crossed.

Behind us, Léonie stood beside the eastern trucks.

Shawna went to her. They embraced hard, two women who had promised each other a door and found different futures beyond it.

“Tell them we made it,” Léonie said.

“Tell them yourself,” Shawna answered. “All the people waiting for you.”

Léonie nodded. Tears ran down her face, but she was smiling when she turned toward the trucks.

David shook my hand.

Tomas clapped Tank on the shoulder and said something that made Porsche laugh when she translated.

“He says you are too large for history's small rooms.”

Tank nodded gravely.

“Nigga, I been explaining that all night.”

The trucks rolled toward the eastern road with Léonie in front, Tomas driving, David beside the people who needed him. We watched until the convoy reached the turn beyond the trees, clear of the depot, where two members of her resistance network stepped from cover to meet them.

Then we went home.

Tank drove the Mercedes through. I followed in the Lamborghini with Shawna beside me. Victor walked last, looking back once at the silent machine building before he crossed.

Storm turned the final ring.

The portal narrowed.

Snow became a line.

Then nothing.

The door was closed.

Reiss pulled the alignment key from the controls and snapped its glass stem beneath a heavy tool. Bell disconnected the first of the frame's great support rings. They would dismantle the rest when the people were safe upstairs. No second journey waiting as an excuse. No promise to fix every grief by finding a convenient year.

We had brought back the people who chose to come.

We had left the others on a road they chose, with one less monster behind them.

For one brief second I let that be enough.

Then an explosion shook the chamber.

Dust fell over my car.

The Heart's light flickered behind its glass.

Storm leaned against the controls, pale with exhaustion.

“Voss,” she said. “He took the upper tower.”

Tank got out of the Mercedes and looked toward the smoke.

“Nigga, we gone one night.”

I opened my door.

Shawna opened hers.

Above us, the whole school began to fall.

14. School Was Falling and I Still Had Perfect Attendance

The floor dropped beneath us.

Not a little shake. Not the polite tremble a building used when it wanted people to check the weather. The whole chamber fell hard enough to lift my stomach into my throat. Chairs slid. Glass rattled around the Heart. Somebody screamed my name like I had personally installed gravity.

Nigga, I had been gone one night.

One.

I caught Shawna against the Lamborghini. Tank grabbed the Mercedes door with one hand and Rosa with the other. Petra braced herself across the rescue van's open rear so the stretchers couldn't slide out. Marcellus caught Rivka's chair before it tipped.

Then Storm raised both hands.

The fall slowed.

Her boots left the floor. White light ran along her arms. Outside the chamber windows, clouds climbed past us instead of waiting below.

“Bell,” she said.

The professor was already moving.

He and Reiss worked at the support console, four hands and two hands finding their separate places. I didn't understand half the lights. I understood the strain in Storm's face and the sound of the school trying to remain a school around us.

The floor steadied.

Not level.

Steady enough.

Storm came down on one knee.

Vega reached her immediately.

“How long?” I asked Bell.

He looked at the controls.

“Until he opens another support lock.”

“Nigga, I was hoping for minutes.”

“So was I.”

Voss's voice filled the chamber speakers.

It came from above, smooth and furious, making the whole place feel briefly like the inside of his unpleasant head.

“The academy is now under emergency authority. Surrender the Heart and the unauthorized visitors to the central tower.”

I looked at the sixty-two people who had just crossed out of one man's captivity and heard another man deciding they were negotiable.

My patience left so completely I didn't even feel it go.

“Turn that shit off.”

Bell struck a switch.

The voice continued.

He struck another.

Still Voss.

Tank picked up a chair and smashed the speaker.

Silence.

Bell looked at him.

“Thank you.”

“Nigga, I got a specialty.”

We had to get the returnees away from the hanging annex. The support chamber sat beneath the island, and if Voss severed it from the rest of the foundation, nobody upstairs would have time to watch it fall before we became a very sad cloud.

Pike's voice came over the radio. He held the upper music hall with his officers. Sable remained locked in a patrol cell under guard. Finn remained in another, loudly insisting he had warned everybody about Voss and deserved credit for the parts of the warning he had eventually provided.

I told Pike to keep both cells closed and prepare room for people who had actually helped.

“How many?”

“Sixty-two new arrivals. Some injured. All tired. Make it warm.”

“Already done.”

That nigga was becoming one of my favorite uniforms.

The lift could carry the stretchers. The stairs could take the people able to walk. The cars would go up the old service ramp, which Bell warned was narrow, damaged, and not designed for a Lamborghini.

I looked at him.

He looked back.

“I hear it when I say it now,” he admitted.

Miriam stayed beside the Heart's housing, studying the fittings. She had arrived in a world of floating schools and impossible engines and apparently decided the quickest way to survive the surprise was to find the part that needed fixing.

Bell noticed.

“You understand machinery?”

She gave him a look.

He held up two apologetic hands while the other two remained on the controls.

“Poorly phrased.”

She pointed at a vibration in the support bracket. He looked, adjusted it, and the light over the housing steadied.

For a second the professor forgot the school was falling.

“Would you consider—”

“Later,” she said.

I laughed once.

“Nigga, she just got here and already outranking you.”

Bell nodded with delighted exhaustion.

“Entirely deserved.”

Shawna led the first walking group to the stairs with Mercedes and Rosa. Vega went with the stretchers. Petra escorted the lift. Victor remained below with me, Tank, Bell, Reiss, and Storm.

We had to move the Heart to the central support chamber above the main hall. Voss controlled the old tower, but Bell could isolate its override from the newer system if we reached the central chamber with the real core. The old tower's locks could interrupt the foundation through the existing link. Bringing the core directly into the newer chamber would shorten that vulnerable chain.

That was enough explanation for me.

“Where it fit?” I asked.

Bell looked at the housing, then the Lamborghini.

His expression became pain.

“Passenger seat.”

Tank put a hand on his shoulder.

“Nigga, breathe. This car been a train passenger. It's ready for responsibility.”

We secured the housing inside the Lamborghini with the care a man used when he understood his cargo was currently keeping his wife from dropping through the world. No jokes while we lifted it. No swagger while Bell checked its supports. I let the professor do his work.

Then I sat beside the Heart and felt its blue light wash over my hands.

Still no power.

Just me.

Victor crouched beside the open door.

“I'll keep the upper path clear.”

“You got enough charge?”

“For you to drive fast.”

“Nigga, that's my favorite unit.”

Tank would drive the Mercedes behind me with Reiss. Bell and Storm would climb through the service lift once the last stretcher cleared. The rescue van was already going up with Vega.

Nobody was leaving a vehicle full of injured people on a ramp while the action heroes enjoyed their moment.

I started the engine.

The Heart glowed beside me.

“All right, expensive nigga,” I told it. “Let’s go pay rent.”

The service ramp curved upward through the island’s rock. Water ran down its walls. The headlights caught old warning signs, rusted rails, doors somebody had locked years ago and forgotten to open when the people inside changed.

I drove carefully for the first turn.

Then gunfire struck the wall ahead.

Careful remained a value. It simply became faster.

Two of Voss’s men stood behind a maintenance cart at the next bend. Victor came down from the upper landing in a flare of blue, forcing them back. I drove through the space he made. Tank followed, leaning on the horn as if the gunmen were ordinary traffic being rude.

“Move, niggas!” he shouted through the window. “School supplies coming!”

The ramp shook.

A crack opened across the concrete.

I saw it too late to stop.

The Lamborghini leaped the gap.

For one second the Heart's light turned my whole car blue.

Then the tires struck the other side and the engine roared us onward.

Behind me, Tank crossed with the Mercedes. His rear wheels caught the edge, bounced, and landed. Reiss shouted something that sounded like a complicated scientific opinion about death.

Tank laughed into the radio.

“Nigga, welcome to the car.”

The last turn opened onto the music hall's stage.

Yes.

The stage.

Bell had mentioned it as a service entrance. He had not mentioned that an audience of terrified students, freed prisoners, faculty, police, and my wife would be looking straight at us when we emerged.

I drove out beneath the theater lights with the Heart glowing in the passenger seat.

For a second nobody made a sound.

Then Shawna saw me.

She stood so fast her chair fell backward.

“That's my fucking husband.”

The whole hall rose.

Not because the danger was over.

Because the man they had been told to surrender had just driven the thing keeping them alive onto the stage like it was an award he had come to collect.

Nigga, entrances mattered.

I stopped the car, got out, and raised my badge.

“Nobody handing nobody over.”

The roar hit me like heat.

Pike saluted. Elias lifted both fists. Lena stood beside Rosa, her voice joining the chant. The students who had watched my first test shouted my name until it stopped belonging to one throat at a time.

Aiden.

Captain.

Ten toes down.

I let them have five seconds.

Then I pointed toward the doors.

“If you can carry, carry. If you can heal, find the doctor. If you can hold a wall up, nigga, we got walls looking insecure.

Nobody running alone. Nobody leaving somebody because that person ain't glowing.”

They moved.

That was the part I was proudest of.

A woman with wings took two medical bags upstairs. Elias lifted a fallen beam clear of the main exit. Sunfire appeared in her racing jacket and began warming the coldest corner of the hall with a controlled glow from her hands. Petra brought the last stretcher out of the lift. Mercedes directed people toward the safe rooms without raising her voice once.

Shawna reached me.

She touched my face.

“You brought it.”

“Baby, I bring things.”

“You brought me back my idiot too.”

“Premium delivery.”

She kissed me quickly and went back to work.

Outside the theater windows, black aircraft gathered around the upper tower.

Voss had watched the hall refuse him.

He was taking it personally.

Good.

I intended to keep making that nigga feel seen.

15. Every Cop in the Sky Wanted My Shift

Chief Gloria Knox arrived with three police helicopters and a bottle of champagne.

She said the bottle was for after.

Nobody asked after what. The school was tilting, black aircraft circled the upper tower, and a man in a torn racing jacket was using his bare hands to keep a marble staircase attached to the wall.

After was doing plenty of work already.

Knox stepped onto the landing terrace in a dark coat with her badge over her heart. Two campus officers rushed forward to tell her the airspace was restricted. She looked past them at me standing beside my Lamborghini.

“My captain is here.”

“Ma'am, the chancellor—”

“Looks busy becoming a former chancellor.”

She walked around them.

Tank watched her approach with open delight.

“Nigga, your boss got entrance music even when nobody playing.”

Knox hugged Shawna first. Then she took one look at my shirt, my bruised face, and the newest crack in the Lamborghini's front bumper.

“You making the department proud?”

“Aggressively.”

“Good. Why is there a school in the air?”

“Advanced program.”

She looked up at the towers.

“Clearly.”

Her officers brought medical supplies, extra radios, and enough armed confidence to make Pike stop feeling as if he was defending the entire academy with six loyal people and a bakery next door. Knox put him in charge of getting the injured onto the helicopters. She did not waste time pretending she knew his campus better than he did.

I appreciated that.

A nigga could be impressive without being incorrect at volume.

Inside the central support chamber, Bell and Miriam had installed the Heart into the newer housing. The floor had stopped tilting. For the first time since our return, the academy seemed willing to remain at one altitude long enough for somebody to finish a sentence.

But the old tower still held three foundation locks. Voss could open them one at a time, separating pieces of the floating island from the support field. He could not make himself the school. He could make the school come apart around him.

Bell showed us the tower through a narrow window.

It stood on its own rocky spur beyond the stadium, joined to the main island by a broad bridge. Black metal shutters covered its lower floors. Armed aircraft circled the upper balconies. A narrow maintenance spine ran from its foundation down beneath the stadium.

“We reach the old control room,” Bell said, “and I can sever his override.”

“Then let's reach it,” I said.

“He has fortified the bridge.”

Tank looked out at it.

“Nigga, bridges keep taking jobs they ain't qualified for.”

Storm stood beside the Heart, one hand resting against its glass. Vega had made her drink water and sit for ten minutes. She had obeyed nine of them, which apparently qualified as cooperation among women who could hold cities in the air.

“He wants you on that bridge,” she told me. “He has watched you drive toward every threat since you arrived.”

“He should've learned something encouraging.”

“He has learned what you won't abandon.”

I looked toward the hall where Shawna was helping Miriam find a warm coat.

Storm followed my gaze.

“That is a strength,” she said. “It is also information.”

I nodded.

No lecture. Just a woman who knew the cost of loving people standing beside a man who had made a career out of refusing to admit costs existed.

We could use the maintenance spine to enter below the bridge. It was too narrow for cars. The upper lift was locked from inside. Voss had left the obvious road heavily guarded and the inconvenient one nearly empty, because he still thought danger was something he could arrange neatly for other people.

Shawna listened from the doorway.

“You take the bridge,” she said. “We take the spine.”

I smiled before I could help it.

“Baby, we getting a routine.”

“Then get good at your part.”

She would go with Mercedes, Petra, Bell, and Miriam. The women had already opened more locked rooms together than Voss had managed to keep closed. Bell needed the old control

panel. Miriam had the patient hands to help him work while the building argued.

Tank and I would make the bridge loud. Victor and Sunfire would cover the air. Knox's helicopters would keep evacuating the injured and those who wanted solid ground. Storm would remain with the Heart, maintaining the island's support until Bell could cut the last old ties.

Porsche stood in the doorway with a radio in each hand.

“And me?”

“You got everybody talking,” I said. “Keep it that way.”

She looked down at the radios.

“Nigga, finally a job that recognizes my natural gifts.”

Leon appeared behind her carrying three bags at once in three separate bodies.

“Need help?”

She looked at him approvingly.

“All of you, yes.”

We prepared on the landing terrace while the academy worked around us. Students carried stretchers. Faculty opened supply rooms they had previously guarded as if extra blankets might undermine academic prestige. Elias helped Harlan Moss support a cracked garden wall by driving roots through its stone joints.

The landscape architect smiled for the first time since his rescue, dirty hands steady on something he had chosen to grow.

Rosa stood beside Tank's Mercedes. She had changed out of her cold-weather coat and into one of his hoodies. It nearly reached her knees. The red ribbon from the race still circled his wrist.

She took that wrist in both hands.

“You keep coming back to me.”

“That's where I'm headed every time.”

“I mean it.”

“So do I.”

He leaned down and kissed her. No joke in it. No performance. Just my brother finding the part of the world where he didn't have to be the biggest thing in the room to feel safe.

I turned away and found Shawna watching me.

“You happy for him?” she asked.

“Nigga finally got somebody who can tell him to sit down and have it happen.”

“That's not what I asked.”

I took her hand.

“Yeah. I am.”

She squeezed it.

Then she held up my torn jacket.

“You wearing this?”

“It's got history.”

“It's got holes.”

“Prestigious holes.”

She shook her head and helped me put it on anyway.

The bridge rose from the academy's eastern plaza in a long white curve. Voss's men had parked two armored carriers across its middle. Portable barriers blocked the gaps. A black aircraft hovered above each side, its gunner watching the approach.

I drove toward them with my siren on.

Tank followed in the Mercedes.

Victor flew low over our roofs. Sunfire swept higher, trailing a ribbon of orange light that made the clouds look as if dawn had decided to try a second entrance.

The guards saw us coming.

One of them lifted a loudspeaker.

“Stop your vehicles.”

I lifted my own microphone.

“Nigga, you first.”

He looked at his parked carrier as if the request had injured logic.

Good. Confusion bought time.

The first aircraft fired across the bridge. Victor caught the gun mount in a bright net of charge and twisted its aim toward empty sky. Sunfire flashed past the second aircraft's windshield, blinding the pilot long enough to make him climb away.

I accelerated.

The guards ducked behind the carriers.

At the last moment I turned toward the bridge's raised service ledge. The Lamborghini climbed onto it, tires gripping the narrow strip while open air waited beyond my left window. I passed the first carrier with inches to spare. Tank struck the movable barrier behind me and shoved it clear for the Mercedes.

His voice came over the radio.

“Nigga, I made a lane.”

“Proud of you.”

“Put that on my diploma.”

Gunfire struck the stone beneath us. I kept the car straight until the service ledge widened near the far end. Then I dropped back onto the main bridge and spun the Lamborghini across the roadway, blocking the guards' line of fire toward the maintenance entrance below.

That entrance opened.

My wife disappeared inside with her team.

The loud part was working.

Voss appeared on a balcony above the bridge.

He had changed out of his charcoal suit. A dark armored coat covered his chest and shoulders. Thin blue channels ran along its sleeves. He held a black staff in one hand, longer and uglier than the cane I had broken.

Nigga had upgraded his attitude into equipment.

“Captain Aiden,” he called down.

I stepped out of the car.

“You keep saying my name like it gonna help you.”

“I offered you honors.”

“You offered everybody underneath us chains.”

He lifted the staff.

The bridge cracked.

A section behind Tank broke away from the main span. His Mercedes slid toward the opening. He hit the brakes, jumped out, and caught the car's door as if personal loyalty could outweigh gravity.

For one terrible second it almost seemed to.

Victor dove.

Blue light caught the Mercedes beneath its chassis. Tank hauled on the door. I ran back and grabbed his arm. Together we

dragged the car's front wheels onto solid stone while Victor held the rear above the gap.

The Mercedes settled.

Tank put his forehead against its roof.

“Nigga, don't you leave me.”

Victor landed beside us, breathing hard.

“You could thank the person.”

Tank pulled him into a hug so sudden his boots left the ground.

“My lightning nigga.”

“Can't breathe.”

“That's gratitude.”

Voss watched from above with fury spreading through his face.

He had tried to turn my friendship into a weakness and found it had more hands than he expected.

I looked up at him.

“You got anything else?”

He smiled.

Then the old tower's upper windows lit blue.

In my earpiece, Bell shouted Shawna's name.

I stopped smiling.

The loud part had reached the room my wife was in.

16. The Tower Was Scared of My Wife

Bell shouted Shawna's name because she had just kicked him out of the way of a falling beam.

I learned that part three seconds after my heart tried to climb out of my chest.

“I'm fine,” she said over the radio.

“Then tell the four-arm nigga to stop announcing you like a tragedy.”

“He was busy falling.”

Bell sounded deeply offended in the background.

“I was pushed with exceptional force.”

“You're welcome,” my wife said.

I let myself breathe again.

Then the bridge beneath my Lamborghini split.

Voss had stopped pretending he cared what happened to his own people. The guards still stationed along the span scrambled toward the tower doors as cracks ran through the white stone. One carrier slid against the railing. Its driver tried to reverse. The rear wheels spun over open air.

I got into the Lamborghini.

Tank looked at me.

“Which problem?”

“The one with people in it.”

“Nigga, that's every problem.”

“Then we picking by distance.”

I drove alongside the sliding carrier and stopped close enough for its passenger door to open over my roof. The guard inside stared down at me through the gap.

He had been shooting at us five minutes ago.

I looked up at him.

“You coming, or you taking the scenic route?”

He climbed onto the Lamborghini.

Another man followed. Then the driver. Three armed men abandoned their weapons and crawled across my roof toward a piece of bridge their boss had not yet decided to destroy.

Tank hauled them down one by one.

The carrier fell.

It vanished into the clouds without a sound that reached us.

The driver stared after it.

Then he turned toward Voss's balcony.

The look in his face changed the shape of the battle.

“He knew we were there.”

I got out of the car.

“Nigga, he could see you.”

The man swallowed. He was about thirty-eight, close-cropped hair, a scar across his chin, shoulders built for following orders somebody else had made profitable.

“Rook,” he said. “Captain of his air guard.”

I looked at the discarded weapons.

“You done?”

He stared at the clouds where his carrier had gone.

Then nodded.

“I’m done.”

“Good. Help Tank get your people off this fucking bridge.”

Rook moved.

Not to my side because a speech had washed him clean. To the people he had brought here, because he had finally seen what Voss would spend to avoid losing. He shouted names. Men answered. Two lowered their guns. One tried to object and looked toward the balcony for instructions.

Voss raised his staff again.

Rook pulled that man away from the edge a second before the stone beneath him broke.

The objection ended.

Above us, Sunfire drove the remaining aircraft back from the bridge with bright sweeping passes. Victor landed near the tower doors and forced their locking mechanism open with one concentrated burst.

“Aiden!”

I ran toward him.

The Lamborghini and Mercedes remained on the last solid section of the span. Rook's men helped Tank move both into the shelter of the tower's lower service bay. Nigga, five minutes of honest cooperation had improved their employment prospects dramatically.

Inside, the tower was all black stone and blue light. Voss's decorative portraits lined the walls. Chancellor at an unveiling. Chancellor beside a new aircraft. Chancellor holding a ceremonial shovel while three men behind him looked as if they had done the actual digging.

Tank came in behind me and studied the shovel picture.

“This nigga never had dirt on a shoe.”

“We can fix that.”

We climbed toward the control room.

Shawna's team had reached it from below. She stood in the doorway with Mercedes, covering Bell and Miriam while they

worked at the old panel. Petra held a damaged support arch above their heads. Blue sparks jumped from the wall every few seconds, lighting the sweat on her face.

I entered.

Shawna looked me over once, made sure the important pieces remained attached, and pointed toward the far stairs.

“He went up.”

“You coming?”

She smiled.

“Nigga, I been inside.”

We went together.

At the top of the stairs, a gallery overlooked the central stadium. Voss stood before a tall window, his armored coat open enough to reveal a harness of black conductors beneath it. Blue light pulsed along his ribs. A portable transmitter sat beside him, linked to the old support system.

He had built himself another way to touch the Heart without standing beside it.

Storm's voice came over the radio.

“He's drawing from the central housing.”

Bell answered from below.

“I can cut the old line, but the surge must go somewhere.”

“Let it burn his tower,” Tank said.

Miriam's voice followed, sharp and practical.

“His tower is still tied to the stadium. There are people there.”

I looked through the window.

The stadium had become an evacuation point. Hundreds of students and visitors gathered on its field while faculty guided them toward airships and helicopters. Sunfire's glow marked one landing area. Knox stood near another, directing people with the authority of a woman who did not care whether the ground had originally intended to float.

Voss had placed his escape inside their danger.

He watched me understand.

“You see?” he said. “Power is arrangement.”

I walked toward him.

“Nigga, you sound like a man trying to sell a bad couch.”

He struck with the staff.

Blue force hit the floor between us and threw me against the wall. Shawna fired. Her shots struck the staff's head, sparking against its black casing. Voss staggered but kept his grip.

Tank charged.

The second burst caught him across the chest and drove him backward into the stair rail. He hit hard, rolled, and came up

swearing with both lungs, which reassured me more than any medical assessment available at that moment.

Victor entered through the window in a blaze of blue.

Voss turned toward him.

The harness opened like a hungry hand.

Victor's charge bent into it.

He cried out.

I saw the race again. Saw his car drinking him. Saw Voss discover that the same cruelty could fit more than one occasion.

Shawna shot the transmitter.

The box burst in a shower of sparks.

Victor dropped free.

I caught him before he struck the floor.

Voss looked at my wife with genuine fear.

Not because she was somebody he could use against me.

Because she kept breaking the thing he needed.

“You,” he said.

She aimed again.

“Me.”

He retreated through the upper doorway as the transmitter burned. I helped Victor to Tank and followed with Shawna.

We emerged onto the tower roof.

An aircraft waited on a circular pad. Voss climbed inside and pulled a lever. The old foundation locks began opening beneath us.

The stadium lurched.

I heard the scream of hundreds of people through the open air.

Bell shouted over the radio.

“The central housing is overloading. If he completes the release, the field will tear.”

Voss's aircraft rose.

He looked down through its glass canopy, blue light crawling around his armored chest.

I had never hated a smile more efficiently.

“Enjoy your honors,” he said through the aircraft's speaker.

Then he flew toward the central support chamber.

Toward the Heart.

Toward the people he had left beneath its failing field.

I looked at Shawna.

She looked at the stadium.

Then at the service bay below us where my Lamborghini waited.

“You got a road?” she asked.

I looked across the broken bridge, the floating maintenance platforms, the narrow blue lanes flickering between the towers.

Not a good road.

Not a road anybody would admit drawing on a map.

But a nigga had driven into this school before the road was even open.

“I got something.”

She took my hand.

“Then let's go be magnificent.”

17. Blue Thunder Looked Good on a Nigga

I drove off the broken bridge because the bridge had stopped being useful.

Nigga, I gave that bridge several chances.

The Lamborghini left the stone ledge and landed on a maintenance platform hanging below it. The suspension slammed hard enough to make my teeth click. Shawna caught the handle over her door and shouted something that began with my name and ended with a detailed opinion of my judgment.

I agreed with the passionate parts.

Ahead, a blue service lane flickered between the platform and the stadium's outer ring. It was narrower than a proper road and less confident about existing. The Heart's unstable field kept making pieces of it fade.

I watched the light pulse.

Waited one breath.

Then drove.

The wheels caught the lane at its brightest point. We raced through open air while the path went dim behind us. Below, clouds climbed toward the academy's falling edges. Above, Voss's aircraft crossed toward the central tower.

Shawna stared through the windshield.

“Aiden.”

“I see it.”

“You see all of it?”

“Nigga, I'm trying to focus on the helpful portion.”

The lane ended short of the stadium ring.

I didn't brake.

The Lamborghini flew the gap and struck the ring road with its front wheels first. The rear swung wide. I corrected, straightened, and heard a roar from the field below.

People had seen us.

People were cheering.

Nigga, I needed those people to evacuate, but I understood the interruption.

Knox looked up from beside a helicopter and put both hands on her head.

“That's my fucking captain,” she said over the radio.

Pike answered from the control entrance.

“He's technically ours this week.”

“Commander, don't get greedy.”

I took the last turn toward the central chamber.

Voss's aircraft had landed through its glass roof.

Not on it.

Through it.

Broken panels lay across the terrace. Smoke rose from the aircraft's nose. He had abandoned any interest in returning school property in good condition.

Shawna and I got out.

Inside, Storm stood between Voss and the Heart. Her hands were white with restrained lightning. She looked exhausted enough to fall but remained exactly where she had chosen to stand.

Behind her, Bell's assistants sheltered near the wall. Lena crouched beside one whose leg was trapped under a fallen beam. She was speaking in a calm voice that belonged entirely to her now.

Voss raised his staff.

“You cannot hold it forever.”

Storm's eyes burned.

“You keep mistaking exhaustion for agreement.”

He struck.

White light met blue.

The room shook.

I ran toward the trapped assistant while Shawna moved around the opposite side. Together we lifted the beam enough for Lena to pull him clear. The assistant looked at me, recognized me, and began thanking me while he was still being dragged across the floor.

“Nigga, thank me in the hallway. Move.”

He moved.

Voss saw me.

His face did something beautiful and ugly at once: astonishment because I had arrived again, hatred because apparently arriving was a talent he could not buy.

“What are you?”

I stepped into the open.

“Consistent.”

He turned the staff toward me.

Shawna fired.

The staff broke near its head. Blue force burst sideways into the Heart's housing. Glass cracked. The core's light flared so bright every shadow in the room vanished.

Storm threw both hands toward it.

The surge struck her and drove her to her knees.

Bell's voice came through the radio.

“The transfer conductor is open. Get away from the housing.”

Voss's armor began drinking the loose current.

He smiled through the pain.

The nigga was still trying to win with a mouthful of the disaster he had made.

Then the ceiling support above Shawna began to fall.

I saw it.

Saw her look up.

Saw the distance between us.

There was no time for a clever route, no car, no faculty member with a gift ready to do the part my body could not reach.

I ran.

The broken transfer conductor lay across the floor between us, black metal wrapped in blue light. It was part of Voss's attempt to bond a human body to the Heart's charge, a system he had forced Bell's designs into and Reiss had warned him not to use.

I stepped over it.

It caught my leg.

Current tore through me.

Nigga, I had never known pain could be a color.

Blue filled my hands. My chest. My mouth. Every muscle locked, then opened into a terrible fast clarity. The falling beam

seemed to move slowly enough for me to see the chips of paint leaving its edge.

It wasn't slow.

I was moving.

I reached Shawna.

Caught her around the waist.

We crossed the room in a flash that left blue fire crawling along the floor behind us.

The beam struck where she had stood.

I hit the wall with her in my arms and fell to one knee.

The light went out.

For a moment I could not breathe.

Shawna held my face.

“Aiden.”

I tried to answer.

Nothing came.

My hands shook violently. Tiny blue threads moved beneath the skin, then faded. The old wound still hurt. My bruised ribs still hurt. Whatever had happened had not repaired a single fucking thing. It had simply made me do something impossible and sent the bill directly to my body.

Storm stared at me from beside the broken housing.

Voss stared too.

Bell arrived at the doorway with Miriam behind him and stopped so abruptly she nearly walked into his back.

“You bonded with the conductor,” he said.

I finally found enough air for words.

“Nigga, was there a cheaper option?”

Shawna laughed once, half relief and half terror.

Then she pulled me against her so tightly my ribs filed another complaint.

Voss raised his armored hand.

“That power is mine.”

Tank came through the doorway behind Bell.

He looked at my glowing fingers.

Looked at Voss.

“Nigga, ain't nothing about this man ever belonged to you.”

He fired.

Voss ducked behind the Heart's damaged housing. Storm used the moment to pull the loose current back into a contained arc. Bell and Miriam reached the emergency braces. Shawna helped me stand.

My legs felt like somebody had replaced the bones with hot wire.

Victor arrived through the roof opening and looked straight at me.

He could feel it.

I saw that in his face before he spoke.

“You didn’t have that before.”

“Nigga, I had several other advantages.”

He smiled despite everything.

“Of course you did.”

Voss tore a black coupling from the housing and leaped back toward his aircraft. The core itself remained inside the emergency braces. He had taken a concentrated store of charge, enough to keep his armor alive while the Heart continued supporting the school.

The aircraft's engines whined.

Tank fired at its rising nose. Victor forced it away from the open roof with a burst of lightning. Voss escaped through the gap anyway, his damaged craft dragging sparks into the morning air.

The stadium shuddered again.

Bell shouted from the braces.

“We have to reset the outer support ring. Now. The western section is breaking loose.”

I looked toward the windows.

A quarter of the stadium's outer structure had begun sliding away from the island. People crowded the stairs leading off it. A helicopter hovered too far away to reach everyone before the stone separated.

My Lamborghini waited on the terrace.

Blue threads flickered in my fingers.

Shawna saw both things at once.

“Can you control it?”

“Don't know yet.”

“Then listen to me. One thing. One burst. You don't spend yourself like you're infinite.”

I looked at her.

The word infinite had never sounded more like a trap than it did in her mouth.

I nodded.

“One thing.”

Bell showed us the outer support arch from the window. Its emergency return point sat along the stadium road, just beyond the widening gap. A powered vehicle could carry a short charge across it and wake the local field long enough for the engineers to secure it.

Yesterday that would have meant Victor's car.

Victor's car had burned because Voss wanted to turn a man into fuel.

Today my hands glowed.

I wasn't going to let Voss decide what that meant too.

I got into the Lamborghini.

Shawna got in beside me before I could start an argument we had already settled a hundred ways.

Tank leaned through my window.

“Nigga, you got lightning now?”

“Little bit.”

“That nigga was already too much. They gave that nigga electricity.”

Victor stood behind him, smiling with exhausted wonder.

“Blue Thunder,” Shawna said.

We all looked at her.

She touched my hand on the wheel.

“That's what it looked like.”

I smiled.

“Baby, you naming my greatness?”

“Somebody has to keep it organized.”

I started the engine.

The new charge moved when I wanted it to.

Not easily. Not painlessly. I felt it gather in my arms, felt my heartbeat grow hard and quick, felt the Lamborghini answer with a low blue shimmer across its dark paint.

Then we moved.

The car shot along the stadium ring faster than it had ever moved under its own engine. The world sharpened around the windshield. Every broken edge, every loose stone, every opening in the road seemed to arrive with just enough time for my hands to answer.

The gap opened ahead.

I held the wheel.

Blue light crossed the hood.

We jumped.

For one brief burst the car carried my charge through the empty space between the two pieces of road. The local field caught it, flared, and held. The Lamborghini landed beneath the support arch in a thunderclap that rolled across the stadium.

The sliding section stopped.

People on the stairs caught one another instead of falling.

The engineers' lights turned green.

My hands went dark.

So did the edges of my vision.

Shawna caught the wheel while I fought to keep my head up.
She guided us into the safe bay beside the arch and brought the car to a stop.

I leaned forward, breathing hard enough to hurt.

“One burst,” she said, holding the back of my neck.

I nodded.

Could not speak yet.

Below us, the stadium began cheering.

Above us, Voss's aircraft circled back toward the tower.

Inside my car, my wife kept her hand on my neck until my breathing slowed.

Blue Thunder had arrived.

Nigga, I still needed a minute.

18. The Sky Stayed Up Because We Did

For the first minute after Blue Thunder, my greatest achievement was keeping breakfast inside my body.

Nigga, nobody had put that part on the poster.

Shawna held a bottle of water to my mouth. My hands were still shaking too hard to trust with it. Through the windshield I could see students crossing the restored stadium road, helping one another toward the helicopters. Every few steps somebody looked at my car and raised a hand.

I raised mine back.

The fingers trembled.

That did not make the wave less important.

Tank reached us first. He leaned through the window, saw my face, and lost the joke he had brought with him.

“How bad?”

“Nigga, electricity got a terrible cancellation policy.”

He looked at Shawna.

She shook her head once: tired, hurt, awake.

He understood.

Victor landed beside the car and sat on the curb without pretending he had meant to sit there. His blue uniform was torn at one shoulder. The glow around his hands had faded to a faint pulse.

“The first time your body holds a charge,” he said, “it feels like it should be able to hold all of it.”

I looked at him.

“It can't,” he said.

“Nigga, my stomach already submitted that finding.”

He smiled tiredly.

“Then listen to your stomach.”

Above the tower, Voss's damaged aircraft circled once. Smoke trailed from its left engine. The coupling he had stolen from the Heart glowed through the cockpit like a little captive sun.

Bell spoke over the radio. The newer support chamber was stable. The stadium's western ring was holding. Miriam had isolated the old tower's first two locks. One remained, and Voss still controlled it through the stolen coupling.

“We have to separate him from it,” Bell said.

Tank looked up.

“Nigga, separate how thoroughly?”

Bell paused.

“Enough that he stops using it.”

“Now that's a specification I can respect.”

The aircraft descended toward the stadium.

Voss was not fleeing.

He had seen people cheering beneath my car. Seen his guards stop firing. Seen the academy move at the sound of my voice instead of his. The nigga could have left with a flying machine and a stolen store of power. It wasn't enough. He wanted the people who had refused him to watch somebody take me apart.

He landed on the stadium's central platform.

The place where they handed out trophies.

Some men never understood how thoroughly location could insult them.

His aircraft's canopy opened. He stepped out in the black armor, the coupling fixed against his chest. Blue force moved around him in ugly jerks. The staff was broken, but he had turned the remaining length into a handle for the charge.

“Aiden,” he shouted.

His voice carried through the stadium speakers, still linked to the old tower.

People stopped moving.

I sat up.

Shawna put her hand against my chest.

“One more does not mean unlimited.”

I covered her hand with mine.

“I know.”

“Say what you're actually going to do.”

I looked down at the field. At Voss standing in the center of a school he had nearly destroyed because it had stopped admiring him.

“Finish with help.”

She nodded.

Then she opened my door.

Tank took the driver's seat. I moved into the passenger side. Shawna climbed onto the rear platform of a nearby rescue cart with Victor, and Petra joined them from the stairs. Knox's officers kept the evacuation lanes clear. Rook and the men who had abandoned Voss put their weapons down in a visible line and helped the last spectators leave the lower seats.

Voss saw them.

“Traitors.”

Rook looked up at the platform.

“You dropped our bridge.”

“I gave you purpose.”

“You gave us a long fall.”

Tank started the Lamborghini.

“Nigga, even his employees reviewing him badly.”

We drove down the stadium access road toward the field. The tires rolled over grass as green and perfect as if nobody had spent the morning trying to turn it into wreckage. I looked at the finish arch from the race. It stood above the far entrance, bent but intact.

Two days ago I had arrived beneath it in first place.

Today I intended to leave the same way, even if I had to let my brother drive.

Voss lifted his armored hand.

Tank swerved before the blast struck. Blue force tore a long groove through the turf behind us. The Lamborghini slid sideways and came around facing the platform.

“Nigga got no respect for landscaping,” Tank said.

“Harlan gonna be furious.”

Voss struck again.

Petra stepped in front of the rescue cart and took the edge of the blast across her marble shoulders. It drove her back three feet. Mercedes caught the cart before it rolled into the stairs. Victor sent a brief answering bolt at the coupling, making Voss turn away from them.

I got out of the Lamborghini.

Voss smiled.

“At last.”

“Nigga, you been looking at me all week.”

“Without the car.”

I glanced at Tank.

He revved the engine.

“Car still here,” I said.

Voss lunged.

He crossed the platform in one enormous step and struck down with the broken staff. I moved sideways, slower than I wanted, fast enough to live. The blow smashed the edge of the trophy pedestal.

Gold-painted stone burst across the grass.

I picked up a broken piece and hit him in the face with it.

His head snapped back.

Tank shouted through the open window.

“Nigga used the award!”

“It's educational.”

Voss hit me across the shoulder. I fell onto the platform steps, caught the rail, and dragged myself up before he could strike again. Pain flashed through my ribs. I had no fresh body waiting

under the damaged one. Blue Thunder had not given me a replacement.

He saw the weakness and came closer.

That was useful.

Shawna moved behind him.

Lena's voice suddenly rang across the stadium, clear as a bell.

“Voss.”

He turned toward the sound, searching the seats.

Her gift carried the word from one speaker to the next, moving his attention away from the woman approaching his blind side.

Rosa stood beside her in the upper gallery, one hand on her back. Two singers, no longer reaching through prison walls, using the whole open sky.

Shawna reached the coupling.

She struck its exposed latch with the broken staff head she had recovered from the support chamber.

The black casing shifted.

Voss spun toward her.

I caught his arm.

Current tore through my hand.

Blue woke beneath my skin.

This time I knew it was limited. Knew the pain that came after. Knew I was choosing a few seconds, not becoming a god with the whole afternoon available.

I spent them on his hand.

The charge moved through me and into the ground, a hard bright arc that made my teeth ache. Voss's grip loosened. Shawna pulled the coupling free of its chest bracket.

The armor went dark.

I went down on one knee.

Shawna ran the coupling toward Victor and Bell's waiting transport case.

Voss followed her with a gun drawn from inside his coat.

Nigga, after all that machinery, he still came back to the same ugly decision every other coward had made in front of my wife.

I drew first.

“Drop it.”

He froze.

For a moment the stadium held its breath.

The gun remained in his hand.

He looked at me kneeling on the grass, shaking, bruised, tired enough that staying upright had become work.

He thought he had found the part of greatness that could be outwaited.

Then he looked at Shawna.

His weapon moved.

I fired.

Voss fell backward against the broken pedestal.

The gun dropped from his hand.

He tried to rise once.

Failed.

I kept my weapon steady until Knox reached him with two officers and Vega came behind them. The doctor knelt, checked, and looked up at me.

One small shake of her head.

Finished.

The chancellor was dead.

The Heart's last old lock opened under Bell's control. The stadium settled with a long, deep sound that ran through the ground beneath my knee. Above us, the towers stopped leaning. The clouds resumed their proper position below the windows.

For a second nobody cheered.

We listened to the school stay in the air.

Then the sound began.

From the upper gallery. From the evacuation stairs. From the helicopter crews hovering beyond the rail. From the people who had been hidden beneath the academy and the people who had arrived through a door that would never open again.

Aiden.

Shawna reached me before the chant could become too large to hear her voice inside it.

“Look at me.”

I did.

“You done?”

I looked at Voss. At the steady towers. At Tank climbing out of my car with tears in his eyes and a grin too big to hide them.

“Yeah.”

My wife put both hands on my face.

“Then come back to me.”

I tried to stand.

My legs said no.

Tank caught me under one arm. Victor caught the other. Between them they hauled me upright while the stadium roared louder at the sight of us together.

“This nigga finally heavy,” Tank said.

Victor laughed, breathless.

“He has always been heavy.”

“Nigga, emotionally ain't a lifting category.”

Shawna walked in front of us, making room, keeping her eyes on mine every few steps. I could not produce one more spark. Could barely lift my hand to wave. Every joint hurt. Every old injury had returned to remind me it had paid rent before the new power moved in.

But the sky stayed up.

My people stayed alive.

And when we passed the broken race arch, Tank stopped and looked at the sign still hanging above it.

FIRST PLACE.

He nodded toward me.

“Nigga, even when we carrying him.”

I laughed so hard my ribs nearly ended the celebration.

They carried me through anyway.

19. Valedictorian Again, Because Niggas Keep Graduating Me

I woke up with Shawna asleep against my chest and Tank arguing with a nurse about fruit.

Nigga, I knew immediately I had survived.

Death might have had trumpets. It did not have my brother explaining that a pear was now an emotional subject.

“He can have one when he wakes,” the nurse said.

“This nigga saved a school.”

“And his stomach needs rest.”

“His greatness don't.”

“His greatness can wait until breakfast.”

I opened one eye.

“Nigga, let the woman work.”

Tank turned so fast his chair scraped across the floor. His face opened into a grin that told me how frightened he had been while I wasn't awake to make it easier.

“There he is.”

Shawna lifted her head.

For one second she looked lost between sleep and the last thing she remembered fearing. Then she saw my eyes open and put her hand against my cheek.

“Hey.”

“Hey, baby.”

She kissed me carefully.

That scared me more than a hard kiss would have.

“How bad I look?”

“Like somebody hit a very expensive statue with a truck.”

“Statue still handsome?”

“Obnoxiously.”

I relaxed.

Vega appeared at the door with Storm behind her. The doctor checked me before she let anybody explain the outside world. My ribs were bruised, my shoulder strained, my hands burned, and my body thoroughly offended by being used as the temporary pathway for the Heart's charge. Nothing about the new ability had healed the old wounds. Nothing about the title people were shouting in the corridors changed the fact that I needed sleep.

“No powers today,” Vega said.

“Nigga, I just got them.”

“Then you can enjoy knowing where they are.”

Storm laughed softly.

The dean looked better. Tired, but no longer holding the sky up through force of will and a series of increasingly personal disagreements. She sat beside the bed and told me the school was stable. Bell and Miriam had severed the old tower's controls. The real Heart remained inside the restored central housing. Voss's armor and the stolen coupling were secured. His surviving guards had surrendered. Sable and Finn remained in custody, separately, so neither could improve the other's story before Pike finished asking questions.

The time door had been dismantled completely.

Reiss had watched the final ring come off its mount.

Then he had gone upstairs and slept in a room with an unlocked door.

I listened with Shawna's hand in mine.

When Storm finished, I asked about the people.

All sixty-two returnees were safe. The thirty rescued before the historical mission were safe too. Dennis from the laundry had gone home with his own keys and had already returned to work long enough to tell his supervisor which locked storage rooms he would never enter again. Nobody had required gratitude as a condition of staying. People were calling families, arranging rooms, asking questions, refusing questions, resting.

The ones who had come from 1944 were taking the new world at the pace they could bear.

That seemed right to me.

Some surprises deserved more than an afternoon.

Storm took my unbandaged wrist gently.

“You changed this place.”

I looked at the window. Beyond it the academy floated in bright morning air, scarred in places, beautiful in others, still very much a school.

“It needed a little parking correction.”

She smiled.

“Yes. Apparently it did.”

For two days I was forbidden to leave the medical tower without somebody sensible beside me.

Tank volunteered.

Vega looked at him for so long he withdrew the application himself.

Shawna took me walking instead. Slowly at first. Across the balcony. Down one corridor. Eventually into the garden where Harlan Moss was repairing the damaged paths with roots coaxed carefully through the stone.

He wore the polished brown shoes Tank had bought him.

That afternoon his wife arrived.

Anne came up the garden steps carrying a small overnight bag and stopped when she saw him. She was a little shorter than Shawna, with graying curls and a face that seemed to lose five months of exhaustion in one breath.

Harlan dropped the pruning shears.

Neither of them ran at first.

They walked toward each other, slowly enough to believe each step.

Then she reached him and hit his chest with both hands before folding herself against it.

“You still have those shoes,” she said through tears.

He looked down at the brown leather.

“New pair.”

“Same fool wearing them.”

“Your fool.”

She cried harder.

Tank stood beside me with his mouth pressed into a line. Rosa slipped her hand into his. He squeezed it without looking away from the couple.

“Good shoes,” he said quietly.

I nodded.

“Excellent fucking shoes.”

A week later Bell let me sit in the Lamborghini again.

He had repaired every dent except one small mark near the rear fender, which he said he would preserve if I wanted a reminder of the train. Gold badge emblems now shone on the doors, and a discreet second strip of police lights sat above the windshield. Bell said a graduate deserved appropriate trim. Nigga, the car had received formalwear.

I looked at it.

“Leave that.”

Miriam stood beside him in a clean blue work coat. She had spent the week learning the academy's engines one careful question at a time. The floating roads still astonished her. The mechanical problems did not.

“You drive as if roads are suggestions,” she told me.

“They been flexible.”

“The car has not always appreciated your confidence.”

Bell nodded so vigorously all four hands moved.

“Thank you.”

She looked at him.

“But it is a remarkable car.”

He nearly cried again.

Nigga, I was going to start carrying tissues for that man.

My new ability came with lessons, which I considered rude but useful. Storm and Victor helped me learn the difference between feeling charge and having enough to spend. Bell watched what happened when I passed it through the car. Vega watched what happened to me afterward and ended every session before my pride could become an injury.

One short burst could sharpen my reactions and send blue current through my hands. A car could carry that charge into a brief surge of acceleration. Afterward I shook, sweated, and tired quickly. Trying to hold it longer made everything worse. I could not fly. I could not call up an endless storm. I could not fix a wound by admiring it. The body beneath the light still needed food, rest, and a wife willing to say, “Nigga, enough,” with final authority.

I had that wife.

The power had no chance of making me completely unmanageable.

Only impressively difficult.

Two weeks after Voss fell, the academy held its graduation.

They put my name first on the program.

Then they put it in larger print than the title.

Tank unfolded the paper and stared at it.

“Nigga, this school's graduating from you.”

“They learned a lot.”

“You attended one class.”

“Intensively.”

The ceremony took place in the restored stadium. Every seat was full. Helicopters and airships hovered beyond the upper rail, carrying guests who had decided a normal chair lacked ambition. The orchestra sat beneath a blue canopy. Rosa sang the opening number. Lena joined her for the second verse, and their voices rose through the open air without a wall between them.

Shawna sat in the front row wearing the ruby Claudine had given us, set now in a simple pendant Marcellus made to keep the stone close to her skin. The red flashed against her blue dress. She caught me looking and smiled as if the whole stadium existed mainly to give us more room for that smile.

I wore a dark suit, my gold badge, the cross, and an honors robe so heavy Tank said they had stitched my ego into the lining.

Victor stood beside me in blue.

He had his own honors. He had earned them. When the dean called his name, I stood before anybody else and cheered loud enough to make him laugh on the way to the platform.

That nigga had tried to beat me.

Then he had helped me save people who would never have known his name otherwise.

I wanted the whole sky to know it now.

Petra graduated with distinction in rescue strength. She accepted her award, turned toward Mercedes, and kissed her in front of the entire faculty. Mercedes looked startled for one beautiful second, then put both arms around her and made the applause last longer.

Porsche stood up cheering.

Leon became three men beside her and cheered three times as loudly.

Knox leaned toward Pike.

“Do all three need separate identification?”

Pike closed his eyes.

“Please let me have one peaceful afternoon.”

Before Storm called my name, the great screen replayed our arrival: the broken train, my car beneath the platform, Shawna pulling people through the carriage door. Tank watched himself catch three people at once and nodded with satisfaction.

“Nigga, that man strong.”

“That's you,” Rosa said.

“Exactly. Camera telling the truth.”

Then Storm said my name.

The stadium stood.

All of it.

Nigga, even some people who had been sitting comfortably on air came down so they could stand properly.

I walked onto the platform beneath the repaired finish arch. The dean held a diploma in one hand and a gold captain's insignia in the other.

“Aiden,” she said, “Top Graduate Captain of Sky High.”

The roar rolled across the clouds.

She waited for it to quiet, failed, and continued over it.

“For extraordinary command, ingenuity, courage, and devotion to those placed in his care.”

Tank shouted, “And the driving!”

“And the driving,” Storm agreed.

The engineering faculty stood and applauded as one wounded profession.

She gave me the diploma.

Then another.

I looked at it.

“What's this one?”

“An honorary distinction for your vehicle.”

Nigga.

My car had graduated.

I turned toward Tank.

He had both hands on his head.

“This nigga ride more educated than my cousins!”

I held up both diplomas.

The stadium lost its fucking mind.

Storm stepped aside for my speech.

I looked down at the paper somebody had offered me backstage.

Then folded it and put it in my pocket.

“Aight,” I said.

The room settled into the kind of quiet a man felt in his chest.

“First, I want everybody to appreciate that I arrived here late, parked wrong, destroyed a platform, missed most of my classes, and still graduated first.”

Laughter broke across the stands.

“That's not advice. Most niggas try that and wind up walking home with a bill.”

More laughter.

I looked at Shawna.

“I came because somebody saw something I did in Vegas and figured I ought to try it higher up. I brought my people because everywhere I go gets better when they there. Then I met more people. Some tried to beat me. Some fed me. Some fixed the car after I made their profession nervous. Some were singing where nobody could hear them.”

Lena looked up from beside Rosa.

“I hear you now,” I said.

She pressed her lips together and nodded.

I raised the diploma.

“This got my name on it. Fine. Nigga, I like my name. But every person who held a door, carried a stretcher, told the truth, brought a shoe, flew back for a friend, or stood beside somebody who couldn't stand alone—you're in it.”

I let the silence hold that.

Then I smiled.

“My wife's still getting the good parking space.”

The stadium roared again.

Shawna stood, laughing, and lifted both hands toward me.

I came down from the platform before anybody could announce another honor.

Went straight to her.

Put my arms around her waist.

“How I do?”

She looked at the diplomas, the badge, the cheering school, the car waiting beside the field with a blue ribbon tied around its mirror.

Then she looked at me.

“Damn, boy.”

I kissed her before she finished.

Nigga, I knew the rest by heart.

20. A Nigga This Great Needed an Ocean

After graduation, Madame Afterglow opened every table in Cloud Nine and announced that my first hand at each one would be played on the house.

Nigga, she should have specified which house.

By midnight I had won enough money for the casino's finance manager to come downstairs personally. He stood behind the blackjack table in a beautiful gray suit, watching me turn over another winning card while Tank laughed into his drink.

“This nigga been counting the future,” Tank said.

“Can't do that,” I told him.

“Then why you keep winning?”

I looked at my cards.

Looked at my wife standing beside me in blue silk and the ruby pendant.

Looked back at my brother.

“Nigga, patterns.”

Shawna laughed and kissed the top of my head.

The finance manager looked at Afterglow.

She waved him away.

“Let the captain play.”

“Madame, the probability—”

“Has met him.”

He withdrew with the injured dignity of a man whose entire education had failed to prepare him for the evening's central problem.

Cloud Nine had repaired its shattered windows and replaced the glass moon. The new moon was slightly larger. Afterglow said the old one had looked timid in photographs of me standing on it.

I respected an owner who could learn from an event.

The ballroom glittered. Music climbed through its open doors onto the roof terrace. Adult heroes danced beside cops, singers, gamblers, mechanics, and the friends from Vegas who had arrived because Rosa told them there was a party in the sky and they refused to believe her without checking.

Some wore gowns. Some wore capes. One man wore a cape over a gown and looked so pleased with himself I shook his hand on principle. A table near the far wall had enough champagne, pills, and white powder on it to explain why two wealthy guests believed they had personally invented dancing. Their friends moved the table farther from the orchestra before the drummer began accepting scientific suggestions.

My people were beautiful in every corner.

Rosa sang with Lena, then stepped offstage and let her take a song alone. Tank stood beneath the lights watching both women, but his face changed whenever Rosa looked his way. The nigga's whole expression went soft and proud, and I loved seeing him unable to hide it.

Mercedes danced with Petra. Porsche danced with one Leon while another fetched drinks and the third stood near the terrace door recovering from being asked to do too much with the same legs.

“He's only got a minute,” Mercedes warned her.

“Then he better use it beautifully.”

Petra laughed so hard the floor beneath her shoes briefly turned white with marble dust.

I won another hand.

The dealer looked at me with open admiration.

“Sir, I have dealt cards for twenty years.”

“You doing good.”

“I have never seen this.”

Tank slapped the table.

“Nigga, that's what the school said!”

Shawna took the chips from in front of me and put them into a little velvet bag.

“You're finished.”

I looked up at her.

“Baby, the universe talking.”

“It can call tomorrow. You're dancing with me.”

I stood so fast the finance manager nearly cried with relief.

“Excellent decision,” he said.

I pointed at him.

“Nigga, don't get comfortable. We walking past roulette.”

Shawna pulled me away laughing.

We danced beneath the new moon with no chancellor waiting to interrupt us. Nobody asked her for a private word. Nobody threatened a locked door. The only thing coming toward us was a waiter carrying drinks and looking mildly frightened that I might somehow win those too.

She rested her cheek against mine.

“You like being a superhero?”

“I like the parking.”

“Aiden.”

I thought about the blue charge in my hands. The fatigue afterward. Victor sitting beside my car and telling me to listen when my body said enough. Storm standing in the air to hold an

entire school. Lena making one word travel where bullets couldn't reach.

“I like knowing another thing I can do,” I said.

Shawna nodded.

“That's a better answer.”

“I had it behind the parking.”

She smiled against my cheek.

For a while we let the song do the talking. I could feel the room looking at us, but it stayed outside the small space between her hand and my shoulder. My fame had gotten louder in the sky. My love for her had gotten quieter in certain places, stronger where it didn't need anybody listening.

Then she spun away from me, came back with both hands on my chest, and said, “Show these people what all that greatness does on a dance floor.”

Nigga, a direct request from my wife was a sacred assignment.

I did the turn I had practiced in the bathroom.

Perfectly.

The orchestra saw us and changed its rhythm. Rosa laughed into the microphone. Tank climbed onto a chair to announce that the captain was now operating across multiple disciplines. I turned Shawna again, caught her at the waist, and dipped her low enough for the ruby at her throat to catch the moonlight.

She looked up at me, smiling.

The ballroom applauded.

This time I didn't even pretend to dislike it.

Oren Titan approached afterward with Opaline on his arm. The big man had apparently recovered from the indignity of watching me rescue his wife while keeping a drink upright. He carried a trophy he had bought himself: a small silver pedestal with two champagne glasses fixed to its top.

“For the man with the steadiest hands in the sky,” he said.

Tank looked at the trophy.

“Nigga, another building?”

“A sculpture,” Oren said.

“These niggas keep doing architecture to us.”

Opaline hugged Shawna, then thanked me again. Oren did not look smaller beside her gratitude. He looked relieved he had found a way to join it without making the whole thing about the moment he had failed to catch her.

That was progress.

I shook his hand.

“Next time we lift the furniture together.”

He laughed and agreed immediately.

Across the room, Claudine raised her glass toward us. The older casino guest wore enough emeralds to make Marcellus turn his head despite himself. She saw Shawna's ruby pendant and smiled with the satisfaction of a woman who had given the right thing to the right person.

Shawna went to her.

They talked for a long time.

I didn't follow. Some gifts kept becoming conversations after the man who carried them had left the room.

Near the terrace, Marcellus sat at a small table with Miriam and Bell. A blue cloth lay between them. On it rested the Blue Mercy ring, a tiny clock mechanism Miriam had brought from the depot, and one of Bell's unfamiliar engine parts.

Three beautiful things. Three people who knew how much care could fit inside something a careless man might call an object.

Marcellus looked up when I approached.

“Come admire something you aren't allowed to drive.”

“Nigga, that sentence leaves me very little.”

He showed Miriam the ring. Told her its name. Told her about Celeste, briefly, in the voice he used when the person mattered more than the story surrounding the jewel.

Miriam listened without trying to make his grief resemble hers.

Then she showed him the clock piece. It had belonged to a workshop where she worked before she was taken. She had kept it hidden because it was proof she had once fixed things for people who said thank you.

Marcellus held it carefully.

“We could make it run again.”

She looked at him.

“I would like that.”

Bell quietly cleared space on the table.

The party went on around them while they bent over a small machine and gave it the possibility of another morning.

I left them to it.

On the terrace, Tank stood alone looking out at the clouds. He had taken off his jacket. The red ribbon remained on his wrist. Rosa's singing drifted through the open doors behind us, warm enough to make the night feel less high.

I stood beside him.

“You good?”

He nodded.

Then shook his head.

Then laughed at himself.

“Nigga, I don't know what this is.”

“Clouds.”

“Fuck you.”

I smiled.

He looked toward the ballroom. Rosa was laughing with Lena between songs, one hand at her waist, head tilted back. My brother watched her the way a man watched a door he had finally realized he was allowed to walk through.

“I keep thinking about houses,” he said.

“You got a house.”

“A different kind.”

I let him find the words.

“A place where her coat already there. Where I don't got to ask if she staying. Where I come in and she mad I forgot some little shit, and I get to go back out and buy it because that's the problem we having that day.”

He looked embarrassed by how much he had said.

I looked at my brother until the embarrassment had nowhere useful to stand.

“Nigga, that sound like something worth buying the little shit for.”

He laughed quietly.

“You got that.”

I looked through the doors and saw Shawna searching the room for me.

“Yeah.”

“Don't get stupid with it.”

“Nigga, you met me.”

“I said with it. You can keep being stupid everywhere else.”

We stood there another minute. Then Rosa came out and slipped her arm through his. He kissed the top of her head without checking whether anybody was watching.

I went back inside to my wife.

The next morning, the school attempted to hold a quiet farewell breakfast.

That lasted until somebody unveiled a statue of me on the lawn.

Nigga, the statue was taller than the dining hall.

It showed me standing on the hood of a Lamborghini with lightning in one hand and a diploma in the other. The sculptor had given my chest an extra six inches of confidence. My coat blew backward in a wind that seemed to exist solely because I deserved dramatic weather.

Tank walked around the base in silence.

Then he looked at me.

“This nigga got a permanent entrance.”

Shawna put both hands over her face.

I stood very still.

Because I respected art.

Storm came beside me with a smile she was not trying hard enough to hide.

“The students insisted.”

“All of them?”

“Enough of them to carry the stone.”

Bell cleared his throat.

“There was disagreement about whether the car should receive a separate statue.”

I looked at him.

He looked at the Lamborghini parked nearby.

“I remain in favor.”

Shawna started laughing so hard she had to hold my arm.

The statue's lightning rod chose that moment to catch a harmless little spark from the passing weather. Blue light ran down the stone arm and into the carved car.

The students applauded.

Tank pointed at it.

“Nigga, even the statue got powers.”

I looked up at my enormous stone face.

The sculptor had gotten one thing exactly right.

That nigga looked pleased to be there.

Breakfast became a parade before anybody could stop it.

Students lined the main drive with banners. The orchestra marched between the towers. Faculty walked beside our cars, shaking hands through the windows, offering invitations we would never have enough ordinary days to accept.

Miriam brought Bell's final inspection sheet for the Lamborghini and made me promise to listen if the engine sounded unhappy. I promised. She looked at Shawna until my wife promised too.

"Now I believe it," Miriam said.

Jakob played his violin beside the fountain. Not a song I knew. A song he had chosen for a morning with open air around him. Rivka sat nearby with her bag at her feet and a cup of coffee in both hands. She watched the absurd parade, then caught my eye and raised the cup.

I bowed my head to her.

No speech needed.

Harlan and Anne stood beneath a newly repaired arch of flowering branches. He wore the brown shoes. She had one hand tucked into his arm like she intended to keep it there for the rest of the day and perhaps several years afterward. He showed me a small flower growing out of a crack in the stone.

“This one wanted to be first,” he said.

Tank nodded approvingly.

“Nigga got good influences.”

We said goodbye to people whose lives would continue after our engines faded. That mattered to me more than I expected. Sky High wasn't becoming a place we had saved and could now forget. Victor would remain to train the next advanced class. Petra had accepted a rescue-instructor post and made Mercedes promise to visit before either of them tried pretending distance was a personality trait. Mercedes kissed her and said she had never been shy about booking a flight.

Porsche said goodbye to Leon three times because he insisted on making the most of his gift.

“Don't get arrogant,” she told him after the third kiss.

“You kissed all three.”

“Nigga, I was checking consistency.”

Lena and Rosa promised to sing together again. Amaya had accepted a place at the academy's aquatic center, with a pool whose doors opened from the inside and a teaching schedule she had helped choose. Reiss was staying long enough to dismantle every remaining part of Voss's experiment. After that, he said, he wanted to see an ordinary beach with no physics involved beyond the waves.

I told him that sounded excellent.

Storm waited by the front staircase where I had first parked in her space.

The gold sign was still there.

It now read CAPTAIN AIDEN — WHENEVER HE IS HERE.

I looked at it.

Then at her.

“Dean.”

“Captain.”

We shook hands. No accidental spark this time. I knew enough to keep the little blue current inside me quiet.

“Come back,” she said.

“You sure? I made repairs expensive.”

“You made the place worth repairing.”

She embraced Shawna. Then Tank. Rosa. The whole crew, one by one, without making it ceremonial enough to hide that she meant it.

Victor stood beside my car.

He put a hand on the roof.

“One more race when you return.”

“You sure, nigga?”

“A fair one. No collapsing trains. No overloaded rings. No rescuing anybody halfway through.”

I looked at the sky.

“You asking a lot from the environment.”

He laughed.

Then he hugged me, hard.

“Thank you,” he said quietly.

I held him a second longer.

“Stay magnificent.”

He stepped back and smiled.

“You make it difficult to do anything else.”

The invitation arrived before I could get into the car.

A black airship descended beyond the front gate. Its side carried a gold crown above a checkered flag. A woman in a white driving suit came down the steps holding a long envelope on a silver tray.

Tank watched her approach.

“Nigga, another school?”

“I can't keep graduating. We running out of wall.”

She stopped before me and bowed her head.

“Captain Aiden. On behalf of Duke Aurelio Cruel, you are invited to the Grand Prix of Kings.”

The crowd around us quieted.

Victor's smile faded slightly.

“Cruel,” he said.

Storm looked at the crown on the airship.

“An ambitious host.”

I opened the envelope.

Inside lay a heavy card showing a coastline, a harbor full of yachts, and a race circuit curling between pale buildings beneath a blue Mediterranean sky. The winner would receive a prize fleet and the deed to a private island called Isla Gloria. The invitation promised a month of racing, music, luxury, and competition among people who considered losing a personal insult.

Nigga, they had written me a holiday.

There was a second card for Shawna.

An invitation to headline one of the evening performances.

And one for Rosa.

She read it over Tank's shoulder and stopped breathing for half a second.

“Aiden.”

“I see it.”

Shawna studied the picture of the ocean.

Not the yachts.

The water.

I watched her face change at the thought of it: sun, salt, a shore that stayed beneath your feet, a room where the loudest thing outside might be waves if I behaved for ten consecutive minutes.

“You want to go?” I asked.

She looked at me.

“I want the ocean.”

“Then we getting the ocean.”

Tank leaned over the invitation.

“Nigga, it says island too.”

“Baby asked for water. I like to include accessories.”

Storm laughed despite herself.

Victor shook his head with a grin that had returned in full.

The messenger looked from me to the Lamborghini, to the statue behind us, to the school full of people still waiting to wave goodbye.

For the first time, she seemed less certain about the competition she had come to invite me into.

“Shall I tell the duke you accept?”

I put the card inside my jacket, beside my badge.

“Tell that nigga to make room.”

Then I got into the Lamborghini.

Shawna sat beside me. Tank and Rosa climbed into the Mercedes. Mercedes and Porsche took their red convertible. Marcellus and Vega would travel with us as far as the city below before the whole crew arranged the next flight together.

The Heart remained above us, holding Sky High where it belonged.

The time door remained gone.

My new power rested quietly in my hands, a little blue promise with very clear limits.

The engine needed none of it to sound magnificent.

I started the car.

The whole school cheered.

We rolled down the open ramp this time. The proper one. The road shone beneath the tires and curved gently through the clouds. Behind us the academy rose into sunlight, scarred, repaired, loud with people who had earned the right to enjoy their own morning.

Shawna took my hand off the gearshift and held it against her knee.

“You happy?” she asked.

I looked at my wife. At the ruby. At the watch. At the road opening beyond the windshield.

Then I looked in the mirror and saw my people following.

“Nigga,” I said, “look how much world we still got.”

She smiled.

I put my foot down.

The clouds opened, and we went toward the sea.

BOOK III: THE FASTEST KING ALIVE

1. The Ocean Was Waiting on Me

The first thing I saw in Monaco was a man falling off a yacht with my name on it.

Not his name. Mine. AIDEN, in gold letters so big the helicopter had to swing around to get all of them in the window. Under that, somebody had written THE FASTEST KING ALIVE.

I hadn't even raced these niggas yet.

Shawna leaned across me. Her hair brushed my mouth, she smelled like the expensive part of a flower, and below us this grown man in a white dinner jacket was descending through the Mediterranean afternoon with a bottle of champagne still in his hand.

“Is that part of the welcome?” she said.

“Better not be the captain.”

Tank pressed his face against the opposite window. “Nigga, the captain got his own boat.”

“He better get back on it.”

The falling man caught a striped awning. It tore. He dropped another six feet, landed on a lower deck, bounced against a table and stood up holding the bottle over his head. A hundred people

cheered. He bowed with the deeply relaxed expression of a man who had never paid a hospital bill himself.

Rosa put her sunglasses back on. “I’m singing for these people at nine. If they’re dead by eight, I’m keeping the deposit.”

We had come down from Sky High two days earlier. Nigga, I had saved an entire school out of the sky and graduated so hard they played my arrival at the graduation before they played the graduation. I was supposed to take a vacation. Dean Storm had told me to rest, Chief Knox had told me to represent the department, and my wife had asked for an ocean.

An ocean sounded easy.

The duke’s invitation, delivered before we left the floating campus, said the winner of his monthlong Grand Prix of Kings would receive a fleet of cars, a fleet of yachts and an island called Isla Gloria. The island had a palace, an opera house, a private harbor and twelve beaches. Twelve, nigga. I figured Shawna could have one for each month, and I’d keep the water between them.

So we came to race.

My police Lamborghini arrived before I did. Dark blue, gold badge on the doors, blue lights tucked above the windshield. I could see it sitting on the yacht’s upper platform now, strapped beside a swimming pool full of women in shining swimsuits and men too rich to admit they couldn’t swim. Beside the car stood

Mercedes in white and Porsche in yellow, both arguing with a man whose hat had a feather three feet long.

They had flown ahead with Marcellus to make sure the rooms were right. Apparently the rooms had started a fight.

Our helicopter settled onto the rear deck. A valet hurried toward it with a little numbered ticket.

"For the aircraft, sir."

Tank looked at the ticket.

"Nigga, you parking the helicopter?"

"I supervise arrivals."

"This nigga supervised gravity and called it a job," I said.

The valet looked from Tank to me, then at the pool full of people watching us.

"You're Captain Aiden."

"Now you supervising recognition."

He laughed before he could stop himself. Then he put the ticket away and opened both arms toward the yacht like he had personally built it during our flight.

"Anything you need, Captain."

"Nigga, start with my people. Everybody eats, everybody gets a room, nobody got to explain who they came with twice."

He nodded hard and went to work.

Before the blades stopped, the man in the feathered hat marched toward us carrying a silver tray. He had a mustache thin enough to have been signed by a jeweler.

“Captain Aiden,” he announced. “By special instruction of His Grace, Duke Aurelio Cruel—”

“Nigga, somebody really put Cruel on the birth certificate?”

“An ancient name.”

“That don't improve it.”

Shawna squeezed my arm. The man tried again.

“I am Bellario, master of ceremonies and chief marshal of the Grand Prix. His Grace regrets that he cannot personally greet every invited contestant.”

He gestured toward the harbor. At the far end stood a black yacht with four decks and a gold statue of a horse kicking another gold horse in the face. A man in a pale green suit stood on its balcony beneath a huge umbrella. Even from three hundred yards away I could tell he was looking directly at me.

“He's right there,” I said.

“His Grace is at luncheon.”

“Tell him chew faster.”

Bellario's mustache moved without the rest of his face. Mercedes came over carrying the hat's missing feather.

“This nigga said we can't be on the drivers' floor,” she said.

Porsche followed with a room key between two fingers. “Then he offered to upgrade us if we had dinner with him.”

Bellario straightened. “A misunderstanding.”

“Then misunderstand this.” Porsche dropped the key onto his tray. “We already bought the floor.”

I looked at her.

“With your money,” she added.

“Good.”

“Both floors.”

“Better.”

Bellario took a breath. On his tray lay a blue velvet box. He opened it, revealing a little bronze steering wheel on a chain.

“Each contestant must earn the gold wheel before participating in the Grand Prix. The qualification exhibition begins in one hour. An unfortunate late arrival may find the entry list already closed.”

“Nigga, I’m on time.”

“For your arrival, certainly.”

He turned the tray slightly, like that was going to make his sentence less stupid.

Tank stepped out of the helicopter behind me. The rear of the helicopter lifted when his weight came off it. Bellario saw him

and briefly reconsidered everything his family had done to bring him into the world.

“The course,” Bellario continued, “is a ceremonial run from the harbor to the Royal Meridian Hotel. Contestants depart from the eastern quay. We are, regrettably, moored at the western quay.”

“How far?”

“Eleven minutes by tender. Forty by road.”

“And when do they close the list?”

“In seven.”

Shawna turned toward the duke's yacht. The man in green raised a glass.

Oh, this nigga wanted to play before I unpacked.

I took the little bronze wheel and hung it around Bellario's neck.

“You wear that, my nigga. It'll remind you of what almost happened.”

Then I walked toward my car.

There are people who think because you own a helicopter you have to use the helicopter. These are the same people who look at a Lamborghini on a yacht and see a transportation problem. I saw my car. My car saw me. Its doors came up before I touched them, and one of the women in the pool screamed like the machine had proposed marriage.

Shawna got in beside me.

“Baby,” she said, “tell me this yacht has a road.”

“It got a front.”

“Aiden.”

“Trust the front.”

Tank climbed onto a nearby launch with Rosa. Mercedes and Porsche followed him, still carrying the feather. Marcellus emerged from the cabin holding a little cup of coffee, saw me putting the car in motion, and sat back down very carefully.

“I’ll meet you at the hotel,” he said.

Smart nigga.

Ahead, a service ramp reached from our yacht to a broad floating stage. The stage held a piano, six flower towers and a singer who had started warming up. Beyond it, a smaller yacht rocked gently at its moorings. Beyond that, the eastern quay glittered in the sun.

A reasonable person would have stopped at the word beyond.

I kissed my wife.

“You ready to see the ocean?”

“I was hoping from a chair.”

The engine rose under us. People turned. The singer held one note so long it became fear. I took us down the service ramp, across the stage and past the piano with maybe an inch on each side. The pianist kept playing. That nigga respected his craft.

We hit the edge of the stage with enough speed to make the sea disappear below the windshield.

For a second, all I could see was sky.

Shawna grabbed my arm and laughed one huge terrified laugh directly into my ear.

“Aiden, you stupid beautiful motherfucker!”

Then the tires landed on the smaller yacht's sun deck.

A table collapsed behind us. A man in a silk robe threw both hands up, either praying or awarding me points. I kept the wheel straight. The front of his yacht dipped under our weight; its bow lifted into a ramp. Nigga, the boat helped me. Some things understand greatness immediately.

We launched again.

The car hit the quay sideways, tires shouting, and I pulled it into a turn so clean a line of photographers all stepped backward at the same time. My blue lights flashed across their faces. Behind us, the smaller yacht's owner stood on his deck cheering with the broken table leg over his head.

We had six minutes left.

At the entry gate a woman in a silver racing suit looked from my badge to my car to the two yachts we had just crossed.

“You were on the wrong side,” she said.

“I corrected it.”

She held out a clipboard.

“Name?”

“Nigga, look at the yacht.”

She did. Then she wrote AIDEN in letters large enough to be seen from the yacht.

The starting area was already full of cars. A red machine with white stripes sat low as a threat beside a silver coupe. Behind them waited a black car wearing the number one, its nose shaped like a shark that had married money. The driver leaned on its door in a chrome jacket, thirty-one years old, handsome and aware of it.

He watched the torn flowers falling out of my grille.

“Interesting route,” he said.

“You should see the parking.”

“Cassius Chrome.”

“Aiden.”

“I know.”

He said it without smiling. I liked that. A nigga who knew my name and still wanted to beat me was at least taking his life seriously.

The driver of the red car came over pulling off her gloves. Inez Inferno, the woman whose face appeared on half the racing posters between the airport and the harbor. She had dark hair

braided tight, a narrow scar on her chin and eyes that assessed me like she was deciding which part of my car to pass first.

“You brought a passenger,” she said.

“My wife.”

“This isn't a scenic tour.”

“It is for her.”

Shawna leaned out. “I'm Shawna.”

“Inez.”

They shook hands through the window.

“If he scares you,” Inez told her, “you can ride with me.”

Shawna glanced at the sea behind us. “I think we passed scared at the piano.”

Inez laughed. Not polite, either. A real laugh that changed her whole face. Then she looked at me again.

“Keep up, Captain.”

Bellario's voice crackled over the speakers. Somehow the nigga had reached his microphone before his dignity. He announced that the exhibition would follow the Royal Corniche, climb through the old town and finish at the hotel. The first three would receive gold wheels. Everybody else could enjoy the parties and explain to their children why they had become spectators.

I didn't need a gold wheel. I had four black ones and a wife wearing diamonds. But sometimes you let the occasion catch up to your standards.

Cassius leaned across his window one last time.

"Nigga, was that really your first time crossing those boats?"

"That nigga's asking about practice," I told Shawna. "He thinks I practiced disrespecting the marina."

"Did you?" she asked.

"Nigga, you were there."

"I'm checking whether you had a smaller marina at home."

Cassius laughed. "This nigga got a wife who investigates him."

"Nigga needs one," Inez said from the other side.

"Niggas," I said, "the investigation can follow my taillights."

The light changed.

Cassius left like the devil had called him personally. Inez went beside him, red car snapping through the first bend. I let them get out together. Then I put my foot down.

The Lamborghini roared between two white cars whose drivers both looked over at once. I could see one man's mouth shape the word police. Nigga, yes. Put your seat belt on emotionally.

We swept beside the harbor. Yachts leaned in their ropes. On the balconies, people waved flags. At the first sharp turn, Cassius

slipped inside Inez, and she answered by driving so close to his rear bumper their reflections touched. They were good. I could see it immediately. Neither wasted a movement. Neither needed to look back to know the other was there.

I liked them even more.

Then a green car came out of a side street where no race car should have been.

It had no number.

Its driver wore a pale mask.

He aimed straight at Cassius.

“Nigga, what—”

Cassius swerved. The green car struck the wall and spun across the road. Inez shot through the gap. Cassius's front wheel caught the stone curb. His black car lifted, struck a low barrier and hung there with the right side over a hundred feet of open air.

The crowd stopped sounding like a crowd.

Shawna's hand closed on my wrist.

“Aiden.”

“I see him.”

The road was still full of racing cars. I pulled across it, blocked the next two and jumped out before mine finished rocking. Cassius was fighting his belt inside the black car. Every movement lowered its nose farther over the drop.

“Stay still!” I shouted.

“Get me out!”

“Nigga, that is the plan. Help the plan by not rolling into the sea.”

I climbed onto the barrier. The metal under my hands was hot. Below me the harbor flashed between buildings, and I could hear a woman's voice screaming Cassius's name over and over. He looked up at me through the open side window.

“You can't hold the car.”

“I can hold you.”

The wheel slipped.

Blue light cracked across my fingers.

It came fast, the way it had at Sky High, a sharp electric pressure that seemed to start behind my teeth and run down my bones. I could use it. I could not ask it to last forever. The first time I had tried that, my knees had explained the limits to the rest of me.

So I spent it on one thing.

I caught Cassius by the front of his jacket, pulled him through the window and threw both of us backward onto the road just as the car went over.

The black machine dropped out of sight.

A beat later something huge struck the water below.

Cassius lay across me, breathing like he had stolen the air.

“Nigga,” I said, “you got to get off my chain.”

He looked down. Dante's gold cross was caught beneath his sleeve. He freed it with shaking fingers.

I sat up. The road tilted once. Shawna was already beside me, her hands on my face, checking my eyes.

“How much?” she asked quietly.

“One burst.”

“Tell me the truth.”

“One burst, baby.”

She nodded. Then she kissed me hard enough to make the whole street remember there were other reasons to lose your breath.

By the time she pulled away, the crowd had found its voice.

They were screaming my name.

People on the balconies screamed it. Drivers standing beside their stopped cars screamed it. The silver-suited woman from the entry gate had apparently run half the course and now stood on a staircase shouting, “That's the yacht man!” like it was a title passed through generations.

Cassius got to his feet slowly. He stared at the broken barrier, then at me.

“You stopped your race.”

“You was in it.”

He shook his head.

“Nobody stops here.”

I stood. My legs were steady again, mostly. I dusted off my jacket, straightened the cross and looked toward the hill.

“Nigga, I didn't say I quit.”

We put Cassius in the back of a marshal's car. I got behind my wheel. Shawna tightened her belt and gave me the look she used when she wanted to call me an idiot but was too proud of me to make it sound convincing.

“Three minutes behind,” she said.

“Then we should go.”

The Lamborghini climbed.

I didn't use the blue thunder again. I used my eyes, my hands and the fact that I had not come all this way to lose a little wheel to men who wore driving gloves at breakfast. We passed four cars through the old town. We passed two more beneath a railway bridge. At a bend lined with white flowers, I saw Inez ahead and a yellow car beside her, fighting for first.

Shawna started laughing.

“What?” I said.

“You really think you're going to do it.”

“Nigga, I know I'm going to do it.”

The hotel rose at the top of the hill, all marble balconies and flags. The final straight narrowed between fountains. Inez moved left. The yellow car moved right. Neither had left room for me.

So I drove through the fountain.

Water hit the windshield like applause with weight. Shawna shrieked. Stone dolphins vanished on either side. We came out in a shining wall of spray, hit the finish line half a hood ahead of Inez and stopped beneath the hotel's canopy with a live ornamental fish on the windshield.

For two seconds nobody moved.

Then the doorman took off his hat.

“Welcome, Your Majesty.”

I looked at Shawna.

She was soaked, gorgeous and laughing so hard she couldn't answer.

Inez rolled up beside us. She looked at the fish. She looked at me. Finally she slapped both hands against her steering wheel and laughed too.

“You ridiculous motherfucker.”

I picked the fish off the glass and handed it to the doorman.

“Put my nigga back in his house.”

Above us, on the grand balcony, Duke Aurelio Cruel stood beside a table laid for lunch. His green suit shone. His glass had stopped halfway to his mouth.

Bellario arrived carrying a gold wheel.

This time he didn't make a speech.

He put it around my neck with both hands.

Shawna stepped out of the car. The crowd moved toward us in a wave, shouting, filming, holding out hats and champagne and one man's marriage certificate for reasons he was going to have to explain to his wife. I pulled Shawna against me before they could separate us.

“Got your ocean,” I said.

She brushed a drop of fountain water off my cheek.

“Now get me a towel, fastest man alive.”

I looked up at the duke.

He set his glass down.

The month had begun.

2. The Woman Who Drove Through Fire

The Royal Meridian gave me a bedroom with a ceiling painted like heaven and a bathtub big enough to baptize a basketball team. Two porters argued over which bags belonged to me.

"The black ones are the captain's."

"Nigga, all of them are the captain's," Tank said.

"Even the white—"

"Especially the white ones. That's his wife."

"And the trunks?"

"That's the nigga preparing to stay great in different weather."

I let them finish before pointing to Shawna's little blue case.

"That one comes with me."

A porter reached for it anyway.

"Nigga, I said with me. My wife asked me to carry it. I ain't promoting you into my marriage."

Shawna leaned against the door laughing. The porter apologized, grinning now, and Tank took the two largest trunks himself because the conversation had apparently made him impatient with luggage.

I put Shawna in the bathtub before anybody had a chance to ask me another question.

She sat among the bubbles with her hair pinned up, holding the gold wheel I had won and turning it between her fingers.

Through the open balcony doors we could see the harbor, the yacht with my name, and the smaller yacht whose owner had already renamed it AIDEN LANDED HERE.

“Nigga got a gift shop open,” I said.

Shawna looked over my shoulder. On the smaller boat, somebody was carrying boxes of shirts onto the deck.

“You owe that man a table.”

“I gave him a business.”

“You gave him tire tracks.”

“Limited edition.”

She tried to stay serious. Failed. I took that as permission to kiss her again.

For a while the whole Grand Prix could do whatever the fuck it wanted outside. I had warm water, my wife and a door that locked. When we finally got dressed, her lipstick was on my shoulder and a bell was ringing somewhere in the suite with the desperate persistence of a man who didn't know how close he was to getting fired.

Tank stood at the door holding the room-service bell between two fingers.

“Why didn't you knock?” I asked.

“I did. The door didn't answer.”

Behind him, Rosa had a plate of fruit. Mercedes wore a silk robe over her clothes because, according to her, the robe was included and she was getting her money's worth. Porsche had three phones laid out on a tray and was talking into the fourth.

“No,” she told somebody. “He saved your favorite driver and beat your other favorite driver. The price changed twice.”

I pointed at her.

“What's that?”

“Appearances.”

“I ain't said yes to appearances.”

“That's why they cost extra.”

She covered the phone with her hand. “You want six hundred thousand to eat dinner near a watch?”

“Does the watch eat?”

“No.”

“Make it eight.”

She nodded and went back to the call like this was exactly the kind of business judgment she had expected.

Marcellus sat beside the balcony with a little screwdriver and my gold wheel. He had taken the chain off because the clasp was cheap.

“Gold plate,” he said.

“Nigga.”

“Very thick plate.”

“That ain't the point.”

“No,” he agreed. “It rarely is.”

He fitted a better clasp, one of his own, then held the wheel to the light.

“Beautiful work on the face. Someone talented made the original design. Someone cheap ordered the copies.”

Rosa stopped eating her grapes.

“The musicians say nobody's been paid in three weeks.”

Porsche lowered her phone.

“They told the dancers tomorrow.”

Mercedes leaned against the doorway. “They told the drivers' hosts next week. One girl asked to leave, and the hotel said her passport was at the island office.”

The room changed. Not dramatically. Nobody stood up with a speech. But Tank put the bell down, and Shawna stopped turning the wheel.

“How many?” I asked.

“Don't know yet,” Mercedes said. “Enough that they're scared to count in front of anybody.”

There are lies rich niggas tell because they want more money, and lies they tell because they think other people belong to them. The second kind always pisses me off faster. I had bought enough things to know the difference between owning a building and owning the woman standing in it.

Porsche's phone started ringing again. She silenced it.

“There's a mechanic downstairs who wants to see you. She says you picked up something in your grille.”

“The fish?”

“No. A piece of the green car.”

We went downstairs together.

The hotel's underground garage looked like somebody had threatened a museum until it learned to accelerate. Red Ferraris, silver machines with doors like wings, a white car sitting under its own chandelier. My Lamborghini stood in the middle with half the harbor still drying on it.

A woman with close-cut hair and grease on one cheek waited beside the front wheel. She wore blue overalls tied at the waist and a pair of gold hoops so large I respected her confidence around machinery.

“Lark,” she said. “Thirty-two, chief mechanic for the Silver Arrow team until somebody sold the team without telling the people inside it.”

She gave me a handshake strong enough to be honest.

“Aiden.”

“I watched.”

She held up a bent piece of green metal.

“This was lodged below your light. The car that hit Chrome wasn't part of the field.”

“I noticed the mask.”

“I mean it belongs to the harbor service. It should have been carrying luggage.”

Tank took the fragment and turned it over.

“That's some violent luggage.”

Lark didn't smile.

“My partner drove one of those cars. Mateo. He's been missing nine days.”

Shawna stepped closer. “Your partner on the team?”

“My partner in my house.”

She said it firmly, like she was tired of people trying to make the missing part smaller.

“He's thirty-four. Laughs with his whole mouth. Puts salt on pineapple. Buys me flowers even though I keep telling him a plant would survive longer. His last message said they wanted extra crew for the island. Then nothing.”

Mercedes folded her arms.

“They keep sending people there.”

Lark looked at her. “You heard it too?”

“I hear things men think women ain't listening to.”

I took the green fragment from Tank.

“What do you need?” I asked.

“To know whether you really stopped for Cassius. Or whether it was a show.”

“Nigga was hanging off a cliff. That's an expensive show.”

She studied me. Then she nodded once.

“I need somebody who can get through a door they won't open for me.”

“Show me the door.”

Before she could answer, an engine shouted from the garage entrance.

Inez's red car came down the ramp and stopped close enough for its heat to reach my shoes. She climbed out in black jeans and a

red sleeveless shirt, braid down her back, the gold wheel she had won hanging against her chest.

“I’ve been looking for you,” she said.

“Everybody has.”

“I found you first.”

She looked at Shawna. “You hungry?”

“Yes.”

“Good. My father cooks. He lives on the mountain. I brought two cars.”

I looked past her. A second red car waited at the top of the ramp.

“Nigga, that sounds like a race wearing a dinner jacket.”

“It can be both.”

Her eyes dropped to the green metal in my hand. For the first time since I’d met her, her smile went away completely.

“Where did you get that?”

“Out of my fish tank.”

“Aiden,” Shawna said.

“Out of the car.”

Inez reached for the fragment, then stopped before touching it.

“Bring Lark,” she said. “And don’t let a hotel car follow you.”

The mountain road started above the city and climbed into terraces of olive trees, old stone walls and houses whose balconies seemed to be standing on faith. Inez led in her red machine. Shawna sat beside me, Lark in the back of a car Porsche had obtained by pointing at it and saying, "That one belongs with us now." Tank followed in a black SUV so large it made the little stone villages look recently built around it.

At the first overlook, Inez stopped and got out.

"There's a restaurant at the top," she said. "Nine turns. Two narrow bridges. No traffic this afternoon; they close it for race practice."

"Your father live at the restaurant?"

"No. We eat there first, so he's got time to stop pretending he isn't excited."

Shawna laughed.

Inez rested her arms on my open window.

"The exhibition was one thing. You went through a fountain."

"It was in the way."

"You're fast. But this road is mine."

I looked at the road curling up behind her. Beautiful road. Lots of opportunity to be wrong in public.

"What we racing for?"

"An honest answer."

“To what?”

“Why you're here.”

“Shawna wanted the ocean.”

Inez waited.

“Nigga, that is the honest answer.”

She looked at my wife. Shawna shrugged.

“I did.”

For a moment Inez seemed almost disappointed. She had probably expected a secret revenge, a lost fortune, a hidden father. People see a man driving a police Lamborghini across yachts and assume his life requires explanation. Sometimes a nigga just loves his wife.

“Then race for dinner,” she said.

I glanced at Shawna.

“Baby?”

She tightened her belt.

“Win me something with potatoes.”

Inez went first.

She knew every inch of that mountain. I could tell by the way she entered a turn before the turn seemed to exist, the way her red car moved from sunlight to shadow without any hesitation.

She wasn't performing for me. She was speaking a language she'd learned before anybody told her it was difficult.

I answered with my right foot.

We climbed past a chapel and two empty market squares. At the first bridge she gained half a car. At the second I took it back. Shawna watched the road with one hand on the dashboard and the other on my thigh, not holding me down, just staying connected to the nigga who had decided dinner should happen at a hundred impossible miles an hour.

Inez's car flicked left around a stone fountain.

I stayed on the road this time. Growth.

Then we hit the smoke.

It rolled across the upper bend, black and thick, carrying the bitter smell of burning rubber. Inez braked. I pulled beside her. Through the smoke, a delivery truck sat sideways against the wall, its cab burning. Beyond it, a little open-top car had stopped with its driver trapped between the truck and the drop.

A man in a chef's jacket stood on the far side waving both arms.

"Papa," Inez said.

She was out of her car before the word finished.

I caught her wrist as she passed.

"Together."

"That's my father."

“I heard you.”

Her eyes hit mine, hot with the kind of fear that wants to turn itself into violence. Then she nodded, and we ran into the smoke.

The heat slapped us. Inez pulled her shirt over her mouth and reached the small car. Her father was outside it, trying to free the truck's driver from the burning cab. Another man lay on the road, dazed, one arm over his face.

Inez went to the man on the road. I went to her father.

“Move back,” I said.

“He's caught.”

“I see him.”

The truck driver was conscious, terrified, his belt jammed beneath a twisted piece of door. I didn't need a lesson in trucks to know we had very little time. I grabbed what was in the way and pulled.

It moved an inch.

Fire climbed the dashboard.

“Nigga,” I told the truck, “don't make this complicated.”

I pulled again.

This time the metal gave enough. Inez's father reached in beside me, and between us we dragged the driver out. His shoes hit the road. He tried to stand. Couldn't. I threw his arm over my

shoulder and carried him away while Inez helped the other man toward our cars.

Shawna was already there with water and a cloth from the back seat. She took the driver's face gently between her hands.

“Look at me. You're out. Stay with me.”

Behind us the truck's front tire burst with a sound like a shot.

Tank's SUV came around the bend. He stopped, took in the fire, the men, Inez and her father, then looked at me.

“Nigga, we left you alone for six minutes.”

“Dinner got delayed.”

He lifted the second injured man into the SUV like the man weighed the same as a suit jacket. Lark got in beside him.

Porsche called ahead to the mountain clinic. Mercedes flagged the practice marshals arriving from below, and within a minute everybody had a job except the fire, which continued being a disrespectful motherfucker until a crew put it out.

Inez stood beside her father. He had gray at his temples, a burn on one sleeve and hands that wouldn't stop shaking. She held both of them.

“Why were you up here?” she asked.

“The restaurant called. They said you wanted—”

He stopped.

I saw her face change.

“I didn't call the restaurant.”

Nobody spoke for a moment.

Then her father looked at me.

“You are Aiden.”

“Yes, sir.”

“My daughter said you were very annoying.”

“Papa.”

He held out his shaking hand.

“She was smiling when she said it.”

I shook it carefully.

“Esteban Inferno,” he said. “You saved my life, and my daughter's pride will never recover.”

“Nigga, her pride looked healthy in them turns.”

Inez let out a breath that almost became a laugh. She brushed soot off her father's cheek, then turned toward the burned truck.

Its rear doors had fallen open. Inside were cases of fruit, a few crates of flowers and a green service-car panel stacked behind them.

The same green as the fragment in my pocket.

Lark saw it too.

“They didn't want you at his house,” she said.

Esteban closed his eyes.

For the first time, he looked old.

Tank watched the emergency crew load the last injured man into a vehicle.

"Nigga, we was racing for potatoes."

"We still eating potatoes," I said.

"Nigga, the potatoes got witnesses now."

Esteban looked between us. "Does he always talk like this?"

"Which nigga?" Shawna asked.

He pointed at me.

"That nigga makes it everybody's evening," Tank said.

"You came," I told him.

"Nigga, you had the address."

Inez took her father's arm. "Come on. Let the niggas argue where the food is."

We ate at his house anyway.

It stood above the road, white walls, blue shutters, a courtyard full of lemon trees. The dining table was long enough for all of us. Esteban insisted on cooking, even with the burn on his sleeve, and Inez argued with him until Shawna quietly handed her a knife and a bowl of vegetables.

"Help him do it," she said.

So Inez helped.

I stood at the courtyard wall watching the sea below. Cassius arrived in a borrowed silver car with one arm in a sling and a bottle of wine under the other.

“Nigga, you drive that yourself?” I asked.

“With one good arm I’m still quicker than most people with two.”

“Most people ain’t me.”

“No,” he said. “They aren’t.”

He put the bottle on the table and held out his good hand. This handshake felt different from the one we had never actually had at the starting line. His fingers closed hard around mine.

“I watched the harbor footage,” he said. “You jumped a Lamborghini across two yachts, pulled me out of my car and still won.”

“Three things.”

“What?”

“You forgot the fish.”

He stared at me. Then he started laughing. It hurt his shoulder, so he held it and kept laughing anyway.

At dinner Esteban served lamb, potatoes crisp at the edges, bread warm enough to steam when Tank tore it. Shawna held up her fork toward me.

“You won the potatoes.”

Inez shook her head. “We didn't finish.”

“My wife eating them, ain't she?”

Everybody laughed except Esteban, who was looking at the green fragment beside my plate.

Finally he picked it up.

“Seven years ago,” he said, “a car this color followed my wife to the last race she ever attended.”

Inez put her fork down.

“Papa.”

“You brought him here.”

“Because he saved Cassius.”

“And now he has saved me.” Esteban turned the piece of metal in his hand. “Perhaps I have been waiting for a man who would stop.”

The courtyard grew quiet. Beyond the wall, the sun touched the sea.

Esteban reached into his shirt and drew out a little folded photograph. He placed it beside the green metal. A woman stood in front of a racing car, smiling into the camera with one hand lifted to block the sun. She wore a plain blue dress. On the car behind her, someone had painted a white bird.

“My wife was Amalia,” he said. “She loved this race before the duke turned it into a kingdom.”

I looked at the photograph. Then at the mountains, the road and the impossible amount of money glittering below us.

“What happened?” I asked.

Esteban watched his daughter's face for a long moment.

“I believed the wrong man,” he said.

And underneath the table, Shawna took my hand.

3. Dinner with a Man Named Cruel

Esteban said the wrong man's name, and Cassius stood up so fast his chair fell over.

“Nero Chrome,” Esteban said.

“That was my father.”

“I know whose father he was.”

“Nigga,” I said, “everybody leave the potatoes out of this.”

Cassius wasn't looking at me. He had one hand flat on the table and the other held against his injured shoulder. Esteban sat very straight, his wife's picture beneath his palm. Inez stood between them before either man moved again.

“Papa, you don't know everything.”

“I know who was beside the car.”

“You know what Bellario told you.”

Cassius laughed once. No amusement in it.

“Of course. Bellario.”

He turned toward the courtyard gate.

I caught him there.

“Where you going?”

“Somewhere my father isn't being tried by a man who let the duke buy his mouth.”

Esteban's chair scraped behind us.

Tank put one hand on its back.

“Sit down, my nigga.”

“I will not—”

“Then stand still. Pick one.”

I kept my eyes on Cassius.

“You can hear him and still hate what he says.”

“I've heard it for seven years.”

“Then hear it once with me here.”

His jaw moved. He looked at Shawna, who had come to stand beside the table, holding Amalia's photograph carefully by the edges.

“Your father drove this car?” she asked.

Cassius looked back despite himself.

“The White Heron,” he said. “He built it with Esteban.”

“Then sit down and tell us something nobody else gets right.”

That reached him.

He picked his chair up. He didn't apologize, and Esteban didn't ask him to. Sometimes, nigga, the best you can get from two men is both their asses back at the table.

Esteban began again.

Seven years earlier, the Grand Prix had been smaller. There were rich men in it, but money wasn't the only invitation. Mechanics entered cars they had built behind their houses. Boat captains raced old engines down the coast. The drivers ate at the same tables as the people who changed their tires, and at the end of the month the winner sailed to Isla Gloria with everybody who had helped him get there.

“Amalia loved the last night,” Esteban said. “She would dance until the musicians begged her to stop.”

Rosa smiled faintly. “I know that kind of woman.”

“She collected people. If a waiter looked lonely, suddenly he was sitting with us. If a driver lost, she found something he had done well and made him talk about that. When Aurelio bought the race, she told him the prize was already here. He only needed to leave it alone.”

“What'd he say?” I asked.

“That a woman who enjoyed giving things away should marry a poorer man.”

“Nigga.”

Esteban nodded.

“He said it smiling.”

That year Esteban and Nero had entered the White Heron together. One drove the mountain stages, the other the coastal ones. Amalia kept their books, knew every worker by name and had discovered that the prize fleet included vessels the duke had never actually paid for. Their owners had been promised shares in the Grand Prix. Instead, crews stopped receiving wages, captains disappeared from the entry list and the harbor gates began closing at night.

“She went to the island,” Esteban said. “A captain named Celadon took her. She came back with a packet of papers and told me we had to finish the race. Win it in front of everybody. Then we could make him give back what he had taken.”

“Why didn't she show you the papers?” Shawna asked.

“She did. I looked at the first page, kissed her forehead and said I trusted her.”

His voice roughened.

“I thought that was the same as listening.”

I felt Shawna's thumb move against my hand.

Esteban told us about the final mountain stage. The White Heron led by eleven seconds. Nero had driven the morning. Esteban was due to take over at the ridge. Amalia traveled ahead in a little blue support car carrying the papers and the team's food, because even when a man was about to expose a duke she thought he ought to have lunch.

At the ridge, Nero never arrived.

Instead, Bellario brought news that the support car had gone over the road. Amalia was dead. Nero had vanished. A green harbor car had been seen leaving the scene.

“The duke showed me a signed withdrawal,” Esteban said.

“Nero's name. Money paid. A place on a ship leaving that night. Bellario said he watched Nero get into the green car.”

Cassius leaned forward.

“My father couldn't write with his right hand that week. He'd broken two fingers.”

Esteban blinked.

“The signature was steady as a schoolmaster's,” Cassius said. “I told them. I was twenty-four, and I told every man in that room. They said grief was making me irrational.”

“Why didn't you tell me?”

“You wouldn't open your gate.”

The words landed harder than shouting would have.

Esteban stared at him. Inez looked away, and I understood this was a conversation they had been walking around for seven years, keeping it alive by never allowing it to finish.

Cassius took something out of his jacket. A little metal bird, white paint worn off one wing.

“My father gave me this the morning of the race. Said if he won, I'd drive the first lap next year.”

He set it beside Amalia's photograph.

“He never came home.”

Outside the courtyard a car horn sounded.

Nobody moved.

It sounded again, and Tank stood up with the expression of a man grateful for a fresh target. He opened the gate. Bellario stood beyond it beside a cream-colored limousine, dressed for dinner, feather restored.

“His Grace requests Captain Aiden's presence at the opening banquet.”

I looked at the nigga for a long time.

“Does he?”

“Attendance is traditional.”

“So is knocking.”

Bellario glanced past Tank and saw the table. Saw Cassius, Esteban, Inez. His face didn't change, but his eyes counted us twice.

“An intimate gathering,” he said.

“Getting less intimate.”

Shawna squeezed my hand and stood.

“We'll be there.”

Bellario bowed to her with the precise depth of a man who practiced alone.

“His Grace particularly hopes you will sing.”

“Then he should particularly hope he's paid my musicians.”

The bow ended early.

After he left, Esteban went inside and returned with a small lacquer box. He opened it to reveal a folded letter, a yellow ribbon and a photograph of Amalia laughing beside a white boat.

“This came three days after she died,” he said. “A woman delivered it. She wouldn't give her name. I read the first line so many times I almost wore through it.”

“What's it say?” I asked.

He unfolded the top edge.

“Esteban, if you are reading this without me, do not let a man who never loved either of us explain my last day.”

Cassius closed his eyes.

Esteban held the letter toward Inez.

“I wasn't brave enough to obey her.”

She took it without a word.

We left the table standing. Plates, bread, photograph, the little white bird. Nobody tried to make it look like a dinner that had ended normally.

At the hotel, Shawna changed into a blue dress that moved around her legs like water had learned her name. She wore Dante's watch on her wrist and earrings I had given her after Sky High. She stood before the mirror fastening one, and I came up behind her.

"You want to skip this?" I asked.

"No."

"We can eat somewhere nobody named Cruel owns the forks."

She met my eyes in the mirror.

"I want to sing. I want Rosa to get paid. I want that nigga to look at us across his own table while we find out what he's hiding."

"That's my wife."

She turned around.

"And you want to race him."

"I want to beat him."

"Then do it with your eyes open."

I kissed her forehead.

She pushed my chest lightly.

"Don't Esteban me."

Nigga, I laughed so hard she smiled before she could help it. Then I took her face in both hands.

"I hear you. You want to sing, Rosa gets paid, we watch the duke. I don't go running off because somebody waves a faster car."

"And?"

"And if it's a really fast car, I bring you."

She hit me with the earring box.

The banquet occupied a terrace above the sea. Three hundred people sat beneath chandeliers hanging from living trees. At the entrance, a young doorman looked at my invitation, then at my badge, then back at the invitation.

"It says king."

"It also says captain," I told him.

"Which should I announce?"

Tank leaned over his shoulder.

"Nigga, use your diaphragm and say both."

"Is there a preferred order?"

"The nigga arrived first at everything today. Any order works."

The doorman laughed, took a breath and announced me so loudly the nearest chandelier trembled.

I slipped a folded bill into his palm.

"That's for respecting punctuation."

He looked at the amount, looked at me and announced my wife with even more feeling. Nigga had found a second diaphragm. A string orchestra played on a platform over the swimming pool. Along the terrace stood twelve cars under silk covers, each with its own guard and a woman holding a silver card naming the race it belonged to.

I walked in with Shawna on my arm, my badge against my chest and Tank behind me in a white suit that made him look like he had personally purchased summer.

Conversations stopped in waves.

The first wave was people recognizing me. The second was people asking the first wave who I was. The third was everybody looking at Shawna and deciding the answer must be more impressive than they had heard.

The duke rose from a long table at the center.

Aurelio Cruel was forty-eight, tall, broad through the shoulders, handsome in the way a sword can be handsome before somebody pulls it out. His hair was black with two white streaks. He wore a green diamond on one hand and a watch whose face seemed larger than the gold wheel I'd won.

"Captain," he said. "Your entrance this afternoon was costly."

"For who?"

The people close enough to hear laughed before they looked at him. He let them finish.

“For the harbor's dignity.”

“Nigga, the harbor selling shirts.”

This time the laughter reached the next table.

He smiled. “Come. Sit beside me.”

There were two chairs waiting. One for me, one for Shawna. Farther down the terrace, Mercedes and Porsche had been directed toward a little table behind a pillar.

I stopped.

“Where's my people?”

“We've arranged seating by distinction.”

“Then you arranged it wrong.”

The duke rested his fingertips on the back of my chair.

“A captain. A celebrated singer. Naturally, some guests have qualifications others do not.”

Mercedes had heard him. She walked over before I could answer, yellow silk catching the light.

“Mine got you to call my agency three times last year,” she said.

“Porsche's got your minister to pay double for dinner and still ask if she had a sister.”

Porsche appeared beside her.

“I told him no. He looked financially devastated.”

A man at the duke's table suddenly became fascinated by his soup.

The duke's smile thinned.

“There is no need for vulgarity.”

“Nigga, you invited me,” I said.

I took the chair beside him, lifted it and carried it to Mercedes's table. Tank picked up the table itself. Rosa brought the flowers. Within twenty seconds we had joined two tables together directly in front of the orchestra, and half the terrace was standing to help because nobody wanted to be the last person on the wrong side of the evening.

Cassius arrived with Inez. He saw what we were doing and dragged his own chair over one-handed.

“Careful,” I told him.

“It's my good arm.”

“Keep one.”

The duke stood alone beside his empty place settings.

Then he laughed.

It was a good laugh. Full, generous, almost convincing.

“A king makes his own table,” he said.

I sat down and pulled Shawna into the chair beside me.

“Now you catching on.”

The waiter approached with a bottle and looked at the duke, then at me.

"Who should taste?"

"That nigga owns the bottle," Tank said. "This nigga owns the table."

"I own neither," I said. "My wife wanted wine. Give the woman wine."

Shawna held out her glass. "These niggas will appoint a president of the bottle if you let them."

Mercedes nodded. "Nigga will run unopposed."

"And win," I said.

The waiter laughed so suddenly he had to steady the bottle with both hands. The duke didn't laugh at all. Nigga was losing authority to a drink he had paid for.

Dinner came. Lobster, lamb, fish served whole on silver platters. Tank looked at the fish and said, "This better not be the nigga you saved." Rosa nearly dropped her wine.

The duke joined us after the second course. He had accepted that if he wanted the most important table at his party, he would have to sit at mine.

He told stories about princes losing fortunes. He described a driver who had bet his castle and left in a taxi. He named the

prize fleet: forty road cars, twelve racing cars, six yachts and a flagship called the Sovereign Sun. At the end of the month, the winner would sail that flagship into Isla Gloria's harbor and receive the island before every camera in the world.

"And if you lose?" I asked.

"I do not compete."

"Convenient."

"I own the competition."

"For now."

He watched me over his glass.

Shawna's hand settled on my knee.

The orchestra quieted. Rosa rose first, went to the little stage and sang a song so rich and warm the sea itself seemed to lean closer. Tank sat still through the whole thing. Nigga, the man could lift a table with dinner on it, but that woman's voice pinned him to a chair.

When she finished, he stood up before anybody else.

"That's Rosa!" he shouted.

Everybody knew. He told them anyway.

Then Shawna joined her.

My wife began without an introduction. One clear note, then another, rising over the water. I had heard her sing in rooms

where I was the only person listening. I'd heard her angry, laughing, half asleep, making up words because she couldn't remember the real ones. This was different. She stood in the light with her shoulders bare and let the whole terrace hear how large she was inside.

The duke stopped drinking.

A woman at the next table began to cry.

I sat forward, both hands flat on my knees, because if I leaned back I felt like my chest might open.

Rosa answered her. Their voices wound together. The orchestra followed, and for once in my life, nigga, I didn't need to be doing the most impressive thing in the room. My wife was doing it, and she kept looking at me like the song had an address.

When they finished, the terrace stood.

Shawna came back through hands reaching for hers. A conductor kissed her fingers. One old man said something in Italian so emotional his wife nodded like he had finally gotten a point right after forty years.

The duke rose to greet her.

“You must perform on Isla Gloria,” he said. “The opera house was built for a voice like yours.”

Shawna smiled.

“Then make sure the people who clean it get paid.”

His hand stopped halfway toward hers.

At the edge of the terrace, a waiter dropped a glass.

Bellario was beside him instantly. Too quickly. He caught the man's arm and began steering him toward a service door. The waiter looked back once, directly at our table.

Lark stood up.

“That man knows Mateo.”

I rose with her.

The duke stayed between us and the door.

“Captain, dessert—”

“Nigga, move.”

His eyes hardened.

Then he did.

By the time we reached the corridor, Bellario was gone. The waiter stood alone beside a linen cart, shaking, blood on one finger where the glass had cut him.

Mercedes took a clean napkin and wrapped his hand.

“What's your name?” she asked.

“Luc Marel.”

“How old are you?”

“Twenty-nine.”

“Okay, Luc. Breathe.”

He looked past us toward the terrace.

“They said if I spoke to the drivers—”

Tank shut the corridor door.

“Now you're speaking to us.”

Luc swallowed. Then he pulled a folded service menu from his pocket. On the back, in hurried pencil, was a list of names.

Thirty-two of them.

Mateo was halfway down.

Beside the list were two words.

CINDER DOCK.

Below that, a time.

MIDNIGHT FRIDAY.

Lark covered her mouth with one hand.

Luc looked at me.

“Are you really a policeman?”

I took the gold badge off my chain and put it in his good hand.

“Nigga,” I said, “tonight I am whatever you need me to be.”

4. I Arrested the Finish Line

By morning, the city had put my face on a bus.

Not an advertisement. The whole front of the bus was my face.

The driver looked out through my sunglasses, and when it turned a corner my left cheek opened to let people off.

Tank watched it pass beneath our balcony.

“Nigga, they made your head public transportation.”

“About time the people rode in something great.”

Rosa was eating breakfast in his lap despite there being twelve empty chairs. She leaned forward to see the bus, then looked back at me.

“You charging for that?”

Porsche answered from the next chair.

“Now we are.”

It was the first official race day. The Grand Prix of Kings lasted a month, with seven major races, exhibitions, sea events and enough parties to make a man forget why he had brought his passport. The ceremonial qualifier had put me first on the grid. Today's Crown Circuit would take us through the city three times, then climb to the glass palace above the harbor.

Winner received the first of seven jeweled keys. All seven together opened the prize ceremony. The points decided who held them at the end.

I liked a competition that gave a nigga jewelry for doing his job.

Lark had spent the night in the garage with my car. When I went down, she stood beside it holding a mug that read WORLD'S WORST PASSENGER.

“Your wife bought me this,” she said.

“She knows talent.”

Shawna came down behind me carrying a little bag of breakfast. She put it on Lark's workbench.

“Eat.”

“I will.”

“Now.”

Lark took a piece of bread out without arguing. I respected how quickly Shawna had become the chief of all this.

Cassius waited near the far wall in a fresh racing jacket, arm still in the sling. His replacement car sat under a black cover.

“You racing?” I asked.

“No. Doctor said another impact could tear the shoulder worse.”

“Nigga, listen to the doctor.”

“I am. I hate it.”

He walked with me around the Lamborghini.

“Watch the third descent. There's a blind rise before the old customs house. Yesterday's practice showed a dip after it.”

“Anything else?”

He looked toward Lark. She nodded.

“The green harbor cars have disappeared. Every one of them. The service company says they changed the fleet overnight.”

“Fast workers.”

“Frightened workers.”

Luc had slept in one of our extra rooms, with Tank's jacket over a chair outside the door as a warning anybody with survival instincts could understand. He had told us the staff were being moved to Cinder Dock on Friday, four nights away. From there, boats took them to the island's old shipyard. Nobody who went there came back to work the mainland hotels.

He didn't know what happened to them. That was bad enough without inventing worse.

Chief Knox called while I was putting on my gloves.

“Captain,” she said, “why is there footage of your patrol vehicle on a boat?”

“International waters.”

“It was on two boats.”

“International boats.”

There was a pause.

“Did you save that driver?”

“Yes, ma'am.”

“Good. The department has received eleven marriage proposals, three requests for transfer and a yacht club membership.”

“Keep the membership.”

“Already did.”

I smiled.

Then I told her about Luc, the missing staff and the duke's fleet. She went quiet in a different way.

“Keep your people close,” she said. “Your badge gets attention. Attention can open a door or tell the wrong man which door you're standing behind.”

“I know.”

“And Aiden?”

“Yes, ma'am?”

“Win the race.”

Nigga, that was leadership.

The grid sat beneath an arch covered in blue flowers. The street beyond it climbed between grand hotels, then fell toward the port. Thousands of people pressed behind the barriers. More

watched from balconies, windows, rooftops. A choir had been hired to sing the race anthem, but half of them started chanting my name when I got out of the car.

The conductor tried to recover the key.

Lost it completely.

Shawna kissed me beside the driver's door. She wore a blue team jacket with AIDEN on the back in gold. Under my name she had added HUSBAND, because apparently the women of Monaco required a second line of clarification.

Inez walked over in her red racing suit.

“You running the police car all month?” she asked.

“Why?”

“Because I want to know whether being arrested is going to count as losing.”

“Depends how fast you confess.”

She grinned. Then her expression turned serious.

“My father read the rest of Amalia's letter last night. He wants to show you after the race.”

“What'd he find?”

“A reason to hate himself.”

“Tell him wait till we know where to put it.”

She looked toward the duke's balcony. Aurelio stood beside Bellario under an awning, both dressed in white, like innocence was a team color.

"I told my father I'm winning today," Inez said.

"Nigga, you can tell him you drove beautifully."

She punched my shoulder lightly.

"Try to keep your car out of the architecture."

The anthem finally ended. Drivers climbed in. The crowd grew tight and loud around us.

A marshal leaned through the window to ask whether my police lights were part of the car's original equipment.

"Nigga, they're part of the car's personality."

"They may distract other drivers."

"My face does that. You want me to race backward?"

Shawna bent at the waist laughing. The marshal tried to stay serious and failed around the mouth.

"Please use them only when necessary."

"Nigga, I am a necessary situation."

Tank pointed at the marshal from behind the barrier.

"That nigga about to learn."

"All of them," Porsche said.

I put both hands on the wheel.

For a moment I thought of Vegas. Big T's lot. My first night. The heat of the gun, the hurt in my side, Shawna looking at me like she couldn't decide whether I was rescue or a different kind of disaster. Now she stood behind a race barrier across an ocean wearing my name, and a city was waiting for me to do something impossible before lunch.

Nigga, life had finally started acting like it knew who I was.

The lights went out.

Inez launched beside me. A yellow car took the outside, its driver a narrow man called Prince Bastian who had introduced himself three times at dinner and seemed offended that no one had introduced him a fourth. He swept ahead into the first turn.

I let him enjoy it until the second.

Then I passed him so close he looked over like I had entered his living room without knocking.

The city became motion. White stone, blue water, red banners. We passed the opera steps with Inez half a car behind. She came alongside on the descent, and for two turns we ran together, close enough that I could see her eyes through the visor.

She was smiling.

I smiled back.

The nigga in the yellow car tried to fit between us.

There was no between us.

He backed off at the last second and nearly lost his rear wheels to the curb. Inez shook her head inside her helmet. I laughed once, sharp and happy, and we dropped into the tunnel beneath the old city.

Inside, the engines multiplied. Mine roared off the walls. Hers answered. Lights ran across the hood in long white bars. At the exit she took the lead by a nose.

I could have called the blue thunder.

I didn't.

That mattered to me. I liked knowing the difference between what I could do and what the power could add. The thunder was a burst, a loan against the strength in my body. I wasn't spending it because a beautiful woman had better timing through one tunnel.

I caught her at the harbor bend.

The first lap ended with us side by side.

Above the crowd I heard Tank's voice. I couldn't make out the words, but the volume suggested he had physically challenged the entire spectator area to doubt me.

On the second lap, things got ugly.

A white car came out of the service lane ahead of us. It belonged to the race, had a marshal's stripe on the side and should never have been moving across the active road. It stopped sideways at the entrance to the third descent.

Inez swore over the open race channel.

“Obstacle!”

She turned sharply, barely missing it. Her red car hit a loose section of barrier and spun toward a staircase descending into the market below.

I pulled left.

The yellow car behind me hit the stopped marshal's car. Metal folded. Smoke burst across the road. Somebody's horn started and didn't stop.

Inez's car slid backward down the first three steps.

People in the market scattered.

“Nigga, no.”

I took my car onto the staircase beside her.

The first impact drove the breath out of me. The second made my teeth meet. I kept the Lamborghini straight while her car bounced against the stone rail, scraping sparks from the wall. We descended side by side, two beautiful machines doing something no manufacturer had put in the brochure.

At the bottom stood a flower stall, an old stone well and a crowd trapped between them.

I hit the horn.

People moved.

Inez's car wasn't going to stop in time.

I drove across her path and caught her front corner against the rear of mine.

The impact spun us both. My shoulder hit the door. Flowers exploded across the windshield. We came to rest around the stone well, her car on one side, mine on the other, with a wreath hanging from my mirror like I had won a funeral.

For one second all I heard was ticking metal.

“Inez!”

“I'm here.”

“You hurt?”

“My pride.”

“Nigga, it needed room anyway.”

She laughed once, then groaned.

I was out before she opened her door. Her ankle had twisted beneath the pedals. She could move it, but not without pain. I helped her onto the low stone wall around the well.

A woman from the flower stall came over holding two huge bouquets.

“For you,” she said breathlessly.

“Ma'am, I just destroyed your business.”

“You saved my sister.”

Behind her, another woman was crying and pointing at the place where Inez's car would have gone.

The flower seller pushed the bouquets into my hands.

“Take them.”

Nigga, what was I supposed to do? Refuse flowers while standing in a car crash shaped like a love letter?

I handed one bouquet to Inez.

“First date on the mountain, second in a well. You moving fast.”

“Tell your wife I want a refund.”

The crowd laughed. It helped. Fear loosened enough for people to start moving again.

My radio crackled. Shawna's voice came through, low and urgent.

“Talk to me.”

“I'm good. Inez twisted her ankle. We're both out.”

“Your chest?”

“Fine.”

“Your side?”

“Fine, baby.”

She took one breath I could hear all the way from the grid.

“Then get her help.”

The marshals reached us two minutes later. One tried to tell me to stand aside. I showed him my badge, pointed to Inez and told him to be useful in that direction.

Above us, at the top of the staircase, Bellario appeared.

He was speaking into a radio.

Smiling.

Not at me. At somebody I couldn't see.

I looked down at the white marshal's stripe reflected in the broken glass on my hood. Then up at his radio.

Something in me went still.

Inez followed my eyes.

“You see it too,” she said.

“I'm starting.”

The race continued around us. The leaders had gone. The announcer's voice drifted over the buildings, saying Captain Aiden had made another courageous sacrifice and would surely receive the admiration of the entire principality.

Admiration was nice.

Nigga, I wanted my key.

Lark arrived with Tank and a service crew. She went straight to the Lamborghini, checked the wheels, looked beneath the front and stood back with both hands on her hips.

“You are a violent owner.”

“She still run?”

“She is offended. She still runs.”

I got in.

Tank leaned through the window.

“Aiden.”

“What?”

“You serious?”

I looked at him.

He stepped back and slapped the roof.

“Go get them niggas.”

There was no easy road out of the market. There was, however, an arcade through the old customs building, a broad set of doors and a courtyard that opened onto the last climb. Lark looked at the route. Looked at me. Then she moved her tools out of the way.

I drove through the customs house with both bouquets on the passenger seat.

A guard dropped his sandwich.

I shouted an apology through the window because I respected lunch.

We came out on the climb half a lap behind the leaders. My car's rear panel flapped. The steering pulled a little. There were petals in every vent. Nigga, we looked like the world's most expensive prom had escaped from a hurricane.

I drove anyway.

One car at the old palace. Another beside the railway. Two through the harbor tunnel. The crowd saw the broken blue Lamborghini and rose in sections, pointing, shouting, spreading my return faster than the announcer could understand it.

By the final lap I was fourth.

By the glass palace I was third.

Ahead, Prince Bastian's yellow car chased a silver coupe toward the line. Behind them rolled the white pace car that should have withdrawn at the final corner.

Instead, it slowed across the road.

Bellario stood at the finish with the jeweled key on a cushion.

Nigga wanted me stopped one more time.

I put on my siren.

The crowd screamed.

The pace car didn't move.

I leaned out the window and pointed straight at its driver.

“You are under arrest, motherfucker!”

He looked back.

That was his mistake.

The silver coupe went left. Bastian went right. I went straight, not into the pace car but across the low marble divider beside it, the Lamborghini lifting just enough to make every camera on the finish line tilt upward.

For a breath I was above all three of them.

Then I landed beyond the pace car, the steering wheel kicking against my hands, and crossed the line first with my siren singing louder than the anthem.

The palace windows shook with the crowd.

I stopped, climbed out and walked back toward the pace car. Its driver had both hands up already. Bellario came toward me with his radio against his chest.

“Captain, the result requires review.”

“Nigga, review this.”

I pointed to the driver.

“Who told him to stay on the track?”

“A communication error.”

“Who told the other car to block the descent?”

“An unfortunate sequence—”

“Keep talking. You might confess by accident.”

The cameras moved closer. Bellario saw them. Saw the crowd. Saw the duke on the glass balcony, watching him with a face that offered no rescue.

He lifted the cushion.

"The first key," he announced, voice suddenly enormous, "to Captain Aiden."

The driver of the pace car pointed at Bellario.

"That man told me—"

"Nigga, I know which man," I said. "I'm asking why you let that nigga choose where your car stopped."

"He's the marshal."

"And I'm the nigga you tried to stop. See how the second title got important?"

Tank arrived beside me. "Nigga, keep pointing. We love directions."

Bellario lifted the cushion higher. "The key, Captain."

"Look at this nigga changing the subject with jewelry," Porsche said.

"Good jewelry?" Mercedes asked.

"We'll ask Marcellus. Nigga ain't bribing us with plate twice."

I took the key.

Then I took his radio.

“Evidence,” I said.

He looked like he wanted to bite me.

Shawna came through the crowd at a run. I caught her with my good arm, lifted her off the ground and kissed her while the city shouted around us.

“You brought me flowers,” she said when she saw the car.

“Whole market.”

“You're bleeding.”

“Small amount.”

“Nigga.”

I loved when she said it like that. Like my entire government name had disappointed her in one syllable.

She pressed a cloth to the scrape above my eyebrow. Behind her, Inez arrived in the medical cart with her ankle wrapped and both bouquets in her lap. She had kept mine safe.

“You won in that?” she asked, looking at my car.

“Car wanted it bad.”

She shook her head slowly.

“I've raced the best drivers in the world.”

“Now you have.”

She laughed, then raised her bouquet toward the crowd.

“Aiden!” she shouted.

The crowd answered so loudly the duke stepped back from his balcony.

That night, Lark laid Bellario's confiscated radio on our dining table. It had gone silent the moment I took it. Nothing useful remained on it, and we weren't going to invent a miracle because a radio looked important.

But Luc recognized the little silver mark etched on the back.

A white bird.

“The Sovereign Sun uses that mark,” he said. “The old crew put it on their equipment.”

Cassius reached into his pocket and put his father's little metal bird beside it.

Same wings.

Same lowered head.

Inez unfolded Amalia's letter.

“Now,” she said, “we read the whole thing.”

5. The Last Lap Belongs to the Passenger

“Nigga, how many birds this man own?” Tank asked.

On our table we had Cassius's little white bird, Bellario's radio with a white bird on it, a picture of a white car called the White Heron, and Amalia's letter, which began with a drawing of the same damn bird.

Marcellus adjusted his glasses.

“One design. Several objects.”

“So the nigga had a brand.”

“He had a boat,” Cassius said.

“And a car,” I said.

“And a wife who liked birds,” Inez added.

Tank looked around the table.

“All right. Y'all niggas got an answer for every bird. Read the letter.”

We were in the suite after midnight. The balcony doors stood open. Down in the harbor somebody was celebrating my victory with fireworks they definitely hadn't cleared with the people trying to sleep. Each blue explosion lit Shawna's face for a second. She sat beside me in a robe, bare feet tucked beneath her, her hand resting on my scraped knuckles.

Lark had fallen asleep for twenty minutes in a chair, then woken up angry that she had wasted time without dreaming about Mateo. Mercedes made her eat soup. Porsche took her phone away when she tried to read the same old messages again.

“Nigga ain't answered yet because he can't,” Porsche told her. “You starving yourself won't make the phone stronger.”

Lark looked ready to argue. Then she accepted the bowl.

Inez set the letter flat. Esteban sat opposite her, shoulders bowed, but his eyes stayed on the page.

“You read it,” he said.

She began.

“Esteban, if you are reading this without me, do not let a man who never loved either of us explain my last day.”

The room settled.

“I know you. You will look for somebody to beat, then somebody to blame, then a place to sit alone until those feel like the same thing. Before you do any of it, remember the race at San Aurelio. Remember the goat.”

Cassius looked up.

“The goat?”

Esteban covered his eyes with one hand.

“Oh, Amalia.”

I leaned forward.

“Nigga, now we getting somewhere.”

Inez kept reading, but she was smiling through the hurt in her face.

“You told me you were the finest driver on the coast. You told me no living thing could surprise you on a mountain road. Then a goat sat on your hood and rode you into second place.”

Tank made a sound like a sofa tearing.

“A goat?”

Esteban lowered his hand.

“It jumped from a wall.”

“Nigga, it qualified?”

“It refused to move.”

“So did he win?”

“Nero won,” Cassius said quietly. “He always said the goat had better cornering instincts.”

For a moment Esteban laughed. A real laugh, pulled out of a room in him he had kept shut for seven years.

Inez read on.

“You were so angry you refused your little silver cup. Nero took it for you. He filled it with wine, gave it to the goat's owner and told everybody the second-best driver in the race had four legs.

You chased him through the village. I fell in love with you again watching you forget to be impressive.”

Shawna looked at me.

“Don't say it,” I told her.

“I didn't.”

“Your eyes said a whole paragraph.”

Inez continued.

“That night you told me a story your father had told you: a king owned every road in his country, but he could not make the woman beside him enjoy the journey. He bought faster horses. She asked him to stop near a river. He built a bridge. She asked him to sit beside her. He conquered the town on the other bank. At last she got out and walked home, and the king spent the rest of his life arriving first at places she no longer wanted to go.”

“Nigga needed to listen,” I said.

Shawna squeezed my knuckles.

The letter said Amalia had reminded Esteban of that story the night the duke offered to buy the White Heron. Not the actual car, only the name, the team, their loyalty. Esteban had been tempted. Nero had refused. Amalia had watched the duke's face when a poorer man said no to him.

“She wrote the letter after that?” Inez asked her father.

“The first part.”

“The ink changes here.”

Marcellus leaned forward without touching the paper.

“Yes. Written at different times.”

Inez read the next page.

“I went to Isla Gloria because Celadon asked me. His wife has been told he took a contract abroad. His crew have been told their wages will arrive after the race. Neither is true. Aurelio is putting the fleet into other men's names while keeping the men who can contradict him where they cannot speak.”

Lark set her bowl down carefully.

“Same thing,” she whispered.

“Nigga been doing it seven years,” Tank said.

Amalia had gone aboard the Sovereign Sun and found Celadon confined to his own cabin under the watch of men who called themselves guards. He had not been beaten into a lesson. He had been made to wait, week after week, while letters to his family vanished and his name was used to sign things he never saw.

The details were small and ugly. Cold meals. A locked door. The sound of his crew working outside while he couldn't answer them. Amalia wrote that he had asked her to remember his wife's favorite flower because he was frightened he might forget something ordinary before anybody came for him.

Rosa reached for Tank's hand beneath the table.

Inez's voice grew steadier as she read.

“Celadon gave me the original fleet agreement. The ships belong to the winning team until their crews are paid, and then to the winner. Aurelio cannot honestly give the island without the flagship's captain witnessing the handover. That is why he needs Celadon alive. That is why the race keeps returning every year, bright enough to hide what does not change.”

I looked toward the harbor. The duke's black yacht stood in darkness except for one gold window.

Nigga had built a monthlong party around a locked door.

The next page was addressed to Nero.

Cassius sat straighter.

“I am leaving this with you because Esteban loves me too loudly to hear danger without trying to hit it. If the papers vanish, remember the trophy we gave him after San Aurelio. The small one he pretended not to want. I put the carbon copies beneath its base before we left the house.”

Esteban made a broken little sound.

Inez stopped reading.

“What?” she said.

He looked at Cassius.

“I sold it.”

Nobody spoke.

“After she died. I sold all the trophies. I couldn't look at them.”

Cassius stared at him for a long moment, then reached into his pocket for his phone.

“Not all.”

He made a call. Spoke a few quick sentences. Ended it.

“My mother bought three of them through a friend. She said you weren't allowed to throw away every good thing just because you thought my father had ruined the last one.”

Esteban's mouth opened.

“She kept them?”

“Until she died. Now I have them.”

“Nigga,” I said softly. “Your family got a whole other family under the table.”

Cassius nodded without looking at me.

The letter's final page had been written on the morning of the last race. Amalia knew Bellario had seen her leave the flagship. He had offered to escort her. She had refused. She had asked a woman selling flowers near the harbor to keep the letter and send it if she didn't return.

“He wanted the blue support car,” Inez read. “He said the duke had prepared a place for it ahead of the ridge. He asked twice whether Nero would be with me. I told him no. That was a lie. Nero knows, and he is coming.”

Cassius put his good hand over his mouth.

“My father went after her,” he said.

Esteban nodded once. Then again, unable to stop.

The last lines were simple.

“Do not let him turn Nero into your enemy. Do not let Inez inherit a silence and call it pride. And if you win this race, my love, take the long way home. The last lap belongs to the passenger.”

Inez put the page down.

For a while we heard only the sea and the occasional far-off firework insisting it was still a happy night.

Then Esteban stood. He came around the table slowly, stopped beside Cassius and held out both hands.

“I wronged your father.”

Cassius looked up at him.

“Yes.”

“I wronged you.”

“Yes.”

Esteban nodded. He didn't try to make the yes smaller. Didn't tell a story about how much he had suffered, though we had all seen enough to know he had.

“If he lives,” he said, “I will tell him myself.”

Cassius's face changed.

“Don't give me that unless you mean it.”

“I mean it.”

I stood too.

“Nigga, we ain't burying a man because the duke printed it pretty.”

Cassius looked at me then. Really looked.

“You think he's there?”

“I think we got a boat, an island, a captain nobody's allowed to see and a whole lot of people somebody don't want talking. I think we stop asking the nigga locking the doors where everybody went.”

Tank got up beside me.

“And start opening doors.”

“Nigga, exactly.”

Petra asked on the phone whether this was worth waking the driver.

"Nigga," Cassius said, "tell the driver my father might be alive."

A pause.

"No, don't tell him that nigga. Tell him my father. I was talking to Aiden."

Tank covered his mouth.

"Nigga clarified the nigga," I whispered.

Cassius pointed at us without looking away from the phone.

"These niggas are not helping."

"These niggas opened the letter," Inez said.

"And this nigga's bringing the cup," Petra answered loudly enough for all of us to hear.

Cassius closed his eyes. Then he laughed, and the waiting became something we could survive together.

The little trophy arrived at three in the morning in the arms of Cassius's assistant, a fifty-year-old woman named Petra who looked at the room full of us and said, "Finally," as if she'd been waiting seven years for the men to develop sense.

It was ugly. A silver cup with two crooked handles and a goat standing on the lid.

Tank picked it up.

"Nigga, they put the goat on the trophy?"

"Nero had it added," Cassius said.

"That is friendship."

Marcellus examined the base. He asked for a small cloth and better light. We gave him both. He worked carefully, not making a show of it, and after a few minutes a thin square of paper came free from beneath a false lining.

The copies were faded but readable.

Names. Ships. Crew lists. A handover clause. Celadon's signature. A second witness: Nero Chrome.

And beneath it, another name.

Bellarion Venn.

The chief marshal had witnessed the original agreement. He knew exactly what had been stolen.

Mercedes leaned closer.

“So the nigga with the feather ain't just holding the tray.”

“He carrying the whole damn crime,” Porsche said.

Cassius took a photograph of his father's signature and held the phone close, as if the light might warm it back into a living hand.

Inez sat beside him. Their shoulders touched.

Neither moved away.

That was when the glass broke.

One sharp crack from the balcony. Then another.

The lamp beside Marcellus exploded.

Tank threw the table sideways. Rosa pulled Lark down. I caught Shawna around the waist and brought her behind the sofa while the room filled with the sound of expensive things losing their value all at once.

“Nigga!” Tank roared.

“I know!”

“Which nigga?”

“The shooting nigga!”

A dark shape moved on the neighboring balcony. Another shadow appeared above the garden wall. They had come across the adjoining suite, using the roof garden to reach us.

They had picked a room containing Tank, Inez, Cassius, my wife and me.

Some niggas don't research their vacation.

I went low across the carpet. Shawna stayed behind the sofa with Rosa and Lark, but her hand was already in the bag she had dropped beside the chair. She looked at me once, lifted the little pistol she carried and nodded toward the side door.

She had that side.

I took the balcony.

The first man came through the broken glass. I hit him before his feet settled. We went into the wall together, his gun striking the frame. He tried to bring it back around. I drove him through the open balcony doors and into a lounge chair that broke beneath both of us.

He was big. Trained. Angry that I hadn't fallen down in the place he expected.

Nigga, disappointment was about to become his whole evening.

He swung at me. I moved, caught his arm against the rail and put him down hard enough that he forgot the next part of his plan. Behind me, Tank lifted the second intruder bodily out of the side doorway and deposited him on the dining table we had just overturned.

The table lost.

Cassius stood behind Tank holding a vase.

“You only got one good arm!” I shouted.

“And an excellent vase!”

He broke it over the man's helmet.

The third attacker decided the balcony was no longer a promising entrance and tried to climb back across the gap. Inez reached him first. Even with her wrapped ankle she moved like anger had given her another leg. She caught his jacket, pulled him backward and sent him into the fountain on our terrace.

Water rose around him.

Shawna came out behind me, gun lowered now, eyes wide and steady.

“Everybody?”

I looked around. Counted. Tank. Rosa. Mercedes. Porsche. Marcellus. Lark. Luc. Inez. Cassius. Esteban. Shawna.

Everybody breathing.

“Everybody,” I said.

She pressed her forehead to mine for one second.

Then Porsche stepped over the broken lamp and held up her phone.

“I got their entrance on camera.”

Mercedes took a little hotel key from the first man's pocket.

“I got their room.”

Tank looked at the three men on the floor and in the fountain.

“I got these niggas.”

Down below, hotel guests had come out onto their balconies.

Somebody started clapping. Then somebody else. They had seen me save Cassius, win a race, rescue Inez and now throw an armed man into outdoor furniture before breakfast.

A woman across the courtyard shouted, “Marry me!”

Shawna leaned over the rail.

“He's occupied!”

The applause doubled.

I pulled her back against me, laughing despite the blood on my sleeve.

At our feet, the first attacker groaned.

I crouched beside him.

“Who sent you?”

He shut his eyes.

“Nigga, don't go to sleep. We having a conversation.”

He looked at me then, frightened enough to stop pretending his mouth was decorative.

“The marshal,” he whispered.

Cassius stood behind me with the goat trophy in his good hand.

Bellario had finally entered the race.

6. The Yacht with a Ballroom in Its Mouth

The duke sent flowers after his men shot up my room.

Blue roses. Three hundred of them. The card said he deplored the recent unpleasantness and looked forward to seeing me at his masquerade aboard the Sovereign Sun.

Tank read it twice.

“Nigga deplores.”

“He sure do,” I said.

“Can I deplore his ass off the boat?”

“Get dressed first.”

We had moved suites. Not because I was scared of a balcony, but because Shawna said she wasn't sleeping in a room where the curtains had been shot in places curtains shouldn't have to worry about. The hotel gave us the entire top floor. The manager cried while handing over the keys. I couldn't tell whether it was gratitude or the cost of the furniture.

The three attackers were downstairs in the custody of Commandant Odette Valeur, a forty-six-year-old woman with silver at her temples and a white uniform she wore like an argument nobody had won yet. She commanded the harbor police. She had come to arrest the men, looked at my badge,

looked at the broken suite and asked who had put the fountain man in the fountain.

“Inez,” I said.

Odette nodded toward her.

“Good distance.”

Then she took the prisoners somewhere Bellario couldn't collect them with a polite note.

I liked her immediately.

Bellario denied everything. The duke announced that the attackers had been jealous gamblers acting without permission. Nigga, without permission from who? He left that part floating. Bellario vanished from the next day's press events, but his feather appeared on an assistant's hat, and that was almost more disrespectful.

Odette visited us again the afternoon of the masquerade. Lark spread Amalia's papers across the table. Cassius put his father's bird beside them. Luc told her about the missing staff.

She listened to every word.

Then she looked at me.

“If I take this to the palace alone, it disappears into a drawer. If you show it to the whole harbor while winning his race, the drawer becomes difficult to close.”

“Nigga, I can make it a convertible.”

Her mouth twitched.

“I’ve seen your driving.”

She gave us one useful fact: the Sovereign Sun would leave the harbor after the masquerade and reach Cinder Dock the next night. Its scheduled crew had been replaced. Some of the replacements had not volunteered.

Lark stood up.

“Mateo?”

“Possibly.”

“That word is killing me.”

Odette held her gaze.

“I won’t give you a better one unless I have it.”

Lark sat down slowly. Mercedes put an arm around her shoulders without making her look at anybody.

That evening my people came down the hotel staircase like the building had spent its entire life waiting for them.

Tank wore black velvet and a silver mask that covered half his face. Rosa wore a red gown and a mask made of little dark feathers. Mercedes had chosen a white suit with nothing timid about it. Porsche wore gold, from the heels to the tiny knife-shaped hairpin she insisted was purely decorative and which I respectfully chose not to investigate.

Cassius wore a sling matched to his jacket. Inez had traded her ankle wrap for a high boot and carried a cane topped with a silver horse. She looked dangerous enough that several men on the staircase suddenly remembered women could tell when they were staring.

Shawna came last.

Black dress. Blue stones at her throat. A mask she took off before reaching me because she wanted me to see her whole face when I forgot how my lungs worked.

“Nigga,” Tank said behind me.

“I know.”

“Nigga, you see your wife?”

“I am actively seeing her.”

“You look like you need a chair.”

“Go find your woman.”

Rosa took his hand.

“He found her.”

Shawna stopped on the step above me and straightened my collar.

“Try to keep the tuxedo intact.”

“Depends how the tuxedo behaves.”

She kissed me.

Somebody farther down the staircase started applauding. Then the whole lobby joined in. Nigga, I couldn't even kiss my wife privately in a room full of strangers anymore. Fame had become an audience with poor boundaries.

I bowed anyway.

The Sovereign Sun waited beyond the harbor wall, longer than a street, white and gold beneath a thousand lights. Its bow opened into a ballroom. I am telling you exactly what I saw. The front of the boat had split into two great curved doors, revealing a dance floor that seemed to float above the water. A staircase descended toward the tenders, and musicians played from balconies inside the ship's mouth.

Tank stared up at it.

“This nigga boat got teeth?”

“Those are columns,” Rosa said.

“That's how they get you.”

A steward in a white coat led us aboard. On the wall behind him hung portraits of previous Grand Prix winners. I recognized Esteban in one, younger, standing beside Nero and Amalia with a trophy between them. Somebody had moved a large vase in front of Nero's face.

Cassius stopped.

I moved the vase.

The steward opened his mouth.

“Nigga, choose your next words carefully.”

He shut it.

We entered the ballroom together.

There were dukes, actresses, drivers, singers, women who charged rich men for the pleasure of their company and rich men who believed nobody could tell. Champagne moved through the room on silver trays. A pianist played a song that made the women at our table look at one another and smile. Mercedes whispered something to Porsche, and both of them walked toward a man in a white dinner jacket before he had time to flee.

“That their friend?” Tank asked.

“That look like a debt.”

The duke stood beneath a chandelier shaped like a crown.

“Aiden,” he said. “You honor my ship.”

“Ship was overdue.”

His eyes moved over my people. Counted Cassius's sling, Inez's cane, Shawna's bare shoulders. Stopped at Odette, who had come aboard separately in a black dress with her badge at the waist.

“A commandant at a masquerade,” he said.

Odette smiled.

“A duke hosting one. We all enjoy costumes.”

Nigga, I almost proposed friendship on the spot.

Aurelio turned to Shawna.

“I hope tonight's entertainment meets your standards.”

“My standards are sitting beside me.”

She took my arm.

I looked at the duke and smiled with every tooth God had trusted me with.

He announced the evening's exhibition after the first dance. Two cars waited on a circular platform behind the ballroom: a silver roadster and a black coupe with a blue interior. They belonged to the prize fleet. Guests could bid for the right to challenge the leading driver in a short timed run along the ship's upper deck.

Nigga had put a racetrack on a yacht.

I finally understood why rich people kept getting invited places. Sometimes one of them had a good idea.

The duke held up a little gold key.

“The challenger wagers fifty thousand. If he defeats Captain Aiden, he keeps the roadster.”

“If he loses?” I asked.

“The money supports the Grand Prix.”

“The workers?”

“The institution.”

“Nigga, the institution can get a job. My races pay the workers.”

A murmur crossed the room. Aurelio watched the faces around him and adjusted smoothly.

“Of course. Tonight's proceeds shall go to the staff.”

Porsche, across the room, raised her phone so he could see it recording.

“Say the amount too.”

He said it.

Then Inez stepped forward.

“I'll race.”

Cassius caught her elbow.

“Your ankle.”

“It's my left ankle.”

“And still attached to the rest of you.”

She looked at him.

He looked back.

Something quiet happened between them. Not soft exactly. Two people recognizing the same fear from opposite sides.

She lowered her hand.

“Fine. I'll choose his challenger.”

The duke laughed. "And whom do you choose?"

She pointed at him.

The whole ballroom turned.

Aurelio's smile remained. Only his eyes moved.

"I do not usually—"

"Nigga, you own the competition," I reminded him. "Drive something."

The applause began at our table. Spread outward. Became impossible to ignore without looking smaller than the portrait behind him.

He handed his glass to Bellario's assistant.

"All right," he said.

The duke's assistant tried to hand me a waiver.

"Nigga, what's this?"

"Acknowledgment of the exhibition."

"I acknowledge that nigga challenged the room and the room pointed at him."

Inez took the paper. "It says he's not responsible for disappointment."

"Which nigga?" Tank asked.

"The duke."

"That nigga responsible for half mine already."

Aurelio held out his hand for the page. "Shall we drive?"

"Nigga," I said, "I've been dressed for it since the harbor."

Shawna kissed my cheek. "Go. The nigga's gloves are getting nervous."

We went up to the deck.

The track circled the yacht's upper level around two pools, a glass conservatory and a helipad. The cars had been arranged for display, but the road was real enough and wide enough to make a bad decision feel generous. Floodlights shone over the water. Guests lined the balconies below us. The captain's bridge glowed at the front of the ship, guarded by two men in dark coats.

I watched those men while the duke chose the silver roadster.

Lark had gone below with Luc to look for familiar crew.

Mercedes and Porsche followed a steward who had whispered to them at the bar. Shawna stayed at the railing with Rosa and Odette. Nobody needed to be taken away from me to have something to do. My people were already moving.

Aurelio pulled on leather gloves.

"Do you know what the difference is between a guest and an owner?" he asked.

"Guest can leave without selling the furniture."

"An owner decides when the evening ends."

“Nigga, we’ll see.”

We started together.

He was good.

That surprised me for half a second. Then it pleased me. I wanted the man to have at least one real thing to lose.

His roadster took the first curve cleanly. I stayed close in the black coupe. We swept around the glass conservatory with the sea falling away beyond the rail. He accelerated toward the helipad, then moved across my line hard enough to make his intention plain.

This wasn't a polite exhibition.

Good.

I came around the outside. He tried to shut the gap. I let him think he had, then took the next turn so close to the pool that water rose over my left wheels. The guests below screamed. On the far balcony, Tank was jumping up and down in his velvet suit like a furious wedding cake.

“Nigga, get him!”

I got him.

At the final bend I moved alongside the duke, looked straight across into his car and smiled. He saw it. Lost one fraction of a second deciding whether to hate me or the smile.

I used the fraction.

The black coupe crossed the line first.

I stopped at the railing. The ballroom below erupted. Aurelio rolled to a halt beside me, both hands still on the wheel.

For the first time all night he looked his age.

I got out and held up the car's key.

“For the staff,” I said.

The cheering doubled.

Then a gunshot came from below deck.

The cheering stopped so abruptly I could hear the ocean against the hull.

Shawna was already moving toward the stairway. I jumped the low rail, landed on the lower platform and reached her at the door. Rosa and Odette were behind her. Tank thundered down from the other side.

Lark came out of a corridor carrying a man whose white shirt was stained at the shoulder. Luc held his other arm. Mercedes followed with three women in crew uniforms. Porsche came last, face hard, a broken champagne bottle in her hand.

“Somebody asked the wrong question,” she said.

Behind them, two guards rounded the corner.

Odette showed her badge.

“Stop.”

One lifted his gun.

I hit him with the door.

Nigga, it was a beautiful door. Heavy wood, brass edge. Somebody had paid excellent money for it to become part of his problem. His weapon struck the floor. Tank caught the second man against the corridor wall and made the wall reconsider its career.

Shawna took the wounded crewman's weight from Lark.

“Where's Mateo?” Lark asked him.

The man shook his head, breath catching.

“Island. They moved him ahead.”

She went pale.

“Alive?”

He nodded.

“Yes.”

For a second she couldn't stand. Mercedes caught her around the waist.

“Nigga alive,” she said firmly. “Hear that part first.”

The wounded man looked at Cassius, who had reached us with Inez.

“Chrome?”

Cassius froze.

“Yes.”

The man's eyes filled.

“Your father said you'd come.”

Cassius made a sound I had never heard from him, not when his car hung over the cliff, not when we read the letter. It was smaller than a word and much harder to hear.

Aurelio appeared at the top of the stairs.

“Captain, this has become disorderly.”

I turned toward him.

“Nigga, I haven't started.”

Below us, the yacht's great bow doors began closing.

The ballroom narrowed around the sea.

He was ending the evening.

I looked at the black coupe above us, then at the open front of the ship, then at the harbor launch approaching beyond it with blue lights flashing.

Odette followed my eyes.

“No,” she said.

“Yes,” I said.

“You cannot drive a car through the ballroom.”

“Nigga, watch the piano.”

Tank started laughing.

That was all the encouragement a man like me required.

7. Everybody Get in the Beautiful Car

There were eight people between me and the black coupe, and every one of them had an opinion.

“You can't take the car,” the steward said.

“The car cannot go down those stairs,” a guard said.

“That car is worth two million,” the duke said.

“Nigga, move,” Tank said, and all three opinions relocated.

I went up the steps two at a time. Shawna stayed below with the wounded crewman while Odette called her harbor launch closer. Lark and Luc gathered the workers at the ballroom's open bow. Mercedes took off her heels, put them into Porsche's hands and went back for a woman who had frozen beside the broken service door.

“Look at me,” she told her. “We leaving this nigga's boat.”

The woman shook her head. She couldn't get the words out.

Mercedes held her face gently.

“You can be scared while we move. Come on.”

They moved.

Above them, I started the coupe.

Aurelio stood at the top of the stairs with two more guards. He had taken off his driving gloves very slowly, like a man trying to convince the world he still controlled how fast things happened.

“You will regret this,” he said.

“Nigga, I’ve regretted shoes. You need a better threat.”

One guard stepped toward my door. I rolled forward. He stepped back. We had reached an understanding.

The car’s nose dipped onto the grand staircase.

Somewhere below, the pianist played three startled notes and stopped.

I took us down.

The coupe hit the steps with a violence no two-million-dollar object should experience without at least a conversation. Its suspension bucked. Gold railings blurred past the windows. I held the wheel tight and kept my foot steady while the ballroom rose toward me in a wall of faces, tables and people discovering they had stood in a road all along.

“Move!” I shouted.

Nigga, they moved beautifully.

I landed on the dance floor between two tables, slid through a carpet of fallen masks and stopped with the front bumper six inches from the piano.

The pianist looked at me.

I looked at him.

“Keep playing,” I said.

The nigga started again.

Above us, the bow doors kept closing. Beyond them, Odette's vehicle launch came alongside, broad deck lit blue, its crew throwing ropes toward the yacht. The launch sat lower in the water. Between us and it stretched a gap wide enough to make a sensible man reconsider owning legs.

I got out and pointed toward the doors.

“Everybody to the launch.”

Cassius stood beside me, face tight.

“My father—”

“He ain't on this boat,” I said. “We know where to go now.”

“You heard him.”

“I heard him, nigga. And we're going.”

He nodded once, hard, then helped Inez toward the opening.

Odette's crew laid a boarding bridge between the vessels. Tank carried the wounded man across it. Rosa followed with Lark, one arm around her waist. Luc went next with the other workers. Mercedes and Porsche brought the frightened woman between them, talking the whole way, a little chain of stubborn life moving across black water.

Shawna waited on the ballroom floor.

“You too,” I told her.

“With you.”

“Baby—”

“With you, Aiden.”

I looked at her. The room behind us was emptying through the upper stairs. The duke had disappeared from the railing. We could hear men shouting on the deck, doors slamming, feet coming down the service corridor.

“You know I'm bringing the car.”

“Nigga, I met you.”

I laughed. Couldn't help it. She got in beside me, gathered her dress away from the pedals and pulled the belt across her chest like we were leaving a restaurant after a reasonably successful date.

Odette stood on her launch, staring through the narrowing bow.

“No,” she shouted again.

Tank put a hand on her shoulder.

“This nigga don't hear that good.”

The bridge came up. The launch drifted back just enough to clear the doors. A guard appeared at the rear of the ballroom and lifted his gun.

I put my foot down.

The coupe crossed the dance floor. The pianist bent low over his keys. The closing bow doors became two white cliffs squeezing the night between them.

Blue thunder ran through my hands.

Just once.

A bright line down the wheel, across the dash, into the engine. The car surged beneath us like it had remembered a life as lightning. We hit the edge of the ballroom and left the ship.

Shawna took one breath.

I heard it clearly.

Then the launch rose beneath us.

We landed hard. The car's front wheels struck the deck, the rear slapped down, and every man aboard the launch staggered as if the sea had punched it from below. Tank caught a railing. Odette caught Tank. The coupe slid, stopped against a rubber barrier and went silent.

For one second, nigga, the whole ocean was quiet.

Then the launch erupted.

The workers cheered. The police cheered. Tank shouted something so loud that one of the harbor officers joined in without understanding the words. Rosa kissed both his cheeks.

Cassius stood with his good hand over his mouth, laughing like a man who had forgotten he was allowed.

Odette opened my door.

“You are,” she said, then stopped.

I waited.

She looked back at the yacht, at the closing doors, at the car sitting on her deck.

“You are a very difficult man to arrest.”

“Nigga, I'm on your side.”

“That makes it worse.”

Shawna started laughing.

I tried to laugh with her, but my chest had gone hollow. The thunder had collected its price. My fingers shook against the wheel, and the deck tilted beneath my feet when I stood.

She saw it immediately.

“Aiden.”

“I'm good.”

“No. You're here. Sit down.”

I sat.

Tank crouched beside me while the launch pulled away from the Sovereign Sun. Blue lights washed over his mask.

“How bad?” he asked.

“Need a minute.”

“Take two. Nigga, we rich in minutes.”

Shawna held water to my mouth. I drank. The cold came back into me slowly, followed by the weight of my own hands.

Behind us, engines started.

Three small speedboats came out from the yacht's stern.

Odette turned toward the helm.

“Of course,” she said.

The first boat swept alongside and a shot struck the launch's railing. Everybody went down except Tank, who bent over Rosa and made himself a wall before remembering walls were also allowed to crouch.

“Stay here,” Shawna told me.

“I can—”

“You spent it getting us off the ship. Let us get you home.”

She said it without begging. Without making me less. My wife knew what I had done and what was left in me, and she wasn't going to let my pride turn her rescue into a second problem.

So I stayed.

Nigga, that was harder than jumping the car.

Odette's officers answered the gunfire. Tank helped move the workers behind the coupe. Porsche held pressure against the

wounded crewman's shoulder while Mercedes kept him talking. Rosa sang very softly to the frightened woman, a little tune with no words, just enough sound to give her somewhere to put her breath.

Cassius stood at the rail beside Inez. She pointed toward a line of mooring buoys ahead, then spoke to Odette. The commandant listened, nodded, and the launch turned toward the narrow passage between the harbor breakwaters.

Inez knew the water because her father had raced it.

Cassius knew the boats because his father had built them.

My niggas had brought whole lives with them.

The first pursuing boat followed too close. It hit the rough wake near the breakwater, rose sideways and came down hard enough to throw its driver against the wheel. It fell behind.

The second tried to cut across the harbor mouth. A police boat came out of the darkness with its lights blazing and forced it toward the open sea.

The third stayed with us.

A man stood in its bow, gun braced against the windshield.

Shawna saw him before I did.

She pulled me lower, lifted her pistol over the edge of the car door and fired once. The man's weapon dropped into the water.

He fell backward into his own boat, alive and suddenly interested in lying down.

Tank looked over.

“Nigga, your wife just edited that whole boat.”

Shawna didn't smile until the boat turned away.

Then she looked at me.

“Your ocean's rude.”

I took her hand and kissed the knuckles.

“I'll speak to it.”

We reached the harbor under a roof of sirens. People lined the quay in evening clothes. They had watched the yacht incident from balconies, phones, boats and probably the moon by then. When the launch docked and they saw the coupe, somebody began shouting my name again.

I could stand now. Could walk. But Shawna kept her arm around my waist, and I let the crowd see that too.

The woman Mercedes had brought off the yacht touched my sleeve.

“My name is Alina,” she said. “I thought nobody would come.”

I looked back at my people stepping off the launch around her.

“Nigga, look how many came.”

She began crying then. Mercedes held her. Porsche took off her own gold wrap and put it around Alina's shoulders.

The duke's two-million-dollar coupe sat on the launch with a cracked windshield, bent wheels and half a masquerade still inside it.

Odette looked at it, then at me.

"What do you want me to do with that?"

"Evidence."

She closed her eyes.

Tank laughed so hard he had to lean on the gangway.

The launch's youngest officer stared at the coupe while his partner coiled a rope.

"Nigga drove out of a boat."

"I saw him."

"Into a boat."

"Nigga, I was on the boat."

"With his wife."

Shawna looked over. "The wife was also on the boat."

He blushed. "Ma'am, I meant—"

"Nigga means he ain't ever taking his girl anywhere again,"

Tank said. "Aiden raised the transportation."

I shook my head. "Nigga, take her somewhere she likes. My wife likes surviving me."

"And dinner," Shawna said. "Nigga keeps delaying dinner."

The officers laughed. One of them brought her a sandwich from the cabin like he was restoring order to the whole sea.

By Friday evening, the city had named the harbor passage Aiden's Mouth.

Nobody asked me. I would have picked something less likely to get Tank started at breakfast.

We had one day to prepare for Cinder Dock. We used it to rest, listen and put the rescued people somewhere safe. Odette took statements. Lark stayed beside the wounded crewman, whose name was Tomas, until he could tell her exactly what he had seen.

Mateo was alive. Celadon was alive. Nero Chrome was alive.

They were held at the old shipyard on Isla Gloria, where the duke kept the ships whose ownership he couldn't explain.

Friday's transfer would bring more workers to join them. Tomas had tried to get a message to Lark. A guard had shot him for it.

Cassius sat beside his hospital bed for an hour after hearing about his father. Didn't ask the same question ten times. Didn't make Tomas prove hope until it broke. He just sat there, looking at his own hands.

When he came out, Inez waited in the corridor.

“He's alive,” Cassius said.

She nodded.

“My father is alive.”

This time his voice broke.

She put both arms around him carefully, avoiding the shoulder.

He held her with his good arm and bent his face into her hair.

I left them there.

Nigga, some races ain't yours to finish.

At midnight we went to Cinder Dock.

No grand entrance this time. The dock was an old coal harbor beyond the bright part of the coast, warehouses black against the sea, one working crane standing over a narrow pier. Odette brought officers. Tank came with me. Lark, Mercedes and Porsche waited aboard a nearby rescue launch with blankets and room for people who had been told there was nowhere else to go.

Shawna stayed beside the launch's wheel with Rosa.

When the transfer van arrived, it carried eleven workers and two guards.

The guards saw Odette's lights and reached for their guns.

Tank hit the first van door so hard it opened the other way.

“Nigga, police!” he shouted.

“That's my line,” I told him.

“Say it faster.”

The second guard ran toward the pier. I followed. He fired once over his shoulder, missed everything except the peace of the evening, and leaped aboard a waiting speedboat.

I landed on the bow before it pulled away.

His face changed.

“Nigga,” I said, “where you going without finishing our introduction?”

He lunged at me. We struck the windshield together. His gun skidded away. The boat turned in a tight circle, engine howling, dragging a rope behind it like a tail. I caught the edge of the console, pulled myself upright and put him flat on the deck.

The boat hit the pier gently enough that only two boards objected.

I stepped off with the guard by his jacket.

Behind me, eleven people climbed out of the van into light.

One man knelt and touched the ground.

Another saw Lark and started crying before she asked him anything.

“Mateo told us you'd come,” he said.

She covered her face. Then she moved forward and hugged him like she could reach Mateo through somebody who had seen him yesterday.

The last worker out of the van carried a canvas bag against his chest. He was an older man with a white beard and the hands of someone who had spent his life fixing things other men broke.

He looked at my badge.

Then at my face.

“You're Aiden.”

“Yes.”

“Captain Celadon said if I saw you, I should give you this.”

He opened the bag.

Inside lay a small brass ship's bell, a torn racing flag and a photograph taken on the island. Nero Chrome stood beside Celadon in front of a white car with its wheels removed.

The White Heron.

On the back, in a careful hand, somebody had written:

The emperor's curve is where Bellario waits. Do not let him choose your passenger.

I held the photograph under the dock light.

Nigga, the old race was still running.

And now I was in the lead.

8. My Wife Knows the Way

The duke changed the rules on Sunday.

Monday's mountain race would require each driver to carry a passenger selected by the chief marshal. The passenger would serve as witness, navigator and official representative of the Grand Prix.

“Nigga,” I said when Porsche read the announcement, “Bellario trying to put himself in my marriage?”

Shawna took the paper from her.

“He can get in line behind the sea.”

Tank leaned over her shoulder.

“What's a representative do?”

“In this race?” I said. “Probably betray you uphill.”

The announcement had arrived with a portrait of Bellario in his restored feather hat. The nigga had survived being named by three attackers, two workers and a letter from seven years ago by standing behind a duke with enough armed men to make a conversation inconvenient. Odette had warrants for his guards. Bellario himself stayed inside the race compound, surrounded by cameras and people who wanted to believe a famous event could not possibly be rotten where they were enjoying it.

We were making that belief difficult.

Every rescued worker had spoken. The videos had spread. The duke called us kidnappers stealing his staff. Then Alina appeared on a hotel balcony beside Mercedes and said, “I asked them to take me,” and the lie got laughed off the street.

The city liked the duke’s money.

Nigga, it loved me.

By Monday morning, somebody had painted my badge on the old harbor wall. Beneath it, in letters taller than Tank, were the words HE COMES BACK FOR YOU.

I stood looking at the picture from our balcony.

Shawna came beside me carrying two cups of coffee.

“You like it,” she said.

“I love it.”

“I know.”

“Is it too much?”

She looked at the enormous gold badge.

“For you? They could use another wall.”

I pulled her close with my free hand.

“Nigga, that’s why you’re my wife.”

She rested her cheek against my shoulder.

For a little while we watched the harbor wake. Fishing boats went out between the yachts. A man washed the steps below the

hotel. Somewhere, somebody practiced a trumpet badly enough to make Rosa close her balcony door.

“Ride with me today,” I said.

Shawna looked up.

“As your passenger?”

“As my way home.”

She held my eyes for a moment.

Then she smiled.

“That was good.”

“I got more.”

“Save some for after the race.”

The starting line sat at the edge of the upper city, where the road began climbing toward a ruined fortress called the Emperor's Seat. The course ran through vineyards, pine woods and a long exposed curve around the mountain's northern face. That last turn gave the race its name.

The Emperor's Curve.

Nero had warned us about it in the photograph.

Lark had repaired the Lamborghini until the blue paint shone again. She stood beside it with grease under her nails and a look of fierce ownership.

“If you bring this car back with a tree inside it,” she said, “I’m making you help.”

“Nigga, I helped yesterday.”

“You held a lamp.”

“A great lamp.”

“You moved it every time somebody called your name.”

“People needed light.”

She fought a smile. Lost enough of the fight to make me feel victorious before the race began.

Cassius stood with Inez beside her red car. His sling was smaller now, but he still wasn’t racing. Her ankle had healed enough for the doctor to let her drive, provided she promised not to leap into another fountain carrying a man.

“I promised nothing about men carrying fountains,” she told me.

“Nigga, that’s how they get you.”

Cassius held the photograph of his father inside a clear sleeve.

“I sent a message through the rescued men,” he said. “If any of them can get word to the island, he knows I’m here.”

“He knows,” I said.

“You don’t know that.”

“No. But look what he wrote. That nigga still warning other people while he locked up. He ain’t stopped being your father.”

Cassius looked down at the picture.

Inez's hand settled against the back of his neck. Brief. Familiar enough now that neither pretended it was an accident.

I left them their moment.

Bellario approached with a man in a gray racing suit. The man was about thirty, neatly shaved, eyes moving from my car to my badge and back. He carried a white helmet under one arm.

“Captain Aiden,” Bellario said. “Your official passenger, Monsieur Lucard.”

“No.”

The feather trembled.

“Passengers are assigned by lot.”

“Then the lot lost.”

Shawna came around the car wearing a white racing jacket and her own blue helmet. The crowd behind the barrier began cheering the moment they recognized her.

Bellario looked at her, then at me.

“Your wife has no experience as a navigator.”

“Nigga, she found me.”

“That is not a qualification.”

“Best one I got.”

Lucard shifted his weight. He looked almost relieved.

I noticed.

“Who told you to get in my car?” I asked him.

Bellario answered.

“The race—”

“I asked that nigga.”

Lucard swallowed.

“I was told it was an honor.”

“What else?”

His eyes flicked toward Bellario. Then away.

Shawna stepped closer to him.

“You don't have to ride with anybody you don't trust.”

The man looked at her like she had opened a window.

“I don't want to,” he said quietly.

Bellario's face tightened.

“Then you may withdraw.”

Lucard did. Immediately. He walked to Odette, who waited near the start with two officers, and began speaking very quickly.

Nigga, sometimes the best thing you can do for a trap is give the bait somewhere else to stand.

Bellario tried to recover with a rulebook. I took it from his hands, opened to the passenger clause and read the part about a driver retaining the right to reject a passenger for safety reasons.

The clause was underlined.

By the duke's own printer.

I held it up to the cameras.

“Nigga, you should read your book.”

The crowd laughed. Bellario turned red beneath the brim of his hat.

Shawna got into my car.

On the duke's platform, Aurelio watched us with one hand around the railing. Beside him stood a stranger in a dark uniform with no visible race badge, broad-shouldered and still as a closed door.

I noticed him too.

Then the engines started, and I had other business.

The first climb was all sunlight and turns. Shawna read the course notes through the headset, her voice calm in my ear. She didn't pretend to know more than she knew. When a line confused her, she said so. When she saw something out the window that the notes missed, she told me that instead.

“Narrow after the stone house.”

“I see it.”

“Man with a flag at the bend.”

“I got him.”

“Goat.”

“Nigga, where?”

“On the wall. Stay away from his championship.”

I laughed so hard I almost missed the turn.

She laughed with me, then brought her voice back steady.

“Left after the bridge.”

We took it clean.

Inez followed close behind. Ahead of us, a dark green car driven by Rafe Velluto held the lead. Rafe was twenty-eight and had spent the entire week telling reporters he wasn't impressed with me. He had also copied my gold wheel chain, bought the same sunglasses and started arriving at breakfast fifteen minutes late.

Nigga was studying hatred very carefully.

He carried Bellario as his passenger.

I saw the feather through the rear window at the start and nearly thanked God for the convenience.

The road climbed into pine trees. The sea vanished. Shadows crossed the hood in long cool stripes. Rafe drove well, fast and controlled, but each time I got close Bellario pointed across his body and made him move to block me.

“That nigga driving his elbows,” I told Shawna.

“Then pass the elbows.”

I did it on the next open stretch. Came alongside, looked through Rafe's window and raised one hand.

Rafe's jaw tightened.

Bellario shouted something at him.

They fell behind.

We reached the Emperor's Curve in first place.

The road ran along the bare face of the mountain, a low stone wall on one side, a cliff on the other. Far below, the sea appeared again, impossibly blue. The old fortress stood ahead on a high spur, flags lifting from its broken towers.

Shawna stopped reading.

“Aiden.”

A truck stood across the road at the far end of the curve.

Not burning this time.

Waiting.

Two men beside it lifted guns.

I hit the brake.

The Lamborghini slid sideways across the road. Gunfire struck stone above us. Shawna ducked, one hand against the dash, the other already reaching for the radio.

“Ambush at the curve,” she said. “All drivers stop below the trees.”

Her voice stayed clear.

I loved her so hard in that second it hurt.

Behind us, Rafe's green car came around the bend too fast to stop. Bellario saw the truck. Saw the guns. His face changed from control to pure animal understanding.

The nigga had arranged the trap.

Somebody had decided to close it on him too.

Rafe swerved past my car. His wheels struck the stone wall. The green machine spun, hit the truck and stopped with its hood folded upward.

Inez pulled up behind us and jumped out, cane forgotten, gunfire striking the road between the cars.

“Stay down!” I shouted.

“Nigga, I'm not standing for applause!”

She dragged Rafe out of the green car while I moved toward the truck. Shawna stayed behind the Lamborghini, covering the space between us with her eyes and her voice on the radio. Bellario struggled with his belt, trapped in the passenger seat of a plan he had finally understood from the correct angle.

One gunman came around the truck.

I threw myself against him. We hit the stone wall together. His weapon went over the edge. He tried to follow it with his body; I caught his jacket and pulled him back because I wanted answers more than a falling silhouette.

The other man ran toward the fortress steps.

Inez went after him.

Rafe grabbed her arm.

“No.”

She turned on him.

“My ankle's fine.”

“Nigga, he got a gun and you got a horse cane.”

For one magnificent second she looked ready to prove that wasn't a disadvantage. Then Shawna called her name, and Inez stopped.

The running man vanished into the fortress.

I secured the first man's arms with the help of a marshal who had finally discovered his courage in the back of a medical van. Odette's officers arrived below the bend. They took over the scene while I went to Bellario.

He was pale, shaking, feather bent against the roof.

“Get me out,” he whispered.

I looked at him through the window.

“Nigga, I thought you chose the passengers.”

“Please.”

I opened the door. He fell toward me, legs unsteady, one hand clutching the rulebook he had somehow kept through the crash.

I caught him by his jacket.

“Who killed Amalia?”

His mouth opened.

“Don't you fucking lie to me.”

He looked at the truck, the gunman in custody, the cliff. At Rafe, who stood bleeding from his eyebrow. At Shawna, who had come beside me without putting away the anger in her face.

“The duke ordered the papers recovered,” Bellario said.

“How?”

“We stopped the car. She tried to go around. I told them to block her. I thought she'd brake.”

His voice collapsed.

“She didn't have room.”

I held his jacket tighter.

“And Nero?”

“He climbed down after her. He came back with her bag. He wouldn't give it up.”

“So you took him.”

“The duke took him.”

“Nigga, you was standing right there.”

Bellario closed his eyes.

“Yes.”

Odette stepped beside me.

“I heard that,” she said.

So had three cameras, two drivers, my wife and half the race over the still-open channel.

The duke's secret had finally found a microphone.

Bellario looked toward the fortress as if he expected the second gunman to return for him.

“He'll kill me.”

Odette took his wrist.

“Then you're fortunate Captain Aiden stopped.”

She put him in the police car without another word.

Rafe stared at Bellario through the police-car window.

"Nigga put me in his own ambush."

"Nigga put himself in it," I said.

"So this nigga's stupid too?"

"That's the part he didn't put on the invitation."

Inez tapped Rafe's arm with her cane. "You kept saying Aiden wasn't impressive."

Rafe looked at me. "Nigga, I was wrong."

"Say it where the cameras can develop," Tank's voice came through the radio.

"Nigga, how are you in this conversation?"

"Aiden got a channel. I'm the nigga on it."

Rafe started laughing, shaking his head until the fear finally loosened enough for him to breathe normally.

The race had been halted below the mountain. Drivers stood beside their machines waiting for instructions. I expected a cancellation. The duke's officials expected a cancellation. The crowd at the fortress expected to go home with a story about almost seeing something.

Then Rafe walked over to me.

"My car's done," he said.

"Yeah."

"You saved me."

"Inez saved you."

He looked at her.

She lifted her cane slightly.

“Remember that when you're discussing how unimpressed you are.”

He nodded. Swallowed.

Then he turned back to me.

“Finish it.”

The drivers behind him began nodding.

Inez smiled.

“Race restarts at the trees,” she said. “First to the fortress.”

I looked at Shawna.

She put her helmet back on.

“Nigga, I still know the way.”

We went back down to the restart.

No duke gave the signal. Odette stood between the cars, raised one hand and dropped it.

We climbed together, all the surviving drivers, engines filling the mountain. Inez stayed beside me through the first two bends. A silver car pressed behind us. We passed the place where the truck had stood, now cleared, and the crowd gathered near the fortress began to roar.

Shawna's voice came through the headset.

“One more turn.”

“I know.”

“Don't take it wide.”

“I know.”

“Aiden.”

“What?”

“I love you.”

Nigga, I took that turn like God had personally held the road still.

We crossed first.

The fortress bells began ringing. Nobody had told the bell-ringer to do it. The old nigga simply looked at the police Lamborghini, saw my wife laughing beside me and decided history had arrived with excellent taste.

I got out with Shawna in my arms.

The crowd closed around us. Inez stood on her car's door sill and lifted both hands toward me. Rafe shouted my name. Odette held up the second jeweled key, taken from Bellario's abandoned case, and the people cheered so loudly a flock of birds rose from the ruined tower.

“Nigga,” I whispered against Shawna's cheek, “we got another bird.”

She laughed into my neck.

That evening Cassius and Esteban watched Bellario's confession together.

Neither spoke while it played.

When it ended, Esteban reached for Cassius's good hand.

“We go get him,” he said.

Cassius nodded.

“Yes.”

On the table between them lay the photograph of Nero and Celadon beside the White Heron. Beside it, my two jeweled keys shone under the lamp.

Five races remained.

A whole island waited.

And downstairs, the duke's messenger had just arrived with a black envelope bearing a gold crown.

Shawna took it from him, opened it and read the single line inside.

If you want the island, Captain, stop borrowing my roads and come to my sea.

I looked out at the harbor.

“Nigga,” I said, “tell him put on something waterproof.”

9. I Put My Badge on a Speedboat

“Nigga, you don't own a racing yacht.”

Tank said it with the confidence of a man standing on one of my regular yachts, looking at two more of my regular yachts, while a waiter brought him breakfast on a plate that cost more than my first apartment.

I looked at him.

“Did that sentence feel poor when it came out?”

“Aiden.”

“Nigga, did your mouth need a loan?”

Rosa put down her coffee before she spilled it laughing.

Tank pointed toward the duke's new announcement. The third key would be awarded after the Sea Crown, a race around the offshore islands in high-powered boats. Drivers could bring their own crews. The duke would provide a vessel to any competitor who needed one.

His offered vessel for me was called Second Chance.

It was painted yellow.

The nigga had written the joke on the side of the boat for me.

“I ain't riding that,” I said.

Lark examined the photograph.

“No,” she agreed. “You aren’t.”

“What’s wrong with it?” Shawna asked.

“It belongs in a museum. A museum that apologizes.”

Cassius laughed, then held his shoulder. The sling was gone now, replaced by strict instructions from the doctor and Inez’s willingness to enforce them with eye contact.

“My father kept a boat here,” he said. “Before the island.”

Esteban looked up.

“The Red Saint?”

“Yes.”

“Nigga,” I said, “every vehicle in this family got a religious problem.”

The Red Saint sat in a locked shed beyond the fishing harbor. Cassius had inherited the lease and paid it for years without opening the place. He told us that on the drive there, looking out the window as if the words were written on the sea.

“I thought if I opened it, I’d have to decide what to throw away.”

“Now you can ask him,” I said.

He nodded once.

The shed doors rolled back to reveal a red racing boat beneath a gray cover. Its shape was low and clean, all muscle. Lark walked

around it slowly. Esteban touched the side with the tenderness of a man finding an old friend's coat.

“Nero beat me three times in this,” he said.

Cassius smiled.

“He said four.”

“One was wind.”

“Nigga, wind participates in boats,” Tank said.

Esteban laughed. The sound came easier now. Not easy, but easier.

We uncovered the Red Saint together. Dust rose in the light. Beneath the windshield lay a pair of old gloves and a little photograph of Cassius at twenty-four, standing beside his father with both of them grinning like the camera owed them money.

Cassius picked it up.

Inez stood beside him. She didn't say anything. Just stayed there while he looked.

Lark found the engine sound enough for the race after work and attention. We gave her both. She brought in three mechanics from the rescued crews, paid them before they touched a tool and told them this boat was carrying a man who considered walls a rumor.

“Nigga,” one mechanic said, looking at me, “you the fountain driver?”

“The yacht driver,” another corrected.

“The staircase driver,” the third said.

Tank folded his arms.

“All them niggas is the same nigga. Keep up.”

They stared at me with open delight.

Then they made the Red Saint shine.

That night we went to the Coral Crown, a casino built above the harbor on pillars shaped like women holding the roof. Its owner, Rocco Silvar, met us at the door in a pink jacket and enough gold to make Marcellus squint.

“Captain Aiden,” he said. “A pleasure.”

“Depends how the night goes.”

Rocco was forty-two, round-faced, merry and dangerous in a way that didn't require pretending he wasn't enjoying himself. He had known Mercedes for years. She kissed his cheek, then held his chin between two fingers.

“You still owe Paloma.”

His smile faltered.

“I sent the payment.”

“You sent flowers.”

“Very expensive flowers.”

“Nigga, flowers don't pay rent unless she sells the whole funeral.”

He looked at Porsche.

She held out her phone.

“She's awake. You can apologize live.”

He paid before we reached the table.

I loved my people.

The casino had prepared a private room for us, but I wanted the main floor. I liked the noise, the light, the sight of grown men begging colored chips to improve their lives. Rocco gave us a table near the band. Rosa sang one song because the singer recognized her and almost dropped the microphone. Tank stood beside the stage trying to look calm while six men told him the woman he loved had the voice of an angel who knew exactly what a bad night cost.

“Nigga, I know,” he kept saying.

Then he tipped the band so much the drummer stood up.

I played cards with Cassius, Rocco and a man named Count Adrian Tide, who would captain the duke's newest boat in the Sea Crown. Adrian was thirty-five, broad, blond and handsome enough to have learned how rarely apologies were required if he smiled at the right angle.

He looked at my chips.

“You drive well,” he said. “Water is different.”

“Nigga, I been wet.”

Rocco laughed into his drink.

Adrian kept smiling.

“Have you ever captained a racing boat?”

“No.”

“Then tomorrow will be educational.”

“For somebody.”

He put down his cards. A very good hand.

I put down mine. Better.

The table went quiet. Then Cassius started laughing.

“You did that on purpose.”

“Won? Yeah.”

Rocco pushed the chips toward me with both hands.

“Nigga, the house is impressed,” he said.

“The house should add a balcony.”

Adrian watched me collect the pot. His smile had become something he was carrying rather than wearing.

“Ten million on tomorrow,” he said.

“Twenty.”

He blinked.

Rocco made a delighted little noise.

“Twenty,” Adrian agreed.

I looked toward Shawna. She sat with Mercedes and Porsche, laughing at something Alina had said. The rescued woman wore a green dress Mercedes had helped her choose and looked like somebody returning to her own face.

Shawna caught my eye.

I held up two fingers.

She looked at the chips. Then at Adrian. Then back at me.

“Bring me something nice,” she mouthed.

Nigga, the wager became sacred.

We stayed until the band changed sets twice. There was champagne. There were women in diamonds and men trying to become stories worth telling them. In one private room, rich fools had laid out enough cocaine to make their noses seem ambitious. I walked past with my wife and let them ruin their own timing. I needed my hands steady in the morning, and I already felt like the most dangerous drug in the building.

Mercedes and Porsche left the casino with a contract for the Grand Prix's official hospitality team, written on terms they had chosen, and Rocco's apology recorded for Paloma. Tank left with Rosa on his arm and a thousand people convinced he was the luckiest man alive after me.

I left twenty million richer in possibility.

The Sea Crown began at noon.

Our boat waited at the end of the quay, red hull shining, my gold badge fixed above the dashboard. Cassius had insisted on placing his father's little white bird beside it.

“He'd like that,” he said.

“Tell him yourself when we bring it back.”

Lark took the engineer's place. Esteban came as navigator. Tank squeezed into the rear seat and immediately accused the boat of being small on purpose. Shawna stayed on the viewing yacht with Rosa, Mercedes, Porsche and Inez. She had kissed me before we boarded, then put a folded handkerchief into my pocket.

“For when you pretend the spray isn't in your eyes.”

“Nigga, you think of everything.”

“That is why you keep surviving.”

The starting horn sounded.

Adrian's white boat leaped ahead. Three others followed in a roar of engines and spray. I brought the Red Saint out behind them, feeling the water through the hull, listening to Esteban's voice and Lark's sharp little comments from the engine station.

“Easy through the chop.”

“I got it.”

“Nigga, the sea doesn't care you won cards.”

“Then it's about to learn.”

Tank gripped the side rail as we hit the first swell.

“Nigga!”

“What?”

“The water punched me!”

“Punch it back.”

He looked at the sea with genuine consideration.

Esteban laughed so hard he had to repeat the next turn.

We rounded the first island in fourth. Took third across the open channel. The Red Saint handled like it had been waiting seven years to be angry at somebody. I learned its movements fast, the lift before a wave, the shiver when I asked too much, the smooth powerful answer when I stopped fighting what it already knew.

Adrian stayed ahead.

He was excellent. I could see why the duke had chosen him. His boat ran clean, straight and wickedly fast. He used the islands to break the following boats' sight of him, opening space whenever the water narrowed.

But he kept looking back.

Nigga knew I was coming.

The Red Saint lifted over another swell. Tank grabbed the rail with both hands.

"Nigga, we in the air."

"Briefly," I said.

"Nigga, briefly is where the fear lives."

Lark laughed. "You want him to slow down?"

"I want that nigga to warn the boat before he promotes it."

Esteban pointed ahead. "Next marker."

"You heard the nigga," I said. "We got a marker."

"Nigga, I can see the marker. I want to remain where seeing is possible."

Then we landed cleanly, the hull cutting through the next wave, and Tank's complaint turned into a shout of pure delight.

At the second marker we passed a blue boat whose captain had driven too hard into the crosswind. It listed sharply, one side low, two crewmen waving for help. Adrian went past without slowing.

Esteban saw it.

"Aiden."

"I see them."

We turned.

Tank stood up before I told him. Lark threw a line toward the damaged boat. The first crewman caught it. The second slipped, vanished into the water and came up coughing beside the hull.

Tank reached over the side and hauled him aboard with one arm.

“Nigga, you heavy when wet.”

The man lay on the deck, gasping.

“Thank you.”

“Thank the captain. I was eating lunch before he made this a lifestyle.”

We stayed until the rescue boat arrived. By then Adrian had gained nearly a minute.

Esteban looked at me.

“My wife would have liked you.”

“Nigga, she had taste.”

Then I turned the Red Saint toward the last channel.

We chased.

The coast blurred. Spray hit my face. Tank shouted every time we rose over a swell, and after a while his shouting changed from protest to celebration. Lark leaned forward, watching the boat, watching me, her mouth open in disbelief as the white shape ahead grew larger.

“You're catching him,” she said.

“Yeah.”

“You stopped.”

“Yeah.”

“You shouldn't be catching him.”

“Nigga, stop telling the boat.”

Esteban pointed toward the final turn, a gap between two rocky islands with the finish line beyond it. Adrian entered first. I came alongside halfway through, the red and white boats so close their spray struck together in a high shining wall.

He looked over.

I smiled.

That same fraction of a second again.

Some niggas never learn what their pride costs them.

We came out of the channel level. The harbor opened ahead, full of boats and flags and people standing wherever a human body could fit. On the viewing yacht I could see Shawna at the rail, both hands raised.

I heard her even over the engine.

“Aiden!”

I gave the Red Saint everything it had asked me for.

We crossed first by a breath.

The horn sounded. Tank stood up and roared. Lark grabbed my shoulder hard enough to bruise it. Esteban took off his cap and held it against his chest.

For a moment he wasn't looking at the finish.

He was looking at the little white bird.

Adrian came alongside after the race. He sat still in his white boat, wet and furious and trying to decide whether he had just witnessed an insult or a miracle.

“You've never done that before?” he called.

“No.”

He looked at the Red Saint. At my badge. At Tank, who was now waving at strangers like he owned their country.

Then Adrian laughed, helplessly.

“You magnificent bastard.”

“Nigga, pay the woman.”

He did.

Twenty million went into Shawna's account before I got off the boat. She met me on the quay, took my wet face in both hands and kissed me while the third jeweled key hung between us.

“What'd you buy me?” she asked.

“Options.”

She smiled.

“I want the opera house.”

“Then we better finish the month.”

Above the cheering crowd, I saw Aurelio standing on his balcony beside the stranger in the dark uniform. The stranger wasn't watching the boats.

He was watching me.

When our eyes met, he raised two fingers in a slow salute.

I didn't salute back.

Nigga, a man that still in the middle of all that noise was either very impressed or very dangerous.

I had room in my schedule for both.

10. The Strongest Man in the Room Met Me

The night after I won the Sea Crown, Mercedes and Porsche opened a club on somebody else's yacht.

That somebody was Rocco Silvar. He insisted it was a temporary partnership. Porsche told him every partnership was temporary if he kept talking through the women explaining it to him.

The yacht had three bars, a glass dance floor and a bedroom upstairs whose ceiling opened to the stars. Rocco showed me the bedroom personally.

“Very popular,” he said.

“With who?”

“Guests.”

“Nigga, that's a wide category.”

He spread his hands, smiling. “We respect discretion.”

From downstairs, Mercedes shouted his name.

His smile vanished.

“We also respect punctual payment,” he added, and hurried away.

I brought Shawna flowers that night. Actual flowers, purchased without destroying the place they came from. She examined the bouquet like she suspected a car might be hidden inside it.

“No fountain?” she asked.

“No.”

“No injured driver?”

“No.”

“You just went to a shop?”

“Nigga, I am a complicated man.”

She kissed me beside the yacht's rail while the party built around us. The harbor shone. Music rose through the deck. Beyond the lights, Isla Gloria lay somewhere in the dark, holding men who should have been sitting at tables like ours.

We hadn't forgotten them.

We also hadn't promised the duke we'd stop living while we came for him.

Mercedes's club was called Blue Hour. The women working it had chosen their clothes, their prices and who they wanted near them. Some danced. Some hosted tables. Some took men upstairs and came back smiling at their phones rather than at the men. Nobody's passport disappeared into an office. Porsche kept the door with two huge attendants and the calm expression of a

woman who had made an excellent list of people she wasn't allowing inside.

Tank stood at the bar beside Rosa. A woman in silver leaned toward him, touched his sleeve and asked if he wanted company.

He pointed to Rosa.

“I got company.”

The woman looked at her. Then back at him.

“Oh. Good company.”

“The best.”

Rosa pretended not to hear. Failed so badly she had to look down into her drink.

I nudged Tank.

“Nigga, you glowing.”

“That's the lights.”

“Nigga, them lights don't have feelings.”

“Mind your marriage.”

“My marriage upstairs choosing what to take from the stars.”

He laughed and pulled Rosa closer.

Cassius arrived with Inez half an hour later. No sling. Just a dark jacket and the cautious way he held his shoulder. She wore red and carried the silver horse cane because, she said, it had grown on her.

They weren't holding hands when they came aboard.

They were by the time they reached our table.

Nobody said a word for almost three seconds.

Then Tank leaned forward.

“Nigga.”

Cassius closed his eyes.

“Please don't.”

“Nigga, your hand got a girlfriend.”

Inez burst out laughing. Cassius tried to keep his face straight and lost immediately.

Shawna kissed Inez's cheek.

“You look happy.”

“I am annoyed in a new direction.”

Cassius lifted their joined hands.

“Very committed annoyance.”

We drank to that.

Rosa sang first. The band gave her something slow and deep, a rhythm that moved through the floor before anybody decided to dance. She stood in the light with one hand on the microphone, looking at Tank while she sang about a man who kept arriving at her door pretending he had forgotten something.

Tank looked at me.

“Nigga, that ain't about me.”

“Of course not.”

“I really left my jacket.”

“Seven times?”

“Different jackets.”

When the song ended, Rosa walked straight off the stage into his arms. He lifted her without thinking. The whole club cheered, and for once the man who could carry a car looked embarrassed by the attention.

Then Mercedes announced the evening's guest.

Bruno Bastion.

Thirty-eight years old, six feet eight, shoulders like a doorway, champion of a dozen strength contests whose trophies looked too small in photographs because he was holding them. He came aboard wearing a sleeveless black shirt, white trousers and a gold belt large enough to keep a small nation together.

Rocco had hired him for an exhibition. Guests could challenge him at the strength table. Anybody who beat him would receive a gold bar and a year's membership at the Coral Crown.

Bruno looked around the club and smiled.

“Who wants to try?”

Four men did.

Four men regretted it.

The first lasted two seconds. The second lasted one. The third tried using both hands and lost more publicly. The fourth sat down, looked at Bruno's arm and decided he had always preferred dancing.

Bruno laughed with him, not at him. I noticed that.

Then he saw me.

“Captain Aiden.”

“Nigga, you know me?”

“I watched the boat race.”

“Which boat?”

“The one where the car flew out of it.”

“Oh. Regular boat race.”

He laughed. A good big sound.

“Come sit down.”

The crowd began chanting before I moved.

Shawna looked at Bruno's arm. Then mine. Then my face.

“You're going to do it.”

“Nigga, they got a chair ready.”

“Aiden.”

“I can't disrespect furniture twice in one night.”

Bruno tested the table with one hand.

"This thing sturdy?"

Rocco nodded. "Very."

Tank looked at me. "Nigga, they still believe in furniture."

"Let the niggas believe," I said. "We ain't touched it yet."

Bruno grinned. "You always bring this many niggas to watch?"

"Nigga, they follow the noise."

Rosa pointed at Tank. "That nigga makes half the noise."

"Supportive noise," he said.

Shawna rested her hands on my shoulders. "Win clean."

"Nigga, I bathed."

"Your mouth didn't."

Bruno laughed so hard we had to wait for him to get his arm back on the pad.

I sat opposite Bruno.

Up close, his hand was enormous. He wrapped it around mine carefully, checking that I was ready instead of trying to surprise me. That made me like him more, which was unfortunate for his record because now I wanted him to have a memorable defeat.

"No powers?" he asked.

"No thunder."

“Good.”

“No excuses?” I asked.

He grinned.

“None.”

Porsche stood beside the table.

“Ready?”

Bruno nodded.

I nodded.

“Go.”

The table creaked immediately.

Nigga was strong.

Not famous strong. Not gym-picture strong. Actual strength that arrived all at once and expected the world to make room. His forearm tightened. His shoulder rolled forward. My elbow pressed into the pad, and for half a second my hand moved toward the table.

The crowd screamed.

Tank slapped both hands over his head.

“Nigga, don't let that mountain take you!”

I looked at Bruno.

He looked at me.

We both smiled.

Then I pushed back.

Slowly.

His eyes changed first. Then his breathing. Then the grin disappeared because his face had found more urgent work. I brought our hands upright, held them there for a beat and heard the whole club go quiet enough for the band to stop playing.

Shawna stood behind me.

“Come on, baby.”

Nigga, that was unfair to Bruno.

I put his hand down.

The table broke.

Not exploded. Not shattered into a weapon. It simply gave up beneath the amount of greatness it had been asked to host, one leg folding, the top dropping, both of us standing at once to keep from landing in our own victory.

For a second Bruno stared at the broken wood.

Then at his hand.

Then he threw his head back and laughed so loudly the people on the neighboring yacht started cheering without knowing why.

“You are a fucking monster.”

“Nigga, I’m a husband.”

Shawna came around the table and kissed me.

The club lost its whole mind.

Bruno took off his gold belt and put it over my shoulder before Rocco could explain that it wasn't part of the prize. I gave him my gold wheel from the harbor qualifier in return. Marcellus had fixed the clasp. It could handle a big nigga.

“Now you raced,” I told him.

He held it up, laughing.

“Now you lifted.”

We became friends over broken furniture. It happens.

Later, Shawna went onstage.

She asked for the pianist to stay, then looked toward me.

“Aiden.”

I froze with my drink halfway to my mouth.

Tank saw my face.

“Oh, nigga.”

“What?”

“She called you by the whole name.”

“Nigga, that's the only name.”

“She used all of it.”

Shawna held out one hand.

“Come here.”

I went.

The pianist stood up and offered me the bench. I looked at him.

“Nigga, don't get generous.”

Shawna leaned close.

“You played for me in Vegas.”

“That was a room.”

“This is a bigger room.”

I sat.

I knew enough piano to make a woman stay beside it. I did not know every song in the world. My wife chose one I knew, and when I touched the first chord, she began singing before I could get distracted by the fact that an entire yacht had decided to watch my hands.

Her voice settled over the notes.

I followed it.

That was the trick, if you can call loving somebody's voice a trick. I didn't try to outrun her. Didn't fill every space because I was afraid the room might notice silence. I gave her a place to step, and she stepped into it so beautifully that the people closest to the stage stopped holding their drinks halfway through their mouths.

Then she changed the melody.

Looked at me.

Dared me.

Nigga, I caught it.

The pianist, standing beside the stage, put both hands on his head.

Shawna laughed into the next line. I answered her with a bright run of notes that surprised me enough to make me grin. She came closer, one hand on my shoulder, singing now like we were alone again, except three hundred people were finding out what alone with her could sound like.

When we finished, nobody moved for a breath.

Then the room stood.

Bruno lifted his new gold wheel above his head. Tank shouted so hard Rosa covered one ear. Mercedes climbed onto a chair. Porsche kept filming, steady as a woman who understood the value of proof.

Shawna bent and kissed me at the piano.

“You keep surprising me,” she whispered.

“Nigga, I got to. You married me.”

Her eyes shone.

Upstairs, later, with the ceiling open and the stars above us, she laid her head on my chest and listened to the sea.

“You liked them cheering,” she said.

“Yeah.”

“I liked them cheering too.”

I looked down at her.

“For you?”

“For us.”

She traced the edge of the cross at my chest. DBM. Damn, boy. Magnificent. Shawna had put those ridiculous words on Dante's cross years before I knew either of them, and now the gold lay warm against my skin like the dead nigga had handed me a compliment with instructions to keep earning it.

“Do you ever get tired?” she asked.

“Of you?”

“Of needing to be the greatest thing in the room.”

I considered lying beautifully.

Didn't.

“Sometimes.”

She kissed my chest.

“You can sleep in this room.”

So I did.

For three hours, nigga, the fastest king alive didn't go anywhere.

At dawn, somebody knocked.

It was Bruno, now wearing a shirt large enough to suggest he had borrowed a sail. Beside him stood Lark, holding a message written on the back of a shipyard meal ticket.

Mateo's handwriting.

She was smiling and crying at the same time.

“He got my letter,” she said. “He knows we're coming.”

I took the message.

Most of it was for her. Ordinary things. Their apartment. The plant he had finally bought instead of flowers. The way he missed her swearing at the kettle. At the bottom he had added a line for me.

The duke is moving the old captains before the final race.

There is a road under the opera house. Celadon says the third key opens more than a trophy.

I looked at the jeweled sea key on the bedside table.

Bruno folded his huge arms.

“I heard you need help on an island.”

I smiled.

“Nigga, bring a bigger table.”

11. Three Cars and a Whole Lot of Me

Porsche refused to drive a Porsche in the Midnight Relay.

“Nigga, I'm not putting my name on somebody else's steering wheel,” she said.

I looked at the red Ferrari she had chosen.

“You understand that's another nigga's name too?”

“Not mine. That's the distinction.”

Mercedes leaned against the passenger door, wearing a white racing suit with blue stripes.

“She been waiting all week to say distinction.”

“And used it perfectly.”

The Midnight Relay required three cars and three drivers on each team. One leg through the old city, one along the harbor, one up the royal road to the palace. The fourth key would go to the team with the fastest combined time.

Naturally, the duke expected me to run the final leg alone while my people lost enough time to make my greatness mathematically inconvenient.

Nigga didn't know my people.

Porsche took the first leg with Mercedes. Tank took the second with Rosa because he said if a race required somebody shouting at him from the passenger seat, he wanted his favorite voice. I took the last in the police Lamborghini with Shawna.

Lark ran the garage. Cassius and Inez entered together on another team, joined by Rafe Velluto, who had decided nearly dying beside Bellario was a poor foundation for continued loyalty to the duke. Bruno supervised our starting area by standing in it. Nobody argued with the placement.

We practiced in the afternoon on a closed road above the port.

Porsche was fast immediately.

Not reckless. Fast. She read the road with a hard, clear attention I recognized from watching her negotiate. Once she chose a line, she committed to it. Mercedes called the turns and insulted her at useful moments.

“Brake, nigga.”

“I am braking.”

“Then brake with your foot instead of your opinion.”

The car came around the bend beautifully.

They both screamed with delight.

Tank was a different experience.

He had chosen a huge black performance coupe because he said small cars made him feel like somebody had shipped his knees

separately. He sat behind the wheel with both shoulders taking up the available country and looked at the practice course.

“I got this.”

Rosa tightened her belt.

“I know.”

He took the first turn too wide.

She grabbed the door.

“I knew less than I thought.”

He corrected, overcorrected and brought the car to a stop beside the cones with one cone under the front bumper and another somehow upright on the hood.

I walked over.

“Nigga.”

Tank stared through the windshield.

“Don't.”

“Nigga, the cone riding better than you.”

Rosa covered her face.

Tank opened the door and got out.

“Then you show me.”

So I did.

Not with a lecture. I put him in the passenger seat and drove the course once, slow enough for him to feel what I was doing. Then once fast. He watched my hands. Asked a question without pretending he already knew the answer. I liked him for that more than I could have told him without making him uncomfortable.

When he took the wheel again, he was better.

By the fifth run, he was good.

By the eighth, Rosa came out of the car laughing instead of gripping the door like it owed her money.

"Nigga," Tank said, looking at me, "you should teach."

"I already graduated."

"That ain't the same thing."

"It was when I did it."

He shook his head, grinning, and went for another run.

Porsche parked beside Tank after the last practice run.

"Nigga, you found the road."

"Road found me," he said.

"That nigga still got a cone under the car," Mercedes said.

Tank got out and looked.

There was no cone.

Both women started laughing.

"Niggas," he said, pointing at them, "that's psychological interference."

"This nigga learned a phrase," I said.

"From your wife."

Shawna raised one hand. "I said stop interfering with the cones. He expanded it."

Rosa kissed Tank's cheek. "That's my educated nigga."

He smiled so widely the women stopped teasing him for almost a minute.

At dusk, the teams gathered beneath the palace hill. The city had strung lights along the course. Blue over the harbor, gold through the old streets, red above the final climb. It looked like somebody had dressed an entire country for my entrance.

The duke stood on the ceremonial platform with Count Adrian, three local magnates and the stranger in the dark uniform. Bellario's empty chair had been removed. No announcement. Just a gap covered by a vase.

Nigga loved hiding a man with flowers.

Aurelio announced a special prize for the night's winning captain: a diamond-studded steering wheel and the right to choose his place in the island stages.

He looked directly at me when he said choose.

I smiled back.

My third key was in Shawna's pocket. The note about the road beneath the opera house was folded beside it. We were learning what his prizes had been built to control.

The first leg began at nine.

Porsche left the line third.

By the old customs house she was second.

On the big screen above the starting area, we watched her red Ferrari move through the narrow streets, Mercedes's head turning beside her as she called the road. A silver car pressed ahead. A green coupe chased behind. The crowd followed each turn with a roar that rolled across the square.

Tank stood with both hands on his head again.

“Nigga, she driving.”

“She said she would.”

“Nigga, she driving like she mad at the future.”

The silver car braked at the market bend. Porsche slipped inside it, took the lead and came out with her rear tires smoking just enough to make the crowd believe it had witnessed a threat become a woman.

Mercedes's voice came through our radio.

“We first, motherfuckers.”

Porsche shouted something joyous and filthy behind her.

I laughed so hard Shawna had to take the radio from my hand.

At the changeover, Porsche stopped cleanly. Mercedes jumped out with the relay baton, ran to Tank and slapped it into his waiting palm.

“Don't embarrass the ladies.”

“Nigga, watch me.”

Tank went.

The black coupe roared onto the harbor road with Rosa beside him and a cone nowhere in sight. He held first through the opening bend. Lost a little on the long descent. Gained it back where the road widened, letting the car use the power he'd been carrying too carefully in practice.

Rosa's voice came through the channel.

“That's it. That's it, baby.”

Tank laughed.

“Nigga, I can do this.”

I leaned toward the radio.

“You doing it.”

Then the lights went out.

Not all of them. A whole section of the harbor course, two long bends beneath the warehouse roofs. The screen went dark there.

We could still hear engines, the crowd's frightened intake of breath, Rosa saying Tank's name once.

My chest tightened.

“Nigga, talk.”

Tank answered immediately.

“I'm here.”

“Keep coming.”

“Something in the road.”

The screen returned in a flash of headlights.

A truck had backed out of a warehouse. Behind it, three motorcycles moved across the course, riders in dark helmets. This wasn't a hidden mistake. This was a public attempt to break the race under enough confusion to blame the night.

Tank slowed.

The green coupe behind him didn't.

It struck his rear corner and pushed him toward the truck.

Rosa cried out.

I was already in my car.

“Aiden,” Shawna said, climbing in beside me.

“I know.”

We hadn't received the baton. My leg hadn't started. I did not give one single magnificent fuck.

I drove.

The police Lamborghini left the staging area in a roar of blue lights. Officials jumped aside. Bruno lifted a barrier out of our path like he was opening a curtain. We hit the harbor road with the siren howling and the crowd splitting around us in a wave of raised hands.

Ahead, Tank had stopped sideways between the truck and the water. One motorcycle lay on its side. Rosa was outside the car, helping its rider away from the hot engine. Even with somebody trying to hurt them, that woman had found a person to save.

The other two riders turned toward us.

“Nigga,” I said, “bad direction.”

I took the car between them.

One swerved into a stack of empty crates. The other dropped his bike and ran. Tank caught him by the back of his jacket before he reached the warehouse door.

“Where you going?” Tank demanded.

The man kicked at him.

Tank lifted him higher.

“Nigga, now you going up.”

I stopped beside Rosa. Shawna jumped out and helped her move the injured rider behind the car. He was groaning, frightened, no

longer anybody's dangerous idea. Odette's officers arrived moments later and took the attackers into custody.

Tank came to my window.

“Rosa good?”

“She good.”

“My car ain't.”

I looked at the black coupe. Its rear wheel sat at an angle nature had not intended.

Tank held up the relay baton.

“I got this far.”

I took it from him.

“Nigga, that's far enough. Get your woman.”

He nodded, went to Rosa and gathered her into his arms. She held his face between her hands and kissed him with such fierce relief that even the officers looked away.

I put the baton beside Shawna's seat.

The race channel erupted.

“Captain Aiden has entered the second leg without authorization. The final changeover has not—”

Odette's voice cut across it.

“The changeover occurred at the disabled vehicle. I witnessed it.”

A pause.

“That isn't the designated—”

“I am designating it.”

Nigga, I loved a woman who could finish a sentence like a gunshot.

We went.

The leaders were far ahead. Cassius's team had taken first; Rafe had completed the opening leg, Inez the harbor section, and Cassius himself now drove the final climb with his doctor's reluctant approval and one very determined shoulder.

I wanted him to win something.

Just not this.

We passed the first trailing car at the tunnel. Passed another on the hill. The Lamborghini climbed under us, blue lights washing the palace walls. Shawna watched the clock and the road, then put the clock down.

“What?” I asked.

“I'd rather watch you.”

“Nigga, that costs extra.”

“I paid in years of my life at the ballroom.”

I laughed and took the next turn tighter.

At the final straight, Cassius's silver car appeared ahead. He saw my lights in his mirror. His window came down.

“You stopped again?” he shouted as I came alongside.

“Nigga, y'all keep needing things!”

He laughed, shook his head and put his foot down.

For one long shining second we ran together beneath the palace lights, two men whose fathers and ghosts and impossible women had brought them to the same road.

Then my Lamborghini edged ahead.

We crossed first.

The palace square exploded with noise.

Porsche and Mercedes reached the finish before I got out. They had commandeered a service cart and driven it up the hill with Bruno standing on the back like a monument that had grown impatient.

“We won?” Porsche shouted.

I held up the baton.

“Nigga, we won.”

Mercedes jumped into my arms. Porsche kissed Shawna's cheek. Bruno lifted both women onto his shoulders while the crowd cheered, and Rocco, somewhere near the platform, announced that the Blue Hour team had free drinks for the rest of the month.

Porsche shouted down at him.

“Put it in writing!”

Tank arrived with Rosa in Odette's car. I met him at the door.

“You did good,” I said.

He shook his head.

“You had to come get me.”

“Nigga, you got Rosa out. You kept the baton. You brought your people through. Don't make me argue with you while we winning.”

He looked at me for a moment.

Then he pulled me into a hug so hard my feet nearly left the ground.

“My brother,” he said.

“Always.”

The duke presented the fourth key without touching my hand.

The stranger in the dark uniform stood behind him. This time he spoke.

“You collect people, Captain.”

His voice was deep, quiet, carrying easily through the noise around us.

I looked at him.

“They collect me.”

“An expensive habit.”

“Nigga, I’m rich.”

A faint smile touched his mouth.

“So I see.”

He stepped back before I could ask his name.

Shawna took the new key, laid it beside the third and looked toward the sea.

“Tomorrow,” she said, “we go see my opera house.”

I put an arm around her waist.

“Nigga, let’s see what the duke keeps under the music.”

12. There Was a Road Under Her Song

Isla Gloria looked like somebody had built a crown and then put beaches around it so it wouldn't seem arrogant.

The palace stood on the highest point, white stone against green hills. Below it, the opera house faced the harbor with six tall columns and a roof the color of old copper. Roads wound between gardens, hotels and little houses painted yellow, blue and pink. At the far end of the island, beyond a black ridge, cranes stood over the shipyard like long-necked birds nobody had fed.

Shawna leaned against the rail of our ferry.

“That one,” she said, pointing at the opera house.

“Nigga, I know.”

“I want the blue room upstairs.”

“You ain't seen upstairs.”

“I can tell.”

Mercedes nodded beside her.

“She can tell.”

Porsche looked at me.

“Nigga, don't argue with architecture. It picked her.”

We had come under an official invitation to tour the island before the final stages. The duke wanted cameras showing us enjoying his hospitality. We wanted to see the road beneath the opera house. Everybody was getting something out of the morning.

Odette stayed on the mainland with Bellario and the witnesses. Bruno came with us. So did Esteban, Cassius, Inez and Lark. Rosa had a rehearsal with the island musicians. Mercedes and Porsche brought clothing and money for people who might need to leave quickly, carried in bags that looked exactly like what rich women brought to an island because they were exactly that too.

Nigga, my people could pack a rescue inside a vacation.

A harbor band greeted us at the quay.

They began the duke's anthem.

Then their drummer recognized me, hit a different rhythm and shouted, "Captain!"

The brass section followed him without permission. The anthem became something faster, louder and much more interested in my arrival. People came out of the cafes. Workers leaned from windows. A man carrying a crate set it down and began clapping over his head.

The duke's representative, a thin man called Lord Orlan, tried to speak through the music.

“Welcome to—”

“Aiden!” the crowd shouted.

“His Grace hopes—”

“Aiden!”

Orlan gave up and handed me the flowers.

Shawna took them.

“For the house,” she said.

A line of cars waited beyond the quay. The duke had arranged sedans. I had arranged for my Lamborghini to come off the ferry behind us. Tank's new black coupe followed it, replacement already purchased because Rosa said she couldn't watch him mourn a wheel for the rest of the month.

Bruno climbed into the back of a large open car and made its suspension bow respectfully.

Orlan led us through town toward the opera house.

People watched from every doorway. Not all of them cheered. Some looked at us with a cautious attention that made the bright buildings seem thinner. They had heard about the rescued workers. They knew people whose names were on Luc's list. They didn't know yet whether I was a visitor who would leave them with a worse duke or a man who meant what the harbor wall said.

I waved anyway.

Then I stopped the car.

A woman stood outside a bakery holding a little photograph against her apron. She was about sixty, face lined from sun and worry. I got out and walked to her.

“Who?” I asked.

“My son. Julian. He's a mechanic.”

She held up the picture.

I recognized him from Cinder Dock. One of the eleven. The man who had knelt and touched the ground.

“He's safe,” I said.

She stared at me.

“He's on the mainland. Odette's people got him a room. We can call him right now.”

Her hand went to her mouth.

Porsche was beside me already with her phone.

Five minutes later the woman was hearing her son's voice for the first time in two months.

The whole street had stopped.

She laughed. Cried. Called him an idiot for not eating enough. Nigga, mothers can cross an ocean between sentences and still arrive with a complaint ready.

When she handed the phone back, she took my face in both hands and kissed my forehead.

“You came back for him.”

I looked at the crowd around us.

“We got more to do.”

The cheering began slowly this time.

It hit harder.

At the opera house, a conductor named Maestra Valentina Sorell met Shawna at the doors. She was fifty-seven, straight-backed, silver hair pinned high and the expression of a woman who had heard every excuse a singer could invent and rejected most of them before breakfast.

“I heard your performance at the banquet,” she said.

Shawna smiled.

“Thank you.”

“I didn't say whether I liked it.”

“No. But you opened the door.”

Valentina held her gaze.

Then she smiled too.

Nigga, my wife had just won an argument in music without singing.

The hall was magnificent. Red seats, gold balconies, a ceiling painted with clouds. The stage stood beneath a great blue curtain embroidered with silver stars. Shawna walked down the aisle slowly, touching the backs of seats as she passed.

I watched her face.

Some things a man buys because he wants other people to see the price. Some things he wants because he has seen the person he loves imagine a life inside them.

I wanted this whole fucking room.

For her.

Rosa joined the musicians near the pit. Tank followed, carrying her bag like it contained his religion. Mercedes and Porsche went upstairs with a wardrobe assistant who had recognized them from Blue Hour. Lark asked to see the building's old machinery, and Cassius went with her. Esteban remained beside Inez, staring at a portrait in the side corridor.

Amalia.

She had sung here once, he told me. Not professionally. At a festival after a race. The portrait showed her laughing with a flower in her hair, the same open happiness that had survived in the photograph on his table.

The duke hadn't covered this one.

Maybe he thought a dead woman's smile couldn't accuse him.

Nigga was wrong about a lot of things.

Valentina asked Shawna to sing one passage onstage.

Shawna looked at me.

I sat in the front row.

“I’m here.”

She began.

The empty hall filled around her voice. No microphone. No chandelier party. Just air, stone, wood and a woman standing where she wanted to stand. Valentina's expression changed halfway through the first phrase. By the end she had folded her hands against her chest.

Shawna stopped.

The echo stayed.

Valentina looked at me.

“You brought us a queen.”

“Nigga, I’ve been saying.”

She blinked at the word, then laughed because my face had apparently made the meaning clear enough.

“I should like her to stay.”

“That’s her call.”

Shawna came down from the stage.

“I’ll sing the closing concert,” she said. “With Rosa. And the full company.”

Valentina nodded.

“The duke has reduced the company.”

“Then unreduced it,” I said.

She looked at me.

“Nigga, bring everybody back.”

For the first time, the old conductor’s eyes shone.

We left them discussing music while I went looking for Lark.

I found her beneath the stage, standing in front of an iron door with the third jeweled key in her hand. Shawna had given it to her before rehearsal. Cassius stood beside her, holding a lamp. On the door was the same little white bird.

“The old service road,” Lark said. “Runs beneath the hill to the shipyard.”

“How’d you find it?”

“The stage carpenter’s brother is missing. He stopped pretending he didn’t know things when I said Mateo’s name.”

Cassius held the lamp closer.

“Nigga, you sure this is a key for this door?”

Lark looked at him. “Same bird. Same old maker’s mark. Same shape.”

"That nigga's asking whether the door agrees," I said.

"The door can disagree unlocked," Shawna said.

Tank arrived behind us. "Niggas, did y'all find the downstairs?"

"Whole downstairs," I said.

"Under the singing?"

"Nigga, under the singing."

He looked back toward the stage. "Rosa better not find out I missed her rehearsal to stand under it."

The key turned.

The door opened onto a sloping passage wide enough for a car. Electric lights ran along one wall. Far below, we could hear engines.

Cassius looked at me.

"My father."

"Maybe."

This time he accepted the word.

We went down together, with Tank and Bruno joining us at the first turn. Shawna came after them carrying her jacket and the expression that meant she had heard half an explanation and was coming for the other half in person.

"Nigga, don't leave me upstairs singing to a trapdoor."

"I was about to call."

“Then your timing's improving.”

The passage ended at a broad underground garage. Old racing cars stood under covers. Crates filled one wall. At the far end, a group of workers loaded equipment into a truck under the watch of three guards.

Lark stopped so suddenly Cassius nearly walked into her.

“Mateo.”

The man near the truck looked up.

Thirty-four. Dark hair. Lean face. One hand bandaged. He stared at her like the whole underground room had become a dream he was afraid to wake from.

“Lark?”

She ran.

A guard stepped into her path.

Bruno moved first.

Nigga, I had seen strong men hurry. I had never seen a mountain decide it had an appointment. He crossed the space in three strides, caught the guard around the middle and sat him on the hood of a covered car with enough force to end the conversation.

Tank took the second guard.

I took the third.

It was not a long fight. Sometimes a man who has spent months frightening hungry workers discovers he has not actually been practicing for us.

Mateo dropped the crate in his hands.

Lark hit him with both arms around his neck.

He held her so tightly I looked away for a second. Not because it was private in the way a bedroom is private. Because there was something in that first breath together I didn't want to turn into a thing I owned by watching too closely.

Shawna took my hand.

We let them have it.

Then Mateo lifted his head.

“You came.”

Lark was crying openly now.

“Nigga, I told you to buy a plant and come home. You had one job after the plant.”

He laughed into her hair.

“I bought it.”

“Then you better be alive to water it.”

“I am.”

She kissed him like she needed the answer in a language his mouth couldn't get wrong.

Behind them, the other workers began moving toward us.

There were nine in the garage. We took all nine.

Mateo told us Nero and Celadon had been moved that morning to the Sovereign Sun, now anchored beyond the shipyard. The duke's captain, Morcant, had taken them personally. He was preparing to leave the island before the final race.

Cassius swore and turned toward the passage leading deeper under the hill.

I caught his shoulder carefully.

“We got people to bring out.”

“My father—”

“We know where he is. We can go after him with everybody ready.”

His eyes burned.

I held them.

“Nigga, don't make him wait seven years for you to die running past help.”

He looked at the workers. At Lark and Mateo. At Inez, who had reached us now and stood beside the passage without trying to hide how frightened she was for him.

He nodded once.

“All right.”

Then an engine started beyond the garage.

A black armored car came through the far entrance, followed by two motorcycles. Its windows were dark. Its front grille looked like it had been designed specifically to discourage touching.

A voice came through a speaker.

“Step away from the workers.”

I looked at Tank.

Tank looked at Bruno.

Bruno looked at the covered cars.

Nigga, the three of us had the same beautiful problem at once.

No Lamborghini.

Plenty of cars.

I pulled the nearest cover off.

Under it sat a white racing machine with a long nose and a painted bird on the hood.

The White Heron.

Cassius made a sound beside me.

Esteban, arriving at the garage entrance, stopped dead.

“My God.”

I opened the driver's door.

“Nigga, your god got keys?”

Mateo reached into his pocket and threw them to me.

“I kept it running,” he said.

Of course he had.

I got in. Shawna took the seat beside me. Behind us, Tank and Bruno moved the workers toward the service passage while Cassius and Inez covered the retreat.

The armored car came forward.

I started the White Heron.

Seven years of waiting woke beneath the hood.

Esteban put one hand on the roof as I rolled past.

“Bring her back,” he said.

I looked up at him.

“Nigga, I'm bringing everybody back.”

Then I drove straight at the duke's black car.

13. I Drove a Legend Through the Opera

The White Heron had a steering wheel made of polished wood, a dashboard full of old-fashioned dials and an engine that sounded like seven years of patience had finally called somebody a bitch.

“Nigga,” I said, “I like this car.”

Shawna pulled her belt tight.

“This car hasn't met you.”

The black armored machine came toward us through the underground garage. Its driver expected me to stop. I could see that in the straight line he held, the lazy confidence of a man whose vehicle weighed twice mine and whose employer had never encouraged imagination.

I went left at the last second.

The White Heron slipped between his bumper and a stack of crates. Wood burst behind us. Shawna ducked as a loose lid flew across the hood. I brought the car around the far end of the garage and headed for the sloping service road while the motorcycles split to follow.

Behind us, Tank and Bruno were getting the workers through the other passage. Cassius had the rear. Inez helped Esteban, who kept turning to look at the white car as if seeing it move had put another age inside his chest.

They were moving.

That was what I needed.

The first motorcycle came alongside.

Its rider looked through Shawna's window.

She looked back.

"Nigga, wrong wife," I said.

She lifted her pistol just enough for him to see the choice clearly.

He fell back.

The second rider tried the other side. I moved close to the wall, not touching him, simply removing the generous amount of road he had assumed belonged to his bad decision. He braked hard and struck a stack of empty barrels.

They went everywhere.

The nigga disappeared into the sound of his own entrance.

We climbed.

Cassius's voice came through the little radio Shawna carried.

"Nigga, remember that's the White Heron."

"Nigga, I can see the hood."

"My father built her."

"Then your nigga built beautifully."

Esteban's voice sounded behind him. "Tell him the left side pulls a little under heavy braking."

"He heard you," Shawna said.

"Tell him anyway," Cassius insisted.

"Niggas," I said, "I got the car, the road and the entire family on the radio. Everybody represented. Let a nigga drive."

Shawna laughed and held the radio closer so they could hear the engine they loved still answering.

The White Heron wasn't the Lamborghini. It was narrower, lighter in my hands, fierce in a different way. I could feel the old road beneath its tires, the deep worn grooves of a passage built before the duke started calling everything his. The car wanted speed. It wanted a driver who didn't mistake age for apology.

I gave it one.

Shawna looked back.

"The black car's coming."

"I hear it."

Ahead, the service road split. One branch climbed toward daylight. The other led beneath the opera stage. I had come down that way. I knew the iron door, the narrow turn, the room where the stage machinery stood.

The armored car couldn't fit through all of it as easily as I could.

Nigga, sometimes being pretty has dimensions.

I took the stage road.

Behind us, the black car hit the corner too wide. Metal screamed against stone. It kept coming, but slower now, one headlight broken, the driver learning that weight could be an inconvenience when the world stopped being impressed by it.

We reached the iron door.

Closed.

Shawna held up the third key.

“Nigga.”

“I know.”

I stopped. She was out before the car settled, key in her hand. The lock turned. The door opened just as the black car appeared around the bend below us.

She got back in.

I drove through.

On the other side, the stage carpenter stood beside a great lifting platform with both hands raised.

“No cars!” he shouted.

“Nigga, temporary exception!”

We rolled onto the platform.

He stared at us.

Then he stared at the armored car squeezing through the iron doorway behind us.

His face changed.

“Up?” he asked.

“Up,” Shawna said.

He pulled the lever.

The platform rose.

Slowly at first. Then faster, old machinery groaning around us. Above, a square of stage floor opened into light. I could hear music. Rosa singing with the orchestra, unaware that her rehearsal was about to acquire a car.

The White Heron emerged through the center of the stage.

Rosa stopped on a note so high it almost became a weapon.

The orchestra stopped with her.

Valentina stood in the conductor's place, baton lifted, looking at the white racing car rising between her singers.

Shawna rolled down her window.

“We found the road.”

Valentina stared.

“Nigga,” Rosa said, “why is your husband in my key change?”

The platform reached the stage.

Behind us, the armored car struck the lift's lower gate. The impact shook the boards beneath our wheels.

I opened my door and stood up.

“Everybody off the stage.”

No speech. No explanation long enough to get somebody hurt. Valentina saw my face, turned to her company and moved them toward the wings with the speed of a woman who had spent forty years making talented people obey a cue.

Rosa came to Shawna's side.

“Tank?”

“Bringing the workers out. He's safe.”

Rosa nodded and took the nearest singer's hand.

We cleared the stage.

Then the black car's roof appeared through the opening.

The driver had forced the lower gate aside and brought his vehicle onto the lift before it could descend fully. The mechanism protested. The stage boards shook. The front of the armored car rose crookedly into the light, one wheel hanging lower than the other.

Nigga was committed to arriving badly.

I climbed back into the White Heron.

Shawna held the door for Rosa to get clear, then shut it and looked at me.

“You got a plan?”

“Enough of one.”

“That is your favorite amount.”

I drove across the stage.

The black car lurched after us, scraping the edge of the opening. We went through the blue curtain into a side passage wide enough for scenery carts. The armored car followed and immediately discovered why scenery carts did not come with armor.

It wedged between the walls.

Stopped.

Its driver revved the engine.

The walls remained unimpressed.

I stopped the White Heron at the far end and got out.

Tank appeared at the passage entrance with Bruno beside him. They had brought the workers upstairs through the side corridor. Mateo stood behind them with Lark holding his arm so tightly I doubted the nigga would ever be allowed to leave a room without checking in again.

Tank looked at the stuck car.

“Nigga parked with confidence.”

Bruno put both hands on its hood.

“You want him out?”

“Yeah.”

They opened the door together.

I am choosing opened because the door eventually did what a door is supposed to do, even if it no longer planned to remain part of the car afterward.

The driver came out with both hands visible.

Smartest thing he'd done all day.

We took his gun, put him beside the other guards and called Odette's officers already waiting near the ferry terminal. Lord Orlan arrived halfway through and tried to explain that the duke would be distressed by the damage to the opera house.

Shawna turned toward him.

“Then he can pay the company to rehearse somewhere while it's fixed.”

“The cost—”

“Nigga,” I said, “look at me before you complain about a bill.”

He looked.

Stopped complaining.

The workers came into the auditorium one by one. Nine people from the underground garage, pale in the daylight falling through the open doors. The singers brought water. The stage crew brought chairs. Somebody found bread. Valentina herself knelt beside a woman whose feet had blistered in old work shoes and helped her take them off.

The grand room changed purpose without losing any of its beauty.

Esteban walked onto the stage and stood beside the White Heron.

Cassius joined him.

Neither touched it at first.

Then Esteban put one hand on the wooden wheel, and Cassius rested his good hand on the door.

“My father told me,” Cassius said, “that this car could make a coward honest because there wasn’t enough metal between him and the road to lie.”

Esteban smiled sadly.

“He told me it could make an old man young if the old man stopped talking and drove.”

“Both sound like him.”

“Yes.”

I came up beside them.

“Car did good.”

Esteban looked at me.

“You drove it like you knew her.”

“Nigga, she introduced herself loudly.”

He laughed. Then the laugh broke, and he leaned against the roof with his eyes closed.

Cassius stayed beside him.

No accusation. No seven-year argument reopening because the room had gotten quiet. Just a son and an old friend standing with a car that had outlived a terrible lie.

I left the keys in Cassius's hand.

“Your father going to want those.”

He closed his fingers around them.

“I know.”

Outside, a crowd had gathered on the opera steps. They had heard gunfire under the hill, seen police at the ferry and watched workers come out of a building where the duke had told them nothing unusual happened.

When Mateo stepped through the doors beside Lark, a man in the crowd called his name.

Mateo looked up.

Then three people ran forward. Friends from the island crew. They caught him between them, laughing and crying, asking questions over one another until Lark said, “Niggas, one at a time. I just got him back.”

They made room for her immediately.

Mercedes and Porsche arranged places on the ferry for everybody leaving. They paid for rooms before the boat sailed. No speeches. No making people say thank you to a camera. Just keys, blankets, money in hands that had been empty too long.

A reporter asked me whether the incident would affect my standing in the Grand Prix.

I looked at the opera house behind me.

“Nigga, I just drove a champion out of a basement and gave nine people their afternoon back. My standing looks excellent.”

The crowd roared.

The reporter tried another question.

“Do you still intend to claim the island?”

Shawna came down the steps and took my arm.

I looked at her, then back at him.

“My wife likes the acoustics.”

That was the sentence they played all night.

On the ferry home, Lark and Mateo sat together under a blanket despite the warm evening. He kept touching her hands, her hair, the edge of her sleeve, small checks that she was still there. She let him, though once she caught his wrist and said, “Nigga, I’m not evaporating.”

He smiled.

“I know.”

“You keep looking.”

“I missed looking.”

She went quiet then and leaned into him.

Tank and Bruno stood at the rail discussing the stuck armored car with the professional respect of men who had found a satisfying object to move. Rosa listened for two minutes, shook her head and went to sit with Shawna.

Cassius stood alone near the stern.

I went to him.

“Tomorrow?” he asked before I spoke.

“We find a way onto the Sovereign Sun.”

“I don’t want to wait another race.”

“We won’t.”

He looked at me then.

“You promise?”

I didn't use the word lightly with a man holding his father's keys.

“Yeah,” I said. “I promise we go.”

Inez joined us, slipped her hand into his and looked toward the dark shape of the flagship beyond the ridge.

“He's coming home,” she said.

Cassius nodded.

Down in the ferry's vehicle bay, the White Heron stood beside my police Lamborghini. Old white, new blue. Two impossible cars from two generations of niggas who had thought a race might let them decide what kind of man they would become.

I rested my hands on the rail.

The duke had lost his hidden road.

He was about to lose his captain.

And if he kept sending cars after me, nigga, he was going to lose the whole fucking garage.

14. A Father Is Not a Prize

Cassius wore his father's jacket to the rescue.

It was too loose through the shoulders and a little short at the wrists. He had found it in the shed with the Red Saint, folded in a box beside old race programs. The leather smelled faintly of oil and the kind of time nobody can buy back.

I saw him standing beside the helicopter and didn't make a joke.

Tank did.

“Nigga, you dressed like you about to apologize to a motorcycle.”

Cassius looked down at himself.

“It's my father's.”

Tank's face changed.

“Then it's a good jacket.”

Cassius nodded.

“Yeah.”

That was the whole conversation. Sometimes my brother knew exactly when to stop being funny.

The Sovereign Sun had moved overnight to a private anchorage beyond Isla Gloria's northern cliffs. Its public crew were ashore.

Captain Morcant commanded the men left aboard, along with the two prisoners the duke had kept out of sight for seven years.

Odette had received word from a crewman who had managed to leave with the opera workers. Morcant planned to sail before sunset. Nobody knew where.

We weren't letting the afternoon decide for us.

Our pilot was a woman named Selene Price, thirty-nine, former rescue flyer, hired by Rocco after Porsche explained that his casino would benefit from being remembered fondly by the people currently saving his guests. Selene looked at the list of passengers, then at Bruno.

"You're two," she told him.

He looked at Tank.

"So is he."

"Nigga," Tank said, "I don't split fares."

Selene pointed at Tank, then Bruno.

"Separate aircraft."

"Nigga, she divided us," Tank said.

"She weighed us," Bruno answered.

"Emotionally?"

"Nigga, structurally."

I stepped between them. "Both niggas get there. Neither nigga takes the roof off the helicopter. That's the agreement."

Selene looked at me. "You are the one I'm worried about."

Shawna nodded. "She picked the correct nigga immediately."

"Y'all trust me or not?" I asked.

"Nigga, I trust the result," Tank said. "Transportation be having a difficult middle."

We took two helicopters.

Shawna came in mine with Cassius and Inez. Tank, Bruno and two of Odette's officers took the second. Rosa stayed on the rescue yacht below with Mercedes, Porsche, Lark, Mateo and a medical crew. Esteban waited there too, holding the goat trophy in both hands like Nero might recognize it before he recognized the years on his friend's face.

Before we boarded, Shawna caught my wrist.

"You're quiet."

"Thinking."

"About?"

"The promise."

She looked toward Cassius.

Then back at me.

"You promised to go. You're going. Bring your eyes with you."

I kissed her.

“Nigga, you keep making good points at inconvenient times.”

“That is marriage.”

We lifted off.

The island passed beneath us, bright roofs and green hills. Then the northern cliffs opened to the sea, and the Sovereign Sun appeared in the cove below, white decks empty, gold trim shining like the ship hadn't done a damn thing wrong.

Two armed boats circled it.

Morcant had expected trouble.

Nigga, he had underestimated the transportation.

Selene brought us low over the water. The first guard boat turned toward us. A gun flashed from its bow. The helicopter jolted as a shot struck something behind the cabin, loud enough to make Cassius flinch and Inez reach for his good hand.

Selene didn't even swear.

“Rude,” she said.

Then she took us over the yacht's stern.

The second helicopter came across from the other side. Tank stood at its open door, one hand locked on the frame, shouting down at the men on deck like he had come to collect a personal debt from the entire boat.

“Police, niggas!”

I shook my head.

“Nigga love my job.”

Selene set us onto the upper platform hard enough to bounce. I was out before the rotor slowed, Shawna behind me, Cassius and Inez moving toward the stairwell together. The guards on the deck had turned toward Tank's helicopter. By the time they saw us, I had already reached the first one.

He swung his rifle toward me.

I hit him with my shoulder and drove him into a sun lounger. The weapon skidded away. Shawna covered the second guard until Odette's officer took him down. The third ran toward the bridge.

I followed.

The yacht shook under our feet as its engines woke.

Morcant was leaving.

Nigga had seen two helicopters land on his boat and decided the solution was a different patch of ocean.

I reached the bridge door just as he came out.

Morcant was forty-six, heavy through the chest, shaved head, white shirt open at the throat. He carried a pistol in one hand and a ceremonial saber in the other, because apparently he couldn't decide whether to be a captain or a warning label.

“You're on my ship,” he said.

“Nigga, your captain downstairs.”

His jaw tightened.

“Celadon lost his ship.”

“No. A nigga stole it.”

He lifted the pistol.

I moved behind the door as the shot struck the frame. The wood splintered against my shoulder. I hit him before he could bring the gun back around, and we went through the bridge doorway together, knocking a chair across the floor.

He was strong. Fast too. He drove an elbow into my ribs, caught my jacket and threw me against the console. Pain flashed through my side, old and familiar enough to make me angry before I was afraid.

“Nigga,” I said, “you picked the sentimental side.”

He swung the saber.

The blade cut through my sleeve and bit into the chair behind me. I grabbed his wrist, struck him hard and sent the pistol out of his other hand. It slid beneath the console.

He tried to pull the saber free.

I took the chair with it.

For one ridiculous second we stood holding opposite ends of a chair with a sword through it.

Morcant stared at me.

I stared back.

“Nigga, this is embarrassing for your profession.”

Then I drove the chair into him.

He fell against the bridge window. The glass cracked. He came back swinging, no longer interested in dignity, and struck me across the mouth. I tasted blood. Hit him twice. He staggered, caught the edge of the console and reached for a hidden knife.

Shawna appeared in the doorway.

“Don't.”

Her gun was steady.

He looked at her.

At me.

At the knife halfway out of his sleeve.

For one moment he had a chance to be smart.

He chose differently.

He lunged toward her.

I caught him around the waist and drove both of us through the side door onto the narrow exterior walk. We struck the rail. It

bent. Morcant's knife flashed past my face and went into the water below.

He grabbed my collar.

The rail gave.

We went over together.

I caught the lower edge with one hand.

Morcant caught my sleeve.

Below us, the yacht's wake boiled white against the hull.

“Nigga,” I gasped, “you heavy for a man with no future.”

He tried to climb me.

The sleeve tore.

I reached down with my free hand, caught his wrist and held him for a second. I wasn't doing it because he deserved a beautiful ending. I wanted him alive to say what he knew, and I didn't want Cassius's reunion to begin with my body in the water.

Morcant looked up at me.

Then he pulled the small gun from his belt with his free hand.

Nigga had learned nothing.

I let go of his wrist and hauled myself toward the rail as the shot went wide.

Morcant fell.

The sea took him out of sight.

I hung there for one hard breath.

Then Bruno's hand closed around my forearm.

“Nigga,” he said, “you weigh less than the table.”

He lifted me onto the deck.

I rolled onto my back, coughing, while Shawna knelt beside me and put both hands on my face.

“You here?”

“Yeah.”

“Stay here.”

“Trying.”

She kissed my bloody mouth without caring what it did to her lipstick.

Behind her, Tank came onto the bridge carrying a man by the back of his shirt.

“This nigga knows the cabins.”

The man nodded so fast I worried about his neck.

“I know. I know.”

I stood.

My knees complained. Nothing blue. Nothing borrowed. Just my own body reminding me it had participated in the morning.

“Show us,” I said.

We went down through the ship.

The corridor below the bridge smelled of polish, old air and food carried past doors without stopping. At the far end stood two locked cabins. The guard's hands shook as he opened the first.

Captain Celadon sat beside the window.

He was fifty-nine, beard gone white, shoulders narrow beneath a clean shirt. He looked up at us without surprise at first, as if he had practiced disappointment often enough to make hope wait outside.

Then he saw the little white bird in Cassius's hand.

“Nero?” he whispered.

“His son,” Cassius said.

Celadon stood.

Slowly. One hand on the chair.

“My God,” he said. “You came.”

Cassius was already at the second door.

The guard opened it.

Nero Chrome stood on the other side.

Fifty-four. Gray in his hair. Leaner than the photographs. One cheek marked by an old scar. He wore a plain blue shirt with the sleeves rolled up and held a book open in one hand, thumb

keeping his place as if some part of him had refused to believe any interruption could be final.

He looked at Cassius.

The book fell.

Nobody spoke.

Cassius took one step.

Nero took one.

Then they were holding each other, the father's arms around the son's shoulders, the son's face pressed into the blue shirt, both of them making sounds no proud man would choose in front of strangers and neither caring that we were there.

I stood in the doorway.

Shawna's hand found mine.

Nigga, I had won four keys, three kinds of race and a gold belt off the strongest man in a yacht club. None of it made my chest feel like watching Cassius become somebody's child again without becoming smaller.

Nero held his son's face between both hands.

“Look at you.”

Cassius laughed through tears.

“Look at me? Nigga, look at you.”

Nero laughed too.

Then his eyes moved over the jacket.

“You kept it.”

“Kept everything.”

Inez stood behind Cassius with one hand over her mouth. Nero saw her.

“Amalia's girl.”

She nodded.

He held out an arm, and she went into it with Cassius still beside him.

For a moment the old race had three people in the same room who had all been waiting to finish the same sentence.

Celadon touched my badge.

“Captain?”

“Aiden.”

He looked toward the ceiling, listening to the engines.

“Who's steering my ship?”

I looked at Tank.

Tank looked at Bruno.

Bruno looked back at me.

Celadon closed his eyes.

“Move.”

Nigga walked past all of us like seven years had been an inconvenient delay between him and his bridge.

We followed him up.

The remaining guards had surrendered to Odette's officers. Morcant's boats had been intercepted outside the cove. On the bridge, Celadon took the wheel, looked over the controls, touched one familiar brass fitting with two fingers and brought the Sovereign Sun around toward the harbor.

Nero stood beside him.

Cassius stood beside Nero.

The ship finally looked like it knew where it was going.

Our rescue yacht came alongside near the mainland quay. Esteban waited at the rail holding the goat trophy.

Nero saw it from the bridge.

He stopped breathing for a second.

Then he laughed.

A huge, broken laugh that brought his son turning toward him in alarm.

“That ugly fucking goat.”

Esteban lifted it higher.

“I kept second place,” he called.

Nero came down the gangway slowly. Esteban met him halfway. For a moment they stood facing each other, seven years between them and a little silver animal held like a peace offering neither man knew how to name.

“I believed them,” Esteban said.

Nero's face changed.

“I know.”

“I should have believed you.”

“Yes.”

Esteban bowed his head.

Nero took the trophy from him.

Then he put his other hand on his friend's shoulder.

“Tell me about her,” he said.

Esteban looked up.

“Amalia?”

“All the things we remember before that day.”

They sat together on the deck.

Cassius stayed near them. Inez sat beside him. Nobody hurried the stories.

Captain Celadon's wife arrived at the harbor an hour later.

Renee, fifty-seven, dark curls threaded with gray, carrying no bag, wearing the first shoes she had found when Odette called.

She ran the length of the quay. Celadon met her at the gangway
and held her like the ship beneath his feet had become irrelevant.

The harbor cheered.

Not just for me this time.

For the men coming home.

I stood with Shawna at the rail while the sun moved west.

She touched the split in my lip.

“You promised to go.”

“Yeah.”

“You brought them back.”

“Yeah.”

She smiled, eyes bright.

“Damn, boy.”

I looked down at the cross.

“Magnificent,” I said.

“Nigga,” Tank called from behind us, “y'all flirting in the middle
of a national event.”

I pulled Shawna closer.

“Then the nation can learn something.”

15. A Nigga Came Home in His Own Jacket

Nero Chrome's first request after seven years of captivity was for a shower.

His second was for a steak.

His third was to know why his son had put a police badge on the Red Saint.

Cassius looked at me across the table.

“Nigga, explain your department.”

We were in Rocco's private dining room at the Coral Crown. Rocco had closed the whole room for us, told the kitchen to make anything we wanted and personally removed a portrait of the duke from the wall. Mercedes watched him carry it out.

“You should have done that earlier.”

“He was a guest.”

“He still can be. In somebody else's house.”

Nero sat beside Cassius, wearing fresh clothes that didn't fit him quite right because the tailor had estimated from a photograph taken before the duke stole seven years of his appetite. He ate slowly at first. Then faster. Celadon sat farther down with Renee leaning against his shoulder, refusing to let an empty chair separate them after everything else had.

Esteban brought the potatoes himself.

Nero looked at them.

“You still overcook the edges.”

“You still like them.”

“Yes.”

The old friend smiled. The son watched. A room full of new people learned where these men had once been young together.

Then Nero asked about Cassius's mother.

Not loudly. Not dramatically. He had been waiting until the room settled, perhaps until he could believe the first answers were real enough to survive the next one.

“Livia?” he said.

Cassius's hand stopped beside his plate.

I saw it happen.

So did Inez.

Nero looked at his son's face, and the answer reached him before the words did.

“No.”

Cassius swallowed.

“Three years ago.”

Nero sat very still.

“She waited?”

“Every day.”

The room went quiet without anybody asking it to.

Cassius reached into his jacket and took out a little envelope. No hidden crime inside. No last secret that would solve the race. Just a letter he had carried because sometimes a man knows which conversation will hurt before he reaches it.

“She wrote this for you. I kept it.”

Nero took the envelope in both hands.

He didn't open it at the table.

“Excuse me,” he said.

Cassius stood with him.

Nero touched his arm.

“Stay. Eat. I want to see you eating when I come back.”

He went out onto the balcony alone.

Nobody followed.

I put my hand on Shawna's knee. She covered it with hers.

Nigga, you can bring a man out of a locked room. You cannot bring back every afternoon somebody stole while he was in it. I hated the duke so cleanly in that moment it almost felt cold.

Cassius stared at his plate.

Inez moved her chair closer.

“She liked you,” he said to her suddenly.

“Your mother?”

“She saw you race. Said you drove like you expected the road to apologize.”

Inez laughed softly.

“She sounded wise.”

“She was.”

He looked toward the balcony.

“I don't know how to give him everything he missed.”

“You don't have to do it before dessert,” Shawna said.

Cassius looked at her.

She smiled gently.

“Start with who's sitting beside you.”

His fingers closed around Inez's.

That was a start.

When Nero returned, his eyes were red. He folded the letter carefully and put it in his shirt pocket. Then he looked at his son, at Inez, at their joined hands.

“About time,” he said.

Cassius stared.

“What?”

“You looked at her like a hungry dog at the old races.”

“I was twenty-four.”

“You were very grown to be that obvious.”

Inez bent forward laughing.

Cassius covered his face.

“Nigga, seven years and this is what you came home to say?”

“I’ve had time to prepare.”

Tank hit the table with his palm.

“I like this nigga.”

Nero looked at him.

“I heard you pulled a door off my prison.”

“Door was talking crazy.”

“Then I like you too.”

Nero looked around the table as the laughter settled.

“Which one of you taught my son to swear like that?”

Cassius pointed at me.

I pointed at Cassius.

“Nigga, your father asked for facts.”

“Nigga, you’ve been an influence.”

Tank raised his hand. “This nigga was already saying it when we found him.”

Inez nodded. "Angrily. Now the nigga sounds happy sometimes."

Nero put his arm around his son's shoulders. "Then these are good niggas."

Cassius laughed again, face open now, and for a second nobody at that table needed another thing from the night.

The room breathed again.

After dinner, Cassius took his father down to the garage.

We all went. Of course we did. Nigga had a car waiting that had been gone almost as long as he had, and none of us had developed the modesty to miss it.

The White Heron stood beneath a soft light, cleaned by Lark and Mateo until the old paint shone. My Lamborghini sat beside it, blue and gold, looking like the future had arrived wearing a badge it hadn't entirely earned honestly.

Nero stopped at the white car.

Put one hand on the hood.

"Hello, girl."

Cassius stood beside him.

"Aiden brought her out."

"So I heard."

Nero looked toward me.

“Through an opera house?”

“Nigga, acoustics were excellent.”

He laughed, then opened the driver's door and sat down slowly. His hands found the wheel. His shoulders changed. For a second I could see the man in the photograph, the one before the locked cabin, before the white in his hair.

Mateo stood nearby, nervous.

“I kept her running. Changed what needed changing. Nothing I couldn't put back.”

Nero looked up at him.

“You kept her alive.”

Mateo nodded.

“Trying.”

“Thank you.”

Lark took Mateo's hand. He squeezed it hard enough that she looked at him and smiled.

Nero turned the key.

The engine filled the garage.

Half the hotel came downstairs.

People in bathrobes. A chef with flour on his sleeve. Two women from Blue Hour carrying their heels. Rocco himself,

looking alarmed until he recognized the sound and then looking honored that it had chosen his building.

Nero shut the engine off and climbed out.

“Who wants to drive?”

Every man in the garage moved a little.

He smiled at Cassius.

“Your first lap. I promised.”

Cassius looked like somebody had reached back through seven years and opened a door inside him.

He got in.

Nero took the passenger seat.

They drove out together, slowly, up the ramp into the warm night. The crowd at the entrance stepped aside. When people saw who was in the white car, the cheering followed it down the street.

I stood with Shawna at the top of the ramp.

“That's good,” she said.

“Yeah.”

“You look proud.”

“Nigga, I did some good work.”

She kissed my cheek.

“You did.”

The White Heron returned twenty minutes later with Cassius grinning and Nero pretending his son had not impressed him.

“Too cautious through the harbor bend,” Nero said.

“You told me slow down.”

“I was testing whether you'd listen.”

“Nigga, I listened.”

“Then you passed one part.”

Inez leaned into the window.

“Don't worry. I can help him with the other part.”

Nero looked at her, then at his son.

“Oh, I imagine.”

Cassius put his forehead against the wheel.

Nigga had wanted his father back. He was going to have to accept the complete package.

Then Nero turned toward me.

“Your turn.”

I raised my eyebrows.

“You sure?”

“I want to feel what my car felt in that opera house.”

“Nigga, the opera house signed a release.”

He laughed and stayed in the passenger seat.

Shawna folded her arms.

“Bring him back with the same number of years he has right now.”

“I’ll try not to add any.”

We drove out.

The city was quieting, lights soft along the waterfront. I kept the White Heron easy through the first streets. Nero watched my hands without speaking. At the closed practice road above the harbor, he looked at me.

“All right.”

I smiled.

The car rose into its power.

We took the first bend fast. The second faster. I could feel Nero’s attention sharpen beside me, the little shift in his breathing when he realized I wasn’t guessing. The road opened ahead, white lines curving beneath the lamps, and the old machine answered every movement with a clean, fierce joy.

At the overlook I stopped.

Nero sat still for a moment.

Then he laughed.

“Jesus Christ.”

“Nigga, he available for comparison?”

He wiped one eye with the heel of his hand.

“I have spent my whole life around drivers.”

“Good life.”

“I thought I knew the best.”

“You met him late. Still counts.”

He shook his head, delighted.

Then his expression grew serious.

“Aurelio will try to take the final race from you before it starts.

He always preferred owning the result to risking the road.”

“He running out of things to own.”

“Yes.”

Nero looked across the water toward Isla Gloria.

“The seven keys were made for the old race. Each opened a part of the island to the winner. The road. The harbor. The palace gates. The fleet house. We turned them into trophies because people like symbols more when they can wear them.”

“What does the last one open?”

“The main harbor chain. The ceremonial entrance. Celadon holds the second lock from the flagship.”

I thought about the duke's insistence on keeping the captain alive.

“He couldn't finish giving away what he stole without him.”

“Exactly.”

“Nigga built himself a cage with a party on top.”

Nero smiled faintly.

“And you keep moving the furniture.”

We sat looking at the water for a little while.

Then he said, “Livia's letter told me to eat well.”

I turned toward him.

“She knew me. Knew I'd come home angry enough to forget ordinary things.”

“You hungry?”

He considered it.

“Yes.”

“Nigga, then let's get something.”

We bought sandwiches from a little late-night place near the harbor. The owner recognized Nero, came around the counter and held him for a long time before taking the order. He recognized me second and gave us both extra meat with a seriousness that made it feel like an award.

We ate in the car.

No cameras for a few minutes. No duke. No crowd needing me to turn the night into a legend.

Just a man who had come home and a nigga helping him remember dinner.

When we returned, Shawna waited outside the hotel with Inez and Cassius.

Nero handed his son the keys.

“Keep them tonight.”

Cassius looked at him.

“I’ll see you in the morning?”

The question came out smaller than he meant it to.

Nero put a hand on his shoulder.

“In the morning.”

Cassius nodded.

Inez took his hand, and they walked into the hotel together.

Shawna came to me.

“You add any years?”

“Fed him instead.”

“Good.”

I pulled her close.

Upstairs, on our bed, lay the invitation to the fifth race. Black paper. Silver letters. The Night Baptism, a coastal run after sunset, with a storm expected before the finish.

The duke had added one handwritten sentence.

Perhaps the weather will do what your friends prevent.

I showed it to Shawna.

She read it, looked at the clear night outside and handed it back.

“Nigga,” she said, “he still thinks you're going alone.”

16. The Storm Asked Who Was Driving

“Nigga, that's a hurricane.”

Tank stood under the hotel canopy looking at the sky. The sky looked back like it had come to collect money.

“It's a storm,” Lark said.

“That storm got a management position.”

Mateo laughed beside her. He had been out of captivity three days and already learned that Tank's weather reports came with threats.

The Night Baptism was scheduled to begin at sunset. Sunset had arrived behind a black wall of cloud, so the duke's officials simply announced that it had happened somewhere and continued laying out the flags.

Rain swept across the harbor in long silver sheets. Boats strained against their ropes. The race road ran along the coast, through old tunnels and over a causeway to a lighthouse before turning back toward the city. It should have been postponed.

Aurelio offered every driver the chance to withdraw.

He did it while standing beside a camera.

Nigga had finally found a way to make weather smug.

I chose an Aston Martin from the loan fleet for the race. Dark green, broad-shouldered, built to carry a man through a bad evening with his suit still attached. The police Lamborghini needed a rest, and Lark had informed me that machines could not file complaints but she could speak for them.

“You'll bring this one back,” she said, standing beside the Aston.

“Nigga, you said that about the last one.”

“And look how necessary it was.”

She and Mateo had prepared the car together. They moved around each other without colliding, handing over tools before the other asked, arguing about small things with the joy of people who had missed having small things to argue about.

I watched them for a second.

Then Lark caught me.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“Nigga, you smiling.”

“Car looks good.”

She looked at Mateo.

He smiled too.

Shawna wore a dark coat over her team jacket. Rain shone in her hair as she came toward me, carrying my helmet in both hands.

“You don't have to prove the storm wrong,” she said.

“I ain't mad at the storm.”

“Good.”

“Storm ain't met me.”

She closed her eyes briefly.

Then she handed over the helmet.

“Come back and tell me about it.”

I kissed her forehead.

“Every turn.”

Nero stood beside Cassius's silver car at the grid, speaking quietly to his son. Inez waited nearby in red, watching the rain strike the road. Rafe had withdrawn. Adrian had entered. So had six other drivers whose pride, ambition or bank accounts had made a complicated decision on their behalf.

The duke stood beneath a huge green umbrella.

The stranger in the dark uniform stood behind him without one.

Rain ran off his shoulders.

Nigga didn't blink.

I walked past both of them toward the car.

Aurelio spoke.

“Perhaps tonight we discover whether you are fortunate or talented.”

“Nigga, you discovered talent at the fountain. Now you're investigating denial.”

The mechanics nearby burst out laughing.

He let the sound pass over him.

“The sea gives nothing back for admiration.”

“Then stop watching me so hard.”

I got in.

The light changed.

We left into the rain.

The Aston moved differently from the Lamborghini, heavier through the first turn, planted when the road opened. I kept it steady while water blurred the windshield and headlights tore long tunnels through the darkness ahead. Adrian took an early lead. Inez followed him. Cassius stayed just behind me, patient, listening to the road instead of the audience.

The city vanished behind us.

On the coast road, the wind struck sideways hard enough to move the whole car. I corrected and felt the tires answer. Rain drummed against the roof. The engine held its deep note beneath everything, a sound I could trust when the world outside had become water and occasional stone.

“Nigga,” I told the car, “we doing fine.”

It did not answer in words.

Cars know when to be professional.

We reached the first tunnel in fourth. Inside, the sudden absence of rain felt almost violent. The road shone under the lamps. I passed Adrian's teammate at the exit, came out into the storm in third and saw Inez's red taillights ahead.

She moved left before the next bend.

I stayed right.

We ran side by side through a wall of spray.

Then her voice came over the channel.

"You enjoying the ocean now?"

"Nigga, my wife wanted all of it."

She laughed, and we took the curve together.

At the lighthouse causeway, the marshals waved yellow flags.

Water washed over the low wall in bursts, not deep enough to stop the cars but enough to make every movement matter.

Adrian slowed. Inez held back. I came alongside the white car at the first long straight and saw his face through the window, jaw tight, eyes fixed ahead.

He was frightened.

Good drivers get frightened. They just don't always let the fear choose their hands.

I passed him cleanly.

The lighthouse rose ahead, its beam sweeping the rain. We circled beneath it and turned back toward the mainland. The sea hit the wall with a force that made the road shake.

Then the lights went out again.

Not the harbor this time. The lighthouse.

The beam stopped.

For one second the whole causeway disappeared.

A truck came out of the darkness at the far end, headlights high, moving toward the race against the traffic.

“Nigga.”

I saw the shape. The distance. The narrow space between its wheels and the wall.

I didn't have time to be angry.

I took the Aston toward the low sea barrier.

The right wheels climbed the stone edge. The car tilted. Rain struck the side window. For a breath we ran on two wheels, the truck filling the space where my hood should have been.

Its mirror struck mine.

Glass vanished.

Then I was past.

The Aston came down hard, rear tire bursting as it hit the road. I fought the wheel, kept the nose straight and heard the truck brake behind me as Inez and Adrian scattered around it.

“Truck on the causeway!” I shouted into the channel.

Cassius answered.

“I see it.”

A crash sounded behind me.

Then his voice again.

“Clear. We're clear.”

I breathed.

The tire was gone. The car dragged to the right. Sparks ran beneath the rear corner, bright against the rain. Ahead lay five miles to the city and the finish.

Lark's voice came through.

“Aiden, stop.”

“The wheel still on.”

“Nigga, that isn't the whole requirement.”

“I can feel it.”

“Then feel where you can pull over.”

I slowed enough to bring the car under control. Other drivers passed. Inez first, then Adrian, then Cassius, who stayed beside me for a moment.

“You need me?” he called.

“Nigga, go win something.”

He hesitated.

“Go!”

He went.

I found a marshal's shelter near the mainland end of the causeway. Two officials stood beneath it, white-faced. One had a radio that wasn't working. The other stared at my ruined wheel.

“Do you have a service car?” I asked.

He nodded toward an old blue coupe parked beneath a tree.

It was not a racing car.

It looked like a schoolteacher had lent it to his cousin and expected it back with a full tank.

The rules allowed a replacement vehicle in the event of race interference, provided the driver completed the course from the point of the stop.

Nero had made me read that part before the start.

Nigga believed in knowing where a duke might try to lie.

I pointed at the coupe.

“That one.”

The official shook his head.

“It's mine.”

“You got insurance?”

“Yes, but—”

“I got money. We both protected.”

He looked at my face.

Then at the race disappearing into the rain.

Then he handed me the keys.

“My wife named it Clementine.”

“Nigga, Clementine about to become famous.”

The marshal looked at his keys in my hand.

"Nigga, you really taking Clementine?"

"Nigga, she ready."

"She's never been in a race."

"Neither had that nigga's boat yesterday. Look what happened."

He stared toward the storm. "My wife going to kill me."

"Tell her the nigga with the badge borrowed it."

"She'll say which nigga."

"Then show her the race."

He laughed, frightened and delighted at once. "Nigga, bring my eggs."

"I heard you the first time, breakfast captain."

I got in.

The seat smelled faintly of peppermint. A little knitted bird hung from the mirror. There was a bag of groceries in the back and a classical music station playing softly beneath the storm.

I moved the eggs onto the floor.

Greatness respects breakfast.

Then I drove.

Clementine did not leap forward.

Clementine considered.

Then she went.

I took the first bend clean, let the little car gather speed on the descent and felt its narrow body slip through the wind more easily than the heavier Aston had. It had no business being in the race. Neither had I, according to most of the people whose names were now beneath mine on the standings.

We understood each other.

At the old tunnel I caught the last racing car.

The driver looked over.

Looked again.

“Nigga,” I said through the open window, “you getting passed by groceries.”

I went around him.

The radio crackled with disbelief from the commentary booth. They had found me on a camera and were trying to decide whether the picture had been mislabeled.

“Captain Aiden appears to be driving—”

“A car,” Tank shouted somewhere behind the open team channel. “Nigga, finish the sentence.”

Lark was laughing now. She didn't want to. I could hear her fighting it.

“Keep it together,” she told me.

“Me or Clementine?”

“Both of you fools.”

We climbed toward the city.

One car. Then another. The little blue coupe ran beneath the lamps with its knitted bird swinging wildly and the eggs safe on the floor. I drove every turn as if I had known the machine my whole life. No blue thunder. No borrowed power. Just hands, road and a stubborn little engine discovering it had more in it than its owner had ever asked.

By the harbor I was fourth.

The crowd saw me.

Nigga, I will never forget that sound.

It started with laughter. Not mockery. Astonishment too large to come out politely. Then it became shouting. People pointed at

the blue coupe, at my badge held against the windshield, at the grocery bag visible through the rear window.

“That's him!”

“Nigga, that's Aiden!”

“He in a regular car!”

“The nigga made it irregular!”

Inez saw me in her mirror and started laughing over the radio.

“No.”

“Yes.”

“Aiden.”

“Nigga, move. I got milk.”

She fought me through the next bend anyway. Nearly held me. I passed her at the exit with the knitted bird swinging like it was cheering for its own family.

Cassius was second.

Adrian first.

The final straight opened before us, wet and bright beneath the city lights. Adrian's boat-race pride had become a car-race lead, and he meant to keep it. Cassius pressed him on the inside.

I came through the gap between their spray.

Clementine's engine screamed.

The little bird hit the windshield.

We crossed first by half a bumper.

I stopped beneath the finish arch with steam rising from the hood and the classical station still playing.

For three seconds nobody moved.

Then the official whose car I had borrowed arrived on the back of a service motorcycle and fell to his knees in front of Clementine.

“My wife is never going to believe this.”

I got out and handed him the eggs.

“Nigga, breakfast intact.”

Shawna ran toward me laughing so hard she could barely breathe. She hit my chest with both hands, then kissed me, rain on her face, joy everywhere.

“You won in that?”

I looked back at the little blue coupe.

“Baby, that's Clementine.”

The crowd took up the name.

Clementine. Clementine. Clementine.

The duke presented the fifth key while a thousand people chanted for a schoolteacher's grocery car.

Nigga, I had never seen a rich man lose to produce before.

It looked excellent on him.

17. They Gave Me a Crown I Didn't Enter For

The Rose and Thunder Ball was supposed to honor the most glamorous people of the Grand Prix.

I did not enter.

I want that understood before anybody starts lying about my humility. I entered a car race. I entered another car race. I entered a boat race because a nigga challenged my relationship with water. I had not entered a contest requiring a sash.

Then Mercedes came into our suite carrying a crown.

“Nigga, stand still.”

“Why?”

“Head measurements.”

“For who?”

She looked at me.

“Nigga, whose head are we discussing?”

Porsche followed with a white suit laid across both arms. The jacket had blue silk inside and gold buttons stamped with a little steering wheel.

Shawna looked up from her music.

“Oh, that's good.”

“You knew?” I asked.

“I suspected the world would notice you were handsome eventually.”

“Nigga, it noticed early.”

“Then put on the suit.”

The ball had started as one of the duke's side events, another evening where rich men paid to be seen beside beautiful women and everybody pretended the seating hadn't been negotiated. Mercedes and Porsche had taken over its hosting after the original organizers tried to underpay the performers.

Now the performers were choosing the prizes.

Rocco said it was a bold direction.

Porsche told him bold directions were expensive and he should sign the check before developing an opinion.

The event took place in the old winter garden, a glass palace above the harbor filled with palms and white flowers. Rain from the storm still glittered on the roof. The city outside smelled clean, as if even the streets had washed up for me.

When we arrived, the band stopped halfway through a song.

The singer pointed.

“That nigga brought the whole moon in a suit.”

The drummer hit a roll so long the saxophonist laughed into his instrument.

I looked at Shawna.

“See? Early.”

She took my arm tighter.

“Try to survive the compliment.”

Mercedes greeted us at the stage. She wore white feathers and diamonds, hair swept up, looking like a woman who could ruin a rich man's sleep by forgetting his name. Porsche wore blue satin with a slit that made three men at the nearest table sit straighter and one woman turn her chair for a better view.

Alina stood beside them in green, holding the microphone with a confidence I hadn't seen on the yacht. She had chosen to host part of the evening. Chosen it herself. That mattered enough that I noticed it before I noticed how beautifully she wore the dress.

“You ready?” Mercedes asked me.

“For what?”

“Nigga, stop pretending the lights ain't on you.”

The lights moved onto me.

The crowd cheered.

Porsche announced the first award: the Golden Heart, chosen by the rescued workers for the person whose name they had heard before they knew his face.

I stopped smiling for a second.

Julian came onstage. The mechanic whose mother had called him from the bakery. He held a little gold heart on a blue ribbon.

“My mother told me to make sure you knew,” he said, voice shaking slightly, “she's keeping bread ready.”

I bent so he could put the ribbon around my neck.

“Nigga, tell her I don't miss dinner.”

He laughed. The room stood.

Then Porsche announced the next award.

Best Dressed.

I looked down at the suit she had literally brought me that afternoon.

“Nigga, you rigged this.”

“We dressed the winner,” she said. “That's different.”

Mercedes put a blue sash across my chest.

The crowd lost its mind again.

Then Alina announced Most Wanted.

I raised an eyebrow.

“By which department?”

“All of them,” Tank shouted from our table.

Rosa nearly fell against him laughing.

Shawna came onto the stage and stood beside me.

“I accept this one on behalf of the household.”

The women in the front row cheered her. One held up a hand-painted sign reading WE RESPECT THE WIFE BUT THE MAN IS BEAUTIFUL.

Shawna read it.

Nodded gravely.

“Accurate.”

Nigga, I loved this room.

Alina tried to ask me to move to the center of the stage.

"Which center?" Tank shouted. "That nigga makes every spot the center."

"Nigga, let her host," I said.

"Then let the nigga be centered."

Mercedes took my elbow and moved me two feet. "There. Nigga centered."

Porsche adjusted the light. "This nigga reflects expensive."

Shawna looked up at me. "He reflects loud too."

"Niggas," I told the room, "I appreciate the technical crew."

Alina was laughing too hard to read the next line, and Mercedes put an arm around her until she could find her place again.

The crown came last.

Not the Grand Prix crown. Not the island. A smaller gold thing with blue stones, chosen by the performers, drivers and hospitality crews as their king of the month. Mercedes held it above my head while Porsche adjusted the sash to make room for the new disaster my appearance was about to cause.

“You got a speech?” Mercedes asked.

I looked over the crowd. My people. New friends. Men I'd beaten. Women whose names I had learned because they had more to say than a rich nigga had bothered to hear.

Then I looked at Shawna.

“Nigga,” I said, “I came for a beach.”

The room exploded.

I didn't get to say anything else for almost a minute.

When the noise settled, I lifted my glass.

“To my wife. To my people. To every nigga who thought he could make this month belong to him before we got here.”

I smiled.

“We appreciate your preparation.”

They drank to that so hard the waiters had to move faster.

The dancing began immediately afterward.

Shawna took me onto the floor. She had changed into silver, and under the glass roof she looked like the storm had left its best

light on her shoulders. We moved together while the band played something slow enough for the room to watch and fast enough for her to make me work.

“You enjoying your crown?” she asked.

“Nigga, it fits.”

“That's because Mercedes measured your head.”

“She should measure my future.”

Shawna laughed and spun away, then came back against me with one hand at the back of my neck.

“Your future's dancing.”

I kissed her before the turn finished.

The band hit the next note like it approved.

At the edge of the floor, Cassius danced with Inez. He wasn't as smooth as she was. She knew it. She let him find the rhythm without making him feel examined, and when he finally relaxed, she rested her forehead briefly against his.

Nero watched from the table.

Esteban sat beside him.

“Your son steps heavy,” Esteban said.

“Your daughter drives angry.”

“They'll manage.”

“Yes,” Nero said. “They will.”

Celadon and Renee barely moved at all. They stood together in the middle of the floor, holding one another, letting the music pass around them. After seven years, nigga, a man can dance by staying exactly where he wants to be.

Then the glass roof broke.

A black car came through the winter garden's upper service entrance, smashing the doors inward and sending a wave of broken glass across the empty reception area. Two motorcycles followed. Men in dark masks jumped off them with guns in their hands.

The music stopped.

I pulled Shawna down behind a stone planter.

“Nigga,” Tank roared from the other side of the room, “at the dance?”

Apparently at the dance.

The first gunman fired into the ceiling. People screamed and dropped. Alina took the microphone, crouched behind the stage and told the crowd where to move, voice clear enough to cut through the panic. Mercedes and Porsche opened the side doors. Rosa led the people nearest her toward them. Bruno put himself between the gunmen and the dancers like somebody had moved a wall into the room on purpose.

I looked at Shawna.

“You got the side?”

“I got it.”

I went.

The crown stayed on my head.

Nigga, it had a good fit.

I crossed behind the planters while the gunmen looked toward the exits. Tank met the first one at the edge of the dance floor and put him into a table that had done nothing to deserve its evening. Bruno caught another man before he could raise his weapon and lifted him off the ground with a patience that frightened me more than shouting would have.

The third ran toward me.

I hit him with the Most Wanted trophy.

It was heavier than it looked.

He went down.

Somewhere behind me, Porsche shouted, “Nigga, that's engraved!”

“I'll read it later!”

The driver of the black car tried to reverse out through the broken doors. I climbed onto the hood, caught the edge of the roof and swung myself through the open side window before the car moved ten feet.

He stared at me.

I still wore the crown and the sash.

“Nigga,” I said, “you interrupted the king.”

He reached for a gun beside his seat.

I caught his wrist, drove it against the wheel and brought the car to a stop with one foot across the console. The horn sounded beneath his elbow. He tried to hit me. I hit him first.

Then I dragged him out through his own door.

Odette's officers came through the side entrance moments later. They had been stationed nearby because the duke had stopped pretending he respected parties. She took one look at me, the crown, the ruined trophy and the man at my feet.

“Captain.”

“Commandant.”

“Congratulations.”

“On which part?”

She looked around the room.

“All of it, apparently.”

The attackers were taken away alive. One had a broken arm, another would need stitches, and the driver had discovered that a sash did not reduce a man's ability to throw him onto marble.

Nobody in our crowd was shot.

A few cuts. A sprained wrist. Fear that would last longer than the cleanup. But people stood again. Found their friends. Asked where their shoes had gone. Started helping one another gather the pieces of the evening.

Shawna came to me and straightened the crown.

“Crooked.”

“Fight was crooked.”

She kissed me.

Then she looked toward the band.

“Can you still play?”

The pianist checked his hands.

The drummer lifted his sticks.

The singer looked at the broken glass, the overturned tables, the people holding one another in the middle of the floor.

Then he looked at me.

“Nigga, what you want to hear?”

I took Shawna's hand.

“The rest of the song.”

They played it.

The room began dancing again.

Not because nobody was scared. Because the gunmen were gone and we were still there, and my wife had chosen a silver dress she was not going home in after half a song.

The duke sent no flowers this time.

He had left the mainland for his island palace, taking his guards and the stranger in the dark uniform with him. Odette could hold the men we caught. She could protect witnesses. But Aurelio's palace had its own armed gates, and he had decided to make the final days of his race a war from behind them.

Nigga should have stayed at the dance.

At least there I had been dressed for mercy.

18. The Duke Finally Drove His Own Bullshit

Aurelio Cruel entered the sixth race himself.

The announcement came from Isla Gloria at breakfast. His Grace would personally defend the honor of the Grand Prix in the Bridge of Kings, a crossing of the floating road between the island's eastern harbor and the old naval fort.

Tank looked at the photograph of the course.

“Nigga, that's water with opinions.”

The road had been assembled from broad linked platforms, each wide enough for two cars, stretching across a sheltered bay. Boats held the outer sections steady. At the far end, a steep ramp climbed onto the fort's quay. The drivers would cross twice, circle the island's coastal road and finish at the palace gate.

Nero studied the picture.

“It used to be a ceremonial crossing. Slow. Flags. Music.”

“Nigga made everything a threat,” I said.

“Yes.”

Celadon stood beside him, arms folded.

“The platforms can carry the cars. The danger is what he asks the drivers to do on them.”

I looked toward the harbor, where the Sovereign Sun now flew its old white bird above the bridge. Celadon had reclaimed the ship in every way that mattered to the people who worked aboard it. The duke still claimed to own it. He also claimed I had ruined the winter garden, which was technically true in enough places to make arguing tedious.

Tank stood at the dock counting the cars going aboard.

"Nigga, why we bringing a boat to a car race?"

"Because the road in the water," I said.

"And why the road in the water?"

"Because that nigga owns an island."

"So when you own it, we fixing that?"

Shawna looked over her shoulder. "Nigga, he'll put another road higher up and race both."

"See?" Tank said to Bruno. "That nigga ain't a solution. That nigga's more geography."

Bruno laughed and ducked beneath the gangway frame.

We took the flagship to the race.

Nigga, if somebody steals a man's boat and that man gets it back, you ride with the man.

The whole crew came aboard in the morning. Lark and Mateo loaded the Lamborghini. Tank brought the replacement black coupe. Porsche brought her Ferrari. Cassius drove the White

Heron onto the lower deck with Nero beside him. Inez arrived in red and kissed Cassius before handing him his gloves, a gesture so ordinary now that both their fathers looked away to give it room.

Shawna carried her music in a blue case.

“Rehearsal after?” I asked.

“Victory after. Then rehearsal.”

“Nigga, order matters.”

“It does.”

We sailed into Isla Gloria's harbor with the ship's bell ringing. People crowded the quay. They saw Celadon on the bridge, saw Nero standing beside him and began cheering before they even found me on the deck.

I liked that.

Then they found me.

Nigga, I liked that too.

The duke waited at the starting area in a green racing suit. His car was black and gold, long, low and ugly with money. He wore no mask of courtesy now. The white streaks in his hair stood out sharply against the dark suit, and his eyes followed me with a kind of hunger that had forgotten how to look charming.

“You brought stolen property to my island,” he said.

Celadon stepped forward.

“I brought my ship home.”

Aurelio looked at him.

For a moment I saw the old habit in his face: speak sharply, summon a guard, return the man to a room. Then he saw Nero. Cassius. Odette's officers on the quay. The cameras. The crowd pressing close enough to hear every word.

He swallowed the command.

Nigga, it looked painful.

“The race,” he said, “will proceed.”

I stood beside my Lamborghini.

“Good. You been talking for three weeks.”

His jaw tightened.

“You think these people love you.”

I looked around.

A woman held up a loaf of bread from the bakery. Julian stood beside her, waving both arms. Alina stood with Mercedes and Porsche on the viewing platform. Rocco wore a blue shirt with my face on it and looked delighted to have found a profitable form of courage.

“Nigga,” I said, “ask them.”

He didn't.

We lined up at the floating road. Six cars entered. Inez and Cassius had chosen to race. Adrian joined too, along with a veteran driver named Sabine Cross, forty-one, who had told a reporter she considered Aiden impossible but wanted to confirm it at close range.

I respected scientific curiosity.

The first horn sounded.

The platforms moved gently beneath our wheels. Water shone on both sides. The road ahead rose and fell in long shallow motions, never quite still, making distance a thing you had to feel as much as see.

The second horn sounded.

The duke looked across at me.

I smiled.

The third horn sent us forward.

His black car surged first. Mine came beside it. We reached the first joint together, wheels striking the metal seam with a hard ringing sound. The platform dipped beneath us, rose again, and the sea came up level with the lower edge of my window.

Nigga, that got my attention.

Aurelio knew the course. He had practiced. His car moved with ugly confidence, taking the center of each platform and forcing

me toward the edge. I let him have the first bend. Stayed close. Watched the way the floating road lifted before the next joint.

Behind us, Inez and Cassius ran side by side in red and white, their cars bright against the blue water. Sabine held fifth. Adrian stayed back, patient after discovering twice that my existence complicated his wagers.

At the halfway point, the duke struck my rear quarter.

Lightly.

Deliberately.

The Lamborghini moved toward the edge.

I caught it.

“Nigga,” I said, “you want to make this personal in public?”

He hit me again.

This time I let the car move farther, gave him the space he expected to take and watched him overcommit into it. His front wheels crossed the seam at the wrong angle. The black car bounced, lost its clean line and fell half a length behind.

I took the center.

The crowd on the fort's quay began screaming.

We hit the final ramp together, blue and black climbing out of the sea. I landed first on the stone road, turned beneath the fort wall and headed back toward the second crossing.

The duke followed.

Close.

He was furious now, but still good. That mattered. A bad driver could have excused himself. Aurelio knew exactly how well I was beating him.

On the return crossing, a platform ahead of us shifted sharply.

One of its holding boats had moved away.

The floating road opened into a narrow gap.

Not huge. Huge would have made the trap obvious enough for everybody to stop. This was the kind of gap meant to catch one car wrong and turn the rest of the race into a tragic discussion about conditions.

I saw the duke look toward it.

Then toward me.

Nigga, there it was.

I didn't call the thunder.

I called his bluff.

I stayed beside him.

Closer.

So close he could not change his line without hitting me hard enough for every camera to see the choice. The gap came toward us. His hands tightened on the wheel.

He braked.

I didn't.

The Lamborghini left the edge, cleared the broken space and landed on the next platform with a crack that went through my teeth. The car stayed straight. Behind me, Aurelio's black machine hit the gap slower, nose dipping, rear wheels lifting before the front caught the far side.

It landed badly.

Its front bumper tore away.

I kept going.

The other drivers slowed and took the gap under the marshals' direction. The race wasn't over. The trap hadn't swallowed anybody. The duke had simply damaged his own car trying to arrange the shape of my fear.

Nigga, expensive lesson.

We came off the floating road onto the island circuit. The coast flashed past my windows. Villages, gardens, the opera house, the bakery where Julian's mother stood waving a blue cloth as I passed.

Inez caught the duke before the palace hill.

Cassius caught him after.

Aurelio tried to hold them off. Couldn't. The black car's damaged front scraped at every dip, throwing sparks beneath the

gold paint. He had enough speed to remain dangerous and not enough control to look graceful doing it.

I crossed the finish first.

Inez second.

Cassius third.

The duke came fourth, his car smoking, his face so still it looked painted.

Sabine climbed out behind him and walked straight to me.

“I can confirm it,” she said.

“What?”

“You're impossible.”

“Nigga, peer review.”

She laughed and shook my hand with both of hers.

The sixth key was brought forward by Lord Orlan, who now looked like he had begun rehearsing a life in which he worked for somebody else. He held the cushion out at arm's length.

I took the key.

Behind him, the duke stepped out of his ruined car.

The crowd booed.

Not everybody. Enough.

He looked up at the palace, then back at me.

“You haven't won the island.”

“One more race.”

“One more road.”

“Nigga, I like roads.”

He came closer.

For the first time there were no cameras between us, only at our sides. His voice dropped.

“I can make the island empty before you claim it.”

My smile went away.

He saw it and thought he had found something useful.

“I can burn every car, sink every ship, silence every stage. You can arrive first to ashes.”

I looked at him for a long moment.

Then I took the key off its ribbon and held it between two fingers.

“Nigga, you keep mistaking your last chance to walk away for suspense.”

His eyes hardened.

I didn't raise my voice.

“You touch my people, your last race happens on foot.”

He stepped back.

His guards closed around him. The crowd parted as he walked toward the palace gates. At the top of the steps stood the stranger in the dark uniform.

This time the stranger smiled at me openly.

Like he had enjoyed every second.

Shawna came beside me.

“What'd he say?”

I told her.

All of it.

She looked toward the palace, then down at the six keys in the case Porsche held open beside us.

“Then we don't leave everybody here alone tonight.”

“No.”

“Nigga, good.”

We took over the opera house before sunset.

Not by force. Valentina opened the doors and told us which rooms had beds, which corridors reached the street and which windows stuck when the sea wind turned. The company stayed. Workers brought food. Rocco sent supplies. Celadon kept the Sovereign Sun ready in the harbor, its lights bright, its crew finally working for a captain they trusted.

Tank and Bruno stood at the main doors while people came and went.

Mercedes and Porsche organized rooms with the efficiency of women who had spent their adult lives judging whether a strange building wanted anything good for them.

Nero and Esteban sat with the old island mechanics, drawing the final race course from memory. No secret instructions. Just the shape of roads they loved and the places the duke had changed.

Shawna rehearsed with Rosa and the full company.

I stood in the back of the hall listening.

Outside, the island waited for the night.

Inside, my wife filled the room with a voice the duke had promised to silence.

Nigga, he was going to have to come through me first.

19. The Opera Had Security

Chief Gloria Knox arrived on Isla Gloria wearing a blue suit, sunglasses and the expression of a woman whose captain had made her vacation an international event.

She came through the opera house doors while Tank and Bruno were arguing about which one of them occupied more of the entrance.

"Move," she said.

They moved.

Bruno looked down at Knox. "Ma'am, are you his commander?"

"When he remembers."

"Nigga remembers," Tank said. "Nigga just remembers at speed."

Knox looked toward me. "Captain, did you send my car over an ocean?"

"Which ocean?"

"That answer concerns me."

"Nigga's being precise," Tank said.

"Nigga's being evasive," Shawna corrected.

Knox put her sunglasses in her pocket. "At least everybody here knows him."

"We know that nigga," Rosa said warmly. "We packed accordingly."

"Nigga," Tank whispered to Bruno, "that's where he got it."

Knox took off her sunglasses and looked down the aisle at me.

"Captain."

"Chief."

"Nice theater."

"My wife likes it."

"So I've heard. The entire department has heard. One officer has started taking singing lessons in case you promote the orchestra."

Shawna laughed from the stage.

Knox looked up at her.

"Mrs. Aiden."

"Chief."

"Keep him breathing."

"Working full time."

Nigga, women meet and immediately form a government around your stupid decisions.

Knox had come with six officers who were technically on leave and practically dressed like they expected trouble to recognize them. Odette met her near the front doors. The two women

shook hands, exchanged a few words and began making the building safer without asking either of us how strongly we felt about furniture placement.

I appreciated expertise.

Especially when it arrived with my department's name on the jackets.

The night before the final race, the opera house held more life than it had seen in years. Singers rehearsed onstage. Workers ate in the side rooms. Drivers talked with mechanics in the courtyard. Somebody had found a television, and Clementine's victory played on it every twenty minutes, provoking the same delighted shouting each time the eggs appeared.

The marshal who owned Clementine had brought his wife to the island. Her name was Elise. She was fifty, cheerful, and had informed her husband that they were never selling the car because it now had a better story than either of them.

I gave them a new luxury sedan anyway.

She looked at the keys.

“Nigga,” she said, then covered her mouth. “I’m sorry. My husband keeps playing the video.”

I laughed and hugged her.

“Your car earned the accent.”

By nine, the square outside the opera house glowed with lanterns. Julian's mother sent bread. Rocco sent wine. Mercedes and Porsche arranged tables so the workers and performers could eat together. No separate room behind a pillar. No invitation stamped important enough to excuse a man being rude.

Tank sat with Rosa on the steps.

I passed them carrying a plate.

He looked up at me.

“Nigga, can you stop saving countries during dinner?”

“Only an island.”

“That's how you start.”

Rosa leaned against his shoulder.

“He saved my rehearsal.”

“He drove a car through it.”

“And brought the singers back.”

Tank considered that.

“Nigga's thorough.”

Across the square, Cassius and Inez stood beside the White Heron. She had one foot on the low curb, red dress moving in the evening breeze. He leaned against the car, listening while she spoke. Not planning his answer. Listening.

Nero watched them from a table with Esteban.

“I would have been terrible at this age,” Nero said.

“You were terrible at this age,” Esteban replied.

“Yes. But beautifully.”

They clinked glasses.

I went upstairs to find Shawna.

She stood in the blue room she'd chosen from the ferry, looking out over the harbor. It was exactly what she had imagined: pale walls, blue curtains, a little balcony facing the sea. Her music lay open on a desk. Dante's watch sat beside it while she adjusted the strap.

“You were right,” I said.

She turned.

“About the room?”

“About everything. But start there.”

She smiled and came to me.

Down below, the square hummed. The island had a night before it had a king, and we stood above it holding each other like the future was close enough to touch but not yet safe enough to trust completely.

“Tomorrow,” she said.

“Yeah.”

“You win. We sing. Everybody gets to sleep.”

“Nigga, that's a beautiful schedule.”

“Follow it.”

I kissed her.

Then the first explosion shook the harbor.

The windows rattled. A blue flare rose above the shipyard ridge.

Down in the square, voices changed pitch. Music stopped.

Shawna closed her eyes for one second.

“Nigga.”

“I know.”

We ran downstairs together.

Black vehicles came down the royal road toward the opera square. Six of them. Armed men stood in the rear of two open trucks. Behind them, motorcycles spread through the narrow streets, engines rising over the sound of people moving toward the doors.

The duke had sent the rest of his evening.

Knox met me at the bottom of the stairs.

“People inside. Hold the square.”

Odette was already moving her officers toward the side streets. Tank and Bruno stood at the main doors, directing the crowd inward. Mercedes took the women nearest the tables toward the

rear corridor. Porsche helped Elise and her husband through the courtyard gate. Rosa stayed with the singers, keeping them together while Valentina led the oldest musicians down the side steps.

Shawna looked at me.

“I’ll get them through.”

“I know.”

She kissed me once, quick and fierce.

Then she went to work.

I walked down the opera steps.

Nigga, the square looked different when everybody you loved was behind you.

The first black car stopped near the fountain. A man climbed out wearing a gray coat and carrying a long gun. He was older, thick through the neck, his face calm with the certainty of somebody who had survived by making other men afraid first.

“Captain Aiden,” he called.

“Nigga, you know my name. Save us time.”

“Walk away from the building.”

I looked back at the opera house.

Then at him.

“That’s my wife’s rehearsal.”

He lifted the gun.

The world became noise.

Stone chipped beside me. I went behind the fountain as Knox's officers answered from the steps. The gray-coated man ducked behind his car. Two motorcycles cut across the square, riders trying to reach the side entrance.

Tank met the first one with a table.

He lifted it, turned and put it directly into the motorcycle's future.

The rider hit the wood, flew sideways and landed in the flower bed.

“Nigga,” Tank shouted, “closed section!”

Bruno caught the second rider when he tried to get past the doorway. The bike skidded away. Bruno put the man down, took his weapon and kicked it out of reach with the irritated efficiency of a champion clearing a gym floor.

I moved between the fountain and the parked cars.

A gunman came around the hood of a silver sedan. I struck his arm, drove him backward and fired when his partner raised a weapon from the opposite side. The second man fell. The first stumbled away with his hands up, his courage suddenly interested in retirement.

“Nigga, stay there.”

He stayed.

Across the square, Cassius and Inez had brought the White Heron out of the courtyard. Not into the gunfire. Between the side street and the people still crossing to shelter. Its white body blocked the opening long enough for Nero and Esteban to guide the last group inside.

A truck accelerated toward the gap.

Inez saw it.

She got behind the wheel, turned the White Heron sharply and moved the car out of the way just as the truck struck the stone bollards hidden beside the curb.

Its front rose.

Stopped.

The driver hit the windshield and slumped, alive but no longer participating.

Cassius looked at Inez through the open window.

“Nigga, marry—”

He stopped himself.

She stared.

Then she grinned.

“Finish the fight first.”

I heard it from ten feet away and almost laughed in the middle of a gun battle.

Love, nigga. Terrible timing. Excellent taste.

The gray-coated man had reached the steps.

Knox confronted him halfway up. He fired, forcing her behind a pillar, then turned toward the main doors where Shawna was helping Valentina move a wounded musician.

I crossed the square at a run.

Blue thunder flashed through my body.

One burst.

The distance seemed to tighten. My hands moved faster than the thought finishing in my head. I hit the gray-coated man before he reached the door, drove him off the steps and landed with him on the stone below.

His gun went one way.

My breath went another.

We rolled. He struck me in the jaw. I answered. He reached for a knife. I caught his wrist and held it against the pavement while the thunder burned out of me, leaving every muscle suddenly aware of its own weight.

“Nigga,” I told him through my teeth, “you picked the wrong building.”

He tried to headbutt me.

I put him down.

When I stood, the square tilted.

Knox caught my arm.

“Captain.”

“I’m here.”

“I can see that. Stay useful by sitting.”

She pushed me onto the lower step, took the man's weapon and went back into the fight.

Nigga, my chief had promoted bossing me around into an international discipline.

I sat for thirty seconds. Long enough to get my breath. Long enough to see the fight turn.

Odette's officers came through the side street behind the trucks. The attackers' line broke. Some ran. Some dropped their weapons. One tried to drive away and found Bruno standing beside his open door, holding it in place with one hand.

“Nigga,” Bruno said, “engine off.”

The engine went off.

The square fell quiet in pieces.

Sirens. Groans. People calling names. The little crackle of a damaged car cooling beneath the fountain's spray.

We had wounded. Cuts, bruises, one officer hit in the shoulder, a violinist with glass in his arm. Two attackers were dead. The others who hadn't fled lay under guard or sat with their hands visible, discovering how ordinary a bad decision looked after the shooting stopped.

Shawna came down the steps and knelt in front of me.

“How much thunder?”

“One burst.”

She checked my eyes.

Then she pressed her forehead against mine.

“Okay.”

Behind her, Rosa began singing.

Softly at first, from somewhere inside the doors. A note to find the people who were shaking. Another to tell them the room was still there. The singers joined her one by one, no orchestra, just voices moving through the broken quiet.

Shawna looked back.

Then she stood, helped me up and sang with them.

The sound filled the square.

People came to the windows. To the doors. The workers who had hidden under the stage came upstairs and stood shoulder to shoulder in the aisle. Celadon rang the Sovereign Sun's bell from the harbor, and its deep answer crossed the water into the music.

I stood between my wife and my brother, bruised, exhausted,
wearing a badge over a gold cross and six keys waiting inside
the building behind me.

The duke had sent guns to end her song.

Nigga, he had made the audience bigger.

20. Breakfast Before Paradise

The morning of the final race, Tank burned the toast.

After everything we had survived, nigga, that felt personal.

He stood in the opera house kitchen holding two black slices between his fingers while Rosa watched with the expression of a woman reconsidering the limits of a man's usefulness.

“You can lift a car,” she said.

“Car don't burn this fast.”

“You left it in there.”

“I was checking the doors.”

“Nigga, the toast wasn't attacking the doors.”

I came in and took one look at the plate.

“Duke send that?”

Tank threw a towel at me.

Everybody laughed.

It was a good sound to hear in a building that still had bullet marks beside the entrance.

The injured had been taken to the clinic. The wounded officer was stable. The violinist had insisted he could still play and then been told by Valentina that optimism was not a substitute for an uninjured arm. Nobody from our company had died in the

attack. Two of the duke's men had. Their bodies were taken away before breakfast, and the square had been washed clean without pretending the night had never happened.

Knox sat at the kitchen table with Odette, coffee between them. They had the calm, tired faces of women who had spent the night keeping other people from becoming tomorrow's bad news.

"Captain," Knox said when she saw me.

"Chief."

"Race. Win. Come home."

"Nigga, concise leadership."

"I'm practicing for when you start interrupting."

Shawna came in carrying a plate of eggs.

Clementine's eggs.

The marshal's wife had insisted on cooking them for us before the final race. Apparently groceries could become ceremonial if a nigga drove them fast enough.

We ate at long tables pushed together beneath the kitchen windows. Drivers, musicians, mechanics, police, sex workers, boat captains, jewelers. Marcellus had come from the mainland with a case of tools and the real Blue Mercy ring on his hand. He had spent the early morning repairing the clasp on my key case

because, he said, one should not win an island and lose its entrance into a drain.

I sat beside him.

“You been quiet.”

“I’ve been watching you damage things.”

“Nigga, that’s almost a career now.”

“For both of us, apparently.”

He lifted the case. Six jeweled keys lay inside, each different, each bright. The gold wheel, the little steering crown, the sea-blue stone. He had cleaned them all.

“Original work,” he said. “The old race commissioned a different maker for each. Your last one is the largest.”

“How you know?”

“I know the man who made it.”

“Of course you do.”

“He was very vain.”

“Nigga, was it you?”

Marcellus smiled into his coffee.

Tank nearly choked.

“You made the big key?”

“Forty years in a trade leads to the occasional relevant object.”

I looked at him.

"Nigga, you could have mentioned it."

"You were busy driving through the doors the smaller ones opened."

Fair.

Tank leaned over Marcellus's shoulder.

"Nigga made the biggest key before Aiden even got here."

"Years before," Marcellus said.

"So that nigga was preparing."

"I was working."

"Preparing while working," Tank insisted.

I shook my head. "Nigga, let the man have a past without making it my appointment."

Shawna looked at me in surprise. "That was almost modest."

"Nigga, almost. The key still ends up in my hand."

Marcellus laughed softly and opened the case wider. "You young niggas exhaust a very old object."

He showed me a little photograph from the case. A much younger Marcellus stood beside an older jeweler, both holding the unfinished ceremonial key. The date was more than twenty years earlier. No secret prophecy. No destiny waiting in a

workshop. Just an old man whose life had been larger than the corner of it I'd met.

"I wanted the teeth shaped like waves," he said. "My teacher told me a key must first open something."

"And?"

"It does both."

I shook his hand.

"Then I'll bring it back for inspection."

He nodded.

"Please bring the hand holding it too."

Across the table, Mercedes and Porsche argued about the names of the clubs they planned to open on Isla Gloria.

"Blue Hour stays," Mercedes said.

"For the yacht," Porsche replied. "The island room needs its own name."

"Nigga, it's the same ocean."

"Different door."

Alina leaned between them.

"What about No Second Door?"

They both looked at her.

She shrugged.

“Nobody gets sent around the back.”

Mercedes smiled slowly.

“That I like.”

Porsche wrote it down.

I pointed at them with my fork.

“You got the building by the eastern quay.”

“You haven't won it yet,” Porsche said.

“Nigga, put it on hold.”

She grinned.

“Already did.”

Lark and Mateo planned a garage. Not a palace workshop where drivers swept in, shouted and vanished. A place with windows, decent food and enough room for mechanics to sit down without somebody accusing them of laziness. Mateo wanted a little garden behind it. Lark told him if he managed to keep the plant at home alive for a month, she would consider expanding his responsibilities.

He kissed her cheek.

“Nigga, I watered it before they took me.”

“Then it survived better than your communication.”

He laughed. She did too.

Nero and Esteban wanted the White Heron on the final road, but Cassius refused to race it that day.

“She’s done enough,” he said. “I’ll drive my own.”

Nero nodded.

No argument.

The old car would wait at the finish with them inside it.

Inez sat beside Cassius, watching him across the rim of her cup.

“What?” he asked.

“You started a sentence last night.”

Tank looked up immediately.

“Nigga.”

Cassius put his cup down.

“I remember.”

“You planning to finish it?”

“After the race.”

She considered him.

Then she smiled.

“Drive well.”

Nigga, that man had acquired a finish line inside the finish line.

After breakfast I went to the courtyard.

The police Lamborghini waited in the sun. Dark blue, gold badge, repaired body, familiar shape. Lark stood beside it with Mateo, both of them wearing clean team shirts for the first time all month. She held out the keys.

“She’ll bring you through.”

“I know.”

“Don’t ask her to be a boat.”

“Nigga, that was another car.”

“Don’t ask her to be a plane.”

“Context matters.”

Mateo laughed and stepped back as Shawna came through the doors.

She wore white.

Not a wedding dress. White trousers, a fitted jacket, blue silk at the throat. Dante’s watch on her wrist. My earrings. Her own beautiful face, looking at me like she had found the one place in the courtyard she meant to stand.

“You riding?” I asked.

“Final race is single driver.”

“I can argue.”

“Nigga, I know.”

She put her hand against my chest, over the cross.

“I’ll be at the finish. I want you to see me before you stop.”

I held her close.

The noise of the courtyard moved around us. Tools. Footsteps. Tank asking somebody whether the toast had been thrown out or merely relocated. Life, nigga. All these people making plans because they expected a tomorrow big enough to hold them.

“I love you,” I said.

Shawna looked up.

“I know. I love you too.”

“Even when I do too much?”

“Especially when you come back and tell me.”

I kissed her.

Then a messenger arrived from the palace.

No feather this time. No velvet tray. Just a young man in a gray jacket holding an envelope with both hands. He looked frightened enough that I thanked him before opening it.

Inside was an offer.

The duke would surrender the prize fleet, withdraw his objections to the rescued workers leaving and pay me fifty million if I left Isla Gloria before noon.

He would retain the island.

The opera house was not mentioned.

Nigga really thought he had found a number larger than my wife.

I handed the letter to Porsche.

“Keep that.”

She read it and whistled.

“You want me to answer?”

“Yeah.”

“What should I say?”

Shawna looked at the blue curtains visible through the upstairs window.

“Tell him I already chose the room.”

Porsche smiled and began writing.

We left for the starting line with the whole square cheering.

The final race would begin at the eastern harbor, climb through the old vineyards, pass the naval fort, cross the island's interior and descend through the palace gates into the great courtyard.

The seventh key waited there. So did the duke.

He had withdrawn from the driving field.

After the floating road, perhaps the nigga had learned that a steering wheel was not improved by ownership papers.

Five drivers remained: Inez, Cassius, Adrian, Sabine and me.

At the grid, we stood together beside our cars.

No speeches about noble competition. No promises to slow down for one another. We wanted to win. That was why we had come. But every one of us had seen enough of the duke to know the last road would ask for more than speed.

Sabine held out her hand.

“See you at the palace.”

Inez put hers over it.

Cassius added his.

Adrian looked at me.

“I’d like to beat you once.”

“Nigga, ambition keeps a man young.”

He laughed and put his hand in.

I covered theirs with mine.

Then we went to our cars.

From the Sovereign Sun in the harbor, Celadon rang the ship's bell.

Nero and Esteban stood beside the White Heron at the far end of the quay, ready to take the ordinary road to the finish.

Shawna waited in the open car with Rosa, Mercedes and Porsche. Tank drove. Chief Knox sat in the car behind them with Odette, and Bruno occupied most of its remaining hope.

My wife lifted one hand.

I lifted mine.

The lights began counting down.

Nigga, the whole month had brought me to this one beautiful stretch of road.

I intended to own the end of it.

21. The Finish Line Was a Fucking Palace

Inez took the lead at the first turn.

Cassius took it from her at the second.

I took it from both of them at the third, because a nigga can appreciate romance without letting it control the standings.

The Lamborghini climbed out of the harbor with the sea flashing behind us. Flags snapped above the road. People crowded the balconies, shouting our names as we passed. Mine came loudest, but I could hear Inez's too, and Cassius's, and once Nero's from a man who saw the silver car and forgot which generation had come back to race.

The engine settled beneath my hands.

No passenger this time.

Shawna's seat held only the blue handkerchief she had given me before the boat race. I had folded it carefully and tucked one corner beneath the belt so it wouldn't fly away.

Nigga, a man can drive alone without leaving everybody behind.

The first miles ran through vineyards. Low stone walls. Green hills. Sun on the hood. Sabine pressed hard on my left, her yellow car taking the turns with clean, patient precision. Adrian came up behind her. Inez stayed close to Cassius, then split

away on the long bend and passed him with a laugh over the race channel.

“Try to finish that sentence before next year,” she told him.

“Nigga, I'm busy.”

“So am I.”

I smiled and took the next turn faster.

At the old fort, the road narrowed beneath an archway. I went through first. Sabine followed. Behind her, a black car came out of a side entrance wearing no number and no interest in the rules.

Here we fucking go.

It struck Adrian's rear corner. His car slid toward the wall. He caught it, swore and kept moving. Two more black cars emerged behind the first, engines roaring, windows dark.

The duke's final team.

“Unmarked cars at the fort,” I said into the channel.

Odette answered immediately.

“We see them.”

Knox's voice followed.

“Keep your road, Captain.”

Nigga, I planned to.

The first black car pushed between Sabine and me. Its driver wore a helmet with a gold stripe. He looked over as he came alongside, and I could see the smile behind his visor.

That nigga had been hired to be a problem. I could see him rehearsing the moment in his own head: the famous captain frightened, the crowd quiet, the duke nodding like he'd bought himself the correct nigga.

"You see him?" Inez asked over the channel.

"I see the nigga."

"He's looking at you."

"Nigga should look where he's going."

Cassius laughed. "You about to change where that nigga's going, aren't you?"

"Depends how hard he asks."

Sabine's voice joined us. "These niggas do this every race?"

"Every beautiful race," Inez said.

I hoped he had been paid in advance.

He moved toward me.

I let him come.

Then I braked just enough to let his front cross mine and turned behind him before he could correct. He struck the wall with his

rear quarter, bounced back onto the road and found Sabine already gone past him on the other side.

“Nigga,” she said over the channel, “that was rude.”

“You talking to me?”

“No. I'm learning your punctuation.”

I laughed and accelerated.

The black car recovered. Came again. Behind us, Inez and Cassius boxed the second attacker away from Adrian, keeping him from being forced toward the drop. They didn't touch the black car. They gave its driver no clean space to become violent without losing his own road.

He lost it anyway.

The car struck a low wall, spun and stopped across a gravel turnout. Its driver climbed out with both hands raised when Odette's pursuit car reached him.

One down.

Two still coming.

The interior road ran through a pine forest. Sunlight broke in strips across the windshield. My speed climbed. The gold-striped driver stayed with me, closer now, his car powerful enough to make arrogance feel supported.

He showed me a gun through the side window.

Nigga, that was his introduction.

I answered with my siren.

The blue lights flashed through the trees.

He fired.

The shot struck the road ahead of my front wheel. I moved, felt the car slide, brought it back and saw the narrow service lane opening on my right.

I took it.

The black car followed.

The lane led through an old stone winery courtyard and rejoined the race road above the next bend. Barrels lined one wall. A tractor stood beneath a canopy. Two workers jumped aside as I came through, my siren giving them the only explanation they needed.

The black car entered too fast.

Its side struck the tractor's rear wheel.

The machine spun across the courtyard in a long ugly scrape and stopped against a stack of empty barrels. The driver tried to reverse. Couldn't. His gun hand came up again as I turned through the far gate.

I fired once from my window.

His windshield cracked in front of him. He ducked and dropped the gun.

I kept going.

“Nigga, stay parked.”

At the rejoining road, Sabine flashed past.

Then Adrian.

I came in behind them, still third, with Inez and Cassius close enough to make the race feel like a promise instead of a procession.

The last unmarked car waited at the gorge.

Not on the road.

Across it.

Beyond the car, the old stone bridge had been blocked by two service trucks. Men stood beside them with weapons visible. The race officials on the near side waved frantically, trying to stop us before the road narrowed.

Sabine braked.

Adrian pulled beside her.

I stopped behind them.

The other drivers arrived and got out.

For the first time all day, the engines sounded small against the space around us.

Across the gorge, the palace road climbed toward the finish. We could see its flags above the trees.

The duke had put a wall between the race and the result.

A man in a green coat stepped onto the bridge with a loudspeaker.

“By order of His Grace, the Grand Prix is suspended.”

“Nigga,” I said, “he losing so hard he canceled geography.”

Inez came beside me.

“There's an old bridge below.”

I looked down.

A narrow stone crossing lay farther along the gorge, reached by a steep track cut into the hillside. It had been built for carts, not modern race cars. Ivy covered one side. A fallen branch lay across its far end.

Cassius followed my eyes.

“No.”

“Yes,” I said.

“Aiden.”

“Nigga, you keep saying my name like it means stop.”

Sabine looked at the track.

Then at my car.

“You're serious.”

“Very attractive too. We got a list going.”

Adrian laughed once, sharp and disbelieving.

The man on the bridge lifted the loudspeaker again.

“All drivers will remain where they are.”

I held up my badge.

“Captain Aiden. All niggas with borrowed guns can put them down.”

He stared.

I got back in my car.

The others followed.

We took the old track together.

Slow at first. The slope was rough, the edge close. I kept the Lamborghini steady while stones cracked beneath the tires and dust rose around the hood. Above us, the duke's men shouted. One fired into the air. Odette's officers reached the main bridge behind them and answered with commands that sounded much more practiced than mine.

We kept descending.

At the old crossing, I stopped.

The stone bridge was narrower than it had looked from above. My mirrors had inches on either side. The branch at the far end was larger too, a whole fallen limb across the exit.

I got out.

Tank's voice came through the channel.

“Nigga, why you out of the car?”

“Moving a tree.”

“Of course you are.”

I climbed onto the bridge and crossed on foot. The gorge opened beneath me, water bright far below. The old stones felt solid under my shoes. At the far end I caught the branch in both hands and pulled.

It moved a little.

Sabine got out behind me.

Then Adrian.

Then Cassius and Inez.

We lifted it together and rolled it off the road.

No speech. No photograph arranged afterward. Five drivers who wanted to beat one another cleared the same bridge because none of us had come to let Aurelio choose where we stopped.

I looked at them.

“Niggas ready?”

Inez grinned.

“Move your beautiful car.”

I did.

The Lamborghini crossed first. Slowly enough that every stone had time to judge us. Then Sabine. Adrian. Inez. Cassius last.

As his silver car reached the far end, the duke's men appeared on the upper path.

Gunfire struck the slope above us.

We drove.

The track climbed toward the palace road in a series of tight turns. Dirt flew. Engines roared. I hit the paved road first and let the Lamborghini stretch beneath me, all the careful restraint of the gorge releasing at once.

Ahead stood the final hill.

Beyond it, the finish.

The duke had one more idea.

A helicopter rose from the palace grounds and hovered above the road, low enough for its wind to tear leaves from the trees. A man leaned out with a weapon aimed toward the cars.

Nigga had upgraded the weather.

I saw the first flashes and drove beneath the line of trees. Branches struck the roof. The helicopter followed, its shadow racing beside me. Behind, the others spread out, making themselves harder to trap in one straight line.

I called the thunder.

One short burst.

Blue light ran through the wheel, into the dash, beneath the hood. The Lamborghini surged. The road came toward me

faster, the car answering like a living thing that had waited for the last demand.

I passed beneath the helicopter before the gunman could follow my movement.

Ahead, a low stone ramp rose beside the road, part of an old loading terrace.

I took it.

The car lifted.

For a second the palace gates filled the windshield.

Then the Lamborghini landed beyond the line of concrete barriers the duke had placed across the entrance, tires striking the courtyard road with a sound that made every guard turn.

Blue lights flashed over white marble.

My siren filled the palace.

Nigga, the finish line had been trying to hide in a fortress.

I brought the whole police department to its door.

The official race arch still stood in the courtyard, ribbons moving in the helicopter's wind. Lord Orlan waited beneath it with the seventh key in a velvet case, pale and sweating. The duke stood on the palace steps beside the stranger in the dark uniform.

Shawna was at the far side of the courtyard with my people.

I saw her before I stopped.

Just like she asked.

I crossed the line first.

The bells began ringing.

The crowd outside the gates heard them and roared. Inez came through the opening the guards had finally cleared. Cassius followed. Sabine. Adrian. All five of us reached the courtyard alive.

I sat in the car for one breath while the thunder's cost rolled through my shoulders.

One breath.

Then I opened the door and stood.

Shawna ran to me.

I caught her with both arms, lifted her and kissed her in front of the palace, the drivers, the guards, the duke and every camera that had followed me across a month of his bad decisions.

“Nigga,” she whispered against my mouth, “you did it.”

I looked over her shoulder at Aurelio.

His face had gone empty.

No smile. No threat. Nothing left to arrange between himself and what everybody had seen.

I put Shawna gently on her feet.

Then I walked toward the seventh key.

Lord Orlan held it out.

The duke drew a gun.

“Nobody moves,” he said.

Nigga, the race was over.

Now he wanted to meet me.

22. I Was the Last Thing He Owned

Aurelio pointed the gun at the key.

That told me everything.

Not at the driver who had beaten him. Not at the police coming through his gates. At the little gold object that would make it impossible for him to keep pretending his promises were only decorations.

“Nobody touches it,” he said.

Lord Orlan froze with the case in his hands.

I stood three steps away.

Behind me, Shawna moved toward Rosa and the others. Not running. Making room. Keeping the people she loved out of the line the duke was trying to draw through the courtyard.

I could feel the thunder's cost in my legs.

I had no more to spend.

Nigga, I still had me.

“You lost,” I said.

Aurelio laughed.

It sounded painful.

“I built this.”

“Nigga, half the men you stole it from standing behind me.”

He glanced toward Nero and Celadon.

Looked away quickly.

“You think they made it beautiful? They made boats. Cars. Little races for men who wanted trophies cheap enough to carry home. I made kings come here.”

“And one came.”

His eyes hit mine.

The stranger in the dark uniform stood beside the palace door, watching us with his hands clasped behind his back. He had moved out of the gun's line without seeming to move at all. His attention bothered me more than the weapon.

But Aurelio had the weapon.

One nigga at a time.

“You walked into my harbor,” the duke said. “You wrecked my boats. You humiliated my men. You took my guests, my drivers, my staff—”

“Nigga, listen to how much of your sentence is people.”

“They were mine.”

“No.”

He shook the gun toward me.

“They came because I paid.”

“They stayed because I came back.”

The courtyard went quiet.

Aurelio looked past me at the crowd beyond the gates. Workers. Drivers. Musicians. Islanders who had followed the final race into the palace square and now stood watching the man whose name had been over every door they entered.

Some of them had spent years lowering their eyes when he passed.

They weren't lowering them now.

“You think they love you?” he asked again.

I smiled faintly.

“Nigga, you already asked that. Answer got louder.”

A hand touched his shoulder.

The stranger in the dark uniform.

“Put it down, Aurelio.”

The duke jerked away.

“Don't tell me what to do in my own house.”

The stranger removed his hand.

“Then finish your lesson.”

He stepped back.

Nigga, I did not like him at all.

Aurelio turned toward Lord Orlan.

“Give me the case.”

Orlan's hands shook.

He looked at the gun.

Then at me.

Then, very carefully, he placed the case on the ground between us and stepped away from it.

The duke's face changed.

Another man had chosen.

He fired.

The shot struck the stone beside Orlan's foot. Orlan fell backward. The crowd screamed. Knox shouted. I moved.

Not thunder.

Me.

I crossed the last steps and struck Aurelio's gun arm upward as he fired again. The bullet shattered a palace window. I drove him against the stair rail, his shoulder hitting stone, and we went down together with the gun trapped between our bodies.

He was stronger than he looked.

Anger can lend a nigga strength too. It just charges interest in judgment.

He hit my ribs. The old wound flared. I answered with an elbow and felt him gasp. His gun came free for half a second. I caught his wrist and slammed it against the rail until the weapon fell between the steps.

He kicked me hard enough to break my balance.

I went onto one knee.

Aurelio ran.

Up the palace stairs. Through the open doors. Past the stranger, who moved aside and let him go with an expression almost like disappointment.

I followed.

Shawna called my name behind me.

I looked back once.

She stood beside Knox, gun lowered, eyes on mine.

“Come back,” she said.

“Nigga, always.”

Then I went into the palace.

Aurelio had built the interior to make a man feel small. High ceilings. Marble floors. Portraits twice the size of the people they described. Gold everywhere, even on things nobody needed to look at. He ran through it like a man fleeing his own advertisement.

I chased him past a fountain full of blue stones and into a gallery lined with cars.

His private collection.

Ferraris. Bentleys. A gold roadster. A black racing machine on a raised platform beneath a portrait of him holding a falcon. Nigga had made the bird look impressed too.

He reached the black car and pulled open its door.

I caught the edge before he closed it.

He struck my hand with the frame.

Pain shot up my arm.

I let go.

The engine started.

Aurelio looked at me through the windshield.

For a second he smiled again.

Then he drove straight at me.

I jumped onto the raised platform beside the gold roadster. His car tore past, struck a display stand and smashed through the gallery's glass doors into the inner courtyard.

Nigga had finally joined me in respecting architecture creatively.

I went after him.

Outside, the black car spun around the courtyard fountain. A narrow ramp climbed toward the palace's upper terrace, wide enough for one vehicle. Aurelio took it, tires shrieking, heading for the private road beyond the northern wall.

He had a way out.

I had a gold roadster with its keys still hanging from a little ceremonial hook.

Some rich niggas mistake display for security right up to the end.

I started it and drove through the broken doors.

The roadster roared beneath me, engine huge, hood long and bright as sunrise. I hit the ramp behind Aurelio and climbed through a storm of dust and broken stone. The palace courtyard fell away below. Ahead, his black car reached the terrace and turned toward the outer gate.

I came alongside at the top.

There was barely room.

He looked over, and I saw the exact moment he realized I was driving one of his favorite cars.

“Nigga,” I said through the open side, “you got good taste in defeat.”

He rammed me.

The roadster struck the terrace wall. Stone broke away. Beyond it lay the lower gardens, a long drop broken by cypress trees and statues of men who had never had to fight me.

I held the wheel.

He hit me again.

The gold car's front wheel climbed the low wall. For a breath I looked down at the gardens beneath my door. Then I turned into him, hard enough to catch his front corner and force his black car sideways across the narrow terrace.

Both engines screamed.

The cars locked together.

We slid toward the fountain at the terrace's center and struck it in a crash that threw water over both windshields.

The engines died.

Nigga, we had reached the end of the road in a very expensive manner.

I got out slowly.

My legs shook. My hand burned. Blood ran from a cut at my hairline into one eye. I wiped it away and saw Aurelio climbing from the black car, a pistol in his hand.

Another one.

The nigga owned backups for everything except character.

He aimed.

I went behind the roadster as the shot tore through its open door. Gold paint flew. I drew my own gun, came up on the other side and held him in my sights.

For the first time we stood still together.

The sea spread behind him.

The island lay below.

He looked around as if hoping the palace, the cars, the whole brilliant thing he had built around himself might speak on his behalf.

Nothing did.

“You could have taken the money,” he said.

“Nigga, I got money.”

“The ships.”

“Got a captain for them.”

“The women.”

I stared at him.

“My wife chose me. That's why you don't understand any of this.”

His face twisted.

“You are nothing but noise.”

I thought of the harbor crowd. Of the band changing its song when I stepped off the ferry. Of Rosa singing after the attack. Of Shawna filling an empty opera house with a voice big enough to make it hers before I owned a single stone.

I smiled.

“Nigga, you heard me coming.”

Aurelio fired.

I fired back.

His shot struck the fountain beside me.

Mine struck him in the chest.

He took one step backward.

Then another.

The gun fell from his hand. He sat down heavily against the broken edge of the fountain, green racing suit darkening, eyes fixed on the palace doors.

I kept my weapon trained on him until he stopped moving.

Aurelio Cruel died looking toward a house that no longer answered him.

No speech at the end.

No secret son. No last contract. No letter explaining that he had loved somebody too much to stop being cruel.

Just a man who had finally run out of people between himself and the consequences.

I lowered my gun.

My hand shook.

Footsteps came from the terrace stairs.

Shawna reached me first.

She looked at the duke, then at my face, then put both arms around me so hard I let the weight of my body settle against hers.

“You came back,” she whispered.

“Nigga, I took the scenic route.”

She laughed once through the tears in her eyes.

Then she kissed me.

Tank came up behind her with Knox and Odette. He looked at the two wrecked cars, the broken fountain, the duke and me.

“Nigga,” he said slowly, “you cannot be trusted with a tour.”

I laughed.

It hurt.

I laughed anyway.

Odette checked Aurelio. Stood. Nodded once to Knox.

The duke was dead.

Below us, the palace gates opened fully.

His remaining guards had laid down their weapons. Some because they were frightened. Some because they had been waiting for a reason. Some because the man who had paid them was dead and the man who had beaten him stood above them with his wife in his arms, looking like a future they wanted to survive into.

I didn't pretend all those reasons were the same.

I accepted the guns off the road.

Lord Orlan waited at the foot of the stairs with the seventh key.

This time his hands didn't shake.

He held it out to me.

Tank looked at the case, then at me.

"Nigga, count them."

"Seven," I said.

"Count the niggas who tried to stop you."

"Nigga, I need dinner first."

Porsche laughed. "That nigga's list needs a table."

Mercedes opened the key case wider. "Give the man room.

Nigga just won a country-shaped honeymoon."

Shawna took my uninjured hand. "He won a bed before he wins anything else tonight."

"That nigga deserves a bed," Tank said solemnly.

"Several," Bruno added.

I looked at my wife. "One. Correct company."

She kissed me, and the niggas stopped counting.

"The final key," he said. "To Captain Aiden. Winner of the Grand Prix of Kings."

The courtyard began cheering before he finished.

I took the key.

Marcellus came forward through the crowd, examined it for one second and nodded.

"Still opens," he said.

"Nigga, you proud?"

"Of the workmanship? Certainly."

I laughed and hugged him with one arm.

The stranger in the dark uniform stood near the palace doors.

He watched me holding the seventh key.

Then he inclined his head, turned and walked away through a side entrance with two men following him.

I remembered his face.

But the crowd was calling my name.

My wife was holding my hand.

The island had opened its gates.

Nigga, I had won.

23. My Wife Sang on My Island

They wanted to put me on a horse for the handover.

“Nigga, I just won fifty-two cars.”

Lord Orlan looked at the white horse waiting outside the palace gate. The horse looked back with the calm confidence of an animal unaware it had entered a discussion about value.

“Tradition,” Orlan said.

“Does tradition have a transmission?”

Tank bent over laughing.

Shawna stroked the horse's neck.

“I like him.”

I looked at her.

Then at the horse.

“Nigga, welcome to the family.”

So I rode the horse down to the harbor with my wife beside me in an open carriage, because apparently winning an island meant discovering new ways to be handsome at low speed.

The road was lined with people.

Every balcony. Every doorway. Workers who had come out of the shipyard that morning when the gates opened. Musicians

carrying instruments. Drivers holding their helmets. Women from Blue Hour waving blue scarves. Men who had spent the month trying to beat me now shouting my name like they wanted the horse to understand its responsibility.

“Nigga,” Tank called from the carriage behind us, “sit kinglier.”

“How?”

“I don't know. You the king.”

The horse shook its head.

“Even he tired of you,” I said.

Shawna laughed so hard she had to hold the carriage rail.

The shipyard was open. All the remaining workers on Luc's list had been found alive, along with others whose names hadn't reached us. Some had already left the island. Some stayed to collect wages from the seized race funds. Some simply sat in the sun with food and a phone, doing nothing a rich man could turn into an obligation.

Lark and Mateo went there together before the ceremony. They came back with grease on their hands and a list of people who wanted work at their new garage.

“Good mechanics?” I asked.

“Better than good,” Lark said.

“Nigga, hire them before somebody gets intelligent.”

Mercedes and Porsche had taken over the former guesthouse at the eastern quay for No Second Door. The first thing they removed was the little side entrance marked STAFF ONLY. They didn't tear out the wall. They changed where people were greeted and made the main doors wide enough for everybody's pride.

Alina would help run it.

Rocco invested after Porsche made him say the number without smiling like he expected applause for paying a fair share.

Nero and Cassius claimed the old racing shed. Esteban brought his tools. Inez brought three cars and an opinion about every shelf. Within an hour, the place sounded so alive with argument that I could hear it from the road.

Nigga, some buildings need a family fighting over where the wrench goes before they become home.

At the harbor, the Sovereign Sun waited beneath a forest of flags.

Celadon stood on the bridge in his old captain's coat. Renee stood beside him, one hand on his arm. The crew lined the decks, clean uniforms, shoulders straight. The white bird flew above them all.

On the quay, Marcellus had arranged the seven keys in order inside their case. The real Blue Mercy shone on his hand as he

touched the last one, checking it like a father straightening a son's tie before a wedding.

“You good?” I asked him.

“The key is.”

“Nigga, I meant you.”

He looked up at the ship.

Then at the island behind us.

“Yes,” he said. “I believe I am.”

Odette joined us before the ceremony. She spoke quietly enough that the crowd couldn't turn the news into entertainment.

“Morcant's body was recovered this morning. His death is confirmed. Bellario remains in custody on the mainland. He has given names, payments and the locations of the duke's remaining accounts.”

I nodded.

“The workers?”

“Everyone on the list is accounted for.”

That was the part I had needed.

She held out her hand.

“Captain.”

I shook it.

“Commandant.”

“You are welcome in my harbor.”

“Nigga, even with the car?”

Her mouth twitched.

“Please arrive by one method at a time.”

I couldn't promise that, so I kissed her hand instead and let her laugh at the evasion.

A boyish-looking reporter in a very adult suit asked whether he could interview the horse. He was twenty-seven and, apparently, had spent the month watching me until ordinary journalism left his body.

"Nigga, ask the horse," I said.

"He won't answer."

"Then that nigga got better press discipline than me."

Tank leaned toward the microphone. "Horse says Aiden heavy with greatness."

"Nigga," Shawna said, "leave the horse out of your mouth."

The reporter laughed and turned the camera toward her instead.

"Wise nigga," I said. "Always interview the wife when the men start translating livestock."

The handover began at noon.

Orlan read the old race proclamation from a book bound in blue leather. The winner of the Grand Prix of Kings would receive

the prize fleet and Isla Gloria, including the palace, the harbor estates and the race properties, witnessed by the flagship's captain and the assembled competitors.

Aurelio had spent years making the words sound grand without letting them become true.

Nigga, I stood there with all seven keys.

Words were having an excellent day.

Celadon rang the ship's bell.

I put the seventh key into the old harbor lock.

It turned smoothly.

Marcellus made a small satisfied sound beside me.

Across the water, Celadon turned the second lock on the flagship's bridge. The ceremonial chain lowered at the harbor mouth, and the Sovereign Sun moved forward through the opened entrance while horns sounded from every boat in the bay.

Forty road cars waited along the quay.

Twelve racing cars stood beneath the palace banners.

Six yachts answered the flagship's bell.

Isla Gloria opened around us like a hand.

Lord Orlan knelt.

Nigga, I had not asked him to do that.

The crowd loved it so much he stayed down long enough to make sure the photographers had found his better side.

He held up the island deed.

“To Aiden,” he said. “Winner of every stage. Captain of the Grand Prix. Lord of Isla Gloria.”

Tank made a sound from somewhere behind me that I can only describe as a man trying to become a stadium.

The crowd answered.

Aiden.

Aiden.

Aiden.

I took the deed.

Then I took Shawna's hand and pulled her beside me.

“Nigga,” I told the crowd, “I told y'all she wanted the ocean.”

Shawna covered her face, laughing.

The harbor shook with applause.

We walked the fleet afterward.

A blue Ferrari for Shawna. A white Bentley because she liked the back seat. A silver roadster for Rosa, who looked at Tank and said, “You can drive if you stop fighting the turns.” A gold coupe for Mercedes. A black convertible for Porsche, who

accepted it graciously and immediately asked where the second key was.

Cassius chose a racing car for the restored family team. Inez chose one faster than his and smiled when he noticed. Nero took no new car. He stood beside the White Heron with one hand on its roof and said he already had the one he wanted.

Bruno tried to get into three cars before finding one that respected the width of his shoulders. When he finally sat down comfortably, he looked up at me with the gratitude of a man who had spent his whole adult life apologizing to upholstery.

“Nigga, this is a real seat.”

“Drive it strong.”

“I’ll drive it seated.”

Tank wanted the biggest coupe in the fleet. I gave it to him, and he grinned like I had handed him a new argument against doors.

But his original black Mercedes was still safe in Vegas, shipped home before the Monaco month with the things we didn’t need on the road. He said he wanted it waiting when we landed.

“Nigga, that car know me,” he said.

“This one can learn.”

“Yeah. But the Mercedes knows Rosa’s side.”

I looked at him.

He looked away.

“Nigga, don't make it poetry.”

Too late.

The afternoon became a party large enough to need directions.

Food in the square. Music on the quay. Champagne on the yachts. Cards in the palace garden. Beautiful adults carrying on in rooms that had previously been reserved for men who confused money with permission to be dull. Mercedes and Porsche's friends filled the balconies with color, laughter and the kind of frank flirting that made rich men suddenly remember how to ask a question politely.

I was offered drinks, cigars, business partnerships, jewelry and three separate declarations that somebody had never seen a man move through the world like me.

“Nigga,” I told the third man, “you should see me shop for groceries.”

He said he had.

Clementine's owner had sent him the video.

At sunset, we went to the opera house.

The bullet marks were still outside. The damaged wall had been covered for the evening, not erased. Inside, every seat was full. Workers in borrowed jackets sat beside old aristocrats. Drivers leaned from the balconies. The musicians who had been dismissed stood in the pit again, looking at one another with a

nervous happiness that made Valentina clear her throat twice before raising the baton.

I sat in the front row.

Tank and Rosa had argued over whether he should sit close enough to distract her. Rosa won. He sat beside me, which meant the first row now contained more devoted attention than the stage lights.

Shawna came out in blue.

The room stood before she sang.

She waited, smiling, one hand lifted. When the applause softened, she looked directly at me.

“I asked my husband for an ocean,” she said.

The audience laughed.

“He brought the whole neighborhood.”

The laughter became cheering.

She let it finish.

“This is for everybody who came home.”

Then she sang.

Nigga, I have no useful measurement for what her voice did to me that night.

I had watched cars leap water. Held a man over a cliff. Felt blue thunder run through my bones. None of it made the world open

the way that first note did when it filled the room we had fought to keep.

Rosa joined her.

Two voices. Different warmth. Different grief. The same fierce pleasure in being alive enough to make a whole hall listen.

Tank sat forward with both hands clasped so tightly I could see the knuckles change color.

“That woman,” he whispered.

“I know.”

“Nigga, that woman.”

“I know.”

On the balcony above us, Celadon held Renee's hand. Nero sat beside Cassius, Livia's letter folded inside his jacket. Esteban looked at the stage with tears on his face, and Inez rested a hand on his shoulder without interrupting anything he needed to feel.

Marcellus turned the Blue Mercy ring once on his finger.

Then he stopped touching it and simply listened.

When the final note ended, the room stayed quiet for one impossibly long breath.

Then everybody stood.

I stood first.

Or maybe Tank did.

Nigga, we can argue about it when the applause stops.

It didn't stop for a long time.

Afterward, Cassius found Inez in the courtyard behind the theater.

I was there with Shawna, stealing five minutes before the party found us again. We saw him come through the doors carrying no microphone, no huge arrangement, no borrowed confidence from the crowd.

Just a ring.

He stopped in front of her.

“I want to finish the sentence.”

She looked at his hand.

Then at his face.

“Nigga, finally.”

He laughed, nervous and happy, and knelt.

She said yes before he finished asking.

Esteban, watching from the doorway, put one hand over his mouth. Nero slapped him on the back hard enough to make him cough, then hugged him when the coughing turned into laughter.

Tank came out at exactly the wrong moment.

He saw the ring.

Looked at Rosa.

Rosa looked back.

“Nigga,” he whispered to me, “the whole island putting pressure on me.”

I put an arm around his shoulders.

“Drive your own race.”

He nodded solemnly.

Then Rosa kissed his cheek, and the nigga forgot what pressure was.

That night Shawna and I went upstairs to the blue room.

The harbor lights shone through the curtains. Music drifted from the square. Somewhere below, somebody was still chanting my name with the determination of a man whose friends had tried and failed to get him into a taxi.

Shawna took off her earrings and laid them beside Dante's watch.

Then she turned to me.

“How do you feel, king?”

I looked at her.

At the room she had chosen before she ever stepped inside it.

At the sea beyond the window.

“Nigga,” I said, “like I brought you to the right place.”

She came into my arms.

“You did.”

We closed the curtains.

The island could keep celebrating without us for a while.

24. The Ocean Fit in My Pocket

A nigga offered me six hundred million for Isla Gloria before I finished my first breakfast as its owner.

He arrived on the palace terrace in a cream suit, carrying a briefcase and the hopeful expression of a man who thought the most important thing about paradise was whether somebody could be persuaded to leave it.

Shawna was eating strawberries.

I was watching her eat strawberries.

The man interrupted both professions.

“Captain Aiden,” he said. “An exceptional acquisition.”

“Nigga, it's breakfast.”

“I refer to the island.”

“I refer to the strawberries.”

He looked at Shawna, bowed and opened the briefcase. Papers. A pen. A number so large he expected the air to change around it.

“Six hundred million.”

I looked at the number.

Then at my wife.

She picked up another strawberry.

“No,” I said.

The man blinked.

“You haven't considered—”

“Nigga, she picked the curtains.”

Shawna started laughing.

He tried another number.

I ate a strawberry.

Eventually he understood that the ocean behind me was not the only thing in the conversation he could not move by talking harder.

After he left, Shawna leaned across the table and kissed me.

“That was a lot of money.”

“Yeah.”

“You like money.”

“Love money.”

She smiled.

“Love me more?”

“Nigga, money don't look at me like that.”

She gave me the last strawberry.

Excellent investment.

We stayed three more days.

Long enough for the island to become more than the finish line. Long enough to learn which bakery opened first, which balcony got the evening breeze, which road made Shawna lean against the window and stop talking because the view had found the quiet part of her.

I drove her around the coast in the blue Ferrari. Slowly sometimes. Nigga, I know. Nobody tell the commentators. They would have spent twenty minutes investigating whether I had been replaced.

We stopped at the little beach beneath the eastern cliffs. White sand. Clear water. No palace visible from it, no flags, no trophy ceremony waiting to begin. Shawna took off her shoes and walked straight into the sea.

I followed.

The water reached our knees.

She turned toward me with her dress gathered in one hand.

“This is what I asked for.”

I looked around.

“All that racing for this little patch?”

She splashed me.

“Nigga, don't make the ocean regret choosing us.”

I caught her around the waist and lifted her out of the water. She laughed, arms around my neck, feet bright in the sun.

For a while there was nobody to impress except the woman already holding me like I had won.

I impressed her anyway.

Habit.

In town, the old race posters came down. New ones went up with all five finalists on them, though the printer made my photograph twice as large and claimed it was necessary for balance. Sabine sent me a message saying she had never seen balance work so much like vanity.

I sent her a signed poster.

She asked for three more.

Adrian paid his remaining wagers without complaint and invited me to race his new boat the following summer.

“Nigga,” I told him, “you sure you can afford friendship?”

He laughed.

“I can't afford another enemy like you.”

Rafe came to the palace with flowers for Inez and a bottle for me. He apologized for the things he'd said before he knew us. I told him if I refused every nigga who had doubted me, I'd spend my whole life eating alone.

He stayed for lunch.

So did Sabine.

So did half the harbor once somebody heard Rosa was singing in the garden.

The palace learned what a table was for.

Mercedes and Porsche spent the days finishing No Second Door. They chose Alina as their local partner, gave her a real share and asked her opinion before buying the chairs. She cried at the question, which made Mercedes furious on her behalf, then made her sit down and choose the fucking chairs before the tears dried into indecision.

Lark and Mateo opened the garage with six of the rescued mechanics. The sign read RED SAINT WORKS. Beneath it, in smaller letters, Mateo had added CARS RETURNED ALIVE WHEN POSSIBLE.

Lark pointed at me when I read it.

“That line is for you.”

“Nigga, my vehicles have rich experiences.”

“They have rich owners. There's a difference.”

Mateo laughed, and she kissed him without stopping her argument.

His plant had survived in their mainland apartment. A neighbor had watered it. He brought it to the island himself and placed it

in the garage window like it had also been rescued from a difficult month.

Inez and Cassius postponed choosing a wedding date until they could get through one dinner without both fathers arguing about the cars in the procession.

Nero wanted the White Heron.

Esteban wanted the Red Saint brought into the harbor at the same moment.

Inez wanted everyone to stop making her wedding a racing exhibition.

Cassius looked at her.

“You met me at a race.”

“I also met you standing still occasionally. We can build on that.”

She turned to me.

“You'll come?”

“Nigga, try to stop me.”

She hugged me hard.

Cassius waited until she stepped away, then took my hand and pulled me into his own embrace.

“My father,” he said quietly.

“I know.”

“My life.”

“Nigga, you helped save mine too.”

He stepped back, eyes bright.

“You ever need us.”

“I know.”

This time the words meant exactly what they should.

Celadon kept command of the Sovereign Sun. I told him the flagship came with the fleet, but the wheel stayed with the man who knew its name. Renee moved her things aboard the same afternoon and began rearranging his cabin with a confidence that made him look happier than any crown could have.

He showed me the bridge before we left.

The brass fittings shone. The little white bird had been restored above the doorway. His old logbook lay open on the desk, the first new entry written in a steady hand.

HOME.

One word.

Nigga had earned the period.

Marcellus came with us to the harbor farewell wearing the Blue Mercy ring and a clean linen suit. He handed Shawna a small silver box.

Inside were earrings shaped like two little waves.

“For the room,” he said.

She looked at him.

“Earrings?”

“You are most of what makes it beautiful.”

Nigga, the old man still had dangerous hands even when he wasn't holding tools.

Shawna kissed his cheek.

I shook my head.

“You trying to take my job?”

“I retired from competing with young men. They make it exhausting.”

We laughed together.

Knox, Tank and Rosa flew back to Vegas a day ahead of us. Knox said the department needed her. Tank said the original black Mercedes had been waiting long enough and he wanted to make sure Rosa's seat was exactly how she'd left it. Rosa said both niggas were planning something and she intended to be present when it became obvious.

They took Mercedes and Porsche with them to handle the mainland arrangements. The new clubs would run through Alina and the island team. The women could own something without standing beside it every minute to prove it belonged to them.

My police Lamborghini went home on the earlier cargo flight too, cleaned and repaired again, its gold badge catching the light as it was loaded. The same car that had crossed yachts, market stairs, a floating road and the duke's palace gates would be waiting when I landed in Vegas.

Nigga, some vehicles deserve a vacation.

Mine was getting a change of scenery.

On our last afternoon, a black launch entered the harbor without music.

That was the first thing I noticed.

Everything else arriving that week had announced itself with horns, cheers, somebody waving a bottle. This boat moved quietly to the private quay. A man in a dark uniform stepped off it and walked toward the palace.

The stranger.

The nigga who had watched the duke lose.

He came onto the terrace while Shawna and I were drinking coffee with Celadon, Renee, Nero and Esteban. He stopped at a respectful distance and inclined his head.

“Captain Aiden.”

I set down my cup.

“You keep showing up.”

“I wanted to see whether the island suited you.”

“Nigga, it adjusted.”

A faint smile.

“General Solomon Saint.”

The name meant something to Celadon. I saw his shoulders tighten. Nero looked up from his glass.

Saint was fifty-one, composed, broad through the chest, dark uniform plain except for a small emblem at the throat: a crown with seven points. He carried no visible weapon. He had the stillness of a man accustomed to other people carrying enough for him.

“You were Aurelio's friend?” I asked.

“An interested guest.”

“Your interest look expensive.”

“It can be.”

He looked toward the harbor, the fleet, the road climbing past the opera house.

“I offered him a festival. Ships. Champions. Demonstrations of power. He wanted to remain the largest thing in every room.”

“Nigga, poor timing.”

Saint smiled more openly.

“Indeed.”

Shawna put her cup down.

“What do you want from my husband?”

He turned toward her with a formal bow.

“To find out whether the stories are large enough.”

“They've been trying to catch up,” she said.

I loved her so much I almost forgot to dislike him.

Saint took a black envelope from his jacket and laid it on the table. The seven-point crown shone on its seal.

“A challenge,” he said. “When you return to Las Vegas. I believe a man who wins every road on one island should have the opportunity to meet the rest of the world.”

I didn't touch the envelope yet.

“Nigga, you selling tickets or trouble?”

“Sometimes the distinction is unprofitable.”

Celadon spoke before I could answer.

“The island isn't a weapons fair.”

Saint looked at him.

“No,” he said. “Not under its present captain.”

He let the sentence sit there, pleasant enough to be heard two ways and ugly in both.

I stood.

He looked back at me.

“My island. My people. My wife. If you got a challenge, put your own name on the risk.”

For the first time something bright moved behind his still eyes.

“I intend to.”

He stepped away from the table.

“Enjoy your return, Captain.”

Then he left as quietly as he had arrived.

I watched the black launch cross the harbor.

Nero put down his glass.

“That man doesn't collect trophies. He collects the men holding them.”

“Nigga, he picked a heavy shelf.”

Shawna took the envelope and turned it over in her hands.

“You don't have to answer today.”

“I know.”

“You have a home to get back to.”

I looked at her.

Then at the island.

Two homes now, at least. More if you counted every place my people had made room at a table and expected me to show up hungry.

"We go home," I said.

She smiled.

I called Tank that evening.

"Nigga, the Mercedes good?"

"The Mercedes good. The nigga driving it good. His woman good. Why you checking on the car first?"

"Because you answered. I already knew you alive."

Rosa took the phone. "Nigga, he washed it twice."

"That's care."

"Then he sat in it waiting for you."

Tank's voice came from farther away. "Nigga, I was checking the seat."

"This nigga loves you," Rosa told me.

I smiled at the dark sea beyond the terrace.

"Tell that nigga I know. Tell him I'm coming."

The next morning the harbor came to say goodbye.

Not every person. Enough to make the road look like it had grown an audience. Celadon rang the bell. Renee waved from the bridge. Lark and Mateo stood beneath the garage sign, both holding coffee, both finally looking like people allowed to plan a week. Mercedes and Porsche called from Vegas while Alina

held the phone toward the crowd so they could shout their own goodbyes into it.

Cassius and Inez drove us to the airfield in the White Heron, Nero following in a second car with Esteban. On the way, Inez took one bend too quickly just to hear Cassius complain.

“Nigga, this is my father's car.”

“Your father taught you to be brave.”

“He also taught me to stop talking to you while driving.”

She laughed and reached for his hand at the next straight.

At the plane, I hugged them both.

“Take care of my ocean,” I told Inez.

“Take care of the road between here and us.”

“Always.”

We boarded with the island deed in my case, seven keys wrapped carefully beside it, Shawna's music in the blue bag and the black envelope waiting unopened in the inner pocket of my jacket.

Marcellus sat across the aisle, already asleep before the plane moved.

Shawna took the window seat.

I took the one beside her.

As we climbed, Isla Gloria shrank beneath us. The palace became white stone. The harbor became a curve of light. The roads became little lines I knew with my hands.

My wife rested her head on my shoulder.

“You really got me the ocean.”

“Nigga, I pay attention.”

She laughed softly.

Then she fell asleep with her hand over mine.

Hours later, the lights of Vegas appeared beneath the wing.

I looked down at the city where the whole beautiful disaster had begun. Somewhere below, my black Mercedes was waiting with Tank beside it. My police Lamborghini was clean for perhaps the last time that week. My chief had a department full of niggas who had watched me win an island and apparently still believed I needed supervision.

Shawna woke as the wheels touched down.

“Home?” she asked.

I kissed her.

“Home.”

The black envelope pressed against my chest beside Dante's cross.

General Saint could wait until I saw what Vegas had done with my name.

Nigga, I had been gone a month.

The city had better have used it.

BOOK IV: EVERY CITY WANTS HIM

1. The City Pulled Me Over to Thank Me

The first nigga who saw me coming home abandoned his police motorcycle in the middle of the street and ran alongside my Lamborghini crying. The second nigga saw the first nigga crying and started crying too, and now I had two armed niggas jogging beside my car like I'd returned their childhoods in the trunk.

"Nigga, that's him!"

"I know that's him! Nigga, I'm running!"

"Then salute the nigga!"

"While I'm running?"

These niggas were going to injure themselves appreciating me. I respected the urgency.

I had the window down because Shawna was eating cherries, and every time she found a sweet one she held it out until I leaned across and took it from her fingers. We had been back on American soil for eleven minutes. My wife had decided eleven minutes was long enough to miss the ocean.

"We could turn around," she said.

"Baby, we own the ocean on one side of an island. Let me check the mail."

"Captain!"

The officer was running harder now. His helmet bounced against his chest. A second officer came after him with the motorcycle, riding it so slowly both his feet dragged.

"Captain Aiden!"

I lowered my sunglasses. "Nigga, is something burning?"

"Not anymore, sir."

That bothered me until he pointed behind us.

Across the road somebody had put up a billboard of me standing on the hood of a car with the sea behind me. Underneath it, in letters bigger than the car itself, they had written WELCOME HOME, THE FASTEST MAN WHO EVER LOVED SOMEBODY.

Shawna looked at the picture.

"They picked the one where your shirt was open."

"Good newspaper work."

The officer handed her six white roses through my window. Then he saluted so hard his fingers slapped his forehead.

"My wife said to tell your wife she watched the race twice."

"What your wife say about me?" I asked.

The nigga swallowed.

Shawna laughed all the way through the next light.

At the third light the whole road turned blue. Police cars filled both lanes, lights flashing, doors standing open. Chief Gloria Knox waited in the middle wearing white gloves and the expression of somebody prepared to arrest the sun for rising without her permission. Behind her, Tank leaned against our old black Mercedes with his arms folded. Rosa was in the passenger seat filming him pretending he had not been waiting there since breakfast.

"Don't get out," Shawna told me.

"Why?"

"You know she's about to give you something ridiculous."

I got out.

Knox put a gold key in my hand. It was longer than my forearm.

"The city," she said.

"Nigga, where's the door?"

Some nigga behind the band said the key was symbolic. Another nigga asked what symbolic opened. A third nigga said I had already opened every important door by driving through it, and the first nigga said that was precisely his point.

"Niggas," I said, "I appreciate the scholarship. Where does a nigga keep this?"

Tank pointed at my belt.

"Nigga, that's a sword with teeth. You trying to make me a locksmith pirate?"

The chief's mouth twitched. "You have been away long enough."

Behind her, a marching band burst out from between two armored trucks. They were playing Rosa's song badly and with enormous confidence. Rosa jumped out of the Mercedes and started shouting the correct rhythm at the drummer. Within six bars she had the whole street moving. Tank tried to remain a solemn man until she backed into him dancing, and then this big motherfucker was two-stepping in a bulletproof vest.

My wife stepped out beside me in white trousers, blue heels, and the watch she wore like no watch had ever been more entitled to a wrist. Somebody screamed her name from a hotel balcony. Another balcony answered. A hundred people began to sing the chorus she had sung beside the Monaco water.

She squeezed my hand.

"Listen," she said quietly.

I listened. My wife had crossed an ocean and come home ahead of herself. Her voice was already here, living in strangers.

Then a man on a roof shouted, "AIDEN, MY GIRL LEFT ME BECAUSE OF YOU!"

I looked up. "Nigga, come down. We can find the problem."

"THE PROBLEM IS SHE SEEN YOU DRIVE!"

Knox signaled two officers to go upstairs before his grief became a traffic problem.

"We have a reception," she told me.

"Chief, I got one suitcase full of dirty clothes and a wife who wants to go swimming."

"You also have a city that watched you win an island."

"They can visit. Tell them to bring towels."

She opened the armored truck behind her. Inside was a white jacket with gold shoulder boards, hanging alone as if the other clothes had been frightened to share the rack.

"The mayor is having surgery. The deputy mayor fainted when we told her how many people were coming to your reception. The council asked if you would serve as ceremonial mayor for the weekend."

"I'm already a captain."

"Keep the badge."

"And a king."

"Keep the island."

"And married."

Shawna raised her hand. "That one takes priority."

The chief nodded to her with complete seriousness. "Naturally."

I put on the jacket. It fit like the tailor had dreamed about my shoulders and awakened with a measuring tape in his teeth. A girl in the crowd screamed so hard her friend had to sit her on the curb. I hadn't even buttoned the motherfucker.

"You see?" Knox said.

"Chief, niggas scream. That's a city."

But I kissed my wife in the middle of the street while the band played her song, and I kept the jacket.

We made it four blocks into the parade before an armored limousine hit the intersection sideways and took out a float shaped like my face.

I watched my own enormous smiling head roll under a delivery truck.

Tank stopped dancing.

A nigga beside the ruined float took one look at my rolling head and covered his mouth.

"They killed him."

"Nigga, I'm standing here."

"The other you."

"Nigga, there ain't another me."

"The big you!"

Tank grabbed the nigga by the collar and moved him behind the Mercedes. "Both these niggas got heads. Worry about yours."

"That's disrespectful," he said.

The limousine's windshield was black. Its grille had a silver saint nailed across it with his arms spread. Behind it came three motorcycles, their riders wearing mirrored masks. They weren't part of the police escort. A man rose through the limousine roof holding a weapon big enough to make every musician remember he had a family.

Knox shoved the nearest drummer behind her.

The first burst shredded the gold balloons above us.

People ran. I had Shawna behind the Lamborghini before the balloons finished falling. She kicked off her blue heels, passed me the keys, and slapped my chest once.

"Don't come home ugly."

"Baby, nigga would have to invent a new bullet."

Tank was already moving. He drove the Mercedes into the gap between the limousine and the crowd, broadside, tires screaming. Rosa pulled a fallen saxophone player through the passenger door. The man came in horn first. I saw Rosa yell something at him and realized she was telling him not to scratch the leather.

The masked man swung toward Tank.

I hit the Lamborghini's horn.

He turned. I pointed at the ruined float.

"You owe me a face, nigga."

Then I drove.

My police Lamborghini still had its dark blue paint, gold shield, and siren that sounded offended on my behalf. It had been shipped home after Monaco and polished before I landed, and now the engine rose under me like an animal delighted to discover its favorite criminal still had work for it. I put the nose against the limousine's rear quarter and drove the whole ugly situation away from the crowd.

The limousine hit a fountain. Water exploded over the hood. One motorcycle split left, another right. The third rider looked back too long at the fountain and drove directly into the enormous foam shoe from my parade float.

He disappeared inside it.

I wasn't going to let him live that down if he survived.

The limousine recovered and tore down the boulevard. Above it, the masked gunman fought to turn his weapon against the wind. I pulled alongside. His eyes moved from my badge to my face, and even through the mask I saw him recognize the degree to which his day had deteriorated.

"Oh, shit," he said.

"Exactly."

He ducked as I put two shots through the empty roof in front of him. My shots went where I wanted. His next shot went into a billboard advertising my reception.

Nigga was attacking my whole brand.

A tour bus entered the road ahead. Families leaned against its windows waving because my siren sounded like part of the celebration. I couldn't force the limousine left without putting it into them. On the right a hotel ramp climbed toward a parking deck.

I went right.

The limousine followed, which was its driver's first honest mistake. He thought running from a police officer and following me were different activities.

The ramp wound upward. First level, second, third. Sunlight chopped across my windshield. A valet in a red waistcoat saw me and fell to his knees beside a silver Bentley, either praying or proposing. I didn't have time to establish which.

My radio crackled.

"Captain, the deck is closed at the top," Knox said.

"Good. Fewer niggas."

"There is a ten-foot gap where they are connecting the new section."

"Less parking too."

The masked man fired again. Concrete jumped from the rail beside me. I felt the old scar in my side tighten as I turned the wheel. My body remembered every promise I had made to it and broken in a car.

I gave it one more.

The roof opened into blue sky. Orange barriers lined the unfinished edge. Beyond them, the new parking deck stood a little lower and a little farther away than any sensible man would have preferred.

I wasn't a sensible man. I was wearing a ceremonial mayor's jacket over a captain's badge, driving a Lamborghini a city had given me because I had already been a problem in another parking lot.

I hit the last straight stretch.

Blue Thunder stirred in my palms.

I could feel it wanting the engine. It always felt easy right before it took something. A bright pressure beneath the skin, a taste like rain touching a coin. I had learned to respect the moment before it answered. Use it too long and my hands shook. Use it when I was already empty and I might fall down while somebody still had a gun.

I gave the car one heartbeat.

The world narrowed. The engine roared blue. We cleared the barriers and left the roof.

For a second the entire city lay under my front bumper.

My own billboard passed beneath me. My face on it looked calm as hell. I respected that nigga. Billboard nigga had no idea how hard working nigga was about to land. Billboard nigga had clear skin, clean cuffs, no motherfucker shooting at him from a church limousine. Working nigga was jealous. But both niggas had the same wife, which made both niggas winners before the tires came down.

The tires struck the far deck hard enough to make the key to the city jump off the passenger seat. I caught the slide and swung around.

The limousine tried to stop.

It hit the barrier front first, hung with its nose over open air, and settled on its belly with both rear wheels spinning. The gunman vanished inside. One mirrored mask flew out the roof and landed at my feet.

I stepped out, keeping my arm steady by refusing to acknowledge how tired it had become.

Inside the limousine, somebody was screaming at somebody else's mother.

"Everybody out," I said.

The front passenger door opened over the drop.

"Other side, nigga. Let's use the brains you brought."

Four men crawled out. The driver stared at my Lamborghini, then at the gap, then at me.

"You shouldn't be able to do that."

The man beside him nodded so hard I heard his teeth.

"Nigga flew."

"I saw."

"No, nigga, the car flew."

"The nigga was in the car."

"Both niggas flew!"

I took his wrists. "Nigga, the vehicle isn't under arrest. Save some vocabulary for yourself."

I put him against the hood. "Tell your lawyer how hurt you feel."

The last man out wore no mask. He had a shaved head, a silver ear, and a jacket embroidered with a little white saint. He looked over the edge and laughed once.

"General told us you would be difficult."

"General sent four niggas and a rented church car? He doesn't know me."

"He said give you this if you lived."

He reached slowly into his jacket while I watched his hands. What came out was a small gold medal on a red ribbon. On one

side, a crown. On the other, the words WORLD CHAMPIONSHIP OF EVERYTHING.

"Tell Solomon Saint," I said, "he can mail shit."

The man smiled through a split lip. "He wanted to know if you were still fast on land."

Below us, the crowd began to cheer.

I looked down. People had poured into the hotel plaza. Phones pointed upward. The valet in the red waistcoat had found a megaphone somewhere and was announcing that I had jumped a building to save his Bentley.

It wasn't even his Bentley.

My wife arrived with Knox three minutes later. She took my right hand before I could hide the tremor.

"One burst?" she asked.

"One."

She pressed her mouth to my knuckles. "Then sit your spectacular ass down."

I sat on the Lamborghini's hood. Captain, king, mayor, whatever a nigga was, there was no rank above my wife saying sit down after she'd watched me fly over a hotel.

Tank brought the man from the foam shoe. He was still wearing part of it around his waist.

"Found Cinderella," Tank said.

Rosa laughed so hard she had to hand her phone to Knox. Even the chief took a picture.

The limousine driver looked at Shawna.

"Ma'am, your husband just—"

"I saw," she told him.

"No, you couldn't have seen the angle from—"

"Sir. I married him."

That settled the conversation.

Knox collected the gold medal in a white glove, examined it, and returned it to me.

"Saint sent the department a copy of his challenge this morning. We were going to discuss it after your reception."

"The parade was his discussion."

"Apparently."

Shawna looked out toward the desert. Somewhere past it was the airport. Somewhere past that, ocean. Our island sat in that ocean with houses, docks, workers who had finally stopped lowering their eyes when an expensive car passed, and a stage waiting for her music.

"What does he want?" she asked.

Knox was quiet for a moment. "Your island. Publicly, he wants to hold his championship there. Privately, we haven't established why he needs that particular piece of ground."

I turned the medal over. The little crown had seven points. Under it somebody had scratched a single word by hand.

KNEEL.

I laughed.

Nigga had never met my knees. They belonged beside my wife in bed and under the dinner table, and that was the full list of available positions.

"Get him on the phone," I told Knox.

"Aiden," Shawna said.

I looked at her.

"After swimming."

She held up the cherries. Somehow she had brought them through the entire chase. There were four left, dark and cold in their little bag.

I took one from her hand.

Below us, the band started again. Rosa leaned over the parking rail and shouted the beat down to them. Tank put the foam-shoe nigga in a chair so he could stop hopping. The chief of police stood beside my car making arrangements for a criminal general to call my house after I had enjoyed my pool.

And my wife, my beautiful fucking wife, climbed onto the hood beside me like the whole city could wait until her husband had stopped shaking.

I put my arm around her.

The crowd saw it and went crazier.

"They like you," she said.

Below us a nigga had started chanting my name with both shoes in his hands. Another nigga took his shoes off too, apparently unwilling to let the first nigga love me harder. Three more niggas followed. My wife watched five grown niggas barefoot on hot pavement, discovering consequences in real time.

"Aiden."

"Baby, I never told them niggas to do that."

"I know."

"Niggas inventing devotion. You gotta let a nigga create."

"Baby, they got eyes."

She fed me the last cherry and laughed into my neck.

2. The Heavyweight Champion of His Wife

General Solomon Saint called while I was floating in the pool with my badge on my chest. This nigga had tried killing me before lunch and now wanted to discuss my schedule. Some niggas bring flowers. Some niggas bring a question. This nigga brought armed niggas and then called the surviving nigga like we had a reservation together. I answered because a nigga ought to hear audacity at its source.

Not pinned to anything. Just resting there, gold in the sunshine, because Shawna said if I took another work call in the water I should at least dress for it.

Mercedes sat on the edge wearing red sunglasses. Porsche was asleep under a yellow umbrella with a newspaper folded over her face. They had come home from Monaco with us and immediately treated my mansion like a place they had rescued from a boring owner.

"Tell him you died," Mercedes said.

"He saw the news."

"Tell him it was so beautiful you died afterward."

I answered.

Saint appeared on the screen sitting beneath a chandelier made of swords. White hair, black beard, white military jacket, medals down one side like somebody had spilled a jewelry box on him. Fifty-something and still trying to make a face last a whole conversation.

"Captain Aiden."

"General, your limousine's fucked up."

"It served its purpose."

"Nigga, its purpose is hanging over a hotel."

He looked at me floating. He looked at my badge. He looked at the cherry Shawna lowered into my mouth without appearing on the screen.

Something about that last part hurt him.

"I expected a formal response."

"You sent gunfire. I sent arrests. Pretty formal."

"You have acquired Isla Gloria through a contest."

"Won it."

"A distinction of vocabulary."

"Nigga, you watched me race?"

"I watched the result."

"Then you watched this nigga win. You watched the other niggas lose. Nigga with the deed is the winning nigga. Ain't a dictionary in the world confused about this."

Mercedes raised her glass beside the pool. "Educate the nigga."

I sat up. "A distinction of who went home with the fucking island."

Porsche lifted the newspaper off her face. She was awake now.

Saint smiled thinly. "Every king should defend his crown. I propose twelve days of competition. Racing. Combat. Music. Strategy. Athletic trials. A final contest worthy of the victor. The World Championship of Everything. On your island."

"Get your own island."

"I have six."

"Then why you calling about mine, nigga?"

For the first time, he didn't answer immediately.

There it was. Some little door behind his eyes he didn't want opened. I had met men who wanted money, men who wanted women, men who wanted other men to stop laughing whenever they stood up. Saint wanted something under the words he was saying.

"If you win," he said, "my gold fleet becomes yours. Twelve ships. My championship treasury. My concessions throughout the southern sea."

"And if I lose?"

"Isla Gloria."

Shawna sat beside me. He could see her now. Water ran from her shoulders, and the watch on her wrist caught the sun.

"The people on that island aren't a prize," she said.

Saint bowed his head a fraction. "Then win for them."

I felt her hand close around mine underwater.

"You sound brave on a telephone," I told him.

"Will you come?"

"Nigga, it's my house. Will you?"

We ended the call with his smile still trying to recover.

Mercedes took the phone. "That man gets dressed in front of a painting of himself."

"I got a billboard," I said.

"Your billboard doesn't tell you good morning."

Porsche sat up. "You notice what he didn't put on the list?"

"What?"

"Swimming. Nigga picked an island championship and forgot water. He wants the land."

I looked at her.

Porsche shrugged. "Men tell me things when they think I've fallen asleep. It's half my education."

Across the pool, Marcellus had stopped turning the pages of his book.

"Bring me the medal," he said.

I put the little gold crown in his palm. His thumb went straight to the seven points.

For a moment he wasn't beside my pool. His face had gone somewhere older and darker, somewhere with music he had been trying not to hear.

"Tomorrow," he said. "I need to make a call."

He walked into the house carrying the medal.

"Everybody got a mysterious tomorrow," Tank said from behind us. "Mine involves a jewelry store."

Rosa turned her head.

Tank froze with a plate of chicken balanced against his chest.

"For a watch," he added.

"Baby," Rosa said, "you already wear two."

"Different time."

She let him suffer for five beautiful seconds before turning back to the sun.

That evening the heavyweight champion came to my house to ask if I would please hit him for charity.

Darius Diamond was thirty-four, six feet four, and built like a man who had swallowed another champion whole. He had gold teeth only in the back because he said the front teeth were for business. He brought his trainer, his publicist, and a blue velvet robe with my name sewn across the shoulders.

I looked at the robe.

"Nigga, you prepared for my consent."

"The workers' hospital needs a new wing," he said. "We do three exhibition rounds tomorrow. People pay to watch. Nobody gets hurt."

Tank coughed.

"Nobody gets hurt bad," Darius corrected.

"Which nigga gets hurt a little?" Tank asked.

Darius looked at me. I looked at Darius. Tank looked between us.

"Niggas, I'm asking a medical question."

"The losing nigga," I said.

"Both niggas think the other nigga losing."

"Good promotion," Darius said.

Tank shook his head. "Hospital about to make its money twice."

Shawna took the robe from him and held it against me. She stood back, considering.

"You can't say no now," she said.

"Why?"

"Because I need to see this with the gloves."

Darius grinned. "Your wife has excellent taste."

"Nigga, look at her husband."

We agreed on three rounds and no Blue Thunder. I didn't want anybody saying electricity had done something my hands had already been capable of doing when I was broke. Darius shook on it and nearly crushed the hand I needed to prove the point.

When he left, Tank followed me into the kitchen.

"I need help," he said.

"With a different-time watch?"

"Don't start."

He took a box out of his pocket. Inside was a ring with a stone shaped like a drop of sunlight. Marcellus's work. The band had tiny roses running around it, each petal cut so fine it looked soft.

I stopped joking.

Tank stared at the box instead of me.

"You think she wants it?"

"Nigga, she wants you. The ring just gives her something to throw at you when you piss her off."

"I'm serious."

"So am I. That's an expensive argument."

He laughed once, then got quiet again.

"I know how to stand in front of a gun," he said. "I don't know how to stand there waiting on a woman to tell me if she wants the rest of my life."

I leaned against the counter. "You remember that night I couldn't breathe and you carried me anyway?"

He looked up.

"You didn't ask if you were carrying me right. You just wouldn't let me go. That's you, Tank. She already knows the answer to the hard part."

He closed the box with his thumb.

"On the island," he said. "When she sings."

"Then win her a good night."

The next afternoon fifteen thousand people paid to watch Darius Diamond teach me what a heavyweight championship felt like.

It felt like getting punched by an expensive refrigerator.

First round, thirty seconds in, he touched my guard and drove me backward across the ring. The crowd made one enormous

surprised noise. Darius smiled around his mouthpiece. His eyes said he liked me and was absolutely going to beat my ass for a hospital.

"There you are," he said.

"Nigga, I'm right here."

He hit me again to confirm it.

I could hear Shawna at ringside. Not screaming. Worse. Giving instructions.

"Aiden, stop admiring him and move."

My wife knew me. I had been admiring the man. He was clean. Every step meant something. Every time I thought I saw an opening, the opening had a fist waiting in it.

I let him push me another half step. Watched his shoulder. Watched his feet. The bell rang before I answered.

Tank climbed through the ropes with a towel.

"You all right?"

"Nigga got hands."

"He the champion."

"I noticed when he introduced my teeth to each other."

Across the ring, Darius's trainer was laughing. Darius wasn't. He was watching me watch him.

Second round, I stopped trying to be faster than everything at once. I gave him the look he had been waiting for, let him believe I was going where he wanted, and stepped somewhere else. His glove brushed my cheek. Mine found the part of his ribs that hadn't expected company.

He grunted.

I heard Rosa say, "Oh, shit."

Darius came forward harder. I met him. Three exchanges, all heat and breath and ropes under our backs. No lightning. No car. Just another man's will trying to move mine.

I loved the motherfucker for making me work. This nigga wasn't giving me a famous-man round. Nigga wasn't letting the cameras carry my hands. He wanted to know what kind of nigga stood underneath the jacket, and I wanted to show him. Two niggas asking the same question with different fists. Some niggas call that hostility. Nigga, I call it an introduction worth remembering.

At the end of the round he tapped my glove.

"You learn fast."

"You teach violent."

Third round, we forgot the word exhibition together.

He caught me once so clean the arena lights took a short vacation. I stayed up because Shawna was wearing the robe now, and if I fell over in front of my wife wearing my name I

would have to move to another planet. He came to finish the thought. I turned with him, found my feet, and sent the answer up between his gloves.

Darius Diamond sat down.

For a moment nobody moved.

Then the arena went fucking insane.

He blinked at me from the canvas, touched his chin, and laughed with his whole chest.

"Nigga."

"Yeah," I said, breathing like I'd stolen every breath in the room.

"I know."

He got up at eight. The bell ended it before either of us could establish how much more charity our faces could survive.

The judges called it a draw.

Darius took the microphone and told them they were cowards.

"He knocked me on my ass," he said. "Give the captain the belt for the night."

I lifted his wrist. "Hospital gets the money. Champion keeps his title. Nigga just needed somewhere comfortable to sit."

He nearly knocked me down hugging me.

Then an armored motorcycle burst through the arena's service curtain.

The rider came up the aisle standing on the pedals. His jacket bore the same little silver saint. Behind him, two men in delivery uniforms raised guns toward the ring.

Darius looked at me.

"This happen often?"

"Lately."

"Nigga, lately how often?"

"You want a calendar or you want to duck?"

Darius ducked. "Nigga, I invited you to boxing."

"And another nigga invited himself to losing. We can't control hospitality."

"That nigga got a gun."

"So does this nigga. Give me my coat."

He picked up the stool from his corner and threw it so hard it turned the motorcycle sideways. The rider struck the aisle barrier and landed in a pile of empty popcorn tubs.

"Good hands," I told him.

We both went down as shots snapped above the ropes.

Knox's officers moved the crowd toward the side exits.

Mercedes vaulted the ringside table, grabbed a microphone, and began ordering people out with a voice that made panic ashamed

of itself. Porsche pulled a fallen camera operator behind the stairs and took his camera with him.

"Keep filming," she told him.

"I'm a sports cameraman!"

"Then catch the fucking sport!"

Shawna got Rosa beneath the table and came up holding my jacket. My gun was in it. She slid the jacket across the floor to the ring while Tank crossed the aisle through a storm of flying programs.

I tore off one glove with my teeth. Darius stared.

"You got a whole police department in that coat?"

"Just enough."

I put shots into the lights above the gunmen. Glass rained. They ducked, buying Tank the last distance he needed. He hit one man with a folding chair, caught the other man's arm, and drove him through the flimsy wall advertising a luxury mattress.

The wall fell away.

Behind it was an actual luxury mattress.

Both men landed on it.

Tank stood over them, breathing hard.

"Comfortable?"

The crowd that hadn't finished leaving started clapping. Mercedes yelled at them to keep moving while they applauded. The motorcycle rider tried to rise. Darius stepped on his jacket and held him there.

"Count him out," he told the referee.

The referee, who had crawled under the ring, raised one shaking hand and began counting.

By the time the police had the three men cuffed, I was back at ringside with Shawna in my arms. She checked my cheek with her thumb.

"Your face," she said.

"Still the best one."

"Unfortunately, yes."

A man in a purple suit pushed through the officers waving both hands.

"Captain! Captain, I'm Leon Lux. I make pictures."

"Nigga, I just made three arrests."

"I saw! The robe, the fight, the gun, your wife! I want you for my next film."

Shawna's eyes narrowed. "Who plays me?"

"You do. Naturally."

She considered him.

"Go on."

Two hours later Leon had borrowed the arena entrance, Porsche's footage, and my patience. His new movie was about a captain who won a boxing match while assassins attacked. He kept asking me to repeat the walk I had done coming out of the ring.

"I was walking toward my wife," I said.

"Exactly! Do that!"

"Put her over there, then."

Shawna stood beneath the lights with my robe over her evening dress. I walked toward her. Leon made a noise like somebody had handed him a bag of diamonds.

"That's the movie," he whispered.

The camera operator looked at him. "Just the nigga walking?"

"Look how the nigga walks."

"Nigga's going to his wife."

"Exactly. Nigga has somewhere to be."

I heard them and kept walking. Of course a nigga had somewhere to be. My wife stood beneath the lights looking like the answer to why the fuck a nigga bothered winning anything.

I kissed her, and he started crying.

Behind the camera, Porsche negotiated her producer credit while Mercedes sold him the rights to none of our personal lives and all of the motorcycle footage. Darius joined the cast because he said he would be damned if another man got paid to play the nigga I knocked down.

My phone buzzed.

Saint had sent a video. He stood on a white ship, the lights of eleven more burning behind him.

"You appear to enjoy an audience," he said. "Bring one."

The camera turned. Beyond the ships stood Isla Gloria, my island, its mountain dark against the sea. On the shore, men were already raising a stadium.

My smile left.

Shawna saw before I said anything. She took the phone, watched the end, and handed it back.

"We leave in the morning," she said.

Not are we going. Not what happens if. My wife looked toward the airport like she had left a song unfinished and somebody had put his dirty hands on the piano.

I took off the boxing robe and put my captain's jacket on.

Leon called after me asking what happened in the next scene.

"Nigga," I told him, "buy a ticket."

3. Get Your Warships Off My Beach

My island had a welcome sign, three beautiful beaches, and twelve enemy ships pretending they were decorations. Twelve. Nigga didn't park one ugly boat near my property. Nigga brought eleven friends so the first ugly boat wouldn't feel insecure. I looked down at all them expensive white motherfuckers and thought, this nigga really believes a fleet makes a nigga welcome. Nigga, I own a driveway too. That doesn't make every car in it invited.

I saw them from the plane. White hulls in a crescent around the southern bay, gold flags snapping from their masts. The biggest one carried a platform wide enough to land a helicopter on and a portrait of Solomon Saint big enough to frighten fish.

Tank leaned across me.

"Nigga ugly from altitude."

"That's commitment," I said.

Shawna reached over both of us and shut the blind.

"We are eating breakfast."

So we ate breakfast. My wife could tell a war to wait until her coffee arrived, and the war would find somewhere to sit.

Marcellus had barely slept. He held Saint's medal between two fingers, turning it whenever he thought nobody watched. Beside him lay a photograph of a ballroom with no roof. Palm trees leaned over its broken walls. In the middle of the floor, two young people stood in evening clothes, holding one another like the music was coming out of their own bodies.

The man was Marcellus without the gray.

The woman wore a white dress split at the knee and a black ribbon around her throat. She looked straight into the camera as if she had caught it stealing.

"Celeste?" I asked.

"Before Celeste."

He looked at the photograph for another second.

"Her name is Isolde. If she answers my message, I may owe somebody thirty-five years of explanation."

"Damn, nigga. Get a comfortable chair."

He smiled, but it hurt him around the eyes.

We landed to drums. Real island drums, deep enough to come through the soles of my shoes. People lined the runway behind rope barriers waving blue flowers, little handmade flags, and at least three pictures of me that made my shoulders physically impossible. One painter had given me eight abdominal muscles on each side. I respected the ambition.

Chief Knox stepped off behind me in sunglasses and a summer uniform.

"You understand I am on leave," she said.

An island officer hurried forward and handed her a ceremonial sword.

She took it immediately.

"For fuck's sake," Mercedes whispered.

"Some women like necklaces," I said.

Our people waited beyond the drums. Dockhands, hotel cooks, mechanics, singers, the racers we had helped get out from under Cruel. None of them looked pleased about the ships. They cheered us anyway.

A broad woman in a blue dress broke through first and kissed Shawna on both cheeks. Her name was Alma Reyes. She ran the harbor kitchens and could feed two hundred people without raising her voice.

"They put a stage over my vegetable garden," she said.

Shawna turned toward the bay.

"Who did?"

"The general."

I knew right then Saint had chosen the wrong garden.

Alma's husband, Tomas, handed me a folded plan. A stadium had gone up beside the old racecourse. A music pavilion filled the square. A glass fighting cage sat on the beach like somebody had trapped a nightclub in an aquarium. Roads had been painted gold. Saint's men had marked off the ruined hillside palace as a private competitors' residence.

"Nobody hurt?" I asked.

"Not yet," Tomas said. "They pay for what they take. They tell us that means they are welcome."

I looked down at the plan. The whole fucking island was beautiful, and the nigga had somehow found a way to draw himself on all of it.

"Keep your wages," I told him. "Keep your houses. If they tell you anything different, tell them the captain's home."

The crowd heard captain and answered with king.

I wasn't about to interrupt good conversation.

A dockworker elbowed the nigga beside him. "That's our captain."

"Nigga, that's our king."

"Same nigga."

"Then why you arguing with a nigga?"

"Because you keep saying our like the nigga belongs to you."

Shawna took my hand. Both niggas saw it and settled the ownership question immediately.

Solomon Saint met us at the palace gate with two champions on either side. The first man wore a gray uniform and polished boots, a chest like a steel door, and a look that said he'd never been wrong unless another man had failed him. The woman beside him had short dark hair, a yellow suit, and a tiny chess knight pinned at her throat.

"Captain Lionel Graves," Saint said, indicating the man.

"Champion of pursuit, combat shooting, and the continental police games."

Graves looked at my badge.

"You wear that casually."

"Nigga, I wear everything well."

Knox made a little sound behind me that might have been agreement or an old knee.

"Doctor Mina Quill," Saint continued. "Three-time winner of the Seven Sciences Crown."

Mina held out her hand to Shawna first.

"I know your music," she said.

"I hope that's good news."

"Very. I used your last performance to get through a miserable train journey beside a man who explained trains to me."

Mercedes liked her immediately.

Saint led us through the gate. In the courtyard, mechanics worked beneath canvas awnings. Cameras hung from balconies. Waiters carried iced drinks around a marble statue with its face covered by a cloth.

I stopped beside it.

"Who is that?"

"The future champion," Saint said.

I lifted the cloth.

It was Saint.

I looked at him.

He looked at me.

"Nigga, you better hope marble comes with an eraser."

Shawna took a drink from a passing tray and walked past him smiling into the glass.

Our rooms faced the western sea. I gave the balcony view one appreciative minute before I looked for anybody who didn't belong in the room. Tank checked the connecting door.

Mercedes found a silver box full of perfumes and announced that if Saint was poisoning us, at least he understood fragrance. Porsche opened the wardrobe and found her exact size in six colors.

"He's been looking," she said.

"Let him look," Shawna said. "Looking's the part he can afford."

At sunset the whole island gathered for the opening ceremony. Twenty tall gold columns ringed the new stadium, each topped with a crown. Competitions were painted on the bases: speed, strength, song, strategy, endurance, precision, dance. Saint had given everything a dramatic name, but a nigga could still recognize a fist when somebody called it the Discipline of Kings.

He stood on a round platform in the center with the trophy behind him. It was a crown inside another crown inside a larger crown. A man had to want attention on three separate levels to design that shit.

"Each victory," Saint announced, "earns its champion a golden laurel. The leader at the end of the trials earns the right to the final Crown Challenge. The founder defends his title there."

I turned to Shawna.

"So he gets a chair while everybody else works."

"Then take his chair."

Behind us, Tank studied the founder's platform.

"Nigga brought a chair to a championship."

"Nigga brought a throne," Mercedes said.

"A rich chair. Nigga brought a rich chair and wants other niggas to sweat."

I looked at the throne. "Nigga better enjoy the cushioning. I'm about to make standing up expensive."

I loved a woman who understood championship rules.

The crowd cheered when they showed me on the screen. Then they showed Shawna, and the cheer changed. People lifted their phones, voices coming from all sides. She had not sung one note on that stage yet and already they wanted the next one.

Saint noticed.

"Our first exhibition," he said, "will be performed by the fleet."

Horns sounded from the bay. The white ships began to move, lights chasing up their masts. Between them, a little passenger ferry carried people from the outer dock toward the stadium. Adult workers and competitors stood along its rail. I could see their bright shirts in the evening light.

One of Saint's ships crossed too close.

The ferry swerved. Its engine coughed black smoke. Then the tide took its stern and swung it toward the stone wall at the harbor mouth.

People in the stands began to point.

Saint kept smiling.

"A demonstration of the sea's power," he said into the microphone.

I was already moving.

The stairs down to the dock passed beneath the grandstand. I took them three at a time, Tank behind me, Graves following because the nigga could not bear to let another captain run faster in public. At the water, a little silver speedboat waited under a banner bearing Saint's face.

I jumped in.

"That is assigned to the champion," Graves said.

"Then why the fuck are you still talking? Get in."

He got in.

Tank caught the bow rail as I pulled away and nearly brought the whole dock with him. The boat rose onto the dark water. Behind us the stadium lights shone across the bay, and the ferry turned slowly toward the wall with forty people aboard.

I could hear them now.

Not cheering. That mattered. I knew the difference between a crowd making noise for me and people trying to make enough noise to stay alive.

Graves stood beside me.

"We need to get them clear before that hull strikes."

"Good thinking, captain. I was going to autograph the boat."

We came alongside. Tank caught a ferry worker's arm and pulled him across the gap. The man was shaking too hard to

speaking. Behind him, another worker held a woman upright against the rail.

"Engine room's taking water!" somebody shouted.

I looked toward the rocks. Closer now. Too close for polite planning.

"Tank, catch what comes at you."

"Nigga, that is not an instruction."

"It's your whole career."

I put the speedboat against the ferry's side and held it there while Graves helped people across. Wood scraped. Metal screamed. My hands fought the wheel. One man jumped too soon, struck the gap, and vanished below the rail.

I left the wheel to Graves and went over after him.

Cold water shut the noise off. For a second there were only lights breaking apart overhead and the man's pale shirt sinking beside me. I caught his shoulder. He grabbed at me, panicked, pulling us both down. I held him from behind, found the dark shape of the hull, and kicked toward air.

Tank's arm came into the water like God had decided to wear a gold watch.

He pulled us both out.

I landed across the speedboat bench with the man on top of me, coughing seawater into a jacket somebody had tailored in Paris.

"Nigga," I told him between breaths, "you owe my wife a dry husband."

He cried harder.

Graves was still at the wheel. The ferry hit the first stone marker, and a long ripping sound crossed the water.

Two people remained at the far end: an older cook with one leg trapped under a fallen bench and his husband trying to lift it. Tank looked from them to the boat full of shaking passengers.

"Go," I said.

He jumped.

I watched him land on the ferry, get both hands beneath the bench, and lift. The cook pulled his leg free. Tank dragged the two men toward us as the ferry tilted.

Behind us a white launch raced across the bay. Shawna stood in its bow holding a coil of rope while Mercedes steered. Rosa waved a flashlight from the stern. Porsche had commandeered a second boat and was loading more people into it from our crowded deck.

My wife reached Tank just as the ferry struck the harbor wall. The sound was enormous. The bow crumpled. Water shot up over the rail. Tank pushed the two men into Shawna's launch and jumped after them as the ferry slid down the rocks behind him.

Everybody stayed above the water.

I counted until I believed it. Nigga by nigga. Hand by hand. Not uniforms. Not teams. Niggas breathing, niggas coughing, niggas calling the people who would have hated the sea forever if we'd been one minute slower. I needed every nigga who got on that ferry to have another bad breakfast, another argument, another kiss somebody pretended not to want.

Forty.

All forty.

Graves turned toward me. His immaculate uniform was soaked. A bloody scrape ran down his forearm.

"You didn't use the lightning," he said.

"There were niggas in the water."

He looked at the passengers. Looked back at me.

Something moved in his face. Not friendship yet. Recognition of a thing his general had neglected to explain.

We came into the harbor with three boats full of rescued people and Tank holding a soaked cook who refused to let go of his neck.

The stadium was on its feet.

Saint waited at the dock with cameras behind him. He opened his arms as if the rescue had been an entertainment he had generously arranged.

"A remarkable beginning."

I got out of the boat and walked straight into his open arms.

He wasn't expecting that.

I hugged him hard enough to put seawater all over his white jacket and spoke against his ear.

"Forty people, nigga. If one had gone under and stayed there, I'd be carrying your ass out instead of talking."

His body went stiff.

I released him smiling for the cameras.

"Wonderful host," I said.

Behind him, Mina Quill had brought blankets. She wrapped one around the cook and gave another to Tank. Marcellus stood with Alma, helping the frightened passengers name the people they needed called.

Shawna came ashore barefoot. Her dress clung to her knees. She took one look at the untouched stage and climbed onto it.

Saint started to speak.

Rosa took his microphone.

"No," she said.

Then my wife sang.

She didn't sing the big triumphant number everybody expected. She sang something slow enough that the people still shaking

could breathe with it. The first line went across the harbor almost bare. By the second, Rosa was beside her. By the chorus, Alma's cooks were singing from the dock, and the men we had just pulled from the sea were holding each other's hands instead of the boat rails.

I stood there dripping beside my enemy while the whole island belonged to my wife.

Saint couldn't interrupt it. Couldn't buy it. Couldn't even clap until everybody else did, because he needed to know what admiration looked like before he copied it.

Graves stood on my other side.

"She's extraordinary," he said.

The nigga said it like he'd discovered the sea was wet. But I let him have the discovery. Let a nigga hear my wife and find a new room in his own chest. Let the next nigga hear her too. Niggas had come to the island thinking the loudest man owned the evening. My wife hadn't raised her voice, and every nigga with ears knew whose evening it was.

"Nigga, now you're catching up."

When the song ended, the island didn't stop cheering for so long that Saint's opening fireworks went off without anybody watching them.

Shawna came down the steps and put her wet arms around my neck.

"Did you win the boat competition?" she asked.

"Wasn't one."

"There is now."

Tank raised both hands. "Nigga won the unscheduled boat competition."

"Nigga invented it," Rosa said.

"Other niggas can't beat a nigga in a competition they don't know exists."

"Then them niggas should've watched the water," Shawna said.

I looked at her. My wife was getting good at this. Nigga was falling in love with the same woman all over the damn island.

She kissed me in front of every ship the general owned.

That night, a small envelope appeared beneath our door. No threat. No crest. Just Marcellus's name written in a woman's steady hand.

Inside was a black ribbon and a line of writing.

Tell the boy with the impossible car that the general is digging in the wrong room.

Underneath, one more sentence.

And tell Marcellus I have not forgotten how to lead.

4. Every Cop in the World Wanted My Autograph

The general gave me a car with no doors and told me to pursue justice. This nigga had seen the Lamborghini. This nigga knew what I drove. Nigga still rolled out a rich man's shopping cart and looked at me like a favor had occurred. I looked at the car, then at the nigga, then back at the car. Somewhere a manufacturer had built this motherfucker without imagining the nigga who would be insulted by it.

I looked at the car. I looked at him.

"Nigga, justice could at least have windows."

It was a low white racing machine with a roll cage, enormous tires, and the temperament of a lawn mower that had inherited money. The other competitors stood beside identical cars in matching uniforms. Twenty-four captains from twenty-four fictional police forces, all invited to show the world what a real officer could do.

Saint had put me at the far end in a uniform two sizes too small.

I came in my own.

Chief Knox walked the line behind me with the ceremonial sword under one arm. She had taken off her summer jacket because the sun was hot and she intended to insult several men comfortably.

"Your entry conditions permit a personal vehicle," she told Saint.

"Only if it meets the spirit of the contest."

My Lamborghini rolled through the gate behind her with Mercedes driving and Porsche leaning over the passenger door eating a peach.

The entire line of police captains turned.

"That's the nigga's police car?"

"That's the nigga's slow police car," Tank said.

"Nigga has a faster one?"

"Nigga has an island full of faster ones."

"How do I join this nigga's department?"

Knox looked down the line. "Start by standing up straight."

Twenty-three niggas found their spines together.

One man took off his sunglasses and put them back on as if the first look had been a problem with the lenses.

I pointed at the dark blue hood.

"That nigga got spirit."

Saint examined the gold police shield on the door. His reflection looked miserable in my paint.

"A single passenger is permitted," he said.

Mercedes handed me the keys. "Good. I'm coming."

Shawna stood beneath the awning with Rosa. She wore yellow today, and every breeze seemed to know exactly what to do with the skirt. I went over to kiss her before the start.

"What do you want if I win?" I asked.

"A blue piano."

"Done."

"On a boat."

"Bigger done."

"That stays level when the sea moves."

I looked at Tank.

"Nigga, find an engineer."

He held up his phone without looking away from Rosa.

"Already searching."

My wife brushed a little dust from my shoulder. "And you back in one piece."

"You asked for the expensive things last."

The pursuit course wound from the stadium up through the hillside, across a dry riverbed, through the old port, and back along the sea wall. Three gates along the way held red flags. A driver had to bring back one from each gate. Opponents could take a flag by touching the long padded arm fixed to the side of their car against another car's red target.

That was the official game.

The unofficial game was twenty-three niggas looking at me like I had personally insulted every road they'd ever driven.

Captain Graves came over while Mercedes fastened her belt.

"You understand there are no second chances on the upper road," he said.

"Then don't waste your first one staring at my car."

His eyes flicked toward the dashboard. Toward the seat. Toward the wheel.

"It's a very good car."

"You can say beautiful, nigga. It won't make you less police."

He almost smiled.

At the starting line, Mercedes adjusted the rearview mirror toward her face.

"Need that," I said.

"I need to know how I look when we win."

"You look rich."

"Then stop talking and make me accurate."

The gun sounded.

Twenty-four engines hit the morning together. We came off the line in a cloud of white dust, the little pursuit cars jumping over

the rough ground like angry goats. I let three pass me before the first bend. Mercedes watched the mirror.

"Graves on your right. Bald nigga on your left. Handsome one trying to get between them."

"They all handsome if they behind us."

I took the inside turn. The padded arm on the nearest car swung toward my door. I moved just enough to let him miss and watched his arm strike the car beside him instead. Both men shouted. A red flag shot up from the struck car's rear basket. Mercedes caught it before it touched the ground.

She held it across her lap.

"Souvenir."

The first gate stood at the bottom of the dry riverbed. Drivers funneled toward it, tires fighting loose stone. Graves went high along the bank. Two others stayed low. I saw the gatekeeper lift three flags for them and calculate how long it would take to get another one ready for me.

I didn't give him the time.

The Lamborghini hit the bank, rose across it, and came down beside the gate like a dark blue argument. Mercedes leaned out and took the flag from his raised hand with two fingers.

"Thank you, sweetheart."

The nigga bowed.

We were already gone.

Mercedes looked back at the gatekeeper. "Nigga bowed."

"Polite nigga."

"Other niggas just got a flag."

"Other niggas didn't bring you."

She settled deeper into the seat. "Nigga, that's the kind of navigation I enjoy."

I grinned. Behind us the gatekeeper was still waving, some nigga taking pictures of a nigga taking a good morning personally.

On the upper road the sea opened beneath us. It was the kind of blue that made a man forgive weather for everything else it had ever done. White buildings clung to the hillside. People watched from balconies holding breakfast plates, cheering whenever my siren cut through the engines.

A woman threw flowers.

Mercedes caught one and tucked it behind her ear.

"These people understand arrival."

I was smiling when the black truck came around the blind curve.

It didn't belong in the race. It had no number, no padded arm, and six men standing in the open back holding rifles.

The first shot knocked a piece off the stone wall beside my head.

Mercedes dropped the flower.

"Nigga, that's real."

"I noticed the enthusiasm."

I swung the Lamborghini behind a pursuit car as its driver ducked. The truck blocked most of the road. Beyond it the second gate fluttered red and cheerful, not understanding its career had changed.

Graves braked beside me. His car struck the wall, sparks running down the side. He looked at the gunmen, then back toward the stadium below.

His general's flags flew over both.

"Keep the other drivers back," I told him.

"I can engage—"

"Nigga, keep them alive. That's an engagement."

I drove at the truck.

Mercedes caught the handle above her door. She didn't scream. I liked that about her. Plenty of people could act brave in a safe room. Mercedes looked death in the face and got offended about the outfit.

"If we die," she said, "I want you to know this dashboard is too low for my legs."

"Write the factory when we win."

The truck driver turned to block the narrow gap by the wall. I let him believe I wanted it. At the last instant I took the raised stone verge on the other side, put two tires high, and brought the Lamborghini onto its side wheels.

The horizon tipped.

Mercedes pressed herself against the seat as the sea moved above her shoulder.

We passed between truck and cliff with my door a hand's width from the rock.

One gunman stared directly into my windshield as we went by. His mouth opened. He had enough time to appreciate the work and not enough time to improve his aim.

The car dropped onto four wheels beyond the truck. I turned it across the road and fired back through my open window. The men scattered behind the truck's cab. One dropped his rifle. Another jumped into the ditch and discovered the ditch contained an extremely angry goat.

Mercedes watched him struggle.

"Local police," she said.

Behind the truck, Graves and two captains had left their cars. Together they overwhelmed the driver while my shots kept the men in the back from rising. The whole thing ended with five gunmen on the ground and the sixth trying to negotiate with livestock.

Graves came around the cab with his jaw clenched.

"Those are Saint's men."

"Nigga, did the matching outfits help?"

He looked at me for a long moment.

"I gave him my word that I would compete fairly."

"Then do. You didn't give him your fucking eyes."

The other captains gathered around us. The bald one had a cut above his eyebrow. The handsome one was bleeding through his sleeve. Nobody wanted to get back in a car until they knew whether the next corner had another truck waiting. I understood. A nigga can agree to lose a race without agreeing to lose a lung. These niggas had come with trophies in mind, not funerals. I looked at the wounded nigga, the bald nigga, the handsome nigga no longer worrying about his sleeve. All of them were waiting for the nigga Saint had told them to beat.

I took the radio from the truck and put it on the hood.

Saint's voice crackled out.

"Has the captain stopped?"

I pressed the button.

"Just to admire the goats."

Silence.

Then I heard a chair scrape somewhere.

Mercedes leaned close to the radio. "The girls say hello."

I left it on the hood.

Graves looked down the mountain. The whole race had stopped because I had stopped. Twenty-three proud men waited to see if I would go on.

"We finish," I said.

The bald captain nodded first.

"Behind you?"

"If you can keep up."

Nigga grinned like I'd given him his birthday.

The second gatekeeper handed Mercedes a flag while bowing so low his cap fell off. At the port we came into streets lined with hanging laundry and cheering workers. Every other car stayed close behind us, a moving wall of captains who had come to beat me and discovered a better use for their engines.

Then a delivery van rolled into the crossing.

Its driver jumped out shouting that the brakes were gone. The van rolled downhill toward an outdoor café full of people who had turned their chairs to watch the race.

I didn't have any Blue Thunder in my hands yet. I had been saving it because a nigga couldn't spend electricity like money just because he happened to have some.

Now I gave the engine a short bright pulse.

The Lamborghini leaped forward. I came alongside the van, matched its awful rolling speed, and pressed my front quarter against it. Metal folded. My beautiful paint cried without a voice. We turned together, slowly enough to hurt, hard enough to shove my shoulders against the belt.

The van struck a stack of empty fish crates instead of the café. Crates exploded across the street.

One landed perfectly on the café owner's head.

He lifted it off, looked at the untouched tables, and held up both thumbs.

I rested my forehead against the wheel for one breath.

Mercedes touched my arm.

"You there?"

"Yeah."

"Good. Because if you pass out I'm driving, and this bitch already offended my knees."

I laughed and straightened.

My left hand shook once. I kept it low and used the right.

At the third gate, the flags had disappeared.

Saint hadn't been subtle. He had simply ordered them removed while we were coming down the hill. A little man in a cream suit

stood beside the empty pole looking like his stomach wanted to leave without him.

"Regrettable," he said. "Without the final pennant, no competitor can record a complete—"

Mercedes got out.

She walked past him, opened the nearby shed, and found twenty-four red flags on a chair.

The man closed his eyes.

"Nigga," she said softly, "I have found married men in smaller hiding places."

She handed one to every captain.

"Nigga, say thank you," she told the first.

He said it. So did the next nigga. And the next. By the fifth nigga she was smiling like a woman handing out report cards to a class that had finally learned manners.

"Good nigga. Another good nigga. Look at y'all. International courtesy."

The little man in the cream suit wished he had gone into the shed with the flags.

Then she got back in my car and crossed her legs as if she had stepped out to powder her nose.

We entered the stadium together.

The crowd rose. They had seen the truck on the live feed before somebody cut the signal. They had seen the rescue at the café after Porsche somehow found a different camera and put it back on. Now they saw twenty-four cars pouring through the arch, every police captain on his feet behind the wheel except me because a nigga was tired and had a roof.

Graves tried to pass me on the final straight.

I respected him for it.

I also beat him by half a car.

At the line he laughed openly for the first time.

"Had to try."

"Good captain."

"Better driver," he admitted.

"Nigga, don't stop. I'm enjoying this."

Saint waited beside the winners' platform holding the first golden laurel. His smile looked like he'd had it installed against medical advice.

Before he could speak, the bald captain took the microphone.

"We agreed on something out there," he said.

Twenty-two men stood behind him. Graves joined them.

"Captain Aiden led us through a live attack, saved civilians during the race, and still crossed first. We recognize him as the champion of pursuit."

The crowd roared.

Saint had to put the laurel around my neck himself.

I bent just enough to make it possible and looked him in the eyes while he did it.

"Nigga," I said quietly, "your games got expensive fast."

He released the ribbon like it had burned him.

Then the captains started lining up for pictures.

Not one. All of them. Some wanted me between them and their cars. One wanted me to hold his radio and say his call sign. The bald captain admitted he'd told his department he would bring back my autograph if he couldn't bring back the trophy.

Knox stood off to the side, watching twenty-three men wait their turn.

"You collecting departments now?" she asked.

One nigga behind her asked whether I could sign his cap.

Another nigga had brought his badge. A third nigga wanted a photograph for his mother but admitted, when Mercedes looked at him, that his mother did not know how to open photographs on a phone.

"Nigga, it's for you," she said.

"It's for me."

"Let the nigga enjoy himself," I told her. "I take excellent pictures."

"Chief, they followed me home."

Shawna came through the crowd and put her hands on my face. She looked at my pupils, my hands, the little line of strain under my mouth.

"One burst," I said before she asked.

"And one side of the car."

"Baby, both sides still exist."

She kissed me, slow enough for every camera to understand that photographs had limits.

When she let me go, she looked over my shoulder.

At the harbor below, workers were lowering an enormous blue piano onto the deck of a white yacht. Tank stood beside them, arms folded, while an engineer explained the platform beneath it with wild hand movements.

My wife blinked.

"Already?"

"Nigga found an engineer."

Her laugh hit me harder than Darius had.

I took the laurel off and put it around Mercedes's neck. She looked down at it, suddenly quiet.

"For your knees," I said.

She touched the gold leaves.

"You didn't have to do that."

"You caught the flags."

Porsche leaned against her shoulder for the picture. "And the niggas caught feelings. Look at them."

The captains were still standing in line.

Saint was not smiling anymore.

5. Marcellus Had Been a Dangerous Nigga Too

Marcellus put on a white dinner jacket to meet a woman who had threatened him with a ribbon. Old nigga had faced guns in a cardigan. Old nigga had watched a forty-million-dollar stone change hands without spilling his drink. One woman said come see me and the nigga discovered cuffs, posture, cologne, the whole frightened ceremony. A nigga can survive prison and still get nervous because another nigga once failed to answer a love letter.

I watched the old nigga adjust his cuffs for the fourth time.

"You nervous?"

"No."

"Nigga, your left wrist been dressed for ten minutes."

He lowered his hands.

"I would prefer not to look like time has won."

Tank leaned in the doorway. "Time won against everybody, Marcellus. You just got better shoes than most niggas."

"Thank you, Tank. That is almost encouraging."

We found Isolde in the roofless ballroom from the photograph.

Moonlight lay across the old floor. Somebody had cleared the weeds from between its marble squares and hung lanterns in the

broken windows. The mountain rose behind the wall. Below it, the general's stadium shone gold, but up here all we could hear was the sea and a woman turning the pages of a piece of music.

She wore a red dress and silver shoes. Sixty years old, Marcellus told me, and standing like nobody had ever been allowed to make her hurry. Her hair was white at the temples, black everywhere else. The black ribbon around her throat looked new.

Marcellus stopped beneath the arch.

"Isolde."

"You found the door this time."

Nigga took that one straight in the chest.

I looked at Tank. Tank looked at me. We both looked somewhere else because an old man's unfinished love deserved at least five seconds without two young niggas making faces at it.

Shawna stepped forward first.

"I'm Shawna."

"I know. I heard you sing to the harbor."

Isolde took her hands. "You made a frightened room breathe. That is harder than making a happy room clap."

My wife smiled, and I watched admiration pass between two women without either one getting smaller. I liked that shit. I

liked seeing Shawna recognized by somebody who knew what a thing cost before it looked easy.

Isolde turned to me.

"And you are the boy who drives on walls."

"Only when niggas put trucks on the road."

"Can you dance?"

"I'm married to her. You think she would have let me survive the wedding if I couldn't?"

"There is dancing," Isolde said, "and then there is entering a room without letting the room touch your feet."

Tank whispered, "Nigga, what?"

"Old people flirting," I whispered back. "Respect the language."

Marcellus heard both of us and gave me a look that said he still knew where sharp little tools lived.

Isolde led us to a table beneath a broken chandelier. On it lay seven colored stones in a velvet tray, a narrow strip of tarnished gold, and a photograph of a man in a crown smiling beside a dead leopard.

"Victor Bellanotte," she said. "He called himself the Ivory King."

"Nigga had a job?" I asked.

"Collecting what other people had made beautiful."

"That's a theft."

"Yes. He paid an orchestra to pronounce it differently."

She handed the gold strip to Marcellus. His face changed when he touched it.

"Where did you find this?"

"Where you left it."

The old nigga sat down slowly.

Isolde poured wine. Marcellus did not drink his. He turned the gold strip over and looked at seven little holes cut into its edge.

"Aiden," he said, "before I ever cut a stone for Celeste, I cut stones for people who thought a price could make an ugly man handsome. Bellanotte was the worst of them."

"How old were you?"

"Twenty-seven."

I looked him over. "Nigga, I bet you was unbearable."

Isolde laughed before he could answer.

"He had three silk shirts and spoke of them as an estate."

Marcellus finally drank the wine.

Then he told me what happened in that ballroom thirty-five years before I walked into it.



He had arrived on the island with a case of gems, a pistol he disliked carrying, and twenty dollars folded into his sock because every other dollar belonged to somebody who could find him.

Bellanotte wanted a new crown for the festival. Seven points, seven stones, each one the color of a different hour between sunset and dawn. Marcellus had been hired to repair its setting. Isolde had been hired to dance beneath it.

They met because she stole his dinner.

"Nigga," I said, "you married the wrong profession."

Marcellus raised an eyebrow.

"You a jeweler. She a dinner thief. Nigga, that's a complete household."

"We were not married."

"But a nigga was hopeful."

Isolde smiled. "A nigga was extremely hopeful."

Tank slapped my shoulder. "Old nigga blushing. Nigga, look at him."

"It was sitting unattended," she told me.

"It was beside my elbow," Marcellus said.

"Your elbow made no objection."

He said she had walked straight into the workshop, taken a pear from his plate, and bitten it while looking over his shoulder at a stone worth more than the building.

"You could live on that," she had told him.

"I am trying to."

"No. You could live somewhere else on that."

Marcellus had put his tool down. Of course the nigga put the tool down. A beautiful woman was looking at him like the whole room had narrowed to one lucky nigga, and the nigga wasn't about to keep filing metal. I knew that nigga. I had been that nigga. Half the things I owned came from trying to remain that nigga in front of Shawna.

"You greet every jeweler by suggesting robbery?"

"Only the pretty ones."

Nigga was done. I could hear it in his voice thirty-five years later. This woman had stolen one piece of fruit and his entire fucking evening.

They began meeting after the orchestra went home. Isolde taught him the dance Bellanotte loved most, a turning figure with seven changes of direction. Marcellus told her which jewels in the ballroom were real and which were expensive lies.

"The king's sapphire?" she asked.

"Glass."

"His ruby?"

"Also glass."

"His teeth?"

"Unfortunately real."

She laughed and led him through another turn.

One night Bellanotte came into the ballroom while they were dancing. Marcellus expected trouble. Instead the king clapped, slowly, and told him to keep going.

"A tradesman with manners," Bellanotte said. "How charming."

I felt my jaw tighten hearing it.

"I'd have hit that nigga," Tank said.

"At twenty-seven," Marcellus told him, "I had not yet learned how enjoyable that could be."

Bellanotte ordered the musicians back. He made them play while he watched the two young people turn beneath a crown neither of them would ever be permitted to wear. Then he took Isolde by the wrist and told her she belonged at his table for the festival.

She said no.

Not loud. Not frightened. Just no, the way Shawna could say a word and put a wall inside it.

The king smiled as if refusal were a local custom he might purchase later.

The next morning he locked the gate to her apartment.

Marcellus saw the gate and understood how much a pleasant voice could conceal.

"He thought possession was the same as being chosen," the old man said.

Isolde stared into her glass.

"He was not the first."

So they made a promise. After the festival, they would leave together. Marcellus would take the wages Bellanotte had refused to pay him. Isolde would take the jewels the king had been withholding from the dancers as security for their return.

Everybody else in the troupe would get their passports and passage off the island.

The king kept all of it in a chamber beneath the ballroom.

Marcellus had seen the entrance once. Bellanotte had opened it while wearing the crown, standing in a certain place on the floor. A narrow stair appeared beneath a table, and the king disappeared below it carrying a silver lamp.

"I thought the crown opened it," Marcellus told me. "I was only half right."

Isolde set the seven stones on the table, each in a different place.

"The dance," Shawna said.

Isolde smiled at her.

"The position of the feet. The order of the turns. The crown was a beautiful way to carry the pieces. The floor was the lock."

"Nigga built a dancing safe," I said.

"He wanted only his favorite people to be able to enter."

"Then why'd he put himself on the list?"

Marcellus laughed so suddenly wine went down the wrong way. Tank slapped his back with enough enthusiasm to cure diseases the man hadn't developed yet.

At the festival, Isolde wore the white dress from the photograph. Marcellus wore a dinner jacket borrowed from an orchestra conductor who did not know he had been generous.

They entered the ballroom while Bellanotte was giving a speech about beauty.

"I hated that speech," Isolde said. "Every year the same speech. Every year a longer crown."

Marcellus challenged him to dance.

I sat forward. "You did what?"

"I told him a king should be able to lead the woman he had asked to sit beside him."

"Oh, nigga."

"He had an audience," Marcellus said. "It made him stupid."

The king accepted. He took Isolde's hand and discovered, in front of two hundred guests, that owning an orchestra was not the same as hearing it. She moved; he chased. She turned; he staggered. The more he tried to hold her still, the worse he looked.

Then Marcellus stepped in.

"May I?"

He gave the king the borrowed conductor's jacket to hold and took Isolde across the floor.

They danced the seven turns. They moved past the pillars, over the colored squares, beneath the crown hanging on its stand. At the last turn Marcellus lifted the crown as if it were part of the performance and put it on Isolde's head.

The guests stood applauding.

Below the table, the little stair opened.

The king dropped the jacket.

"Now," Isolde said.

Her dancers began the loudest, wildest dance the ballroom had ever seen. Skirts whirled. Chairs moved. Somebody kicked a candle into a fountain and shouted fire with enough conviction to improve the confusion. Marcellus went down the stair carrying the silver lamp.

The chamber held money, jewels, letters, and the private promises of powerful people who had never imagined a jeweler would read them.

It also held an old man.

He sat on a stool beside the locked cabinets wearing a musician's black suit.

"You're late," the man said.

Marcellus raised the lamp.

It was the conductor whose jacket he had borrowed.

"I know," he said. "I'm sorry about the—"

"The escape," the conductor snapped. "For the escape. Take the blue case. The passports are underneath."

I slapped the table.

"Nigga had a whole orchestra helping him!"

Marcellus smiled, and for a second I could see the twenty-seven-year-old through the white hair.

"It was an excellent orchestra."

They got the dancers out. They got the cases up. But the king's guards came before Marcellus could cross the courtyard. A shot struck the lamp in his hand. Hot oil ran down his sleeve. Another shot hit the stone beside Isolde's head.

Marcellus pushed her through the garden gate and turned back for the conductor, who had fallen on the steps.

By the time he reached the harbor with the old man over his shoulder, the dancers' boat was gone.

Isolde had been told he was dead.

Marcellus had been told she had sailed without asking for him.

Two lies, delivered to people too young and hurt to know how much somebody wanted them apart.

"I wrote," she said now.

"So did I."

"Mine came back unopened."

"Mine did not come back at all."

The ballroom had gone very quiet around us.

"Bellanotte kept a porter named Varro," she said. "He sold information the way other men sold fish. I learned years later he had taken money to make certain letters disappear. By then I was married. You were married. We had different lives."

Marcellus looked at the ribbon in her hand.

"And now?"

"Now my husband has been dead eleven years, your wife is gone, and a fool in a general's uniform has begun asking the wrong men about the right floor."

He reached across the table and took her hand.

She let him.

I sat back and let the night into my lungs.

Nigga had danced a tyrant into holding his coat, robbed a king with an orchestra, and carried a conductor out of gunfire. This whole time I'd been calling him my jeweler like the old motherfucker came with a velvet pouch and instructions.

"Marcellus," I said.

He looked up.

"You was a dangerous nigga."

"He was a romantic," Isolde said.

"Same nigga with more paperwork," Tank said.

Marcellus laughed. "You young men think you invented extravagance."

"Nigga, I'm congratulating you. You robbed a king while the king held your jacket. That's advanced nigga. That's a nigga with electives."

The old man covered his face, laughing so hard the white jacket shook.

"Was?" Isolde asked.

Tank laughed. "Oh, she got him. She already got him."

Shawna moved the seven stones lightly with one finger.

"What is still down there?"

"The deeper vault," Isolde said. "Bellanotte's chamber was an anteroom. We never opened the old royal doors beyond it. He couldn't either. He had spent half his life pretending the treasure was his while searching for the way in."

She unfolded a drawing of an enormous pair of doors. Seven stars surrounded a crowned lion. Beneath it, a line of dancers crossed a bridge.

"Saint has men drilling beneath the palace," she said. "He thinks the competition will hide the noise and keep the island full of strangers. He hired me to judge the ballroom final because my name was in an old program. He does not know how much of it I remember."

"And the medal?" I asked.

Marcellus laid Saint's gold medal beside the old strip.

The seven points matched.

"He has part of the design," he said. "He does not have the dance or the stones."

I looked at the tray.

"We do."

"We have six originals," Isolde said. "The seventh was taken from my room this morning. A black stone. Saint calls it the Night Pearl."

Tank rubbed both hands over his face.

"Nigga couldn't just want the island. Nigga gotta want an underground dance bank."

"We get the stone," Shawna said.

"Then we dance," I said.

Isolde looked at my feet.

"First we find out whether that is a threat."

She put the music on.

I took Shawna into my arms. She knew how I moved; I knew the little breath she took before a turn. At first Isolde stopped us every eight steps. My shoulders were too square. My weight came too early. I was leading like I expected the floor to fight back.

"It usually does," I told her.

"Tonight, listen."

So I listened.

To the strings. To my wife's breath. To the small silver sound her heel made before she changed direction.

Then I felt it.

We moved together through the first turn without thinking about who had begun. Through the second, my hand at her back told her something she already wanted to hear. At the third she smiled right into my face, and I knew I had her.

"Nigga," she whispered. "There you are."

"Been right here."

"No. Now you're here."

By the seventh turn, Tank had stopped joking.

Rosa leaned against him watching us. Mercedes stood beside the old pillar with Porsche's arm through hers. Marcellus held Isolde's hand on the table and didn't seem to realize he was still holding it.

The music ended.

My wife stayed in my arms.

Isolde looked from my feet to my face.

"Well," she said.

"Say it," Tank told her.

She smiled.

"The boy can dance."

"Boy?" Rosa said. "That nigga opened the whole room up."

"Nigga just needed the right partner," Mercedes said.

"Nigga had the right partner," Tank said. "Nigga needed to stop fighting the floor."

I held Shawna closer. "The floor knows what kind of nigga it's dealing with now."

She smiled against my cheek. "So does this nigga's wife."

"Nigga can do everything," Tank said. "It's starting to hurt my feelings."

I kissed Shawna's forehead and looked down at the seven places where our feet had stopped.

One square sounded hollow beneath my shoe.

Far below us, something answered.

6. Nigga, I Also Know the Answer

The professor saw me coming and dropped his entire lecture.

Not the notes. The lecture. Forty minutes of prepared disrespect left that nigga's face before I even reached the table.

"Captain Aiden," he said.

"Professor."

"The valedictorian."

"Still me."

Behind him another professor leaned close. "That is the young man?"

"That nigga is the whole graduating class," Tank said.

"He attended—"

"Nigga attended when it mattered. Ask the gym."

I raised one hand. "Tank, let education breathe."

It was our second morning on the island. Saint had put the Seven Sciences Crown in an outdoor amphitheater overlooking the water. A dozen professors sat beneath white canopies. The competitors had desks, pencils, glasses of water, and expressions suggesting they had been told my application was a practical joke.

Mina Quill waved me toward the desk beside hers.

"I hoped you'd come."

"You trying to beat me at thinking?"

"Someone should try."

She had a smile that made competition feel like a good conversation with something sharp under the table.

I sat. Two niggas at the back whispered my name like it was an objection.

"That nigga took the science test?"

"Nigga hasn't taken it yet."

"Then why everybody clapping for the nigga?"

"Because he sat down beautifully."

I straightened my cuffs. Let a nigga appreciate form before content arrived.

Shawna took a seat in the front row wearing a black dress and my laurel from the pursuit race. Mercedes had lent it to her for the morning and warned the entire audience that they were looking at borrowed greatness.

Saint stood above us on the judges' balcony.

"Knowledge," he announced, "cannot be purchased with applause."

"Then stop shopping," I called.

The professor at my table bit the inside of his cheek so hard I thought the nigga might need stitches.

The first challenge was memory.

A wall opened behind the stage, revealing a room full of objects. Paintings. Books. A red shoe on a blue chair. Three clocks. An umbrella hanging upside down. A tray of jewels. We had one minute to look, then answer questions after the wall closed.

Niggas leaned forward, counting under their breath.

I looked.

I didn't try to hold every object separately. I walked through the room in my head like it belonged to somebody I intended to rob, love, or arrest. Those were the three reasons I'd learned to notice where a man kept things.

The shoe belonged to the woman in the left painting. The umbrella dripped onto a book about deserts. One clock had stopped at the hour on Saint's wristwatch. The jewels were arranged in colors I'd seen under the ballroom moonlight.

That last part wasn't an accident.

The wall shut.

"How many red objects?" the professor asked.

I answered.

"The title of the third book from the right?"

I answered.

"What was missing from the portrait above the fireplace?"

"A wedding ring on the man's hand. He wore one in the smaller portrait beside it. Somebody painted over it."

The professor looked down at his card.

"We were asking about the missing button."

"That too. Second one. Bad marriage, bad tailor. Nigga had a day."

Mina laughed into her water.

We tied the first round. Nobody else came close. One nigga answered a question nobody had asked. Another nigga drew the umbrella where the fireplace should have been. The nigga beside Mina kept looking at his own pencil like it had betrayed a long friendship. I respected the struggle. But a nigga couldn't give them his memory just because the niggas had come dressed for success.

Then they asked us to reproduce the room from memory on a blank board.

I drew the room. I drew the furniture. I drew the scratched corner of the jewel tray and the small shadow under the chair where a camera had been hidden.

The professor stared at that last mark.

"You saw the camera?"

"Nigga, it saw me. Seemed fair."

Mina examined my drawing afterward. "You remembered relationships."

"I remember who belongs beside who."

I looked at Shawna when I said it.

She rested her chin on her hand and smiled at me like I'd answered the only question on her examination.

The next challenge brought us onto a circular platform above the amphitheater pool. Three rings turned around a fixed center. Each ring had one white bridge painted across it. When all the bridges aligned, a competitor could walk straight from the center to the outer stairs.

"The inner ring completes a turn in eight seconds," the professor explained. "The middle in twelve. The outer in fifteen. When will all three return to their starting alignment?"

"Two minutes," I said.

The professor blinked.

Mina looked at me, then at the rings, then smiled. Eight, twelve, fifteen. One hundred twenty seconds. I could see her calculating the same clean meeting point.

"Correct," the professor said. "But there are further—"

The platform lurched.

A harsh mechanical sound came from beneath the stairs. The outer ring accelerated. The middle stopped. On the far side, one

of the older contestants fell to his knees as the surface moved under him.

The professor reached for his microphone.

It went dead.

Up on the balcony, Saint lowered his hand from a small black box.

Nigga wasn't even pretending the test was about intelligence anymore.

The railing beside the fallen contestant folded outward. Water shone below it, twelve feet down, shallow enough that falling badly would finish somebody's morning for good.

"Stay in the center!" Mina shouted.

I went the other way.

The rings weren't keeping their advertised times now. That didn't mean they had become unknowable. The scratches on the surface passed the same pillar again, then again. I watched the intervals, watched where the gaps met, and felt the rhythm the way I'd felt Shawna's heel on the ballroom floor.

Not every problem wanted paper.

Some niggas wrote the answer with their feet.

I crossed the first ring as it came under me. Jumped the narrow break to the second. The surface tried to carry me left. I went

with it until the outer ring's white bridge approached, then stepped into its motion instead of fighting it.

The fallen man looked up at me like I had arrived through a wall.

"How did you—"

"Later, professor. Give a nigga your hand."

He did.

The bridge swung past the broken railing. I held him upright and waited for the returning gap. Behind me the audience had gone quiet enough to hear the metal grinding.

One ring. Then the next.

I put the professor on the middle platform and followed him across before the surfaces separated. Mina met us at the center. She took his weight and guided him toward the little service stair that had remained fixed all along.

"The inner ring is safe for another six seconds," she said.

"Then six seconds is rich."

The professor clung to me. "Captain, I cannot—"

"Nigga, you can follow."

"I cannot calculate—"

"Nigga, I already calculated. All you gotta do is be the nigga following the nigga with the answer."

He followed. Smart nigga. Sometimes a nigga proves his intelligence by letting somebody else take the next step first.

We got the last contestant to the stair just as the outer railing tore away and crashed into the pool.

Nobody fell with it.

The audience finally remembered how to breathe.

Tank stood up on his chair.

"THAT NIGGA KNOW GEOMETRY!"

"Dynamics," Mina called back.

"HE KNOW THAT TOO!"

The professor I'd carried held my wrist in both hands.

"You saw the pattern while it was changing."

"Nigga, I drive in Vegas."

He laughed and began crying at the same time. I let him. A man could do both when he'd expected to meet the bottom of a swimming pool face first.

Saint came down from the balcony calling for a technical review. Knox intercepted him at the foot of the stairs.

"I'll take the box," she said.

"Chief, you are a guest."

"And you're holding my evidence."

For three seconds they looked at each other. Then Graves stepped beside her.

"Give her the box, General."

Saint's expression changed at the sound of his own captain's voice.

He handed it over.

The final round took place on dry ground because my wife went to the judges' table and said, "A chair. A table. Something that doesn't fucking move."

They gave us chess.

Mina sat opposite me beneath the white canopy. A camera looked straight down at the board. Around us, the audience settled into the strange silence people make when they expect intelligence to whisper.

"How long have you played?" she asked.

"Long enough to know the little horse starts arguments."

She smiled. "Then we'll get along."

She was very good.

Not stage good. Not a nigga with a trophy who got nervous when the room stopped agreeing. Mina put pressure on places I hadn't known would matter until three moves later. She offered me small victories with hooks hidden beneath them. I refused

the first two and took the third because I had something waiting on the other side.

At move nineteen she looked up.

"You saw that already?"

"Saw you seeing it."

She leaned back, delighted.

We played harder.

On the screen above us, somebody had begun drawing arrows between the pieces. The arrows multiplied until the board looked like twenty tiny wars had argued about directions. I didn't look. I watched Mina's hands. Watched the knight she wanted me to fear. Watched the square she had stopped looking at because she believed I'd forgotten it too.

I gave her my queen.

A nigga in the second row gasped like I'd handed Mina my bank card. The nigga beside him said sacrifice. First nigga said that was a very expensive word for fuck-up. Second nigga told first nigga to wait. I kept my face still. Niggas were about to discover the difference between losing a piece and making a whole room follow it.

Tank made a wounded noise from the audience.

"Nigga, your wife right there. You giving queens away?"

Rosa pulled him back into his seat.

Mina stared at the piece.

Then at me.

Then back at the board.

She took it because the other choices were worse.

Four moves later, she set her king gently on its side.

The amphitheater didn't understand at first. Then the commentator said checkmate, and the whole place rose like somebody had fired a starting gun beneath the seats.

Mina stood and offered me her hand.

"That was beautiful."

"Nigga, I told you about the horse."

She laughed, shook my hand, and leaned close enough that only I could hear the next words.

"The black stone in the memory room wasn't real. Someone exchanged it after you looked. I saw the tray when they opened the back wall."

My hand tightened around hers.

"Where's the real one?"

"Saint's music pavilion. A little case beneath the conductor's desk. I watched his steward carry it there before breakfast. I assumed it was a prize."

"You assume less than most niggas."

"I like to be correct."

Saint had to give me another laurel.

This time he didn't bother smiling.

The professors gathered around while he stood there. The older man I'd carried insisted I accept an honorary chair at his institute. Another wanted me to teach a seminar. A third asked if I would allow him to name a lecture hall after me.

"Nigga," I said, "put a window in it. I like a way out."

He wrote that down like it was architectural philosophy.

Shawna rescued me from the faculty by taking my hand and pulling me toward the harbor.

"You have an appointment," she said.

"With who?"

"Your wife and her piano."

That was a serious institution. I excused myself immediately.

The white yacht rocked gently at its berth. The blue piano stood beneath a little canopy, level as a table in a house. Tank's engineer had done whatever expensive magic my money had asked him to do. I didn't need the explanation. My wife sat down, touched the keys, and made the whole boat feel worth owning.

I leaned beside her.

"How's it sound?"

She played a low chord and let it travel through the wood.

"Like you listened."

I kissed the side of her head.

For ten minutes there were no generals. No crowns. No motherfucker trying to murder an algebra lesson. There was my wife playing music I had bought her a place to put, and my brother sitting on the stern with Rosa's feet in his lap, and Mercedes asleep in a chair she had claimed by draping a scarf over it.

Then Porsche came aboard wearing a purple hat wide enough to require its own ticket.

"The music pavilion," she said. "Saint invited me to his private reception tonight."

"Why?" Shawna asked.

Porsche tilted the hat.

"Baby, look at me."

Mercedes opened both eyes. "Nigga's about to explain his life to your neckline."

"Nigga already tried by telephone."

"This nigga never learns," Tank said.

Porsche smiled. "Some niggas teach themselves the wrong lesson every morning. I just arrive in time for the examination."

I looked at Shawna. "Nigga, we brought an excellent faculty."

We looked.

"Fair," I said.

She took the chair beside the piano. "He thinks I'll tell him which competitions make you nervous if he gives me a necklace."

Mercedes opened one eye.

"Make sure it's real."

"I asked for the black pearl."

I turned toward her.

Porsche smiled slowly.

"Nigga," she said, "I also know the answer."

7. She Stole the Pearl and I Stole the Show

Porsche told me the first king she ever disappointed bought her a horse.

"Why a horse?" I asked.

"He thought I liked riding."

Mercedes spat her drink into the harbor.

"Nigga misunderstood the entire profession," Tank said.

Porsche lifted one shoulder. "Beautiful horse, though. I kept him."

"What happened to the king?" Tank asked.

"Nigga wanted the horse back."

"Nigga lost the woman and asked for the horse?"

"Nigga thought the horse could still improve his reputation."

Mercedes shook her head. "Some niggas can't tell which part of the evening loved them."

"Horse didn't love him either," Porsche said. "Sensible animal."

We were on the yacht getting ready for Saint's reception. My wife sat at the blue piano with a silver comb between her teeth while Rosa pinned her hair. Mercedes wore green. Porsche wore

black, a dress that could have stopped a government if she had been interested in boring work.

"Listen to me," I told her. "You do not owe us a dangerous room because you know how to smile in one."

She turned toward me.

"Aiden. I know."

"Nigga can go get the stone."

"And he'll move it when he sees you coming. I can make him bring it to me. There's a difference."

Mercedes put her glass down. "She's very good at making a man think his idea just arrived wearing perfume."

Porsche smiled at her.

"Besides, he invited the wrong woman if he wanted somebody who would admire his chandelier for three hours. I'm taking his pearl and insulting the furniture."

Shawna removed the comb from her mouth.

"Then we stay close. All of us."

That was how it happened. Nobody sent a woman in alone and waited to hear which part of the plan had gone wrong. We dressed like money and went together.

Saint's pavilion stood where Alma's garden used to be. Glass walls opened to the sea. A red carpet ran between two rows of palm trees. Inside, gold instruments hung above the stage, and

the dining tables were so polished a nigga could see how vain he looked before he sat down.

Saint greeted Porsche at the door.

"You are more beautiful than your photographs."

"You're taller than your portrait," she said.

He was shorter than his portrait by approximately a house.

The nigga loved it.

He took her hand and led her toward a private table beneath the conductor's balcony. Mercedes followed carrying two glasses, moving like Porsche's evening had already required rescuing from dull conversation.

Onstage, Master Silk rehearsed his entrance.

Silk was a singer, rapper, producer, and the owner of twelve pairs of sunglasses he wore indoors to protect his eyes from other people's accomplishments. Forty-two years old and convinced the world had begun recording sound when he first cleared his throat.

He saw Shawna and lowered his microphone.

"You're the island girl."

"I'm Shawna."

"I heard the harbor thing. Nice emotion. Small song."

I turned.

Shawna caught my sleeve without looking at me.

"Let him finish," she said.

Silk smiled. Poor nigga thought permission meant safety.

"I do arenas," he said. "Different scale."

Rosa looked around the pavilion. "Then why your ass in a garden?"

Tank had to walk away before his laugh became a public insult.

The music trial began after dinner. Three performers. Three songs. The audience chose by raising lanterns, filling the glass room with whichever color belonged to the singer they wanted crowned.

Silk went first.

He was good. I wasn't going to lie just because the nigga had invited consequences. His voice filled the room. His band hit hard. He came off the stage, sang to the front tables, and made a woman drop a spoon into her own cleavage. Everybody applauded when he finished.

Then Rosa stepped up.

She had written something while Tank slept beside her the night before. I knew because she'd asked me how to make a line rhyme with stubborn without using a word that sounded like a medical condition.

She sang about a man whose hands could break a door but always slowed down before touching her face.

Tank stopped smiling.

She sang about sleeping in rooms she never wanted to wake up in and finding one she hated leaving. No apology in it. No begging anybody to consider her worthy. She knew what her life had been. She knew who had met her there and stayed.

Then she looked straight at Tank and sang the part about his terrible snoring.

The room laughed. He laughed too, with tears already in his eyes, the big nigga unable to decide which feeling deserved the most space.

Her lanterns went up red.

Hundreds of them.

Shawna went last.

She sat at the piano they had put onstage and touched one key. Frowned. Touched another.

"This is out of tune," she said.

Silk leaned back in his chair.

"Professional rooms have surprises."

Shawna looked at him.

Then at me.

I knew that look. Nigga, that look had cost me houses.

"Bring the blue one," I said.

Saint stood halfway up.

"The trial cannot be delayed for—"

Outside the glass wall, Tank's engineer was already signaling the dock crew.

The yacht eased alongside the pavilion's waterside terrace. The blue piano stood beneath its canopy, white deck glowing around it. Instead of bringing the instrument inside, Shawna walked outside and sat down with the sea behind her.

Every head turned.

Nigga wanted scale. My wife had brought the fucking ocean. Some nigga at the back stood to get a better look, and the nigga behind him stood too, and then every nigga in that room was upright like the sea itself had entered wearing her name. Silk looked at the yacht. Looked at me. Nigga was doing arithmetic with the wrong numbers. You can't subtract a husband from the thing his wife just made beautiful.

Her first note came across the water clean enough to hurt.

She played her own introduction, slow and sure. Then she sang a song about coming home to someone who kept changing the shape of home because he wanted to give her more places to be happy.

She didn't make me sound sensible. Thank God. She sang about the blue piano, the ruined cars, the way I kept buying views and then standing in front of them because I wanted her looking at me.

People laughed where she wanted them to laugh.

Then she sang, very simply, that she would have chosen me in a room without a window.

I forgot the audience.

I forgot Saint.

For a few seconds a nigga who owned an island wanted nothing bigger than the space between her hands on the keys.

When she finished, the blue lanterns rose so quickly the room looked underwater.

Silk watched them climb.

"Damn," he said.

"Nigga," I told him, "there's your scale."

He stood and applauded her himself.

Across the room, Porsche touched Saint's wrist and said something that made him smile. Mercedes caught my eye once. The pearl was coming out.

Before I could move, Silk took the microphone again.

"The lady wins," he said. "But her husband has been talking all evening. Let's see if the captain can keep a beat without a siren."

The room turned toward me.

Shawna rested her elbows on the piano and smiled.

"Go ahead, baby."

Nigga had challenged me in front of my wife after she told a whole room she'd choose me broke. There was no universe where I sat down.

I took the microphone.

"What you want, Silk?"

"Sixteen bars."

"Nigga, I got houses with less room than that."

His drummer laughed and gave me a beat.

I let it run once. Felt where the bass sat. Felt the crowd waiting to see whether I was about to become a story they could tell against me.

Then I began.

"Nigga, I came home, the whole road stood up,

"Chief gave me a key and the damn key couldn't shut,

"Won a whole island, put my wife above the tide,

"Nigga brought a navy just to ask if he could slide.

"Captain on my chest, little lightning in the ride,

"But my woman says sit down, that's the law I won't defy.

"Nigga got a crown with another crown inside,

"I got Shawna saying baby, tell me who you think is fly.

"Nigga asked for sixteen, I brought streets you couldn't buy,

"Nigga got a moonroof, I put roads across the sky,

"Niggas try to name me, every name comes with a crown,

"But the nigga wearing all of them still ten toes down.

"Nigga, ask my brother why the whole room knows his name,

"Nigga, ask his woman why her heart's a little flame,

"Nigga, ask my wife if I can stay when we get home,

"She said baby, all that greatness and you still can't leave me alone."

The room broke open.

Tank jumped onto his chair. Rosa grabbed his belt before the nigga could become a safety issue.

I kept going. About the professor crying, the truck in the goat ditch, Mercedes catching flags while adjusting her hair. I put Darius on the canvas again in a rhyme and gave him so much credit he would have had to smile hearing it. I made the ruined side of my Lamborghini sound like jewelry.

Silk's drummer sped up.

I went with him.

His bassist followed.

I went faster.

The whole band was looking at me now, grinning, daring a nigga to find another corner in the beat. I found it. Turned it. Came out facing the crowd with my wife's name sitting exactly where the downbeat landed.

Silk took his sunglasses off.

I gave the microphone back.

"Nigga," he said.

"I know."

"No, nigga."

"I know that one too."

He laughed and hugged me.

Then the first shot came from the conductor's balcony.

The sound cut through the last note like a hand tearing cloth.

Glass burst over the private table. Porsche ducked beneath Saint's arm and came out holding a black stone between two fingers. Saint reached for her wrist. Mercedes threw an entire silver bowl of chilled fruit into his face.

Nigga got hit by dessert in front of three hundred witnesses.

Porsche ran.

I threw Silk behind the piano bench as another shot struck the wall. Tank overturned the nearest table, making a barrier between the gunman and the crowd. Rosa grabbed the microphone.

"Down the terrace! Keep moving! Leave the fucking lanterns!"

People obeyed her because Rosa could make a direction sound like the only intelligent thing a person had ever been offered.

Saint's men came through the side doors.

Graves met the first one with a punch that turned the man back through the same door. Knox drew her gun beside him. Their shoulders touched; neither moved away.

"Still on leave?" Graves asked.

"Having a marvelous time," she said.

I fired toward the balcony. The gunman ducked behind the gold organ pipes hanging above the stage. My next shots knocked two pipes loose. They fell across the balcony rail with a roar that sounded like God clearing his throat.

The gunman ran.

Porsche slid across the stage in her black dress and came up beside me.

"Got it."

"Nigga, I saw."

"You saw how the nigga grabbed?"

"Saw how the nigga missed."

"Nigga thought the pearl came with ownership."

"Nigga got neither," I said.

She smiled, fierce and breathing hard. "That's the part I wanted the nigga to understand."

Another shot struck the stage. We moved together before the echo finished.

"He wanted a kiss first."

"What'd you tell him?"

"He could kiss my ass at market value."

Mercedes arrived carrying a gold champagne bucket.

"Why you got that?" I asked.

"I hit a man with it and liked the balance."

A guard came around the fallen pipes. She demonstrated. The nigga folded beside the stage with a dinner mint stuck to his lapel.

Shawna had brought the yacht tight against the terrace.

Crewmen helped guests across the gap. Mina Quill stood on the deck counting heads as people came aboard. The island captains formed a line along the glass wall, returning fire whenever Saint's men tried to come through.

They weren't his men anymore. Not the captains.

They had seen enough.

I crossed the stage toward the water with Porsche and Mercedes beside me. Saint stood behind his overturned table, white jacket stained with peaches, staring at the pearl in Porsche's hand.

"You don't understand what you have," he shouted.

Porsche looked back.

"A better offer, baby."

Then we were on the yacht.

I jumped last. A shot struck the rail behind me. Shawna caught my jacket and pulled me into her arms as the yacht moved clear of the terrace.

For a second her face was all I could see.

"Your song," I said, breathing hard.

"Later."

"Baby, that shit—"

"Later, Aiden."

She kissed me once, fierce enough to interrupt a man in the middle of his own heart.

On the stern, Tank looked back at the pavilion and shook his head.

"Nigga invited us to dinner and lost a pearl, a concert, three tables, and all his police."

Silk stood beside him holding his ruined sunglasses.

"And a rap battle."

Mercedes lifted the champagne bucket.

"And this."

Silk looked at the people on the deck. "Nigga, is this every party with you?"

"Some niggas bring a bad mood," I said. "Some niggas bring a whole gun crew."

"And your niggas just keep the music going?"

Rosa lifted the microphone she'd brought aboard. "Nigga, we haven't done the encore."

Silk laughed so hard he sat down on the deck. That nigga had found his kind of audience at last.

The yacht carried us into the dark with Shawna's blue piano untouched and Porsche's black pearl resting in my palm.

Behind us, the audience on the far shore began singing my wife's chorus.

They had seen the gunfire.

They had seen who stayed to bring them out.

And nigga, they knew exactly whose song they wanted to take home.

8. The Floor Got Jealous of My Feet

Saint escaped his own dinner in a submarine the size of a limousine. Nigga went underwater to avoid being embarrassed on land. I watched the little hatch close and pictured this decorated nigga crouching beside some other nigga while peaches dried in his beard. A nigga could sink below the sea, but the story of that dinner was already swimming faster than him.

Porsche found that personally offensive.

"Nigga had a submarine and still spent twenty minutes telling me about the chandelier."

We stood on the yacht watching its little black shape disappear beneath the harbor lights. Graves had seen it leave the pavilion's hidden lower berth. By the time he reached the water, the general was gone.

"His ships will protect him," Graves said.

"From what?" Tank asked. "A dinner review? Nigga got fruit in his beard."

"He has soldiers on every deck."

I looked toward the white fleet. Twelve ships, their lights bright against the black sea. Saint had come to take my island without putting his own shoes in the mud. Now he was hiding under it

because Porsche knew the difference between a compliment and a man reaching for her wrist.

"He'll come back," I said.

"How do you know?" Mina asked.

I lifted the black pearl.

"Nigga left his reason."

By midnight Knox and the captains had the palace gates. The island police stood beside them. Saint's remaining men put down their guns when they realized the crowd behind us included every worker who knew where the exits were.

We didn't cancel the championship. Niggas had crossed oceans to race, sing, fight, fall in love, and lose bets they shouldn't have made in the first place. One frightened nigga on a submarine wasn't about to send all them hopeful niggas home. I told the captains exactly that. Nigga by nigga, they nodded. Even the nigga who still wanted my autograph put his cap away long enough to agree.

Alma came to me with flour on her hands and asked whether she should throw out the food for the next morning.

"Nigga, throw out what?" I said.

"If the festival is over—"

"The festival belongs to us now. Cook everything."

She kissed my cheek and went away smiling.

The competitors stayed too. Some because they wanted to win. Some because they wanted to see what I would do next. Silk said he had never been at a music festival where the headline act also removed the gunmen, and he intended to get a verse out of the experience.

Saint's voice came over the island speakers at one in the morning.

"The challenges continue," he announced. "No crown will be recognized without the founder's final judgment."

I took a microphone from Rosa.

"Nigga, come judge in person."

The island laughed loud enough to reach his ships.

Then I turned the speakers over to Silk and let him play music while people danced in the square. If Saint wanted to listen from his boat, he could buy the album like everybody else.

We went up to the old ballroom before dawn.

Isolde waited with the six stones laid out on a white cloth. Marcellus stood beside her wearing the same dinner jacket, now wrinkled at the elbows because he'd spent the night helping carry frightened people off the yacht.

Porsche placed the black pearl in the empty space.

"One ugly man's favorite conversation piece," she said.

Isolde touched it gently.

"You are certain he gave you this?"

"He put it in my hand. Then he changed his mind. I respect a man's first instinct."

Mercedes set the stolen champagne bucket beside the cloth.

"And a vase."

Nobody asked why she was still carrying it. Some victories wanted witnesses.

Marcellus arranged the stones along the tarnished gold strip. They settled into their old places with tiny clicks. The last one, black as the sea outside, completed a narrow crescent of color.

"The crown was broken after Bellanotte died," he said. "This part is enough for the first door."

"What killed him?" Tank asked.

"His heart."

"Nigga finally met an opponent."

Isolde held out her hand to me.

"Let us see what you remember."

I took it.

She corrected my shoulder before the music began.

"You are expecting gunfire."

"It's been a popular song lately."

"For seven turns, expect me."

So I did.

She was light on her feet without being fragile. Every movement told me where the next one could live. I followed once, then again. By the third turn I could feel the shape of the dance coming back through my body, the way a road feels familiar before you recognize the building at its corner.

We stopped on the final square.

The floor rang beneath us.

"Good," she said.

Then she gave my hand to Shawna.

"Now do it with the woman you are actually listening for."

My wife stepped into my arms.

"Don't embarrass me," she whispered.

"Nigga, you married the floor's favorite man."

"The floor can wait its turn."

Rosa laughed behind the piano. She had taken over the music, slowing the opening bars until our breathing found them.

First turn, the gold strip in Marcellus's hand caught the lantern light.

Second, Isolde placed its stones into the shallow hollows around the pillar.

Third, something below us moved.

Shawna felt it through the sole of her shoe. Her eyes met mine.

"Keep going," she said.

Fourth, fifth. The old marble answered with a low mechanical hum.

Sixth, I brought her around the broken column, her dress brushing my leg, her hand firm against my shoulder.

Seventh, we stopped together.

The table at the center of the room slid backward.

Beneath it, a stair opened into darkness.

Tank stared.

"Nigga just slow-danced a building open."

Mercedes folded her arms.

"Saint brought drills."

"Nigga brought drills," Tank repeated, increasingly delighted.

"Aiden brought his wife."

Marcellus stood looking down the steps. The last time he'd seen them, he'd been twenty-seven, carrying a lamp, expecting a whole different life to meet him at the harbor.

Isolde took his hand.

"This time," she said, "we leave together."

He nodded.

I went first with Graves behind me. Tank followed, then the others. The stair smelled of old stone and sea air. Water had found its way into the walls, leaving pale lines like the room had been counting the tides.

The antechamber was almost exactly as Marcellus had described it. Cabinets. A stool. The remains of a lamp blackened on one side. A conductor's baton lay in a cracked velvet case on the table.

Marcellus picked it up.

"He came back," he said softly.

"Who?" I asked.

"The conductor. Bellanotte must have had him return to the palace after we left."

Isolde opened the case. Beneath the baton lay a folded sheet in an old man's handwriting.

Marcellus read it aloud.

"To the two young fools who gave an old musician one excellent night. The king is dead. His son sold the coast. The men who bought it have no patience for music, so they will never find what his father hid. I have kept the last path for people who know how to share a room. If you return, follow the river beneath the lion. And Marcellus, the jacket was worth more than twenty dollars."

Tank laughed quietly.

The old man wiped his eyes with the back of his hand.

There was a drawing on the other side. A river. A lion. Three little bridges leading toward a pair of enormous doors.

The Vault of Kings.

Not a metaphor. Not a man selling an expensive story about an empty hole. Beyond the cabinets, the far wall held a carved lion large enough for a man to stand in its shadow. Beneath its paws, a narrow passage sloped downward toward running water.

I shone my light into it.

The floor glittered.

Gold coins lay in the shallow water like somebody had dropped a handful and decided he was rich enough not to bend over.

"Nigga," Tank said.

"Yeah."

"No, nigga."

"I see it."

"I don't think you seeing the amount of nigga I am currently experiencing."

Porsche crouched and lifted a coin. One side bore the crowned lion. The other showed a ship sailing under seven stars.

"Pretty," she said.

Marcellus took it carefully. "Old."

Mercedes smiled. "Those words get along beautifully."

We followed the passage to the first bridge.

An underground river crossed the cavern ahead. Above it, three stone arches climbed toward a dark platform on the opposite side. On that platform stood the vault doors, taller than the yacht's mast, made of black metal veined with dull gold.

Between the doors sat a round red stone.

Except it wasn't a stone.

It was an empty setting.

Isolde drew in a breath.

"The Lion's Heart."

"Where's the heart?" I asked.

Graves answered from beside me.

"Around Saint's neck. He wears it beneath his medals. I saw it once when he was injured during a tournament."

The general had the last piece. Nigga had been walking around with a door handle on his chest calling it destiny. All them medals, all them speeches, and the nigga's most useful possession was a necklace somebody needed to put in a wall. I wanted to tell him so badly my teeth hurt. But first a nigga had to reach the nigga, and Saint had brought eleven spare boats to complicate being reached.

Of course the nigga did. A man couldn't own twelve ships without finding something smaller to be insecure about.

I looked at the bridges. Two were broken halfway across. The third stood intact, narrow and wet, rising in a clean curve toward the doors.

"We know where," I said. "Now we know what. That's more than he knows."

A light appeared at the far end of the cavern.

Then another.

Graves pushed me sideways as the first shot struck the wall.

Saint's digging crew had found a side passage.

They came through it in helmets and dark uniforms, guns flashing over the river. I pulled Shawna behind a stone column. She took Isolde with her. Tank shoved Marcellus down behind the bridge rail and returned fire.

The chamber roared.

"Nigga brought drills and guns," Tank shouted.

"Still can't dance," I said.

Graves ducked beside me. "You are joking now?"

"Nigga, the bullets started before the joke. Don't blame comedy."

"These men are trying to kill us."

"Then don't let these niggas interrupt. You cover that side, I cover this side, Tank covers whatever a nigga shouldn't be able to lift."

Tank grunted from the bridge. "Nigga, I heard that."

I moved along the near bank while Graves kept the gunmen from crossing. Water splashed around my shoes. The stone was slick. My light rolled from my hand and shone upward, catching the gold veins on the doors like lightning trapped in a wall.

One gunman reached the intact bridge.

I met him halfway.

He swung the butt of his rifle. I caught the blow on my shoulder, drove into him, and felt the bridge rail give beneath our weight. For one second both of us leaned over the river with nothing but my hand on a broken stone between us and the water.

He looked at my face.

"You," he said.

"Nigga, who were you hoping for?"

I dragged him back onto the bridge and hit him hard enough to end the conversation.

Behind him a second man raised his gun.

Shawna's shot broke the lantern above his head. Darkness swallowed his aim. Graves took him down before he found it again.

My wife looked across the chamber at me.

"One piece," she called.

"Still counting right," I called back.

The gunmen retreated into their passage, dragging two wounded men with them. I could have followed. I wanted to follow. Every part of my body that enjoyed an argument wanted to put Saint's whole digging crew against a wall.

Then I heard Isolde cry out.

A fallen stone had struck Marcellus's leg. He was awake, furious, and unable to stand.

I went back.

Tank lifted the stone. I took Marcellus under the shoulders. The old nigga tried to object until Isolde said his name in a voice that had apparently survived thirty-five years without losing any authority.

He shut up.

We carried him out together.

At the top of the stair, the sky had begun to pale. Rosa helped Shawna close the hidden door while Knox's officers spread across the garden. The ballroom returned to looking like a ruin somebody might photograph and misunderstand.

Marcellus sat on the low wall with his trouser leg rolled up. Bruised, bleeding a little, still arguing that he could walk. Isolde knelt beside him and tied a clean cloth around the cut.

"You came back for me," she said.

He looked at her.

"I was always coming back."

She kissed him before he could say anything else.

Tank turned away, grinning like a nigga trying to give two old people privacy while needing every detail.

My phone vibrated.

Saint, on video, aboard his ship. A red stone hung against his bare throat. The Lion's Heart. He had taken off his medals so I would be certain to see it.

"You have found my door," he said.

"Nigga, the deed says mine."

"Then earn the key. Continue winning. Reach the final challenge. Face me before the whole world."

"Or I come out there and take your necklace."

He moved the camera toward the decks behind him. Armed men stood beside the ship's rail. Beyond them, the other eleven ships held their places around the island.

"You may try."

I looked past his face at the ships.

At the launch hanging from the nearest crane.

At the sailor beside it who was listening instead of looking at the general.

I smiled.

"Oh, nigga," I said. "I intend to."

I ended the call and turned toward my people.

Shawna stood barefoot on the old dance floor, my gun in one hand, the seven stones wrapped safely in the other. Tank had an arm around Rosa. Mercedes and Porsche leaned together beneath the broken arch. Knox and Graves watched the sea. Marcellus had Isolde's lipstick on his mouth and thirty-five years less loneliness in his face.

The general thought he had an army.

Nigga, I had everybody I wanted beside me.

And the morning hadn't even started yet.

9. My Brother Put a Ring on the Whole Damn Night

Tank practiced proposing to a coconut. My nigga had fought men whose shoulders needed separate introductions. My nigga had driven into gunfire because I called his name. Now this nigga stood in a kitchen worrying whether a piece of fruit would accept his future. Some niggas fear death. My nigga feared getting the words wrong for a woman who already knew his whole heart.

I found him behind the yacht's kitchen at eight in the morning, holding Marcellus's ring box in one enormous hand and looking at a coconut on the counter like the coconut had standards he might not meet.

"Rosa," he said, "you know I ain't always been—"

"Nigga, don't apologize to the fruit."

He spun around.

"How long you been there?"

"Long enough to know that coconut ain't ready for commitment."

He closed the box and put it in his pocket. I leaned against the door while the yacht rocked gently under us. Outside, somebody was practicing a trumpet badly. Silk had agreed to help the

island band and now had a whole brass section making him reconsider his generosity.

Tank rubbed his hands together.

"I need it right."

"It is right."

"Nigga, you proposed like you was declaring war on loneliness. You had the house, the flowers, the whole—"

"I was scared too."

He stopped.

"You?"

"Nigga, I can drive off a roof. A roof don't decide it wants somebody else."

Tank looked down at his pocket.

"She deserves something big."

"She picked you. How much bigger you trying to get?"

He laughed despite himself.

The door opened behind me. Rosa stood there in a loose shirt with her hair tied up, looking from us to the coconut.

"What are y'all doing?"

Tank grabbed the coconut.

"Breakfast."

"With no knife?"

He broke it in half with his hands.

Milk went all over the counter.

Rosa stared.

Then she looked at me.

"Why is my man frightened of breakfast?"

"Nigga's exploring himself," I said.

She took half the coconut and kissed his cheek.

"Explore with a towel."

That afternoon we entered the Brothers' Cup.

The name was a lie. Half the teams weren't brothers. One pair were ex-husbands who said fighting together had improved their divorce. Another pair hated each other so loudly the announcer introduced them separately to prevent an argument about whose name should come first.

Tank and me didn't have paperwork making us brothers.

We had blood we'd kept inside each other. We had nights no family album wanted. We had the sound of that old Mercedes coming back when any sensible nigga would have kept driving.

I didn't need the announcer to define shit. This nigga knew when my smile meant fine and when it meant get the car. This nigga could hear my wife's name in the way I stopped talking. Niggas I

was related to by blood hadn't stood where Tank stood. A nigga couldn't print that on a program. But every nigga who had watched us walk through a bad night knew which man belonged beside me.

The arena stood on the beach under an open roof. Sand blew against the outside walls. Inside, the fighting floor was padded blue, surrounded by ropes and a thousand people who had brought drinks because they trusted us to make an afternoon worth attending.

Knox sat at ringside beside Graves. Both had their uniforms open at the throat. Mina Quill was eating ice from a paper cup and studying the brackets as if the fighters were a difficult equation.

Shawna sat in the front row with Rosa, Mercedes, and Porsche. All four wore sunglasses. All four looked expensive enough to make a man improve his posture before passing them.

Our first opponents came in wearing matching red masks.

One was tall. The other was shorter and louder, which is how a lot of niggas try to fix height.

"We are the Red Brothers!" the short one shouted.

Tank looked at the announcer.

"Is that information or a warning?"

The bell rang.

The tall one tried to tackle me. I stepped aside and helped his enthusiasm find the corner pad. The short one came at Tank with a spinning kick so elaborate I thought there might be a second show starting inside our fight.

Tank caught him.

Just caught the nigga.

Held him sideways for a second while the man's legs kept trying to finish the kick.

"You done?" Tank asked.

The man stopped moving.

Tank put him down outside the ropes.

The tall brother looked at his partner. Looked at me. Raised one hand.

"We concede."

The crowd booed because the drinks weren't even cold yet.

"Nigga, fight!" somebody shouted.

The short Red Brother looked at the nigga. Looked at Tank. Looked back at the nigga.

"You fight him."

That nigga sat down.

"Wise nigga," Mercedes said. "The wisdom spreading."

Tank lifted both hands. "I ain't doing nothing to these niggas but helping them discover themselves."

"Respect intelligent niggas," I told them.

Our second match lasted longer. The divorced husbands knew each other's habits so well they could argue and attack on the same breath. One would complain that the other always went left, then go right because he knew his ex was lying about the complaint.

They caught Tank once between them and sent him into the ropes. I met them coming back. The quicker one ducked my first strike. The stronger one reached for my waist. I turned through the space they'd left, brought the strong one down, and heard his ex shout, "I TOLD YOU HE WOULD SEE THAT."

Tank laughed so hard he nearly got hit again.

We won when both men tried to prove they should have been in charge and collided in front of me.

Afterward I helped them up.

"Y'all ever think about getting back together?"

They answered no at exactly the same time.

"Best teamwork all day," I said.

By the final, the beach crowd had doubled. People stood on chairs and on the low sea wall, shouting our names. Somebody had made Tank a sign that said BIG MAN, BIGGER HEART.

He pretended not to see it until Rosa lifted both hands and pointed at the words.

Our final opponents did not wear masks.

They didn't need them.

Kong Harrow stood seven feet tall and looked like a mountain had learned to dislike people. Beside him, Dietrich Stone rolled his shoulders under a robe the size of a bedspread. Both were veteran champions, both older than us, both smiling the calm smile of men who expected our afternoon to end beneath them.

Kong looked at me.

"No lightning."

"Nigga, you brought enough electricity in those shoulders."

"Your car cannot help you here."

"Neither can your tailor. Let's quit discussing absent people."

The bell rang.

Kong hit me before I finished moving my left foot.

Not clean. I turned enough to keep my head attached to the rest of the investment. But the blow landed across my guard and sent a bright pain down both arms.

Nigga was strong.

Really strong.

I heard the crowd react and felt him enjoy it.

He came again. I moved, let the first shot pass, took the second on my shoulder, and answered to his body. He grunted but barely shifted. Beside us, Dietrich drove Tank toward the ropes. For a few seconds the whole world looked like two larger men carrying two smaller problems toward a sensible conclusion. Then Tank planted his feet.

I knew that moment. I'd seen it in alleys, hospital rooms, beside a car with a ruined door. It was the moment my brother decided the world had pushed far enough.

Dietrich tried again.

Tank didn't move.

The crowd rose halfway from its seats.

I smiled at Kong.

"Your friend about to learn something."

He swung.

I went under the blow and came up inside his reach. Short strike. Turn. Another strike before he could bring the mountain around. He caught my shoulder and tried to throw me. I stayed with him, changed the direction, and put the big nigga on one knee.

The floor shook.

Kong looked up at me, surprised for the first time.

"There," I said. "Now we can talk comfortably."

He laughed and got up.

The next minute was work.

Sweat in my eyes. Breath burning. My old scar pulling whenever I turned too far. Kong wasn't stupid. He learned. Each thing I did once became harder the next time. I couldn't beat him by being pretty about the same move forever.

So I gave him something new.

I let him think he had my balance. Let him commit that huge body to finishing the thought. Then I moved where his own weight wanted him to go and took the support away from underneath it.

He hit the mat on his back.

The arena went wild.

I didn't stand over him admiring the picture. I got control before he could recover, held through the first enormous effort to throw me off, and waited until his hand struck the mat.

Once. Twice.

The referee pulled us apart.

Kong sat up breathing like a storm.

A nigga near the ropes whispered, "He put that whole nigga down."

"Twice," another nigga said.

"Nigga, I saw once."

"First the knee. Then the whole nigga. That's two floors of nigga."

Kong heard them and laughed, still fighting for breath. A proud nigga could hate losing and still appreciate the particular motherfucker who had done it.

"You are very good," he said.

"Nigga, I'm trying to impress my wife."

He looked toward Shawna.

"Reasonable."

On the other side of the floor, Tank and Dietrich were still standing chest to chest. Neither wanted to give the crowd the pleasure of watching him step back.

Rosa stood.

"Baby," she called, "I got dinner plans."

Tank's eyes changed.

He caught Dietrich's next rush, lifted the man clean off the floor, and put him down so hard the announcer dropped his microphone.

Dietrich lay there staring at the roof.

Tank leaned over him.

"Nigga, I gotta eat."

The referee counted.

At ten, my brother raised both fists and looked straight at Rosa.

The whole beach seemed to stand with him.

They brought us two laurels and a trophy shaped like clasped hands. I took the trophy. Tank took his laurel, put it over Rosa's head as she came through the ropes, and reached into the little pouch he had tied beneath his fighting shorts.

Rosa's expression changed.

"Tank?"

He brought out the ring box.

The crowd got quiet unevenly, pockets of silence spreading as people understood what the big man was holding.

Tank looked at me once.

I nodded.

Nigga had walked into gunfire beside me. Now he had to take the last step himself.

He went down on one knee.

Some nigga in the back shouted that Tank was hurt. Three niggas told that nigga to shut up. Another nigga saw the box and put both hands on his own head like he was about to receive the ring personally. I watched the happiness travel through them, nigga to nigga, every man finding some unfinished part of his own life in the way my brother looked up at Rosa.

The arena roof almost came off from the sound.

"Rosa," he said.

Then stopped.

She covered her mouth.

He looked at the ring. Looked at her. Took a breath so big I could see it move his whole back.

"I practiced a lot of shit."

She laughed through the tears already gathering.

"I know. You broke breakfast."

"Nigga," he whispered, mostly to himself.

Then he looked right into her face.

"I want you there when it's quiet. I want you there when I'm old. I want you there when my knees don't work, which might be Tuesday after fighting that motherfucker."

The crowd laughed with her.

"I want to learn everything you still want. I want to be the man you wake up and bother for the rest of your life. Baby, will you marry me?"

She was nodding before he finished.

"Yes. Yes, you big beautiful idiot. Yes."

He tried to put the ring on her right hand.

She gave him the left without stopping her tears.

"That one, baby."

"I know. I knew."

"Nigga did not know," Mercedes whispered beside me.

Porsche elbowed her, crying herself.

Tank got the ring on. Rosa pulled him up and kissed him so hard the big man staggered, victorious in a fight and completely defeated by the woman he'd wanted waiting after it.

I stood there holding the trophy with my wife beneath my arm.

Shawna pressed her face into my shoulder.

"You helped him," she said.

"He did it."

"I know. You helped him believe he could."

I watched Tank lift Rosa off the floor, careful with her despite all the strength he'd spent proving he possessed.

That was my brother.

My nigga.

The whole island chanted his name while he held his future against his chest.

For once, when people started shouting Aiden too, I pointed at him and made them get the evening right.

"TANK," I shouted.

They answered.

"ROSA."

They answered louder.

And my brother looked at me over her shoulder with a happiness so naked it made every ugly mile we'd traveled together feel like a road that had finally reached somewhere.

10. Nigga, I Fed the Navy

The first enemy ship surrendered because its captain wanted a second plate. Nigga tasted the food, looked at the flag, and reconsidered who deserved his loyalty. That's how Tank tells it. Nigga skips the fire. Nigga skips the smoke. Nigga skips the whole part where another nigga tried dying beside a door. My brother likes a clean story, and apparently a nigga feeding the navy is clean enough for him.

That's the short version. Niggas who weren't there love the short version because it leaves enough room for them to pretend they would have done the same thing.

The long version began with a French chef calling my apron disrespectful.

Lucien Brûlée stood beside the outdoor cooking stage with his arms folded. Forty-six years old, twelve championship medals, a white hat tall enough to contain an unfinished apartment. His apron had his name embroidered on it.

Mine said ASK MY WIFE.

Shawna had given it to me that morning.

"This is a serious competition," Lucien said.

"Nigga, marriage is serious too. Read the authority."

A young chef beside Lucien looked at my apron. "You really ask her?"

"Nigga, about everything."

"Everything?"

"Nigga, the apron ain't a rumor."

Shawna smiled from the front row. Lucien looked at her, then at me, and understood one thing before understanding any of my cooking: this nigga had a reason to make the meal good.

The audience laughed. He did not.

Behind us the harbor market had become a festival kitchen.

Copper pans hung over long tables. Fresh fish lay on ice.

Baskets of peppers, fruit, herbs, and bread filled the square.

Alma had taken her vegetable garden back in spirit by making Saint's former pavilion feed everybody who walked past it.

The Crown of Flame was supposed to go to the chef who produced the finest meal from the morning's catch.

I entered because Alma asked whether the captain knew what food looked like before somebody served it under a silver lid.

"Nigga, I have been hungry," I told her. "I paid attention."

She gave me an apron and a fish large enough to require respect.

Mercedes looked at it.

"That motherfucker owes somebody money."

"Then we're collecting," I said.

Tank arrived with Rosa holding his arm and looking at her ring every six steps. He had the expression of a man who had won a championship and then discovered the bigger prize kept choosing to walk beside him.

"Fiancée," he said when anybody greeted her.

"We know," Mercedes told him.

"Just making sure."

"Nigga, you said it to a seagull."

"Seagull was looking."

Rosa kissed his shoulder and let him be ridiculous.

The cooking began beneath a row of flags from countries that mostly existed to send proud men here and have them reconsider themselves. Lucien moved like every spoon knew his name. The chef beside him built a tower out of vegetables so delicate people whispered near it. Another man poured sauce in a perfect circle and looked around to see whether anybody had understood the importance of the circle.

I cooked something I wanted to eat.

That offended Lucien more than the apron.

"You are using the larger pan?"

"Nigga, I got larger intentions."

He watched me taste, adjust, taste again. Watched a nigga stop talking long enough to listen with his mouth. That confused him more than the apron. Nigga expected swagger to come without attention. Nigga expected noise where I had patience. But a hungry nigga remembers the first meal that made him stop thinking about the next one. I wanted every nigga at the table to get that kind of quiet. Watched the way I let one flavor arrive before the next. I didn't have his vocabulary for it. I knew when a bite needed heat, when it needed something bright, when it tasted expensive but nobody would want a second mouthful.

Shawna came up beside the table.

I held out a spoon.

She tasted and closed her eyes.

"Aiden."

"Good Aiden or what-the-fuck Aiden?"

"You know which one."

I looked at Lucien.

Nigga looked away.

Then a horn sounded from the fleet.

Long. Broken. Wrong.

Smoke climbed from the stern of the nearest white ship.

At first the crowd kept eating. Smoke belonged around cooking competitions. Then a second plume rose, black and thick, and men appeared along the rail waving their arms.

Graves came through the market at a run.

"The Saint Aurelia," he said. "Fire below decks. The general's ordered the other ships to hold position."

"Why?" Shawna asked.

"He thinks it's a desertion signal."

I took off the apron.

Lucien looked from me to the smoking ship.

"Your fish—"

"Nigga, don't let it burn."

I ran for the dock.

Knox had already commandeered the harbor fireboat. She stood at its wheel with the ceremonial sword strapped across her back because apparently nobody had successfully told her vacation was supposed to involve less weaponry.

Tank jumped aboard behind me.

Rosa caught his arm.

He turned, frightened for one instant that she was going to ask him to stay.

She straightened the life vest across his chest.

"Come back wearing that ring's husband," she said.

Then she let him go.

We crossed the harbor with water rolling white beneath the bow. The burning ship towered ahead. Men crowded its rail. Some wore Saint's uniforms. Some wore kitchen whites. None looked like a general's plan once the smoke got into their lungs.

A gunman on the upper deck raised his weapon toward us.

His own captain hit him with a fire extinguisher.

I looked up.

The captain leaned over the rail, a gray beard blackened with soot.

A sailor beside him pointed down. "That's the nigga."

"I see the nigga."

"The racing nigga."

"Can the racing nigga climb?"

"Nigga can do everything."

"Then let the nigga get up here before you write him a poem," Keel said.

I liked that captain already. Nigga knew how to make admiration useful.

"You coming aboard or admiring the paint?"

"Nigga, you keep greeting people like that, we'll get along."

His name was Armand Keel. Fifty-two, at sea since adulthood, and furious enough to burn hotter than his ship. Saint had ordered him to save the ceremonial gold cargo before the engine crew. Keel had refused. Now the officers Saint had placed aboard to watch him were trying to prevent the crew from abandoning the vessel.

I climbed over the rail with Tank behind me.

"Captain Aiden," I said.

"I know who the fuck you are. Half my men have your race on their phones."

"Good taste at sea."

The deck lurched beneath us.

The fire wasn't in the cargo. It had spread through a service corridor beneath the stern, trapping nine crewmen behind a fallen door. Keel had gotten most of his people to the forward deck. His first mate had gone back for the nine and not come out.

I looked at Tank.

He nodded once.

We went down together.

Heat struck like a solid thing. Smoke swallowed the corridor after ten feet. A bell kept ringing somewhere, too small a sound for the size of what was happening.

I could hear men shouting behind the fallen door.

"Captain?"

"Different captain," I shouted back. "Better looking. Stay loud."

One man laughed, then coughed hard enough to make the laugh hurt.

Tank got his hands beneath the edge of the door. I took the other side. Together we lifted until the metal moved, inch by awful inch, our shoulders shaking under its weight.

A hand came through.

Then a face.

We pulled the first man clear. The next crawled after him, dragging a third whose ankle had folded badly. Smoke thickened. My eyes burned. Tank grunted and raised the door another inch while I got the injured man beneath the shoulders.

"Nine," Tank said.

"We're getting nine."

We counted them into the corridor.

Seven.

Eight.

The ninth was the first mate, a broad woman with a burned sleeve, holding a little framed photograph against her chest. She

had gone back for a young deckhand, got him out, then stayed with the men who couldn't get through the doorway.

"You last?" I asked.

"I'm last."

"Then move, nigga. You got a hell of a story to tell."

Tank let the door fall behind her.

The crash followed us up the stairs.

On deck, a Saint officer blocked the gangway with a pistol in his hand.

"No one leaves with the general's property," he shouted.

Keel looked at his crew.

At the injured man between Tank and me.

At the smoke climbing over all of us.

Then he took off his cap.

"Nigga," I said to the officer, "look around and find somebody who still gives a fuck about your general."

The officer looked.

Nobody helped him.

He put the gun down.

We got every crew member off before the stern settled low enough to take water over the rail. The fireboat towed the ship clear of the harbor mouth while the island crews poured water

into the burning section. It would float. It would need a shipyard, money, and a captain who didn't think men were furniture.

It had all three by noon.

Keel stood beside me on the dock holding the white flag he had taken down himself.

"What do you want for the rescue?" he asked.

"Nigga, wash your hands. We're eating."

He blinked.

Behind us the market square smelled so good I almost forgave the ship for interrupting my fish.

Lucien stood at my table, sweating through his immaculate jacket. Alma had helped him turn my enormous pan into enough food for everybody coming off the fireboat. Shawna carried plates. Rosa filled glasses. Mercedes and Porsche had set two long tables end to end beneath the shade.

The sailors sat down like they weren't sure sitting was something they still had permission to do.

I handed Keel the first plate.

"Eat."

He took a bite.

Stopped.

Looked at the plate.

Looked at me.

"You made this?"

"Had help finishing."

Lucien came beside us.

"The balance was his," he said stiffly. "I merely prevented it from being ruined while he performed whatever that was."

"Lunch delivery," Tank said.

Keel took another bite.

Then another.

Halfway through the plate he began laughing, a low, exhausted sound that grew until his shoulders shook.

"The general told us you were a savage."

I raised an eyebrow.

"Nigga, he should taste the peppers."

The captain laughed harder.

Around him his crew ate. Some cried quietly into their food. Some called home. The first mate put her little framed photograph on the table beside her plate and touched it once before beginning.

Saint called Keel while we were still eating.

The captain answered on speaker.

"Return to your vessel," Saint said. "The cargo must be secured."

Keel looked at the plate in front of him.

"My men are secure."

"I did not ask about your men."

The whole table went quiet.

Keel swallowed his last bite, set down his fork, and looked at me.

"May I have another plate?"

I nodded toward Alma.

She was already filling it.

Keel picked up the phone.

"Then you asked the wrong captain."

He ended the call.

The sailors began to clap. The nigga whose ankle hurt clapped against the table. The nigga with the photograph clapped with tears running down her face. The captain clapped at his own crew, and those niggas clapped harder because they were still there to hear him. A nigga can own a ship. A nigga can paint his name on it. But them niggas knew who had walked into the smoke, and no paint was going to change the answer.

Not politely. Not because somebody had told them to show gratitude. They stood around that long table with smoke still in their clothes and clapped until the people in the square joined them.

Keel put his white flag on the table.

"The Aurelia is yours," he said. "Her crew chooses to sail with you."

"Nigga," Tank whispered, "you bought a navy with lunch."

"One ship."

"You got leftovers."

When the judges came to award the Crown of Flame, Lucien stopped them before they could make a speech.

"Give it to him," he said.

"Chef, the formal tasting—"

"Look at the tables. There is your tasting."

The judges looked.

Every plate was empty.

Shawna put the golden laurel around my neck and kissed the soot off the corner of my mouth.

"Captain. Champion. Chef."

"Husband," I said.

"My favorite one."

Across the bay, eleven white ships watched our first blue flag
rise.

And nigga, I had a feeling a lot of sailors were about to get
hungry.

11. A Gunfight with Excellent Manners

Chief Knox brought flowers to a shooting competition. A nigga has to pause when love enters a room carrying evidence. This woman had spent years making grown niggas stand up straighter. This woman could stop a lying nigga halfway through his favorite sentence. Now she had pink flowers for one particular nigga and expected all the other niggas to act like botany had suddenly become police work.

Pink ones.

I saw them sticking out of the bag beside her ammunition case and stopped so suddenly Tank walked into my back.

"Nigga, move," he said.

"Chief got flowers."

He looked.

"Oh, shit."

Knox shut the bag.

"Do either of you have something useful to contribute?"

"Water," Tank said. "Flowers need water."

She stared at him until the big nigga remembered an appointment on the other side of the stadium.

I stayed.

"Graves?"

"Captain."

"I'm a captain too. Nigga know a rank when he hears a dodge."

She looked toward the practice range. Lionel Graves stood beneath a canvas shelter adjusting the sleeve over the scrape he'd gotten during the ferry rescue. He was talking to Mina, who appeared to be explaining why the new scoreboard had awarded the throwing champion three hundred points for sneezing.

Knox watched him listen.

Then she looked back at me.

"They are for his table. His room is miserable."

"Chief, the nigga lives there. That's a beginning."

She picked up her case.

"Win your competition."

"Say please."

"Captain."

"All right, damn. Nigga can't enjoy love around the police."

The Precision Crown took place in the old quarry above the east beach. Saint had built a grandstand into the rock, with targets rising from behind stone walls and moving along distant rails. It

looked expensive, dramatic, and like a place a man would choose if he expected a stray bullet to improve the afternoon.

We had checked it before the audience arrived.

Graves insisted on that. He walked the whole course with the island officers. Knox watched the entrances. The workers who had built the place showed Tank every space large enough to hide a man. By the time the competition started, Saint's favorite surprises were sitting in a guarded truck on the other side of the hill.

Porsche called it the disappointment wagon.

It was getting crowded.

The first round was clean shooting. Distant targets, brief appearances, no fireworks beyond what a gun already supplied. Twelve competitors came down to four. Four came down to three.

Me. Graves. Knox.

A nigga in the stands leaned toward the nigga beside him.

"Which one you got?"

"The captain."

"Nigga, two captains."

"The good-looking nigga."

"Chief pretty too."

"The married nigga."

Shawna turned around. "That one."

Both niggas nodded. Expert testimony had arrived.

I looked at them standing on either side of me.

"Nigga, this is a staff meeting."

The chief checked her target card.

"Try attending one."

She had beaten Graves by a single point. He took it well, which in a proud man meant his smile hurt at the corners but remained a smile.

"Excellent shooting, Chief."

"I know."

"Nigga," I whispered, "tell her about the flowers."

He looked at me.

"What flowers?"

Knox's elbow struck my ribs without appearing to move.

I respected the precision. Nigga couldn't admire a woman without his chief making an elbow part of the lesson. Graves looked at the bag, then at the chief, then at me. I watched the nigga understand. Watched the nigga try not to smile too quickly. Nigga, there is nothing quieter or louder than a man discovering somebody thought about him before he entered the room.

The final round used a great wooden wheel carrying colored plates through openings in a stone screen. Some were targets. Some were not. The whole trick was knowing when to do nothing, which explained why half the audience expected me to lose.

I stood at the line and waited.

The first plate passed.

I let it.

Second. Third.

On the fourth I fired.

The target broke cleanly inside its little window.

Then another.

Then two in quick succession, each one appearing only long enough to announce itself and regret it.

I didn't think about looking fast. I looked where the answer would appear and let the rest of the world be scenery.

The wheel stopped.

The scorekeeper stared at the board.

"Perfect," he said.

Tank rose from the front row.

"NIGGA, WE KNEW!"

Shawna caught his sleeve and pulled him down before he blocked her view.

Graves came within one target. Knox came within two. Both had performed well enough to win almost any other day.

Today a nigga was trying to impress his wife again.

The chief looked at my score and shook her head slowly.

"You are a deeply irritating employee."

"Put it in gold on my next jacket."

Then a helicopter came over the quarry wall.

No numbers. Black windows. Saint's silver crest beneath the nose.

The audience ducked before the gunman opened the side door. They were learning the difference between a dramatic entrance and a nigga arriving to ruin somebody's lunch.

I caught the chief's arm and pulled her beneath the shelter as shots tore through the canvas roof.

Graves rolled behind the stone barrier beside us. Tank and the island officers moved the spectators toward the covered tunnel. Rosa stood at its entrance calling names and counting groups, making sure nobody disappeared in the rush.

The helicopter hovered above the quarry.

A voice boomed from its speaker.

"Return the Night Pearl and the general will permit the competition to continue."

I looked at Knox.

She looked at me.

"Permit?" she said.

"Nigga just offended your whole profession."

The helicopter moved lower.

At its open door stood Colonel Flint, the man Graves said commanded Saint's hired soldiers. Forty-seven, one pale eyebrow, gold gloves. He held a gun in one hand and the helicopter's doorframe in the other, leaning out to see whether fear looked good from above.

"Captain Aiden!"

I stepped far enough from the shelter for him to see me.

"Nigga, use your indoor voice."

He fired.

I was already behind the barrier.

The stone exploded where I'd stood. Dust rained over my shoulders.

"I don't like him," Knox said.

"Give him time. He gets worse."

Graves pointed toward the service road. My Lamborghini stood beside a small quarry truck beneath the ridge. Beyond it the road climbed to a broad loading platform level with the helicopter's lower turn.

I saw the shape of the thing.

He saw me see it.

"Captain," he said carefully.

"Nigga, don't start a sentence you can't finish before I get in the car."

I ran.

The helicopter swung toward me. Knox and Graves fired from the shelter, forcing Flint back into the cabin. I reached the Lamborghini, threw myself behind the wheel, and drove up the service road while stone chips snapped against the rear glass.

My hands were steady. I had used no Blue Thunder since the pursuit course. My body felt full of its own breath again.

I still didn't waste it.

At the loading platform I hit the horn.

Flint turned toward me.

"Over here, nigga. Big blue answer to your question."

The helicopter came around the ridge after me. Its rotor wash sent dust spinning across the platform. I drove toward the far

end, then turned sharply enough to make the tires scream against the gravel.

The helicopter followed my motion instead of the wall.

Its landing skid clipped the old loading crane.

Metal shrieked.

The aircraft lurched, low and sideways, fighting to recover. Flint lost his grip and fell from the open door onto the crane platform below. He landed badly but moved at once, dragging himself toward the stairs with his gun still in his hand.

The pilot brought the helicopter down hard on the quarry road.

I stopped the Lamborghini between Flint and the stairs.

He pointed his gun at me.

I stepped out with mine already up.

For a second the whole quarry seemed to hold its breath.

"You've seen the score," I told him.

His eyes moved to the gold laurel lying on my passenger seat.

Then to the distance between us.

Then to my hand, which wasn't shaking.

"Nigga," I said, quieter now, "make one good decision while you still get to make decisions."

He put the gun down.

Graves reached us a minute later. He looked from Flint to the dented helicopter, then at my car parked crookedly beneath the crane.

"You pursued an aircraft."

"It was fleeing."

"Nigga, it was flying."

"Nigga, those things can happen together."

Graves looked at the helicopter again. "You drove after a flying man."

"And now the nigga's standing. That's progress."

The pilot heard us from the roadside and put his face in his hands. Nigga had no idea how he was going to explain this to anyone who knew what an aircraft was.

"In a Lamborghini."

"Nigga, I didn't bring a horse."

Knox arrived behind him, breathing hard and furious about it.

She cuffed Flint herself.

"On leave," Graves said.

"Still having a marvelous time."

The audience came back out of the tunnel as the island officers led Flint away. Nobody had been hit. The damaged helicopter sat on the service road with its pilot holding an ice pack to his

forehead and explaining to anyone who would listen that a car had bullied him out of the sky.

The announcer waited until I returned to the platform.

Then he raised the microphone with both hands.

"Our champion of precision," he said, "Captain Aiden."

"And aviation!" somebody shouted.

The quarry erupted. Niggas stood on chairs, niggas waved hats, niggas who hadn't fired a gun in their lives began explaining my shots to niggas who hadn't asked. One nigga said he had always believed a car could chase a helicopter. His friend told the nigga to name one previous occasion on which he'd expressed that belief. The nigga declined details. Greatness was spreading faster than honesty.

I pointed at my wife in the front row.

She stood and shook her head at me, smiling despite the tears she always tried to hide after the part where I might not come back.

I went straight to her.

"You all right?" I asked.

"Nigga, you chased a helicopter."

"Baby, it started."

She caught my face in both hands.

"You chased a helicopter."

"I hear you. Sounds good when you say it."

She kissed me hard enough to tell me exactly how good and exactly how angry lived beside each other in her heart.

Behind us, Knox handed Graves the pink flowers.

He stared down at them.

"For your table," she said.

"I don't have a vase."

Mercedes stepped between them and offered her stolen champagne bucket.

"Nigga, everybody's problems getting solved today."

Graves took it.

The chief laughed. A real laugh, open and surprised, like somebody had found a room in her chest she hadn't used in a long time and put the lights on.

I watched Graves hear it.

Watched his whole face soften.

Then I turned back to Shawna before the nigga caught me looking at his future.

12. The Movie Could Barely Afford Me

Leon Lux landed on my island with three cameras, a white suit, and Darius Diamond carrying a suitcase full of boxing gloves. One nigga wanted to film me. One nigga wanted another chance to hit me. Both niggas were smiling like I had sent invitations. I watched the two niggas come down the steps and thought, a nigga wins an island and every nigga on earth decides the extra room is personally for him.

"Nigga," I said, "did you pack clothes?"

Darius opened the suitcase.

More gloves.

"These are formal."

Leon kissed both my cheeks before I could establish a defensive position.

"My star!"

"My guy who keeps finding me."

"The picture needs its final sequence."

"You made a picture?"

"Of course I made a picture. You gave me a champion, a wife, a gunfight, and the greatest entrance I have ever photographed. I would have been a criminal not to."

"Nigga, that's my profession. Find your own guilt."

He laughed and held up a poster.

There I was, twelve feet tall in spirit and twenty-four inches tall on paper, holding a gun in one hand and a rose in the other.

Behind me a city burned artistically. Beside me Shawna wore my robe over a dress that had never actually caught fire, though the poster suggested it might have.

The title was CAPTAIN FOREVER.

Tank read it twice. "That's my nigga."

Darius leaned beside him. "That's our nigga."

"Nigga, you just met the nigga."

"Nigga knocked me down. That's an introduction."

"I been knocked down beside the nigga. Different membership."

Leon watched them argue and quietly told his assistant to bring a second poster.

Underneath it: HE ARRESTED DEATH FOR LOOKING AT HIS WIFE.

I looked at Shawna.

She looked at the poster.

"They got my hair right," she said.

"Baby, look at the line."

"I did. Death had better behave."

Leon wanted to film a chase through the old inland station. The railway had stopped carrying passengers years ago, but its engine still ran for tourists during the festival. A bridge crossed the dry valley beyond it, and the road wound beneath the tracks before climbing toward the palace.

"You drive beside the train," he said. "You climb aboard. You retrieve the jewel. You return to your wife."

"Nigga, that's Thursday."

"Exactly!"

Shawna took the script from him. She turned three pages, stopped, and looked up.

"Why am I tied to a chair?"

Leon's smile weakened.

"The villain—"

"I can stand."

"Yes, but the dramatic—"

"I can shoot too. We established that at your audition."

Porsche leaned over her shoulder.

"And why am I called Woman Number Four?"

Mercedes took the next page.

"Nigga, I'm Woman Number Five."

Leon looked at me for help.

I leaned back in my chair.

"This is your gunfight, my nigga."

By the time we reached the station, Shawna drove the getaway car, Porsche stole the jewel, Mercedes owned the train, and Darius had become my long-lost brother because he refused to spend an entire film losing the same exhibition match.

Tank read the new page.

"Nigga, I'm the brother."

"You can have two," Darius said.

Tank considered him.

"Can you cook?"

"No."

"Then we're hiring wrong."

The first scene began at noon.

I wore the dark blue captain's jacket, an open white shirt, and the gold cross against my chest. Leon wanted to replace the cross with something larger. Shawna told him the existing one had earned its place. He looked at her face and abandoned jewelry criticism for the rest of the day.

The train rolled slowly through the station. Mercedes leaned from its window in a conductor's cap she had decorated with a green scarf. Porsche stood on the rear platform holding a velvet jewel case. Darius, dressed as a villain who had recently become

my brother in a complicated personal development, shouted at me from the roof.

I drove the Lamborghini alongside.

Leon yelled something through a megaphone.

I couldn't hear him over the engine, so I did what made sense.

I stood in the moving car, caught the train's handrail, and swung onto the platform beside Porsche. She handed me the case. I took her hand and brought her with me up the steps to the roof because leaving a woman behind after borrowing her jewelry seemed like bad manners.

Darius saw me coming and grinned.

"You ready?"

"Nigga, I been ready."

We fought for the camera. Big blows that passed where they were supposed to, hard falls onto padded places, the two of us moving with enough trust to make danger look beautiful. He threw me toward the edge. I caught the rail. He reached for me. I pulled him off balance and brought him down beside me with the whole valley passing beneath our shoulders.

Leon screamed through the megaphone.

This time I heard him.

"BEAUTIFUL!"

Then Mercedes screamed from inside the train.

Different voice. Different problem.

The engine surged.

The slow tourist rhythm became a hard, accelerating rush. The platform shot past the station. Crewmen ran beside it until they couldn't keep up.

Darius looked at me.

"Part of it?"

"Nigga, look at Leon."

Leon stood in the middle of the tracks holding the megaphone at his side, mouth open, watching his budget leave at dangerous speed.

We got down into the carriage.

Mercedes stood beside the driver, who was pulling at a control that had stopped listening. A man in a black jacket lay on the floor clutching his wrist. Porsche stood over him holding the heavy jewel case.

"He came out of the engine room," she said. "Told us to enjoy the final scene. I disliked his performance."

The man had Saint's crest sewn inside his jacket.

Of course he did.

Nigga had turned wardrobe into a confession.

"Another Saint nigga?" Mercedes asked.

"Dedicated nigga," Porsche said. "He wore the logo under the other logo."

"Nigga got layers of employment."

The man groaned from the floor.

"Nigga, be quiet," Porsche told him. "You're the least interesting part of your own ambush."

The driver looked at me.

"The bridge is closed beyond the next curve. They're repairing the far span."

Outside, the valley deepened beneath the tracks.

I looked down the train. Four carriages, twenty-three adult crew members, and a load of props that suddenly seemed stupidly heavy. Darius gripped the doorway behind me. Porsche's face had gone calm in the way it did when she was angry enough to make careful decisions.

"We get them off," I said.

Shawna's car appeared on the road below.

She had seen the train accelerate. She was already following, Rosa beside her with the radio. Behind them came Tank in the Mercedes, then Knox, then three of the island captains.

My wife looked up through the open roof.

I pointed toward the old loading crossing ahead.

She nodded.

No long conversation. No nigga pretending a marriage was only flowers. We had learned to hear each other's decisions before the words arrived.

The loading crossing was wide enough for the cars to come alongside the lower carriage steps. Not safely. Not in any way a man would recommend over taking a normal fucking vacation. But enough.

Shawna matched our speed first.

Darius lowered the first crew member toward her back seat. The woman dropped, landed hard, and crawled forward as Rosa pulled her clear. Tank came alongside next. Two men jumped into the Mercedes one after another, neither concerned about the upholstery.

We worked our way through the carriage.

Hands. Names. One person at a time.

Mercedes stayed at the rear counting. Porsche moved people toward the door. Darius lifted those too frightened to trust their own legs.

"I can't jump," one nigga said.

"Then this nigga can lower you," Darius answered.

"I'm heavy."

"Nigga, I fight heavy niggas. You're a cameraman."

He lifted him. The nigga discovered faith halfway out the door and landed in Tank's car shouting both our names like he was trying to thank the whole family before the next curve.

The bridge grew larger ahead.

I could see the missing section now. Sunlight where tracks should have been.

"Last four!" Mercedes shouted.

Knox's car came up with Graves driving. They took two.

Tank returned for the next.

Shawna came for us.

Darius jumped first, landing across the back seat with a grunt that suggested the car had won that exchange. Porsche followed. Mercedes waited beside me, refusing to go until I gave her a look that wasn't asking.

"Nigga," she said, "don't make me come back up here."

Then she jumped.

I went for the driver.

He stood at the engine controls staring at the bridge as if responsibility meant dying beside the thing you hadn't managed to stop.

I caught his arm.

"Your train can be replaced."

"I can't leave—"

"Nigga, yes you can. I'm personally introducing the option."

I dragged him back through the carriage.

The track curved. Shawna's car dropped away behind the last rise in the road. There wasn't room for it to come beside us again before the bridge.

I felt Blue Thunder wake in my hands.

Not enough to stop a train. I wasn't a fucking god. I was a man with a charge that could buy a short, bright chance if I spent it honestly.

I held the driver against me, took three steps through the moving carriage, and let the blue rush sharpen the moment.

We jumped from the rear platform as the train entered the bridge.

The world flashed wide.

I saw the road below, Shawna's white hood, Tank's Mercedes, the old station shrinking behind us. Saw the exact little patch of hillside that didn't contain rock.

Then we hit the slope and rolled.

Pain went through my shoulder. Dirt filled my mouth. I held the driver away from the sharp stones until we stopped against a low bush at the bottom.

Above us, the engine went through the broken span.

The sound traveled across the whole valley.

The train folded into the dry ravine in a storm of dust and torn wood. One carriage hung for a second, almost upright, then followed the rest down.

I lay on my back and stared at the sky.

The driver began laughing weakly beside me.

"You jumped a train."

"Nigga, don't tell my wife."

"I'm right here," Shawna said.

I closed my eyes.

"Damn."

She knelt beside me, hands moving over my face, my shoulders, the place my old wound still complained when I treated my body like a vehicle with replaceable parts.

"Everyone?" I asked.

"Everyone."

I let myself breathe.

Tank stood above us looking toward the wreck.

"Nigga, the movie better make its money back."

Leon arrived last, covered in dust, clutching one of his camera operators by the sleeve.

For once he didn't look at the wreck first.

He counted his people.

Touched their shoulders.

Then he came to me with tears running down his face.

"My captain," he said.

I held up one shaking hand.

"Give a nigga a minute before you pitch the sequel."

He laughed and cried harder.

Porsche sat on the hood of Shawna's car with the jewel case in her lap. She opened it, took out the fake diamond, and held it toward the wrecked bridge.

"All that for glass."

Mercedes leaned beside her.

"Baby, men have done worse for less."

That night, Leon showed the footage on a screen in the harbor square.

He kept the pretend fight separate from the real rescue. He put every crew member's name before the scene where we got them off. Then he showed the last jump without music, without a speech, just the sound the camera had caught when my wife called my name.

The whole square stood. Every nigga with a seat got out of it. Niggas who had come to see a movie stood beside niggas who

had lived through the last scene, and for once the loudest nigga in the square was not the nigga with the least to lose. It was the train driver. The nigga kept shouting that I had come back for him. I looked at my wife. She squeezed my hand before a nigga could get embarrassed about being understood.

I sat beside Shawna with my arm in a sling I had agreed to wear only because she threatened to decorate it if I argued.

On the screen, I flew off a train holding another man alive.

Beside me, my wife held my good hand.

"That's my husband," she said softly.

And nigga, the way she said it was bigger than the screen.

13. Even the Horse Knew Who the Fuck I Was

Dr. Vega flew to my island, looked at the sling, looked at my face, and called me a spectacular idiot before taking her suitcase off the dock.

"Nigga, good morning to you too."

"You jumped from a train."

"Everybody keeps saying that like they saw a different ending."

She pointed at the chair beside Shawna's piano.

I sat.

Nigga could win five crowns and still get seated by a woman carrying a medical bag. My wife watched from the keyboard with the calm satisfaction of somebody whose reinforcements had arrived. Tank stood beside her trying to look innocent, which was difficult for a nigga who had personally participated in half the things the doctor was about to dislike.

Vega examined my shoulder, asked questions, and listened long enough to distinguish answers from Aiden talking.

"Bruised," she said. "Strained. You need rest."

"I rested last night."

"You slept. Rest includes what happens after you wake up."

"Nigga, that's where my schedule gets complicated."

She looked at Shawna.

Shawna nodded once.

Two women had just agreed about my body without letting the owner vote.

"No Blue Thunder," Vega said. "No lifting people. No fighting men larger than furniture."

"What if the furniture starts?"

"Aiden."

I raised my good hand. "All right. Nigga heard you."

For an hour I obeyed.

I sat beside the piano while my wife practiced. I watched Rosa turn her ring in the sunlight. I let Mercedes bring me coffee and describe the hotel she and Porsche intended to open when this was over: no man allowed to confuse paying for a room with owning the woman in it, a rooftop bar, excellent beds, and a garage full of cars guests could rent only after Mercedes decided whether she liked their shoes.

"That's your business plan?" I asked.

"Nigga, shoes tell stories."

"Some niggas wear ugly shoes and pay on time."

"Then they can pay somewhere uglier."

Porsche stretched out in the next chair.

"We're calling it the Velvet Mile."

I looked at them.

Two women who had spent years being welcomed into other people's expensive rooms wanted a place whose doors answered to them.

"Pick your building," I said.

Mercedes stopped smiling.

"Aiden."

"Pick it. I'll buy the building. You own the business."

Porsche looked at Shawna, as if she needed somebody else to confirm the nigga had said what he'd said.

My wife kept playing.

"He heard you the first time," she said.

Mercedes looked down at her coffee. For once the woman who could talk a saint out of his jewelry didn't have a line ready.

Then a horse came down the dock.

Black coat, white mark between the eyes, mane moving in the sea wind. Behind it came an older stablemaster holding a broken lead and apologizing to everybody the horse had decided was scenery.

The horse stopped beside my chair.

Looked at me.

Lowered its enormous head into my lap.

Tank put his coffee down.

"Nigga."

"I see it."

"The horse knows the nigga."

"The horse wants the apple," Shawna said, pointing at my plate.

Tank shook his head. "Nigga, don't reduce a relationship to groceries."

I gave the horse the apple.

The stablemaster arrived breathing hard. His name was Mateo, and he looked old enough to have seen every way a rich man could misunderstand a saddle.

"Paladin," he said. "He doesn't usually let strangers touch him."

"Nigga got taste," Tank said.

The horse pressed its nose beneath my good hand. I rubbed its forehead. It stood completely still.

Mateo looked from the horse to me.

"Saint entered him in the Riders' Crown. His own rider refused to mount him after yesterday's practice."

"Why?"

"Paladin dislikes being frightened into obedience."

I looked at the horse.

"Reasonable nigga."

Shawna stopped playing.

"Aiden."

"I'm sitting."

"You are thinking about not sitting."

The horse chose that moment to nudge the golden laurel hanging from my chair. It lifted the ribbon in its teeth and dropped it into my lap.

Tank spread both hands.

"Nigga, the horse nominated him."

Vega came up from below deck, saw the animal, and stopped.

"Absolutely not."

I raised my good hand again.

"Doctor. We are only discussing transportation."

An hour later I entered the Riders' Crown with my arm still in its sling and my wife riding beside me on a gray mare.

Before any nigga decides this meant I won the argument, understand the conditions. No jumping. No racing the rough course. We entered the opening procession only. Vega rode in a little carriage behind us with her medical bag and the expression

of a woman following a patient toward the exact mistake she had described.

Paladin moved beneath me like he knew the sea had dressed itself blue for my arrival.

The spectators lined the path from the stables to the hilltop arena. They saw my sling. Saw my wife. Saw the black horse carrying me without one bit of the trouble he had given Saint's rider.

A nigga beside the gate took his hat off.

"The horse accepted him."

"Nigga, the horse got standards," another said.

"That horse threw the general's rider into a fountain."

"Then that nigga needed washing."

I smiled and kept going.

At the arena, twelve riders waited around a course of gates, low walls, and a narrow bridge over a decorative stream. The first event rewarded control: pace, balance, partnership. No speed. No height. Aiden-safe, according to nobody who had ever met me.

Mateo came beside Shawna's mare.

"You could enter," he told her. "I watched you on the path. You listen to her."

My wife looked at the course.

Then at me.

"What do you think?"

"Nigga, I think they better polish your crown."

She entered.

I stayed outside the ring, one hand resting on Paladin's neck, and watched my wife make twelve proud riders discover how quietly somebody could beat them.

She didn't force the mare. She moved with her. At each turn she seemed to arrive a breath before the horse needed the answer. The little bridge gave the other animals trouble; hers paused, considered the stream, then crossed because Shawna had waited without turning waiting into a fight.

The crowd began applauding before she finished.

I got loud.

Of course I got fucking loud. That was my wife. Niggas had spent all week screaming for me; now I had a reason to make them feel outnumbered.

"THAT'S HER. THAT'S THE WOMAN. NIGGAS, LOOK AT HER."

Vega pulled her hat lower.

"Your shoulder is attached to your lungs," she told me.

"Doctor, my pride is attached to my wife. This is a larger system."

Shawna won the control crown by a margin the judges discussed twice before admitting arithmetic wasn't going to protect the other riders.

Then a shot sounded from the hillside.

The horses startled.

Another shot struck the arena bell, sending a metallic scream across the course. A black car burst through the far service gate with two of Saint's men standing through its roof. They weren't aiming at the riders now. They were driving straight toward Mateo's stable wagon, where the prizes and the older royal tack had been stored.

Saint wanted something in that wagon.

One gunman grabbed a carved saddle from the open back as the car passed. The other fired into the air to clear the road.

Paladin reared beneath me.

I held him with my good hand and let him come down.

"Easy, nigga," I whispered.

He listened.

The car raced toward the narrow orchard road. Shawna turned her mare to keep the frightened riders away from its path. Graves and the island officers moved toward the service gate, but the car had already cleared it.

Mateo shouted.

"The saddle! They took the old king's saddle!"

I looked at Paladin.

Paladin looked at the road.

Nigga, some conversations don't need subtitles.

We went.

Behind me Vega shouted my whole name with none of the affection I'd grown accustomed to hearing in it.

I didn't jump. I didn't lift anybody. I didn't use lightning.

I rode a horse down an orchard path while a car tried to escape the consequences of choosing wheels in a place built around trees.

Paladin knew the land. I could feel it. The little changes in his stride told me where the ground rose, where the branches narrowed, where the car ahead would have to slow. I stayed with him, keeping my injured arm against my chest and my weight where it didn't ask the horse to solve two problems at once.

The gunman turned.

Saw the black horse.

Saw me.

The nigga's mouth opened so wide he forgot the thing in his hands.

"HE'S ON A HORSE!"

"I SEE THE HORSE!" the driver shouted.

"THE NIGGA'S ON THE HORSE!"

"WHICH NIGGA?"

Paladin drew level with the window.

The driver looked at me.

"Oh, fuck."

I pointed ahead.

The orchard road ended at a locked gate.

He braked hard enough to throw both gunmen against the roof opening. The stolen saddle bounced onto the hood. I took Paladin wide, brought him around, and stopped beside the car while Graves's police truck came up behind us.

No shot fired by me. No leap. No lightning. Just a car full of niggas discovering the horse knew the map better.

Graves got out smiling.

"You didn't bring a horse yesterday."

"Learning nigga."

He arrested the three men while I slid carefully out of the saddle.

My shoulder hurt. Of course it hurt. Being right about the horse did not make Vega wrong about the body.

Shawna arrived beside her with the control crown around her neck.

I looked at my wife.

"Baby, you were incredible."

"You are trying to begin this conversation somewhere safer."

"Nigga, yes."

She laughed despite herself, then took Paladin's lead and handed me to the doctor.

Mateo recovered the stolen saddle. Beneath its loose lining he found a narrow silver plate engraved with three bridges and a crowned lion.

The same bridges beneath our ballroom.

He gave it to Marcellus that evening.

And Paladin, who had apparently decided one apple constituted a binding alliance, refused to return to the general's stables.

"Put him with Shawna's mare," I said.

Tank grinned.

"Even the horse wants the nigga's lifestyle."

My wife leaned against me on the yacht, both our crowns lying on the table between us.

"You rest tomorrow," she said.

"Absolutely."

She looked up.

"Aiden."

"Baby, I'm agreeing before any new information arrives. Let a nigga enjoy his honesty while it's fresh."

14. The Nigga Who Wanted to Go Home

I conducted the interrogation in a reclining chair because my wife had made rest a condition of remaining married to a man with two functioning shoulders.

Colonel Flint sat opposite me with his wrists cuffed, his gold gloves folded on the table, and a face full of professional disappointment.

"This is irregular," he said.

I lifted my lemonade.

"Nigga, you tried shooting me out of a helicopter. You don't get to request a normal room afterward."

Knox sat on my left. Graves stood by the open door. Outside, the sea glittered like it had never heard a bad idea in its life.

Flint looked at my sling.

"I heard about the train."

"Nigga, who hasn't?"

"The general said you would exhaust yourself before the final challenge."

"Then tell that nigga I'm resting aggressively."

He didn't smile.

I watched him look at the table. At the glass of water nobody had stopped him drinking. At the plate of food Alma had sent with enough on it to suggest she considered being my enemy a temporary failure of appetite.

"You hungry?" I asked.

"No."

His stomach answered differently.

I pushed the plate closer.

"Nigga, let the honest part of you have breakfast."

For a minute all we heard was the sea and a fork working through a meal the colonel had decided not to enjoy where anybody could see him.

Then Knox put his phone on the table.

Thirty-one missed calls.

All from Sabine.

The nigga's fork stopped moving.

"Who is she?" I asked.

"No one involved in this."

"Nigga, thirty-one calls is involvement."

He looked at the phone like it could hurt him more efficiently than any weapon we had taken away.

"My fiancée."

Graves looked down.

Knox leaned back in her chair.

There it was. The person behind the uniform. Some niggas buried that person so deep they needed a whole gunfight and a closed door before anybody could hear him breathe.

"Call her," I said.

"What?"

"Nigga, she watched your helicopter fall out of the sky. Call the woman."

He stared at me.

"You would permit that?"

"I'm beginning to understand why she called thirty-one times. You difficult in the morning."

Knox uncuffed one wrist and stayed beside him while he picked up the phone.

Sabine answered before it finished ringing.

I heard his name, then a sound that made the colonel close his eyes.

"I'm alive," he said.

He listened.

"Yes."

Listened again.

"No, the captain has not—"

He glanced at me.

"He gave me breakfast."

Whatever she said next made his mouth twitch despite himself.

"Yes. That captain."

He looked embarrassed now, which was a much healthier color on the nigga than dead-eyed loyalty.

"Sabine. Please. I know he's handsome. I am trying to tell you I survived."

I turned my head toward the window.

Knox looked at the ceiling.

Graves gave up and walked outside to laugh where the colonel couldn't watch him.

The call lasted six minutes. Flint said very little. At the end he promised something three times, softer each time, and put the phone down with both hands.

"She wants me home," he said.

"Nigga, I gathered."

"I told her one more season. One more contract. Then we would buy a house by the water."

He looked through the window.

"There has always been another season."

I thought of Tank with the coconut. Of Rosa on that fighting floor, laughing through tears because the big nigga had finally stopped waiting for perfection to introduce him.

"You love her?" I asked.

Flint looked at me sharply.

"Of course."

"Then why Saint keep getting the years you promised her?"

The room went quiet.

I let it.

Niggas like me talk because we enjoy the shape of a room answering. Sometimes a nigga has to stop long enough to hear the answer that doesn't want company.

Flint touched the edge of his gold glove.

"He made me a colonel."

"And now you sitting here asking permission to call your own woman. Nigga, what part of the promotion still belongs to you?"

He looked down for a long time.

Then he pushed the glove away.

He told us about the fleet.

Not a map of tricks. Not some little secret button that would make eleven warships surrender because a nigga pressed it correctly. He told us about people. Captains who had not been

paid. Sailors whose families had been moved into houses Saint owned. Men ordered to guard gold they had been promised and never allowed to touch.

The festival was supposed to make Saint richer than all of them combined.

The vault was supposed to make him untouchable.

"What is in it?" Knox asked.

Flint shook his head.

"He never said. Money, certainly. Old stones. He mentioned a book once. Names. Promises powerful men made before they were powerful."

"Blackmail," Graves said from the doorway.

"He called it inheritance."

"Nigga names everything except what it is," I said.

Flint looked at me.

"The final challenge will bring him ashore. He cannot bear to surrender the title without being seen defending it. But he has no intention of letting the winner leave the arena."

"I noticed a pattern."

"There is a road beneath the stadium. It runs to the old palace. His cars are there. His own guard. If he loses, he leaves through it and attacks the crowd to cover his escape."

Knox's face hardened.

"Then we clear that road."

Flint shook his head again.

"He will move if he sees officers there. He knows every uniform on the island."

I looked out at the yacht.

Mercedes and Porsche were arguing with a real-estate man about a building in Vegas. The man kept pointing at a photograph. Mercedes kept pointing at a different photograph, apparently explaining that the existence of a cheaper ugly building did not create an obligation to admire it.

"Not every uniform," I said.

That afternoon the Velvet Mile acquired its first employees before it acquired a building.

Six women and three men who had worked Saint's private parties came to the yacht because Porsche had called them by name. All adults. All professionals who had heard enough rich men call them temporary while asking them to stay until morning.

They knew the palace's lower rooms. They knew who came through them. They knew the soldiers who talked too much after the drinks arrived.

I met them at the table with my shoulder still wrapped and my badge beside the lemonade.

"You don't owe us a risk," I said.

Mercedes sat beside me.

"We're asking what you know. You choose what happens after that."

A woman named Leda looked at Porsche.

"You really took his pearl?"

Porsche lifted her chin.

"Nigga put it in my hand."

Leda laughed so hard her earrings shook.

Then the stories came out.

The general who demanded every mirror be covered because he couldn't enjoy himself while another general looked back. The merchant prince who arrived with cocaine on his jacket and insisted it was powdered sugar despite carrying no pastry. The duke who hired three companions, spent the whole night asking whether his ex-wife had seemed happy at a party, and tipped them to lie differently.

Niggas with fleets. Niggas with crowns. Niggas whose entire kingdom collapsed when a woman said she had an early train.

Porsche knew every kind of them.

Mercedes knew which ones had keys to Saint's lower garages.

By evening we knew the people forced to service his cars, the drivers he trusted, and the guard who had been quietly letting kitchen workers leave whenever another attack began.

No one went sneaking through a room for us that night. No one had to become a sacrifice in a dress.

They brought their knowledge. They brought their names. They brought one driver who had decided he was finished carrying a rich man's cowardice from door to door.

That was enough to begin.

When the last guest left, Mercedes sat back and stared at the empty chairs.

"The hotel," she said. "I want them to have somewhere they can come without inventing a reason."

"Then build that," Shawna told her.

Porsche looked at the photograph of the Vegas building they had chosen: curved windows, a rooftop terrace, a garage entrance opening onto a quiet side street.

"Ours," she said softly.

I pushed the purchase agreement toward them. My part was the building. Their part was everything they wanted to make inside it.

Mercedes took the pen.

"Nigga," she said, blinking fast. "You better come to the opening."

"Baby, try keeping me out."

Across the harbor, Saint's eleven ships shone white beneath the stars.

At our table, three women planned a place that would still matter after his fucking flags came down.

I sat there resting exactly as ordered and watched my people get richer in ways a nigga could feel.

15. Rich Niggas Float Differently

Cassius Chrome arrived on a red speedboat and parked so close to my yacht that Tank asked if the nigga intended to come upstairs through the kitchen.

Inez Inferno stood in the passenger seat holding two bottles of champagne and looking at the eleven white ships across the bay. Her engagement ring caught the sun. Cassius watched her notice it and smiled the helpless smile of a nigga who had won something he still couldn't believe had said yes.

"You collect enemies in matching sets now?"

"Nigga sent the whole catalog," I said.

Cassius climbed aboard and hugged me carefully around the shoulder. Somebody had told him about the train. Everybody had told everybody about the fucking train. By then a man could order coffee on another continent and have the waiter explain my landing before asking about milk.

"I left you alone for a week," Cassius said.

"Long week."

"You won more trophies?"

Tank pointed toward the cabin. Laurels hung from three hooks, the mirror, and a lamp whose original purpose had lost the argument.

Cassius stared.

"Nigga."

"Don't start," Mercedes said. "We already doing that."

Inez went straight to Shawna's piano and put the champagne beside it.

"I came for the music," she said.

"Everybody says that until he starts driving something," Shawna told her.

"I can appreciate two disasters."

We had a party that night because a nigga couldn't spend his whole island worrying about the man trying to steal it. The Crown of the Sea began the next morning. Saint's last captains were expected to compete in racing launches while their general watched from the flagship. Keel said some of them wanted to talk. I said they could talk with a drink in their hand like civilized criminals.

By ten the yacht and the harbor terrace had become one long expensive mistake everybody intended to remember fondly.

Silk brought the band. Rosa brought a voice that made the men leaning against the rail stand up straighter. Mercedes and

Porsche brought friends who arrived beautiful, loud, and entirely uninterested in being described as atmosphere. There were singers, sex workers, drivers, thieves, fighters, a chief of police wearing gold earrings, and one professor who kept telling people he normally went to bed at nine while refusing every offered ride home.

Cocaine appeared in a room farther down the terrace where two merchants had decided they were younger than their knees. I didn't ask for anybody's life story. I had enough crimes of my own to remember without taking attendance at other niggas' parties. One of the merchants emerged convinced he could freestyle against me. Silk handed him the microphone. Nigga rhymed ocean with ocean four times, bowed, and demanded a boat. We gave him water and a chair. Even the criminals have standards when the band is that good.

Tank danced with Rosa beneath the lanterns. He kept showing people her ring as if she hadn't been holding the hand herself all evening. Darius challenged Kong Harrow to arm-wrestle and lost so spectacularly a waiter caught the table before it followed him. Then both men insisted I try. My wife looked at my shoulder. I looked at the men. They looked at her. Two heavyweight champions withdrew the challenge with excellent manners.

"Nigga," Darius whispered, "your wife got reach."

"Across continents," I said.

The first enemy captain came without his white jacket.

Keel introduced him as Alaric Dawn, forty-nine, commander of the Saint Verity. He had a scar through one eyebrow and hands that looked like they'd spent years holding the sea away from other people. He took the drink I offered and watched my party for a long time before speaking.

"Your people are not afraid of you."

"They know when to be."

He glanced at me.

I smiled. "Nigga, I'm not running a monastery. Somebody steals from my wife, we'll have a memorable conversation. But they can dance without asking whether I'm in the mood."

Dawn looked at Rosa singing with Tank's hand resting at her waist. At Mercedes telling a wealthy man exactly where he could put his offer. At Knox laughing beside Graves, the two of them close enough that nobody could pretend the flowers had been an office supply.

"Saint calls that weakness."

"Saint watches it from a boat he won't get off. Nigga can call long distance."

Dawn laughed once.

Then he told me what he wanted.

His crew had families ashore in other ports. He wanted wages paid, promises kept, and the right to stop sailing behind a man who aimed guns at the people fixing his engines. In return he would race me honestly, lose honestly if he lost, and bring his ship into the harbor under whichever flag he chose when the contest ended.

"And if you win?" I asked.

"I keep my ship."

"Nigga, I was going to let you keep steering it anyway."

He looked surprised by that.

"You don't want command?"

"I want an ocean my wife can look at without seeing eleven motherfuckers preparing a tantrum. You want to help, help."

We shook hands.

Two more captains came after him.

By midnight, Saint's fleet had three men at my table discussing what a new morning might look like. Nobody pledged their souls. Nobody made a speech about the future of nations. Niggas asked practical questions about whether a promise would still mean something after the applause, and I answered them with Keel sitting beside me, alive, fed, and still captain of the ship he'd brought home.

Shawna sang one last song before we went upstairs.

I stood behind her chair, my good hand resting lightly at the back of her neck, and let the party move around us. There were beautiful people everywhere. Men stared at her. Women looked at me. Money changed hands over games nobody would admit losing later. Somewhere Darius was teaching the nine-o'clock professor to throw a proper punch without hurting the champagne glass he refused to put down.

My wife looked up at me at the end of the song.

"Ready?"

Nigga, I was ready before she asked.

We left the party to our friends and took the night upstairs. In the morning her lipstick was on my collar, my shoes were under a chair I hadn't meant to touch, and she was asleep across my chest with one hand carefully clear of my injured shoulder. I lay there longer than a champion's schedule recommended because no crown in the world had ever asked me to stay warm like that.

Then Tank knocked.

"Nigga, boats."

I closed my eyes.

"Nigga, marriage."

"Nigga, boats waiting."

Shawna laughed without opening her eyes.

"Go win the water, baby."

The Crown of the Sea began under a clear sky.

Sixteen launches waited in the harbor, bright hulls nosing against the tide. The course circled the eastern headland, crossed the open bay, passed between two old sea towers, and returned beneath the high bridge at the harbor entrance. Cassius rode with me. Inez took another launch with Porsche because she said it would be useful for the world to remember I was not the only person who could make a vehicle ashamed of its previous speed.

Shawna watched from the yacht with Vega beside her. The doctor had examined my shoulder again. Better, she said. Better did not mean indestructible. I told her I respected the distinction. She told me to demonstrate it before she believed in miracles.

I used no Blue Thunder at the start.

The boat had plenty to say without borrowing my bloodstream. We hit the first stretch with the bow rising over the chop, spray breaking white against the windshield. Cassius laughed beside me, one hand gripping the rail, the other pointing toward Dawn's launch as it cut across our wake.

"That nigga means it!"

"I asked for honest!"

"Nigga brought enthusiastic!"

Dawn took the lead around the headland. Inez came up outside him, her red boat flying low over the water. Porsche's purple scarf streamed behind them like the sea had decided to dress for

a better woman. The other launches spread across the bay, engines hammering, crews leaning into every turn with their whole bodies.

I let the water teach me its rhythm. Not every wave deserved a fight. Some lifted us where we needed to go. Some needed to pass beneath the boat without finding my temper. I found the clean line through the middle stretch and felt the hull settle into a speed that made Cassius stop laughing long enough to appreciate it properly.

"Nigga," he said, very softly.

That was the compliment I wanted from another driver. The quiet one. The one that came when a nigga had stopped performing admiration and simply had to say what his body knew.

At the old towers, a black launch came out from behind the nearer wall.

Too fast. Wrong direction.

Its driver wore Saint's colors. The man beside him lifted a gun toward Inez's boat.

Dawn saw it first.

He turned across the attacker's path, forcing the black launch wide. A shot struck his windshield. Glass flashed into the sea. His boat lurched, hit the next wave badly, and rolled onto its side.

Two men went into the water.

I turned before Cassius finished shouting.

The race broke apart around us. Inez swung back. Porsche was already standing, pointing to where Dawn's passenger had surfaced. The black launch tried to circle for another attack.

I put our boat between it and the men in the water.

Cassius drew the gun he'd worn under his jacket and fired toward the attacking launch. The gunman ducked. I drove hard across its bow, close enough for our wake to strike broadside. The black boat bucked, lost its turn, and slammed into the stone foot of the sea tower.

It stopped moving.

Its crew crawled onto the rocks with their hands up when the island patrol boat arrived.

I was already beside Dawn.

He gripped our rail with one hand, blood running from a cut above his eye. Cassius hauled him aboard while I held us steady. Inez and Porsche got his passenger out on the other side.

The general's captain lay on my deck coughing seawater into the boat he'd come to beat.

"The race," he said.

"Nigga, you nearly drowned."

"Finish it."

I looked down at him.

He was smiling through the blood.

"I'd hate to think I lost to a man who didn't finish."

Cassius met my eyes.

"We can still catch them."

I looked toward the scattered launches racing for the bridge.

Inez's boat came alongside. She gave me one sharp nod.

We went together.

No lightning. No miracle button. Just two boats cutting through the last stretch with men and women inside them who had come to understand each other at dangerous speed. Inez took the outside line. I took the inside. We passed one launch, then two, then the leader, all three boats so close that a man on shore later swore we had tied them together.

At the finish, the nose of my boat crossed first.

Inez came in beside me, laughing so hard she had to lean against Porsche to stand up.

Dawn raised one shaking hand from the deck.

"Champion," he said.

I gave him my hand and pulled him to his feet.

The harbor erupted.

By sunset three more white ships had lowered Saint's flags.

Dawn's Verity. The Saint Orison. The Saint Lucia.

Four ships with us. Eight still behind him.

Tank stood on the dock counting on his fingers with the satisfaction of a nigga who liked subtraction when it made his enemies poorer.

"Nigga, you winning a fleet in installments."

I looked at the four blue flags rising together.

"Then tell the general his next payment's due."

16. Nigga, That's My Dance Partner

The Count of Valcera asked to dance with my wife while I was standing close enough to hear the mistake form.

Forty-one years old. Silver hair. Black velvet jacket. A smile that had probably opened a lot of doors for the nigga before he reached the one with my name on it.

"One dance," he said.

Shawna looked at him.

Then at me.

The little smile she gave me was dangerous. Not because she wanted the count. Because she wanted to see what kind of foolishness a nigga would build around the possibility.

"He asked me," she said.

"I heard the nigga."

"Then let me answer."

I took a sip of champagne that suddenly tasted like patience.

She turned back to him.

"Thank you, but I came with my husband."

The count bowed.

"A fortunate man."

"Nigga," I said, "that's the first accurate thing you've said."

He moved away smiling. Shawna watched me watch him.

"You were about to buy the orchestra, weren't you?"

"Already paid them."

"To stop playing?"

"Baby, don't insult my imagination. I was going to have them play something no nigga could dance to."

She laughed into my shoulder, and the whole room got easier.

The ballroom final took place in the restored lower hall of the palace. We kept the roofless old room above locked and watched. Its stones, its secret stair, and the seven-part crescent were too important to leave unattended while the island danced.

Below, the hall shone. Blue roses along the pillars. Silver candles on the tables. Mirrors cleaned until a nigga had to confront the full quality of his tailoring from every direction. A hundred couples had come to watch twenty-four compete, and half the men looked at my jacket with the private pain of somebody realizing he should have spent more money.

My sling was gone. Vega had checked the shoulder that morning and warned me against treating improvement like immortality. I promised a quiet evening. She looked at the orchestra, the guards, the cameras, and the four former enemy captains drinking at my table.

"Define quiet," she said.

"Baby, we got strings."

She refused to accept music as a medical category.

Isolde came down the stairs with Marcellus on her arm.

The room changed when they entered.

Not the way it changed for me, loud and hungry and already reaching for cameras. This was older. People who knew her name stood without being asked. Dancers turned from their own reflections. The orchestra leader lowered his hands until she reached the floor.

Marcellus wore the white dinner jacket again, properly cleaned, the little cut on his leg hidden and nearly healed. He held himself straight beside her. The old nigga had stopped trying to defeat time. He was standing in it with a woman who remembered him before the gray and liked what she saw afterward.

I leaned toward Tank.

"Look at our jeweler."

"Nigga got his whole past wearing earrings."

"Present," Rosa corrected.

Tank nodded. "Nigga got his whole present wearing earrings."

Isolde heard him.

"Better," she said.

The first competition belonged to the veteran pairs. Couples who had danced together for years. Couples who had lost partners and found new ones. One pair had met only a month earlier and moved with such fierce concentration that nobody dared suggest a month was too short to matter.

Marcellus and Isolde stood last in the line.

When the music began, I watched his hand settle at her back.

No trembling now.

They moved.

The first turn was almost cautious. The second wasn't. By the third I could see the photograph alive again, not copied, not pretending thirty-five years had vanished. Something better than that. Two people making room for everything that had happened and still finding the same place to put their feet.

Isolde smiled at him.

Marcellus smiled back with the whole face I'd rarely seen him allow himself.

They won before the judges raised their cards. Every dancer in the room knew it. The applause began at the end of the last note and kept going until Isolde pressed her forehead against his and laughed because there was nowhere else for the feeling to go.

The old nigga cried.

Didn't hide it. Didn't apologize. Just stood there holding the woman while the room gave them the years it could.

I clapped until my shoulder complained.

"Vega watching," Tank whispered.

"Nigga, let her charge me for joy."

Our turn came after midnight.

The Grand Dance Crown had three rounds. A slow dance. A fast one. A final piece chosen by the orchestra with no announcement, so a couple had to hear each other instead of waiting for the steps they'd practiced.

The count and his wife were good. Her name was Anika, thirty-eight, and she danced with a look that said she'd spent years making his confidence appear deserved. They moved beautifully together when he remembered not to fight her. When he forgot, the beauty tightened around the edges.

Shawna watched them from beside me.

"He pulls too hard," she said.

"Nigga likes proving he's leading."

She looked up at me.

I held her gaze.

"I learned," I said.

"I know."

We took the floor.

The slow dance began with a single violin. I felt her breath before I moved. Let the first step belong to both of us. The room turned around her shoulder, candlelight slipping across the watch on her wrist, her fingers warm against my neck.

I could have looked at the crowd.

I wanted to. Nigga, I am still me. A room full of people admiring my wife and the man she chose is a beautiful thing to notice.

But she was looking at me, and the room lost the competition.

We turned through the light.

Somewhere beyond her face a judge lowered his pen.

Somewhere a camera moved. Somewhere the count realized the audience wasn't watching his perfect jacket anymore.

I only knew because Shawna's smile changed.

"What?" I whispered.

"You stopped showing them."

"Baby, I'm showing you."

She brought her hand a little closer against my shoulder.

We finished the first round to applause that sounded farther away than it was.

The fast dance brought the room back.

Drums under the strings. Brass rising. The floor suddenly alive beneath everybody's feet. I took Shawna through the first quick turn and felt her laugh before I heard it. That laugh did something to my knees no enemy had managed. We moved faster, not frantic, each change answering the last so cleanly I could almost feel the music waiting for us to arrive.

Tank started shouting.

Then Rosa.

Then Mercedes yelled, "NIGGA, THAT'S A HUSBAND," and half the room lost whatever dignity it had brought to the event.

The count tried to match our pace. Anika could have. He couldn't. At the far turn his foot caught the hem of her dress. She recovered him before he fell, smiling so professionally it made the mistake hurt worse.

I saw it.

Shawna saw it.

We didn't laugh.

A woman saving her man from his own feet deserved better than being made the joke.

We finished together, breathing hard, her forehead against my chest for one second before she stood straight and let the room see her smile.

Two rounds to us.

The final music began without warning.

The old seven-turn melody.

Not the exact tempo from the ruined ballroom. Faster now, richer, the orchestra giving it a new body. Isolde lifted her head across the room. Marcellus's hand closed around hers.

The count looked sharply toward the musicians.

I understood then.

Saint had arranged the piece. He wanted to see the dance. Wanted the cameras to show him how our feet moved through the sequence that had opened his precious room.

The nigga thought he'd found a way to steal knowledge without coming ashore.

Shawna felt my hesitation.

"What?"

"He's watching."

She looked toward the camera above the far mirror.

Then back at me.

"Then give him something worth watching."

We danced.

Not the lock. Not the seven stops. The music belonged to more than a buried door. We took the melody somewhere else, turning where the old sequence would have paused, letting a long step

become a close one, making the whole thing ours while Saint watched from the wrong end of the sea.

My wife followed me so quickly I felt drunk with being understood.

Nigga, there is power in a car. There is power in a gun. There is power in a room standing when you enter.

And then there is a woman knowing where you mean to go before you have found the words to ask her.

The last note held.

I brought her close.

We stopped together.

The room exploded.

The count didn't applaud.

His wife did.

She came over before the judges finished adding their numbers and kissed Shawna on both cheeks.

"Beautiful," she said. "Both of you."

The count stood behind her with one hand inside his jacket.

I saw the movement.

So did Porsche.

She stepped behind him and put the stolen champagne bucket over his wrist before the knife cleared the cloth.

The sound was small and expensive.

He bent forward, gasping.

Mercedes took the knife from his fingers.

"Nigga," she said, "that's not a dance move."

Graves reached us at once. He held the count while Knox checked the little radio concealed beneath his collar.

Saint's voice hissed through it.

"Did you get the sequence?"

I took the radio.

"Nigga, you gotta feel it in your hips."

I dropped it into Mercedes's empty champagne glass.

The count's wife looked at him as if she had finally found the right distance from which to see her marriage.

"A knife?" she said.

He opened his mouth.

She removed the wedding ring from her finger and placed it carefully in his jacket pocket.

"You can keep leading yourself."

Then she walked over to Isolde and asked whether she might sit with her.

The older woman made room.

They crowned Shawna first.

I insisted.

The gold laurel settled against her dark hair, and she looked at me with a happiness so bright I nearly forgot to accept my own.

Isolde raised her glass from the table.

"To people who know how to share a room," she said.

Marcellus touched his glass to hers.

Tank pulled Rosa closer.

Graves looked at Knox.

And my wife took my hand in the middle of the floor while every nigga in the room stood to see us dance once more.

17. Every City Sent a Key

By the eleventh morning, three cities had offered me keys, two had offered me houses, and one had asked whether I would consider becoming its most famous resident without technically having to live there.

"Nigga," Tank said, looking at the envelopes, "they recruiting you like weather."

We sat in the palace breakfast room with the sea beyond the windows and eight white ships still trying to make a horizon threatening. My people had spread across every comfortable chair. Mercedes read the Velvet Mile paperwork with Porsche. Rosa wrote wedding ideas on the back of a menu and crossed out every place that wasn't Vegas because Tank said if he was going to cry in front of a whole city, he wanted a city that already knew him.

Shawna sat beside me with her feet in my lap.

I opened the first envelope.

Port Carmine wanted to name its waterfront after me.

Gilded Bay wanted a photograph of me holding its rescue-service flag.

San Paloma wanted to know whether I would attend the opening of a sports arena built by a man whose nephew had been on the ferry.

"Tell them yes," I said.

"To all?" Shawna asked.

"Nigga, I got a calendar."

"You have me reminding you what day it is."

"Premium calendar."

She pinched my knee.

Then Vegas called.

One of my westside managers, a man named Boone who had never met a dollar he couldn't persuade into staying overnight. He told me the clubs were full, the new cars had arrived, and two niggas had tried telling him my absence meant their debts had become historical.

"History got interest," I said.

"That's what I told them."

"No trouble at Shawna's property. No touching the staff. And if a nigga says my badge made me forget my money, show him the part where I'm still asking about it."

Knox looked up from her coffee.

I looked back.

She took another sip.

Nigga, we understood each other. I wasn't going home to become a decorative good man. I had built an empire full of

cash, cars, vice, and people who knew which door to knock on when their own night got complicated. The badge had given my jacket another beautiful place to shine. It had not turned the rest of me into a church bulletin.

By noon the visiting dignitaries arrived carrying velvet boxes. No speeches about policy. Thank God. These people had seen enough of my week to know a nigga should not be trapped behind a podium if anything with an engine remained nearby. The woman from Port Carmine handed me a gold key shaped like a fish.

"Our harbor," she said.

The man from Gilded Bay gave me a silver key shaped like a wing.

"Our sky."

San Paloma gave me a key that looked almost normal until I realized it had my face engraved on the teeth.

Tank leaned close.

"Nigga, you can unlock your own mouth."

I nearly ruined the photograph laughing.

Then Shawna received a key too.

Blue enamel. A little treble clef worked into the handle. The woman from Port Carmine presented it with both hands.

"For the hall where we want you to sing," she said.

My wife stared at it.

I watched her thumb move over the blue enamel. The crowd waited, cameras raised, but she took one small second for herself before smiling.

"I'd like that," she said.

Nigga, I would have bought that whole harbor for the way she looked at the key. But somebody else had heard her and wanted her there. I couldn't improve that by reaching for money. So I stood beside her, proud enough to hurt, and let the room give my wife something she had made happen herself.

The parade afterward was less restrained.

Cassius and Inez brought the Monaco prize cars out in a line of color so bright the street looked wet. Red, white, silver, gold, my dark-blue Lamborghini leading them with its repaired side reflecting the crowd. Mechanics had fixed the scrape while I slept. The chief's gold shield was clean again. Nigga looked rested even when I wasn't.

Mercedes drove a green convertible with Porsche beside her, both wearing scarves like the wind had been hired specifically to flatter them. Darius and Kong rode in a car too small for either man's pride, their knees practically in the windshield. Tank drove Rosa in the old black Mercedes because he said some cars earned the right to carry the good part too.

I rode with Shawna.

We passed the market. Passed Alma's kitchens. Passed the repaired ferry dock where the man I'd pulled from the water stood beside his husband holding a sign that said THE CAPTAIN CAME BACK.

Shawna touched my arm when she saw it.

I lifted my hand to them.

The whole street answered.

At the top of the hill, an armored car burst out of a side road and struck the lead escort.

The celebration broke apart.

Another car came behind it. Then a third. Black paint. Covered plates. Saint's men had stopped wearing visible crests after Porsche made the joke, but a nigga doesn't become mysterious by changing his laundry after everybody has seen his face.

Shots cracked across the road.

I pulled Shawna low and turned the Lamborghini between the attackers and the crowd. Cassius swung his red car across the opposite lane. Inez came up behind him, trapping the first armored car between two machines whose owners had already beaten an entire continent at driving.

The attacker's driver tried to force his way through.

Cassius smiled at him through the windshield.

Nigga, that smile meant a repair bill was about to become a biography.

I took the second car up the hill away from the spectators. It followed, gunfire chipping the wall beside us. Shawna held the radio in one hand and my spare magazine in the other, her face calm, her voice telling the captains exactly where the people needed space.

"Left at the fountain," she said.

"I see it."

"The lower road's clear."

"I see that too."

"Aiden."

I glanced at her.

"I am enjoying this less than you."

"Baby, I can enjoy enough for both of us."

She laughed despite the gunfire, and I took the turn.

The armored car came after us too fast. Its weight dragged it wide. I went around the fountain, crossed the little stone square, and came back against its flank while the driver still tried to persuade physics to consider his rank.

We struck hard enough to fold its front wheel under the body.

The car stopped in the fountain.

Water climbed over the hood.

For one beautiful second every statue in the square appeared to be spitting on the nigga simultaneously.

I stepped out with my gun up.

"Everybody out."

The driver opened his door into waist-deep water.

"Nigga," I said, "you picked a dramatic place to park."

Behind us, Tank had stopped the third car by putting the old Mercedes across its path and letting Darius and Kong emerge from the tiny convertible together.

The gunmen looked at the two enormous men.

One put his weapon on the dashboard before either fighter spoke.

"Intelligent nigga," Tank said.

The first armored car belonged to Cassius and Inez now, in the sense that neither of them intended to permit it another decision. Its driver came out holding both hands over his head and asking which champion was arresting him.

"All of them," Knox said, arriving with the island police.

No spectator had been hit.

One escort officer had a broken wrist. Two attackers were wounded. The fountain needed a new statue hand. My

Lamborghini's new paint had lasted approximately forty-seven minutes.

Shawna looked at the fresh scrape.

"You couldn't keep one side pretty?"

"Baby, I'm keeping both our sides alive. The car understands the priorities."

From the stalled armored car, a phone began ringing.

I answered on video.

Saint's face filled the screen.

He saw the fountain behind me.

His eyes closed briefly.

"Nigga," I said, "you should stop buying these cars if you're going to keep giving them to my city."

He opened his eyes.

"Tomorrow. The final challenge. No more proxies. You and me."

"I been here."

"At dawn, the twenty champions ride. By noon, one reaches the Crown Gate. I will be waiting."

"Wear the necklace."

His hand moved to the Lion's Heart beneath his collar.

"Earn it."

I ended the call before he could enjoy saying anything else.

The visiting officials stood at the edge of the square, velvet key boxes still under their arms. They had watched the whole thing. Their escorts had watched it. Their photographers had photographed every expensive second.

The woman from Port Carmine looked at the car in the fountain.

Then at my wife.

Then at me.

"We should give you a bigger key," she said.

Tank bent over laughing.

Nigga, every city really did want me.

18. The Night the Flags Changed

Saint tried to leave himself an escape route by burning everybody else's.

At nine that night, the guard ship Apostle turned its guns toward the outer docks.

Keel saw it from the Aurelia and called me before the first shot.

I stood on the palace balcony with Shawna beside me, still holding the tie she'd just taken off my neck. Below us the festival lights shone along the harbor. People were eating, drinking, making one more bad decision before the final championship gave them something else to discuss.

"He's aiming at the boats," Keel said. "Passenger launches. Anything that could carry spectators away."

I looked toward the white ship turning in the bay.

"Then that nigga just volunteered to become ours."

Shawna put the tie down.

No complaint. No pretending she'd rather have married a man who would watch the docks burn from a comfortable room. She went inside, brought my jacket, and helped me settle it over the shoulder that still reminded me I was made of meat under all the beautiful ideas.

"Come back," she said.

"You know where I live."

"Aiden."

I stopped smiling for one second and looked straight at her.

"I am coming back."

She nodded.

Then she picked up her phone and called Rosa to get the harbor cleared.

I took the speedboat with Tank and Graves. Knox stayed ashore directing the island officers. Keel came out from the other side in the Aurelia's launch. Four blue-flagged ships moved behind us, their captains finally given a reason to stop waiting politely for Saint to finish being wrong.

The Apostle fired.

Water erupted beside the outer pier. People ran beneath the lights. The second shot struck an empty warehouse and punched a bright hole through its roof.

I heard Rosa over the radio, steady and furious.

"Keep moving toward the square. Nobody back for a bag. Your bag can meet Jesus by itself."

Tank laughed once, hard and proud.

"That's my fiancée."

"Nigga, I recognize the management."

We reached the Apostle as its deck crew argued with the soldiers stationed above them. That mattered. Saint had brought his army aboard ships whose crews had no desire to become the men who burned a harbor full of people they had spent the week watching us save.

A sailor dropped a ladder over the side when he saw our boat.

Another man tried to pull it back up.

The sailor hit him with a bucket.

I looked at Tank.

"Mercedes started a movement."

We climbed.

On deck, the world became light, shouting, and the sharp crack of guns over open water. Graves pulled one sailor behind a hatch cover as bullets struck the rail. Tank drove into the soldiers guarding the forward stairs, huge shoulders clearing a path nobody had expected a human body to negotiate.

I went toward the bridge.

The officer in command waited beneath the windows with a pistol in his hand and a white scarf around his throat. He shouted for his crew to hold their positions.

Nobody moved toward him.

He shouted louder.

A woman at the wheel turned and looked at me.

"Captain," she said.

The officer smiled, thinking she meant him.

Then she stepped aside so I could pass.

Nigga's face changed beautifully.

"Put it down," I told him.

He raised the pistol.

I shot him before he finished deciding I was another man he could order to be afraid.

He fell against the wall and did not get up.

I stepped over the gun and looked at the woman at the wheel.

"Turn us away from the harbor."

She did.

The ship's bow began to move. On the deck below, Saint's soldiers saw the guns swing toward open water and understood command had changed without waiting for a speech.

Some dropped their weapons.

Some didn't.

The ones who didn't met Tank, Graves, and an entire crew who had become tired of letting strangers tell them what their own ship was for.

By the time Keel came aboard, the Apostle's white flag lay on the deck.

Five ships with us.

Seven with Saint.

Not for long.

Keel stood beside me on the bridge and opened the fleet channel. He didn't ask me for a speech. He simply said the captain was listening if anybody had something to say.

For a moment there was only static.

Then another voice answered.

"Saint Clement requests passage into the harbor."

Another.

"Saint Mercy joining."

Another.

"This is the Orator. We will not fire on the island."

I watched white flags come down across the bay.

One after another.

Three ships moving out of Saint's line and into ours.

Eight with us.

Four with him.

Tank came up to the bridge wiping blood from his knuckles. He looked at the changing formation and started counting again.

"Nigga, we need a bigger dock."

Graves stood beside the window, breathing hard.

"The men wanted a choice," he said.

"They made one," I answered.

The flagship's lights flashed across the water.

Saint called me.

I put him on the bridge screen so every sailor could see the face of the man who had told them to burn their own welcome.

"You have stolen my fleet."

"Nigga, your fleet drove over here."

"You bought weak men with cheap kindness."

Tank looked at the deck outside, where two of Saint's soldiers lay dead and several more sat wounded beneath a guard.

"Cheap?" he said. "Nigga, we worked."

Saint ignored him.

"The final challenge stands. Tomorrow. You will not win by collecting cowards."

I leaned close to the screen.

"Then come ashore alone and show us what courage looks like without twelve ships standing around it."

His eyes narrowed.

"I will be there."

"Wear something pretty. Whole world's watching."

I ended the call.

Keel laughed quietly beside me.

"You know exactly where to press him."

"Nigga built a whole personality out of one sore place. It's hard to miss."

We came back to the harbor before midnight.

The warehouse still smoked. Nobody had been inside. Two dockworkers had cuts from flying glass. One island officer had been shot through the leg and was already under Vega's care. Three enemy soldiers had died aboard the Apostle. The crew laid them beneath clean covers before we left. I had no soft story to tell about it. They had aimed at people who couldn't shoot back. I had brought my own answer aboard.

Shawna waited at the dock.

She counted me, Tank, Graves, Keel.

Then she came straight to me and put her arms around my neck.

I held her with both arms despite the shoulder.

Vega could bill me in the morning.

"Back," I said against her hair.

"I see you."

Behind her, Mercedes and Porsche handed blankets to the sailors coming ashore. Rosa stood beside the band, telling Silk which song the harbor needed next. Isolde and Marcellus had brought lanterns from the ballroom, and the little flames lined the repaired pier in a row of gold.

Eight blue flags moved against the dark sea.

The island began to sing.

Not my name this time. One of Shawna's songs, the harbor song, the one about getting through a night together without letting the water keep anybody it had taken a liking to.

I stood there with my wife in my arms while my ships answered with their horns.

Nigga, a man can be loud by himself.

This was what happened when the whole ocean decided to speak beside him.

19. Twenty Champions and the Nigga They Were Chasing

Saint came ashore at dawn wearing a white coat and the Lion's Heart outside it.

The red stone lay against his chest, big enough to catch the first sunlight from halfway across the harbor. Behind him came twelve guards, four cars, and a man carrying a chair. Even at the end, this nigga couldn't travel without somewhere dramatic to sit.

I watched from the palace steps beside my wife.

"He came," she said.

"Nigga couldn't stay away from an audience."

"You recognize the condition?"

I looked at her.

She smiled.

"Baby, mine is treatable with kisses. His requires a whole defeat."

She gave me one of the treatments.

I held her longer than I meant to.

Around us the team prepared for the day. Tank checked on Rosa, then checked again because becoming engaged had apparently

made him believe his eyes might miss something between looks. Mercedes and Porsche wore dark racing jackets over bright dresses. They had spent the night making sure the workers beneath the stadium knew which doors would be open when the trouble started. Nobody was going to get trapped in Saint's escape road because a rich man needed a shield made of people. Knox stood beside Graves with the pink flowers tucked into a little vase on the breakfast table behind them. The champagne bucket had returned to Mercedes after she pointed out that romance shouldn't monopolize a useful blunt object. Keel called from the harbor: eight ships ready to keep the four remaining white ships away from the civilian docks. Inez and Cassius waited beside their cars, both calm in the way only very fast people can be when an entire day is about to ask who they are. Marcellus came down with Isolde.

He carried the seven-stone crescent in a velvet pouch. She carried the silver plate from the saddle and the conductor's letter. Three objects. Years of people wanting them for different reasons. Now they lay together in the hands of two old lovers who had finally stopped being separated by other men's lies. "The last door," Marcellus said, "has the Lion's Heart setting. Once Saint is stopped, we can open it."

"And the bridges?" I asked.

Isolde touched the plate.

"The drawing shows where the old walkway joins the central bridge. It is still passable. The two broken spans were never the only way across."

Good. A map giving us a path, not a curse inventing another obligation. I was done chasing pieces around my own fucking island.

Vega checked my shoulder one last time.

"Better," she said.

"That's what I like hearing."

"It remains attached to a mortal man."

"Doctor, don't say that in front of the fans."

She didn't laugh. But her hand rested on my arm a moment longer than the examination needed.

"Come back where I can complain about you."

"Always room for your hobbies."

Then I took my wife aside, just beyond the doorway where the morning couldn't make a spectacle out of every word.

She straightened the cross against my chest.

The gold had warmed against my skin. The little letters caught the light as she touched them: DBM. Damn, boy. Magnificent. Dante's old boast, my wife's old private joke, a thing that had survived enough bad men to deserve a place in a better morning.

"Still suits you," she said.

"Nigga, I've been trying."

She laughed softly and kissed the cross, then my mouth.

"Win your ridiculous championship," she said. "Then come find me."

"Where?"

"Wherever you left the blue piano."

I put my forehead against hers.

For one breath I let the whole world wait outside the door.

Then I went down to the starting line.

Twenty champions waited beneath the stadium arch. Some had won races. Some had won strength, endurance, precision, strategy. All had qualified for the final route through the island, thirty miles of road, water, and the old mountain passage ending at the Crown Gate. Saint would face the first arrival in the final defense of his founder's title.

It was a ridiculous arrangement designed by a nigga who wanted the privileges of winning before anybody had finished competing.

I intended to improve it personally.

The opening leg belonged to cars.

My Lamborghini waited in its dark blue paint, gold badge bright, fresh scrape along one side like a little signature from yesterday's fountain conversation. I put my hand on the hood before getting in.

"Last busy morning," I told it.

Cassius heard me.

"Nigga, that car knows you lying."

"A vehicle should have dreams."

He laughed and climbed into his red machine.

Inez stopped beside my window.

"I am not letting you win because you saved half the island."

"Nigga, I saved the half with good judgment. Try representing it."

She grinned, slapped the roof, and went to her own car.

Saint addressed the crowd from his platform. He spoke of courage, dominion, the ancient right of a champion to rule what he had conquered. The audience listened with the polite impatience people reserve for the man standing between them and the thing they actually paid to see.

Then he said my name.

The crowd answered so loudly the microphone fed back.

He waited for it to stop.

It didn't.

Nigga had to start the race while people were still shouting for the man he wanted dead.

I could have loved that moment for a whole year.

Instead I drove.

We hit the first boulevard twenty engines wide, the sound rolling between the palace walls and out over the water. Cassius took the lead. Inez went outside him. Two police captains came up behind me, their lighter cars quick through the first bends. I held the center and let the Lamborghini settle into its own voice before asking it for anything louder.

At the market turn, the street narrowed.

I knew that street. I had chased gunmen through it, fed sailors beside it, watched my wife receive a key to a concert hall from a woman who had never known her name before the harbor song. The place wasn't scenery anymore. I knew where Alma's cooks stood to watch. I knew which balcony had a loose blue shutter. I knew the little rise before the stone bridge because my car had complained about it twice already.

The other drivers saw a corner.

I saw the island I'd spent twelve days learning how to come home to.

I passed two cars before the bridge.

Cassius saw me in his mirror and laughed. I knew because he always tilted his head when a race became the kind of argument he wanted to remember.

Inez stayed beside him, fierce and clean, refusing every easy opportunity to let the road blame her for something she hadn't chosen.

The three of us reached the harbor gate together.

The second leg waited on the water: racing launches tied to a long pontoon, one for each competitor. We left the cars, ran down the steps, and jumped into boats as the officials released the lines.

I was third out.

For a moment the sea spread before us with the morning laid flat across it, every wake carving a bright line toward the headland. The island behind us shouted. The ships beyond us watched. Somewhere on one of those decks a sailor probably decided he had never seen a man enjoy his own trouble more than I was enjoying mine.

Nigga would have been correct.

I caught Cassius before the first buoy. Inez caught both of us around the next. We traded the lead along the headland, the water lifting our bows, spray hitting our faces hard enough to make the whole world taste alive. No Blue Thunder. I didn't need it yet. I had a boat that wanted to move and two friends

who wanted to beat me honestly enough to make winning worth the breath.

Then the black barrier rose across the narrow channel ahead.

Not part of the course.

A steel gate between the old sea towers, pulled up by men on Saint's remaining guard launch. I saw the top bar break the water. Saw the boats behind us still accelerating toward the passage. Saw the driver ahead of the pack realize too late that the route had become a wall.

Inez turned first.

Her hull skidded across the chop, clearing the barrier by a length that made my stomach tighten. Cassius followed. The fourth boat tried to go between them and struck the gate's rising edge.

Its bow lifted.

The driver went over the side.

I turned back.

Of course I turned back. Nigga, you can hate losing and still understand what a human body looks like when the water closes over it.

The man surfaced beside the gate, coughing, one arm hanging wrong. I brought the launch alongside and reached with my good hand. He caught my wrist. I pulled until the shoulder burned and the man came over the rail in a heap of wet anger.

"My race," he gasped.

"Still breathing. Plenty of time to complain about it."

Saint's guard launch turned toward us.

Before its gunman could rise, a blue-flagged patrol boat crossed between us. Graves stood at the bow with Knox beside him.

Their return fire drove the guard crew down while island sailors lowered the barrier again.

The channel opened.

Knox looked at me across the water.

"Finish, Captain."

I looked at the injured competitor.

He pointed ahead with his working arm.

"Nigga, you heard her."

I put him aboard the patrol boat and went.

The leaders had gained a long stretch. I could see their wakes curving toward the mountain dock, pale lines against the blue.

My shoulder throbbed. My hands felt steady enough, but I knew the difference between wanting more and having more.

I gave the engine one brief pulse of Blue Thunder.

One.

The boat answered with a bright surge that flattened the distance in front of us. Wind struck my face. The wake behind me glowed blue for a heartbeat and disappeared.

Then I let it go.

The exhaustion came as a hollow feeling beneath my ribs, not enough to stop me, enough to remind me the power had accepted payment. I breathed through it and let the boat's own speed carry the rest.

At the mountain dock I was second.

Inez waited at the foot of the stone steps, already out of her launch.

She looked at me and shook her head.

"You went back."

"Nigga was in the water."

"I know."

She slapped my shoulder gently, then ran up the steps before admiration could cost her the lead.

The third leg crossed the mountain passage on foot.

No cars. No horses. No boats. Just a steep old road winding through tunnels and terraces toward the Crown Gate. The contest wanted endurance now, after speed had spent everybody's breath. Spectators lined the safe sections, shouting encouragement from behind ropes. I heard my name. Heard

Inez's. Heard Cassius coming up behind me cursing the man who had invented stairs.

Halfway up, the path opened onto a terrace where the old king had once kept statues of himself doing things his body had probably never attempted.

Saint's men waited behind the last statue.

Four of them.

No cameras aimed there until Porsche's little filming crew, following from the upper path, rounded the bend.

The gunmen saw the lens.

Saw me.

Two hesitated.

The third lifted his weapon.

I hit him before he had a line to shoot along. My shoulder screamed. I ignored it long enough to drive him into the statue's stone base and take the gun away. Inez came back down the path like a woman personally offended by an unfair corner. She knocked another man's legs out from under him. Cassius reached us with a rock in one hand and the exhausted rage of a driver forced to exercise on purpose.

The last two men dropped their guns.

"Niggas," Cassius said, breathing hard, "I did not climb all this way to become patient."

The camera caught every second.

By the time we reached the Crown Gate, the whole stadium had seen the ambush fail.

I crossed first.

Inez came three steps behind me.

Cassius followed, bent forward with his hands on his knees and a promise to buy an elevator for the mountain if he survived the afternoon.

The gate opened.

Below us the stadium rose in a circle of blue and gold.

Thousands of people stood. The ships sounded their horns from the harbor. My wife waited at the edge of the platform with a towel in her hands and the face I had been running toward all morning.

I went straight to her.

She wiped the sweat from my forehead.

"One pulse?"

"One."

"Shoulder?"

"Complaining."

"Husband?"

I put my hand over hers.

"Right here."

Saint stood at the center of the arena beneath the enormous crown trophy.

His chair waited behind him.

The Lion's Heart burned red against his white coat.

He looked up at the gate, at the crowd on its feet, at the woman touching my face like winning only mattered because she still had a face to touch.

For the first time since I'd met him, the nigga looked small without being far away.

I kissed my wife.

Then I went down to finish the conversation.

20. The Last Thing the General Learned

Saint took off his white coat slowly, giving the cameras time to love the motion.

They didn't.

Every camera kept finding me instead.

I stood opposite him on the arena floor with sweat drying on my face, my shoulder hurting, and the last of the Blue Thunder spent somewhere between a drowning man and a mountain full of armed niggas. My wife had given me water. My brother had put his forehead against mine and said one word.

"Finish."

I intended to.

Saint wore a black fighting shirt beneath the coat. No medals now. Only the Lion's Heart at his throat. He was broader than he'd looked sitting down, strong through the arms, his movements clean. A man who had trained for violence and then spent years paying other men to do the inconvenient parts.

"You are tired," he said.

"Nigga, you been avoiding me for twelve days. I had to find hobbies."

"You have mistaken popularity for power."

I looked around the stadium.

At the island captains standing beside the exits.

At the sailors watching from the upper rail.

At the people we had pulled off boats, trains, broken platforms,
and all the other places his ambition had become somebody
else's problem.

Then I looked back at him.

"Nigga, you keep mistaking an audience for people who can't
make up their minds."

He smiled thinly.

"Three falls. The founder's defense. Yield, or be put down."

"Let's see what the chair taught you."

The bell rang.

He came fast.

Faster than I expected, which was my last free mistake. His first
strike hit my guard. The second found the side of my body I'd
turned too slowly to protect. Pain sharpened the stadium lights. I
moved back, let him pass, answered with a short blow he took
without changing expression.

The nigga could fight.

I wasn't going to pretend otherwise because the crowd wanted
me to be invincible. I had spent enough of my life being

underestimated to recognize the danger of returning the favor out of vanity.

He worked the injured shoulder.

Of course he did. Saint had watched every recording. He knew where the train had left its hand on me. He drove toward it with a patience that made his cruelty useful. Every time I turned away, he forced me into another angle. Every time I planted, he made the next movement cost more than the last.

I heard Shawna call my name once.

Not frightened.

Certain.

Like she was reminding the nigga inside my body which man he was supposed to be.

I stopped retreating in the direction Saint wanted.

His next blow came where my shoulder had been. I wasn't there. I came up beside him, close enough that his reach stopped being an advantage, and put him down against the mat with both of us breathing hard.

The referee counted the fall.

The crowd exploded.

Saint rose slowly.

His mouth had stopped smiling.

"One," I said.

He wiped his lip with his thumb.

"You think that means anything?"

"Nigga, the board seems excited."

The second fall took longer.

He made me work for every inch. I felt the morning in my legs, the boat in my hands, the train in my shoulder. He hadn't climbed the mountain. Hadn't pulled anyone from the water. He was fresh, furious, and strong enough to make those facts matter.

He caught my ankle during a turn and sent me down.

I hit the mat hard.

The stadium gasped.

Saint stood over me.

"There is the man beneath the legend."

I looked up at him.

"Nigga, the man still married. You're not improving my alternatives."

Somewhere above us Tank laughed like a gunshot.

I got up.

One fall each.

The last one would decide it.

Saint looked toward the tunnel behind his chair.

Just once.

But I saw it.

His escape road. His waiting cars. His plan to turn the audience into cover if the applause went wrong.

I looked toward the same tunnel.

Mercedes stood at its far end with Porsche beside her. Behind them the palace workers were already walking away from the lower rooms, guided by the driver who had come to our table the day before. Every person Saint meant to use was leaving while he stood here trying to prove he had control.

Mercedes lifted one hand.

Done.

I turned back to him.

"No more furniture hiding behind your chair," I said.

His eyes narrowed.

The final bell rang.

He attacked harder now, patience burning away under the insult. That was what I had wanted. Not for the nigga to become stupid all at once. Men like Saint don't stop being dangerous because you hurt their feelings. They become dangerous in a narrower direction.

I let him choose it.

Let him believe the injured shoulder was all the map he needed.

When he committed, I moved with the blow instead of against it, turned through the small space his anger had left, and brought him down before his feet could find the ground he expected.

He struck the mat on his back.

I held him there.

He fought to rise.

I held.

The referee counted.

The stadium counted with him.

At the final number, Saint stopped struggling for one second because the sound of thousands of people agreeing he had lost hit him harder than I had.

The bell rang.

I stood.

World Champion of Everything.

The whole arena came up around me.

Niggas shouting. Women screaming. Flags moving. My brother on his feet with Rosa beside him. My wife looking at me with both hands against her mouth, eyes bright, her whole body already moving toward the stairs.

I looked straight at her.

That was my crown.

Saint pulled the knife from beneath the edge of the mat.

The referee saw it too late.

I caught Saint's wrist as he rose. The blade passed my side close enough to cut the shirt. We collided against his chair, wood cracking beneath our weight. The Lion's Heart swung between us. I caught the chain with my free hand and pulled.

It broke.

The red stone came into my palm.

Saint saw it and made a sound I'd never heard from him before.

Not command.

Need.

He drove his shoulder into me and ran for the tunnel.

Gunfire began above the arena.

His remaining guards had been waiting for the signal. They stood from their places along the upper rail, weapons raised toward the crowd.

The island captains were already there.

Knox had placed them beside every exit and stair. Graves moved across the lower platform with his gun up. Keel's sailors pulled spectators behind the concrete barriers. Rosa took the

microphone and told the audience where to go, her voice cutting through the panic with the same force that had filled the room when she sang about Tank.

Shawna reached me at the edge of the floor.

"The stone," she said.

I put it in her hand.

"Take it to Marcellus."

She gripped my wrist.

"You come too."

I looked at the tunnel Saint had vanished into.

Then back at her.

"I'm bringing the end."

She kissed me once, hard and quick, and went toward the guarded palace passage with Porsche and Mercedes.

Tank came beside me.

"Nigga?"

"Nigga."

We ran.

The lower road thundered with engines.

Saint had four cars waiting beneath the stadium. Three stood empty because the drivers had left with the workers. The fourth

roared toward the far tunnel with Saint in the passenger seat and one loyal guard behind the wheel.

My Lamborghini waited at the near entrance where Cassius had left it.

Keys inside.

Engine warm.

Some friendships save time in beautiful ways.

Tank got in beside me.

I drove.

The tunnel narrowed around us, lights streaking across the windshield. Ahead, Saint's black car swerved between support columns, its rear end striking sparks from the wall. He fired back through the broken rear window. Glass burst across my hood. I kept the Lamborghini steady and let the distance shrink.

No Blue Thunder left.

No need to pretend there was.

Just my hands, my car, my brother, and a nigga who had run out of other people to stand between us.

We came out beneath the palace into the old garden road. Saint's driver took the turn too fast. The car slid across the gravel and struck the low wall beside the ruined ballroom.

Saint got out before it stopped moving.

He ran through the arch.

Toward the open stair.

Shawna and Marcellus had already opened the antechamber from the palace side with Isolde's help. They stood at the far end of the ballroom behind Graves and two officers who had come through the upper passage. Saint saw them, saw the red stone in Marcellus's hand, and fired.

Graves pulled the old man behind the pillar.

Shawna returned fire from the other side.

Saint ducked down the stair.

I followed him into the dark.

The river chamber opened ahead, lit now by the lamps Isolde and the workers had brought along the upper path. The great doors stood beyond the water, black and gold, waiting like they had all the time in the world.

Saint stood at the center of the bridge with his gun raised.

I stopped behind the lion's stone paw.

"No more crowds," he called.

"Nigga, you the one who kept inviting them."

He fired.

Stone jumped beside my face.

I waited for his next movement, saw the angle change, and came out far enough to answer. My shot struck his shoulder. He staggered against the rail but stayed upright.

Tank entered behind me.

Saint turned toward him.

I fired again.

The gun left Saint's hand and struck the bridge stones.

He stared at the empty hand.

Then at me.

For a moment the only sound was the river.

I walked onto the bridge.

He backed toward the vault doors, one hand pressed against his wounded shoulder, his face gray beneath the fury.

"I could have made you rich beyond anything you understand."

"Nigga, you couldn't even make yourself happy."

"You think a woman and a crowd are enough?"

I looked past him at the great closed doors.

At all the wealth he had spent twelve days trying to reach while the people who worked for him went hungry.

Then I looked back at the nigga.

"I think you saw something you couldn't buy and tried killing everybody who had it."

He came at me with the knife he'd kept in his boot.

Fast.

Desperate.

Still dangerous.

I shot him before he reached me.

He fell against the vault door, slid down its black face, and sat at the foot of the thing he'd wanted more than the men who had carried him across the sea.

His hand opened.

The knife struck the floor.

Solomon Saint died looking at a door he never opened.

I stood there until I knew there would be no next movement.

Then I lowered the gun.

Tank came across the bridge and put a hand on my back.

Neither of us said anything for a moment.

Above us, faint through the stone, the stadium bells began ringing.

The championship was over.

The guards who had survived had surrendered. The crowd was safe. The last four white ships were lowering their flags rather than die for a dead man's pride.

I learned all that afterward.

Right then I heard my wife's footsteps on the bridge.

I turned.

She came straight into my arms.

The red stone was safe with Marcellus. My brother stood beside me. The river kept moving beneath our feet. My body hurt in every place a body could store a long day.

Shawna put both hands against my face.

"Finished?" she asked.

I looked over her shoulder at the man beneath the vault door.

Then back at her.

"That nigga is finished."

She closed her eyes and leaned her forehead against mine.

"Good," she whispered. "I have been waiting to kiss the world champion without somebody trying to shoot him."

"Baby," I said, "the line starts here."

She kissed me until the whole underground kingdom felt smaller than the place her hands held.

21. Nigga, We Found the Other Rich

The vault opened so quietly it offended Tank.

Marcellus put the Lion's Heart into the empty setting. Isolde turned the old silver plate beneath it. Somewhere inside the wall, a mechanism that had outlived several terrible men finally completed the conversation it had been built to have.

The doors moved.

No explosion. No thunder. No choir.

Tank stared.

"Nigga, after all that, it could at least sing."

Then the light reached the first room.

My brother stopped complaining.

Gold.

Not a little gold. Not a rich man opening a drawer to remind another rich man the night could become competitive. Gold stacked along the walls, gold bowls taller than the champagne bucket, gold coins in low stone bins, gold bars laid in rows beneath a balcony whose rail appeared to have been built by somebody who believed iron was an insult.

Beyond it stood another room.

And another.

Jewels under glass. Paintings in covered racks. Crowns resting on velvet like somebody had put several countries to bed and forgotten to wake them. A line of old cars beneath dust-coated sheets, their shapes long and beautiful enough that Cassius made a sound I had previously heard only when Inez entered a room.

"Nigga," Tank said.

Nobody answered.

"Nigga."

Still nothing.

"I need one nigga to acknowledge what the fuck I'm looking at."

Mercedes walked past him toward a cabinet full of necklaces.

"Baby, we're busy."

I stood beside Shawna at the threshold.

For once I didn't immediately imagine buying something.

I had walked in already rich. Already king of an island. Already carrying more money around in the paint on my cars than I'd once imagined seeing altogether.

This was a different rich.

This was the kind of rich that made previous rich sit quietly and wait to be introduced.

Shawna looked up at me.

"Breathe."

"Baby, I might own the air."

She laughed, and the sound traveled through rooms that had waited decades to hear something worth keeping.

Marcellus moved carefully between the cabinets. He didn't grab. Didn't rush. He examined a clasp here, a stone there, the old man's eyes going sharp with the pleasure of work made well by hands he would never meet.

Isolde walked beside him.

At the third case she stopped.

A pair of silver dancing shoes rested on a black cushion. Small sapphires ran along the straps. Beneath them lay a card in Bellanotte's handwriting.

FOR THE WOMAN WHO WILL LEARN TO STAY.

Isolde looked at the card for a long time.

Then she turned it face down.

"He never understood," she said.

Marcellus took her hand.

"No."

They left the shoes in the case and walked on together.

I watched them go.

Nigga had buried a fortune underground because he couldn't make a woman want the room he'd put her in. Thirty-five years later she came back holding the hand of the jeweler he'd told to know his place.

Some losses deserved interest.

Tank found a crown large enough for his head and stood in front of a dusty mirror.

Rosa came beside him.

"Too much?" he asked.

She considered the crown.

Then his face beneath it.

"For breakfast, yes."

He took it off immediately.

"Wedding?"

"We'll discuss it."

Nigga looked happier about that uncertain answer than he had about finding the gold.

Porsche opened a shallow drawer and found rings arranged by color. She called Mercedes over. The two women stared at them, then at each other.

"Hotel elevator," Mercedes said.

"What?" I asked.

"I want the hotel elevator blue. This blue."

Porsche nodded. "And the roof needs a pool."

They were standing in a king's treasure room using it to argue about a business they would own together. I liked that so much I told them the pool could have a second pool if the first one got lonely.

"Nigga," Mercedes said, "don't encourage me without a ceiling."

"We bought a roof. Put your ceiling somewhere else."

Farther back, Graves found the documents.

Not loose papers scattered for dramatic convenience. Shelves of ledgers, sealed boxes, old deeds, marriage settlements, letters, maps, records of money passing between men who had called themselves sovereign while borrowing from the same rooms.

He opened one book and went quiet.

Knox came beside him.

I saw their faces change and left the jewelry cabinet.

"What?"

Graves turned the book toward me.

The crowned lion appeared at the top of the page. Beneath it, a list of names and properties. A family of ports. Shipping companies. Private banks. Palace estates. The kind of old wealth that kept producing new disguises while the same people remained underneath.

"The king wasn't only hiding money," Graves said. "He was hiding who owned it."

Knox opened a second book.

Love letters inside.

Real ones. Angry ones. A woman's note telling a prince she would wait at the east door until midnight and not one minute longer. A husband's promise to leave a title behind if his wife would leave a marriage she had been sold into. Photographs of couples who had never been permitted to appear beside one another in public.

Private lives, kept like chains.

I looked toward the gold rooms.

Then back at the letters.

"These mattered more," I said.

Knox nodded.

Men could replace money. They couldn't replace a secret after somebody else put it in the wrong hands.

Keel arrived with a black case recovered from Saint's car. One of the drivers who had come to Mercedes and Porsche recognized it and brought it under guard. It held the general's current papers: recent photographs, marked copies of old records, letters bearing a midnight crown instead of the seven-point saint.

The old books and the new papers matched.

Same properties.

Same families.

Different names on the envelopes.

Saint had been collecting the remaining pieces for somebody else.

Graves read the heading on the newest letter.

"Emperor Zero."

Tank looked over my shoulder.

"Nigga couldn't pick a smaller problem for us after dying?"

The letter did not ask Saint to conquer the island for its beaches.

It asked him to recover the ownership books and the private correspondence attached to them. The writer intended to put the old claims beside new debts, buy men who could be bought, expose men who could be frightened, and take the rest by force.

There were names of rulers in it, but that wasn't the part that held me.

It was the ordinary things beneath the titles.

A woman kept from the man she loved because her family owed the wrong bank.

A captain ordered away from home until he agreed to command a ship he hated.

A marriage treated as a receipt.

Nigga had found a way to put prices on the hours people were supposed to choose for themselves.

I thought of Flint calling Sabine.

Of Marcellus's letters never reaching Isolde.

Of Shawna saying she'd have chosen me in a room without a window.

Then I closed the book.

"Where is he?"

Graves turned the last page.

Midnight City.

A kingdom above the Mediterranean, old stone rising over a port full of modern money. A place where the owners of ugly empires wore beautiful jackets to decide which one of them deserved the next crown.

At its center stood the Crown of Midnight.

Marcellus came to the table when he heard the name.

"A jewel?" Shawna asked.

"A very old one," he said. "The crown identifies the holder of certain royal claims. The real value is what travels with it. The register. The authority people agree to recognize."

"Not magic," Tank said.

Marcellus looked at him.

"No."

"Good. Nigga tired of explaining ordinary rich already."

My phone rang before we finished reading.

An unknown number.

I answered because I'd come too far to let a ringing phone develop an opinion of itself.

A man appeared on the screen sitting in a dark room beneath a crown-shaped light.

Older than Saint. Or maybe simply calmer about being old.

Silver at the temples, dark suit, no mask. His face was handsome in the expensive, practiced way of a man who had spent years making other people wait for the end of his sentence.

"Captain Aiden," he said.

"Nigga, everybody got my number today."

"The world watches its new champion."

"Then the world saw your collector lose."

His eyes moved once, almost a smile.

"Solomon was useful until he began mistaking borrowed importance for ownership."

"Dead nigga's friends always got criticism ready."

"I did not call to mourn him."

"Then get to your point. My wife and I found a room full of diamonds. We're busy."

He leaned forward.

"Come to Midnight City. The tournament of criminal kings begins soon. Bring your winnings. Bring your courage. Let us see whether the man who won everything on an island understands what a crown means elsewhere."

I looked at my people around the table.

My wife.

My brother and his future wife.

The two women planning a hotel from a dead king's colors.

The old lovers holding hands beside letters that had tried to keep people apart.

Then I looked back at the screen.

"Nigga, you should've let me enjoy my vacation."

The man's smile finally appeared.

"I am Emperor Zero."

"I'm Aiden."

"I know."

"Good. Saves time when you hear people shouting it."

I ended the call.

For a moment nobody spoke.

Then Porsche looked at the map.

"Mediterranean," she said. "Good weather."

Mercedes nodded. "Hotel ideas."

Tank rubbed a hand across his face.

"Niggas really can't let a man get married before finding another crown."

Rosa took his hand.

"Then we make the wedding bigger."

Shawna looked at me.

"We choose this," she said. "All of us."

I nodded.

No letter had written our next step for us. No dead king owned it. We could have closed the books, kept the gold, and spent the rest of the year congratulating ourselves beneath better weather.

Instead my wife put her hand on the map, and my brother put his hand beside hers, and the room filled with the quiet certainty of people who knew whose cars they intended to ride in.

Nigga, we had found the other rich.

Now we were going to find the man who thought it belonged to him.

22. A Nigga Leaves with More Than He Brought

We buried Solomon Saint on a hill where he could overlook the island without making any more decisions about it.

No statue. No giant speech. His surviving men were permitted to attend, and the ones who had surrendered kept their lives. The ones who had ordered attacks on civilians went with Knox's officers to answer for them. I didn't stand at the grave pretending I'd discovered forgiveness between the gunfight and breakfast.

The nigga had tried killing my people.

I had killed him first.

The island got another morning.

That was the part I cared about.

By noon all twelve ships flew blue.

They lined the bay with their crews on deck, horns sounding one after another as the flags went up. Keel stood beside Dawn on the first pier. Graves had a new jacket. Knox had the expression of a woman watching a successful operation while refusing to admit how much she enjoyed the man standing next to her.

Tank counted the ships twice.

"Twelve," he said.

"Nigga, you found multiplication?" Mercedes asked.

"I found ownership. Different joy."

The champagne bucket stood on the table between them full of blue roses. It had survived a gunfight, a romance, a knife attack, and several afternoons of Mercedes refusing to let anyone call it unnecessary.

"That bucket gets a room at the hotel," Porsche said.

"That bucket gets a suite," Mercedes answered.

I stood on the pier with Shawna beside me and the championship crown in my hands.

It was ridiculous.

Gold inside gold inside gold, all those points reaching upward like the thing was trying to win another competition against itself. Saint had designed it for a head that needed help looking important. On me, it just looked like the jeweler had finally been given enough room to express his opinion.

Shawna put it on my head.

The harbor roared.

Niggas on boats. Niggas on roofs. Niggas in the square who had been calling me captain twelve days earlier and now needed three titles just to finish the first breath. The heavyweight champions stood beside the scientists. The cooks stood beside the cops. Sex workers leaned over the balcony of the best hotel on the island and waved silk scarves at the man who had just helped two of their friends buy one of their own.

I held my wife's hand up with mine.

The roar got louder.

"That's your woman," somebody shouted.

"Nigga," I called back, "that's why I'm standing this straight."

They laughed and kept cheering.

Then the island gave Shawna her own stage.

Not another temporary platform over Alma's vegetables. A permanent pavilion at the water, open to the sea, with a roof shaped to carry a singer's voice into the square. The workers had been finishing it while the championship kept us busy. Tomas showed her the name above the entrance.

SHAWNA'S HARBOR.

She stopped walking.

I watched her read it once.

Then again.

"They asked me," I said quietly. "I said ask her."

She looked at Tomas.

He held out the little ceremonial key.

"May we?"

My wife nodded before she trusted her voice.

Then she hugged him, and Alma, and the two young adult carpenters standing beside the entrance looking more frightened of her gratitude than they'd been of the general's soldiers.

I stood back and let her have it.

A nigga can give his wife diamonds. I had done that with enthusiasm. This was people giving her a place because she had already put something in their lives they wanted to keep hearing. She sang there that evening.

The blue piano came off the yacht, carefully, with Tank's engineer supervising every inch as if the instrument had a nervous system he had personally promised to protect. Rosa joined her. Silk brought the band. Darius attempted a backing vocal until Kong informed him that friendship did not require lying about pitch.

The harbor ate, drank, danced, and spent enough money to make my westside managers proud from a distance.

I had kept the empire. The cars. The clubs. The island. The twelve ships. The new fortune waiting in the vault while Marcellus and the people who understood old art made sure we didn't treat a painting like an expensive tablecloth.

I was still a criminal.

Still a captain.

Still the nigga my wife could order into a chair when my shoulder hurt.

Nothing I had won improved on the last one.

Near midnight, Knox found me beside the water.

Graves stood a little distance behind her, giving us room without looking like he wanted to be anywhere else.

"I'm going back to Vegas," she said.

"City misses your sunshine."

"Someone has to prevent your officers from requesting Lamborghinis as standard equipment."

"Forward-looking niggas."

She almost smiled.

"Graves is coming with me."

I looked past her at the man.

He stood straighter.

"Police business?" I asked.

Knox looked me directly in the eyes.

"Some."

Nigga, I had never respected a one-word answer more.

I offered Graves my hand. He shook it hard.

"Look after her," I said.

The chief raised an eyebrow.

"And let her look after you," I added. "Nigga, I know the arrangement."

Graves smiled.

Knox took his hand when they walked away.

No hesitation. No pretending the crowd couldn't see it. She pulled him close at the end of the pier and kissed him under the harbor lights while the band played something slow.

Tank saw from across the terrace.

He slapped my arm.

"Nigga, the police got romantic jurisdiction."

"Let the woman work."

Marcellus and Isolde sat beneath the new pavilion's side lanterns with two untouched glasses of wine between them. His Blue Mercy ring caught the light when he moved his hand. The real stone, the one we'd already bled for before all this, still belonged to him.

Isolde touched the setting with one finger.

"Celeste's?" she asked.

He nodded.

"It's beautiful."

"Yes."

There was no argument in it. No woman asking a man to prove new love by throwing old love into the sea.

Marcellus took a small box from his pocket.

Inside was a bracelet of seven tiny blue stones, their settings joined by a narrow line of silver shaped like dancing feet.

"This one," he said, "I made for you."

Isolde looked at it for a long time.

Then she held out her wrist.

He fastened it with steady hands.

"No more letters that don't arrive," she said.

"No more leaving without saying where."

She kissed him, and the old nigga smiled so hard I looked away to give the moment something cameras didn't need to own.

They would travel together. Isolde wanted to see Midnight City, whose dance halls she'd known when she was younger.

Marcellus wanted to go wherever she intended to wake up next.

He pretended his decision was professional interest in the Crown of Midnight until she touched his cheek and told him he had always been a poor liar when he was happy.

Mercedes and Porsche showed me the first sign design for the Velvet Mile.

Green and violet. Their colors. Their names on the papers. My money in the walls, their decisions inside them.

"Opening in Vegas after the work is done," Porsche said.

"Aiden brings the cars," Mercedes added.

"Nigga, I bring the whole street."

They kissed my cheeks at the same time, then went back to arguing about whether the rooftop pool needed a piano of its own.

My wife heard that from the stage.

"Yes," she called.

The matter was settled by the highest authority available.

Later, Tank found me at the yacht rail.

Rosa had gone below to rest her voice. He stood beside me looking at the ships for a while, the big nigga quiet in a way I had learned not to interrupt too quickly.

"Vegas," he said at last.

"For the wedding."

"Yeah."

"We'll do it big."

He shook his head, smiling.

"Nigga, I know you. Big ain't the worry. I just want everybody there."

I looked at him.

"Then everybody comes home."

He nodded.

We stood together a little longer, looking at the place we'd arrived with trouble waiting and were leaving with our people louder, richer, and more in love than the general had known how to bear.

The invitation to Midnight City lay on the table inside.

Heavy black paper. Silver letters. A crown pressed into the seal. Emperor Zero had sent it by courier after the call, as if a man became more frightening when his manners required better stationery.

The tournament of criminal kings.

A throne waiting for somebody arrogant enough to think the rest of the world would agree he belonged in it.

Nigga, I had already packed.

We left the island two mornings later.

Long enough for Vega to be satisfied I could lift my arm without making her reconsider her career. Long enough for the ships to take on crews who wanted to be aboard them. Long enough for Shawna to sing once more at her harbor and promise the audience she would come back.

Keel remained with the fleet and the island captains. Cassius and Inez stayed a little longer with their boats and their engagement, promising to answer when the next race got interesting. Darius and Silk went back toward Vegas to prepare the film celebration

and argue over its music. Knox and Graves left together. No wedding yet. Plenty of future in the way they walked onto the plane.

Our car convoy went aboard the transport for Midnight City. Dark-blue Lamborghini. Old black Mercedes. The best of the Monaco fleet. Luggage, instruments, clothes nobody needed but everybody intended to wear. Tank and Rosa. Mercedes and Porsche. Marcellus and Isolde. My wife and me.

We watched Isla Gloria fall away behind the ship.

The twelve blue flags stood above the harbor.

The pavilion roof caught the sun.

My wife leaned against me at the rail, Dante's watch warm on her wrist, my hand around hers.

"Every city wants you," she said.

"They got excellent judgment."

"What do you want?"

I looked at her.

The ocean moved around us. Ahead, another crown, another beautiful liar, another room full of men who would have to learn my name the exciting way.

Beside me, the woman I had been trying to impress since the first night looked up with sunlight on her mouth.

"Nigga," I said softly, "I'm standing next to it."

She smiled and pulled me down to kiss her.

Behind us my brother shouted that somebody had parked a Ferrari in front of the breakfast room.

Mercedes shouted back that the Ferrari looked hungry.

Rosa started laughing. Porsche joined her. Marcellus and Isolde came up the stairs holding hands like the ship had been built to take them somewhere together.

And ahead, beyond the bright water, Midnight City waited for the world champion to arrive.

Let the niggas get dressed.

I was bringing my wife.

BOOK V: THE CROWN OF MIDNIGHT

1. The City That Stayed Up for Me

Midnight City had built a throne at the airport.

I thought that was considerate as hell until a nigga in a silver cape told me it wasn't mine.

"It's for the victor of the tournament."

"Nigga, then why you making me walk past it?"

"You have not won."

"You have not seen me lose. We both working with expectations. Move the chair."

A guard behind him lowered his eyes.

"That nigga wants the throne brought over," another whispered.

"That nigga just landed."

"Nigga, I been sitting all flight. I know what kind of chair I deserve."

The first guard nodded before he remembered whose rifle he was carrying.

He had a tall hat, a little mustache, and twenty men behind him holding gold rifles. Every rifle turned toward me at the same time. Shawna stepped out of the police Lamborghini, stretched after the flight, and took one look at the situation.

"Baby, we just landed."

"I know. These niggas already hiding my furniture."

The silver cape made a noise in his throat. Tank got out of the next car carrying a garment bag in one hand and the expression he usually wore before putting somebody through a closed door. Rosa was still in the car doing her lipstick. She rolled down the window to see who was about to interrupt her vacation.

"Is that your king?" she asked the silver cape.

"I am Lord Octavian Rusk, master of ceremonies."

"Then do a ceremony where you get out of the way."

Behind us, the whole airport had stopped pretending it was busy. Pilots watched from the stairs of their jets. Baggage men stood on their carts. A woman in a white flight uniform took her sunglasses off slowly, like her eyes deserved this without anything between them and me.

I had come to Midnight City because Emperor Zero thought the world was something he could buy, and General Solomon Saint had died proving that a nigga can have a whole army and still pick the wrong island. We had found enough money under Isla Gloria to make rich men look poor. We had also found enough of Zero's secrets to make him want all of us dead.

He had sent an invitation anyway.

Black card. Silver letters. My name bigger than the address.

COME AND CLAIM WHAT YOU THINK YOU DESERVE.

Shawna had read it twice, then asked if there would be dancing.

That was why I loved my wife. A man could threaten the future of everybody we knew and this woman would still make sure I packed my good shoes.

The ship from Isla Gloria had taken us as far as the mainland port. We changed to planes there, cars loaded into cargo holds, because a nigga was not arriving at a tournament of criminal kings in a rented van.

Isolde took a different flight from the same airfield. Vegas. She wanted the room above Marcellus's workshop ready for dancing when he came home. She kissed him at the gate, straightened his collar, and told him to call before he started missing her dramatically.

The old nigga called from the next gate.

“Already?” I asked.

“We lost thirty-five years to poor timing. I'm improving.”

He held the phone out. Isolde told me to bring him back with all his fingers because she needed somebody to fasten her necklaces.

“Nigga, he heard you.”

“I want you to hear me too.”

I promised. Marcellus took his phone back and walked toward our plane smiling at it like somebody had finally taught a jewel to speak.

One of the airport workers finally came close enough to stop pretending he was moving luggage. Young nigga, twenty-seven maybe, blue uniform, white gloves, a whole expression of recognition trying to get out through his mouth.

"That's the nigga," he whispered to another worker.

"Which nigga?"

"The island nigga. The champion. The cop."

"Those the same nigga?"

I turned.

"Nigga, I heard all three descriptions."

The first worker almost dropped his clipboard.

"Captain. I watched the championship. My father said no man could do all that."

"Your father doing better now?"

He laughed so suddenly the second worker started laughing too.

"He owes me money."

"Nigga, collect it with interest. I worked hard on that argument."

Shawna leaned against my shoulder, smiling. The worker looked at her and forgot the clipboard completely. It hit the ground. His

friend caught it off the bounce and bowed like that had been a planned part of welcoming my wife.

"Mrs. Aiden," he said.

"Shawna," she told him.

"Yes. Of course. Shawna. We watched you sing. My mother made everybody be quiet. Even my father. Especially my father."

"Your mother sounds talented," my wife said.

Nigga, both workers looked blessed personally.

Rusk tried to interrupt. Neither one heard him the first time. A king could stand on a whole throne beside these niggas and still lose their attention to my wife being nice for twelve seconds.

The first worker took off his airport badge.

"Would you sign the back?"

"You sure they allow that?" I asked.

"My supervisor asked me to get his signed too."

The supervisor was standing behind a baggage cart pretending he hadn't sent the nigga over. I pointed at him. He gave up the performance and came running with his badge in his hand.

Tank watched the little line form.

"Nigga, you ain't even reached customs."

"Customs reached me."

"These niggas got jobs."

"They improving their workplaces."

Rosa took a pen out of her bag and handed it to Shawna.

"Sign the pretty side. Niggas gonna frame these."

We signed the badges. The supervisor asked whether he could name the terminal lounge after me. Rusk said that required royal authorization. The supervisor looked from Rusk to the throne to me and appeared to solve the question in a way the master of ceremonies didn't enjoy.

"We can put up a temporary sign," he said.

"Nigga, that's initiative," I told him.

By the time Vesper reached us, a porter was carrying a whiteboard across the terminal. Somebody had written CAPTAIN AIDEN'S ARRIVAL LOUNGE in blue marker. Underneath, in smaller letters, the younger worker had added AND SHAWNA'S.

My wife saw it.

"He gets a tip."

"Nigga gets a promotion if the king situation works out."

Tank shook his head.

"We been here eleven minutes."

"And you wasting them counting, my nigga. Look alive. The country learning."

"Lord whatever," I said. "Nigga, I'm tired. My wife looks beautiful. My brother got a suit in that bag that cost more than your first apartment. Look at that nigga. Does he look like he packed patience?"

Tank lifted the garment bag.

"This my good suit. Don't make a nigga meet you in it angry."

"So show us our rooms," I told Rusk, "or bring that throne closer. Nigga can keep talking while I enjoy my future furniture."

Rusk's face tightened. A few of the riflemen looked at each other. That little look meant they had already realized the same thing I had: their boss was standing too close to my hood.

Then somebody started clapping.

Slow. Three times.

A woman came down the airport steps in a dark green coat with nothing timid about it. Black hair pinned high. A gold snake around one wrist. Two guards carrying her luggage like they were transporting the last clean water on earth.

She was thirty-seven, I found out later, and she had the kind of face that could make a man apologize for a crime she had committed.

"Aiden," she said.

"That's usually who it is."

"Queen Vesper Vane."

"Queen of what?"

"You ask that before you kiss my hand?"

"Nigga, I'm married before I ask either."

Shawna laughed. Vesper looked at her, then at the wedding ring, then back at me with a smile that got sharper instead of smaller.

"How unfortunate for the city."

"The city's gonna survive," Shawna said. "I'm less sure about your master of ceremonies."

Vesper turned one finger and the gold rifles lowered.

"Lord Rusk mistakes anticipation for authority. Your rooms are ready. The opening procession is in forty minutes."

"We just flew in."

"The kings wait for nobody."

A jet engine started somewhere behind me. My police badge shone in the sun. I was looking at a queen, a throne, a thousand windows full of nosy rich people, and a city that thought forty minutes was enough time to put my wife in a dress.

"They finna learn," I said.

At the hotel entrance, the man taking our luggage dropped my smaller bag when he recognized my face.

The bag hit the marble and opened. A shirt came out. Then a shoe. Then the little framed photograph Shawna carried from our wedding.

The man went down on both knees.

“Captain. I’m sorry. I’m so—”

“Nigga, pick up my wife before you apologize to my shoes.”

He lifted the photograph carefully. The glass hadn’t broken. Shawna took it, checked the frame, and smiled at him.

“She’s fine.”

The man looked from the picture to her face.

“That’s really you.”

“Still is,” she said.

Behind him, a second porter whispered, “Nigga, I told you.”

“You said the car man.”

“That is the car man.”

“You didn’t say the wife was real too.”

Nigga, I heard every word. I stood there enjoying the exact moment two grown men realized greatness traveled with luggage and occasionally asked somebody to find the other shoe.

I took my bag off the floor myself.

The first porter tried to stop me.

“Sir, I can carry—”

“Then carry hers. Mine knows who it belongs to.”

Shawna gave him the photograph to hold while she straightened the bag. He held it with both hands, terrified of disappointing two versions of the same beautiful woman at once.

Mercedes leaned toward Porsche.

“Nigga looks like he got handed a religion.”

“Baby, look at the man standing next to it.”

I put an arm around my wife and let the porters lead us inside. Behind us, the one with the photograph kept whispering, “I told you,” and the other kept answering, “Nigga, you did not tell me enough.”

Our hotel had once been a palace. You could tell because getting to the bathroom required crossing land somebody had probably died over. Marble stairs, red carpets, chandeliers thick as trees. Two young men tried to take Shawna's bags and accidentally competed for the same handle until she assigned them separate suitcases.

Our suite overlooked the harbor. Modern yachts sat under stone walls older than everybody's grudges. Ferraris crawled along the waterfront between flower stalls and armed men drinking coffee. Above the city, on a black hill, Zero's palace stood with every window shut against the afternoon.

Shawna walked out onto the balcony and let the sea wind move her hair.

"That's pretty."

I looked at her instead.

"Yeah."

"You didn't even look."

"I looked where I wanted."

She turned with that smile I had crossed whole cities to keep, and I caught her around the waist before she could say something that would have had me canceling the tournament. For a minute there were no kings. No invitations. No bullet scars. Just my wife with her hands at my collar, straightening something that hadn't been crooked until she decided it needed attention.

"You gonna behave tonight?"

"You looking at the most beautiful behavior a nigga ever brought overseas."

"Aiden."

"Nigga, you said my name like I already did it."

"You looked at the throne like you were measuring the balcony."

"That's planning. A nigga got a wife. He thinks about where she's gonna sit."

"Beside you when you behave."

"Then I'm gonna misbehave beautifully enough you stay close."

She kissed me once, hard enough to make that answer official.

A knock came at the door. Tank carried in a black case with the hotel crest on it.

"Somebody sent you a welcome present."

I opened it. Inside was a pistol plated in white gold, a key to a red Ferrari, and a note.

FOR THE MAN WHO NEEDS HELP ARRIVING ON TIME.

"Who sent it?"

"Vesper."

Shawna read the note over my shoulder.

"She better send me something."

Another knock. Rosa came through holding a long green box.

"That queen sent you emerald earrings," she told Shawna. "I was gonna steal them, but Tank looked disappointed before I even did it."

"I was looking at your shoes."

"You were looking with judgment."

"Baby, one heel is a weapon."

"Both of them are weapons. Keep up."

Shawna opened the earrings, admired them, and set them beside the mirror without putting them on. She chose a blue pair I had given her instead. Nigga, my whole chest went stupid. People kept trying to give me cities, but my wife choosing my earrings could still knock the sense out of me faster than any man alive.

By the time we came downstairs, the procession had started without us.

There were drums outside. Horns. Men on black horses. Women in gowns riding in open cars. Every balcony on the avenue had a banner hanging from it. We were supposed to join at the front, behind the ceremonial carriage carrying an empty cushion where the Crown of Midnight would eventually sit.

The Ferrari was waiting at the curb.

So was a young hotel manager who looked ready to start a new life somewhere else.

"Captain Aiden, the avenue has been closed."

"Open it."

"I cannot. The procession route is sealed."

I looked at the route. I looked at the Ferrari. I looked at the elevated tram line running down the middle of the street.

Tank saw me looking.

"Nigga."

"What?"

"Nigga, that's a train track."

"That's a road with confidence."

"For a train."

"What this nigga have that I don't?"

"Tracks. A schedule. A whole different vehicle."

"And I got my wife looking at me. Nigga better keep his schedule."

Shawna was already getting into the passenger seat.

"Don't scratch my side."

Rosa grabbed Tank's sleeve before he could climb in behind us.

"We taking the normal road. I want to arrive with my hairstyle still believing in God."

I drove the Ferrari through the hotel courtyard, past a fountain, up a service ramp, and onto the low platform where the trams came through. A bell rang. People screamed. A tram driver leaned out and saw me coming toward him in a car that cost enough to buy his entire argument.

I took the outside rail.

The Ferrari tilted.

Shawna held her hair with one hand and my thigh with the other.

"Aiden."

"I got it."

"I know. I'm saying your name because I like it."

Nigga, I almost missed the turn.

We dropped from the platform into the procession between two marching bands. One band stopped. The other started playing louder like they were trying to survive through talent. My front tires landed inches from a drummer's shoes. He looked at me, looked at the Ferrari, and kept the beat.

I threw him a stack of money.

"That's professionalism, my nigga."

The crowd recognized the badge first. Then my face. Then the red car where no red car was supposed to be.

"Aiden!"

Somebody yelled it from a balcony. Another voice caught it. By the time we reached the empty royal carriage, the whole avenue was saying my name.

Shawna stood just enough in her seat to wave. Her blue dress caught the sun. Cameras turned away from kings who had spent years preparing to be looked at and pointed at my wife arriving late with me.

A man in a purple limousine slammed his fist against his window.

"You have broken the order!"

"Nigga, I improved it!"

That was when the first shot hit the ceremonial carriage.

The empty cushion jumped. A horse reared. The music tore apart into separate frightened noises.

I saw three black vans pull out from a side street. Men in white masks stood through their roof openings. They weren't firing into the crowd. Their guns tracked the cars carrying the visiting kings. One burst shattered the purple limousine's windshield. Another took the mirror off my Ferrari.

Shawna dropped into her seat.

"Now you can scratch my side."

I hit the gas.

The Ferrari crossed in front of the carriage as the next burst came. Glass broke above us. I pulled the white-gold pistol from its case and fired toward the nearest masked man while Shawna grabbed a fallen parade banner and threw it across the windshield of the van coming alongside.

The driver saw nothing but the city's royal crest.

He hit a flower cart so hard roses filled the air like the street had exploded romantically.

"Baby, you wrapped that nigga's whole vehicle!"

"You like my throw?"

"Nigga, I would marry that throw if I hadn't married the woman!"

"Then stop looking so pleased with that gun. Who gave you that?"

"Queen! Nigga, we can argue after the florist stops flying!"

The second van came at the carriage. Its driver wanted the road open and didn't care how many horses had to disappear to make that happen. I cut between them and caught his bumper with the Ferrari's back corner. The whole car jolted. My shoulder slammed the seat. Blue heat sparked inside my arms, that thunder I could call for a little while if I was willing to pay for it afterward.

I didn't spend it yet.

A little power was good. Knowing when a nigga needed to keep some was better.

I drove up onto the broad stone steps of the opera house. People scattered behind columns. The van followed until its front end struck a statue base and stopped hard enough to throw the masked gunman against his own roof.

The third van turned toward the harbor.

I went after it.

"Seat belt," I said.

Shawna pulled it tight.

"You say that every time we're already flying."

"Because you listen beautifully under pressure."

We passed fish stalls, a wedding party, and a priest who lifted his hands at exactly the right moment for our car to miss his sleeves. The van cut onto a loading pier. A cargo crane stood over the water with a steel container hanging from it. Beyond the pier, Vesper's black speedboat waited with its engines running.

The masked men were not trying to escape the city.

They were trying to reach her boat.

I saw Vesper on the upper dock. She saw me see her.

Neither one of us smiled.

The van braked beneath the crane. Three men jumped out. One carried a narrow silver case that must have come from the carriage during the confusion. The cushion had been empty. Something beneath it hadn't been.

I hit the blue thunder.

For three seconds the whole world became sharp.

My hands, the wheel, the engine, the air in my teeth. The Ferrari leaped forward with blue fire running across the hood. Shawna shouted my name and it sounded like a song somebody had turned all the way up.

We went off the end of the loading ramp.

The car struck the hanging container with its front wheels, rode the metal side at an angle no mechanic on earth would have

signed his name under, and dropped onto the dock between the men and the boat.

Every window on the pier shook when we landed.

My arms went dead-heavy. That was the price. I let the thunder go before it took more than I had to spend.

One masked man raised his weapon.

Shawna opened her door into him.

The second slipped on the roses still caught beneath our tire. I put him down before he could stand. The third held the silver case over the water.

"Stop or I drop it!"

I got out slowly, my legs arguing about the landing.

"Nigga, you keep threatening me with stuff I don't know the price of."

"It belongs to the emperor!"

"That explains why you're scared."

He threw it.

I caught the case against my chest with one hand and caught him by his coat with the other. For a second we were both leaning out over the harbor. He stared at the water. I stared at him.

"Nigga, can you swim?"

"No!"

"You stole a case, ran to the harbor, and dressed for a fucking ballroom? Nigga, which part did you plan?"

"Please!"

"I'm holding you, my nigga. That's why you still get to ask questions above water. Stop kicking my car."

I dragged him back and dropped him on the dock. Harbor police were finally arriving, breathless, uniforms immaculate enough to prove they'd missed most of the trouble.

Their chief took one look at my badge.

"Captain Aiden?"

"Arrest these niggas. And somebody get my wife a different car. This one got opinions now."

The chief saluted.

Nigga, he saluted so hard his hat nearly left him.

Vesper came down the steps without hurrying. Her guards stayed above. She looked at the destroyed Ferrari, the captured attackers, my wife standing on the dock with one emerald box still in her handbag, and the silver case in my hands.

"You are very difficult to welcome."

"You sent the car."

"I expected you to use the street."

"You should have said that."

I opened the case. Inside lay a strip of black velvet and a heavy gold seal marked with a crown. No jewels. No magic. Just an old piece of authority a whole lot of men had nearly died trying to move from one place to another.

Vesper's eyes changed when she saw it.

"The signet of invitation," she said. "It admits one claimant to the private rounds."

"I thought I was already invited."

"You were invited to watch."

Shawna came beside me and closed the case.

"That's embarrassing for whoever sent the invitation."

By evening the city had put my face on the side of a building.

I hadn't asked. Nigga, I had been taking a shower. I came out in a towel and there I was outside our balcony, forty feet tall, stepping out of the wrecked Ferrari with the silver case in my hand. Underneath it, somebody had written THE KING FROM THE WEST.

Tank stood at the balcony rail with a drink.

"Niggas got your good side."

"I ain't got a bad one."

"Your left shoulder looks tired."

"Nigga, that's history."

"History needs ice."

"Then put ice on the real nigga. That nigga outside forty feet tall. We can't afford his treatment."

Tank looked from me to the building and started laughing into his drink.

Shawna sat at the vanity putting on my blue earrings. Her dress for dinner was black, fitted, and personally disrespectful to every other plan I had made that night.

I went behind her and put my hands on her shoulders.

"We can stay in."

"You just stole a king's invitation."

"I can steal dinner too."

She looked at me in the mirror.

"I want to see what they do when you walk in."

So did I.

Downstairs, Lord Rusk waited by the throne from the airport. It had somehow reached the hotel before our luggage. The silver cape was gone. His new coat was black, and there was a bandage across one eyebrow where the parade had given him a different opinion about the afternoon.

"Captain," he said carefully. "The council has acknowledged your claim."

"Good."

"There are rules."

I sat down on the throne to adjust my cuff.

Every conversation in the lobby stopped.

Shawna stood beside me, her hand resting on my shoulder like she had been born knowing where a crown would eventually fit.

"Aight," I told Rusk. "Start with the interesting ones."

2. I Arrested the Man Who Paid for Dinner

The first rule was that no king could arrest another king during dinner.

"Nigga, why that first?"

Lord Rusk looked at my badge.

"Experience."

"Whose?"

"The household's."

"So some nigga already needed arresting at dinner."

"Captain—"

"Nigga, you warned the right guest. Keep reading."

The second rule was that every claimant had to bring a gift worth a million dollars. The third was that the host could reject any gift he considered beneath his station. The fourth concerned seating, inheritance, and a dead prince's second wife, and I stopped listening because Shawna had started rubbing the back of my neck.

"What counts as a gift?" I asked.

"Gold. Jewels. Land. A pledge of valuable service."

"I brought myself."

Rusk waited.

I waited back.

"Captain, surely you understand—"

"Nigga, that's at least two gifts. I'm handsome and I'm here."

Shawna bent down beside my ear.

"You forgot punctual."

"Baby, they started early."

Rusk escorted us to a car before I could improve the rules any further. Tank and Rosa followed in a black Bentley the hotel had provided after seeing what had happened to the Ferrari.

Mercedes and Porsche came down together, one in silver and the other in red, arguing about which of them a visiting prince had been looking at across the lobby.

"He was looking at me," Mercedes said.

"He was looking at the reflection of me in your bracelet," Porsche told her.

The prince hurried over holding two bouquets.

"Ladies, perhaps both—"

"Nigga, pick a struggle," I said, and kept walking.

Dinner was at the House of Nine Doors, a white mansion built over the water. Eight of its doors were enormous. The ninth was

little and blue and stood halfway up an outside wall with no stairs beneath it.

"What's that one for?" Tank asked.

"Disgraced guests," Rusk said.

"Nigga, if somebody tries to put me through a wall door, I'm taking the whole wall."

The dining room ran the length of the house. A hundred candles burned along a table set for twenty-four. Every plate had somebody's crest on it. Mine showed a wolf standing on a car, which I decided was close enough.

Vesper sat beside an empty chair at the center. Our host stood when we entered.

Baron Silas Bell was a broad man in his forties with a polished head and a beard cut so sharply it looked like it had its own knife. His suit was cream. His rings were black. He wore a little silver crown tilted to one side, like royalty had caught him off guard.

"The captain," he said. "We heard you had a dramatic journey."

"Your city put train tracks in my way."

"Those have been there seventy years."

"Nigga, they should have moved them when they heard I was coming."

A man at the far end laughed into his wine. Bell didn't.

I kissed Shawna's hand before pulling out her chair. Three other men immediately stood to help their wives sit down. One wasn't fast enough and his wife gave him a look that ruined the rest of his meal before it arrived.

Vesper watched the chain of events with open amusement.

"You have introduced a new custom."

"You niggas wasn't helping your women sit?"

"Some of us were waiting for our women to help us," said an old king with a silver beard.

His wife patted his cheek.

"And some of us are still waiting."

Wine came. Fish came. A whole roasted bird came under a dome so big two waiters had to lift it together. Tank saw it and sat straighter, finally convinced the trip had a purpose.

Before Bell could begin the formal business, a king with a ruby over one eye leaned across the table and pointed at my badge.

"Is that genuine?"

I looked down at it.

"Nigga, it better be. They made me promise things."

"You are a criminal."

"And employed. Don't limit a nigga because your imagination got narrow shoulders."

His wife laughed into her wine. He looked at her. She looked right back, still laughing, like marriage didn't require her to pretend he hadn't walked into the joke carrying his own chair.

"I mean," the king said carefully, "what do you do with the authority?"

"Usually arrive where somebody thought I wouldn't."

"And then?"

"Depends how handsome the situation is when I get there."

Tank leaned over his plate.

"Nigga, don't ask him to explain the whole career. Your food gonna retire."

The ruby-eyed king ignored him.

"I have commanded men for thirty years."

"Nigga, congratulations. They still listen?"

His wife put her glass down before she lost it entirely.

He turned a shade darker.

"My household is loyal."

"I ain't doubt your household. You the nigga doing a speech about it."

Across the table, Porsche whispered to Mercedes, "That nigga asked one question and lost three anniversaries."

"His wife smiling like she just got a present she picked herself."

Shawna laid her hand on my forearm.

"Baby. Let him eat."

I kissed her fingers.

"See? That's command. Everybody comfortable."

The old silver-bearded king at the far end lifted his glass toward us.

"I would like to propose a toast."

Bell's face tightened. Apparently he owned the toasts along with the furniture.

The old man continued anyway.

"To the captain, who has introduced three useful customs to this city in less than a day: arriving when he pleases, telling the truth about our foolishness, and looking at his wife as though he has won something more valuable than an argument."

His own wife smiled at him.

Nigga, the old man had scored one for himself on my play. I respected the movement.

Glasses rose around the table. Even the ruby-eyed king lifted his, though he held it low enough that a man could pretend he was only checking the color.

I stood.

"To everybody smart enough to enjoy me while I'm here."

Tank raised his drink higher.

"That's our nigga."

Rosa touched her glass to his.

"That's an expensive nigga."

Shawna looked up at me.

"That's my husband."

Nigga, I sat down so happily the chair probably thought it had won the toast.

Bell tapped his glass.

"Before we eat, the gifts."

A procession started at the door. Emerald swords. A model yacht with keys beneath it. A painting of Bell wearing the exact expression he was wearing while looking at the painting.

Mercedes leaned toward Porsche.

"If I ever buy a man a picture of himself, call somebody."

"I'll buy you a better man."

My turn arrived. Rusk looked nervous enough for both of us.

I stood, buttoned my jacket, and set the silver invitation case on the table.

Bell's smile vanished.

Vesper's stayed still.

"This was stolen this afternoon," I said. "Some niggas tried to make off with it while everybody was busy running. I brought it back."

"A recovered object cannot be offered as your own gift," Bell said.

"Good thing the gift is this nigga not asking why your crest was inside their van."

Bell looked at the case.

Then at me.

"You consider that a gift?"

"Nigga, I gift-wrapped the question by waiting till everybody had wine. Shawna told me to be social."

"He was excited to meet you," my wife said.

The nigga looked considerably less excited to have been met.

The room went so quiet I heard Tank put his fork down.

Shawna looked at Bell like she had been expecting him to disappoint her and was annoyed by how quickly he had managed it.

Bell spread his hands.

"Many vehicles in this city bear my crest."

"They all carry masked niggas shooting at the parade?"

"I rent to a variety of clients."

"That's a hell of a variety."

Vesper lifted her wine but didn't drink.

Bell turned his head toward a side door. A servant stepped out. Two guards took his place. Their jackets sat wrong over what they were carrying.

I knew that shape. Nigga, I had owned that shape in several colors.

"You are a guest in my home," Bell said.

"Nigga, I'm also a cop in your dining room."

"You accepted my hospitality."

"The guest accepted a bird. The cop accepted evidence. You should've asked which one was hungry."

Tank looked at his plate, then at Bell.

"And this nigga ain't even been served yet. You got problems arriving from every chair."

Rusk cleared his throat.

"The first rule—"

"I remember. No arrests during dinner."

I picked up my plate, ate one bite, and put the napkin down.

"I'm finished."

Tank stood so fast his chair slid into the man behind him. Rosa caught her wine before it tipped. Porsche took a candle off the

table. Mercedes lifted the long silver serving tray like she had been waiting all night for somebody to hand her a shield.

Bell's first guard drew.

I hit the table with both hands and tipped its heavy center section up.

The gunfire struck the underside. Plates shattered. Roast bird flew over Tank's shoulder. Every king in the room discovered a reason to be under his chair except the old man with the silver beard, who stayed seated long enough to finish his wine.

Shawna dropped behind the raised table beside me.

"You could have let me finish."

"I'll buy you another bird."

"I wanted the sauce."

"Baby, I'm arresting the sauce too."

Tank went around the end of the table and put a guard into the wine cabinet. Rosa swept broken glass away from the old queen's shoes and pulled her down behind a pillar. Mercedes caught a falling lamp on her tray, cursed its ancestors, and launched the whole arrangement at the second guard.

The curtains caught fire.

"That wasn't the plan," she said.

"It was a beautiful plan till the last second," Porsche told her, and threw a pitcher over the flames.

Bell ran through a private door.

I followed with Shawna behind me, both of us moving through the smoke and shouting while the kings crawled out of the way. A side corridor opened into a gallery full of cars. Inside the house. Nigga, the baron had parked a whole collection on Persian rugs and still expected me to respect his dinner rules.

Bell jumped into a silver coupe. Its engine screamed. Glass doors at the far end began opening.

I got into a black Ferrari beside it.

Shawna slid in with me.

"You choosing cars by color now?"

"I'm choosing the one with keys."

Bell tore through the doors onto a balcony wide enough to host another dinner. The sea flashed beneath the railing. He headed for a bridge joining the house to a neighboring tower.

I followed.

The Ferrari's tires slid on marble. My left arm still ached from the blue thunder at the pier, and I kept it honest. No power this time. Just me, the engine, and my wife's hand braced against the dash while she laughed like she had personally ordered this evening.

Bell knocked over a line of stone flowerpots behind him. One broke beneath our front tire. Another bounced against the windshield and exploded into dirt.

"He throwing gardens at us!" Shawna shouted.

"Nigga's out of ideas!"

We crossed the bridge. A servant pushing a cake cart flattened himself against the wall. I swerved, clipped the edge of the cart, and launched a six-tier cake through the open doorway of a bedroom.

Somebody inside screamed.

Then a woman shouted, "Silas, you said your wife wasn't coming!"

Shawna looked at me.

"Arrest him twice."

The bridge ended inside the tower's second-floor ballroom. Bell drove straight through a circle of musicians. They abandoned their chairs just before his car struck the little conductor's stand. My Ferrari followed beneath a chandelier that had not expected traffic.

The exit ahead was narrow.

Bell's coupe fit.

My Ferrari didn't look like it would.

I turned the wheel, rode one side up a fallen orchestra platform, and went through tilted onto two wheels. A violin bow caught in the passenger mirror. Shawna took it off carefully and laid it in her lap.

"Souvenir."

We landed on a terrace overlooking the harbor road. Bell had nowhere left to go. His car spun near the steps. He got out holding a gun and a little black remote.

"Stay there!"

I stopped.

Not because of his voice. Because four waiters and a woman in a chef's coat stood trapped between the cars. He had picked a place where somebody else would pay if the evening went wrong.

"Move them," I said.

"You don't command me in my house."

"Nigga, I been doing it for twenty minutes."

He showed me the remote.

"The garage beneath us is full of fuel."

Shawna opened her door slowly.

Bell pointed the gun at her.

My whole body went cold.

"Look at me," I said.

He did. Everybody did. There are moments when a man's voice stops belonging to his throat and comes from somewhere lower, somewhere that has buried too much to bargain politely.

"You put that on her again and you won't live long enough to hear what you pressed."

Bell's hand shook.

The woman in the chef's coat stepped sideways. Shawna noticed. So did I.

She was standing beside a large silver trolley, its top covered in empty serving dishes. I couldn't have told anybody afterward how we agreed. My wife looked at the trolley. I looked at Bell. That was enough.

"What do you want?" I asked him.

"The case. And your badge."

"Nigga, you want my jacket too? It fits better on somebody loved."

He took one angry step toward me.

Shawna kicked the trolley into his knees.

I was out of the car before he hit the ground. His gun went across the stone. I caught his wrist, drove the remote out of his hand, and pinned him against his own silver hood. The waiters

ran. The chef picked up the remote, looked at it, and made the most disgusted face of the night.

"This opens the pool cover."

Silas Bell shut his eyes.

Nigga, I laughed so hard I nearly let him go.

Nearly.

"Nigga, you threatened my wife with a swimming pool?"

"You cannot understand the pressure I am under."

The chef held up the remote.

"There are four buttons. Heating. Cover. Lights. Fountain."

"Nigga chose fountain and spoke with his whole chest," Shawna said.

I had to brace myself against the hood. Bell tried to turn.

"Stay there, my nigga. I'm laughing. I ain't resigning."

"This is humiliating."

"Nigga, you brought that from the factory. I'm only delivering the handcuffs."

Harbor Chief Lucien Ardent arrived with twelve officers and the confidence of a man who had heard I was already there. He was forty-nine, immaculate, and wearing a medal he had not possessed at the pier. Apparently the city gave them out quickly when I was nearby.

I handed Bell over.

"Attempted murder. Stolen parade furniture. Whatever you call all that dinner shit."

Ardent stared past me at the Ferrari sitting crooked beside the shattered ballroom doors.

"You brought that through the tower?"

"Most of it."

One of his officers leaned toward another.

"That nigga drove upstairs."

"Inside?"

"Nigga, look at the violin. It's in the car."

The second officer looked through the Ferrari's open window and saw Shawna's souvenir laid carefully across the seat.

"That nigga went through the orchestra."

"Nigga still got his wife with him."

"She helped," I told them. "Don't have my wife stand here while y'all give all her greatness to the driver."

Both men straightened. One saluted Shawna. She nodded like he had finally read the proper name on the invitation.

"Captain," Ardent said, "our men would be honored to drive under your command tonight."

"Then drive my people somewhere with food."

By the time we reached the dining room again, Tank had found the kitchen.

He stood beside a new platter with gravy on his cuff. Rosa was sitting on the edge of the table, feeding him a bite while the old queen watched approvingly. Mercedes and Porsche had taken charge of a nervous prince and were making him apologize to the servers one at a time for something he'd said during the gunfire.

Vesper stood near the burned curtains.

Her dress was untouched.

That annoyed me more than a little.

"You could've helped," I told her.

"I moved three guests through the west door."

"You also watched your baron try to kill us."

"He is not my baron."

"He had your invitation seal."

"So do you. Shall I call you mine?"

Shawna came beside me and took my arm.

"Try it and see if he answers."

For a second Vesper's expression softened. It surprised me. Not jealousy exactly. More like she had looked through a window and found a room she used to know.

Then it was gone.

"Silas entered the tournament to clear a debt," she said. "He thought stealing the private seal would keep a stronger claimant out. He chose poorly."

"Who was supposed to get it?"

"A man who has not lost a fight in eleven years."

Tank stopped chewing.

"He overdue."

Vesper looked at him, then at me.

"Tomorrow night. The cathedral beneath the city. Bring your badge if it comforts you. The men there won't care."

"Nigga, they always care by the time I leave."

Outside, the police had closed the waterfront for us. A crowd filled the far side of the barriers. Somebody had already printed the picture of me holding Bell against his car. Shawna took one, studied it, and nodded.

"That's a good picture."

"You want your nigga to sign it?"

"I want you to explain why your hand looks that good in it."

"That's the hand that holds you. Nigga keeps his best work in circulation."

"Baby, you handcuffed a man with it."

"And came home to you. Look at this nigga completing assignments."

Rosa laughed. Tank told us to get in the car before he had to hear anything else married people thought was private just because they said it softly.

We went to a little place beside the harbor with blue chairs and grilled fish and an owner who tried to give us the whole restaurant when he saw the badge.

I bought dinner instead.

Nigga, I had arrested enough property for one night.

Shawna sat between my knees on the low seawall afterward, holding a paper cup of wine while the city shone behind us. The rest of our people argued over dessert at a table a few feet away. Police cars waited at both ends of the street. Somewhere a musician was singing about a man who had arrived from the west and broken a king's dinner in half.

"That song about me?" I asked.

"Already," Shawna said.

"He left out the Ferrari."

"Give him time."

I kissed the side of her neck. She leaned back against me, warm and alive and laughing at something Tank had said.

Then she put her hand over mine.

"I saw how you looked when he aimed at me."

"Don't want you seeing it again."

"I wasn't scared of you."

I held her closer.

"I know."

"And I wasn't waiting for you to do everything."

"Baby, you put a whole dinner cart through that nigga's legs. Nobody confused you with furniture."

She laughed so hard her wine nearly went into the harbor.

The musician by the harbor stopped singing when he saw me listening.

Nigga, that was rude. He'd just reached a part where I sounded extremely good-looking.

"Keep going," I told him.

"Captain, I didn't mean—"

"You meant the nigga in the song saved everybody. Keep meaning it."

He laughed and found the chord again. Young man, twenty-nine, hands strong from work that didn't always come with an audience. He'd put my name into a melody that climbed too high in the second line and made him fight his own throat to come home.

I held up a hand.

“Try that part lower.”

He tried it. The phrase opened.

Shawna lifted her head.

“There,” she said.

The musician looked at his guitar as if the instrument had been keeping something from him all afternoon.

“Nigga,” he whispered.

“Exactly,” I told him. “Now sing your whole song.”

He did. Tank started keeping time on the table. Rosa took the harmony without being asked. Mercedes clapped once, then again, until the people outside the restaurant joined her.

By the last chorus, half the harbor was singing about a nigga sitting on a seawall with his wife between his knees.

I sang with them.

Shawna turned around laughing.

“You harmonizing with your own legend?”

“Nigga, I know the material.”

The musician finished red-faced and happy. I gave him enough money to stop worrying about his next several evenings, and he asked whether I wanted my name on the song.

“It already in there seven times,” I told him. “Keep yours on it too.”

He nodded so hard his guitar moved.

Then he started the song again from the beginning, because apparently some niggas understood a good night when it asked for an encore.

The cathedral invitation arrived before dessert.

A little black card, carried by a man with one cauliflower ear and two enormous friends. On the front was a painted fist. On the back, in silver ink, somebody had written:

THE CHAMPION ACCEPTS YOUR BADGE AS
COLLATERAL.

I took out my pen.

Underneath, I wrote:

NIGGA, HE CAN HOLD MY COAT.

I handed it back.

Shawna read it over my wrist and kissed me before the messenger could leave.

By then the man had seen enough greatness for one shift. He bowed, actually bowed, and walked backward all the way to the street.

3. Eleven Years Undefeated Until I Took My Shirt Off

The cathedral was underground because the man who built it had been banned from building anything else above ground.

That was what the driver told us.

I believed him as soon as I saw the elevator.

It held six cars, had a chandelier, and played organ music while lowering us through the bones of Midnight City. Shawna sat beside me in a white dress with a slit that could have started its own criminal organization. Tank leaned against the back of the elevator with his arms folded while Rosa checked whether the chandelier had real diamonds in it.

"Leave it," he told her.

"I'm looking."

"You looking with your bag open."

Mercedes and Porsche had come in boxing jackets over their dresses. Mercedes's said TEAM AIDEN. Porsche's said HE ALREADY WON. They had commissioned them that morning from a tailor who apparently understood the speed of history.

When the elevator stopped, the noise hit us first.

Men shouting. Money changing hands. Music loud enough to move somebody's religion around. The cathedral's old columns

rose around a boxing ring built where an altar might once have stood. Above it hung six giant screens. Below them, rows of velvet seats held rich people who wanted to see poor decisions happen close enough to feel expensive.

At the far end of the ring stood the champion.

Malik "Graveyard" Gault was thirty-three and looked like a building that had learned resentment. He wore black gloves, black trunks, and a chain thick enough to tow a boat. Somebody had tattooed a crown across his chest. Underneath it were eleven little marks.

Years undefeated.

Nigga, he was about to need a new tattoo arrangement.

He watched me cross the floor.

"That the nigga?"

His voice came through the speakers because somebody had put a microphone too close to a man who should've been left to breathe quietly.

"That the college nigga?"

I stopped beneath the ring lights.

"Valedictorian. Nigga, say it with the whole education."

The crowd laughed. Gault didn't.

"And the cop nigga?"

I touched the badge on my jacket.

"Captain. You checking the nigga's credentials before you lose?"

"And this nigga sings?"

Shawna answered before I could.

"When he feels like it. Usually when the nigga hears a song he can improve."

Gault leaned on the ropes.

"What this nigga when he bleeds?"

"Still better dressed than you," Rosa called. "You asked about four niggas and they all him. Which one you ready for?"

Tank turned his head away so Gault wouldn't see him laughing. It didn't work. Nigga, Tank's shoulders were shaking like a truck at a red light.

Vesper sat in a raised box beside an empty chair draped in black cloth. Zero's chair. He wasn't there, but he had arranged for his absence to take up more room than everybody else's body.

Rusk stood beneath the box with a scroll.

"The captain enters three trials. Strength, courage, dominion."

"Y'all named three fights like they got degrees."

"The first is fought against the chosen hand of the cathedral. The second against the reigning champion. The third is determined by the queen."

"And if I win?"

Vesper leaned forward.

"A seat among the criminal kings."

"I sat in the throne yesterday."

"Yes. We noticed."

A thin older man approached carrying my gloves. He had silver hair cut close, a straight back, and a scar that crossed one cheek without disturbing the calm around his eyes. His suit was dark blue. Unlike everybody else in the room, he wasn't trying to look dangerous.

That made me watch him more carefully.

"Bastien Moreau," he said. "I will keep the rounds."

"You a referee?"

"Tonight."

"What were you yesterday?"

"Tired."

I liked the nigga immediately.

He checked my gloves while Shawna helped me take off my jacket. A few women near the ring started calling out before the shirt even cleared my shoulders.

"Wait till he breathes," Porsche told them. "You haven't seen the shoulders move yet."

Shawna looked around the crowd with a little smile, then put her palm on my chest where everybody could see whose hand belonged there.

The shouting doubled.

I bent and kissed her.

"How fast you want this done?"

"Fast enough that my dinner's still hot. Slow enough they learn your name."

"Baby, that's a narrow window."

"You're gifted."

My first opponent wore a red mask and had two attendants carrying a hammer behind him. I looked at the hammer. I looked at Bastien.

"That's allowed?"

"It is ceremonial."

"Good, because my ceremony didn't bring one."

The red mask came over the ropes, bounced on his feet, and hit his own chest three times. He was fast. I saw that before he moved toward me. Some fighters advertise power because they want you looking somewhere other than their feet. This one hardly seemed to touch the floor.

The bell rang.

He threw three punches before I had finished deciding where his face probably was under the mask. One caught my shoulder. One brushed my ear. The third met my glove hard enough to wake my arm all the way up.

The crowd roared.

"Aight," I said. "Nigga got somewhere to be."

He came again. I moved this time. His fist passed my face, his momentum carried him across me, and I caught him with a short punch that made the red mask twist sideways.

He stopped to fix it.

I stopped too.

"You good?"

He blinked through the wrong eyehole.

"Wait."

I waited.

The whole cathedral booed.

"Shut up," I told them. "The nigga can't see. You paid for a fight or a traffic accident?"

He straightened the mask and nodded. We started again. He was still quick, but now every time he moved the mask slid a little, and the fight turned into him trying to hit me before his costume betrayed him.

I caught him with a clean shot to the body. He folded. I stepped back and let Bastien count.

At eight, the man lifted one glove.

"I am finished."

"What's your name?" I asked.

"Adrian."

"Adrian, my nigga, next time just come as Adrian."

I helped him stand. The crowd went from booing to cheering so fast I wondered how any of these people stayed married.

Adrian stopped beside the ropes before they took him away.

He had the red mask in his hands now. His own face looked ordinary beneath it: a grown man with a swelling lip, embarrassed eyes, and enough courage left to come back toward the nigga who had just put him down.

"Could you sign it?" he asked.

I looked at the mask.

"Nigga, you keeping the thing?"

"My brother told me not to fight you."

"Smart brother."

"I said nobody was that good."

I took the pen a man held out from ringside.

"Nigga, what your brother's name?"

“Luis.”

I wrote on the inside of the mask: LUIS WAS RIGHT.

Then I signed it.

The women behind our corner started laughing. Tank leaned over to read it, and the big nigga nearly dropped the water bottle in his hand.

Adrian looked at the words. Looked up at me.

Then he laughed too.

“He's never letting me forget this.”

“Nigga, that's why I made it permanent.”

I put one hand on his shoulder.

“You were fast. Get rid of the mask. Let people see the man doing the work.”

His smile changed. The joke stayed, but something steadier stood up beneath it.

“Thank you.”

He went through the ropes holding the mask against his chest. The crowd reached toward him now, asking to see what I'd written, calling his name alongside mine.

Porsche watched him go.

“This nigga came in to lose a fight and left a collector's item.”

Mercedes nodded.

“Baby, being near Aiden is a financial event.”

I looked at Shawna.

“My wife gets the best returns.”

She put one finger over my mouth before I could explain those in public, then steered me back to our corner and handed me the water.

"One."

"You keeping count?"

"I'm keeping dinner warm in my imagination."

Before Gault entered, a man in a silver jacket climbed up beside our corner carrying a little board covered in betting prices.

"Captain, the odds have changed."

"Nigga, I ain't changed. Catch the board up."

He swallowed.

"You are still the underdog."

Tank leaned over him.

"That nigga what?"

"The underdog. In the market."

"Nigga, look up. Does that look underneath anything?"

The man stared at my shoulders, then at the people behind him calling my name, then at Shawna wiping my face as if the whole

room had been built to make sure she could reach me without standing on tiptoe.

"The champion has eleven years—"

"Nigga, we heard the years," I said. "We about to discuss the minutes."

Mercedes came over with Porsche and a stack of betting slips thick enough to make the man reconsider which direction he wanted to leave.

"We backed Aiden," Mercedes said.

"Obviously," Porsche added.

The silver jacket looked alarmed.

"How much?"

Porsche told him.

Nigga, his face lost money just hearing it.

"That is a significant exposure."

"Then cover your ass with a better opinion," she said.

He hurried away.

Shawna looked at the slips.

"You two bet that much?"

"On him?" Mercedes pointed at me like the answer should've been visible from space. "Baby, this nigga lands cars where

helicopters get nervous. I know a sound investment when it takes its shirt off."

Porsche handed Shawna one slip.

"That's yours."

My wife looked at it, then at me.

"Now you really need to win."

"Nigga, I was planning to lose economically till you said that."

She laughed and kissed my shoulder.

Tank leaned close while the women returned to their seats.

"Listen. This nigga ain't one of those pretty fighters who gets surprised by a punch. He good."

"I know."

"I seen him move."

"So have I."

"Then don't be so busy being the greatest nigga in the building that you forget this nigga brought both hands."

I looked at my brother.

He wasn't doubting me. A nigga who loves you will sometimes be the only person in the room willing to remind you that your blood still works like everybody else's.

I touched his fist with mine.

"I got you."

"You better have you. I already got me."

"Nigga, that's a beautiful sentence from a man who lost his room key twice today."

"The hotel got too many doors."

We laughed together, and the laugh loosened something under my ribs the crowd couldn't reach.

Then Gault entered without music.

The cathedral supplied its own.

Eleven years made a heavy noise. Men stood when he passed. Women touched the edge of his robe. His attendants put the chain around a wooden stand shaped like a kneeling man.

I looked at the stand.

"Nigga, your necklace got staff?"

He hit me before the crowd finished laughing.

The punch landed on my gloves and still sent me backward. My heels touched the ropes. Something sharp went through my ribs, a little hello from all the trouble my body had survived before this city thought it was special.

Gault came after me.

He was not slow. That was the dangerous part. Big men sometimes give you enough time to admire how much they're bringing toward you. This nigga brought it right now.

I ducked one punch and took another against my side. The cathedral tilted. I heard Tank shout, but the words were lost beneath the blood rushing through my ears.

Gault leaned close.

"Stay down when I put you there."

"Nigga, you talking about next week? Do something."

He did.

He caught me hard enough that one knee touched the canvas.

The crowd exploded.

Shawna didn't move. Her eyes stayed on mine. There was no panic in them, and somehow that hurt more than panic would've. She believed I knew what I was doing. I had to become the man she was looking at before the next bell.

I stood.

Gault smiled for the first time.

"Good."

I wiped my mouth with the back of my glove.

"Nigga, you enjoy that?"

"Very much."

"Remember it pretty. Tell your niggas you had me kneeling."

"I'll tell them I had you down."

"Then explain how this nigga got back up while you were practicing the story."

I changed the fight.

Stopped giving him the straight line. Made him turn. Let his shoulders tell me what his gloves were lying about. When he swung at my head, I wasn't there. When he turned to find me, I put a fist where his breath had been.

The first good shot made his smile disappear.

The second made the crowd quiet.

The third made Tank climb halfway onto the ring apron before Rosa pulled him down by the back of his jacket.

"Nigga, let the man work!"

"That's my nigga! I'm supporting!"

"Then support him from the floor. Nigga, you shaking his whole workplace!"

Gault drove me into the corner. I could feel blue thunder waiting under my skin, eager and expensive. I left it there. Nigga, I wasn't about to need lightning to convince this man my name was Aiden.

He swung wide.

I stepped inside, hit him twice, and moved before the answer came. His glove struck the corner post. The sound made everybody flinch except him.

Then he came at me angry.

That was when he became easier.

Not easy. A storm ain't easy because you can see it. But anger told me where his next foot would land before he knew himself. I gave him room he couldn't use and took back room he thought he owned.

By the next bell, he was breathing through his mouth.

Bastien came between us.

"Corners."

Gault didn't turn. He stared at me, chest rising hard.

"You really don't have to do this," he said quietly.

"Nigga, I'm in the ring. We past invitations."

"If you win, he doubles what I owe."

For the first time, I looked beyond the fighter and saw the chain stand, the attendants, the empty black chair.

Eleven years undefeated.

Eleven years belonging to somebody.

I went to my corner.

Shawna put the towel against my face.

"What?"

"Zero owns his debt."

"Can you buy it?"

"Probably."

"Then win first. Men like that hear money better when you're standing."

She kissed the clean side of my mouth.

Nigga, how was I supposed to lose after that?

The last round started with Gault trying to take my whole head home.

I let him come. Took what I had to take. Gave more back. The ring shook beneath us. The crowd stood. Somebody threw a glass and Bastien caught it against his jacket without taking his eyes off the fight.

Gault hit the ropes. I hit him once more, clean and final, and the big man sat down like a building had decided it needed a minute.

He tried to stand at five.

Tried again at seven.

At nine, I held out my hand.

He looked at it.

The bell rang.

I kept the hand there.

He took it.

Nigga, the sound that room made could have raised the cathedral to street level.

Shawna came through the ropes and nearly took me off my feet herself. Tank shouted my name like he was mad at anybody who hadn't heard it. Mercedes kissed Porsche on the cheek, then told her not to get ideas because she'd just been overwhelmed by athletic excellence.

Vesper rose in her box.

"The second trial is complete."

I held Gault's wrist up with mine.

"The nigga's debt is complete too."

She went still.

"That is not a prize you were offered."

"Then offer it now."

A murmur passed through the kings. They didn't mind money changing hands. They minded somebody deciding which hands mattered.

Vesper looked toward the empty chair.

"The emperor will expect compensation."

"Tell him send an invoice with a picture of his face on it so I know who to disappoint."

Gault let out one shocked laugh.

I looked at him.

"Nigga, you free enough to laugh yet?"

"I think so."

"Then make it a good one. That's your laugh now."

He tried again. Louder. The nigga looked surprised by how far his own voice could travel without waiting for somebody to allow it.

"That nigga laughing," Tank shouted.

"I hear him," Rosa said.

"Nah. Nigga laughing like he got tomorrow."

Gault heard that too. He looked at my brother and nodded, once, hard.

Vesper descended from her box and approached the ring.

Bastien held the ropes for her. She didn't climb in. She stood outside with one hand resting on the top rope, looking at me like the evening had stopped following the order she'd memorized.

"The final trial," she said, "is dominion. You may claim the cathedral's purse. Ten million. Or you may purchase the champion's freedom."

The room quieted again.

Gault's hand fell from mine.

"Take the purse," he said.

"Nigga, be quiet."

"I mean it."

"I know. That's why I told you to be quiet."

I looked at Vesper.

"Buy his freedom."

She studied me for a long second.

"Done."

The cheering started, but I lifted my glove.

"And I'm charging the cathedral eleven million for the fight."

Shawna bent forward laughing.

Rusk actually grabbed the rail.

"You cannot simply—"

"Nigga, I just sold out your dead church, beat your champion, saved your parade yesterday, and brought my own beautiful wife. You think all that come free?"

Vesper put her hand over her mouth.

It didn't hide the smile.

The old silver-bearded king from dinner stood in the front row.

"I'll pay it."

Everybody turned.

His wife pulled him back down by his sleeve.

"We'll pay it," she corrected.

That was how I won three trials, freed a champion, and left a million ahead of where the queen had meant to put me.

Gault met us outside the changing room afterward. Without the chain, he looked younger. Not smaller. Just less arranged for somebody else's benefit.

"If you need me," he said, "send word."

"I need you to go eat something you chose yourself."

He nodded, then looked at Shawna.

"Your husband is—"

"I know," she said.

Gault smiled.

"No. Nigga, I don't think anybody knows all of it yet. I came in here thinking I knew the man I'd have to fight."

"And?" she asked.

"The nigga I needed to meet showed up afterward. Same face. Same hands. Different damn use for them."

She looked at me, proud enough to make my battered ribs sit up straighter.

Nigga, I liked him better every minute.

Bastien waited by the elevator. While everybody else celebrated, he slipped a folded card into my hand.

No crown on it. No fancy threat.

Just an address and a time.

"There is a woman who ought to have seen that fight," he said.

"Who?"

He looked toward Vesper, standing alone beneath the cathedral's last chandelier.

"Someone she was before this city taught her what love cost."

Before I could ask another question, the elevator doors opened. Shawna took my arm. The whole room applauded as we went up.

I looked at the card again once the city lights returned.

A garden. Tomorrow afternoon.

Underneath the address, in a different hand, somebody had written:

COME WITHOUT A CROWN.

"You going?" Shawna asked.

I folded it and put it beside my badge.

"Depends if they got dinner."

"Baby."

"Nigga freed a champion. Let him investigate a menu."

"You already decided."

I smiled at her.

"Yeah. We going. But your nigga taking snacks. I can't keep changing these people's lives on ceremonial portions."

4. My Wife Wore Blue to a Black-Tie War

The garden had six fountains and no water.

"That's depressing," Shawna said.

"Rich niggas always find a way to own something thirsty."

We had come on foot because my arms still hurt from Gault and Shawna said walking might remind my body I wasn't a car. Tank followed twenty feet behind with Rosa. Mercedes and Porsche had stayed at the hotel to help Marcellus examine the invitation seal. By help, they meant ask which stones they could wear while he examined it.

Bastien waited beside a fountain shaped like two lovers reaching for each other across a broken rim.

"You came together."

"Usually how marriage works," I said.

"Not in this city."

"Then these niggas need better marriages."

"Aiden," Shawna said.

"What? This nigga said people stop coming together."

"Ask which person gets left behind."

I looked at Bastien. The old nigga's smile thinned, and I understood there was somebody missing from more than his invitation list.

"Better husbands too," I said. "Some niggas need to learn the walk starts when she ready."

Bastien smiled and showed us through an iron gate. Beyond it, the garden was different. Water ran between the stones. Lemon trees shaded a low table. A woman in plain white clothes knelt beside a flower bed, trimming dead leaves with little silver scissors.

Vesper looked up.

Without the coat, the guards, or the snake bracelet, she looked almost ordinary.

Almost. Nigga, some people can put on plain clothes and still look like the clothes owe them money.

"I asked you to come without a crown," she said.

"Ain't won it yet."

"You wear the expectation."

Shawna stopped beside the table.

"He sleeps in it too."

Vesper laughed. It was the first laugh I'd heard from her without an audience waiting to decide what it meant.

Before we reached the table, one of Vesper's little garden bridges shifted beneath Rosa's heel.

She stopped. Looked down. Looked at Tank.

“Nigga.”

He came toward her immediately.

“I got you.”

“I know you got me. I'm deciding how angry I am at the bridge.”

The stone slab had slipped away from its support. Nothing dramatic. Just enough water and empty space beneath it to ruin a woman's shoe and make the whole morning personal.

I stepped onto the bank, took the broken edge with both hands, and lifted it back where it belonged.

Tank stared.

“Brother, I was gonna carry her.”

“Nigga, carry her across a better bridge. I'm improving the romance.”

Rosa walked over slowly, testing every step. When she reached the other side, she kissed Tank anyway.

“For coming,” she said.

He smiled like he had personally rebuilt the garden.

Vesper looked at the slab, then at my hands.

“That takes four gardeners.”

“Nigga, hire the ones with better relationships.”

Shawna took my wrist and turned my palm over, checking whether I'd scraped it. Then she kissed the spot she had been looking at.

Vesper watched that part longer than the stone.

“Does he do everything like this?” she asked.

“Everything he thinks I'm watching,” Shawna said.

“Nigga, I do things when you aren't looking too.”

“Yes, baby. Then you come tell me.”

Bastien laughed behind us. Tank put an arm around Rosa, and for a minute the old garden held four people loving each other openly enough to make a queen forget she had invited us there to discuss danger.

Bastien poured coffee. Vesper waved Tank and Rosa toward the remaining seats. Tank chose a chair, tested it with one hand, then moved to a stone bench because he had learned not to trust old furniture that looked pleased with itself.

"Why we here?" I asked.

Vesper set down the scissors.

"Because last night you bought a man instead of winning money."

"Bought him out. That's different."

"Yes. It is."

She watched the water moving through the garden.

"The emperor will notice."

"Nigga been noticing me since before he introduced himself."

"You haven't met him."

"He keep sending other people to get embarrassed."

Bastien lowered his cup.

"That is how he measures people. He watches what they spend to rescue someone. Then he chooses a price he believes they cannot pay."

Shawna leaned forward.

"And you both work for him?"

The question sat on the table among the little cakes.

Vesper didn't pretend not to hear it.

"I govern the tournament. Bastien protects my household. Neither arrangement began with a simple yes."

"Nothing starts simple after you put crowns on it," Rosa said.

Vesper looked at her.

"Did you always know you wanted the man you're with?"

Rosa glanced at Tank, who suddenly found the lemon tree fascinating.

"I knew I wanted that nigga to stop looking at me like he was leaving tomorrow."

"I wasn't looking like that," Tank said.

"Baby, you could make ordering breakfast sound temporary. Nigga would ask for eggs like commitment might hear him."

"I ate there every morning."

"And I kept wondering whether the nigga would learn my favorite order before he ran out of other things to be brave about."

Tank looked at her.

Then he named it. Every item, down to how she wanted the coffee.

Rosa's face softened.

"See? That nigga was listening. That's who I wanted."

Bastien laughed into his cup. Vesper's face changed again, that quick private ache I'd seen at dinner.

"I was meant to marry a prince," she said. "Nico Arden Valcour. He used to come through that gate with fruit he claimed he'd stolen from the palace kitchen. The gardener told me years later he bought it from a shop and rubbed dirt on the bag."

"Nigga wanted a dangerous reputation," I said.

"He wanted me to think he had one."

"Did you?" Shawna asked.

"No. I liked that he tried."

The water kept running. Outside the wall, somewhere in the modern city, a sports car snarled past. Vesper looked toward the sound as if it had interrupted somebody standing just behind her.

"He died in the harbor fire sixteen years ago," she said. "He was twenty-six. I was twenty-one. The city called it an accident and held a beautiful funeral. It has been holding beautiful funerals for inconvenient people ever since."

Bastien's fingers tightened around his cup.

I noticed. So did Shawna.

"You don't think it was an accident," she said.

"I stopped believing in accidents before I stopped wearing his ring."

Vesper rose before the silence could turn into something she hadn't invited.

"Tonight is the Ball of Allegiances. Every claimant must name a house that will stand with him. If no house agrees, his claim ends."

"Aight. What's yours?"

"Vane."

"You standing?"

She looked directly at me.

"I haven't decided."

"You invited us all the way to your secret garden to tell me you undecided? Nigga, you could have sent a confused pigeon."

Shawna laughed. Even Bastien gave up trying to stay solemn.

Vesper's smile returned slowly.

"I wanted to see what you were when nobody applauded."

Tank lifted one enormous hand.

"I can clap if it's awkward."

That evening, the hotel tried to put me in a black suit with a silver sash.

I put on white.

The tailor made a little broken sound.

"Captain, the invitation specifies—"

"It specifies my name. We good."

Shawna came out of the bedroom in a blue gown that made the tailor forget every regulation he'd ever loved. The back was low. The shoulders were bare. Her hair fell over one side, and my earrings moved against her neck when she turned.

"What?" she asked.

Nobody answered fast enough.

"Nigga, say something," Tank told me. "You look injured."

I walked over and took her hand.

"You know what you doing to a nigga."

"Yes."

"You came out here and found your husband without a fucking thought left in him."

"That's unusual. Usually my nigga has at least six about himself."

"You wearing all six."

Tank pointed at the tailor.

"Write that down. Nigga finally made a speech worth charging for."

Shawna laughed and put her hand against my chest.

"That confidence dangerous," I told her.

"You married it. Nigga, stand up straight and enjoy your decision."

I kissed her wrist and told the tailor to add another diamond to whatever he was charging me for, because I had suddenly become richer in ways that required celebration.

The ballroom at the Glass Palace had a ceiling painted like the night sky. Real glass stars hung beneath it. A thousand candles reflected in mirrored walls, turning every beautiful woman into a whole problem and every insecure man into a meeting of himself.

We arrived while a duke was announcing his allegiance.

He stopped halfway through his own family name.

Shawna and I crossed the floor together. Heads turned in waves.

A woman touched her husband's sleeve without looking at him.

A photographer nearly backed into a fountain. The orchestra changed songs, and I didn't know whether somebody had told them to or the musicians had simply recognized that the old song wasn't dressed well enough.

A young man near the entrance took one look at me and whispered, "That nigga wore white."

His friend leaned around him.

"That nigga brought a woman in blue."

"Everybody supposed to wear black."

"Nigga, everybody supposed to survive a Ferrari landing too? That rulebook probably tired by now."

I heard them.

Of course I heard them. A nigga could say my name under an orchestra and I'd find the corner where the appreciation was hiding.

I turned just enough to let them know.

"Y'all look sharp," I said.

Both men straightened.

One actually forgot what to do with his drink and handed it to the other.

Shawna squeezed my arm.

"You made their night."

"Niggas dressed for an event. I'm letting them know it arrived."

The first man hurried after us.

"Captain. My wife asked whether we could take a photograph."

His wife stood three feet away staring at him because he had very obviously invented her request while she watched.

"I did not," she said.

"But you would enjoy one."

She looked at me. Then at Shawna.

"Actually, yes."

Nigga, honesty recovered beautifully.

We took the photograph. Then another because the man blinked. Then a third because he kept looking at me instead of the camera.

"Nigga, the photographer over there," I told him.

"Sorry. I saw the fight."

"I was in it. We got history. Look at the camera."

His wife laughed so hard she nearly spoiled the fourth one too.

By the time we finished, three more couples were waiting. Rusk tried to lead us toward the royal platform. Mercedes intercepted him, took one look at the crowd, and decided the palace could wait until the people got their pictures.

"A nigga gets one chance to stand beside greatness in a good suit," she told him. "You can't hurry the memory."

Rusk opened his mouth.

Porsche handed him a camera.

"Make yourself useful, silver cape."

He took the photograph.

Nigga, he took a good one.

I checked it, nodded, and clapped his shoulder.

"You got an eye."

The man looked so pleased he forgot to be offended by the next two people asking him to take theirs.

Vesper stood on the balcony above.

Beside her, for the first time, stood Emperor Zero.

No mask. No machine voice. No smoke hiding what a nigga looked like.

He was a man in his fifties with dark eyes, silver at his temples, and a face that looked calm because other people had been doing

his panicking for decades. His black suit was plain except for a white jewel at the throat. He held a glass he hadn't drunk from. When he saw me, he smiled like he had just located something expensive in another man's pocket.

"Captain Aiden."

His voice carried without a microphone.

"Emperor Nobody," I said.

Shawna's hand tightened on mine.

Not to stop me.

Nigga, she was trying not to laugh.

A few kings looked down at their shoes. Vesper stayed perfectly still. Zero set his untouched glass on the rail.

"They told me you were charming."

"They told me you were taller."

"Who?"

"Niggas who lie apparently."

He laughed once. It sounded real enough to be dangerous.

"Enjoy the ball. We will speak when you have acquired a house."

"I got several."

"An old house."

"Nigga, I can stop renovating one."

Shawna pulled me toward the dance floor before Rusk could die of secondhand embarrassment.

"Dance with me."

"Gladly."

I put my hand at her waist. She rested hers on my shoulder. The music came up around us, and for the first few steps I let her lead because she knew the song and I liked watching what happened when she knew I trusted her.

Then I turned her.

Her gown opened around her legs like blue water. She came back laughing. I caught her low, brought her close, and the people nearest us stopped dancing so they could watch a marriage make them reconsider their evening.

"Niggas staring," she whispered.

"Niggas learning."

"Learning what?"

"How jealous feels with an orchestra. That nigga by the fountain has forgotten his whole wife's name."

"Baby, she's looking too."

"Then the niggas can compare notes on the way home. I got you right here."

She kissed me right there in the middle of the ballroom.

Somebody applauded.

Nigga, after that everybody thought they had to.

The first allegiance came before the song ended.

The silver-bearded king from dinner approached with his wife.

Lord and Lady Orsini. He bowed to Shawna, then shook my hand.

"House Orsini stands with you."

His wife looked at the other tables.

"Write that large enough for the people pretending not to hear."

Rusk hurried over with his scroll.

A second house joined. Then a third. The old king had paid for my fight. The others had seen the footage. Nobody wanted to be the last rich nigga to admit what the room already knew.

Vesper came down from the balcony while Rusk was still writing.

"You appear to have solved your difficulty."

"I wore white."

"Was that the strategy?"

"Baby picked the cufflinks. We were thorough."

She looked at Shawna's blue dress.

"Will you permit me one dance with your husband?"

Shawna looked at me, then back at her.

"He makes his own decisions. So do I."

Vesper inclined her head.

I kissed Shawna's hand before taking Vesper's.

"One song," I said.

"I can do a great deal in one song."

"Nigga, so can my wife. That's why I'm saying it clear."

Vesper was a beautiful dancer. Precise, light, never where the other person's balance expected her to be. I understood immediately why men mistook dancing with her for being chosen.

She looked up at me as we turned.

"If you had come here alone—"

"I wouldn't have come the same man."

She stopped talking.

I didn't soften it. Not because I wanted to hurt her. Because some doors get crueler the longer you leave them halfway open.

"You admire her," she said.

"Nigga, I adore her. Admire is what I do to a nice engine."

Vesper's smile was smaller when it came back.

"That must be very pleasant."

"Sometimes she steals my whole side of the bed."

"And you permit it?"

"I'm trying to buy a wider bed without letting her find out why."

She laughed, and this time there wasn't anything hidden behind it.

Then I saw the violinist lift his bow wrong.

Not a little wrong. Wrong like the music had stopped mattering and his hand needed to point elsewhere.

Behind him, a man in a black dinner jacket opened the orchestra's side door. Three more men stepped through. No instruments. No interest in the song.

I turned Vesper out of their line and shouted Shawna's name.

My wife was already moving.

The first shot shattered a glass star above us.

The ballroom became falling light.

I dragged Vesper behind a marble pillar. Tank hit the orchestra platform hard enough to break its front edge. Mercedes and Porsche pulled two frightened women under a table while Rosa stood on a chair and shouted over the gunfire, telling people which doors were clear.

Shawna kicked off her heels and ran toward the fallen violinist's case.

"Baby!"

"I see it!"

She threw me the pistol inside.

I caught it, fired toward the men at the side door, and heard one of them curse my entire bloodline as he dropped behind a cello. Vesper picked up a broken chair leg and struck the man who came around our pillar. His dinner jacket wasn't protective enough for the evening he'd chosen.

"You do help," I told her.

"When the company improves."

Across the room, Zero stood behind the balcony rail with two guards in front of him. He wasn't fleeing. He was watching.

I hated that calm nigga more every second.

One attacker grabbed Rusk and pulled him toward the ninth-floor terrace. Rusk's scroll dragged behind them, collecting glass and wine. I went after him because a man could annoy me for three straight days and still not deserve to be thrown off a palace before dessert.

The terrace doors burst open beneath us.

Wind hit my face. The attacker shoved Rusk against the railing and raised his gun.

I hit him before he fired.

We crashed into a stone planter. The gun went over the side. He came up with a knife. I caught his arm, slammed him against the wall, and took the fight out of him in three ugly seconds.

Rusk clung to the railing.

"You saved me."

"Nigga, you still owe me the rules."

"I thought—"

"I know what you thought. This nigga put you over a rail. I saw the whole bad idea."

Rusk looked at the attacker, then back at me.

"You left the queen to come for me."

"Queen had a chair leg. Nigga, you had a scroll. I prioritized the office supplies."

He started laughing and couldn't stop. Fear does that sometimes. Turns a proud man into a noise he didn't know he could make.

Inside, the gunfire had ended. Ardent's police poured through the doors. Tank stood over two men who had decided the floor was their new address. Shawna retrieved one blue heel from beneath a chair and held it up triumphantly.

The whole ballroom applauded again.

This time it wasn't about the dance.

Zero came down the stairs slowly, stepping around broken glass like it had been laid there for his convenience.

"An unfortunate interruption."

I walked toward him with the borrowed pistol still in my hand.

His guards stiffened.

"You call that unfortunate?"

"I call it a failed attack on the council."

"Nigga, you watched it like you paid for seats."

His smile thinned.

Vesper stepped beside me.

"The attackers will be questioned by Chief Ardent," she said.

Zero looked at her.

For one long second, I saw the line between them become visible.

Then he inclined his head and turned away.

Shawna found my hand after he left.

"You okay?"

I looked at her gown, her bare shoulder, the heel she was still holding, and the little cut on my own hand that she had already noticed.

"Better when you got both shoes."

She lifted the second one from behind her back.

"Then you're perfect."

Vesper watched us go. Bastien stood behind her, and when I glanced back, the old man gave me one quiet nod.

We had come to the ball needing one house.

By midnight, seven had pledged themselves to me.

Rusk wrote the last name with a bandage around his hand and a new expression whenever he said Captain.

One of the men I'd posed with leaned over his shoulder.

"Seven houses?"

"Seven," Rusk said.

"Nigga came needing one."

"Then you might consider what it means that six insisted on being included."

I looked at him.

"Nigga, listen to you appreciating me in complete sentences."

He looked up from the scroll and smiled.

"I'm learning, Captain."

Nigga, sometimes all you have to do to improve a party is save everybody at it.

5. The Nigga on the Hood Was Me

"That nigga left us seven cars."

Tank stood in the hotel garage staring at the keys in his hand.

"Which nigga?" I asked.

"All the niggas. Every house you saved last night sent a car."

"See, nigga? That's gratitude with tires."

There was a yellow Ferrari, a blue Aston Martin, a white Lamborghini, a black Rolls-Royce, two Bentleys, and something low and silver that looked like it had been designed by a man who hated speed limits personally.

Porsche walked between them in a white jacket and stopped beside the silver one.

"That one's mine."

"Your name ain't on it," Mercedes said.

"Neither is yours."

"Nigga, her name is Porsche," Tank told me. "She gonna keep doing this forever."

"Let her. Nigga got enough cars to make a point slowly."

Porsche laid her palm on the silver hood.

"Listen to this nigga granting permission. Baby, I already introduced myself to the upholstery."

Mercedes opened the passenger door.

"Then introduce your nigga to the seat controls. I'm not riding with my knees in the glove box."

"You taking half my car?"

"Nigga, you taking the whole man's car. We all learning generosity."

A garage attendant came running between the cars with a polishing cloth in his hand.

"Captain. Please. One photograph."

I looked at the seven cars behind him.

"Nigga, which one you need me improving?"

"With all of them."

"Ambitious."

His friend held up a phone. The first man stood beside me, tried to fold his arms like mine, then unfolded them because he looked as if he were holding himself hostage.

"Relax," I told him.

"I am relaxed."

"Nigga, your shoulders in my pockets. Come down."

He laughed. His friend took the photograph at exactly that moment.

Shawna came through the door and stopped beside the Aston.

“Look at you working before breakfast.”

“Public service.”

The attendant looked at her, then back at me.

“Your wife?”

“Nigga, look how quickly you stood straighter. Who else would make both of us do that?”

She kissed my cheek and took the cloth out of his hand. There was a little mark on my collar. She wiped it away, smiling to herself while the men watched like they'd been invited behind the curtain of a very expensive miracle.

“You don't have to do that, ma'am,” the attendant said.

“I know.”

She did it anyway.

Porsche leaned against the silver car.

“Nigga got seven cars and still the woman detailing him.”

Mercedes looked over.

“That's the one she drives home.”

Shawna put the cloth back into the attendant's hand, gave my collar one last little tug, and walked on toward the keys.

The man watched her go, then showed me the photograph he'd taken.

I looked happy in it.

Nigga, of course I did. My wife had just polished her favorite thing in the garage.

Marcellus came down the stairs carrying the silver invitation case. He looked tired, but not worried. A jeweler who had spent his life around criminals learns there are too many opportunities to worry and not enough hours to do all of them properly.

He set the case on the hood of the Rolls.

"The seal is genuine."

"Good. Nigga rescued it dramatically. I'd hate to have done that for a fake."

Marcellus gave me his patient look.

"You rescued the people around it too."

"Nigga, they looked genuine. This little gold motherfucker kept secrets."

"And now it will tell us something."

"See? That's why I bring my old nigga. He gets jewelry to cooperate without wrecking the room."

"It belonged to the old royal household. The underside shows part of the Crown's setting."

I leaned closer.

"Worth something?"

"The Crown itself is worth a fortune. What it proves may be worth more."

"Nigga, everybody keep telling me something worth more than money. Then they ask for money."

Marcellus smiled.

"This may be one of the rare exceptions. The stones were arranged to identify the family's private books. The Crown was a key in the ordinary sense: a recognized object, a pattern, a claim. Men trusted the bearer enough to open doors."

"And Zero wants the books."

"He wants everyone to believe he already controls them."

Shawna stood beside the Aston in jeans, a silk shirt, and my chain over her own necklace because she'd decided it looked better that way. The DBM cross lay against her chest. Nigga, I would've let her take my spine if she wore it that confidently.

"What are we doing today?"

"Bastien says he got something to show Marcellus."

"Then I'm driving."

Tank looked at me.

I looked at Tank.

"Nigga," he said carefully, "you gonna let somebody else drive one of the seven cars you just got?"

"That's my wife."

"I know who the nigga's wife is. I'm asking if the nigga knows who usually drives."

Shawna took the Aston Martin keys out of his hand.

"Today the woman who hasn't crashed a Ferrari in this country."

"You helped your nigga crash both of them," I told her.

"And I looked gorgeous. Imagine what I can do with the wheel."

Tank lifted both hands.

"Nigga, she got an argument."

"You on her side?"

"I'm on the nigga's side who still has seven running cars. We trying to preserve him."

We left in three cars. Shawna and me in the Aston. Marcellus with Mercedes and Porsche in the Rolls. Tank and Rosa in the Lamborghini, because Rosa said her fiancé deserved something pretty enough to distract people from his driving.

The coast road curved along the city's old walls. Sea below. Mansions above. Little cafés filled with men who had probably spent their whole lives looking important in the same chair. Every time we passed, somebody stood to wave.

"That nigga know us?" I asked.

Shawna glanced at a man holding up a newspaper with my face on it.

"Apparently."

"Nigga waving like I paid his rent."

"You wrecked his landlord's house last night."

I leaned out the window and waved back harder.

Bastien's address was an old observatory above the harbor. The road narrowed as we climbed. A stone wall ran along one side, and on the other was enough empty air to make a man reconsider how much he trusted his wife.

I trusted mine plenty.

"You taking this corner kind of beautiful," I told her.

"Don't flirt when I'm concentrating."

"Nigga, you married a distraction."

The first black motorcycle appeared behind us just before the observatory gates.

Then another.

Then a van blocked the road ahead.

Shawna saw it before I said anything. Her hands tightened, the car slowed, and the look on her face changed from vacation to somebody about to regret interrupting her outfit.

"Aiden."

"I see them."

"I'm not asking. I'm telling you to buckle your greatness down."

The van doors opened.

She reversed so fast my shoulders hit the seat before the gunfire started.

"Nigga!"

"You told me I was beautiful on corners!"

The Aston swung backward around the bend. A motorcycle came too close. I fired through the open side window and the rider dropped behind his handlebars. The bike hit the wall and scraped along it in a shower of sparks.

Behind us, Tank put the Lamborghini sideways across the road, blocking the second motorcycle from reaching the Rolls. Rosa leaned out and threw a full bottle of mineral water at the rider's face.

"Nigga, that was glass!" Tank shouted.

"I read the label!"

The rider went down. The bottle did too. Rosa looked genuinely offended by the waste.

Shawna turned us at a little overlook no wider than the car. The Aston's back tires hung close enough to the edge that I saw the sea in the side mirror where road should've been.

"Baby."

"Trust me."

"Nigga, I'm married to you. That's documented."

She put the car forward and shot through the gap between the van and the stone wall. Metal shrieked along our side. I fired toward the men crouching behind the open doors. One dropped his gun. Another jumped away so fast he left a shoe.

We cleared the van and reached the observatory gates.

They were already open.

Inside, Bastien stood on the steps with a pistol in his hand and a fallen man at his feet. Three more attackers moved between the garden statues. The old nigga had his jacket off, and there was nothing tired about him now.

Shawna braked beside the steps.

"Get him!"

I was out before the car stopped.

One attacker turned from Bastien toward me. I hit him across the face with the door. The second tried to come around a statue and discovered Tank had arrived behind us with a very personal opinion about statues being in his way.

The stone saint lost an arm.

The attacker lost interest.

Bastien covered Marcellus while Mercedes and Porsche got him into the observatory. Rosa followed carrying a bag of medical supplies she'd started keeping after realizing our vacations required them.

A black SUV burst through the lower gate.

Its passenger leaned out with a gun aimed at Shawna's window.

Nigga, there are some sights that make thought too slow to bother with.

I ran across the garden, stepped onto the broken base of the saint, and threw myself onto the SUV's hood.

My body struck metal hard enough to knock the breath out of me. I caught the edge near the windshield with both hands. The driver screamed. The passenger twisted toward me, but he couldn't get the angle before I kicked the weapon away.

The SUV kept going.

Straight down the slope.

"AIDEN!"

That was Shawna.

Then the Aston's engine rose behind us.

Nigga, my wife came after me like the whole road had insulted her marriage.

The driver swerved. I held on. The hood was hot beneath my chest. The city flashed past sideways. My shoes dragged at the

edge of the windshield, and the passenger kept trying to pull me through the broken side of his own problem.

"Get off, nigga!" he shouted.

"Nigga, stop the car!"

"Get off the fucking car!"

"Stop giving a nigga travel advice while you kidnapping his ass! You shot at my wife. Now my wife following us. Nigga, your itinerary is getting worse!"

Shawna drew alongside. The road barely held both vehicles. Her window was down. Her hair whipped across her face.

"Come here!"

"You sound like we in the kitchen!"

"Then move like you're hungry!"

The SUV hit a pothole. My grip slipped. For one second I saw nothing beneath me but moving road and my own hands failing to agree about staying attached.

I called a little blue thunder.

Not enough to turn the car into lightning. Enough to wake every tired nerve at once. Enough to pull myself across the hood as Shawna matched our speed.

I jumped.

My shoulder struck the Aston's roof. I slid, caught the open passenger window, and folded into the seat with less dignity than a king should legally be allowed to carry.

Shawna didn't look away from the road.

"You good?"

I tried to answer and swallowed half my breath instead.

"Nigga, I'm excellent."

"You bleeding on the seat."

"Excellence leaks."

She laughed once, wild and furious and relieved, then turned the wheel so sharply the SUV driver followed by instinct and ran out of road before he ran out of confidence.

His vehicle crashed through the low wall into an empty terrace café.

Tables flew. An umbrella opened in the middle of the wreck like somebody still hoped it would be a pleasant afternoon.

The SUV stopped against a fountain.

Water shot into the sky.

The owner came out holding a broom, saw me getting out of the Aston, and put the broom down.

"Captain?"

"Charge it to the niggas in the fountain."

Ardent's police arrived almost as fast as the crowd.

He looked at the destroyed SUV, my torn shirt, Shawna calmly checking her lipstick in the passenger mirror, and the Aston missing half its beautiful paint.

"Another attack?"

"No, nigga. I was trying a new taxi."

His younger officers laughed before remembering they were on duty. One stepped close enough to see the badge.

"My brother saw a nigga riding the hood all the way from the observatory."

"And?"

"He said no nigga could survive that."

"Then who this?" I asked, pointing at my whole surviving self.

The officer grinned.

"He said if the nigga survived, it was you."

"Now your brother talking sense. What the other niggas say?"

A second officer raised his hand like we were back in my college.

"My cousin saw the lady drive beneath you. He said nobody drives like that."

Shawna shut the mirror and turned.

"Apparently I do."

"Nigga, take notes," I told the first officer. "Your brother found me on the hood. His cousin found my wife making sure I didn't stay there. We got a whole marriage witnessed from different balconies."

Ardent took off his hat and looked at her properly.

"Madame. Extraordinary driving."

"Thank you. Somebody had to come collect him."

I put a hand on the younger officer's shoulder.

"Tell your nigga to keep watching. And tell him my wife deserves her own damn view."

Shawna took my other arm before I could turn a torn shirt into a full speech.

"Come on, greatness. Somebody needs to clean your elbow."

Back at the observatory, Bastien had set his pistol beside a telescope and returned to looking like a man who might recommend a quiet book.

Rosa was wrapping Tank's knuckles.

"You hit a statue."

"Nigga was behind it."

"The statue didn't know that."

"It know now."

Mercedes and Porsche had found the attackers' discarded coats. In one pocket was a black invitation stamped with Zero's private crest. In the other was a portrait photograph of Bastien taken through a window.

"They came for you," I said.

Bastien looked at the photograph without surprise.

"They have been coming for what I remember for sixteen years. Today they grew impatient."

He led us upstairs into a round room beneath the old telescope dome. Sunlight came through a narrow opening and fell across a wooden chest. No gold case. No dramatic locks. Just a chest somebody had cared enough to repair more than once.

Bastien opened it.

Inside lay a woman's red coat, carefully folded, and a letter tied with blue thread.

Vesper arrived while he was lifting the coat.

I hadn't heard her car. I only noticed the room change when she entered.

"You brought them here," she told Bastien.

"Yes."

"You promised me you would keep it safe."

"I did."

"This is not safe."

The old man looked at her for a long time.

"Neither is letting you spend the rest of your life protecting the man who took yours away."

Vesper's face lost its color.

Outside, police radios crackled. Somebody moved the wrecked car at the gate. The whole city kept going while a room full of people waited for one woman to decide whether she could bear hearing what she'd suspected.

Shawna sat beside her without asking.

Vesper didn't move away.

Bastien unfolded the letter.

"Eliane wrote this the night before the harbor burned," he said.

"She believed I would be angry with her. For sixteen years, that has been the part I cannot forgive myself for."

I sat on the edge of a table, my scraped elbow wrapped, my wife's hand reaching back to find mine.

"Tell it straight," I said. "All of it."

Bastien looked down at the red coat.

And the old nigga began.

6. The Woman in the Red Coat

"Before he tells you," Vesper said, "I need you to know that Nico wasn't brave in the way this city remembers him."

Bastien lowered the letter.

She sat with her hands flat on her knees. No queen pose. No glass held just so. Her fingers trembled, and she was angry enough about it that I looked at her face instead.

"They put him on statues with a sword," she said. "He hated swords. He cut his thumb opening a parcel once and accused the paper of treason."

Tank made a small sound.

Rosa nudged him.

"I liked the nigga," Tank said. "That's a good accusation."

Vesper smiled without meaning to.

"The last afternoon I saw him, he arrived at this observatory carrying a live chicken."

I blinked.

"A whole chicken?"

"He had won it in a wager and couldn't bear to send it to the kitchens. He named it Admiral."

"Nigga promoted the chicken."

"Very rapidly."

She looked toward the balcony, and I followed her eyes until I could almost see the younger woman standing there:

twenty-one, waiting for a prince she loved, trying to look disappointed when he brought the wrong kind of present.

Vesper told us how Nico had climbed the stairs with the bird under one arm and a stolen orange in his pocket. Real stolen fruit that time. Apparently he had decided his reputation needed work.

He'd put the chicken on the table. It had knocked over a vase.

Vesper had told him that if their married life involved poultry on the furniture, she expected at least a larger house.

"He said he would buy me the sea," she told us.

"Ambitious nigga," I said.

Shawna glanced back at me.

"You gave me an island. Don't act unfamiliar."

"Baby, I won that efficiently."

Vesper laughed again, and the sound hurt her afterward. I saw it. The little pause before she could keep going.

Nico had been due at the harbor that evening. His father, King Adrien Valcour, was meeting merchants aboard the royal ship. The Crown of Midnight would travel with him, because even a

man going to discuss cargo apparently needed to look like he owned the moon.

But Nico didn't want to go.

He wanted to stay at the observatory. He wanted to eat the orange with Vesper and explain why Admiral had already earned an upgrade in rank. He wanted, in the plain stupid beautiful way men sometimes want things, one evening that didn't belong to his name.

"I told him to go," Vesper said.

Shawna's hand moved over hers.

"You didn't know."

"I know that now. I have known it for years. Knowing has never made the sentence less true."

Bastien stared at the letter. His face looked older than it had when he was fighting men outside his own door.

Vesper continued.

Nico had kissed her at the gate. Then he'd come back because he forgot the chicken. Then he'd come back again because she had laughed at him, and he wanted another kiss while she was still laughing.

"That's the last one," she said. "Everybody expects the last kiss to announce itself. It was quick. I was holding a ridiculous bird. I remember being worried about my sleeve."

Nobody spoke.

Then Bastien turned the letter over.

"Eliane was with the king that night," he said.

His voice sounded different when he said her name. Not weaker. More careful. Like he had been carrying it a long way and didn't want anybody to think he was tired of the weight.

He was fifty-two then. Eliane was forty-four. She made gowns for the court and costumes for the opera, and according to Bastien she could tell what a person feared by looking at what they wore to dinner.

"What would've she said about me?" I asked.

He looked at my white shirt, torn at one shoulder, my badge, the ring on my hand.

"That you wanted everyone to know who had chosen you."

Shawna turned all the way toward me.

Nigga, the old man had gone straight through the shirt.

"Aight," I said. "She was talented."

Bastien and Eliane had been together seven years. Never married. He'd asked. She'd said yes, then asked him to choose a month when nobody planned to kill the king. He kept telling her next spring.

Seven springs.

"I thought there would always be another," he said.

The afternoon before the fire, Eliane had come to his rooms wearing the red coat. She had sewn it herself, crooked on purpose at one pocket because he had once teased her about making everything too perfect to touch.

She'd brought him bread and a little cheese, and she'd been angry.

He remembered the bread first. That was what he told us. The smell of it. Warm enough to fog the paper. Every time he tried to remember her voice exactly, the bread arrived before the words.

"You are leaving again," she'd told him.

"The king needs me."

"The king has thirty guards. I have one fool, and he is late."

"Tomorrow."

"You love that word."

He had tried to kiss her. She'd turned her face, then caught his hand before he could mistake anger for an invitation to leave.

"Bastien, listen to me. Rafael has been moving the household accounts."

Rafael Sorel.

The man the city would later call Emperor Zero.

At thirty-six he had been the king's favored minister, handsome enough to be welcome in rooms where his family name wouldn't have got him past the stairs. He smiled well. He remembered birthdays. He never raised his voice at servants where anybody could hear.

"The nigga was practicing," Tank said.

Bastien nodded once.

Eliane had been altering a coat for Rafael when she found a folded instruction beneath the lining. Not a murder confession sitting politely in a pocket. A shipping order. A list of names. A date. The kind of thing a seamstress was expected to return without reading because a man who wore a crown nearby assumed every other person was scenery.

But Eliane recognized three names.

Men who had already disappeared.

She had made clothes for their wives after their funerals.

"She asked him about it?" Rosa said.

"No. She copied what she saw. Then she hid the copy where she believed he would never look."

Bastien touched the red coat.

"On a woman he thought beneath notice."

Marcellus leaned forward, studying the embroidery at the cuff.

"Those are account marks."

"Yes."

I looked at the little silver stitches. They had seemed like flowers a moment earlier. Now they looked like a woman daring a whole kingdom to learn how to see.

"Nigga," I said softly. "She wore the evidence."

Eliane had come to Bastien with enough to make him doubt Rafael, but not enough to make him accuse the king's favorite in public. Bastien had served Adrien Valcour for twenty-eight years. He knew the king was vain, generous when watched, cruel when frightened, and devoted to his son in a way that sometimes looked like trying to own the air around him.

He also knew Rafael had become necessary.

Necessary men are dangerous when you discover you can live without them.

Bastien had told Eliane to wait.

"One evening," he'd said. "After the harbor meeting, I will take this to the king."

She had looked at him for a long time.

Then she'd kissed him.

Not because she agreed.

Because she had already decided to do something else.

Vesper got up and walked to the balcony. Shawna followed, stopping beside her without saying anything. I could see both

women's reflections in the old glass, the living one holding a ring from her first marriage on a chain beneath her shirt, the queen holding nothing where a ring had used to be.

Bastien read the letter aloud.

My stubborn love,

You will be angry that I went without you. Be angry after you eat. I know you will forget the bread if there is a crisis, and I refuse to lose an argument to your empty stomach.

Tank looked down at his hands.

Rosa took one of them.

I am going to the harbor because the prince will be there.

Rafael believes I have brought him the household book. I have brought him a copy made for a man who sees numbers and thinks he understands people. The true book remains behind the old royal face. You know the face I mean. You once told me its nose was wrong.

Marcellus looked up sharply.

Bastien kept reading.

The Crown identifies the shelves. It does not contain the truth by itself. Do not let a glittering thing persuade you to stop looking. Men have done that all my life.

I saw Vesper close her eyes at the balcony.

I believe I can get Nico away. He listens when I scold him, perhaps because I am the only woman at court who does not

want him to grow taller in a portrait. If his father comes, I will bring him too. I make no promises about the father's manners.

Rosa laughed once through her nose.

If I return, we marry in autumn. I have chosen it. You have had seven springs to offer something better.

Bastien stopped.

The paper trembled in his hand.

Nobody hurried him.

If I do not return, do not turn me into a reason to become a smaller man. You were difficult enough at your proper size. Love someone who needs you. Love something you can still reach. Wear the blue coat when you are sad. The black one makes you look like an undertaker who has misplaced his customer.

He smiled. A broken, astonished smile, like she had found him through sixteen years just to insult his jacket again.

I have loved you in rooms too narrow for your shoulders. I have loved you in the five minutes between one duty and another. I have loved you badly on Thursdays and wonderfully on Sundays and stubbornly whenever you deserved worse. If there is another life, come early. I am tired of waiting with dinner.

Eliane.

Bastien folded the letter with hands that knew every crease.

For a while, the only sound was the harbor outside.

Then I said, "What happened on the ship?"

He looked at me.

"The king was already dead when she arrived."

Vesper turned from the balcony.

"You never told me that."

"I could not prove it."

"You could have told me."

"Yes," he said. "I could have."

That answer hit her harder than an excuse would have.

Rafael had summoned Bastien away from the harbor with an order bearing the royal seal. A disturbance at the eastern gate. A threat to Vesper's household. Bastien had taken six guards and gone because the prince loved Vesper, and protecting what the prince loved felt like protecting him.

By the time he realized the road was empty, smoke rose over the water.

He had ridden back through streets full of people running the opposite way. The royal ship burned from bow to stern. Men shouted that the king was aboard. Others shouted that he had escaped. Nobody agreed on anything except that the water was bright with fire.

Bastien found Nico on the quay.

Alive.

Vesper made a sound so small I almost missed it.

"Alive?"

Bastien nodded.

"Eliane got him off. She gave him her coat because his shirt was burning. He was hurt, but he knew me. He told me Rafael had ordered the harbor gates closed. He told me his father had been dead before the meeting began."

"Then why—"

Vesper couldn't finish.

Bastien did it for her.

"Because Rafael's men reached us before the physician."

The old man's jaw tightened. He didn't give us every wound. He didn't need to. He told us about the sudden circle of black coats, the prince trying to stand, the one loyal guard who pushed Bastien into the water because a living witness was all he could save.

Bastien went over the quay with Eliane's coat caught around one wrist.

When he came up, Nico was gone.

The city buried a closed coffin three days later.

Eliane never came back from the ship.

Vesper stared at Bastien.

"And you stood beside me at the funeral."

"Yes."

"You let me thank him."

"I was afraid."

The words sat there naked.

A man who had just fought off killers in his own garden said them without trying to dress them up.

"He knew I had survived. He knew I had the coat. He did not know what she had written into it. He offered your life in exchange for my silence. I had watched everyone else die. I thought keeping you alive was the only thing I could still do correctly."

Vesper slapped him.

The sound cracked through the room.

Nobody moved.

Bastien didn't raise a hand to his face.

"You let me become useful to him," she said.

"Yes."

"You let me call it strength."

"Yes."

"You should have trusted me."

"Yes."

She looked ready to hit him again. Then her face collapsed, and the old man caught her as she stepped into him instead.

Shawna came back to me while they held each other.

I put an arm around her waist.

Nigga, I had spent the morning on the hood of a moving car. I had been shot at by men who thought a road belonged to them. None of that made me feel as exposed as watching an old man discover he'd been protecting somebody and betraying her at the same time.

After a while Vesper sat down.

Her face was wet. She didn't hide it.

"Why now?" she asked.

Bastien looked at me.

"Because last night I watched a man refuse a price. And because the emperor has finally become afraid enough to make mistakes."

I straightened.

"Aight. Then let's make him keep making them."

Marcellus spread the coat across the table. He didn't cut it. He studied the stitched marks beside the invitation seal, then turned the seal so the little crown faced the light.

"The old royal face," he said. "A portrait?"

Bastien nodded.

"Adrien's first coronation portrait. It hangs in the House of Nine Doors."

I stared at him.

"The house I drove through?"

"Yes."

Tank leaned back and laughed.

"Nigga, you been in the evidence twice already."

"I was busy arresting dinner!"

Shawna covered her mouth. Mercedes and Porsche started laughing too, not because any of it was small, but because we'd been holding our breath for so long that the first ridiculous thing felt like a window opening.

Vesper wiped her face with a handkerchief Bastien gave her.

"Silas Bell acquired the house from Rafael after the fire," she said. "He never knew what was hidden there."

"Then we go get it," I said.

"The emperor will have sealed the house by now."

I touched my badge.

"Nigga, so will I."

A car horn sounded outside.

Ardent stood at the garden gate with three police vehicles and a folded document in his hand. He looked pleased until he saw Vesper's face. Then he became very careful.

"Captain. The emperor has issued a request for your presence. Tonight. The Palace of Mirrors."

I took the paper.

The next tournament round.

PAIRS OF ALLEGIANCE.

Every claimant and their chosen partner would enter together.

Only one prize would leave with them.

Shawna read it beside me.

"He thinks he's about to test us."

I looked back at the red coat, the letter, Vesper standing beside the man she'd just forgiven enough to keep hurting over.

"Nigga," I said, "he don't know who already tested everybody."

7. We Chose Each Other and Took Both Cars

"Nigga, why this invitation got two seats and one exit?"

Tank held the card up to the light.

Rosa took it from him.

"Because somebody thinks they're clever."

"I don't like clever niggas with buildings."

"You love Aiden."

"That nigga breaks his own buildings. That's different."

"How?"

"Nigga breaks a building, you can see him coming out with everybody who was in it. This nigga sends invitations and makes you count the exits."

Rosa looked at the card again.

"That's a fair distinction."

"Nigga, I know my favorite dangerous man from a damn appointment."

I was standing in front of the mirror while Shawna tied my black tie. She had refused three hotel stylists and told a fourth that if he touched her hair again she would make him explain it to the ocean.

Tonight she wore red.

The kind of red that made a nigga forget blue had ever accomplished anything.

"You looking at the tie?" she asked.

"I'm looking near it."

"Try higher."

"Baby, you gave me a difficult route."

She pulled the knot snug and kissed me.

Behind us, Tank groaned.

"Nigga, we got a betrayal appointment. Can y'all flirt in the car like normal dangerous people?"

The Palace of Mirrors stood on a little island reached by a bridge of white stone. Every window reflected the water. Every guard wore silver. I had started to notice a pattern: the worse the man inside, the more somebody polished the outside.

Rusk greeted us at the entrance with his bandaged hand tucked behind his back.

"Captain. Madame."

"You walking better," I said.

"I owe you my life."

"Start with good seats."

He actually smiled.

Nigga, I had improved him too.

Inside, the couples stood beneath a ceiling of turning mirrors. Old kings with old queens. Young claimants with new girlfriends. One prince with two wives who looked more interested in talking to each other than standing beside him. All of us adults, all dressed like consequences had been invited somewhere else.

Vesper waited beside a raised platform. Zero stood at its center.

"Tonight," he said, "we discover what each of you values more than victory."

I leaned toward Shawna.

"Nigga finna discover how much I value dinner."

She bit back a laugh.

Zero's gaze found us.

"Some men are loudest when they are uncertain."

"Some niggas build a mirror palace because one reflection ain't agreeing with them."

A sound went through the room. Half laughter, half men trying not to be seen laughing.

Zero's expression didn't change.

"The pairs will enter separately. Each will be offered a private bargain. Wealth. Authority. Freedom from a debt. The power to decide who leaves victorious."

"And nobody gets hurt?" Lady Orsini asked.

"Unless they choose very unwisely."

Her husband sighed.

"Darling, perhaps we should have stayed for dessert."

"We did. They interrupted it."

Shawna put her hand in mine.

"Whatever he offers you, make him say the price out loud."

"Whatever the nigga offers you, tell him your husband already got it in another color."

She smiled.

"Even the ocean?"

"Nigga, especially the ocean."

A servant took me through a mirrored door. Another took Shawna through the one beside it. We let go at the same time, not because either of us wanted to, but because there are men who can smell hesitation and I wasn't feeding this one anything.

My room contained a chair, a table, and a view of the harbor.

On the table lay the deed to an estate.

Beside it, a photograph of Shawna performing at the island celebration.

Zero entered through a side door.

"You collect extraordinary women," he said.

"Nigga, I married one. You collecting terrible openings."

He sat without inviting me to.

I sat anyway.

"Your wife has talent. Real talent. A world tour could make her independent of everything you are."

"She already independent of my permission. Nigga, you brought my wife's photograph in here and still ain't looked at the woman in it."

"And if independence takes her away from you?"

I looked at the photograph. Her head tilted back, her mouth open on a note, her whole body giving something to the crowd that I loved partly because it didn't belong only to me.

"Then I buy a ticket."

Zero waited.

"Front row," I added. "Nigga, don't get cheap in your imagination."

He moved the deed closer.

"This estate includes the city's western harbor. Its ships. Its clubs. Its protection. All I ask is that you withdraw from the final Crown round. Your wife receives the opera house outright."

"She pick her own songs?"

"Of course."

"Then she's gonna sing about the nigga who lost his crown to me. You sure you want that in your building?"

For the first time, he showed irritation without covering it immediately.

"You confuse defiance with strength."

"Nigga, you keep confusing furniture with a marriage. You got deeds on a table. This nigga has a woman downstairs who knows how he takes his coffee and still bothers asking how he slept. Which one you think I came this far to keep?"

He leaned back.

"Very well. The next door leads to your partner. One of you must surrender your token before it opens. The other keeps the prize."

He placed a gold token on the table.

Mine bore a crown.

Through the wall, faintly, I heard Shawna laugh.

Nigga, that laugh saved me five minutes of wondering.

"What you offer her?"

Zero stood.

"You may ask her if you reach her."

After he left, a voice instructed me to place my token into a slot beside the door. A little screen showed two cars on opposite

ends of a track suspended above the palace's indoor pool. In one car sat Shawna.

In the other was an empty driver's seat waiting for me.

I looked at the screen.

"Nigga, this is a date with extra nonsense."

The door opened.

The track was a long silver curve beneath the turning mirrors. Half of it vanished behind a wall. The cars were small open racers, beautiful and ridiculous, with polished steering wheels and almost no room for a man to hide his feelings.

Shawna lifted her hand when she saw me.

"They offer you a harbor?"

"You an opera house?"

"And a separation agreement."

The room went quiet.

I looked up at the balcony where Zero had reappeared.

"Nigga."

Just that.

He looked down calmly.

Shawna raised a folded paper.

"I wrote a review on the back."

"What it say?"

"That your mother raised you better than his did."

Tank's laugh came through a doorway somewhere behind the spectators.

Nigga, they hadn't even put that man in a car yet and he was already winning something.

Vesper announced the rules. The track had two paths. Each driver controlled a gate on the other person's route. To reach the finish first, a claimant could close their partner's passage and take the central lane. If both kept the gates open, neither would reach the prize before the countdown ended.

"So the rules are be a shitty husband or lose?" I asked.

"The rules are as stated," Zero said.

"Then you stated some shitty rules."

I got into the car.

Shawna settled her shoulders, smiling across at me.

"You trust me?"

"Nigga, you drove me off another nigga's hood this morning. We established that."

The lights changed.

We moved.

At first the cars were slow enough to feel insulting. Then the track steepened and the little engines found their courage. Mirrors above us swung, making the route look like it kept splitting into ten impossible directions.

I couldn't see Shawna after the first turn.

I could hear her.

"Right gate!"

I kept it open.

"Your turn!"

"Left!"

Her gate opened before I reached it.

The spectators shouted. Some wanted us to win. Some wanted us to choose wrong. Nigga, rich people will watch a marriage like it's a horse race if you give them chairs and something cold to drink.

The countdown appeared above the track.

Thirty seconds.

Ahead of me, the central prize platform held two silver keys.

One for the estate.

One for the opera house.

The track bent away from it. I could see the trick now. The gates weren't the only choice. The cars had been placed close enough

to the platform that a driver with more ambition than caution could reach it.

Zero had counted on us wanting the steering wheel more than each other.

"Baby," I called.

"I see it."

"You know which side?"

"The pretty side."

"Nigga, that's both of mine."

She laughed.

We came out of opposite turns together. Twenty seconds. I saw her face, the red dress tucked around her knees, the confidence in her hands.

I stood in the moving car.

The crowd screamed.

Zero leaned forward.

I jumped toward Shawna's car as she drew alongside.

My empty racer shot through the center lane and struck the low prize platform. Silver keys flew up. I caught one. Shawna caught the other against her chest with one hand while keeping the car straight with the other.

Nigga, my wife caught an opera house without letting go of the wheel.

I landed half in her lap, half behind the seat, all greatness and terrible posture.

"Nigga, you heavy," she said.

"That's reputation."

"Get your reputation out of my gearshift."

"Baby, your nigga trying to land with respect."

"Land with your elbow on your own side. I got a house to win."

She drove us through the finish together.

The countdown stopped at eight.

For a moment nobody knew what to do with a rule that had been embarrassed in public.

Then Lady Orsini stood up and clapped.

"They both arrived!"

Her husband joined her.

"And nobody divorced! Excellent round!"

Somewhere above us a man yelled, "That nigga caught the keys!"

"That nigga's wife caught hers too!" a woman shouted back.

"He jumped out the car!"

"Nigga, she caught the husband. Keep up with the expensive part!"

Shawna heard and lifted both keys, then pointed at me. The woman clapped so hard her bracelets sounded like a small crash of their own.

The crowd erupted.

I climbed out and helped Shawna stand. Her hair had come loose. Her dress had a little streak of grease near the hem. She held up the opera key like it had always been hers and the palace had merely taken too long to find it.

Zero descended the stairs.

"You abandoned your vehicle."

"Nigga, I improved my company."

"This was a test of loyalty."

"And that nigga in my seat was lonely. I brought him back to his wife. You had mirrors everywhere. Don't tell me you missed the whole marriage."

"The rules required—"

Vesper stepped between us.

"A claimant and partner at the finish. They are both here. The tokens were not surrendered. The gates remained open."

Zero looked at her.

"You are becoming precise at unusual times."

"You asked me to govern the tournament."

"I asked you to remember who governs you."

The words made the room colder.

I moved beside her, not in front, because she hadn't asked me to become a wall between her and her own decision.

"Nigga," I said, "she remembers plenty. That's your problem."

He held my gaze, then smiled for the audience.

"The prizes are awarded."

Applause. Relieved at first, then louder as people decided which version of courage was safest to admit.

Tank and Rosa came out of their separate rooms a few minutes later carrying two smaller prize boxes.

"What happened?" I asked.

Rosa opened hers. A diamond bracelet.

Tank opened his. A matching necklace.

"They tried to make us argue," he said.

"And?"

"Nigga, we already know how. We took the jewelry."

Rosa tried the bracelet on while Tank held the clasp.

His fingers were too big for the tiny catch. He frowned at it, tongue pressed against one corner of his mouth, concentrating harder than I had seen him concentrate on men with guns.

“Nigga,” I said, “you need backup?”

“I’m fine.”

“The jewelry putting up a fight?”

“Aiden.”

Rosa kept her arm still. Didn’t laugh at him. Didn’t take it away and do it herself. She watched his face while the strongest man in the room learned to make his hands small enough for something she wanted to wear.

Finally the clasp closed.

Tank looked up.

“There.”

Rosa turned her wrist. The diamonds caught the mirror light and threw it back over both their faces.

“Beautiful,” she said.

He nodded at the bracelet.

“Looks good on you.”

“Nigga, I was talking to you.”

That finished him.

The man went quiet. Looked down. Looked up again like he wanted to make sure she'd said it in a room with witnesses and wasn't going to take it back when he smiled too much.

Shawna squeezed my hand.

“Your brother.”

“My nigga.”

“He looks happy.”

“Nigga finally got somebody who can close an argument around his wrist.”

Tank heard me and raised one finger without letting go of Rosa's hand.

I respected the multitasking.

Rosa kissed his knuckles, the ones I'd seen break glass and men and expensive things bought by men who thought they were safe behind them.

“Keep this pair,” she told him. “I like what they do when you stop trying to scare everybody.”

He smiled at her so openly that one of the queens nearby put a hand over her own husband's and held it there until he noticed.

Nigga, we were improving the whole fucking room.

Mercedes and Porsche emerged behind them with a furious prince between them.

"What did y'all do?" Shawna asked.

"Made the nigga choose," Mercedes said.

"Nigga chose wrong," Porsche added.

"I was presented with incomplete—"

"Nigga, both women were standing in front of you," Mercedes said. "How complete you need a bad decision?"

The prince opened his mouth.

Both women looked at him.

He closed it.

Outside, Vesper caught us at the bridge.

For the first time since we'd met her, she looked afraid without trying to turn it into elegance.

"He knows something has changed."

"A lot changed," I said.

"I have people in that palace. People he can hurt because I hesitate."

"Then we get your people out."

"It is not that simple."

"Nigga, I didn't ask if simple had a room. I asked where your people sleeping tonight."

Vesper looked at me, then past me toward the palace.

"He will count them."

"Then let the nigga learn subtraction while we find them beds."

Shawna took the opera key out of my hand and put it into Vesper's.

"A whole building just became mine. Use the dressing rooms. Use the stage. Use every stupid little balcony. Get them there."

Vesper stared at the key.

"You have not even seen it."

"Then make sure somebody waters the flowers before I do."

Nigga, my wife handed a queen a way out and still made it sound like she was arranging opening night.

Vesper closed her fingers around the key.

"Thank you."

I looked back at the shining palace.

Zero stood in an upper window, a dark shape surrounded by reflections of himself.

I kissed Shawna on the bridge where he could see.

Not for him.

Because the nigga had given me an excellent reason to remember who kept winning.

8. The King Behind the Wall

By noon the opera house belonged to Shawna, contained forty-seven people Vesper wanted alive, and had sold out a concert my wife hadn't agreed to give yet.

"Nigga, how you sell tickets before the singer says yes?" I asked the manager.

The manager, a round man named Paolo, held his hat against his chest.

"We heard she was coming."

"Nigga, she came to look at curtains."

"The city would pay to see that also."

I looked at Shawna, then back at him.

"This nigga got taste and no manners. Baby, come decide what part we keeping."

Paolo nodded so eagerly I almost liked him before my wife had approved the performance.

Shawna looked up from the stage.

"What time?"

"Eight."

"Get me a piano."

Nigga, that was the entire negotiation.

Rosa stood beside her in rehearsal clothes, looking out over the velvet seats.

"I want the second song."

"You can have three."

"I knew this marriage would eventually benefit me."

Tank sat in the front row with his feet spread so far nobody else could use it. He watched Rosa cross the stage like the theater had been built to solve his particular eyesight.

"That nigga in love," I told Shawna.

"That nigga has been in love. He just finally stopped looking surprised."

Vesper's people occupied the dressing rooms upstairs.

Assistants. Drivers. Two singers. An old cook who had brought her own knives because she didn't trust palace kitchens she couldn't insult personally. No prisoners in chains. People who had served one house so long that leaving it felt like stepping out of their own names.

Vesper moved among them, checking rooms, carrying bags, doing little practical things with a seriousness nobody had ever applauded her for.

I let her work.

Paolo caught me before I reached the door.

"Captain. One small difficulty."

“Nigga, don't introduce a large problem wearing a little hat. What is it?”

He pointed up.

The stage curtain had caught halfway open. A man on the high walkway was pulling at a rope with both hands while another shouted that he was making it worse. Below them, Shawna stood with her arms folded, waiting for the theater to stop taking rehearsal personally.

“Has it always done that?” I asked.

“Only for important performances.”

“Nigga, it better retire that habit today.”

I went up the side stairs. At the top, the two stagehands stared at my badge, then at my face.

“Captain, you don't have to—”

One leaned toward the other.

“That nigga fixes curtains too?”

“Nigga, that man's wife downstairs.”

“This nigga can hear you,” I told them. “And that part about my wife is why the curtain losing today. Show me what's caught.”

The first stagehand pointed with both hands. The other took the loose rope and got ready to help instead of spending the whole rehearsal admiring the volunteer.

The curtain's heavy edge had twisted around its guide. I got both hands on it, felt the stubborn weight, and pulled until the trapped fabric came loose with a long velvet sigh.

The curtain opened.

Below us, the whole stage filled with light.

Shawna looked up at me from the piano.

“You showing off up there?”

“Nigga fixing your sky.”

She laughed and played the first chord. Her voice came up through the theater, clear and warm, and the two stagehands forgot to look impressed with me because my wife had begun doing her part.

I let them.

When I came downstairs, Paolo shook my hand as if we'd concluded a matter of enormous artistic importance.

“Perfect,” he said.

I looked at Shawna singing beneath the open curtain.

“Nigga, I know.”

Bastien met me at the stage door with Marcellus. Both wore dark suits. Both looked like they had decided to attend a funeral and were willing to arrange one if necessary.

"Nigga, y'all dress like the portrait owes you money."

"In a sense," Marcellus said.

Shawna came down the steps and straightened my collar.

"Bring back the book."

"That's all?"

"And yourself. The book can't come to my show alone."

I kissed her.

"Front row."

"Better be."

The House of Nine Doors looked worse in daylight.

Nigga, I had done quality work. One balcony still had tire marks across the marble. The gallery doors were boarded. Somebody had placed flowers near the broken orchestra platform, and I couldn't tell whether they were mourning the musicians' equipment or the baron's dignity.

Police guarded the front entrance.

Black Mantle soldiers guarded the back.

Zero's men. Different uniforms, same rich-man posture: shoulders wide because somebody else had promised to pay for the consequences.

Ardent stood between both groups looking like his afternoon had become legally confusing.

He brightened when he saw me.

"Captain."

"Nigga, who invited the funeral jackets?"

"The emperor claims an interest in the property."

"I claimed it first. With evidence. And a Ferrari."

A Black Mantle officer approached. Tall. Blond. A little scar beside his mouth. He introduced himself as Colonel Severin Drake, forty-six, commander of Zero's household forces, like any of that was supposed to make me stop standing where I was.

"The house is closed."

I showed him my badge.

"Open."

"Your foreign rank has no authority here."

Ardent straightened.

"The captain acts with my full cooperation."

Drake looked at him.

"You should be more careful with that."

"Nigga, you should be more careful with your tone," I said.

"This man been nothing but handsome and helpful."

Ardent's younger officers tried not to smile.

Drake stepped closer.

"You enjoy making people love you."

"Nigga, you make that sound difficult. Look at this man." I nodded toward Ardent. "Useful. Respectful. Helped my wife get home. Nigga, I liked him in twelve seconds. You been here longer and somehow getting worse."

One of Ardent's officers coughed into his fist.

Drake looked at him.

"That nigga ain't your problem," I said. "You threatening the wrong part of the conversation."

Bastien walked past us toward the front door.

Drake moved to stop him.

I caught Drake's wrist.

Not hard enough to injure him. Hard enough for his face to understand the rest of the sentence.

"Let the old nigga walk."

For a moment all the guns around us seemed to remember what they were for.

Then Drake stepped back.

"You have fifteen minutes."

"Nigga, I was gonna take twenty. You just made it thirty."

Inside, the house smelled of smoke, polish, and rich people pretending damage wasn't permanent if they could afford

repairs. Bastien led us through a long corridor into a portrait room I hadn't reached during the car chase.

King Adrien Valcour hung above a fireplace in a gold frame.

He wore the Crown of Midnight.

For the first time, I got a good look at the thing we had crossed a sea to take from Zero.

Black diamonds. White gold. Seven rising points. A blue stone at the front dark enough to look like midnight had learned how to shine.

"That's a crown," I said.

Marcellus smiled.

"Yes."

"Nigga, I was expecting a crown, but that's a crown. Why nobody tell me the nigga had that much hat?"

"We've discussed it several times."

"Words, my nigga. You used words. Should've held your hands this far apart and looked worried about my neck."

Bastien stood beneath the portrait.

"His nose was wrong."

Eliane's letter came back to me.

The old royal face.

The face whose nose was wrong.

Marcellus studied the frame. Bastien looked at the fireplace. I looked at both men looking until I decided we were giving the wall too much time to feel important.

"Can I take it down?"

"Carefully," Marcellus said.

Nigga, I took it down carefully enough that only one corner of the wall objected.

Behind the portrait was a shallow bronze door.

No glitter. No dramatic ticking. Just a family crest worn smooth where somebody's hand had once touched it often.

Bastien took a key from inside his coat.

I looked at him.

"You had that the whole time?"

"I knew where it belonged. I was afraid to leave her alone with what opening it would bring."

"Nigga, she got company now."

The key turned.

Inside sat a small black book, a red ribbon, and a child's drawing old enough that the paper had browned. A little boy had drawn a ship and a man with a crown too large for his head.

Nico's name was written at the bottom.

Bastien touched the edge of the paper with one finger.

Marcellus lifted the book.

Names. Payments. Promises. Not magic. Worse, in a way: men writing down what they would do to other men if enough money reached the right table.

Eliane's stitched marks matched the page corners.

Marcellus found Rafael Sorel's name three times before I heard footsteps in the corridor.

"Time," I said.

Drake stood in the doorway with six men.

"You have recovered imperial property."

"Nigga, you timed that beautifully."

"Give it to me."

Bastien closed the bronze door. Marcellus slipped the book inside his jacket.

I picked up the portrait.

"You want your old king back?"

Drake raised his gun.

I threw King Adrien Valcour at him.

Nigga, the king finally did something useful after sixteen years on the wall.

The frame struck Drake across the shoulder. His shot went into the ceiling. I drove forward before his men could get a clear line,

hit the nearest one hard enough to put him into a cabinet, and heard Bastien's pistol answer from beside the fireplace.

Marcellus ducked behind a table. Ardent's officers shouted from the front hall. The house filled with the same noise it had made two nights earlier, and I started to understand why rich people kept extra mansions.

Drake pulled free of the broken frame and came at me with a knife.

He was good.

Not Gault strong. Not red-mask fast. Precise. Every movement meant something ugly and arrived without introduction.

He cut my sleeve. I hit his jaw. He drove me against the fireplace. I caught his wrist before the knife found anything I couldn't replace with a tailor.

"You think they love you?" he hissed.

"Nigga, you asking while we wrestle? Pick a mood."

I slammed him into the mantel.

The knife fell.

Bastien fired over my shoulder at a man rushing the doorway. I shoved Drake into the broken portrait and went after Marcellus.

The front hall was blocked.

The gallery was burning again.

Nigga, that house had an unfortunate relationship with my visits.

"Back way," Bastien said.

"That's where his men are."

"Not all the way back. The ninth door."

I stared at him.

"The wall door?"

He nodded.

Tank's earlier threat about taking the whole wall came to mind, and I decided my brother deserved a chance to be right at a distance.

We ran upstairs.

The little blue door opened onto nothing.

Nothing, in this case, meant twenty feet of air above the harbor, a narrow stone ledge, and a maintenance boat tied below.

Marcellus looked down.

"I am sixty-two."

"Nigga, you wearing it beautifully. Come here."

I helped him through onto the ledge. Bastien followed. Gunfire struck the door behind us. I kicked it shut, looked at the boat, and called down to its startled driver.

"Move left!"

"What?"

"Nigga, your other left!"

He moved.

We jumped.

The boat rocked so hard the harbor tried to get in with us. Marcellus landed against a coil of rope. Bastien hit the bench and rolled. I came down last, caught the boat's canopy, and tore half of it loose before my feet found the deck.

The driver stared.

"Captain Aiden?"

"Drive, my nigga. Autographs when the roof stops shooting."

The boat shot away from the house as bullets struck the water behind us.

Ardent's patrol launch cut across the harbor to meet us. His officers opened the way. Above, on the balcony I'd driven through before, Drake stood with blood at his mouth and the king's torn portrait tangled around one boot.

I waved.

Nigga, manners matter when you leave somebody's house.

We reached the opera house at seven forty-three.

Shawna was furious.

Not because I'd been late.

Because I'd been early enough for her to see the sleeve.

"You bleeding?"

"Mostly architecture."

"Aiden."

"Nigga fought a portrait. Portrait lost. Little cut. Nothing interesting."

"Then let your wife be interested before you start explaining the nigga in the frame."

I held out my arm. Marcellus quietly held up the book behind me.

"At least one of you came back with all his corners," she said.

"Nigga, I came back with the useful ones."

She checked it herself, cleaned it, and put a fresh shirt in my hands.

"You have twelve minutes."

"To explain?"

"To sit down and look like my husband."

"Nigga, that's my strongest subject."

"Then get an A and keep your feet out of the aisle."

I did it in nine.

Nigga, greatness respects showtime.

The opera house filled until people stood along the walls.

Vesper's household sat together in one balcony. Ardent and his

officers occupied another, their uniforms bright beneath the chandeliers. Gault arrived in a dark suit with no chain. When he saw me, he raised a hand and the whole row around him stood to make room.

Tank sat beside me with Rosa's engagement ring box in his pocket, though she'd already said yes on the island. He liked carrying it. Said it reminded him he had managed one proposal without anybody shooting.

The lights went down.

Shawna walked onto the stage.

No crown. No gun. No car.

Just my wife, a piano, and a room that had no idea how quiet she could make it.

She sang the first song without looking for me.

That was what I loved about it. She wasn't borrowing courage from my face. She had brought her own.

By the second verse, a woman behind me was crying. By the final note, even the waiters had stopped moving. The applause came a second late because everybody needed a moment to remember they had hands.

Nigga, I stood first.

I stood so fast Tank stood with me on instinct, and the rest of the room followed like my wife's voice had pulled the city onto its feet.

She found me then.

Smiled.

Everything I'd stolen, won, survived, or driven through felt small enough to put in a pocket beside that look.

Rosa took the stage for the second song. Tank forgot to sit down. She pointed at him once during the chorus, and the nigga actually touched his own chest like he needed confirmation she meant him.

Mercedes leaned over from the next row.

"That's your woman, nigga. Stop looking adopted by surprise."

He laughed, embarrassed and proud, and I put an arm around his shoulders while the whole theater cheered her name.

"That's your nigga singing," I told him.

"I know."

"Then let the woman see you know."

Tank raised both hands over his head and shouted her name so loudly Rosa almost lost the next line laughing.

"There that nigga go," Mercedes said.

"Whole damn balcony heard his relationship," Porsche answered.

Nigga, so did Rosa. She found her note again and sent it straight back to him.

Upstairs afterward, Marcellus laid the recovered ledger beside Eliane's coat.

Vesper read in silence.

Payments to the harbor commander.

Orders transferring the old king's properties before the fire.

Names of men who had sworn loyalty at a funeral for people they'd helped kill.

Then she reached the last page and stopped.

"What?" I asked.

She turned the book toward me.

A newer sheet had been tucked inside the old binding. Bell must have added it after acquiring the house. A record of the coming tournament's final wager.

The Crown was to be awarded publicly.

Then the winner would be invited aboard Zero's armored yacht for a private coronation.

No winner was meant to return.

Tank stared at the page.

"Nigga, they got a whole funeral scheduled after your trophy."

I looked at Shawna standing in the doorway, still wearing the dress the city had just applauded.

Then I looked at Vesper.

"Aight," I said. "We gonna need a bigger after-party."

9. I Bought the Auctioneer's Car While He Was Still in It

The kings held their auction in an old train station because apparently every building in Midnight City had retired from one job and started committing a different crime.

Nigga, I respected ambition.

The platforms were covered in red carpet. Cars stood where trains used to stop. A jazz band played on a locomotive with gold wheels. Above everything hung the Crown of Midnight inside a glass case, turning slowly under a light bright enough to make half the men beneath it reconsider their marriages.

I looked once.

Shawna noticed.

"You want it?"

"On you first."

"It's a king's crown."

"Nigga, it's jewelry until somebody starts arguing."

She smiled and hooked her arm through mine.

We were here because Zero required every finalist to pledge something at the auction. Not buy. Pledge. A house, a fleet, a loyalty. Something the council could seize if a claimant withdrew.

I had no intention of withdrawing.

I also had no intention of letting a nigga touch my island because he liked the sound of paperwork.

Rusk approached carrying a silver tray.

"Your pledge, Captain."

I put a car key on it.

"The Ferrari Vesper gave me."

He looked down.

"That vehicle was destroyed."

"Nigga, parts of it still excellent."

"A pledge must have enduring value."

Shawna put a photograph beside the key. Me landing the car on the harbor dock.

"Its history," she said.

Rusk studied the picture.

Around us, other claimants leaned closer. Somebody asked whether the broken Ferrari would be displayed. Somebody else offered two million before the auction had even begun.

Nigga, I had turned a repair bill into a collectible.

"Three million," said a man in a velvet coat.

"It isn't for sale," Rusk told him.

"Everything is for sale."

I took the key back.

"Four million and a running car."

The man looked at me.

Then at the photograph.

Then he handed me the keys to a green Ferrari parked behind him.

"Done."

Tank put both hands on the back of his head.

"Nigga sold a wreck and got a better Ferrari."

"A nigga invests," I told him.

Mercedes turned to Porsche.

"We need to crash something famous."

"You already dated a musician. Let the rest of us learn."

The man in velvet was Lord Corvin Ash, a collector of cars, swords, paintings, and women who eventually escaped with at least one of the first three. His current companion, a twenty-nine-year-old sculptor named Dalia, shook Shawna's hand and asked whether the opera house had room for a marble bust of a woman looking disappointed.

"Of him?" Shawna asked.

Dalia smiled.

"Beside him."

Corvin pretended not to hear.

The auction began with a yacht, continued through three islands none of which were mine, and reached a red sports car with a silver roof. Its owner, Prince Laurent, stood beside it looking miserable.

Mercedes went still.

"That's the nigga from the hotel."

"The bouquets?" I asked.

"The bouquets, the apologies, the terrible choices. Yes."

Laurent saw us and looked away.

That interested me more than the car.

The auctioneer was a fast-talking man named Enzo Quill. He wore a green suit, white gloves, and an expression that had never met a price it considered final.

"The prince offers his family's last racing car," he announced.

"A magnificent pledge of confidence."

Porsche leaned toward Laurent as we approached.

"Your last car?"

"It is a complicated family matter."

"Nigga, that's how men introduce simple lies," Mercedes said.

"What happened?"

He glanced at Enzo.

"My father lost a wager. Enzo purchased the debt. If I don't place in the tournament, he takes the house."

"And if you do?"

"He takes the prize."

I looked at the auctioneer.

"That nigga good at math."

Laurent's jaw tightened.

"I am not asking for help."

"Nigga, you think I waited for your permission to notice you miserable?"

"A prince has obligations."

"So does a nigga with friends. We both standing here. Which one got the better offer?"

Laurent looked at Mercedes. She folded her arms.

"Don't start borrowing dignity to pay that nigga interest," she told him. "Tell Aiden the truth."

Enzo came over smiling.

"Captain. Shall I put you down for a bid?"

"Depends. How much for the prince?"

His smile sharpened.

"His obligations are not among today's lots."

"Nigga, everything was for sale five minutes ago. This city changes customs fast."

People gathered around us. Enzo knew an audience was money. He also knew Corvin had just paid me four million for a wreck with my photograph beside it.

He named a number.

A stupid number.

Tank laughed in his face.

"Nigga, for that we can get a whole other prince and raise his self-esteem from scratch."

Laurent looked offended, then couldn't keep the smile off his face.

I pointed at the old station clock.

"One race. You and me. Around the harbor road and back through the north gate. I win, you release the debt. You win, you get the four million from my Ferrari."

Enzo's eyes flicked toward Zero, watching from the upper platform.

Then he nodded.

"And your new car."

"Nigga, you haven't even seen me drive the old one."

The station changed in five minutes. Music stopped. Doors opened. Men who had been pretending to appreciate antiques suddenly remembered they loved engines. Ardent's police cleared the route because he claimed it would prevent disorder, which was a beautiful way of describing what he was about to encourage.

Shawna kissed me through the window of the green Ferrari.

"No hood riding."

"I'm inside this time."

"Stay ambitious about that."

Laurent climbed into the passenger seat before I could ask.

"I know the road."

"Nigga, you know how to hold on?"

"I intend to learn."

Mercedes leaned into his window.

"When this nigga turns, you breathe. When this nigga flies, you shut your mouth so your prayer stays inside."

Laurent stared at her.

"Flies?"

"Nigga, you entered the passenger seat of a solution. Stop interviewing the weather."

Enzo drove a black racing coupe with his name painted on the side. Nigga had branded the evidence of his own bad judgment. The flag fell.

We left the station side by side, engines tearing the afternoon open. Enzo took the first turn tight, forcing me wide toward a row of empty stalls. I clipped a basket of oranges. Fruit bounced behind us. Laurent ducked one that came through the window and caught another against his chest.

"Keep it," I said. "Nigga needs a race souvenir."

"I need my heart back where it was!"

"That nigga can sit with the orange. Where we going?"

"Left at the fountain!"

I went left.

Enzo went right.

Laurent stared.

"That's the longer road."

"Nigga got a shorter conscience. Watch."

A delivery truck rolled into our route.

I saw it early enough to choose between crashing and doing something the Ferrari's designers had probably discussed while drunk and then crossed out.

I chose the second thing.

We hit a low loading ramp, jumped the corner of the truck bed, and landed on the road beyond with a noise like a rich man's savings account cracking in half.

Laurent made a prayer out of several languages.

"Nigga, pick one god and give him directions!"

Enzo reappeared ahead of us at the next intersection. Smiling. He thought the truck had solved his problem.

I pulled alongside.

His smile left first.

Then his mirror.

The cars touched. Metal scraped. We raced beneath the old city gate with inches between our doors and the stone. Above us, people leaned from windows shouting my name. One woman threw a scarf. It wrapped around Enzo's aerial like his car had decided to surrender fashionably.

The final stretch ran through the station's covered loading yard.

Enzo cut in front of me and braked.

Laurent shouted.

I turned into the empty lane beside him, rode the Ferrari along the raised platform edge, and came down ahead just before the finish line.

The station erupted.

I stopped under the Crown's glass case.

Enzo kept going into a stack of velvet display chairs.

Nigga, he had finally bought himself a seat.

Laurent climbed out shaking. Mercedes and Porsche reached him first. One checked his face. The other took the orange from his hand and peeled it while he tried to explain what had happened to his understanding of speed.

Enzo staggered from his car.

"The race was irregular!"

I leaned against the Ferrari.

"Nigga, your truck missed. That's irregular for you."

"You left the road!"

"Your nigga put a truck on it. I went where the nigga wasn't. That's racing with good judgment."

Laurent lifted his orange.

"He caught this too," he announced, then looked down. "No. I caught it. He made me keep it."

"See?" I said. "Nigga already remembering his own achievements. Sign his paper."

The crowd laughed.

Zero did not intervene.

That was how I knew the auctioneer wasn't worth enough to save.

Enzo signed the release on the hood of his own wreck. Laurent took it with both hands. For a moment the prince looked younger than twenty-seven, stripped of all the little performances he'd been using to keep nobody from noticing he was frightened.

"I don't know how to repay you," he said.

"Start by choosing a bouquet for one woman at a time."

"That is all?"

"Nigga, you tried it yet? Let's not call the assignment easy before you pass."

Mercedes took the release from him long enough to check the signature, then put it back against his chest.

"That's yours, baby. This nigga gave you back a future. Quit holding it like somebody else's receipt."

Mercedes and Porsche laughed.

Enzo tried to leave in a second car.

I stopped him.

"Where you going with that?"

"It is mine."

"You owe me a running car."

"That was not part of our wager."

"Nigga, I bought it while you was crashing. Ask the auctioneer."

His mouth opened.

Behind him, the entire station began chanting my name.

He handed over the keys.

Sometimes a man signs because of a contract. Sometimes he signs because a thousand people have just realized what kind of nigga he is, and the door has become more valuable than the car.

Corvin stopped me before I reached the new car.

"Captain. A small favor."

"Nigga, I just sold you a wreck. You want it damaged in a particular direction?"

He held out a silver pen.

"A signature. On the photograph. For the collection."

Dalia stood beside him with her arms folded, enjoying every second of a man who usually bought other people's attention trying to ask for mine without showing how badly he wanted it.

I took the pen.

"Where?"

"Anywhere you like."

"Nigga, that's how the Ferrari ended up there in the first place."

Porsche laughed. Mercedes took the photograph from him and held it flat while I signed.

Then she looked at the picture properly.

“Aiden, baby. Your face.”

“What about it?”

“You look offended by the landing.”

“Landing came up fast. Nigga prefers an introduction.”

Corvin leaned closer, delighted.

“May I quote that beside the display?”

I looked at him.

Dalia started laughing before I answered.

“Nigga, put the whole conversation up if the wall's big enough.”

He took the photograph back with both hands. I had seen men carry diamonds with less care. Beside him, Laurent looked from the picture to the debt release in his own hands and began smiling again.

“What?” Mercedes asked him.

The prince shook his head.

“Nothing. I came here terrified of losing my family's car.”

“And?”

He looked at me.

“This man sold one that no longer worked and bought me back with another.”

“Nigga,” Porsche said, “you finally watching the right part of the evening.”

Laurent nodded. Folded the release carefully. Put it inside his jacket over his heart.

I watched him do it and let myself enjoy something I couldn't have parked in any garage.

That night, House Laurent pledged itself to my claim.

The prince arrived at the opera house with one bouquet.

He gave it to Shawna for the lobby and asked Mercedes and Porsche if they would teach him how to apologize without making it sound like another invitation.

Porsche looked at Mercedes.

"This nigga might be trainable."

"Don't say that in front of him. He'll start fetching."

I sat beside my wife watching the harbor lights move across the water.

"How many houses now?" she asked.

"Enough to make that nigga Zero rearrange his face."

"That many?"

"Baby, the nigga needs a whole new expression and a contractor to install it."

She took my hand.

"And how many cars?"

"Baby, don't ask a nigga to count when he's trying to be romantic."

10. The Prince Learned to Carry Something

Laurent came to breakfast wearing a sword he couldn't sit down with.

Nigga, the chair lost the first round. He turned sideways, the scabbard struck the table, and a bowl of oranges went across the floor while the prince tried to apologize to three women and a piece of furniture at the same time.

Porsche caught her coffee before it fell.

Mercedes watched one orange roll beneath Tank's shoe.

"Your Highness," she said, "you planning to fight the omelet?"

"It's ceremonial."

"Nigga, ceremony spilled my juice. Take it off."

He looked at me.

I kept eating.

"You heard the woman. Your nigga graduated breakfast without a sword. You can too."

Laurent unbuckled it and leaned it against the wall. The relief on his face was so immediate that Rosa started laughing before he'd sat down.

"You been suffering for tradition all morning?"

"I wanted to make the right impression."

"Baby, you already made one in the carpet."

The prince looked at the orange juice, then up at Mercedes. Twenty-seven years old, handsome, rich again for the first time since some other nigga had bought his father's bad decision, and still trying to work out why women didn't applaud a man simply for arriving with his own name.

"I came to invite you," he said.

"One woman or the whole room?" Porsche asked.

He took a breath.

"The whole room. To the harbor. My house is reopening its public pier. There are fishermen, stallholders, crews who have waited months for the debt to be settled. I thought it appropriate to thank them."

Mercedes looked at Porsche.

Porsche looked at me.

I nodded.

"Nigga getting closer."

Shawna came in carrying two sheets of music and wearing the expression she got when somebody had called her before she'd decided whether the day deserved her voice.

"What are we doing at the harbor?"

"Teaching a prince to be useful," I said.

She kissed me, took an orange off Tank's plate, and sat down.

"Take the car with the big trunk. Useful tends to come back carrying things."

House Laurent's pier had blue flags, a white bandstand, and a row of empty market stalls waiting for somebody to stop owning them long enough to let people work.

The harbor beyond it was full of boats. Little fishing boats. Tall pleasure yachts. A red ferry with more rust than dignity. At the far end, beside the opening gate, stood a thirty-foot bronze statue of Laurent's grandfather pointing at the sea as if the nigga had personally placed it there.

Tank stood beneath it and looked up.

"That the family?"

"My grandfather," Laurent said.

"He point all day?"

"It symbolizes vision."

"Nigga could've symbolized helping with the bags."

We had brought bags. Shawna made sure of it. Food from the opera-house kitchen, flowers from the lobby, bottled water, a little money because applause didn't buy much before lunch. The forty-seven people sheltering upstairs had helped pack

everything. They had wanted something to do that wasn't waiting for Vesper to get them safely through another day.

Mercedes put two heavy baskets into Laurent's hands before his attendants could take them.

"You carrying these."

"Of course."

"Look at that, Porsche. A nigga said of course and meant his own arms."

The prince smiled despite himself.

He carried the baskets down the pier while we followed. People turned when they saw us. Some recognized him first. Most recognized me immediately afterward, which I thought was considerate of everybody's priorities.

"Captain!"

A woman came out of a fish stall waving a towel. Forty-one, strong shoulders, black hair under a blue scarf, eyes sharp enough to tell whether a man had come to buy or waste the morning.

"Colette Vail," she said, shaking my hand. "I run the boats when the men pretending to own them aren't around."

"Then I came to see the right nigga."

She laughed.

Laurent stepped forward with the baskets.

"Madam Vail. I am sorry for the delay. My family's affairs—"

Mercedes cleared her throat.

He stopped. Looked at her. Tried again.

"I'm sorry you couldn't work. Where do these go?"

Colette stared at him for a second.

Then she pointed.

"Kitchen. Back there."

He went.

Porsche put a hand over her heart.

"Our boy."

"Don't get emotional," Mercedes said. "Nigga still got to find the kitchen."

Ardent arrived while Laurent was discovering that a royal basket carried exactly the same weight as an ordinary one. The police chief wore a white summer jacket over his uniform and brought four officers who looked delighted to be assigned somewhere I was already standing.

"Captain," he said. "I was told there would be a ceremony."

"Nigga, there'll be several if these people keep giving Laurent things to carry."

Ardent looked down the pier. The prince now had a crate against his chest and a woman telling him to mind the step.

"This may be the best public appearance his house has managed in years."

"Keep your voice down. We don't want the nigga getting satisfied."

The man who came to stop the opening arrived in a yellow yacht with his own name on the side.

OREN VEX.

Nigga, I respected not making us guess which motherfucker was interrupting lunch.

He was forty-two, broad, tan, wearing a white uniform that had never been near anything requiring a white uniform. A captain's hat sat on his head at an angle that suggested he'd won it from a better captain in a card game.

Six armed men stood behind him.

The yacht came alongside the public pier without slowing enough to make friends. Ropes hit the boards. A man jumped off and started pushing the stallholders back from the gate.

Colette stepped in front of him.

"Open day," she said. "You buying something?"

"Lord Vex has business here."

"Then tell Lord Vex to use his fucking feet and come have it."

I liked her more every minute.

Vex stepped down from the yacht himself. Looked at Colette, then Laurent, then the baskets, as if the sight of a prince carrying lunch had made him doubt whether the city still knew how to behave.

"This pier is under my protection."

Laurent set the crate down carefully.

"My house's debt was released yesterday."

"The debt. My protection remains."

"Nigga, you hear that?" I asked Tank. "Paid off one problem, another nigga came with a hat."

Vex looked at me properly for the first time.

His expression tightened.

"Captain Aiden."

"Lord Oren Vex. Nigga, you spelled it big enough."

A few people laughed. Vex didn't.

"This is a local matter."

Ardent moved beside me.

"Then you should be pleased I am here."

Vex's eyes went from one badge to the other. For a second he looked like a man who had bought the wrong sort of backup.

He took a folded paper from his jacket.

"House Laurent owes harbor fees."

Laurent reached for it. Mercedes caught his hand before he touched the page.

"What you signing?"

"I was going to read it."

"Good. Nigga, keep that habit."

He read. His face changed. He looked up at Vex.

"This includes three years of charges after today."

"A guarantee."

"For work you haven't done."

"For work I will not have to do if everyone cooperates."

I leaned toward Ardent.

"Nigga threatens like he got a stomachache."

Ardent laughed openly. Vex's jaw moved.

Behind him, one of his men began untying the red ferry from its berth. Another pushed two crew members back toward the gangway with a rifle.

Colette saw them.

"That's my ferry."

"It is security," Vex said.

She went toward the men. One raised his gun.

I caught her shoulder and moved her behind me.

"Nigga," I said to Vex, "you brought guns to take a boat away from a woman holding fish. That hat better come with an excuse."

"Stand aside."

"No. Try the next idea."

The man with the rifle turned toward me.

Tank hit him before his boss could discover whether that idea was better. The rifle struck the boards. The man went into the empty stall beside us, breaking its counter with a sound that made the fishmonger shout about her deposit.

Then the whole pier came apart.

Shots cracked from the yellow yacht. Ardent's officers pulled people behind the stalls. Colette dropped beside a pile of ropes and shouted for her crew to get the ferry stopped.

Its engine roared.

The red boat moved away from the pier with two of Vex's men on the wheel deck and four crew members trapped below them.

Laurent stood with one basket still in his hands.

Mercedes grabbed his collar.

"Nigga, now's a good time to be royal lower to the ground."

He dropped beside her as a bullet took the flag off the pole above him.

Shawna had her gun out. She fired toward the yacht's upper window and pushed the people behind her toward the market gate.

I looked at the ferry. It was moving toward the harbor entrance, straight across the path of an incoming fuel barge. Too big to stop quickly. Too crowded with ordinary workers to turn into somebody else's fucking lesson.

"Boat," I told Tank.

"Which one?"

"Any nigga's boat that loves us."

Colette pointed at a little blue launch tied under the pier.

"That one loves speed more than people."

"Nigga, sounds like family."

I jumped down into it. Laurent landed beside me a second later, no sword, no hat, both hands empty for the first useful thing he'd done without being told.

"I know the ferry," he said.

"You know how to hold on?"

He looked at me.

"I learned yesterday."

Good fucking answer.

Colette drove the launch.

She came over the side after us, started it, and put us into the harbor before either of us found a seat. Water hit my face. The pier rushed backward. I could hear Tank shouting at somebody on the yacht, hear Shawna's gun answer another shot, hear a hundred people calling my name from a place suddenly too far behind us to help.

The ferry's red hull grew in front of us.

One of Vex's men leaned over its rail and pointed his gun down.

I fired upward. He ducked. Colette turned the launch hard enough to put one side nearly under the water, and the ferry's wake struck us like a moving wall.

Laurent grabbed my arm. I grabbed the boat. For a second the three of us were hanging on to one another's decisions.

Then we came alongside.

A crewman on the ferry had thrown a rope ladder over the side. Thirty-six, beard full of salt, shouting something I couldn't hear over the engines.

Laurent looked up at the ladder.

"I should go first. I know—"

"Nigga, let the best man get up there and make knowing useful."

I climbed.

The launch dropped beneath me. My shoes struck red metal. A wave came between the two boats and nearly pulled the ladder out of my hands. I held on, climbed again, and came over the rail with a pistol in one hand and every reason not to die in the other.

The first man tried to meet me at the top.

I hit him before my second foot touched the deck.

He went backward into a bench. The bench went backward into another bench. The ferry had suddenly found a new seating arrangement, and the nigga who'd designed it lay in the middle looking surprised.

The crewman caught my arm.

"Wheelhouse. They're taking her straight into the barge."

I looked through the open deck.

The barge filled the harbor entrance. Black side. White wake. A horn sounded, long and furious, while the ferry kept going toward it.

Laurent came over the rail behind me. He was breathing hard. His jacket was torn. The crewman stared at his face.

"Your Highness?"

"Later," Laurent said. "Help me get the others below the rail."

Nigga, I'd have applauded if my hands hadn't been occupied becoming the reason any of us got to go home.

I ran for the stairs to the wheelhouse.

The second man came through the door with his gun up. He fired. Glass burst beside my head. I dropped behind the stair wall, heard another shot, and came up close enough that the man forgot how much space a gun needed to remain his.

We hit the door together.

The wheel spun under his shoulder. The ferry turned suddenly, throwing us both into the side window. His gun went overboard. Mine slid across the floor beneath the captain's chair.

He reached for my throat.

I gave him the window instead.

His head struck the frame. He let go. I drove him down beside the chair and kept him there until his hands stopped trying to make a future out of me.

Then I stood and looked ahead.

Nigga, the barge was everything.

Its horn filled the wheelhouse. I could see men on its deck waving. See the white line of water piling up along its bow. See the small ugly distance still left for me to argue with.

I took the wheel.

The ferry fought it. Heavy, old, moving with too much of itself committed to the wrong direction. I held on. Turned. Put my shoulder into it like I could tell the whole harbor whose man had arrived.

The deck tilted beneath my feet.

A cup rolled off the captain's shelf and broke. The barge's black wall moved across the window. For one impossible second I thought we'd struck it.

Then the ferry's bow slid past.

Our side scraped along the barge hard enough to tear red paint into the water. Metal screamed. The window beside me cracked. I kept the wheel turned while the huge black hull passed so close I could have reached out and taken somebody's hat.

Then we were clear.

Open water filled the windshield.

The ferry rocked once, twice, and found its feet beneath us.

I put my forehead against the wheel.

"Nigga," I whispered, "you welcome."

Laurent came into the wheelhouse carrying a fire extinguisher. He looked at the unconscious man on the floor. Then at the broken window. Then at the barge behind us.

"You turned it."

"Nigga, you see straight water in front of me?"

"That boat takes three crew to turn in a harbor."

"Then your nigga saved two salaries."

He began laughing. Not the little careful laugh he'd brought to breakfast. This came out of his whole chest, wild and frightened and alive.

The crewman appeared behind him, then the others. Four grown people standing in the doorway of their own wheelhouse looking at me like the sea had introduced them to a better captain.

One of them took off his cap.

"Sir."

I lifted my head.

"Nigga, put it back on. Your boat needs you."

They met us at the pier with the whole market cheering.

Vex sat in handcuffs beside his yellow yacht. Tank stood over him with the man's captain's hat on his own head. It was too small. That made it better.

Rosa saw him and said, "Absolutely not."

"It's maritime," he told her.

"It's embarrassing. Take it off before the ocean files a complaint."

Shawna came down the gangway before I'd reached the last step. Put her arms around me. Held me hard enough that I understood exactly how long she had watched the ferry approach the barge.

"You scared me."

"Nigga scared himself a little."

She pulled back.

"You admitting that?"

"Only to the woman holding me."

She kissed me, and the market became so loud I thought the buildings might start selling tickets.

Laurent came behind us carrying the injured crewman's bag. Mercedes took one look at his torn jacket and wet shoes.

"Your Highness had a morning."

"Yes."

"You enjoy being useful?"

He looked at the people on the pier. At Colette hugging her crew. At the market gate open behind them.

"More than being introduced."

Porsche smiled.

"There he is."

Colette brought us to the bandstand. The ribbon for the pier opening still hung across it, one end shot loose and fluttering in the wind.

Laurent took the scissors from his attendant. Looked at them. Then handed them to Colette.

"You waited longest."

She stared at him for a second. Then took them.

The ribbon fell.

Every stall on the pier opened at once. People moved through carrying baskets, plates, bags, the little ordinary fortunes they'd come to earn before a rich man decided the morning needed his permission.

Ardent shook my hand beside the bandstand.

"Captain, you have acquired the harbor."

"Nigga, I came for breakfast. Things happen."

Colette put a brass key in Laurent's hand.

"Your family's launch house. It's yours again. But the boats answer if Aiden calls."

Laurent looked at me.

"They already do."

On the way back to the opera house, Mercedes made the prince carry the empty baskets. He did it without looking around for somebody to notice.

I noticed anyway.

Nigga, a great man ought to recognize when another one starts trying.

11. My Wife Sang Through the Whole Damn Thing

Paolo sold the benefit out before Shawna finished telling him what a benefit was.

Nigga, the man heard people, money, and my wife's name in one sentence and began opening the doors with his whole heart.

By seven that evening, there were cars along both sides of the opera house, people leaning from the hotel balconies, and a white banner across the street announcing SHAWNA AND ROSA — ONE NIGHT FOR THE HOUSE.

Underneath, in smaller letters, somebody had added CAPTAIN AIDEN WILL BE PRESENT.

I stood in the street looking at it.

"Smaller letters?"

Shawna hooked her arm through mine.

"You singing?"

"Nigga could."

"Then you can audition next time. Tonight you buy a ticket."

I bought the whole front row.

She made me keep one seat and give the others back to the guests who'd been waiting. Nigga, I had married a woman who could redistribute my greatness with two fingers and a look.

Inside, the forty-seven people from Vesper's household had turned the opera house into something that smelled like supper instead of fear. The cook ran the kitchen. Drivers helped park cars. Two singers warmed up with Rosa behind the stage. The others carried flowers, hung lamps, checked seats, did the practical little things people do when they want the place keeping them alive to feel like somewhere they chose.

Nobody wore Vesper's colors. Nobody had to explain why they were there. Paolo called them the house company, and for that evening the name fit.

Dalia was setting a covered sculpture in the lobby when we came in.

Corvin stood beside her telling a man in an expensive coat how much the marble had cost. Dalia kept working around him as if he were another piece of furniture somebody had delivered before she approved the measurements.

"What's under there?" I asked.

She stepped back.

"Your wife."

Shawna stopped.

Dalia pulled away the cloth.

The sculpture was smaller than life, white marble catching the lobby light, Shawna's face turned slightly toward something beyond the room. The scar above her eyebrow was there. So was the little lift at one corner of her mouth, the expression she wore when she knew I was about to do something expensive and had already decided to love me through it.

I looked at Dalia.

"Nigga, you got her."

The sculptor smiled.

"She sat for twenty minutes. You spent nineteen of them telling her she looked beautiful. It helped."

Shawna touched the edge of the marble shoulder.

"You kept the scar."

"It's yours."

Corvin put a hand on the pedestal.

"An extraordinary piece. I could place it in my west gallery."

Dalia moved his hand gently out of the way.

"It belongs here."

He blinked.

"I paid for the—"

"Stone," she said. "You paid for the stone."

I took my checkbook out before the sentence finished.

"Nigga, how much rock you want reimbursed?"

Shawna put her hand on mine.

Dalia was already smiling at Corvin.

"A gift to the house. Put your name on the little card if you need help enjoying it."

The people around us laughed. Corvin looked at the statue, then at Dalia's face, and found a better answer than the one he'd come with.

"Your name first," he said.

She looked at him for a long second.

"There might be hope for you."

Porsche leaned toward Mercedes.

"Everybody learning tonight."

Mercedes looked at Laurent, who was helping an older woman find her seat without mentioning his family once.

"Nigga class filling up."

Gault arrived in a dark suit that made the former champion look like he'd come to apologize to a chandelier for how close his shoulders were getting.

He shook my hand at the stage door.

"I hear the harbor went well."

"Nigga, the harbor still there. That's a strong start."

He smiled.

"Laurent told me you turned the ferry."

"Laurent needs to stop remembering things before people start asking me to do them twice."

Gault looked into the theater. Saw Rosa at the piano, Shawna speaking to the conductor, Tank moving a heavy piece of scenery by himself because a woman had said it needed moving and he didn't want to waste the compliment arriving afterward.

"Where do you need me?"

I pointed at the lobby.

"Smile at the rich people. Let them know the money going somewhere they can feel good about surviving."

"I can do that."

He went out and immediately made a man buy twelve tickets to a show that was already sold out. Nigga, I respected a fighter who understood the second half of his career.

Backstage, Shawna stood in a deep blue dress with her hands flat on a little table. She was quiet in a way I knew now. Not frightened of singing. Frightened of caring how much the singing might mean.

I came behind her and put my hands over hers.

"Baby."

"I know. I'm going to be good."

"Nigga, good ain't big enough for you."

She looked at me in the mirror.

"You keep saying things like that before I go onstage."

"Then go onstage and make me look honest."

Her laugh came back. Small at first, then whole.

She turned around, put both hands against my chest, and straightened the gold cross.

"Keep the car out of the theater."

"Why you starting the night with limits?"

"Because I know my husband."

"Nigga knows his wife too. She gonna make those people cry and then charge them for another song."

She kissed me.

"Go sit down, Captain. Let me work."

The first song brought the whole house to its feet.

Shawna began alone. No orchestra. No piano. Just her voice rising from the middle of the stage while the audience quieted one person at a time until even the men who usually made noise with their money had nothing worth interrupting her with.

I sat in the front row and forgot where my hands were.

Tank nudged me.

"Nigga, you're gripping the chair."

"Chair should feel honored."

Onstage, she lifted her head for the last note. It filled the space above us, touched the high painted ceiling, came back carrying every time I'd heard her stop halfway through a song because the room in her head had gotten too crowded.

She didn't stop tonight.

The applause hit so hard I felt it through the floor.

Rosa came out for the second number in red, all confidence, one hand on the microphone like she had finally found something in the city worth telling how she felt.

Tank stood up before anybody else.

She pointed at him once.

"This one is for a man who still thinks buying two identical cars counts as a personality."

The whole theater laughed.

Tank put both hands on his chest.

"Nigga, she talking about me."

"We got there," I told him. "Everybody got there."

He sat down smiling so hard his face looked different.

I would've stayed in that seat all night watching my people become beautiful in public.

Then I saw the man at the side door.

Gray jacket. Black glove on one hand. No program. He looked toward the balcony, touched his ear, and turned away without looking at the stage once.

Nigga, everybody looked at Rosa.

I got up.

Tank saw my face and came with me.

The man disappeared into the corridor beside the dressing rooms.

I followed far enough to hear a door close upstairs. A heavy door. Then a short cry that somebody tried to swallow before it reached the music.

Tank looked at me.

"The company rooms."

I nodded.

Vesper's forty-seven people were supposed to be spread through the house working. Some were still upstairs waiting to go on or helping the older staff get ready for the reception. Those rooms were where somebody would go if he wanted the people more than the audience.

I took the stairs two at a time.

At the landing, a man in a dark uniform stood beside the wardrobe door. Not Ardent's police. Black Mantle. He saw me and reached for his gun.

I hit him with the door before he got it out.

The wood struck his shoulder. He went into the wall. Tank caught him on the way down and put him on the floor without letting the sound reach Rosa's verse.

Inside the wardrobe room, six people stood against the wall with their hands raised. Two men held guns on them. A third was going through a list.

The old cook had one hand around a rolling pin.

"You let her keep that?" I asked.

All three men turned.

"Nigga, you already lost."

The cook hit the nearest man across the forearm before he finished looking at me. His gun dropped. Tank came through behind my shoulder and drove the second man into a rack of costumes. Silk and velvet fell over both of them like the theater was trying to dress the beating properly.

The third man fired.

The shot struck the doorframe beside my face. Downstairs the orchestra hit a loud brass chord at exactly the same moment, and

for one terrible, beautiful second the audience applauded without knowing what we'd just kept away from them.

I fired back.

The man dropped behind the dressing table. I crossed the room, caught his jacket, and dragged him out before he could decide he liked that position.

His gun skidded across the floor.

The cook kicked it under a cupboard and looked at me.

"They came for us."

"Nigga, they came to get disappointed. You stay behind Tank."

The man with the list tried to crawl toward the window.

Mercedes appeared on the other side of it from the narrow balcony and put one high heel against the frame.

"Wrong exit, baby."

He stopped so suddenly his forehead hit the sill.

Porsche came through the door behind us with Gault. Between them they had another two men by the collars. Gault looked almost apologetic about how unconscious his man was.

"He argued."

"Nigga, you have a persuasive face," I told him.

Mercedes climbed through the window and brushed her dress straight.

"Three more in the laundry lift. I saw them from the stairs."

I looked toward the corridor.

The lift began moving.

The old theater's laundry lift was a wooden platform inside an iron frame, big enough to move scenery when the regular stage lift broke. I had watched Paolo bring a piano up in it that afternoon, worrying over the instrument like the whole house might forget music if it got scratched.

Now three armed men rode it toward the top floor.

Their chief stood beside the gate wearing a long gray coat. He had a rifle in one hand and a little radio in the other. When he saw me, he looked almost relieved.

"Captain Aiden. Finally."

"Nigga, everybody says finally right before their night gets shorter."

He lifted the radio.

"Colonel Drake will be pleased."

"Then call the nigga after. Let him enjoy the suspense."

The lift reached the floor.

The gate opened.

Tank hit the chief into it, and the two of them fell onto the platform. The armed men inside tried to raise their guns without shooting their own commander. That little hesitation gave Gault room to join the conversation.

The whole lift shook.

I came in low as a gun went off above us. Wood splintered. Somebody hit the lever on the wall, and the platform began sinking while five grown men tried to decide who got to remain standing on it.

We dropped past the first floor.

Past the galleries.

Straight toward the orchestra pit.

I heard the music growing louder beneath us. Rosa was at the end of her song. Shawna had joined her for the last chorus. Their voices came up together while Tank held the chief's arm away from all the people he could hurt.

One of the men shoved Gault against the rail. Gault caught himself, then the man, and put them both on the floor. I hit another against the lift's side. The third lost his footing and went through the open gate onto the stage level, rolling behind a curtain.

I followed him out.

The curtain flew aside.

For one second I stood in front of a packed theater with a gunman by the back of his coat and my wife holding a microphone ten feet away.

Shawna looked at me.

Then at the gunman.

Then at the empty space where her show had been proceeding beautifully.

"Aiden."

"Baby, keep singing."

Nigga, she did.

She turned toward the audience and sang the next line louder. Rosa came beside her, took the harmony, and the orchestra caught them without missing the measure.

I put the gunman through the open scenery door before anybody in the front row finished deciding whether that was part of what they'd paid for.

It wasn't.

They applauded anyway.

The chief escaped Tank's grip when the lift stopped below the stage.

He came through a lower door into the loading courtyard, coat torn, radio gone, one hand clamped around his gun. I saw him from the stage wing as he ran toward a black car waiting outside.

He got in.

The car moved.

My Lamborghini stood across the courtyard.

I looked at it.

Shawna saw me looking from the stage.

Even while she sang, she shook her head.

I held up one finger.

Nigga, my wife knew how much trouble I could fit inside one finger.

I ran.

The Lamborghini's engine came alive under me while the black car turned toward the market street. I followed it out of the courtyard, gold badge shining on the door, siren splitting the night open beside the opera house's music.

People jumped back from the curb. The black car swerved around a flower cart and clipped a stone pillar. I stayed close enough to see the driver looking into his mirror, trying to understand how the same man had been upstairs, onstage, and behind his car before the song ended.

Nigga, I had an active marriage.

He turned into the narrow service street behind the theater.

There was a delivery truck at the far end. No room to pass unless a man loved his car less than he loved the person he'd left singing.

I loved my car plenty.

The truck just wasn't getting my vote.

I drove up the low stone edge beside it, tilted the Lamborghini against the lane's raised border, and slid past with one side high enough to make the driver of the truck remove his cap and hold it against his chest.

Then I came down in front of the black car.

Its driver braked.

Too late to keep his dignity. Just early enough to keep his face.

The black car struck my rear bumper and stopped.

Ardent's police filled the street behind it. Gault stood beside the chief's passenger door before the man could open it. Tank came from the other side, breathing hard, still wearing a strip of opera curtain across one shoulder.

"Nigga," he said through my window, "you told her you was keeping the car out the theater."

"I did. This street."

He looked around.

"Technically."

"A nigga keeps his promises."

Ardent got out of his car and looked at the Black Mantle chief.

"And whose performance were you hoping to interrupt?"

The man said nothing.

"Good answer," Ardent said. "Keep it until we reach the station."

I got back into my seat before the final note ended.

My shirt was torn at the shoulder. My hair had acquired a little theater dust. There was a scratch on my cheek that Shawna would inspect later with the intensity of a woman deciding whether she needed to be angry or only very close to me.

Onstage, my wife sang the last line directly at my face.

Rosa held the harmony beneath it.

The whole house rose.

People clapped until the conductor turned around smiling. Dalia stood beside her statue in the lobby with one hand over her mouth. Laurent held the door for the company members returning downstairs, making sure every one of the forty-seven found a place among the applause.

Mercedes sat beside me and crossed her legs.

"Beautiful show."

"Nigga, I caught most of it."

"You were in some of it."

"Versatile."

She laughed and put her hand over mine for one second.

"They all safe upstairs."

I nodded.

Then Shawna held out her hand from the stage.

I went to her.

She kissed me in front of the whole theater, turned me toward the audience, and pointed at the torn shoulder of my shirt.

"My husband," she said into the microphone. "He promised to sit still."

The laughter rolled upward through three balconies.

I took the microphone gently from her hand.

"Nigga, I sat extremely still when I finally got there."

They laughed harder. Then they began calling my name.

Shawna leaned against my good side and let them.

Afterward, Paolo showed us the money the benefit had raised. Enough to keep the company fed, paid, housed, and working long after Zero's people stopped believing they could order everybody back through the door they had escaped.

I doubled it.

Then Corvin, trapped between Dalia's smile and a whole lobby of witnesses, doubled what I'd doubled.

Dalia kissed him on the cheek.

"Look at you," she said. "Useful marble."

The prince laughed. Gault laughed. Tank pulled Rosa close with one arm and tried to pretend he wasn't holding her as carefully as a man carrying his future down a staircase.

Shawna put her hand inside mine.

"You heard the last song?"

"Every word."

"You were outside for part of it."

"Baby, a nigga can hear home from the street."

She smiled.

And all the noise in the house became the right kind again.

12. Mercedes and Porsche Took the Wheel

Mercedes woke me by knocking on the bedroom door with a shoe.

Nigga, I knew it was a shoe before I opened my eyes. A fist asks a man to get up. A heel explains that his opinion has already been considered.

Shawna rolled onto my chest and looked at the door.

"Your friends."

"Our friends."

"My friends use phones."

The shoe knocked again.

"Captain!"

I closed my eyes.

"Nigga's married!"

"Congratulations. Put your pants on."

Porsche's voice came from beside hers.

"And bring the badge. This bitch wants us to be polite first."

Shawna started laughing against my shoulder.

"Get up, baby. If they brought manners, somebody's in trouble."

They had a woman waiting in the opera-house kitchen.

Thirty-two. Name of Juno Valez. Black curls tied back, a yellow jacket with a torn sleeve, a little grease on one wrist. She sat beside a cup of coffee she hadn't touched and watched the door like she expected somebody to tell her she had misunderstood the part where she was allowed to sit.

Mercedes put a hand on her shoulder when I came in.

"My friend. We worked the Silver Garden together a few summers back."

Juno looked up at me.

"I know who you are."

"Nigga, I hope the introduction was kind."

"They said you jumped a boat, drove a hearse with a body in it, and arrested a man at your own graduation."

"They leaving things out now."

She laughed once, and I saw how badly she needed to.

The Silver Garden sat above the harbor, a private club full of rich men, rich women, beautiful workers, and people whose only visible talent was arriving with somebody else's money. Juno had worked there as an escort years ago, then learned to drive for the guests because she liked engines better than promises. Now she ran half the club's cars and got paid as if she borrowed the steering wheels for pleasure.

Her boss owed her and nine other workers months of money.

Yesterday she'd asked for it.

He'd taken her car instead.

"Nigga," Porsche said, "called it an advance repayment."

I sat down across from Juno.

"You took an advance?"

"No."

"Then the nigga making up time."

Mercedes nodded.

"Exactly."

Juno pulled a photograph from her pocket. A silver sports car beside the harbor, roof down, her sitting behind the wheel looking ten years less tired.

"It's in my name," she said. "I bought it. He has it in the garage with the club fleet. He said if I call the police he'll tell everybody I'm stealing from him."

I tapped the badge against my shirt.

"Nigga called the police by taking the car. He just doesn't know which part of the conversation he's in."

Mercedes folded the photograph and put it gently back into Juno's hand.

"We're going with her. You come behind us."

I looked at her.

"Behind?"

"Aiden, baby, I love you. I also know if you walk through the door first, the man is going to either faint or start shooting before I finish a sentence."

Porsche leaned over the table.

"And we have prepared sentences."

Shawna came in wearing a robe and holding my jacket. She put it over my shoulders and kissed my cheek.

"Let the women work."

"Nigga can support a sentence."

"Then stand behind one for a change."

I stood behind Mercedes and Porsche all the way to the car.

Nigga, a great man can survive being third in line if the first two look that good doing business.

The Silver Garden had a marble fountain full of white flowers and a parking lot worth more than several honest towns.

Ferraris. Bentleys. Two dark limousines. A white motorcycle under a glass canopy like the owner had decided even his bad decisions deserved museum lighting. Along the rear wall stood a car transporter carrying six sports cars, all strapped in a row above the waiting wheels.

Tank looked at the transporter.

"Nigga, that's a lot of temptation stacked vertically."

"Mind your posture," I told him. "We're supporting sentences."

Shawna stayed with Juno near the reception desk while Mercedes and Porsche walked into the lounge. Tank and I followed far enough behind them to make it clear the women had come with their own thoughts and a reasonable amount of insurance.

Inside, the afternoon was already drunk.

Cocaine on a mirrored tray. Champagne in buckets. A man in an open silk shirt telling three women how alone his money made him. One woman said she could help with half of that, and her friends laughed while he tried to work out whether he had been invited or robbed.

I respected a room that announced itself clearly.

At the far end, beneath a portrait of a man who looked equally disappointed in everybody, sat Benedict Velvet.

Fifty-one. Smooth bald head. Heavy gold bracelet. White suit with a flower pinned to the lapel. The flower looked more trustworthy than the rest of him by a wide fucking margin.

He saw Mercedes first.

"My favorite trouble."

"Nigga, your favorite invoice. We're here for Juno."

His smile thinned.

Porsche sat down opposite him without being asked.

"And the nine people whose pay you keep calling next Friday."

"This is between me and my staff."

Mercedes sat beside her.

"Then call them down. We'd love an audience."

Benedict looked past them and found me.

His bracelet stopped moving.

"Captain."

"Nigga, I'm listening. These ladies got prepared sentences."

He stood halfway, then sat again when he realized standing wasn't going to change the shape of the room.

"There has been a misunderstanding."

"Great," Porsche said. "You bring the car, the money, and the apology, and everybody can understand lunch."

"It isn't that simple."

"Nigga, you took a car. How many pages you need?"

A few of the workers near the bar had stopped pretending not to listen. Juno came in with Shawna beside her. Benedict saw her and his face hardened.

"You brought outsiders into my house?"

Juno looked at Mercedes.

Mercedes didn't speak for her.

Porsche didn't either.

After a second, Juno looked back at him.

"I brought people who answer me."

The room changed around that one sentence. I could feel it. Men who had been drinking looked down at their glasses. Women by the bar straightened. One of the drivers near the hall took his cap off and held it in both hands like he wanted to hear the rest without anything on his head.

Benedict reached for a little bell on the table.

Mercedes moved it out of his reach.

"Nigga, use your voice. Nobody coming to polish the answer."

He looked at his empty hand.

Then at me again.

"What would satisfy you, Captain?"

I pointed at the women.

"Nigga, you keep missing the actual people talking. That's a costly eyesight problem."

Porsche smiled.

"We want the wages. The car. Everybody free to leave when the evening is theirs. You get to keep whatever dignity you can fit around that."

Benedict sat very still.

Then he said, "Of course."

Behind him, a man slipped out through the service door.

I saw him.

Shawna saw me see him.

She gave the smallest nod toward the hall.

Nigga, my wife could hand me a whole conversation without spending a word.

Tank and I reached the garage as the car transporter started its engine.

Juno's silver car sat at the very back of the upper deck.

A man beside the transporter was closing a gate across the garage entrance. Another stood by the office with a gun in his hand. Two drivers and a woman in a mechanic's coverall were backed against the wall, their hands raised, looking past him toward us.

The man with the gun saw my badge.

"Stop."

"Nigga, you stop. I came later."

He fired.

Tank pulled me behind a concrete post. The shot hit the edge and threw white chips against my cheek. I heard the trapped workers shout. Heard the transporter move. Heard the upper row of cars rattle as the truck rolled toward the steep service road outside.

I looked at Tank.

"Workers."

He nodded.

"Truck," he said back.

Nigga, brothers don't need to repeat the whole dictionary when the important words are clear.

He went toward the gunman as I ran for the transporter. Another shot struck the wall behind me. Then Tank hit something heavy, and the gun stopped speaking.

The transporter crossed the garage threshold.

I caught the rear rail and pulled myself onto the lower deck.

The truck gathered speed down the service road. Above me, Juno's silver car shook against its restraints. I could see the harbor through the open steel frame, bright blue at the bottom of a hill the driver suddenly seemed very eager to finish.

A black coupe came out behind us.

Porsche drove. Mercedes sat beside her with Juno in the back.

"Nigga!" Mercedes shouted through the open window. "We said behind us!"

"I'm on the wrong side of behind!"

"Get the car!"

"That's the part I'm doing!"

The transporter swerved.

Its front tires hit the curb. The whole upper deck lurched, and one of the restraints on Juno's car snapped loose with a sound I felt through the rail beneath my hands.

The silver car rolled backward an inch.

Then another.

Juno saw it. Her face changed in the coupe's back window.

I looked at the road behind us.

At the car above me.

At the low open gate in the transporter's rear frame.

Nigga, some men see a problem. I see something that's about to be very impressed with me.

I climbed.

The wind hit hard when I reached the upper deck. My jacket snapped behind me. The truck swung around another turn, and I

went against the silver car's side with enough force to knock the air out of my chest.

The door opened when I pulled it.

I got inside.

For a second I was sitting in somebody else's sports car, on top of a moving truck, above a road that ended at the harbor.

"Aiden!" Porsche shouted from below.

"Nigga heard you!"

The truck hit another bump.

The car rolled farther back.

I found the key where the garage man had left it. Turned it. The engine woke. I felt the familiar little joy of a machine discovering who had taken the seat, and I smiled despite the fact that the world was presently tilted at an angle no responsible man would have recommended.

The silver car reached the end of the upper deck.

I drove it off.

We fell into the open road behind the transporter with all four wheels leaving the same opinion in the air.

The landing hit like a fist under the whole car.

My teeth came together. The suspension cried out. For one terrible second the silver hood pointed at the wall instead of the road.

Then I caught it.

The car straightened, tires smoking, and I came alongside Porsche with Juno staring at me through the back window like I'd just returned a piece of her life by throwing it out of the fucking sky.

"Mine?" she shouted.

"Yours!"

"Is it okay?"

"Nigga, it got stories now!"

The transporter kept going.

Its driver had jumped out at the next turn.

The truck hadn't stopped with him.

Five sports cars still rode above the runaway truck.

At the bottom of the hill, a public square opened onto the harbor. Tables. Chairs. People finishing lunch beneath striped awnings. The transporter rolled toward it with nobody behind the wheel and enough weight to turn the whole afternoon into a place people never wanted to visit again.

I could see the driver running up a side alley.

Could see Porsche looking from him to the square.

She made her choice before I told her what mine was.

The coupe swung across the alley entrance. Mercedes got out with her gun up. The driver stopped running and put his hands against the wall.

Porsche lifted her phone.

"Ardent! Harbor road! Move those people!"

I put the silver car beside the truck.

The engine strained. We came level with the empty cab, and I could see the wheel turning loosely as the road curved beneath it.

There wasn't time to climb again.

There was enough time to do something stupid with a gift I hadn't asked the sky to explain fully.

Blue light flickered beneath my skin.

One breath.

That was what I gave it. One hard breath of Blue Thunder into my hands, into the wheel, into the silver car's screaming engine. The world sharpened around the edges. The truck's movement slowed just enough inside my eyes for me to find the little space where a better turn could live.

I drove across its nose.

Metal struck metal.

The silver car spun away, but the truck's front swung with it. Its huge tires climbed the edge of an empty loading court instead of the crowded square. The transporter struck a stack of vacant freight crates and plowed through them in a thunder of wood and dust.

Then it stopped against the heavy stone wall at the back.

The cars above it rocked, settled, and stayed.

My engine died.

The blue light left my hands so suddenly I could feel the weight of every finger. I sat in the silver car with my forehead against the wheel, chest empty, arms shaking like I'd spent the whole morning carrying the harbor up a flight of stairs.

Nigga, power had a bill.

Porsche opened my door.

"Baby. Look at me."

I lifted my head.

Juno stood behind her with both hands over her mouth.

Mercedes came around the car, phone pressed to her ear, still keeping the transporter driver at a distance with the kind of stare that made a gun almost unnecessary.

"You all right?" Porsche asked.

"Need a minute."

"You taking two."

"Nigga, expensive women."

She laughed once and touched my cheek.

Ardent's police arrived at the square while people began coming out from behind the awnings. A waiter walked over holding two glasses of water on a tray. His hands shook so badly the glasses rang together.

"Captain."

I took one.

"Nigga, you kept the water in it. That's a skill."

He laughed, relieved enough to look suddenly younger, and put the other glass into Juno's hand.

She stared at her silver car.

The front was crumpled. One headlight hung loose. Both of us had come through the same morning with more marks than we started with.

"I got your car," I told her.

She looked at me.

"You got those people."

I didn't know what to say to that.

She put one hand on the roof.

"We'll fix the car."

Mercedes and Porsche finished the conversation at the Silver Garden without me standing in front of them.

I sat in a chair by the garage with Shawna holding a glass against my mouth because my hands still hadn't forgiven the blue lightning for leaving all at once.

Tank stood behind us. Juno sat beside the other workers. Ardent had Benedict Velvet between two officers, the flower on his lapel crushed against a handcuff chain.

Porsche put the workers' names in front of him.

"Read."

He read.

Mercedes put the amounts beside the names.

"Pay."

He paid.

Nigga, they had prepared excellent sentences.

The nine workers got their money. Juno got hers. Benedict surrendered the garage keys to Ardent and learned that a man could own a nightclub for twenty years and still leave it from the wrong side of a police car.

Juno looked at the damaged silver car through the open garage doors.

Porsche followed her gaze.

"We know somebody who collects famous wrecks."

Mercedes started smiling.

"Baby."

"Exactly."

They called Corvin.

The collector arrived thirty minutes later with Dalia beside him. He looked at the silver car, looked at me, then asked Juno whether she could establish that I had driven it off the moving transporter personally.

Juno stared at him.

"I watched him."

Corvin touched the dented hood like he'd found a rare fucking sunset somebody else had tried to throw away.

"Extraordinary."

Dalia looked at Shawna.

"He was like this when I found him."

Corvin bought the car for enough to pay Juno's rent for years. Then he gave her the keys to the silver sports car he'd arrived in because Dalia said a woman selling transportation ought to leave with some.

Juno tried to refuse.

Dalia shook her head.

"Let him have a good day. He's practicing."

I leaned back in the chair and laughed until my wife told me to stop using recovery time to admire myself.

Nigga, I recovered better admired.

We returned to the opera hotel in the late afternoon.

Juno drove her new silver car with Mercedes beside her and Porsche in the back, all three women arguing happily about which road gave the harbor its best angle. She was going to join Colette's drivers at the pier, run visitors between the boats and the opera house, and decide for herself which evenings belonged to work. She told Mercedes and Porsche they could borrow the silver car whenever they needed it, on the condition that they bring back most of it.

Laurent met us at the door carrying an empty basket.

Mercedes stopped walking.

"Nigga, you still got that?"

"I thought there might be something else to carry."

Porsche looked at her.

Mercedes looked at Juno.

Then all three began laughing.

The prince laughed with them this time. Didn't ask whether it was at him or for him. He took Juno's bag when she offered it and brought it inside.

Upstairs, the company was getting ready for supper. Marcellus and Bastien sat at a little table arguing over cards; Bastien had Eliane's red coat over the back of his chair, and the old man's face looked easier than it had that morning. Somewhere across the city, Zero still had his crown under glass and probably still believed he could tell all these people where to put their hands.

I hadn't forgotten.

I had just found a few more niggas worth winning it near.

Shawna led me into our room, shut the door, and took my jacket off herself.

"Sit."

"Baby, I been sitting."

"Then be excellent at it another minute."

I sat on the bed. She stood between my knees and looked down at the little cut on my cheek.

"Mercedes said you followed instructions."

"Nigga stood behind whole sentences."

"Porsche said you fell out of a truck."

"I was in a car. Details matter."

She shook her head, smiling despite every reason I'd given her to do something louder.

"Juno said you gave her life back."

I looked up at her.

"She already had it. We just got the nigga out of her driveway."

Shawna put her arms around my neck.

For a little while I let the city run without my hands on its wheel.

My wife was there. My people were downstairs. A prince had learned to carry a basket, two women had finished every sentence they brought, and somewhere in the harbor a silver car was taking its owner exactly where she wanted to go.

Nigga, that was a good fucking afternoon.

13. The Wedding I Ruined Beautifully

A woman stopped my car with a wedding cake.

Nigga, not a little cake. A whole white tower on a rolling table. She pushed it into the street, planted both hands on her hips, and waited for me to decide how much marriage my bumper could handle.

I braked.

Tank braked behind me.

Rosa leaned out of his window.

"Don't hit it! That's good frosting!"

The woman came to my door. Thirty-one, dark hair under a florist's cap, green eyes furious enough to make the hat look like a disguise for a weather event.

"Are you Captain Aiden?"

"Depends how expensive the cake is."

"They said you would help."

"Who?"

"Everybody."

I looked back at Tank.

"Nigga, everybody referring business now."

"Then listen before this lady parks a whole marriage on your hood."

"I need you to stop a wedding."

Shawna turned toward me slowly.

"Baby, finally a request you haven't had this week."

The woman was Camille Mercier. She arranged flowers for the city's grand houses, drove a little truck with a broken passenger window, and had been in love with Lady Sabine Leone for four years.

Sabine was getting married in forty minutes.

To Lord Mordecai Draven.

A fifty-eight-year-old king with three dead wives, two living mistresses, and a facial expression Camille described as a shovel wearing perfume.

"Why is she marrying him?" Shawna asked.

"Because Zero owns her father's debt. Because her father is a coward. Because Mordecai likes having something somebody else wants. Pick whichever answer makes you angriest."

Tank got out of his car.

"Nigga, I dislike the shovel part personally."

Camille looked at him, then at me, then at Shawna.

"She told me not to come. She said she'd find a way later. There won't be a later. He takes her out of the city tonight."

Shawna opened her door.

"Get in."

Camille blinked.

"What about the cake?"

Rosa had already climbed out with a spoon she'd apparently been carrying for exactly this kind of emergency.

"Nigga, look at me. Does this face look like it lets a wedding cake die in traffic?"

Camille blinked at her.

"The cake is protected. Go. Your woman's waiting on the nigga, not the frosting."

We reached the chapel while the guests were still arriving. Black cars lined the courtyard. White flowers covered the doors. Two armed men stood beside a sign asking everyone to surrender weapons before entering.

Nigga, I laughed before either guard said a word.

"You think this sign applies to me?"

One recognized my face.

The other recognized my badge.

"That nigga from the cathedral," the first whispered.

"That nigga from the boat," said the second.

"Same nigga from the street," I told them. "Now move before you become the niggas from the doorway."

Both discovered urgent business inside.

Shawna and Camille walked ahead while Tank stayed close to my shoulder. Rosa followed carrying a piece of cake in a napkin. Mercedes and Porsche arrived in the silver sports car seconds later, wearing sunglasses and expressions that suggested they had been waiting all their lives to interrupt a rich man's wedding. Inside, Mordecai stood beneath an arch of white roses.

Camille had been generous about the shovel.

The nigga looked like a grave had ordered a suit.

Sabine stood beside him, beautiful in ivory, her face so carefully still it made me want to break something on her behalf before she even spoke. Her father sat in the front row staring at his gloves.

The officiant saw us and stopped.

Mordecai turned.

"This ceremony is private."

"Then why you got everybody miserable in public?" I asked.

"Nigga, the flowers look like they signed a statement."

Mordecai looked past me.

"Who admitted this man?"

"This nigga admitted himself. Those niggas discovered another room. You caught up?"

A murmur moved through the pews.

Camille stepped into the aisle.

Sabine's face changed completely.

Nigga, there it was. The whole reason we'd driven over. A woman who had been standing like she was already gone suddenly looked alive enough to make every flower in the room seem late.

"Camille."

"I'm here."

Mordecai moved between them.

"She was instructed not to attend."

Shawna stepped past him.

"Sabine. Do you want to marry this man?"

The chapel went quiet.

Sabine looked at her father.

He looked away.

Then she looked at Camille.

"No."

One little word.

Nigga, you would've thought she'd fired a cannon through the roof.

Mordecai's face reddened.

"The agreement has been signed."

"Not by her mouth," I said.

"You have no standing in this matter."

I took out my badge.

"Nigga, I been standing in the aisle for three minutes. Catch up."

His guards moved.

Tank moved sooner.

The first one hit a pew. The second decided to go around Tank and found Mercedes holding a heavy flower arrangement like she had personal reasons to dislike his face.

Porsche pulled the chapel doors shut behind us.

"Private ceremony," she told the late guests outside.

"Apparently."

Mordecai drew a small pistol from beneath his jacket.

I caught his wrist before the barrel cleared the cloth and drove his hand against the stone arch. The gun fell into the flowers. He tried to strike me with his other hand, and I put him across the

signing table so hard the marriage papers rose into the air like doves with bad intentions.

"Nigga," I told him, "you brought a gun to a woman saying no. That's embarrassing."

His father-in-law stood.

"The debt—"

Sabine turned on him.

"You can pay it."

"We will lose the house."

"Then live in a smaller one. I was about to lose my life inside a larger one."

Camille reached her.

They held each other in the middle of the aisle while the flowers shook around the overturned table.

Shawna looked at me.

I knew that look.

"Baby."

"You're a captain."

"Nigga, don't give me that many responsibilities with your eyes."

"You can find somebody to marry them."

The officiant raised one shaking hand.

"I am still here."

"See?" Shawna said.

So we had a wedding.

A different wedding.

Mordecai sat handcuffed in the front row with Tank beside him, looking like a man who had bought a ticket to the wrong disaster. Rosa gave him no cake. She was very firm about that.

"That nigga just looked at my plate," she told Tank.

"I seen him."

"Make sure the nigga understands the separation."

Tank moved his chair between Mordecai and the cake.

"You heard the lady. Nigga, enjoy the ceremony with your mouth empty."

Camille took off her florist's cap. Sabine pulled flowers from the arch and made her a little bouquet herself. Mercedes found two rings in the ceremonial tray and asked the officiant whether somebody had already paid for them.

"Yes," he said.

"Excellent. We honoring the investment."

Sabine laughed through her tears.

The vows were short. Nobody needed them to be impressive. Camille's hands shook. Sabine held them steady. When they

kissed, Shawna leaned against me and the chapel cheered so loudly Mordecai flinched.

Nigga, I had never enjoyed a man's discomfort more respectfully.

The photographer kept trying to put me between the brides.

Nigga, I understood the temptation. I was standing there looking like the reason a wedding had survived its own guest list. But Camille had one hand wrapped around Sabine's, and every time he moved them apart to fit me in, both women looked at the empty space he'd made like he had misunderstood the whole fucking afternoon.

I took the camera gently out of his hand.

"Stand there."

"Captain?"

"Nigga, you got legs. Try them."

He moved.

I stepped back far enough to see the two women properly. Sabine's flowers had slipped against Camille's jacket. Camille still had a little white frosting on one wrist from moving the cake into the street. Both of them were smiling too hard to notice either thing.

"Look at her," I told Sabine.

She did.

“Now tell your woman what you told me in there.”

Sabine's smile shook.

“I wanted you,” she said.

Camille pulled her close.

I took the picture.

The photographer looked over my shoulder at the little screen and went quiet.

“Nigga,” I said, “that's the wedding.”

He nodded slowly.

Then he asked whether I had studied photography.

Shawna answered before I could.

“He studied looking pleased with himself. Everything else came with the course.”

Rosa laughed. Tank laughed. I handed the camera back to the photographer and put an arm around my wife.

Camille came over with Sabine beside her. She touched my sleeve.

“You gave us the whole day back.”

“Nigga, keep tomorrow too. I ain't rescuing the same wedding twice.”

They laughed, kissed each other again, and went back to their flowers while the photographer finally pointed the camera where love was actually happening.

Outside, Zero's carriage arrived before the newlyweds finished their first photographs.

He stepped down with Drake behind him.

The colonel's bruised jaw improved his whole face.

Zero looked from Mordecai in handcuffs to Sabine and Camille holding flowers.

"You are becoming expensive to host."

"Nigga, I'm improving your marriages for free."

"Lord Draven had a binding arrangement."

"Now the nigga got a binding bracelet. Two of them."

"You interfere with every household you enter."

"Nigga, I keep finding women trying to leave them. Fix your welcome mat."

Drake moved toward Tank.

Gault stepped out of the crowd behind him.

I hadn't seen him arrive. The big man wore a blue suit and no expression at all.

Drake stopped.

Nigga, sometimes a friend is a whole closed road.

Zero studied the faces around us. Guests. Police. Florists. Kings who'd watched the fight. Women who had just seen a bride stop pretending she wanted what her father had purchased.

He could have ordered guns drawn.

He couldn't have made the photograph disappear.

So he smiled.

"A joyous occasion."

"You welcome to clap," I said.

He did not.

House Leone pledged itself to me before the carriage left.

Sabine's father said the words quietly. His daughter made him say them again while looking at her.

Camille sent us the cake that evening.

The top tier had been repaired with blue flowers. On the side, in frosting slightly crooked from haste, she'd written THANK YOU, CAPTAIN.

Tank stared at it.

"Nigga stopped a wedding and got a wedding cake."

Rosa cut him a large piece.

"That's what happens when you put greatness to practical use."

"And this nigga gets cake for watching greatness."

"You watched the prisoner, baby. You earned frosting."

Tank took the plate and nodded at me.

"Nigga, best captain I ever worked for."

"You ever worked for another?"

"Why the fuck would a nigga downgrade after this?"

Shawna fed me one bite from her fork.

"You looked good at the altar."

"We already did that."

"We could do it again."

I looked at her.

For a second the room went softer around the edges.

"After this?" I asked.

She nodded.

"After the last job. Big enough for everybody."

Tank pointed his fork between us.

"Nigga, don't book the whole city. Me and Rosa still need a place."

I smiled at my brother.

"Then we do it together."

Rosa stopped cutting the cake.

Shawna took her hand.

Four people around a table. Too many cars outside. A dangerous city trying to decide whether to kill me or put my face on its money.

And for a minute all any of us cared about was who would stand beside us when the music started.

14. The Horse Came Into the Club Because I Needed Him

"Nigga, that horse costs more than the car."

Tank stood outside the Red Cathedral looking at a white stallion tied beneath a chandelier.

The chandelier was outdoors.

The horse wore diamonds.

Midnight City had finally introduced me to an animal with a better necklace than the average criminal.

"What's his name?" Shawna asked.

The groom straightened.

"Sovereign."

I looked into the horse's eyes.

"Nigga, they gave you a lot to live up to."

He snorted on my sleeve.

"He likes you," the groom said.

"He got expensive ways of showing it."

A photographer stopped beside the groom and pointed at me, then at the horse.

"Which one should I photograph first?"

Tank turned.

"Nigga, what kind of question is that?"

"The horse belongs to Lord Magnus."

"This nigga belongs to the history books. Take the picture."

I put one hand on Sovereign's neck and the other around Shawna's waist. The horse lifted his head. My wife lifted her chin. Nigga, the photographer nearly dropped his camera trying to get all that confidence inside one rectangle.

"Beautiful," he said.

"Which nigga?" Tank asked.

"All of them."

"Good answer. Nigga might survive the evening."

Shawna started laughing. Sovereign turned his head toward her, and the photographer took another picture so fast the flash made the groom blink.

Rosa stepped beside Tank.

"You want one with the horse too?"

"I want one with you."

"Nigga, that was smooth."

"I learn around greatness."

He glanced at me when he said it, and I touched my chest like the credit had arrived in cash.

Mercedes leaned toward Porsche.

"These niggas gonna spend the whole night complimenting each other."

"Let the niggas have community. The suits are expensive."

The groom brought a little box of treats for Sovereign. I gave the horse one. He accepted it like a king receiving tax from a nigga whose records required closer inspection.

"That's it," I told him. "You and me understand each other. Handsome nigga. Excellent neck. Bad attitude around strangers."

Shawna looked from him to me.

"I see why you like him."

"Nigga, the resemblance is spiritual."

The Red Cathedral wasn't the underground boxing cathedral. This was a nightclub inside another old church, and I began to wonder whether Midnight City had ever actually prayed in any of these buildings before turning them into places to sin comfortably.

Tonight every nigga still claiming he deserved the Crown gathered for the Court of Appetite. Niggas had ironed shirts for this. Niggas had borrowed diamonds for this. One nigga had brought three attendants to carry a coat he kept telling everybody was light as air. I arrived with Shawna, and that nigga forgot the coat in the doorway.

Gambling. Music. Champagne. Women and men beautiful enough to make a bad idea seem well researched. Adult dancers moved between red curtains while kings put money on tables like they were feeding something that would eat their hands if it got impatient.

Mercedes and Porsche walked in ahead of us and immediately became the two most interesting people in the room.

A man in a burgundy coat stood to greet them.

Porsche stopped.

"Nigga, no."

He smiled nervously.

"Porsche. It has been years."

"And still not enough."

His name was Caspar Romano, forty-three, owner of three clubs and apparently several opinions he'd shared too loudly during the years Porsche worked his parties. She didn't tell the whole story. She didn't need to. Mercedes stepped beside her, and the man started adjusting his cuffs as if maybe the trouble was in his sleeves.

"I would be honored to buy you a drink," he said.

"Buy the room a drink," Porsche told him. "Then tip everybody who works in it."

"Surely—"

I came up behind them.

"Nigga, she gave you a beautiful chance to be quiet with your wallet."

He took it.

That was how the whole club got champagne and every dancer got paid before the first song finished.

A nigga near the bar started cheering my name. The nigga beside him took it up. Then the whole damn room was cheering, and Porsche turned so sharply the nearest nigga stepped back before she even spoke.

Porsche turned on them.

"That was my idea!"

They cheered hers too.

Nigga, I enjoyed a crowd that could learn.

Zero hadn't come. Vesper presided alone, wearing black diamonds and an expression that said she had slept badly but refused to give the city the satisfaction of seeing where.

Rusk announced the final qualifying wager.

Every claimant would place ten million on the table. Each could challenge another to a feat of strength, skill, or nerve. Refusing meant forfeiting the stake and the right to the Crown.

"What if nobody wants to challenge me?" I asked.

From the bar, Gault started laughing.

The men around him did not.

A broad blond king with a beard braided in two places stood. Lord Magnus Hart, forty-one, owner of the diamond horse and apparently a chest that required its own tailor.

"I will."

Tank looked him up and down.

"Nigga woke up ambitious."

Magnus offered his hand. I shook it. He squeezed hard. I squeezed back until his smile became more respectful.

"Three contests," he said. "One of mine. One of yours. One chosen by the queen."

"You niggas love making one thing three things."

"Afraid?"

I looked at Shawna.

She lifted her champagne.

"Don't let him wrinkle the suit."

"That's my actual concern," I told Magnus.

His first contest was arm wrestling.

They brought a table out beneath the main chandelier. The club gathered around it. Magnus removed his coat. People admired the size of him. I removed mine and handed it to Shawna.

The admiration changed addresses.

Magnus noticed. Nigga would have needed a different pair of ears not to. His own people were looking past him, and one loyal nigga in his corner actually whispered, "Damn," before remembering whose wages he collected.

"They cheer before you do anything."

"Nigga, that's called a reputation. You can start one tonight."

We locked hands.

Rusk counted.

Magnus came strong enough to make the table legs shift. I let the nigga feel movement. Nigga felt one inch and started believing in two. I watched that belief walk across his face, all proud and stupid and early, and decided my wife deserved to see exactly how disappointed an inch could make a nigga. His face reddened. The little braids in his beard shook.

"Come on," he muttered.

"Nigga, I'm here. Where you want me?"

He pushed harder.

I moved his hand the other way.

Slowly.

Not because I needed to. Because Shawna had told me not to wrinkle the suit, and I had time to respect instructions.

The crowd started counting with the motion.

Three.

Two.

One.

Magnus's hand hit the table.

The table broke.

Nigga, the legs just gave up and went to four separate places.

For a second we sat facing each other with our hands still locked and a whole piece of furniture missing between us.

Then Magnus threw back his head and laughed.

"Again!"

"Nigga, buy a stronger table first."

My contest was shooting glass targets across the club's enclosed garden. No people downrange, no lesson in how to do it, just a line of expensive bottles set up beneath lights and two men who thought a crowd deserved a show.

Magnus hit most of his.

I hit mine, then the little gold bell above them, then the stem of the rose a waiter had foolishly placed too close to the targets.

The blossom fell intact into a champagne bucket.

I picked it up and took it to Shawna.

"For you."

She smelled it.

"You could have bought one."

"Nigga, where the appreciation in that?"

She kissed me while Magnus told the room he had never seen a man show off so thoroughly and still look like he thought he was being modest.

Vesper chose the third contest.

"Ride Sovereign through the old courtyard course. The horse has refused every unfamiliar rider brought to him."

I looked toward the white stallion outside.

"That nigga already spit on me. We acquainted."

Magnus smiled.

"He threw my cousin into a fountain."

"Your cousin probably introduced himself badly."

The crowd followed us into the courtyard. Music spilled through the open doors. Sovereign stood beneath his chandelier looking bored by the social class around him.

I went close and let him see me.

"Aight, my nigga. Here's the situation. Everybody thinks we about to embarrass each other. I don't like that assumption. You don't look like you enjoy being underestimated either."

Shawna covered her smile with her hand.

The horse lowered his head.

I touched his neck.

"There we go. Handsome nigga recognizes handsome nigga."

I mounted.

Sovereign moved once, testing me. I stayed with him. He moved again. I stayed again. Then he lifted his head and took the courtyard at a pace that made the groom run after us shouting advice I couldn't hear over the crowd.

We went around the first fountain.

Over the low stone wall.

Past the row of lanterns.

The horse knew the course. He simply wanted to know whether the nigga on his back deserved to come along.

I did.

By the time we reached the last turn, everybody was cheering.

That was when the black truck smashed through the courtyard gates.

Three armed men stood in its open back.

The cheering broke.

I saw the nearest gun turn toward the crowd.

"Inside!" I shouted.

Shawna was already pulling Vesper through the club doors. Tank grabbed the groom and hauled him behind a fountain. Magnus reached for his pistol. The truck kept coming.

Sovereign reared beneath me.

I turned him toward the open doors.

"Come on, nigga. We changing venues."

The horse went into the nightclub.

People screamed and jumped aside. A dancer standing on the little stage looked up just as a diamond-covered white horse passed her at full speed beneath the red lights.

"AIDEN?"

"Working!"

The truck followed through the broad entrance until its roof struck the stone arch and stopped with a sound that shook dust from the saints above it.

The gunmen spilled out.

I guided Sovereign behind the bar, dismounted onto the polished counter, and slid the last few feet with a pistol in my hand while the bartender dropped out of sight.

Nigga, I had finally found a reasonable use for a bar long enough to land a plane on.

Gault hit the first attacker before he reached the dance floor. Magnus fired from behind a pillar. Tank put a table between the

second gunman and the guests, then introduced the table to the gunman's whole future.

The third ran toward the back stairs.

Porsche stepped out of his way.

Mercedes did not.

She swung a champagne bucket into him, hard enough that the ice went everywhere and the man forgot which floor he had intended to reach.

"That was paid for!" Porsche shouted at him.

The fight lasted less than a minute.

The club looked like it had celebrated for three days without deciding whether anyone was invited.

Sovereign stood behind the bar eating a garnish arrangement.

Magnus stared at him.

Then at me.

Then at the horse again.

"He has never entered a building willingly."

"Nigga wanted nightlife. You been keeping him outside."

Magnus laughed until he had to sit down.

He pushed his ten million across the nearest surviving table and laid Sovereign's jeweled reins on top.

"My stake. My horse. My house. All stand with you."

I looked at Shawna.

"Baby, we got a horse."

"I noticed when he passed the dance floor."

The police arrived to find the attackers restrained, the guests drinking again, and a white stallion being photographed beside the bar with me on one side and my wife on the other.

Ardent took off his hat.

"Captain."

"Chief."

"The horse?"

"Witness."

He looked at Sovereign chewing another orange slice.

"Of course."

Vesper found me after the crowd settled.

One attacker carried Drake's private signal token. No more masked uncertainty. Zero's household had begun striking places where too many kings admired me at once.

"Tomorrow is the final claim," she said. "He will not let you continue collecting them."

I looked around the club. Gault with a hand on Magnus's shoulder. Mercedes and Porsche receiving cheers from the dancers they'd protected. Tank helping Rosa fix the clasp on her

necklace. Shawna giving the horse a piece of apple and laughing when he tried to take her glove too.

"Nigga," I said, "he's late."

15. Rusk Wrote My Name Too Large for the Door

Rusk arrived at breakfast wearing a pistol and looking apologetic about where he'd put it.

"Nigga, that gun comfortable?" Tank asked.

"Not especially."

"Then why you sitting like it offended you?"

"I have never worn one before."

Rosa moved the fruit bowl away from his elbow.

"Start by not negotiating with it over breakfast."

He took the chair beside Marcellus and laid a rolled banner on the table. When he opened it, my name covered almost the whole cloth.

CAPTAIN AIDEN.

FINAL CLAIMANT OF THE WEST.

Underneath, in smaller gold letters, were the names of every house standing with me.

There were fourteen.

"Nigga," I said, "you been busy."

"Three more arrived before dawn. The horse appears to have persuaded them."

Two of Ardent's young officers carried the banner's second half through the door and nearly knocked over a lamp.

"Nigga, how long is my name?" I asked.

"The names beneath it take more room," Rusk said.

Tank held one end while an officer unrolled the rest.

"This nigga got a whole street of supporters."

"That nigga got the harbor too," the other officer said.

"And the opera house."

Shawna lifted one eyebrow.

"My opera house."

"Her opera house," both officers corrected.

Nigga, they learned in harmony.

Rusk tried to read the pledges while Tank held the banner upright. The cloth kept falling over his face. He pushed it aside, found his place, and began again with a seriousness that made Rosa laugh into her breakfast.

"Nigga drowning in my reputation," I said.

"Then hold the other end," Shawna told me.

I stood and caught it. Now the whole room could see the names. Orsini. Magnus. Laurent. Houses that had spent years pretending not to notice each other and were now stitched together beneath one stubborn nigga's face.

The younger officer looked at me.

"My captain said you had done more in a week than our court in twenty years."

"Nigga, don't say that too loud. Somebody gonna ask me to work weekends."

Tank pointed at the banner.

"You already working the nigga weekends."

"Then the nigga needs a raise."

Rosa put a pastry in my hand.

"Start with this. You look expensive when you're hungry."

I took a bite and stood beneath my own enormous name while my wife checked whether there was enough wall in the opera house to display it.

Nigga, that was a family breakfast with scale.

Shawna looked up from her coffee.

"I told you he needed a stable."

"Baby, apparently he needs an embassy."

Rusk didn't laugh.

Nigga, that made me put the coffee down. I could joke with a nervous nigga. I could make a proud nigga laugh. This nigga looked like somebody had reached into his house while he was still trying to decide which jacket to wear.

"What happened?"

He turned the banner over. On the back was a second instruction, written in black.

The final claim would proceed under armed imperial supervision. No private household guards. No police inside the arena. No substitution of a claimant's prize. The winner would attend the yacht coronation alone.

"Nigga added alone," Tank said.

"He knows we found the book," I told them.

Rusk's mouth tightened.

"He ordered me to record your voluntary acceptance."

"Did you?"

"No."

One little word again, and this nigga had finally said it. Nigga, I watched his shoulders settle after it left his mouth. The man looked like he had been carrying somebody else's ugly furniture on his back and just put the whole damn room down.

This city kept making people work hard to say it.

Rusk reached into his jacket and took out his silver ceremonial chain. He set it beside the banner.

"I have served this tournament for twenty-two years. I have announced men I feared, praised men I despised, and made death sound dignified because someone handed me the correct

wording. Last night my wife asked why I came home with blood on my cuffs. I told her a man had saved me. She asked why I still worked for the man who sent the killers."

Nobody interrupted.

"I found I had no answer that would let me sleep beside her."

I looked at the chain.

Then at him.

"Nigga, keep that. You earned it doing the wrong job long enough. Now do the right one with the same nice jewelry."

He laughed once, surprised.

"What would you have me announce?"

Shawna slid a sheet of paper toward him.

"A public final. Crown on the stage. Prizes awarded there. All houses present."

"The emperor will refuse."

"Then announce that too," she said.

We went to House Orsini before noon.

The old king met us in a courtyard full of lemon trees. His wife, Leonora, sat beside a fountain feeding pieces of pastry to a dog small enough to look like it had been assembled from leftover pride.

"The emperor wants your winner alone," I said.

Lord Orsini sighed.

"He has always preferred private celebrations."

"Nigga, you knew?"

The old man looked at me.

For once, he didn't have a joke ready.

Leonora stopped feeding the dog.

"We knew men failed to return," she said. "We allowed ourselves to believe there were reasons."

"There were," I told her. "The nigga killed them."

Orsini's face hardened.

"You speak easily of opposing him. You arrived with ships, friends, a fortune. Some of us have been growing old beneath his windows."

"I didn't arrive with you," I said. "I earned you. Don't make that sound smaller because you're scared now."

He looked away.

I let him.

A man sometimes needs a minute to decide whether he hates the truth or the person brave enough to say it in his courtyard.

Bastien set Eliane's letter on the table.

Leonora recognized the handwriting.

Her hand went to her mouth.

"She made my wedding gown."

Bastien nodded.

"She also made sure someone remembered what happened at the harbor."

Marcellus showed them the ledger.

No speech. No lecture. Just the pages and the names, the old promises written beside sums large enough to have purchased several very beautiful lies.

Orsini sat down slowly.

He found his brother's name.

A payment dated two days before the brother's ship disappeared.

Leonora put a hand on his shoulder.

The old king read the line again.

Then he stood.

"Rusk."

"My lord."

"Write the announcement."

Nigga, sometimes courage looks like an old man deciding his knees can complain later.

We left the courtyard with six signed house seals and the promise of more before evening. Not because paper made people loyal. Because every man who signed had to look at the

next man while doing it, and some kinds of shame finally become useful when the room is full enough.

Drake waited outside in a black car.

"The emperor requests the original ledger."

"The emperor can request better manners while he's at it," I said.

"You are building a funeral procession."

"Nigga, you keep threatening crowds that already saw me save them. Find a new hobby."

He looked past me at Rusk.

"Your house has been searched."

Rusk went pale.

I moved before Drake could enjoy it.

One step. One hand on the car door. One hard pull.

The door opened with Drake still holding it.

I dragged him out into the street and put him against the roof.

His guards reached for their guns.

Ardent's officers, waiting behind us, raised theirs first. Nigga, those were my niggas this morning. Every one of them had watched Drake threaten their chief, and a nigga does eventually get tired of seeing somebody disrespect the man who signs his holiday leave.

"Nobody," I said, "gets dramatic except me."

Drake's face pressed against black paint.

"You have made a serious mistake."

"Nigga, I know. I should've bought this car in white. Shows bruises better."

I turned his face enough that he could see Rusk.

"Where is his wife?"

"At home."

"Hurt?"

"No."

"Then you gonna call your people and make sure that answer stays pretty."

Drake looked at the police, the crowd, the old king standing in his own gate with a rifle he had clearly owned longer than Drake had been threatening people.

He called.

I listened long enough to hear the men at Rusk's house ordered away.

Then I let him stand.

"Tell Zero I accept the final," I said. "In public. Crown on the stage. My people where I can see them."

"And if he refuses?"

I looked around the street.

At the faces in the windows.

At fourteen houses represented by men who had finally come outside together.

"Nigga, then we'll know which one of us is afraid of an audience."

The announcement went up at sunset.

Rusk had written my name so large the banner wouldn't fit through the opera house door. Tank had to carry it out sideways while Rosa laughed from the steps.

Across the city, people stopped beneath balconies to hear it read.

Final claim. Public arena. Crown awarded before the houses and the city. No private coronation required.

Zero accepted an hour later.

He had crossed out the word captain before my name.

Rusk put it back.

Then he added a second line beneath it.

THE MAN WHO CAME WHEN WE CALLED.

I looked at it for a long time.

Shawna came beside me.

"You like that one?"

"Nigga made it difficult to complain."

"You can manage."

"The letters could be bigger."

She laughed and slipped her hand into mine.

In the courtyard below, Rusk's wife arrived with a little suitcase and kissed him hard enough to make the ceremonial chain swing against his chest.

Tank looked away respectfully.

Rosa looked directly at them and cheered.

Nigga, both approaches had their virtues.

16. The Emperor Finally Invited Me to Sit Down

Zero sent a chessboard to the hotel.

Gold pieces. Black marble. A little card that said he hoped I understood the game.

Tank opened the box first.

"Nigga, he sent you tiny people."

Rosa picked up the queen.

"This one cute."

"Put it back," Marcellus said.

"I'm admiring."

"Your handbag is open."

"Why do all the older men in my life notice that first?"

Shawna read the card, then looked at me.

"You play?"

"I know how the horse moves."

"You got personal experience now."

I took the card and wrote underneath his message.

I UNDERSTAND WINNING. IS DINNER INCLUDED?

Before we sent the board back, Tank set up the pieces and insisted on one game.

"Nigga, I need to know what we're walking into."

"A dinner."

"A dinner with tiny armed niggas on squares. Sit down."

Rosa took a chair beside him. Shawna stood behind me, both hands resting on my shoulders. Mercedes and Porsche leaned over the table like somebody had announced a bet worth inspecting.

Tank moved a pawn.

I moved mine.

"That nigga can go two?" he asked.

"First move."

"Everybody else get two?"

"Different niggas got different jobs."

"Then why this little nigga got no horse?"

"Tank."

"I'm asking about his transportation."

Rosa put her face in her hand.

We played. Tank threatened my knight personally, accused a bishop of sneaking, and tried to persuade his king that a brave

nigga would take a longer step. I won while he was still explaining the step.

He stared at the board.

"Nigga."

"Yes?"

"You surrounded my whole little nigga."

"That's checkmate."

"That's an ambush with furniture."

Shawna laughed and kissed the top of my head. Nigga, I had never enjoyed board games with such immediate payment.

Porsche reached over and tipped Tank's king gently onto its side.

"Poor nigga. Never had a chance."

Tank picked it up again.

"Don't disrespect him. The nigga did his best with the information available."

I shook his hand across the board.

"You gave that nigga a beautiful funeral."

"I'm giving you a rematch when I understand what the church nigga does."

We were invited to the emperor's summer palace at nine.

It was not summer.

Nigga, rich people refuse to let a calendar tell them what their house is called.

The palace sat at the end of a narrow peninsula, all white walls and dark gardens, with the armored yacht waiting below. I looked at it as we crossed the courtyard. Black hull. Gold railings. A name painted at the stern in enormous letters.

ABSOLUTION.

"That nigga named his boat after something he ain't getting," Tank said.

"Don't scratch it," I told him. "I might rename it."

We had brought a small group because this was supposed to be a private dinner and I respected private enough to keep it under twelve people.

Shawna and me.

Tank and Rosa.

Mercedes and Porsche.

Marcellus, Bastien, Gault, Rusk, and Ardent.

Vesper was already there.

Zero watched us enter one after another.

His face remained calm until Gault came through the door.

Then it became calm with work behind it.

"I invited the captain and his wife."

"Nigga, I came with witnesses. You got a reputation."

Ardent removed his hat politely.

"A splendid house, Majesty."

Rosa looked at the ceiling.

"Chandeliers are better at the club. The horse liked those."

Zero directed a servant to add places.

I watched him do it. Watched the tiny movement of his fingers, the silence that followed, the way people hurried because he had never needed to be loud to make them afraid.

Then Shawna took my arm and leaned close.

"Stop looking at him. Look at me."

I did.

Nigga, the evening improved immediately.

She wore silver, soft against her skin, with a blue stone at her throat and her wedding ring catching every candle we passed. She had left the opera house full of people rehearsing tomorrow's victory song. Not hoping. Rehearsing.

That was faith with a piano behind it.

Dinner came in small expensive portions that offended Tank more each time a plate arrived. By the fourth course he asked a waiter whether all the little meals eventually joined together somewhere.

The waiter looked frightened.

Zero laughed.

"Have the kitchen bring him something substantial."

"Nigga, I appreciate a negotiator," Tank said.

For ten minutes, the room almost worked. Niggas ate. Niggas drank. Tank finally got a plate with enough food on it and blessed the waiter like the nigga had personally recovered a lost religion from the kitchen.

Rosa told a story about a singer who had tried to pay her in autographed photographs and then asked for two of them back. Mercedes described the time Porsche had driven a client's stolen sports car to the wrong hotel and accidentally returned it to the man's wife. Porsche corrected the story three times, mainly to emphasize that the wife had tipped.

Even Bastien laughed.

Zero listened like he was studying a language he understood but couldn't speak naturally.

Then he looked at Shawna.

"Do you ever tire of being carried into another man's war?"

My fork stopped.

Shawna's didn't.

She finished her bite before answering.

"Do you ever tire of asking women questions that already contain the answer you want?"

Rosa lowered her glass.

Tank looked down at his plate with the reverence of a man witnessing a beautiful first punch.

Zero smiled thinly.

"I meant no insult."

"Then choose a different shape for it next time."

Vesper stared at her wine.

I looked at my wife and felt the familiar impossible wish to marry a woman I was already married to.

Nigga, she kept making it seem like the first ceremony had been a down payment.

"Aiden has enemies," Zero said.

"He also has me. You keep overlooking the second part."

"And what does he have if the Crown costs more than he can pay?"

Shawna set down her fork.

"You tell me. You're the one raising the price every time he wins."

Nigga, the room went quiet. I heard the sea outside. I heard Tank set his fork down. I heard one of Zero's own guards swallow,

because that nigga had just watched my wife take the emperor apart without standing up.

Zero turned to me.

"Chess?"

"Nigga, you sure? She just beat you at dinner."

We moved to the garden room. The gold board stood beneath a painted ceiling. Beyond the glass doors, the yacht's lights moved on dark water.

Zero took black.

I took white because Shawna said it suited me and because I liked making the first move in somebody else's house.

For a while, we played.

I knew the pieces. I knew the man across from me. Nigga, that was enough to make every square look like somewhere he'd already made a mistake in real life. Zero played well. I played like a nigga who had brought his wife to watch him win and refused to waste her outfit.

He glanced at the badge on my chest.

"A captain, a king, a graduate, a champion. How many names does one man require?"

"Nigga, the names keep arriving. I got good mail."

"You collect applause because silence frightens you."

I moved a knight.

"You collect mirrors because people don't look at you long enough. We can do this all night."

He studied the board.

Then he smiled.

"An error."

"Maybe."

He took the knight.

I let him enjoy it.

Behind him, Vesper stood by the window. Her gaze flicked once toward the terrace doors, then back to mine.

Drake was outside.

Not alone.

I moved my queen.

"Checkmate."

Zero looked down.

His smile disappeared.

Nigga, I had let the knight go so his king would have one place left to stand and no chance of surviving there. The emperor stared at the board. Then he looked at me like the tiny dead nigga on his square had just delivered a personal message.

Behind me, Tank whispered, "That nigga lost his church man too."

Rosa slapped his arm so he would stop laughing. It did not help.

"You have a useful instinct," he said.

"Nigga, people keep calling it instinct after I do it on purpose."

The terrace doors opened.

Drake entered with two guards carrying a long velvet case.

Inside was the Crown.

The real one.

Marcellus stepped closer before anybody invited him.

"May I?"

Zero held out a hand.

"Observe. Do not touch."

The Crown was even more beautiful off the high auction platform. Every stone had depth. The black diamonds didn't swallow light; they held it until you moved, then gave it back where you weren't expecting. The blue center stone seemed almost dark until Shawna came beside me and its color woke against her dress.

I wanted it then.

Not because it made men kneel.

Because I could already see my wife laughing while I tried it on in the mirror, telling me to hold still so she could straighten it.

Nigga, greatness has private uses too.

Marcellus bent close.

His expression changed.

I caught it.

Zero caught me catching it.

"A masterpiece," Marcellus said evenly.

"You recognize the work?"

"I recognize what age does to it."

He stepped back.

The case closed.

Drake carried it out.

Zero rose from the chess table.

"Tomorrow, one of you will hold that Crown. I hope the city survives the honor."

"Nigga, worry about your boat."

Outside, Marcellus didn't speak until we reached the cars.

Then he took my arm.

"That was not the Crown from the auction."

I looked back at the palace.

"A fake?"

"An excellent imitation. Same size, same pattern. The center stone was wrong, and the old repairs were missing."

Tank let out a long breath.

"Nigga trying to give you costume jewelry after all this?"

"He plans to award the copy in public," Marcellus said. "Keep the real Crown for the private houses that know its marks. Divide what people see from what they recognize."

Vesper approached from the steps.

She had heard enough to stop pretending.

"The real Crown is aboard Absolution," she said. "Drake moved it this afternoon."

"You know because you helped?" Shawna asked.

Vesper met her eyes.

"Yes."

The answer hurt, but it didn't hide.

"Then help us move it again," Shawna said.

Vesper looked toward the palace windows.

Zero stood behind the glass, watching us gather around a secret he could almost see.

"If I do this," she said, "there is no return."

I opened the car door for my wife.

"Nigga, we been driving forward the whole time. Get in."

17. I Stole the Yacht Before the Coronation

"Nigga, you can't steal the whole yacht."

Tank said it like he was repeating something we'd already agreed on.

We had not.

"Why not?"

"Because we came for the Crown."

"The Crown's on the yacht."

"Nigga."

"I'm being thorough."

Rosa looked from him to me and shook her head.

"You two argue like brothers who share a criminal brain and keep misplacing the useful half."

We stood in the opera house's backstage corridor while Vesper drew the outline of Absolution on the back of a concert poster. It wasn't a map of alarms or locks. Just decks, rooms, and where the people she cared about would be standing. The yacht had a party aboard that evening, a private celebration for the men who believed tomorrow's tournament was already decided.

Zero would remain at the palace.

Drake would be aboard.

So would the real Crown.

"I can get you invited," Vesper said.

"Nigga, I been invited to five places that tried to kill me. We can stop calling that a benefit."

She looked at me steadily.

"I can get the staff clear of the room. I can identify the Crown's case. I can stand beside you when Drake discovers what we have done. Beyond that, I will not pretend certainty."

Shawna nodded.

"That's enough."

Vesper turned to her.

"You trust me?"

"I'm giving you something to do with it."

The queen looked down at the poster for a moment.

Then she folded it and put it in her bag.

Nigga, sometimes a woman accepting a chance looks more dangerous than a man accepting a gun.

The clothes arrived while we were still arguing about the yacht.

Three tailors. Six garment bags. One man whose only responsibility appeared to be carrying my shoes without allowing gravity to become disrespectful.

Tank looked at the bags.

"Nigga, we robbing a boat or accepting an award?"

"Why should a nigga choose?"

Rosa pulled out his jacket and held it against his chest.

"You look like somebody should bring you a drink and confess something."

He smiled at her.

"You think so?"

"Nigga, I picked it. Obviously."

Shawna came out in black and gold, and every man in the corridor stopped doing the thing he thought mattered.

The shoe nigga nearly let one heel touch the floor.

I took the shoes out of his hands before tragedy arrived.

"Thank you, my nigga. We'll carry the marriage from here."

He backed away, smiling like he'd just helped load a royal weapon.

Vesper watched from beside the dressing-room door.

"Does this happen everywhere you go?"

Mercedes answered before I could.

"Everywhere that nigga takes her. And everywhere she takes that nigga. We stopped separating the events."

Porsche adjusted her white jacket.

"The niggas at the yacht don't even know how underdressed they're about to feel."

I bent to help Shawna with one shoe. She put a hand on my shoulder for balance. The corridor went quiet again.

"Nigga," Tank said softly, "the emperor better have a strong boat."

Rosa squeezed his hand.

"He better have a second one."

We went aboard after midnight.

Not quietly.

The harbor knew my cars by then. The crowd at the pier started cheering before the first engine stopped. Somebody had brought a painted banner showing me on Sovereign inside the nightclub. The horse was bigger than me in the picture, which Tank pointed out twice before I threatened to make him walk.

Shawna stepped out in a black dress with gold at the shoulders. Rosa wore red. Mercedes and Porsche wore white suits, sharp enough to make three men on the gangway stand straighter before they remembered they didn't work for them.

Gault followed carrying a bottle of champagne like it weighed nothing and could become anything.

Marcellus wore gloves.

Bastien wore blue.

I noticed that before we reached the gangway.

He noticed me noticing.

"Eliane's preference," he said.

I nodded.

"Good woman had taste."

The yacht's captain met us at the top. Alaric Thorne, forty-seven, a lean man with sun-browned skin and a white uniform that looked like he actually worked in it.

"Captain Aiden."

"Captain."

He smiled a little at the exchange.

"I was told you would be accompanied by the queen."

Vesper stepped beside me.

"He is."

Alaric looked at her face. Whatever he saw made him step back without asking another question.

The party filled three decks. Niggas above us. Niggas below us. Niggas on the stairs pretending they had somewhere more exclusive to go. Every nigga wore a watch, and not one of them seemed to know his time was about to get exciting.

Music above. Gambling below. Champagne everywhere. Adult dancers in silver moved around a pool lit from beneath, while men who couldn't dance paid to stand near women who could. The air smelled of perfume, salt, cigar smoke, and money trying to convince itself it wasn't frightened.

A woman in a gold dress recognized Mercedes and ran over to hug her.

"You're here!"

"Apparently," Mercedes said. "Dahlia, this is Aiden."

Different Dahlia from the sculptor. This one was thirty-five, a hostess who had worked half the private parties on the coast and had opinions about every yacht's bathrooms.

She looked me up and down.

"Oh. They weren't exaggerating."

Shawna smiled beside me.

"Sometimes they run out of words."

Dahlia laughed and hugged her too.

Nigga, I liked friends who knew how to admire without making a whole mess of it.

Drake found us before the first drink reached my hand.

"You were not expected."

"That's what makes me a gift."

His gaze moved to Vesper.

"The emperor approved this?"

"I govern the tournament's hospitality," she said.

"Not indefinitely."

She stepped closer.

"Then let us enjoy the time you believe I have left."

For a second I thought he might strike her.

Gault shifted behind me.

Drake saw the movement and decided his hands had enough responsibilities already.

"The upper salon is private."

"Nigga, all your favorite rooms are," I said.

The nigga left two guards near the stairs and walked away. One guard watched my hands. The other watched Shawna. I looked at that second nigga until he discovered a much safer interest in the carpet.

Vesper exhaled slowly.

Shawna touched her elbow once.

No speech.

No promise everything would be easy now.

Just contact before we started moving.

Rosa took the little stage by the pool because the band recognized her from the opera house and begged for one song. She gave them two. Tank stood near the front, and when the crowd cheered he looked around with so much pride you would've thought he had personally invented music and was pleased the experiment was going well.

Mercedes and Porsche gathered Dahlia and the other hostesses, told them enough to make clear which parts of the boat would soon be unpleasant, and helped them move guests toward the open deck. Nobody panicked. Professionals can recognize another professional's serious face beneath a smile.

Shawna came with Vesper and me up the stairs.

The guards moved to stop us.

Vesper didn't slow.

"The captain is inspecting tomorrow's prize."

"Colonel Drake said—"

"Colonel Drake is not the queen."

One guard hesitated.

The other reached for her arm.

I caught his hand before it arrived.

"Nigga, don't make your last polite act a bad guess."

He let go of the idea.

We entered the upper salon.

The room was all dark wood, gold lamps, and furniture built to persuade men they would live long enough to finish their cigars. A velvet case stood on a table beneath a portrait of Zero.

I looked at the portrait.

"Nigga got his own face watching his own valuables. That is insecurity with a frame."

Marcellus came in behind us and opened the case.

The Crown lay inside.

He bent close, turned it gently, and found the old repair beneath the left rear point.

"This is it."

Shawna touched my wrist.

"Beautiful."

"You mean the Crown?"

"Don't start."

"Baby, you standing next to me. Clarify your admiration."

She laughed.

The sound was still in the room when Drake stepped through the door.

Six men behind him.

Guns up.

"Put it down."

Marcellus closed the case.

Vesper moved in front of the table.

"The Crown will be presented publicly tomorrow. The genuine Crown."

Drake looked at her like she'd finally confirmed something he'd been hoping to punish.

"You have chosen badly."

"I have chosen late. That is different."

His pistol turned toward her.

I moved.

The nearest lamp struck his arm as I threw it. His shot went through Zero's painted forehead. Nigga, I would've admired the symbolism if I'd had time to stand still and enjoy what a lamp had accomplished.

Shawna dropped behind the sofa with Vesper. Bastien fired from the door. Marcellus took the Crown case and moved low toward the side exit. I hit the first guard coming around the table and drove him into a cabinet full of glasses that had been waiting years to become a dramatic noise.

The yacht lurched beneath us.

Not from the gunfire.

From the engines.

Tank had reached the captain.

Apparently they had found something to agree on.

Drake recovered and came over the table after me. The Crown case was already gone. That made him angrier than the lamp.

We crashed into the sofa, rolled, and struck the floor hard enough to knock a whole argument out of my lungs.

He reached for a knife.

I hit his wrist against the table leg.

He hit my jaw.

For three seconds there was no crown, no room, no audience.

Just a nigga who wanted me dead and me explaining the mistake with my whole body.

Shawna pulled Vesper through the side door.

Bastien covered them.

I drove Drake backward into Zero's portrait and left him wearing the frame around one shoulder.

"Nigga, you collect these?"

Then I ran.

We came out onto the upper deck as the yacht pulled away from the palace pier. Below, guests hurried toward the open rear lounge where Mercedes and Porsche had gathered them. Rosa

had stopped singing and was directing people with a microphone. Gault stood at the foot of the stairs preventing armed men from following anybody who didn't want to be followed.

Alaric's voice came over the speakers, calm and firm.

Remain on the lower deck. Keep away from the forward stairs.

The captain had the vessel under command.

"Which captain?" I shouted toward the bridge.

Tank leaned out of the doorway.

"Nigga, both of y'all apparently!"

The palace lights turned behind us.

Searchlights.

Then sirens.

Two black speedboats shot from the dock.

Drake came out onto the deck above with blood on his mouth and murder back in his hands. He fired toward us. I shoved Shawna behind a steel housing and answered. Vesper knelt beside her, holding a pistol now, her black diamonds flashing when she moved.

Vesper fired back. Nigga, she fired back like she had finally remembered whose hands those were. I saw a man on the other deck recognize her, saw the nigga lower his gun half an inch in

surprise, and thought, yes, my nigga, the queen has changed her evening plans.

Nigga, the queen had finally stopped borrowing courage from silence.

The speedboats closed on either side.

Alaric turned the yacht toward open water. Nigga could sail. I would give him that. Some niggas inherit an expensive steering wheel and make everybody aboard regret the family tree. This nigga put the boat where I needed it before I finished needing it. The deck tilted beneath my feet. One boat swept close enough that I could see the gunman standing at its bow.

Gault lifted the heavy champagne bottle he'd carried aboard and threw it.

It struck the gunman square in the chest and knocked him backward into the boat.

"Waste of good champagne!" Rosa shouted.

"Caspar paid for it!" Mercedes yelled back.

"Then throw another!"

I reached the stern rail with Tank beside me. We fired toward the pursuing boats until they fell back. One turned too sharply and struck the yacht's wake sideways. Men tumbled against their own seats. The other kept coming.

My arms ached.

Blue thunder waited under the fatigue like a bright stupid promise.

I didn't need speed now.

I needed balance.

I took one short pulse, just enough to steady the exhausted muscles while the deck moved under me, and put my next shot where it would stop the nearest weapon from continuing its argument. The gunman dropped out of sight. The boat veered away.

Then the thunder left me weak enough that Tank caught my elbow.

"Nigga."

"I know."

"You using too much?"

"No. Just enough to remember the bill."

He held me steady until my legs agreed with the boat again.

Behind us, Drake reached the yacht's rear steps.

A third launch came alongside for him.

He looked at me across the deck.

I looked back.

Neither of us pretended this was finished.

He jumped into the launch and disappeared toward the palace.

Alaric brought Absolution into the public harbor thirty minutes later.

Ardent's police lined the pier. So did half the city. Word had traveled ahead of us: Aiden had stolen the emperor's yacht, the queen had left with him, the real Crown was aboard, and somehow Rosa had performed two songs during the theft.

Nigga, the city had finally learned to report all the important details.

We stepped down together.

Vesper stopped at the end of the gangway.

Behind her lay the palace lights, the years she'd spent inside them, and a man who would kill her if he could make the world small enough again.

Ahead stood her household.

The old cook reached her first.

Then the drivers. The singers. The assistants. People she'd feared losing so long that she'd forgotten they might walk toward danger to keep her.

They gathered around her without bowing.

She held them without pretending she wasn't crying.

Shawna leaned against me, exhausted.

"You stole the whole yacht."

I looked back at Absolution.

"Nigga, Tank said I couldn't."

"That's your reason?"

"Baby, I had several. That one wore the best shoes."

Marcellus carried the Crown case past us toward the opera house.

Rusk followed with a new announcement already forming behind his eyes.

Tomorrow, the city would see the real thing.

Tonight, my wife took my hand and led me home through a crowd that kept trying to touch my jacket because apparently a nigga's greatness had become a local resource.

18. They Crowned Me While I Was Looking for My Horse

I was late to the final because Sovereign ate part of the invitation.

Nigga, the important part.

The time.

Shawna found me in the stable holding a wet piece of gold paper while the horse looked completely satisfied with his contribution to history.

"Nine," she said.

"It said noon."

"That was the luncheon."

"Nigga ate the difference."

From the city below, bells started ringing.

Tank came through the stable door carrying my white coat.

"They announcing you."

"Already?"

"Nigga, they been announcing you. Rusk starting to run out of adjectives."

I kissed Shawna, took the coat, and climbed onto Sovereign because the horse had caused the problem and I believed in making a nigga participate in the solution.

We rode straight through the city.

Shawna followed in the green Ferrari with Rosa. Tank drove the police Lamborghini. Mercedes and Porsche had already taken Marcellus and the Crown to the arena under Ardent's escort, and Vesper waited with Bastien beneath the royal platform.

Every street was full.

Not traffic. People.

People wearing blue ribbons. People holding photographs from the harbor, the ball, the fight, the wedding. Somebody had painted a police badge on a bedsheet and hung it between two balconies like the city itself had decided to join my crew.

"AIDEN!"

Nigga, I heard my name from every direction at once.

Sovereign liked it too. He lifted his head and pranced the last hundred yards like he had personally paid for the parade.

When we entered the arena, Rusk stood on the platform holding a smaller gold circlet.

"The houses have elected their champion!" he shouted.

I looked up.

"Nigga, I wasn't here!"

The crowd laughed and cheered harder.

"The vote was unanimous among the pledged houses. Captain Aiden is named First King of the Tournament."

I dismounted and walked up the steps.

"I thought we was about to do the tournament."

"We are."

"Then what did I just win?"

"Their confidence."

He put the circlet on my head.

Shawna reached the platform a moment later and looked at it.

"You won while you were losing an argument with a horse."

"Nigga, that's range."

She straightened the little crown and kissed me in front of the whole city.

The noise almost took the roof off an arena that didn't have one.

A boyish-looking marshal hurried up with the driving gloves I'd left in the stable. He was twenty-four, exactly old enough to look offended that a nigga the same age had already collected a college ceremony, a police command, and two separate crowns before breakfast.

"Captain. Your gloves."

"You ran all the way?"

"Yes."

"Nigga, you deserve a medal."

Rusk immediately took one from an attendant's tray.

The marshal stared.

"I was only bringing the gloves."

"Nigga, I was only looking for a horse," I told him. "The morning generous. Accept it."

Shawna pinned the medal to his jacket. The crowd cheered him, and the young nigga stood so straight I thought his knees might lock permanently.

Tank leaned beside me.

"That nigga gonna tell this story at every dinner for the rest of his life."

"Nigga earned seasoning for his memories. Let him cook."

The marshal saluted, tried to leave, remembered he hadn't handed over the gloves, returned, saluted again, and finally escaped down the stairs while Rosa laughed so hard she had to hold the rail.

"You made a whole nigga's biography," she told me.

"He brought the gloves. I recognize service."

Shawna pulled one glove onto my hand herself.

"Now go win the expensive one."

I looked at the little preliminary circlet on my head.

"Nigga, this one's already got fans."

"Then give it a famous older brother."

I kissed her ring.

"Beautiful instruction."

Zero sat across from us beneath a black canopy.

His face looked like somebody had delivered the morning to the wrong address.

Beside him stood Drake.

No disguise. No hidden gunmen. The colonel wore racing leathers and a dark claim token around his neck.

Rusk saw me looking.

"The emperor has entered his household champion."

"Nigga, he finally sent the receipt with the purchase."

The final had three movements.

A race through the city to the arena's northern gate.

A contest on the stone ring at its center.

And a final declaration before the houses, where the Crown's old marks would be examined and the winner acknowledged.

Zero had spent the night trying to remove the examination.

Fourteen houses had spent the same night remembering they owned guns and votes in equal quantities.

The examination stayed.

Magnus met me by the cars.

"May the best man win."

"Nigga, why you making a wish about me?"

He laughed and clapped my shoulder.

Gault stood beside a dark blue racer that looked slightly too small for him.

"You driving that?" I asked.

"I fit if I stop breathing at corners."

"Useful skill."

"Learned it fighting you."

The other finalists watched us. One nigga looked offended that Gault and I were laughing. Another nigga tried laughing too, discovered nobody had invited him into the joke, and went back to polishing his driving gloves. Nigga, making friends remained legal even inside this ridiculous city.

Drake walked past without speaking.

I called after him.

"Nigga, you want a portrait to wear? I can have one delivered."

He didn't turn.

Tank laughed loud enough for both of us.

I chose the police Lamborghini.

Dark blue. Gold badge on the door. My original madness brought all the way from Vegas, through the sky, across the sea, and into a city that was about to learn why a nigga doesn't replace a car just because somebody gives him seven others.

Shawna stood beside the window.

"No thunder until you need it."

"I know."

"And if you need it, come back tired instead of trying to come back legendary."

I took her hand.

"Baby, those ain't separate arrivals for me."

She smiled, then held my face for one second longer than usual.

"Come back."

"Always my intention."

The flag fell.

We left the arena with every engine shouting and every nigga in the stands trying to shout over it. I could hear Tank through the whole damn wall of sound. That nigga could cheer a car into better performance. I took his contribution seriously.

Drake took the lead immediately. Magnus followed. Gault's car surged beside mine, his shoulders filling the window like the vehicle had hired a bodyguard for itself.

The route climbed through the old market, curved past the opera house, and returned along the harbor road. Balconies shook with people. Flags snapped above us. Every corner had a marshal and a policeman, and every policeman who saw my badge looked like he was watching his own dream get better funding.

At the first turn, Drake forced Magnus toward the wall.

Magnus held the car, tires screaming.

I came through the gap he left and drew beside Drake.

The colonel looked across.

I smiled.

Nigga, there is a particular pleasure in making a man hate your good mood while he's working hard to kill it.

The road narrowed beneath an arch. Drake accelerated. So did I. We went through side by side, close enough that our mirrors touched and folded inward like they were politely excusing themselves.

Beyond the arch, a black delivery van blocked half the street.

Not another surprise truck.

This time I saw the driver watching Drake for a signal.

"Nigga, you repeating your homework," I muttered.

I took the side steps.

The Lamborghini climbed the broad stone staircase beside the opera house, bounced onto the upper terrace, and crossed in front of the open rehearsal windows. A pianist looked up from his music as I passed.

I waved.

Nigga kept playing.

My wife hired professionals.

We dropped back onto the road ahead of the van. Behind me, Magnus slammed the vehicle's empty rear corner aside and Gault followed through the opening.

Drake had lost his private advantage.

He tried to make a public one.

At the harbor bend, he struck my rear quarter hard enough to send the Lamborghini sliding toward the seawall. The world turned sideways. I saw water where the road should have been. I saw a thousand people rise from their seats above the harbor.

I turned into the slide.

Caught it.

Barely.

My hands shook once against the wheel. Nigga, once. I let them have that one little confession, then I tightened my grip and told

the car, "Aight, my nigga. We both heard them cheering. Let's give these niggas a reason to lose their voices."

Then stopped.

"Aight, nigga," I said to the engine. "We ain't come this far to swim."

I called the blue thunder for one short burst.

The hood lit beneath my hands. The engine answered like it had recognized its own name. We leaped forward, not forever, not without cost, just enough to take back the room Drake thought he'd stolen.

Three seconds.

Then I let it go.

My arms went heavy. My chest burned. The car stayed fast because a Lamborghini doesn't need magic to be offended.

We reached the final straight together.

Drake on my left.

Magnus close behind.

Gault gaining on the right.

The arena's northern gate stood open ahead.

Then its iron bars began descending.

Too soon.

The crowd saw it.

The marshals shouted.

Zero didn't move beneath his canopy.

Drake braked, expecting me to hit the bars.

I didn't brake.

Nigga, I had seen the gap.

Low enough for my roof.

High enough for one terrible decision.

The Lamborghini shot beneath the gate with sparks tearing along the top. Metal screamed. The gold light above the windshield snapped away. I heard the roof take damage I would complain about later if later remained available.

We cleared it.

Drake struck the brakes harder and spun into the gate's side pillar.

Magnus and Gault stopped short.

For a second I was the only nigga inside the arena. One car. One crown waiting. One beautiful woman standing in the royal box with her hand on her heart because this nigga she married kept making the whole world too damn exciting to sit through.

Then the whole city stood.

Rusk shouted my name through the horns, through the applause, through the sound of men shouting that they'd seen it

themselves, that the nigga had gone under the gate, that the beautiful crazy nigga was getting out of the car right now.

I drove to the center and got out slowly.

My arms were tired.

My knees wanted a chair.

My wife was coming down the steps with her hand over her mouth.

Nigga, I stood straight.

She reached me and hit my chest once with the side of her fist.

"You said you would come back."

"I'm here."

"I saw the gate."

"So did I. That's why I went under it."

She kissed me hard enough to make every bruise feel like it had been waiting for a better explanation.

Behind us, the marshals raised the gate. Drake's car sat ruined beside the pillar. He climbed out furious, but alive, which meant the day still had an ugly part waiting.

Gault and Magnus entered on foot.

Both came straight toward me.

Gault took my hand.

"Best driver I've ever seen."

Magnus looked at the roof of my car.

"Most unreasonable man I've ever admired."

"Nigga, y'all making me sound expensive."

Shawna looked at the damage and laughed through the last of her fear.

"You are."

Rusk announced the second movement.

The stone ring.

Three finalists remained eligible after the race.

Me.

Magnus.

Drake, because Zero's rules had always found a little extra mercy for the men he paid.

Tank helped me out of my driving jacket.

"You got enough left?"

I looked at my brother.

At my wife.

At a city still on its feet.

"Nigga," I said, "I ain't even started collecting the jewelry."

19. Seven Points and One Beautiful Head

Magnus took his shirt off and the crowd cheered.

I took mine off and the crowd changed religions.

"Nigga," Tank said from the corner, "put some of that away. My woman trying to watch respectfully."

Rosa slapped his arm.

"Your woman is engaged, not blind."

Shawna sat at the edge of the royal platform with my jacket across her lap and a smile so proud it made every bruise in my body feel like it had applied for a better job.

Two old fighters stood near the judges, comparing the size of me and Magnus with the confidence of niggas who weren't about to get hit by either one.

"The northern king is heavier," one said.

"That nigga came out a Lamborghini under a falling gate," the other told him.

"Weight matters."

"Nigga, so does being that nigga."

I looked toward them.

They both straightened.

"You got a prediction?" I asked.

The first fighter opened his mouth.

His friend elbowed him.

"The captain wins."

"Nigga, you changed that fast."

"New evidence arrived."

Tank laughed beside me.

"The evidence took its shirt off."

Shawna shook her head, smiling into my jacket.

Magnus heard the exchange and came over to stand beside me.

Now the two old niggas had both of us looking at them, and their expertise began sweating.

"Perhaps," the first one said carefully, "a draw."

Magnus laughed.

"He is afraid of hurting our feelings."

"Nigga, he should be afraid of hurting the odds," I told him.

"Mercedes and Porsche got money moving."

From the front row, Porsche lifted a fistful of slips.

"A whole lot of fucking money!"

The crowd roared.

Magnus looked at me with a grin.

"You make people believe very easily."

I looked at Shawna.

At Tank.

At all those niggas who had already seen what happened when I promised to come back.

"Nah," I said. "I make a nigga remember."

The stone ring stood four feet above the arena floor. No ropes. No soft corners. A circle carved into white stone and surrounded by men who had paid enough to believe they deserved a close view of anything.

Bastien kept the round.

Gault stood beside him as second judge.

Zero had objected to both appointments.

The houses had applauded until he ran out of room to keep objecting politely.

Magnus came toward me with his hands open.

"No anger," he said.

"Nigga, you gave me a horse. We practically related."

He grinned.

Then he picked me up.

Not tried.

Picked me up like a man moving a chair he respected but needed elsewhere.

The crowd shouted. I caught his shoulder, twisted, and landed on my feet with my back against his chest. He locked his arms around me. My ribs complained. My legs pushed. We moved across the stone together, two stubborn men trying to convince the same piece of ground it belonged to different people.

"You heavy," he said.

"Nigga, that's public expectation."

I dropped my weight, turned, and sent him over my hip.

He hit the stone hard enough to make the judges step back.

Then the nigga laughed.

Nigga got up laughing. I laughed with him. The niggas in the front row stared at both of us like we had misunderstood the part where men were supposed to hate each other before entertaining a crowd.

I knew right then why I liked him. Some men enjoy winning. Some enjoy finding a person who makes them discover they still have more to do.

Magnus came again, faster this time. I ducked his first grab, took the second against my shoulder, and felt the edge of the ring near my heel. No thunder. Nothing left I wanted to spend. Just breath, pain, and the woman watching me with her whole heart refusing to blink.

He drove forward.

I let him think he had me moving where he wanted.

Then I changed where I was.

His weight went past mine. I caught his arm, turned with him, and stopped an inch from throwing him off the platform headfirst.

The crowd held its breath.

Magnus looked down.

Then up at me.

I pulled him back onto the stone.

"Nigga, I like my gifts alive."

He sat down, breathing hard, and lifted one hand.

"Yield."

Bastien raised my arm.

Magnus stood beside me and raised the other.

Nigga, the arena had no idea which direction to cheer in, so it chose all of them.

Drake entered before the applause ended.

He wore no ceremonial robe. No smile. Just black trousers, dark gloves, and the expression of a man who had spent too long deciding my death would make his life simple again.

"Weapons," he said.

Bastien looked toward Rusk.

Rusk consulted the old tournament articles, then looked as if he wanted to tear the entire scroll into a more reasonable shape.

"The final challenger may request blades."

Shawna stood.

I looked at her.

She stayed standing.

"Baby," I said quietly.

"I know."

Nigga, that was all. She knew me. Knew I wasn't going to step away now. Knew loving a man didn't mean pretending the sharp part of his life was somebody else's problem.

They brought two blades on a velvet cloth.

I took mine.

Drake took his and smiled for the first time all morning.

"No car to hide in."

"Nigga, you crashed yours trying to catch mine. Respect the vehicle."

The bell rang.

He came low and fast.

Steel caught steel. The impact ran through my tired arm. I stepped back. He followed, pressing every advantage fatigue had

given him. The crowd's noise faded. I could hear that nigga breathing. I could hear my own breath answering. Nigga, I knew exactly how much room stood between him and me, and I knew which beautiful woman was waiting for me to cross it.

He cut my upper arm.

A shallow line. Hot and immediate.

Shawna didn't scream.

That made me love her and hate the situation at the same time.

I caught Drake's next strike, drove him sideways, and hit him with my shoulder. He stumbled. I advanced. For the first time he had to move away from me instead of arranging where I would retreat.

"You tired," he said.

"Nigga, you observant. We both gifted."

He lunged.

I turned the blade aside and struck him across the mouth with my free hand.

The crowd shouted.

He came back angry.

I'd seen that before. In fighters. In kings. In men who couldn't believe another nigga was allowed to keep standing after they'd explained how important they were.

Drake's knife flashed near my face.

I moved just enough.

Nigga wanted lightning. I gave him a tired man's last beautiful inch of room. That inch belonged to me, and the nigga could not have it.

My blade struck his glove. His weapon fell and skittered across the stone.

I stepped back.

"Yield."

He stared at me.

Bastien raised his hand.

"Colonel. You are disarmed."

Drake looked toward Zero.

The emperor did not move.

Did not nod.

Did not save him with a word.

Nigga, there are men who will call you loyal right up until your loyalty needs something back.

Drake reached into his boot.

A second blade.

Bastien shouted.

He came at me with everything he had left.

I met him.

The whole arena seemed to stop around the two of us.

Then Drake fell.

No speech.

No last clever thing.

He lay on the stone with his hand open, and the man who had paid him to die watched from beneath a black canopy without standing.

I stepped away, breathing hard.

Bastien took the blade from my hand.

Gault put his coat around my shoulders.

For a moment nobody cheered.

I was glad.

Not because Drake had become a good man by losing.

Because a dead nigga didn't need applause to prove I had survived him.

Then Shawna came up the steps.

She took my face in both hands and looked at the cut near my shoulder, the blood at my mouth, the exhaustion I couldn't make handsome enough to hide from her.

"I'm here," I said.

"I can see you."

"Just making sure you liked the view."

Her laugh broke in the middle.

She kissed me anyway.

The crowd rose slowly, the sound building from relief into something enormous.

Rusk announced the winner.

My name crossed the arena.

Across the city.

Across every little private room where a man had said I couldn't do it and was now deciding whether to pretend he'd meant somebody else.

Zero stood.

Two guards brought the counterfeit Crown toward the platform.

Vesper stepped into their path.

"No."

The word carried.

The guards stopped.

Marcellus came forward with the real case. Bastien carried Eliane's red coat folded over one arm. Rusk held the house seals where the crowd could see them.

Zero looked at Vesper.

"You have forgotten your place."

She stood straight.

"I have remembered it."

Marcellus opened both cases.

The difference wasn't obvious from the far seats. It didn't need to be. The heads of the old houses came close enough to see the repaired setting, the aged marks, the stones their parents had described to them when the city still believed its ceremonies meant what they said.

Orsini examined the real Crown.

Then the copy.

Then he looked at Zero.

"You were going to give us a lie and keep the thing our names were pledged to."

Zero's voice hardened.

"Your names are pledged to order."

"Nigga," I said, "you about to discover alphabetical ain't the only kind."

A few people laughed nervously.

Vesper took out a single page from the ledger.

She didn't read every account. Didn't turn the arena into a lecture. She read the names of the dead king and prince. The

date of the harbor fire. The payments made before it. Then she held up Eliane's letter and said the woman's name so clearly even the highest seats heard it.

Bastien closed his eyes.

When he opened them, the whole city was looking at him.

"She tried to save them," he said.

His voice was rough, but it reached.

"He paid to make sure she failed."

Zero turned toward his guards.

They raised their weapons.

So did Ardent's police.

So did the house guards.

Nigga, the arena became one long held breath with steel inside it.

I stepped between the Crown and the emperor.

My body hurt everywhere worth naming.

I stood anyway.

"You lost," I said.

Zero looked at my wounded arm.

At the men behind me.

At Vesper, who did not look away this time.

"A ceremony is not a kingdom."

"Then why you so mad about the hat?"

Nigga, they laughed straight in the emperor's face. Kings laughed. Guards laughed. One nigga under Zero's own canopy turned away too late to hide it. Zero looked around like somebody had stolen his favorite voice, and I knew the nigga would remember that sound longer than the fight.

Rusk took the real Crown from Marcellus.

Then he stopped and looked at Shawna.

"Madame."

She stepped forward.

Nigga, I went down on one knee before anybody asked.

The crowd saw it.

The kings saw it.

Zero saw the man who wouldn't bow to him kneel gladly before his own wife.

Shawna placed the Crown of Midnight on my head.

Seven points.

Black diamonds.

One blue stone catching the sky.

Her fingers rested at my temples for a moment.

"There," she whispered. "Now hold still and let them appreciate you."

I stood.

Nigga, they did.

They appreciated me so loudly pigeons rose from the rooftops beyond the arena. Men struck their fists against their chests. Women threw flowers. Tank shouted until Rosa kissed him just to give his voice a break. Mercedes and Porsche climbed onto a bench and waved my banner like they had personally founded the west.

Zero left beneath his black guards.

The nigga had not surrendered. I knew it. Vesper knew it. Tank knew it and was already watching which cars carried that nigga away. But knowing a bad nigga planned to return did not make this crown any less mine right now.

But he left while my wife stood beside me, while the real Crown shone above my face, while the city kept saying the name he had crossed out.

Captain Aiden.

King of Midnight.

Nigga, both fit.

20. The Nigga Brought an Army to My Wife's Encore

Shawna made me take the Crown off before she cleaned my arm.

"Why?"

"Because you keep looking at yourself in the mirror."

"Baby, that's a new view."

"It's the same head with more jewelry."

"Nigga, you say that like jewelry ain't accomplished things."

She pressed the cloth against the cut. I hissed. She gave me a look that reminded me I had accepted a blade fight in public and was now behaving like antiseptic had invented pain personally.

The wound was shallow. Ugly enough to need care, nowhere near deep enough to justify the face I was making.

"Don't tell Tank," I said.

"He can hear you through the door."

"Nigga, I heard all of it!" Tank called.

Rosa laughed outside.

My reign was twelve minutes old and already contained disrespect.

We were in the opera house's upstairs dressing room. Below, the city prepared to celebrate. Rusk had arranged a public reception before Shawna's evening performance. Magnus sent flowers so large they needed a cart. Gault stood at the entrance greeting people like a smiling wall. Ardent's police lined the street, and the fourteen houses had sent enough guards to make the harbor look like it was expecting a very wealthy invasion.

Vesper sat in the adjoining room with Bastien.

They were reading Eliane's letter again.

Not the evidence this time.

The part about dinner.

I left them alone.

Marcellus placed the Crown in its case and closed it.

"You will wear it at the reception?"

"Nigga, you think I fought all day to keep it in a lunchbox?"

He smiled.

"Then try not to drive through anything before the photographs."

Before the reception, three palace attendants came in carrying different capes.

One blue. One black. One so red Tank said the nigga wearing it would need a separate appointment with the sunset.

"You must choose," the senior attendant told me.

"Nigga, I chose a wife. These decisions smaller."

Shawna held the blue one against my shoulders.

Rosa whistled.

"That nigga looks expensive from behind too."

Tank turned toward her.

"Baby."

"You asked me to be honest when we got engaged."

"Nigga, I regret the timing of that promise."

I walked toward the mirror. The cape followed a second late, taking up more room than some of the people who'd come to congratulate me.

"This nigga got a train," Tank said.

"It's a cape," Rusk corrected.

"Nigga, it got a schedule. Look how long it takes to arrive."

Shawna laughed and took it off my shoulders.

"He'll wear the jacket."

The attendants looked disappointed.

I pointed at the senior one.

"You wear it."

"Me?"

"Nigga, you carried it this far. Enjoy the rest of the journey."

He tried it on. Stood taller. Turned toward the mirror like he'd been waiting forty years for somebody to ask his opinion of his own reflection.

Tank nodded approvingly.

"Now that nigga got somewhere to be."

We sent him downstairs to lead the receiving line. By the time I followed, half the guests were complimenting his cape, and the man looked delighted enough to defend my reign with a dining chair if anybody interrupted it.

Nigga, generosity can dress itself when you give it the right closet.

The first hour was beautiful.

People came through the opera house in a long delighted line. Not everybody bowed. Some shook my hand. Some touched my shoulder and thanked me for a thing I'd done so fast I'd barely noticed it becoming somebody else's whole afternoon.

The drummer from the parade arrived carrying a new drum he'd bought with the money I threw him.

"Still keeping time?" I asked.

"Better now, Captain."

The café owner whose fountain had caught the SUV brought a basket of oranges and a repair bill made entirely of jokes about my driving.

Sabine and Camille came together. Married. Holding hands openly. Camille had flowers in her hair that Sabine kept adjusting for no reason except wanting to touch her.

Nigga, I recognized that habit.

I was doing the same thing to Shawna's bracelet.

Rusk's wife kissed my cheek and told me her husband had slept through the night for the first time in months. Rusk looked embarrassed until she took his hand, then he looked willing to be embarrassed indefinitely.

Even Sovereign arrived.

Not inside.

Shawna had been clear about that.

The horse stood beneath the opera house steps wearing blue ribbons, receiving more compliments than most of the visiting kings.

Tank looked at him through the window.

"Nigga got a publicist now."

"You jealous?"

"I want to know why he got more flowers than me."

Rosa kissed his cheek.

"Because you eat worse when people hand-feed you."

At eight, the music began.

Shawna took the stage in gold.

The Crown sat beside me in the royal box because she said if I wore it through the whole show the people behind me wouldn't see anything. I considered that a design flaw in the audience, but marriage involved compromises.

She sang one song.

Then another.

The city quieted around her again.

I sat with my brother on one side and the people we'd brought alive through all this trouble around us, and for a moment I let myself enjoy having won something without immediately checking what it cost.

Then the lights flickered.

Bastien stood.

Ardent touched his radio.

A boom rolled up from the harbor.

Not thunder.

Not music.

Everybody in our box knew the difference.

Shawna didn't stop singing.

She saw me rise. Saw Tank rise with me. Her eyes moved once toward the side doors, where the ushers had already begun opening the exits.

She changed the final note into a held phrase long enough for Rosa to walk onstage beside her.

Then Rosa spoke into the microphone, warm and steady.

"We're going to move the celebration through the garden for a minute. Take your drinks. Take your people. Leave the chairs where they are."

A little laughter.

Enough to keep fear from becoming the first thing everyone obeyed.

Outside, Zero's Black Mantle trucks were moving down the harbor road.

Three at first.

Then six.

Behind them came armored cars carrying the emperor's crest. The first explosion had struck an empty customs building near the pier. A warning, or the start of something larger. With Zero, those were usually the same expense in different envelopes.

Mordecai Draven stood in the lead vehicle.

Still wearing the face of a shovel.

Apparently Zero had released him from custody and given him a new reason to blame me for a woman having preferences.

"Nigga," Tank said, "that man survives embarrassment like it's a vitamin."

I handed the Crown case to Marcellus.

"Stay with the others."

"And you?"

I took the police badge from my jacket and fixed it where everybody could see.

"Going to work."

Ardent met us at the front doors.

"They demand the Crown and the queen."

Vesper stepped behind us.

"I will not let the theater burn because of me."

Shawna came down the stairs in the gold dress, holding a pistol and looking furious that the evening had made it match.

"This theater is mine," she said. "You don't get to decide what I protect inside it."

Vesper looked at her.

Then nodded.

Nigga, my wife had become very good at making queens feel like people worth saving.

The first gunfire struck the stone outside.

We moved.

Ardent's officers took the front steps. Gault and Magnus covered the garden passage where the guests were leaving. Mercedes and Porsche brought cars around to carry the older visitors and anyone who couldn't run. Rosa stayed with the ushers, voice steady enough to make strangers trust the next doorway.

Tank came with me into the street.

No thunder left worth spending.

No need to pretend otherwise.

Just two niggas who had stood beside each other through enough gunfire to know where the other one's shoulder would be without looking.

We fired from behind the low stone wall as the lead truck stopped near the fountain. Tank kept my left clear. I kept the nigga's right clear. Nigga, we had been doing this long enough that I could feel where his shoulder ought to be without looking away from the men trying to make us miss our wives' next song. Mordecai shouted orders from its roof. His men spread toward the theater and discovered the city's house guards had stopped considering themselves decorative.

Windows opened above them.

Rifles appeared.

Old debts had finally found newer priorities.

A Black Mantle car tried to come around our side.

Mercedes met it in the silver sports car.

She didn't ram it.

She spun across its path, stopped sideways, and Porsche opened the passenger door into the driver's line with a gun steady in both hands.

"Wrong fucking street!"

The driver chose reverse.

Nigga, I appreciated a man who could learn while moving backward.

Mordecai saw the retreat and climbed down from the truck. He ran toward the theater's side entrance with four men behind him.

Sabine stood inside that doorway.

Camille beside her.

Neither one waited to become somebody else's helpless ending.

Camille pulled the heavy floral stand into the opening while Sabine slammed the iron gate behind it. Mordecai struck the bars, shouting her name like ownership might still work if he pronounced it angrily enough.

Shawna appeared above him on the balcony.

"She said no yesterday."

He looked up.

That gave me the second I needed.

I crossed the street, hit him from the side, and drove him into the closed gate. His gun fell. His men turned, but Vesper and Ardent's officers had already reached the corner behind them.

They put down their weapons.

Mordecai tried to stand.

I put him back down.

"Nigga, your wedding keeps getting worse."

Tank arrived with the handcuffs.

This time he used two sets.

"For the commitment," he said.

The Black Mantle line broke near the harbor. One nigga ran. The nigga beside him decided to respect his friend's example. Then the whole ugly line started finding other streets, because these niggas had been promised an easy theater and found a city with its sleeves rolled up.

Not because the Crown shone in a room they couldn't see.

Because Magnus's men had blocked the road behind them, because Gault had taken their forward position, because the local police knew every turn better than hired soldiers who thought fear was a map.

And because the city had spent a week watching us show up.

Niggas remember who comes. The drummer remembered. The café nigga remembered. Every house guard who had watched me pull somebody out of a bad afternoon remembered. Now those niggas were here, and Zero was the nigga driving away.

Zero's cars were already climbing toward the Black House above the harbor.

His last palace in Midnight City.

Bastien saw the lights moving on the hill and came beside me.

"He is retreating to the old royal treasury."

"The books?"

"The remaining fortune. Gold, stones, bearer claims. Enough to purchase another army."

I looked up at the dark house.

Then back at the opera theater, where my wife stood on the balcony in gold with smoke drifting past her shoulders.

"Nigga," I said, "he don't get to leave a bad review and steal the cash register."

Shawna came down to the street and took my hand.

Her dress was dirty at the hem. A little soot marked her cheek. She looked so alive I nearly forgot there was still a hill to climb.

"One more tonight?" she asked.

I shook my head.

"We get everybody safe. We breathe. Then we finish the city."

She looked at me carefully.

Then smiled.

"That's the smartest thing you've said all day."

"Nigga, I got crowned twice. The day had competition."

We went inside together.

Behind us, the people who had left the theater began coming back through the garden doors. Nobody wanted the last thing they heard that night to be Zero's guns.

So Shawna sang one more song.

Rosa sang with her.

The band played with two broken lights and a bullet hole through the scenery.

I sat in the front row with my arm wrapped, my brother beside me, the Crown case at my feet, and listened while my wife made the city sound like it belonged to somebody who loved being alive in it.

21. The Last Palace in the Way

At dawn, the city sent me breakfast and an army.

Nigga, in that order.

I appreciated people who understood priorities.

The breakfast came from the café I'd damaged. The army came from the houses I'd saved, embarrassed, beaten, freed, or accidentally improved while trying to get somewhere else. They filled the harbor road beneath the opera house in cars, trucks, police vehicles, and one horse who looked offended nobody had asked him to lead.

Magnus stood beside Sovereign with the reins.

"He wants you."

"Nigga, everybody does. He gonna have to share."

Shawna brought me coffee and checked the dressing on my arm. I'd slept six hours. Not enough to become a new man, enough to stop feeling like the old one had been carried down stairs in pieces.

"You don't need to prove you can bleed again," she said.

"I was planning something different."

"Good. Plan it with both shoulders intact."

She wore black trousers, a blue shirt, and the same expression she'd worn driving the Aston beneath me while I clung to another man's hood. I had stopped asking whether she intended to come. A nigga can learn from marriage if he pays attention between the explosions.

Tank checked the cars. Rosa checked the people inside them. Mercedes and Porsche distributed water and spare jackets with the ruthless authority of women who knew most men would forget both and then describe their discomfort like it was heroic.

Marcellus brought the Crown case.

"It stays with me," he said.

"Nigga, you think I'm putting it on under a low ceiling? I just got it."

Vesper came last, with Bastien beside her.

No queen's cloak.

No black diamonds.

A dark coat and Nico's old ring on a chain where she had hidden it for years.

"Ready?" I asked.

She looked up at the Black House on the hill.

"No."

Then she opened the car door.

"Let's go."

Nigga, I respected an honest answer with motion behind it.

A young house guard approached before we left carrying a polished helmet with my initials on the front.

"For the king."

I took it.

Tried it on.

Tank stared.

Rosa covered her mouth.

"Nigga," Tank said, "you look like a motorcycle got promoted."

"It's protective."

"It's enormous."

"Nigga, there's greatness inside."

Shawna lifted the front edge until she could see my eyes.

"Can you hear me?"

"Baby, I hear you through walls."

"Then hear this. We are taking the car. You don't need a castle on your forehead."

The guard looked wounded on behalf of the helmet.

I handed it back carefully.

"Keep it ready, my nigga. For the statue."

His whole face changed.

"There will be a statue?"

Tank threw up his hands.

"Nigga, don't encourage the nigga!"

"The city has already commissioned three," Rusk said from the steps.

Rosa finally lost the fight with her laughter.

I looked at Shawna.

She looked at me.

"Three?" she asked Rusk.

"The harbor. The arena. The opera-house courtyard."

My wife thought about it for a moment.

"Send me the sketches. They keep making his shoulders too small in the paintings."

Nigga, I nearly took her upstairs and postponed the whole war.

Tank caught my arm.

"Eyes forward, greatness. The bad nigga still on the hill."

I kissed Shawna once, handed the helmet to the proudest guard in Midnight City, and went to the car with a whole extra reason to survive the morning.

We climbed through streets still marked by the night's fighting. Broken windows. Burned tires. Flowers somebody had placed

beside an empty police car. People stood in doorways watching us pass, and the cheering this morning was different.

Less party.

More promise.

I felt it through the windshield.

The Black House rose above a terraced garden with old royal statues along its walls. It had belonged to Adrien Valcour before Zero made every beautiful thing in the city learn a new owner's name.

The gates were closed.

The guards behind them were armed.

Vesper got out of the car.

I got out with her.

She looked at the men on the wall and called three of them by name.

Not rank.

Name.

A gardener's son who had become a guard. A driver who used to bring her to the observatory. A man whose wife had sung at the opera house two nights earlier because Shawna had given her a place on the program.

"My people are safe," she told them. "Your people can be too. Open the gate."

A guard looked back toward the house.

Another lowered his rifle.

Then the inner doors opened and Zero's remaining Black Mantle soldiers came out firing.

The wall guards dropped out of sight.

I pulled Vesper behind the car as bullets struck the stone where she'd stood.

"Nigga never could handle a conversation," I said.

Ardent's police answered from the road. Magnus's men moved toward the side entrance. Gault and Tank went through the low garden wall where the night had already damaged it, two enormous niggas making a new door out of an old disagreement.

Shawna came beside me.

"Gate's opening."

The local guards had made their choice.

One leaf of the iron gate swung inward.

I got into the police Lamborghini.

The roof still bore the race's long scar. The car looked like it had survived a bad opinion and kept driving.

I loved that nigga more every day.

Shawna took the passenger seat.

We went through the gate beneath the gunfire and crossed the courtyard toward the main steps. A Black Mantle truck tried to block us. I turned, clipped its empty rear corner, and sent it sideways into the fountain.

Water rose over the hood.

The driver climbed out with both hands up. Smart nigga. Drenched nigga. A nigga who had just discovered a fountain and immediately reconsidered whether employment required him to die inside it.

"Nigga, good morning," I told him through the window.

Then we were past.

The Lamborghini climbed the first broad steps and stopped beneath the portico. I got out into smoke, stone dust, and the sound of a whole palace discovering the world had finally arrived at its front door.

Bastien came through the gate behind us with Vesper. He knew the house. Knew where people might still be trapped, which hall led to the treasury, which staircase would put Zero near an escape route.

He didn't give a lecture.

He pointed.

We moved.

Inside, the floors shone beneath chandeliers nobody had thought to turn off. Breakfast sat untouched on a long table. Silver cups. Fresh fruit. One folded napkin beside Zero's chair.

Nigga, the man had planned to eat while the city counted its broken windows.

Tank came through the side door carrying a guard's rifle and looking annoyed.

"These niggas got another staircase."

"Rich house," I said.

"I dislike options under fire."

Rosa appeared behind him with two frightened kitchen workers.

"They go out through the courtyard. No one shoots the people carrying aprons, understood?"

"Yes, baby," Tank said immediately.

The workers followed her like she'd been in charge of the palace all along and everybody had simply been too stupid to notice.

We reached the treasury corridor.

Zero stood at its far end with a small black case in one hand.

For the first time since I'd met him, the nigga looked like he had dressed in a hurry. His collar sat wrong. His coat was open.

Nigga had one cufflink. I noticed because a man should remember exactly what greatness does to the nigga trying to stop it.

Nigga, it suited him badly.

"Aiden."

"You keep saying my name like a bill arrived."

He looked past me at Shawna, Tank, Vesper, the people he'd tried to separate until they'd become a whole road he couldn't close.

"You could have had everything I offered."

"Nigga, I took more by disagreeing."

His mouth tightened.

"You think love makes men loyal. It makes them vulnerable."

Shawna stepped beside me.

"And yet here you are alone in a hallway."

That one landed.

I saw it.

Zero's eyes moved to her, then back to me.

"Your wife has a sharp tongue."

"Nigga, that's one of the nicer things she brought."

He drew a gun.

I drove forward before the barrel settled.

The shot struck the wall. My shoulder hit his chest. We crashed through the side doors into a little audience chamber filled with chairs that had probably heard years of men begging politely.

I put Zero across the first three.

He rolled, fast for a man who had spent so long letting other people demonstrate violence. He came up with the gun again. I knocked his arm aside and hit him hard enough to send the black case across the floor.

It opened.

Diamonds scattered beneath the chairs.

Nigga, the emperor had packed light by his own terrible standards.

He kicked my injured arm.

Pain flashed white through me.

I stepped back just enough for him to get between two pillars. He caught a fallen chair and threw it, not at me, at Shawna entering the doorway.

She moved clear.

I caught the chair and sent it back harder.

It struck the pillar beside him and broke.

"Nigga," I said, "you running out of furniture."

He looked at me then with something I hadn't seen before.

Recognition.

Not respect he'd agreed to display.

The private realization that the man in front of him might actually be better than every expensive answer he'd prepared.

"You are extraordinary," he said.

"Nigga, your timing terrible."

He slammed his hand against a wall panel.

A side door opened.

He ran.

I went after him, through a narrow stair and onto the upper terrace. Wind hit my face. The city spread below us, bright and wounded and alive.

A helicopter waited on the rear landing court.

Its blades were already turning.

Zero's last guards stood between it and the steps.

They fired.

I dropped behind a stone planter. Shawna reached the terrace behind me with Vesper. Tank and Gault came from the other stair, forcing the guards to divide their attention.

Zero crossed the landing court.

I could see the distance.

Could feel the little blue thunder left after sleep, enough to move me faster for a breath or two, not enough to make bullets stop caring where my body was.

Below us, a section of the damaged terrace gave way beneath two palace workers trying to reach the stairs.

One fell to a lower ledge.

The other caught the railing and hung there, screaming.

Shawna saw him.

So did I.

Nigga, that worker had been minding his own business before the palace started falling around him. Now the nigga was hanging from a broken piece of stone while Zero escaped in something expensive. I could chase a helicopter or reach a hand. My wife was already reaching. I went where she was.

I went to the railing.

Shawna anchored herself against the pillar and caught my belt as I leaned out. Tank reached us and braced both of us. I caught the worker's wrist.

He was heavier than fear had made him look.

I used the last short pulse of thunder in my arms.

Enough to pull.

Enough to get him over.

Then it was gone, and Tank had to haul me back with him before my knees stopped belonging to me.

The helicopter lifted.

Zero looked down from the open door.

I looked up, breathing hard, one rescued man crying against my leg.

That nigga's face carried no victory. He had the helicopter. I had the people below it. Nigga, he could count aircraft all he wanted. The city could see which man was holding somebody who still got to go home.

He knew what the city would remember about this moment.

The aircraft turned toward the desert.

Away from Midnight City.

Toward the Last City, where men like him went when every other place had finally learned their name.

Vesper watched until it disappeared.

"He'll rebuild."

"Nigga, then we go where he building."

Inside the treasury, an elderly custodian named Madame Caron met Marcellus with the Crown case. She had served the old house long enough to recognize the repaired setting before he finished opening the lid.

She touched one point gently.

"I thought I would die before seeing it carried honestly again."

"It's being carried by criminals," I told her.

She looked at my badge, my torn shirt, my exhausted face.

"I said honestly. I did not say innocently."

Nigga, I liked her immediately.

She opened the treasury with keys she'd kept through three kings and one emperor who had never bothered learning her first name.

Gold filled the old shelves.

Cases of stones.

Books of claims and deeds.

Fortunes taken from houses Zero had persuaded to call their losses necessary.

Marcellus found the records the Crown's marks identified.

Vesper found names of families still living in the city. Bastien found Nico's little wooden horse in a drawer beside a ceremonial sword.

He held it for a long time.

Then he gave it to Vesper.

She smiled through tears.

"He hated the sword."

"I remember," Bastien said.

I sat on the treasury steps because my legs had finally earned a vote.

Shawna sat beside me.

She took my hand.

Below, in the courtyard, the city's people began cheering as the news spread.

The Black House had fallen.

The treasury was open.

The emperor had fled.

"You didn't get him," she said softly.

"Not yet."

"You got everyone else home."

I looked at her.

At the smoke on her sleeve.

At the woman who kept making every victory have a face I wanted to see when the noise ended.

"Nigga," I said, "that's a pretty good morning."

22. The Palace Was Too Small for the Housewarming

They wanted to rename the Black House after me.

I asked if the sign was refundable.

Rusk looked wounded.

"Captain, it is an honor."

"Nigga, so is picking a name my wife likes."

Shawna stood at the top of the repaired entrance steps, looking at the dark walls, the old statues, the windows finally open to daylight.

"Blue House," she said.

Tank looked up.

"It ain't blue."

"Then paint it."

Nigga, a queen had spoken.

By afternoon, niggas were painting the lower walls a deep blue that changed with the sun. One painter kept stepping back to admire it. The nigga beside him kept stepping back to admire the nigga admiring it. I watched them both and thought, yes, my niggas, take your time appreciating the place. It just got a much better owner. The old imperial crest came down. The royal

garden gates opened. People who had worked in the house for years walked through rooms they'd only seen from the servants' corridor and discovered the ceilings weren't any higher when you were allowed to look up.

I kept the throne.

Nigga, obviously. A nigga could change the walls, change the gates, change the name on the mailbox. That beautiful chair had been waiting for my ass through three whole generations of inferior posture.

It was a beautiful chair and had committed fewer crimes than most of the other things we'd inherited.

Shawna made me put it in the music room.

"Why?"

"Because if you put it in the dining room, you'll start giving speeches before breakfast."

"Nigga, my breakfast speeches excellent."

"Your eggs get cold."

The first painter tried to match the blue to the Crown's center stone.

Marcellus objected.

"The Crown is not a paint sample."

"Nigga, it could multitask," I said.

Shawna brought down the shirt I'd worn the morning we first left the hotel together in this city.

"This blue."

The painter held it against the light.

"A beautiful color."

"Beautiful nigga wore it," Tank added from the doorway.

Rosa looked at him.

"You two are getting worse."

"Baby, a nigga can recognize his brother."

"A nigga can recognize him without announcing it to every tradesman on the coast."

I put an arm around Tank's shoulders.

"Let the nigga speak. He's developing as an admirer."

The painter laughed. His assistant laughed. By the time they left with the shirt, both men had promised the house would be the finest blue building anybody had ever blamed on a newly crowned criminal.

Porsche came in carrying a little sample board.

"I voted darker."

Mercedes looked over her shoulder.

"Nigga, nobody asked you."

"That's how voting gets interesting."

Shawna took the board, studied it, and pointed to a second shade.

"Garden doors. That one."

Porsche looked at me triumphantly.

"The queen understands contrast."

"Nigga, the queen understands everything. That's why I'm standing here looking decorative."

Tank stepped beside me and folded his arms.

"The niggas can decorate together."

Rosa kissed him, then pushed both of us toward the garden before our shared admiration delayed the painters another hour.

The housewarming started at four.

By five, we needed the garden.

By six, we needed the street.

At seven, Ardent stopped pretending it was possible to keep the celebration inside one neighborhood and simply closed the roads around it with the expression of a man delighted to be professionally defeated by a party.

Cars lined the terraces. My police Lamborghini sat beneath the front arch with its damaged roof repaired enough to look proud of the scar. Magnus brought Sovereign, who had apparently decided every major public event required his personal attendance. Gault brought half the cathedral's fighters, all in

suits, all trying to look civilized around trays of food they could have carried away whole.

Mercedes and Porsche greeted the dancers and hostesses from Absolution. Dahlia arrived in gold again and told me the yacht had finally earned a party where nobody spent the evening watching which doors were locked.

"You keeping it?" she asked.

"Nigga, I stole the whole thing. Seems rude to return it without using the towels."

Alaric stood behind her smiling.

He had agreed to remain captain.

Not because I threatened him.

Because I asked what he wanted the boat to become, and he said something people were happy to board.

I told him that sounded profitable enough to try.

The treasury's old claims were spread across tables in the east room. Madame Caron, Marcellus, and Bastien worked through them with representatives from the houses. No grand promise that money would make everybody good. We were still a city full of criminals wearing beautiful coats. But if a man had taken your father's fortune and then charged you interest for missing it, you deserved at least the pleasure of watching his account become less comfortable.

Some wealth returned to the houses.

Some repaired the streets we'd fought through.

Some stayed mine.

Nigga, I had not crossed a sea, wrestled a champion, ridden a Ferrari up a container, and been crowned twice to become shy around a vault.

Shawna looked at the figures Marcellus brought me.

"You smiling."

"Baby, these numbers got good posture."

"You already rich."

"Nigga, I enjoy consistency."

She laughed and took the paper out of my hand before I could begin naming future cars after it.

Vesper arrived with Nico's wooden horse in her bag and his old ring at her throat.

For the first time, she wore no black.

A green dress. Simple jewelry. Her hair loose.

The people from her household greeted her without the old careful pauses. The cook kissed her cheek. One of the singers dragged her toward the music room. Bastien watched from the doorway with a smile he didn't seem to know he was wearing.

"You staying here?" I asked him.

He nodded.

"Madame Caron needs someone who knows which keys belong to doors and which belong to arguments."

"Nigga, you qualified."

"And someone should keep watch over the city while you chase him."

I looked toward the desert beyond the far hills.

Zero had reached the Last City.

Vesper's contacts had confirmed it that morning. Fortress. Airfields. More money than sense. More frightened men than he'd ever admit needing.

We had three days before we left.

Three days to rest, prepare, and let the people we'd saved believe us when we said we'd come back.

Bastien touched my shoulder.

"Eliane told me to love something I could still reach."

He looked out at the garden, the music, the household mixing with people they would once have watched through windows.

"I think I have finally followed the instruction."

I nodded.

"Nigga, wear the blue coat. You got time to show it off now."

He laughed and went to find Vesper.

In the music room, Shawna sat at the piano with Rosa beside her. They were arguing about a song. Not angrily. Seriously, which was more dangerous because both women knew what they wanted and could hear exactly where the other one disagreed.

"Let me try," I said.

Shawna looked up.

"You sure?"

"Nigga, you think I put a throne in here just to supervise?"

I sat at the piano.

Played the first phrase she'd been singing.

Found the turn Rosa wanted beneath it.

Then let my hands follow the sound until the room changed around the keys.

Shawna stopped arguing.

Rosa stared.

Tank, standing in the doorway, put his plate down like food had temporarily lost the competition for his attention.

Nigga, I played. The first phrase made Shawna turn. The next one made Rosa put a hand against the piano. I heard somebody whisper, "This nigga plays too?" and another nigga answer, "Be quiet. I'm trying to hear what else the nigga can do." I kept

playing because my wife had started smiling before she started singing.

Shawna began singing.

Soft at first.

Then full.

Rosa joined her on the next line, and the two voices rose above the piano until people came in from the garden to hear what the house had suddenly learned to do.

Nigga, I played.

Played for my wife.

For my brother standing beside the woman he would marry.

For an old man in a blue coat listening with his eyes closed.

For a queen who had spent sixteen years letting silence wear all her best jewelry.

When the song ended, nobody spoke for a moment.

Then Tank said, "Nigga, is there something you can't do?"

Shawna put her hand on the back of my neck.

"Put his clothes in the basket."

The room broke into laughter.

I looked up at her.

"Baby, that's a different discipline."

She kissed me while they were still cheering.

Later, Vesper found us on the balcony.

Shawna leaned against the rail with my jacket around her shoulders. I stood behind her, my hands at her waist, watching the party spread farther into the garden than anybody had planned.

"I wanted to thank you both," Vesper said.

"You already did," Shawna told her.

"Not for the Crown. Or the house."

She looked at me, then at my wife.

"For letting me admire something without needing to own it."

Shawna studied her for a moment.

Then she reached out and took Vesper's hand.

"Come to Vegas when this is finished."

"For the wedding?"

"Both of them."

Vesper smiled.

"I would like that."

Nigga, there was no contest in it anymore. No hidden bargain under the music. Just a woman accepting that another person's happiness could be near her without becoming an insult.

Rosa called us down from the garden.

Tank stood beside a little table with four glasses and a cake Camille had somehow produced despite being on what was supposed to be her honeymoon.

"We need dates," Rosa said.

"For what?" Tank asked.

She looked at him.

"Nigga."

He straightened.

"The wedding. Right. Yes. Dates."

Shawna took one glass and handed me another.

"After the last job," she said.

Rosa raised hers.

"After the last job."

Tank looked at me.

My brother had stood through so much gunfire beside me that sometimes I forgot how carefully he held a small beautiful thing when he finally got one.

He looked nervous now.

Not afraid of the Last City.

Afraid of believing the party afterward could really be his.

I touched my glass to his.

"Nigga, I'm getting you home to marry that woman if I gotta drive the whole desert out of the way."

He smiled.

Rosa kissed him.

Shawna kissed me.

Around us, the city kept celebrating a victory it could finally touch without asking an emperor's permission.

And above the garden, the Blue House shone in the evening light like a palace had learned who was actually worth staying up for.

23. Every Road Had Heard About Me

"Nigga, we leaving with more cars than we came with."

Tank stood in the Blue House courtyard holding a list he'd stopped believing halfway down.

"That's usually how winning works."

"Nigga, we came with a fleet."

"Now the fleet got cousins."

Rosa took the list from him.

"This one's staying. This one's going. This one's the horse trailer."

Tank pointed.

"That nigga ain't coming?"

Sovereign stood beside Magnus beneath the courtyard arch, wearing a blue blanket and looking personally offended by every suitcase passing him.

"The horse stays in Midnight City," Shawna said.

"He gonna think we abandoned him," Tank told her.

"He owns half the garden and has a groom who brushes him four times a day. He'll process it."

I went over and put my hand against the horse's neck.

"Aight, my nigga. Hold the city. No nightclub without somebody watching your jewelry."

Sovereign pushed his nose against my chest.

Nigga, I chose to understand that as loyalty instead of him checking whether I had an apple.

We had rested three days.

Real rest, as much as our people could manage without accidentally starting a party. My arm had closed enough that Shawna stopped checking the bandage every time I moved. Tank had slept so deeply Rosa put a little flower on his forehead and took photographs to prove a man that large could become harmless for eight consecutive hours.

Mercedes and Porsche had bought clothes, opened conversations that sounded like future businesses, and somehow arranged for three car dealers to compete over who could give us the most respectful departure gift.

Marcellus had finished examining the treasury records.

The original historical ledger stayed with Bastien and Madame Caron in the Blue House. Eliane's coat and letter stayed there too, in a room where they would be remembered as things a woman had made, not just evidence men found useful afterward.

Vesper carried authenticated copies of the pages that mattered for Zero's remaining allies. Names. Promises. Payments. The little written betrayals that might make a frightened man in the

Last City ask whether he was standing beside an emperor or waiting behind him in line for the same grave.

The Crown traveled with Marcellus in its case.

It wasn't on my head this morning.

Shawna had pointed out that I couldn't lean back comfortably in the car wearing seven sharp points.

Nigga, another flaw in luxury seating.

Bastien met us at the steps.

Blue coat.

Straight back.

A man staying because he had chosen a place, not because somebody had taught him to mistake fear for duty.

He embraced Vesper for a long time.

"Come back," he told her.

She closed her eyes against his shoulder.

"I intend to."

"Intend firmly."

She laughed through the tears she wasn't hiding anymore.

Then he took my hand.

"You gave her a way out."

"Nigga, she walked it."

"Yes," he said. "She did."

Gault stood beside Magnus near the gate. Both would remain to protect the city and the people we'd left in it. They didn't look disappointed to miss the journey. They looked like men who had finally been given a job worth doing without somebody holding a debt over the pay.

"Send word," Gault said.

"You gonna come?"

"You came for me before I knew to ask."

Nigga, that answer stayed with me.

Ardent saluted at the gate.

Behind him, his officers stood in two lines while the cars rolled through. Some had tied little blue ribbons near their badges. One young officer held a photograph of me riding the SUV hood and asked whether I'd sign it before leaving.

Shawna took the photograph first.

"I was driving the other car."

He straightened so fast his hat moved.

"Of course, Madame. Both of you. Please."

We signed it together.

Nigga, accuracy can be beautiful when your wife insists on it.

At the last gate, the airport worker who'd asked for our signatures stood beside his father.

I recognized the blue uniform first.

Then the grin.

"You collected?" I asked.

He held up a little envelope.

"Every coin."

His father sighed.

"That nigga hasn't stopped talking about you since the airport."

"Nigga, you lost an expensive argument," I told him. "Let the winner enjoy the road."

The older man looked at the cars, the police escort, the city banners, my wife sitting beside me like every impossible thing on the road had been invited to accompany her.

Then he shook his head and smiled.

"I watched the race."

"Good seat?"

"The gate nearly took the car's roof."

"Nigga, nearly been doing a lot of work around me."

His son laughed.

"I told you. That nigga is different."

"I can see the nigga," his father said. "Let me have my own eyes."

Shawna leaned toward the window.

"He was worried about you," she told the younger man.

"About me?"

"About you admiring someone who might let you down."

The father looked at her with surprise, then nodded slowly.

I held out my hand to him.

"Aight, my nigga. Keep checking. That's a father's job."

He shook it hard.

Tank called from the Mercedes behind us.

"Nigga, you making a family reunion at the gate?"

"Building international relations!"

"Then international your ass into the car!"

The two men laughed together as we pulled away.

In the mirror, I saw the father put an arm around his son's shoulders. The young nigga held up his signed badge one more time, and I waved until the road turned.

The city followed us to the harbor road.

Not all the way out.

Enough to make leaving feel like pulling a whole warm room away from your back.

Rusk read one final announcement from the opera house steps. He called me Captain, King, Champion, and several other things I'd have put on a jacket if Shawna hadn't already told the tailor we were finished ordering clothes.

Then he lowered the scroll.

"Aiden," he said, without any title at all. "Thank you for coming."

I put a hand over my chest.

"Nigga, thanks for eventually giving me the good chair."

He laughed.

The city laughed with him.

Then the engines rose, and we went.

The road out of Midnight City climbed through dry hills toward the desert. The sea stayed beside us for the first hour, flashing blue between stone houses and olive groves. Then it fell behind. Nigga, there was sand everywhere. Sand on the hills. Sand beside the road. A whole country of sand waiting for some rich nigga to put a wall around one corner and claim he had improved the view. Somewhere beyond it, Zero was that nigga. I drove the police Lamborghini.

Shawna sat beside me with her feet tucked comfortably beneath her, watching the hills turn gold.

Tank drove the black Mercedes behind us. Rosa rode beside him. Marcellus traveled with Mercedes and Porsche in the Rolls, the Crown secured beside him like a sleeping argument worth forty different kinds of trouble. Vesper rode in the next car with two people from her household who had chosen the road with her.

More cars followed.

Friends. Guards. Drivers. Men and women who had seen enough of Zero's promises to prefer our dangerous certainty.

Nobody was forced to come.

Nigga, that made the line behind me feel heavier in a way I liked.

Shawna put her hand on my arm.

"You thinking?"

"Dangerous accusation."

"What about?"

I looked in the mirror at the convoy.

"All these niggas following me."

"You keep coming back for them."

"That enough?"

She looked at me.

"Ask the people who came back."

I drove a little longer without saying anything.

Then Tank's voice came through the radio.

"Nigga, why you quiet?"

I laughed.

"My wife was admiring my leadership."

"Nigga, admire a gas station next. We got needs."

We stopped at a roadside place with six pumps, a little café, and a man behind the counter who looked out at the cars as if his business had accidentally appeared in somebody else's dream.

"You the king?" he asked me.

"Depends what the coffee costs."

He looked at the badge.

"The cop too?"

"Nigga, I stay employed."

His daughter, a woman in her late twenties who ran the café with him, brought Shawna a cold drink and stared at the convoy through the window.

"They said you stole the emperor's boat."

"Borrowed indefinitely."

"They said you rode a horse through a nightclub."

"Nigga wanted to hear Rosa sing."

"They said you won the Crown."

Shawna smiled.

"That one is accurate."

The woman looked at me for a long moment.

Then she shook her head.

"I thought people were adding things."

Tank came in behind me.

"Nigga, they leaving things out."

We ate outside beneath a striped awning while the engines cooled. The desert wind moved across the tables. Somebody started music from a car. Rosa sang a little under her breath. Porsche stole fries from Mercedes's plate and denied it while still chewing.

For twenty minutes, a nigga got to sit still. A nigga got to eat lunch with his wife. Tank told a story so badly Rosa had to help him finish, and the whole table laughed at the nigga before he reached the good part. I loved every damn second of those twenty minutes.

Then three black cars appeared on the ridge.

Vesper saw them first.

She set down her glass.

"Zero's outriders."

Nigga, the man couldn't even let us appreciate lunch without sending a bad idea in a nice vehicle.

The cars came down fast.

We moved faster.

Tank got the café owner and his daughter inside. Rosa brought the other customers through the rear door. Mercedes and Porsche got Marcellus into the Rolls. Vesper climbed into her car, one hand on the case of ledger pages, the other steadying herself against the roof as the first shots struck the empty pumps.

I pulled Shawna into the Lamborghini.

"Seat belt."

She clicked it into place.

"Nigga, you finally said it before we flew."

"Marriage improving my timing."

We shot out onto the road as the black cars reached the forecourt. Tank followed, cutting between them and the café. One attacker swerved after us. Another tried to reach the Rolls and found Porsche leaning out with a pistol and no interest in becoming any nigga's easy target.

The road climbed toward an old stone bridge.

A dry riverbed ran beneath it.

The lead attacker pulled alongside, his passenger raising a gun toward Shawna's window.

I turned into him.

Not enough to throw us both off the road.

Enough to make his aim become a complaint about his own door.

The cars scraped together. Shawna ducked. I pushed the Lamborghini forward, and the black car fell behind with its front wheel limping against the damaged fender.

The second car came up fast.

The bridge ahead was narrow.

I had one short burst of thunder available after the rest. I could feel it waiting, bright and finite, like a match a nigga couldn't strike twice just because he enjoyed the light.

I used it.

The engine answered.

Blue flashed along the hood.

We crossed the bridge first, tires biting stone, and I let the power go before it could take more than the moment needed.

Tank reached the other end beside me.

Together we blocked the approach while the rest of the convoy crossed.

The pursuers braked on the far side.

Those niggas saw the guns waiting. One nigga looked at Tank. Another looked at me. A third looked at the road behind him with the expression of a nigga remembering he had promised his mother he would visit.

Saw the Crown's car safely beyond us.

Saw a whole line of people who had stopped being scattered names on Zero's list.

Nigga, they decided the emperor could receive disappointing news from men still alive to deliver it.

They turned back.

We kept going.

My hands shook a little after the thunder.

Shawna noticed and put hers over one of them when the road straightened.

"You good?"

"Tired."

"That's allowed."

"Nigga, don't tell the statues. They expect posture."

She laughed and rested her head against the seat.

By evening, the desert had turned copper beneath the sun.

The Last City's towers appeared far ahead.

Black walls. Gold windows. Aircraft moving like insects above the distant fortress. Somewhere inside, Zero was arranging another room he believed I wouldn't reach.

I looked at it.

Then at the woman beside me.

Then in the mirror at my brother, my people, the long line of cars carrying every promise we'd been too stubborn to abandon.

A nigga could call that an army if he wanted.

A nigga could call it a procession.

Zero would call it a threat because that nigga had spent his whole life making love look like something he could turn against you.

I called it my people.

Nigga, that was enough to keep my foot on the gas.

Tank came over the radio.

"You see it?"

"I see it."

"Big-ass place."

"Nigga, we got big-ass plans."

Rosa's voice came behind his.

"Tell him no dying before the wedding."

"You heard your woman," I told Tank.

"Nigga, she telling you too."

Shawna took the radio from my hand.

"Both of you heard us."

The whole convoy laughed through the speakers.

Nigga, I smiled so hard my tired face hurt. Tank was laughing. Rosa was laughing. My wife had the radio and was telling every nigga behind us which ones she expected alive at the wedding. Every nigga answered. Loud. Proud. Like the future already knew our names and was just waiting for the cars.

Nigga, let the emperor have his walls.

Let that nigga have every stolen car waiting in the desert, every frightened champion, every throne he'd bought from a man who wanted to live one more day without looking at the price.

I had Shawna's hand on my arm.

I had Tank in the mirror.

I had a Crown in the back of a Rolls-Royce and a wedding waiting at home and a whole line of beautiful dangerous niggas who knew my name before anybody carved it into a chair.

The Last City grew larger.

I drove toward it.

Ten toes down, my nigga.

All the way there.

BOOK VI: TEN TOES DOWN FOREVER

1. The City That Had Never Met Me

The first thing Emperor Zero sent to welcome me was a gold coffin strapped to a Ferrari.

We had stopped outside the distant towers overnight, slept badly, and rearranged the cars at sunrise; Marcellus kept the Crown close, and Mercedes took over Vesper's long black car with Porsche beside her.

The Ferrari came out of the desert with nobody driving it. I watched it through the windshield of my police Lamborghini while Shawna put on lipstick beside me. Behind us, Tank led a convoy long enough that the last car was still having a different morning. We had driven out of Midnight City with kings owing us money, queens waving from balconies, and my wife wearing sunglasses that cost more than my first apartment building. Now some nigga had sent funeral furniture down the highway.

"Baby," Shawna said, "is that for you?"

"Depends what's inside."

"A coffin, Aiden."

"Could be champagne. Rich niggas get weird with presentation."

The Ferrari slowed ahead of us. On its rear window, gold letters lit up.

WELCOME TO YOUR FINAL DESTINATION.

Shawna considered the message, rubbed her lips together, and snapped her mirror shut.

"Spelling's right. He's already smarter than the last one."

I pulled alongside. The coffin lid opened by itself. There was a suit inside, black silk with a white rose on the chest. A photograph of me stood where the head should have been. This nigga had chosen a bad photograph. I looked good in it, obviously, but it was from before I bought my current watch.

"He wants to bury me without my badge," I said.

"You'd make the other dead people nervous."

A loudspeaker crackled.

"Captain Aiden. Your journey ends here."

I leaned toward Shawna's window.

"Nigga, which here? It's a big desert."

A man appeared on the Ferrari's dashboard screen. White suit. Black gloves. Hair swept back like it had its own chauffeur. I knew Emperor Zero's face. Seeing it that small made him look like a man waiting for somebody to answer the doorbell.

"You have mistaken a succession of fortunate accidents for greatness."

"And you mistook a Ferrari for a mail truck. We all learning."

Shawna laughed so hard she had to hold the mirror again.

Zero looked directly at her. That stopped my laughing before it started.

"Mrs. Aiden. I have rooms prepared for both of you. Separate rooms, should you discover a more intelligent attachment."

My wife lowered her sunglasses.

"Nigga, look at your own wife."

"I have no wife."

"We can see that."

The screen went dark.

Behind us, Tank's voice burst over the radio.

"What that nigga want?"

"Me to die dressed like a waiter."

"Tell him you don't do afternoon funerals. Rosa got a headache."

I was still smiling when the hills beside the highway opened fire.

The first bullets knocked sparks from the coffin. The second burst took out the Ferrari's rear tire. Its beautiful ass swung across our lane with death sliding around on the roof, and Shawna caught my arm before I could turn too hard. A black shape came over the ridge. Then another. Six trucks were dropping toward us through curtains of sand.

"Aiden."

"I see them, baby."

"The coffee."

She lifted our cups out of the holders. I hit the accelerator.

We shot beneath the Ferrari's raised coffin lid. Wood split over the windshield. A sleeve from my funeral suit slapped the glass and blew away. I had been dressed for my own death for three seconds and already ruined the outfit.

Tank's Mercedes swerved around the wreck behind us. Rosa leaned out his passenger window with a pistol and a silk scarf holding her hair down. This woman had packed seven evening gowns for a desert war and was already defending all seven.

"Get your niggas off my luggage!" she yelled.

A bullet punched through a truck's mirror. Its driver ducked. Tank bumped the truck hard enough to push it sideways, and the other convoy cars poured past him.

I saw Vesper's car in my mirror, black and long, moving with the smoothness of a hearse that had decided to pursue a music career. Mercedes drove. Porsche was standing through the sunroof holding two phones and one gun. I did not know which item she considered most dangerous.

"Left side clear!" Porsche shouted over the radio. "And whoever keeps calling me from a blocked number, your timing is fucking disgusting!"

The road ahead ended at a bridge suspended over a dry riverbed. Beyond it rose the Last City.

Nigga, I had seen rich. I owned rich. I had slept in rooms where the curtains required their own employee. This city looked like somebody had robbed the sun and built a neighborhood with the evidence. Gold towers shone behind a wall of black stone. A casino shaped like a giant crown sat on a hill. A white palace floated above the center on enormous pillars, with highways running underneath it and planes banking past its windows. Even from miles away, I could see a waterfall falling off a hotel into a swimming pool big enough to have weather.

Shawna stared.

"I want that pool."

"Which one?"

"Yes."

The bridge began to rise.

It split in the middle, its two halves opening like a mouth. On the other side, armored cars appeared beneath the city's gate. Somebody had figured on trapping us between the trucks and the gap. It was an elegant plan for people who did not know who the fuck was driving.

"Tank, bring everybody close."

"How close?"

"Family close."

He understood. The Mercedes moved up behind us. The other cars tightened into two lines. Our enemies were still firing from the ridges, but the loose convoy had become a single glittering animal, and I was the head of that motherfucker.

Shawna looked at the bridge. Then she looked at me.

"You aren't glowing."

"I'm saving it."

"Good. I'd hate to marry a man who needs lightning every time he leaves the house."

I kissed her hand and shifted down.

A garage stood beside the bridge approach. Its roof was covered in solar panels and old racing signs. A woman in grease-stained white trousers ran out carrying a red flag. She had a silver braid, brown skin, and the kind of arms that could fix an engine or break the owner.

"Not the bridge!" she shouted. "The old spillway!"

She pointed right.

I had half a second to decide if the woman was saving us or selling us.

Then she threw a wrench through the window of a truck trying to ram the garage, and I liked her judgment.

"Everybody right!"

We dropped off the highway.

The Lamborghini hit the sloping concrete of the old spillway, bounced hard enough to make the badges on my uniform slap my chest, and tore downhill. Shawna's coffee left its cup in one perfect brown crown. She watched it land on my trousers.

"That's why I bought you two pairs."

Behind us, thirty engines roared into the riverbed.

A truck followed too fast. Its front end struck the lip of the spillway. It pitched forward, bounced twice, and rolled onto its side. Another stopped at the top. Rosa stood on Tank's passenger seat and fired until the niggas inside remembered an urgent appointment somewhere else.

The garage woman jumped onto a motorcycle and came down after us. She caught my side, one hand on the bars, the other pointing toward a narrow channel beneath the city wall.

"That tunnel goes through!" she yelled.

"How low?"

"Lower than your ego!"

"That don't tell me shit!"

She laughed. I liked her more.

We reached the tunnel with half the desert following us. It was an old service passage, wet at the bottom, with rusted gates standing open. My Lamborghini fit with inches to spare. Tank

folded his mirrors against the Mercedes with a curse. The long black car scraped sparks down both walls.

Porsche's voice came through the radio.

"Vesper, your driver is exceptional!"

"I am aware," Vesper said.

"I meant me!" Mercedes snapped.

"I am aware of that also."

The tunnel bent. Daylight flashed ahead. I could hear something above us that sounded like thunder, but it was too regular, too heavy. Engines. Hundreds of them.

We exploded out of the tunnel into the middle of a parade.

Gold motorcycles. Red supercars. Black limousines with flags. A marching band scattered as my police Lamborghini slid across a boulevard and stopped beside a float carrying a fifty-foot statue of Emperor Zero. His statue held the world in one hand. Some nigga had given him very generous shoulders.

The whole street froze.

I got out of my car, coffee on my trousers, dust on my shoulders, and looked up at the statue.

"You build that yourself?"

Nobody answered.

Then Tank came out of the tunnel sideways and knocked the float's tow bar loose.

The statue started rolling.

A brass player screamed. The float drifted toward a fountain, slow and majestic, while six men tried to stop it by pushing the same side. They only helped it turn. Emperor Zero's golden ass hit the fountain wall. The world fell out of his hand and bounced down the boulevard.

Shawna stepped out beside me.

"Well," she said. "We're here."

An old woman on a balcony began to clap.

One clap. Then another. Then a hundred.

A man in a red racing jacket pointed at my badge.

"That's Aiden!"

Nigga, my name traveled down that street faster than the gold globe. People came out of shops. Waiters abandoned tables. Two women jumped off a stationary party bus and ran toward us waving champagne. Somebody started a chant. The marching band, having survived, began playing something triumphant without being asked.

I had entered Zero's city through a drain and received a parade he had already paid for.

"Captain!" a young man yelled.

He was grown, broad-shouldered, maybe twenty-six, wearing a chauffeur's cap under a motorcycle helmet. He reached me holding a bouquet that had probably been intended for a royal mistress.

"My brother saw you race in Monaco. He said you made Cassius Chrome look like he was parking."

"Cassius is my nigga. Don't disrespect him."

"Sorry, Captain."

"But your brother got eyes."

The man laughed and thrust the flowers into my hands. I passed them to Shawna. She smelled them, looked at the fountain, and smiled like a woman deciding where her new city ought to put the furniture.

The garage rider stopped beside us and removed her helmet.

"June Mercury," she said. "Thirty-two. Mechanic. Owner of that garage your enemies tried to turn into a fucking window."

I shook her hand.

"Aiden."

"Nigga, I know."

Tank came up behind me, looked at June, then at the motorcycle.

"You the one put us in that little-ass tunnel?"

"You the one driving a house?"

Rosa stepped out of the Mercedes and pulled him away before he could fall in love with arguing.

Vesper emerged from the long black car. The applause changed when people recognized her. It got deeper, less surprised. Some bowed. Some said her name as if they had not expected to say it without a guard hearing. She stood beside Shawna and let the city look.

"You know these people?" I asked.

"Some. The others know stories."

"Good stories?"

"Ask after lunch."

Two men came out of a watch shop arguing before either of them had reached me.

"Nigga, I told you that was him."

"You said it was the singer."

"The singer is the nigga. The driver is the nigga. The captain is the same fucking nigga."

The second man looked at my badge, then at the Lamborghini, then at Shawna.

"All that one nigga?"

"All this one nigga," I told him.

His friend slapped his shoulder. "See? Nigga verified himself."

Shawna folded her arms, trying not to laugh.

"Don't encourage him."

"Ma'am," the first man said, "your nigga drove through the wall and knocked over the emperor. Encouragement already happened."

"The emperor's statue," I corrected.

"For now," Tank said.

Both men looked at him.

Tank looked back. "What? Niggas got a schedule."

The watch seller took off his apron and held it out toward my trousers.

"Captain, you need something clean."

"Nigga, I'm not putting on your apron."

"To wipe the coffee!"

"Good, because Shawna already got me cooking when I'm famous."

My wife took the apron, cleaned the worst of the stain, and handed it back with a kiss on the man's cheek. The nigga went silent. His friend looked at him, then at me.

"You broke him."

"My wife did that. Separate department of greatness."

The first man finally found his voice.

"Nigga, frame the apron."

His friend nodded. "Already thinking it."

Black armored cars turned the corner. The crowd broke apart, doors opening, hands pulling friends into shops. The band stopped in the middle of a note. Zero's men spread across the street beneath flags with a silver circle on them.

June took one look and swore.

"Ruin's guard."

"Who the fuck is Ruin?"

"A man who thinks engines should kneel."

"That nigga's about to have a terrible day."

The lead armored car stopped. A tall man stepped out wearing a white driving suit and black sunglasses. There was a silver slash through one eyebrow. He carried no visible gun, which meant he either believed in conversation or had enough niggas around him to outsource it.

"Captain Aiden," he said. "Roland Ruin. His Imperial Majesty welcomes you."

I pointed at the wrecked statue.

"Tell him thanks for the ride."

His jaw moved once. He looked past me at Shawna, Vesper, the convoy, and the people hiding behind shop windows. I watched him count the cost of shooting in front of all those witnesses.

"You will accompany me to the palace."

"We need breakfast."

"The emperor does not wait."

"Then the emperor should've eaten before we got here."

Behind me, Tank made a noise so disrespectful it should have required a second mouth.

Roland took off his sunglasses.

"You have a reputation. I suggest you enjoy its final hour."

"Nigga, I been enjoying it since yesterday. You late."

His men raised their weapons.

Mine raised theirs.

For a second the whole boulevard held still. A flower petal slid off Shawna's bouquet and landed on my shoe. June's motorcycle ticked as it cooled. Somewhere inside a shop, a childless wedding display kept playing a love song to mannequins while forty grown men considered dying outside it.

Shawna touched my wrist.

I knew that touch. Not fear. A request. There were people in those shops, people who had clapped for me before knowing if I could keep them alive.

I took my badge off my chest and held it up.

"Roland. Look at this."

He did.

"You know what this means?"

"It means Las Vegas has poor judgment."

"It means I'm on duty. And right now you're obstructing my honeymoon."

"Your honeymoon?"

"It's a long marriage. We take breaks."

I stepped forward.

His men tightened their grips. Mine moved with me. Roland's expression changed, just a little, when he understood that I was going to walk right up to him with a whole war waiting behind my shoulders.

"You can have your palace meeting," I said. "Tomorrow. Tonight my people eat, sleep, and wash the desert off. Your niggas follow us into our hotel, I'm arresting every last one of them in front of whatever emperor you're renting your spine to."

"You cannot arrest an imperial guard."

"I never attended college either. Life's full of surprises."

June laughed before she could stop herself.

Roland looked at her. I moved half an inch, enough to take his eyes back.

"Me, nigga. We talking."

He held my stare. Then he smiled, slow and cold.

"Tomorrow, then. The emperor enjoys a guest who remains entertaining."

"Buy him a television."

He put his sunglasses on and stepped into the armored car.

They withdrew without firing. The crowd did not immediately return. People waited until the last black vehicle vanished before they dared believe we had stayed alive.

Then the old woman on the balcony clapped again.

I looked up.

"Ma'am, you started all this."

She threw me a white handkerchief.

"For the coffee, handsome!"

Shawna caught it first.

"Thank you! He needs supervision!"

June led us toward the Crownless Hotel, an enormous sandstone place built around a courtyard full of date palms and black cars.

Its owner came running down the steps in slippers, kissed Vesper's hand, shook mine twice, and offered us the entire top floor before learning how many niggas we had brought.

When he learned, he offered the second floor too.

"Captain," he said, looking at my Lamborghini, "would you permit us to display your arrival photograph in the lobby?"

"Make sure my good side in it."

He stared at me, honestly troubled.

"How would I choose?"

Tank bent over laughing.

I liked this fucking city.

June caught me before I reached the elevator. She had washed her hands, but black grease remained under her nails. In the lobby light I could see a scar on her chin and a tiny gold engine hanging from her neck.

"My garage," she said. "You should know what that was."

"A garage. I been to one."

"My father's. Then mine. Zero wants the ground under it for another road to his palace. He offered me a room in a hotel and a job repairing his cars."

"You tell him no?"

"I told him where to park the hotel."

"That's my kind of negotiation."

She smiled, then stopped. "My partner Adrian is still there. He won't leave the lifts. Says nobody steals a man's wrench while he's breathing."

I turned to Tank.

"Send two cars. Bring him and whatever he can carry."

"The nigga's gonna try to carry a lift," June said.

"Then send three."

Tank put his phone to his ear. Just like that, Adrian had more friends than he had possessed five minutes earlier.

June looked at me as if I had done something strange.

"You don't know us."

"I know you put my wife through a tunnel instead of a grave. That's plenty."

For the first time since the road, she had no answer. She rubbed the little engine between her fingers and looked away at the lobby fountain.

The hotel owner approached with a velvet box. Inside was a gold room key the size of a dagger.

"The imperial suite, Captain. We have renamed it."

"Already?"

"The engraver was having lunch downstairs."

AIDEN'S SUITE shone on the handle.

"Nigga," Tank whispered, "we been here eleven minutes."

I took the key. "People recognize quality."

June shook her head, smiling now with all her teeth. "If you live through this, I want to build you a car."

"If you build it right, living through shit comes included."

She held out her greasy hand again. I shook it again. The hotel owner watched a black mark land on his golden key and looked so honored I thought he might frame that too.

Our suite looked over the boulevard and, beyond it, the emperor's palace. Shawna walked through the rooms with the flowers in her arms. She checked the bedroom, the bath, the balcony. Then she came back to where I stood and opened my shirt.

"Any new holes?"

"Only emotional ones. That nigga picked the wrong funeral suit."

Her fingers found the old scar in my side. She kissed my chest above the cross and stayed there for a moment.

Outside, our people were unloading bags. Tank was arguing with a bellhop about whether a gun case counted as luggage. Rosa wanted a piano. Mercedes wanted a better parking space.

Porsche wanted whoever had called from a blocked number to have the courage to do it again.

My wife looked up at me.

"One last city."

"Then Vegas."

"Then the wedding."

"Then you."

"You already have me."

I held her tighter.

"Nigga, that's how I know I'm winning."

She laughed against my mouth, and I kissed her while the emperor's palace glittered outside like a place that had never learned what happened when a man came for his people.

Down in the street, somebody had dragged the fallen gold globe to the hotel entrance.

They had painted my name across it.

2. Two Queens and a Stolen Ballroom

By six o'clock, our hotel had become the most expensive bad decision in the Last City.

There were race cars in the courtyard, guns on the billiard tables, and three women arguing with a florist over whether white roses were romantic or evidence that a nigga had given up. Rosa stood on the piano in the ballroom wearing a green dress and directing furniture like she had conquered the building herself. Tank held her shoes. The pianist, a grown man with gray hair, kept looking at her feet as if God had finally answered a very specific prayer.

"Nobody sits with their back to that window," Rosa announced.

"Why?" the owner asked.

"Because I just paid to have my hair done and we in a city full of shooters."

He moved the chairs personally.

I came downstairs in black trousers, a white shirt, my shoulder holster, and the captain's badge hanging against my chest. The blood money years had taught me how to dress for dinner. Police work had taught me that the gun should match.

Shawna came down behind me wearing blue.

Nigga, some colors belong to everybody until the right woman walks into them. Then you realize the rest of the world had only been borrowing. Her dress moved like water around her legs. Dante's watch sat on her wrist. My ring shone on her hand. She looked at the ballroom, then at the crowd looking at her, and smiled without asking any of them for permission.

I forgot the thing I had been saying.

"Captain?" the hotel owner prompted.

"Give me a minute."

"Of course."

"Maybe two."

He understood. Every nigga in the room understood.

Vesper stood by the doors in burgundy silk, speaking to a silver-haired woman whose black gown looked capable of inheriting property. The older woman watched us approach with a small smile. She carried a cane topped by a pearl. I had seen enough royal women to know the cane was either a weapon or an excuse to hit somebody with a weapon.

"Aiden," Vesper said. "Magnolia Saint-Clair. My old tutor."

"Not that old," Magnolia said. "Sixty-four is an excellent age for disapproving of emperors."

She offered me her hand. I kissed it because my mother had raised me intermittently but effectively.

"A captain, a king, and he remembers manners," Magnolia said.

"Vesper, you should have brought him years ago."

"I was busy," I said.

"Doing what?"

"Becoming all that shit."

She laughed. A clean, wicked laugh. I liked her immediately.

Shawna took her other hand. "I'm his wife."

"Yes, dear. He looked at you as if somebody had opened the sun.

I worked it out."

Magnolia led us toward a table under a chandelier shaped like falling rain. Vesper sat beside her. Shawna sat beside me. Two queens and a woman who had probably slapped a king with a dictionary. I had entered the room thinking I was in charge of dinner.

Then Mercedes arrived carrying a bottle of champagne in each hand.

"The women downstairs want to know if this is a private party."

"Who downstairs?" Shawna asked.

"The women Zero paid to welcome his motor champions. Their bus driver saw Aiden's cars and came here instead."

I looked toward the door.

A line of grown women in glittering dresses stood behind Porsche, who was arranging them by who needed a drink most urgently. Some were dancers. Some were escorts. One carried a violin. Another carried a little dog wearing diamonds, and the dog had the expression of a nigga who knew he would never pay rent.

"We're happy to be confused," the violinist said.

"Then welcome," I told her.

They came in cheering.

The pianist found a rhythm. Rosa came down from the piano and took the microphone. Tank put her shoes at her feet as if presenting a queen with two very small thrones.

"My man," she said into the microphone, "has spent this whole trip claiming he can't dance."

Tank looked at me.

"Don't help her."

"Nigga, I'm the police. I can't obstruct an investigation."

Rosa held out her hand.

Tank went to her.

He danced like a refrigerator being taught to trust love. Slowly at first. One hand too high. One foot trying to move to a song nobody else could hear. Rosa whispered something in his ear. He laughed, relaxed, and found her rhythm.

The room changed around them. People still drank and talked, but they watched those two with the kind of attention you give something that nearly did not survive long enough to happen.

Shawna laid her head against my shoulder.

"He's practicing."

"For the wedding?"

"For being happy without looking over your shoulder every second."

I looked over mine.

She pinched my leg.

"Aiden."

"Somebody gotta do it."

Magnolia waited until Rosa began singing before she leaned toward us.

"Zero has asked every hotel in the city to report your visitors."

"This one gonna need more paper," I said.

"He also recalled the airport landing permissions. Your friends may find arriving difficult."

I took out my phone.

There were eleven messages from Cassius Chrome. The first said he had landed. The second said customs wanted his cars. The third was a photograph of him standing on a crate with his

arms folded. The fourth read: BROTHER I HAVE BEEN PATIENT FOR ALMOST NINE MINUTES.

I called him.

"Where you at?"

"A warehouse beside the airport. They say my fleet is imperial property."

"You show them your paperwork?"

"I showed them my face. They remained confused."

"Who with you?"

"Inez."

In the background, I heard a man yell.

Cassius sighed.

"She has begun explaining."

"Nigga, tell her leave something for me."

I stood up. Shawna stood with me.

Magnolia smiled into her glass.

"Dinner before the battle would have been conventional."

"Save our plates," Shawna told her.

Vesper rose. "I know the airport director."

"That good?" I asked.

"For us."

Tank was still dancing when I reached him. He saw my face, kissed Rosa, and stepped back into his shoes like somebody had rung the bell on a champion.

"Who we getting?"

"Cassius and Inez."

"What they do?"

"Arrived too rich."

"Nigga, that's discrimination."

June came out of the courtyard with Adrian, her partner. He was thirty-five, lean, with a shaved head and a little beard that made him look like he had strong opinions about engines. Our men had brought him safely through the old service route, along with three tool chests and, somehow, half a motorcycle.

"You going to the airport?" he asked.

"Apparently."

"Take the eastern road. Main gate has an armored checkpoint."

June shook her head. "Eastern road has two."

I looked between them.

"Which one got better scenery?"

They stared.

Shawna picked up my jacket. "Main gate. He likes an entrance."

We took four cars. Me and Shawna in the Lamborghini. Tank and Rosa in the Mercedes because she had refused to stay behind while her friends were detained. Vesper rode with Mercedes and Porsche. June and Adrian brought a vicious little silver coupe that looked like it had been built during an argument.

At the airport gate, a man in a black uniform held up his hand. I stopped close enough that he could admire the badge on my hood.

"The airport is closed."

"Then open it."

"To unauthorized arrivals."

"I'm a departure from your usual bullshit. Move."

He looked at Shawna, then at the cars behind us. A second guard approached holding a tablet. My photograph was on the screen with a red border around it.

"You are expected," he said.

"See? Nigga got the invitation."

The barrier rose.

Shawna watched the first guard step aside.

"Too easy."

"Maybe my smile working."

"It works on me. I still know when you're lying."

Inside the cargo yard, a dozen supercars sat under floodlights. Red, silver, black, blue. Cassius stood on the hood of a white truck in a purple racing jacket, applauding slowly as I drove in. Inez leaned against a yellow car with her arms folded. Three guards lay on the ground near her, awake and reconsidering their employment.

"My brother!" Cassius called. "You brought the police!"

I got out.

"Nigga, I am the police."

"Exactly what I told them. They asked for a local authority."

Vesper stepped out of her car.

The airport director, a round man with a red face, stopped speaking before he finished turning toward her.

"Your Majesty."

"Director Pell."

"I had no idea these were your guests."

"You had several ideas. Most of them were poor."

She held out her hand for the keys.

Before he could move, the warehouse doors behind him slammed shut.

Floodlights snapped on across the roof. A voice rolled over the yard.

"Captain. I hoped you would bring the whole family."

Roland Ruin stood on a balcony above the loading bays.

Of course that nigga had found a balcony. Men like him believed height was a personality.

He wore his white driving suit again, now open at the throat. A line of Black Mantle guards appeared beside him. Their rifles pointed down at us.

Cassius looked up, then at me.

"I dislike this airport."

"One star," I said.

Roland smiled.

"You may leave. Your vehicles remain."

"You can keep that ugly truck," I told him.

Cassius looked down at the hood beneath his feet.

"It is a rental."

"Even better."

A shot struck the pavement by my shoe.

The whole yard moved.

Shawna pulled Vesper behind the Lamborghini. Tank shoved Rosa toward a concrete pillar. I drew and fired at the balcony as

Cassius jumped off the truck. The guards ducked. Inez was already moving between the cars, low and fast, keys flying from her hand to mine.

"Silver one!" she shouted.

I caught them without looking.

June's little coupe roared across the yard and struck a stack of empty pallets. Wood scattered. Adrian leaned out and fired toward the warehouse windows. The distraction gave Cassius enough time to pull a door open on the nearest race car.

"Everybody drives!" I yelled.

"Aiden!" Shawna called.

I turned.

She had taken the Lamborghini's wheel. My wife looked at the silver car, then at me.

"Keep up."

Nigga, she drove away before I could fall more in love.

I jumped into the silver car. It smelled of new leather and expensive gasoline. The engine woke like a predator hearing its own name. Across the dashboard, a small plaque read CHROME SPECIAL NUMBER ONE.

"Cassius!" I shouted into the radio. "This yours?"

"Was."

"What?"

"I brought you a gift. Try not to put bullets in the seats."

I laughed and hit the gas.

The car shot forward so hard I felt my stomach stay in customs. Bullets cracked off the yard around me. I swerved behind a cargo loader, came out beside the white rental truck, and saw Roland descending a staircase at the far end of the warehouse. He had a black racing car waiting below.

That nigga thought he was leaving his own party early.

I swung the silver car around the truck, followed Shawna beneath the balcony, and cut toward the staircase. Roland fired through his open door. A bullet took my mirror. I returned two shots through the empty stretch ahead of him, enough to make him drop into his seat and pull away before his guard could join him.

Tank rammed the front barrier with a cargo tractor.

I did not know where he had found a cargo tractor. I had stopped asking where Tank found heavy things. Some men had guardian angels. Mine had industrial equipment.

The barrier folded. Rosa stood beside him in the little cab, still holding the microphone she had carried out of the ballroom by mistake.

"Ladies and gentlemen," she shouted into it, "we will be leaving this raggedy-ass airport!"

We left in a river of stolen-back luxury.

Roland took the outer service road. I followed. Shawna came up on my left, blue police lights spinning over the Lamborghini. Behind her, Cassius and Inez moved together, two bright blades in the night.

A plane rolled across the taxiway ahead of us.

Roland accelerated toward it.

"He going under the wing," Cassius said.

"Then so am I."

"Your roof is higher."

"Nigga, don't make me nervous after giving me the car."

I lowered my head anyway.

The black car slipped beneath the plane's wing. My silver roof cleared it by so little I could hear the air change. On the other side, Roland swung sharply onto a narrow ramp. I followed, tires singing. Shawna took the wider route around the plane and came out ahead of us.

She blocked the exit.

Roland braked.

I closed behind him.

For one second we had the nigga between husband and wife, which is where all his decisions had been trying to put him since morning.

He looked from her car to mine.

Then he drove through a glass terminal wall.

The crash flashed white under the lights. Glass burst into the empty lounge. His car tore between rows of seats, climbed a shallow staircase, and vanished through another window into the passenger pickup lane.

I could have followed.

Then I saw the cleaner standing inside the terminal, frozen beside a cart, with a falling metal sign swinging above him.

I stopped.

Shawna stopped too.

I ran through the broken wall, grabbed the man by the shoulder, and pulled him clear as the sign came down hard enough to fold his cart in half. He clung to my shirt, shaking. A grown man, fifty maybe, with tired eyes and rubber gloves.

"You all right?"

He looked at the wreckage. Then at me.

"My cart."

"We'll get you a new one."

"It was a good cart."

"Nigga, I'm buying you an excellent cart."

He laughed once, shocked to hear himself do it.

Cassius came through the doorway and surveyed the destruction.

"Roland escaped?"

"Yeah."

He looked at the man in my arms, then nodded.

"Good brakes on that car."

"Best part so far."

We took the cleaner with us. His name was Omar. He had a wife at home who, according to him, would never believe any of this unless she saw the cars. So we drove him to the hotel, gave him dinner, and put him in a video call with his wife while Rosa sang behind him and Tank held the new car keys against his chest like a jeweler presenting diamonds.

His wife believed him immediately.

"Omar," she said, "don't let that handsome captain leave before I get there."

Shawna raised her glass at the phone.

"You can look."

"I have been married thirty years. Looking is my vacation."

The ballroom roared.

Omar's wife arrived twenty minutes later with a handbag big enough to discipline a whole household. She saw him beside Tank and stopped with both hands on her hips.

"Nigga, you went to clean an airport."

"I did clean some of it."

"Now you eating with the nigga on television."

"He came through the window."

"Aiden came through your window?"

"A car came through first. Then that nigga came through."

Tank nodded. "That's usually how you know he's close."

She looked at me.

"Captain, this nigga has been telling me for thirty years that nothing interesting happens at work."

"Ma'am, he was saving it."

Omar stood to embrace her. She hit his arm once, then held him for so long the whole table learned why the nigga had wanted to get home.

When she let go, he pointed toward the courtyard.

"They got me a new cart."

"Nigga, forget the cart. You alive."

"It's got a little motor."

She paused.

"A motor?"

"June fixed it."

His wife looked at June, who lifted her glass without apology.

"This nigga gonna drive it around our kitchen," the woman said.

"Only on weekends," Omar promised.

"Nigga, I know you."

I leaned toward Shawna. "That's marriage."

She kissed my cheek. "That is exactly marriage."

I sat beside my wife with dust in my hair and a silver car outside that had been a gift for less than twenty minutes before surviving an airfield gunfight. Inez stole a piece of bread off Cassius's plate. He pretended to object, then moved the whole basket toward her.

Magnolia studied them over her wine.

"Another wedding?"

"Drive slowly," Inez told her.

Cassius smiled into his glass.

The violinist approached our table with her instrument under one arm and a plate of food in her hand. Up close she had a little silver scar through one eyebrow and a look that said she had heard men promise things in several languages.

"Sienna," she said. "Thirty-one. I play violin, drive boats, and occasionally make rich men believe they're interesting."

"Busy woman," Shawna said.

"Depends how rich."

She sat when Shawna moved a chair for her.

"Those other women are my friends. We worked the emperor's private parties. The motor champions paid, but the palace decided when we could leave. Tonight I told the driver the wrong address."

Mercedes appeared beside her with fresh glasses. "I knew that nigga hadn't got lost. He took every turn like he'd rehearsed an escape."

"He had," Sienna said. "For two weeks. Our brother doesn't like leaving either of us behind. My sister plays cello. She's upstairs changing."

I looked toward the door where the women had first gathered. The little dog slept on a silk cushion, wearing enough jewelry to retire a bank manager. One of the dancers was teaching Tank a turn while Rosa laughed at both of them. Everybody had arrived carrying a different reason for wanting to stay.

"Palace coming for you?" I asked.

"Probably."

"Then they know where to find me."

Sienna studied me. "You always say shit like that?"

"Only when I'm awake."

She smiled, but her fingers tightened around the violin's neck. Shawna noticed. She set her glass down and put a hand over Sienna's.

"There's enough room upstairs," my wife said. "You and your friends decide what you want tomorrow. Tonight you eat."

Sienna looked at her for a moment. Then she began eating, fast at first, until she remembered nobody was taking the plate.

The pianist asked whether she would play with Rosa.

She swallowed, wiped her mouth, and stood.

"One song. Then I want cake."

Nigga, that woman put the whole desert inside four strings. The ballroom quieted. Her sister came down with the cello and joined before anyone could ask. Rosa listened for a verse, then found a melody above them, her voice low and rough and full of everything she did not usually explain.

Tank stopped moving.

I watched him watch her. His big hands rested on the back of a chair. He looked almost frightened by how much he loved the woman singing under that chandelier.

"You good?" I asked when he came beside me.

"Yeah."

"Your face look otherwise."

He rubbed his jaw. "I'm just thinking about that day, man. Her in the dress. All these niggas watching me try not to cry."

"Cry, then."

He stared.

"I'm bringing sunglasses," I added. "For both of us."

Tank laughed and leaned his shoulder against mine. Across the room, Rosa saw us standing together and sang the next line straight at him.

My brother smiled like the whole war could wait until she finished.

Vesper returned from the terrace carrying a folded note. She laid it beside my plate.

"From Roland."

I opened it.

TOMORROW. THE EMPEROR'S TABLE. COME WITHOUT YOUR ARMY.

Underneath, in a different hand, someone had added:

I HAVE NEVER SEEN ANYONE DRIVE LIKE THAT.

I passed it to Shawna.

She read both lines and shook her head.

"Your enemies keep writing you fan mail."

"Niggas recognize a man doing his job."

She kissed me in front of the whole room.

Outside, the Last City lit up another thousand windows.

Somewhere behind them, Zero was planning my death. Inside our ballroom, my friends began arguing about which car should carry Tank and Rosa away from their wedding.

I listened to them like a man listening to his future arrive early.

3. Captain of the Whole Fucking Sky

Victor Voltage called while I was in the bath.

I answered because some niggas only call from the sky when the sky is about to become a problem.

"Aiden," he said, "how attached are you to that hotel roof?"

I sat up.

Shawna looked over from the mirror. She had one earring in and the expression of a woman whose husband had just heard the opening sentence of another emergency.

"What happened?" I asked.

"Minor difficulty with the aircraft."

Behind him, somebody shouted, "WE HAVE LOST THE OTHER ENGINE!"

Victor covered the phone badly.

"I am talking to Aiden!"

I stood, water running off me.

"Nigga, what other engine?"

"The second one."

"How many did you start with?"

"Two."

Shawna threw me a towel.

"Tell him breakfast is getting cold."

I heard Seraphine Storm's voice over the phone, calm enough to make the shouting around her sound rude.

"Captain, we are over the western quarter. The emperor's men have fired upon our transport. Victor has kept us aloft longer than the pilot believed possible. He has approximately three minutes of strength left."

"What you flying?"

"A university transport."

"How big?"

"We brought gifts."

Nigga, I knew then it was a big fucking plane.

I dressed in pieces while running. Shawna buttoned my shirt in the elevator. Tank met us in the lobby carrying two coffees and a gun bag. He looked at my wet hair.

"You shower during that phone call?"

"Other way around."

June was already outside, staring west.

A white aircraft hung above the city with one wing trailing smoke. Lightning flashed around its nose. Victor was

somewhere up there putting his whole body between a school full of presents and the ground.

Seraphine came back on the phone.

"There is an unfinished exhibition hall south of your hotel. Its roof is broad enough for an emergency landing, but there are cranes in the approach."

I looked at June.

She pointed before I asked.

"Glass building. Half mile."

"Get everybody out of its way."

"Everybody?"

"Nigga, the plane got gifts."

We took the silver Chrome Special because it was closest and because a nigga should occasionally thank a friend by putting his gift through terrible stress. Shawna came with me. Tank and June followed. The morning traffic scattered around our lights, drivers leaning out to cheer until they looked up and remembered the sky could fall.

The exhibition hall stood beside a dry canal. Its enormous roof shone beneath three construction cranes. Workers ran across the forecourt, pointing at the plane. A security guard tried to stop me at the entrance, saw the aircraft, and decided his barrier did not pay enough.

I drove straight into the hall.

The place was empty except for scaffolding, marble crates, and a ridiculous gold model of Zero's palace. My tires squealed across polished stone. We went through a set of unfinished doors and onto a sloping service ramp that climbed toward the roof.

Shawna held the dashboard.

"Does this go all the way?"

"About to."

"Aiden."

"Baby, I got confidence."

"I would love some information to go with it."

The ramp ended on an open terrace one floor below the roof.

For a second, I had too much information.

Then I saw the scaffolding bridge connecting the terrace to the crane platform.

"There."

"That isn't a road."

"Nigga, it is today."

We hit the narrow bridge. Metal shuddered beneath the tires. A board snapped behind us. I kept the car straight while Shawna watched the far end with her jaw set. We climbed onto the crane

platform just as the plane dropped low enough to blot out the sun.

Victor hung beneath its nose, bright with electricity, one hand braced against the fuselage. His whole body shook. I could see him now. The nigga looked like a man trying to bench-press a terrible decision made by an airline.

"Victor!"

He turned his head.

Even from up there, I saw him grin.

"You brought the new car!"

"Cassius gonna be pissed if you land on it!"

The plane lurched. Victor's grin vanished.

I could not hold a plane. Blue Thunder did not make me a god. It gave me a few fierce moments when my body could conduct something stronger than it ought to survive. I had learned the price at Sky High. Every time I spent it, my hands shook afterward like the strength had taken the bones with it.

But I could give my friend a moment.

I looked at Shawna.

She already knew.

"Enough to help him," she said. "Then you let go."

I kissed her once.

"Get down behind the wall."

She got out, took the emergency flare from the car, and ran toward the roof's far edge to guide the pilot. I stepped onto the hood.

Blue light crawled between my fingers.

Nigga, it hurt before it became beautiful. The old scar in my side tightened. My teeth pressed together. I reached up as Victor brought the plane over the crane platform, low enough that its belly filled my world.

For one breath our hands met.

His lightning met mine.

The air cracked blue.

The plane lifted just enough to clear the first crane. Victor shouted. I shouted back. There was no clever shit in it, no king speech, just two niggas refusing to let go of their people at the same time.

Then I pushed the last of my charge through him and dropped to one knee on the hood.

"Go!"

Victor moved with the aircraft. Its wheels struck the broad roof hard enough to throw dust from the seams. Shawna stood at the far end waving the flare. The pilot turned toward her light. One wing clipped a hanging sheet of construction fabric. The fabric

wrapped around it like a bride's veil on the ugliest wedding of all time.

The plane slid.

A crane cable snapped.

I heard Tank yelling below.

The aircraft stopped with its nose hanging over the far edge of the roof.

For a second, nothing moved.

Then its door opened.

Dean Seraphine Storm stepped out wearing a white traveling suit and carrying a bouquet.

She looked across the roof at me kneeling on a silver car.

"Captain," she called, "your practical work remains exceptional."

I tried to answer. What came out was mostly breathing.

Shawna ran back to me. She caught my elbow before I could pretend I did not need help.

"Sit."

"I am sitting."

"On the ground. You keep choosing expensive things to collapse on."

She got me off the hood and into the passenger seat. My hands trembled so badly she had to open the water bottle for me. I hated that. I loved that she did it without turning it into a speech.

Victor stumbled across the roof toward us. His uniform was scorched. His hair stood up in seven directions, six of which appeared physically impossible.

He bent and hugged me through the open door.

"My nigga."

"You heavy as shit."

"That is gratitude you feel."

"Feels like a grown man in my lap."

Shawna laughed, and Victor laughed, and for a moment the fact that we were all alive was loud enough to drown out the broken plane.

Then bullets struck the roof wall.

Of course. Zero's niggas could not allow a reunion to have decent lighting without firing at it.

Black Mantle guards were climbing the service stairs on the far side of the building. More vehicles stopped in the forecourt below. They had watched the plane come down and come to collect whatever survived.

Seraphine set the bouquet carefully inside the plane's doorway.

"Victor," she said, "rest."

"Dean, I can—"

"That was not a question."

She raised one hand.

The air above the roof tightened. Loose cloth lifted. Dust spun into a pale circle around her shoes. The first guard reached the stair top and found the wind had opinions about his arrival. He flew backward into the men behind him. Their guns clattered down the steps.

Tank appeared at the other staircase with Rosa and June behind him.

"Aiden! How many fucking floors you need?"

"Ask the architect!"

He ran to the plane. Rosa followed with a medical bag she had taken from Vega downstairs. I had not even seen the doctor arrive; apparently she had been summoned by the universal signal of me doing something stupid at altitude.

Passengers began coming out of the transport. All grown, all rattled. A Sky High music instructor carried two instrument cases. A faculty cook held a covered tray against his chest. An enormous instructor in a purple coat emerged with a wedding cake box so large it needed handles.

"That better not be our cake," Rosa said.

"A sample," the cook replied, offended. "The final cake would never travel in these conditions."

Tank stared at the box.

"Nigga, that's a sample?"

I laughed, then regretted laughing because every muscle in my chest had joined a union against me.

The guards fired again from a neighboring rooftop. Seraphine turned, keeping the wind between the passengers and the shots. She could protect the roof or help unload the plane, but not both forever. Victor tried to stand. Shawna pushed him back beside me.

"You two saved it once. Let somebody else have a fucking turn."

Then she took my gun bag and went to Tank.

My wife and my brother moved to the far wall together. Tank covered the neighboring roof. Shawna fired at the light above its doorway, bursting the glass and forcing the guards back into the dark stairwell behind it. June found a construction cart and began loading cases onto it. Rosa got the shaken passengers moving toward our stairs, speaking to them like they were late for rehearsal and she would not accept excuses.

I watched the people I loved handle the world while my hands shook in my lap.

Victor sat beside me on the pavement, leaning against the tire.

"It is difficult," he said.

"What?"

"Being temporarily less impressive."

"Speak for yourself. I'm still handsome."

"Yes. It is extremely irritating."

I held out the water. He drank, wiped his mouth, and passed it back.

"You knew I'd come?" he asked.

"To the desert?"

"To the end."

I looked at him. Under the scorched uniform and ridiculous hair was the same proud nigga who had once wanted to beat me so badly he could barely stand beside me. Now he had crossed an ocean in a plane full of wedding presents because he knew I was walking into the last fight.

"Yeah," I said. "I knew."

He nodded once. Then the nigga ruined the dignified moment by pointing at my wet hair.

"Were you bathing when I called?"

"Yeah."

"This nigga got out of a bath to save me."

"Nigga, don't make it sound intimate. There was a plane."

"An entire plane," Victor agreed. "The nigga was not even dry."

"You want a certificate?"

"I want the school to know. They will add it to the painting."

I looked at him. "What painting?"

Victor grinned.

"Dean Storm commissioned a portrait for the main hall. Captain Aiden above the clouds. Very dignified."

"Nigga, what am I wearing?"

"Your uniform."

"Good. Because you telling everybody about the bath like some nigga about to paint my ass."

Victor laughed until he had to put a hand over his ribs.

"The faculty argued over the inscription."

"What they choose?"

"A Man Above Us All."

I considered that.

"Accurate niggas."

"One professor suggested Outstanding Attendance."

"That nigga knows comedy."

Victor wiped his eyes. "You would have liked the meeting. They spent forty minutes arguing about how much larger than life to make you."

"Nigga, start with actual size. Work from there."

He leaned his head against the tire and smiled into the morning.

I passed him the water again. This time his hands were steadier. Mine were too.

Two exhausted niggas beneath a plane, arguing about a painting neither of us had asked for. I would have come out of a thousand baths for that.

Down below, an armored truck crashed through the exhibition hall's front doors.

The floor shook.

June looked over the edge and swore. "They're inside."

The stairs were our way out. The guards were coming up them. Seraphine's wind lashed the roof, but she could not reach inside the building without letting the shooters across the street have us.

I flexed my fingers.

Nothing. No blue light. Only pain and a weak twitch.

Shawna saw.

"Don't."

"I wasn't."

"I know your face."

"Nigga, everybody knows my face. It's famous."

She ignored that and pointed at the silver car.

"Can you drive?"

I looked from the car to the scaffolding bridge.

"With you yelling directions?"

"Always."

We loaded the most shaken passengers into the faculty transport carts that had come out of the cargo hold. Of course Sky High had brought little electric cars inside its big electric emergency. Seraphine covered their crossing as June drove the first one onto the scaffolding bridge. Tank carried the cake sample himself, because some priorities survive war.

Shawna got behind the wheel of my silver car.

"Move over."

I obeyed. Nigga, loving a woman gives her certain privileges over your most expensive possessions and all your least sensible ideas.

She drove us across the swaying bridge while bullets chipped the concrete behind us. Victor lay across the back seats muttering that he would never complain about legroom again. At the terrace, Shawna turned sharply down the ramp.

Below, the armored truck blocked the exhibition hall.

Its driver saw us coming and swung toward the ramp.

Shawna did not slow.

"Baby."

"I see him."

"Baby."

"I married you. I know a bad approach when I see one."

She drove up the sloping side of a marble crate. The silver car tilted onto two wheels. For one impossible second we balanced against the crate while the armored truck passed beneath our raised side. I could see the driver's astonished face through his windshield.

He looked at my wife like he had just discovered a second Aiden and did not have enough bullets for the information.

Then we landed on all four tires and tore through the hall's broken doors.

Victor sat up just enough to shout.

"Mrs. Aiden!"

"Seat belt!" she shouted back.

We reached the hotel with our people, the gifts, the cake sample, and a piece of the plane's fabric still caught in Tank's collar. The

courtyard filled with cheers. Cassius ran toward the silver car, saw the new scratches, and put a hand over his heart.

"My gift."

"Your gift saved a plane," I told him.

He looked at Shawna.

She raised an eyebrow.

"And I drove it home."

Cassius bowed so deeply Inez slapped the back of his head.

Vega made me sit in a quiet room with Victor for an hour. She examined my hands, checked my pulse, and told me that if I tried to summon more lightning before I could hold a glass steadily, she would have Tank sit on me.

"That medically necessary?" I asked.

"For my peace of mind."

Seraphine came in carrying the bouquet from the plane.

Somehow it had survived with only three petals missing. She placed it in Shawna's hands.

"For your wedding renewal. I wished to bring them personally."

Shawna looked down at the flowers.

"You could have mailed them."

"My dear, your husband would have found that insufficiently dramatic."

I lifted a finger. "She's right."

The dean turned to me. Her expression softened.

"You have assembled a remarkable family, Captain."

Through the open door, I could hear Tank arguing that a sample cake should be sampled by somebody. Rosa was defending it. Mercedes was asking the music instructor if he knew anything filthy. Porsche was telling the hotel owner that a rooftop piano would improve the mood. June and Adrian were describing Shawna's two-wheel stunt to Inez, who kept looking into the room at my wife with growing professional respect.

"Yeah," I said. "I know."

Seraphine took a sealed envelope from her coat.

"The academy sent something else."

I opened it. A photograph slid out: Sky High floating above the clouds, our whole class on the steps, me in the center wearing the captain's badge like the school had been built around it.

On the back, every instructor had signed a message.

At the bottom, Victor had written one line larger than the rest.

IF HE GETS HIMSELF KILLED, I AM GOING TO BE VERY ANGRY.

I looked at him across the room.

The nigga shrugged.

"Motivation."

I folded the photograph carefully and put it inside my jacket, beside the cross.

A siren sounded in the courtyard.

Not the emperor's siren. Mine had a different kind of arrogance.

I went to the window with Shawna's hand on my elbow. Six dark-blue vehicles rolled through the hotel gates, their lights spinning over the palms. The lead car stopped beside my Lamborghini. Chief Gloria Knox stepped out wearing a white uniform, a gold badge, and sunglasses that reflected an entire hotel full of her favorite mistakes.

She looked up at the window.

"Captain!"

"Chief!"

"Why is there an airplane on a shopping center?"

"Exhibition hall!"

"That clears it right up!"

She came upstairs with two officers carrying suitcases. One case held clothes. The other held a ceremonial sword that Las Vegas apparently believed I needed because regular weapons had failed to express its affection.

Knox embraced Shawna first. Then she took my face between both hands and examined me like a mother who had raised a department instead of a child.

"You look tired."

"Saved a plane."

"I saw. Somebody filmed you from a crane. The city council watched it six times."

"They should've been helping."

"They voted to name a road after you."

"I already got one."

"They voted for a better road."

Victor laughed from the couch.

Knox looked at him. "And you're the young man who held it up."

He sat straighter. "Victor Voltage."

"Excellent work. We are considering a roundabout."

"I would accept a tasteful one."

She nodded seriously, then turned back to me.

"I brought twelve volunteers. All grown, all armed, all aware you attract trouble like a free bar attracts off-duty police. They are downstairs helping your people secure the hotel."

"Zero let you through?"

"He tried to charge an arrival tax."

"You pay it?"

She stared at me over her sunglasses.

Nigga, I had forgotten who I was talking to.

"The border captain now owes me money," she said.

Shawna laughed and hugged her again.

Knox set the sword on the table. Its scabbard was blue velvet.

The hilt had my initials worked into gold. I lifted it halfway, saw my reflection in the polished blade, and understood why old kings had difficulty being reasonable.

"The city wanted you to have something dignified," she said.

"Nigga, this is a sword with my name on it."

"I argued for two. Budget hearing was difficult."

She waited until the others began discussing where to put the sword before lowering her voice.

"I didn't come for a photograph, Aiden."

I looked at her.

"I know."

"You made my department the most famous in the world. Half the applicants want to be you. The other half want to arrest you and get promoted. I would prefer to keep the original alive."

"Working on it."

She touched the badge on my chest.

"Work harder. Your wife has plans."

Across the room, Shawna was showing Seraphine a photograph of the dress she wanted for Vegas. Rosa had joined them. Three women leaned over a phone while a whole criminal empire waited outside, and none of them looked remotely willing to postpone their celebration.

I looked back at Knox.

"Yes, ma'am."

She smiled.

"There. Best officer I ever hired. Follows instructions when properly threatened."

Outside, the sky was empty again.

Our people had all come down safely.

4. Dinner with the Wrong Motherfucker

Nigga, I arrived at the emperor's dinner with my wife, two queens, a police chief, and a sword.

He had said come without my army. I had listened. Tank was in the car park being a completely different problem.

The palace stood on white pillars above an artificial lake. Black boats moved beneath it. Gold windows burned in the evening sun. A staircase wide enough for a cavalry charge climbed from the water to the front doors, and some nigga had put a red carpet down the middle like I might have trouble finding the building.

Shawna stood beside me at the bottom, looking up.

"That's a lot of stairs."

"Nigga don't believe in arriving relaxed."

"You could carry me."

I picked her up.

She laughed so suddenly that the nearest guard turned. Two more guards turned with him. Then half the staircase was watching me carry the most beautiful woman alive into the most dangerous nigga's house.

"Captain," one of them said, "the formal entrance requires—"

"Nigga, this is formal. Look at my wife."

He did. His mouth stayed open.

"Close that," I told him. "You on duty."

Shawna hid her smile against my neck.

At the top, a row of palace servants bowed. I put her down and straightened my jacket. The sword hung at my side in its blue scabbard. Knox had insisted I wear it because she wanted to see the emperor's face when he realized Las Vegas was now sending medieval problems abroad.

Vesper walked beside Magnolia. Nobody asked either woman for a weapon. The niggas at the door had clearly met them before.

Knox presented her badge to the chamberlain.

"Chief Gloria Knox."

"His Majesty's table admits guests by invitation only."

"I'm supervising an officer."

"That is not—"

"You want him unsupervised?"

The chamberlain looked at me.

I smiled.

The nigga moved aside.

Inside, the dining room stretched across the palace like somebody had tried to feed a whole dynasty without letting them

speak privately. A long table shone under gold lamps. Beyond the windows, the city glittered far below. At the end of the room, Emperor Zero stood beside a throne that had no business being anywhere near soup.

He wore black. No crown. No mask. Just a hard, handsome face that had spent too many years hearing yes from frightened people. Roland Ruin stood behind his chair. Another man sat near the middle of the table, broad and blond, with a diamond pin in his tie and nervous fingers.

Zero watched us approach.

"Captain. You have expanded my invitation."

"Nigga, your dining table long enough to land the plane you shot. I figured you had room."

His eyes narrowed at the mention of the transport.

"An unfortunate misunderstanding."

"Two engines worth."

Shawna took my hand before the room could feel how badly I wanted to put that nigga through his own window.

Zero looked at her hand in mine.

"A devoted marriage."

"You said that like you're allergic," she replied.

Magnolia laughed softly. Roland stared at the floor. I watched him trying not to smile and decided the nigga might possess one redeemable muscle.

We sat.

The blond man rose to greet us.

"Gideon Gold. Transport and hospitality."

"Aiden. Bad timing and excellent cars."

"I have heard."

"Nigga, everybody heard. You live under an emperor, not a rock."

He laughed too quickly. His eyes moved toward Zero before he sat. I noticed. Shawna noticed me noticing. Under the table, her thumb pressed once against my knuckles.

Dinner began with silver plates and food arranged so carefully I suspected it had been threatened.

Zero asked about Monaco. I told him about the race. He asked about Sky High. I told him about the plane. He asked whether I intended to make every answer an accusation.

"Depends what the nigga asking me did that morning."

Knox drank her wine without looking up.

Vesper set her fork down.

"You could end this tonight."

Zero turned toward her.

"And what would you have me end, Vesper?"

"The theater. You know what we found in Midnight City. You know who signed the promises you broke."

For the first time, the nigga did not have an answer ready.

She did not take out the ledger pages. She did not need to. She named three people and two dates. Magnolia watched him over the rim of her glass. Gideon's fingers stopped moving.

Zero smiled at last.

"Paper travels poorly in the desert."

"Copies travel beautifully," Vesper said.

Nigga, I loved when somebody else at the table brought ammunition that did not stain the curtains.

Zero leaned back.

"You imagine my people will abandon me because you show them figures?"

"Your people will make their own choices," Shawna said. "You should try letting them."

He looked at her as if she had reached across the table and slapped him with his own napkin.

"And you chose this man."

"Every day."

"Despite what he is."

"Nigga, especially knowing what he is."

I looked at my wife.

She kept her eyes on Zero.

"You keep saying captain, king, criminal like you hope one word cancels another. I know who I married. He knows who I married before. None of that is your dinner conversation."

Magnolia set down her glass with a tiny click.

"Excellent," she said.

Zero's jaw hardened.

"You are a singer, are you not?"

"I am."

"Perhaps you would perform."

I started to stand.

Shawna tightened her hand.

"I'd love to."

She rose before I could speak. The room watched her cross to a piano near the window. Its player stood immediately, bowing like he had been waiting his whole life for an opportunity to stop working for that nigga.

Shawna sat.

She did not sing to Zero.

She sang to me.

The first note changed the room's air. Her voice moved low over the table, warm and sure. No begging. No trembling little performance for a man with a throne. She gave me the song as if all those guards and gold lamps had been invited to witness something they could never buy.

I forgot the sword against my leg. I forgot Roland. For a minute I forgot that a nigga at the other end of the table wanted to kill us.

Then Gideon leaned toward me.

"My fiancée is in the western tower," he whispered.

I did not turn my head.

"Name."

"Liora. Thirty-three. She manages the airship berths. Zero accused her of allowing an unauthorized departure."

"She do it?"

"Yes. Her sister was aboard."

"Then your woman sounds smart."

His breath caught.

"He said if I helped you, he would never let her leave."

Nigga, fear had made the man shiny. Sweat at his temples. Fingers crushing his napkin. He had brought his whole heart to a table where somebody else had put it on the menu.

"Listen to the song," I said.

"Captain—"

"Nigga. Listen. Then watch what happens."

Shawna finished on a note so gentle the room stayed quiet after it was gone.

The first person to applaud was a guard by the window.

He caught himself too late.

I stood and applauded with him.

Then Knox. Magnolia. Vesper. Gideon. The pianist. The servants. Roland tapped two fingers against his palm before Zero looked at him.

Shawna rose, took my hand, and returned to her chair with the whole room watching like the emperor had invited the sun indoors and discovered he could not tell it where to shine.

"Beautiful," Zero said.

"Yeah," I said. "Nigga, I know."

He smiled without warmth.

"A pity such things are fragile."

The doors closed.

Every guard in the room moved his hand toward a weapon.

Magnolia sighed.

"At dinner, really?"

Zero stood.

"Captain Aiden. You will place the Crown of Midnight under my protection and depart this city by morning. Your friends may accompany you."

"Nigga, I didn't bring the crown."

"Then send for it."

"Didn't bring a desire to obey you either."

Roland drew his pistol.

Knox drew hers beneath the table.

Vesper stood so smoothly her chair barely moved. Magnolia lifted her cane. Shawna's hand disappeared behind her dress and came back holding the little pistol she had selected that afternoon while asking me whether the silver earrings looked better than the blue ones.

I put one hand on the sword.

Zero looked at it.

"You cannot be serious."

"Nigga, they gave me a sword. What you think I was gonna do, point at dinner?"

The first shot shattered a lamp.

Shawna pulled Magnolia behind the table. Knox fired toward the doorway. I drew the sword and cut the hanging cord above the side curtains. Heavy blue fabric crashed down between us and the guards by the windows. The niggas fired into silk while I kicked my chair into Roland's knees.

He stumbled. I grabbed his wrist and drove it against the table. His gun skidded through a plate of untouched fish.

"That was expensive," he snapped.

"Nigga, so am I."

He hit me hard in the mouth.

I respected the punch. Then I returned it with interest.

Roland went backward into a serving cart. Silver dishes crashed around him. Zero had vanished through a panel behind the throne. Of course the nigga had a private exit built into his personality.

Gideon crawled beneath the table.

"Western tower!" he shouted.

"I heard you!"

Tank's voice broke over the small radio in my pocket.

"Brother, your dinner loud as shit!"

"We arguing over the check!"

"I got the car!"

"Get to the western side!"

Shawna and Vesper moved toward the side door while Knox covered them. Magnolia struck a guard's wrist with her cane, hard enough to make him drop his gun and reconsider what sixty-four meant. I caught the gun before it hit the floor, fired toward the main doorway, and followed my wife into a corridor lined with portraits of Zero looking emotionally unavailable in different outfits.

"Liora!" I told Shawna. "Gideon's woman. Western tower."

"Then we get her."

No argument. No question about why the night had acquired another person. This was why that nigga at the table could never understand us.

The corridor opened onto a glass bridge between the palace and the tower. Below us, black water gleamed under the moon. Above, security lights snapped on.

Gideon caught up, gasping.

"She's on the third landing."

"You go with Vesper and Magnolia," I said. "Knox, take them down."

"Captain—"

"Chief, I'm being excellent. Give me room."

She looked at my bleeding lip, then at Shawna's gun.

"Bring your wife back. She is the sensible officer."

Shawna kissed my cheek.

"Hear that?"

"Nigga, I hear everything."

We crossed the bridge together.

Halfway across, the lights went out.

Then the bridge moved.

Not shook. Moved. The whole glass walkway began withdrawing toward the palace, opening a gap between its far end and the tower.

Shawna looked down.

"Aiden."

"I see it."

Behind us, guards appeared in the doorway. Ahead, the gap widened over the lake. We had come to save a woman and discovered the emperor could put a moat in the middle of a hallway.

"Nigga got money," I said.

"So do you. Jump."

We ran.

I fired once behind us. The guards ducked. Shawna reached the end first, launched herself across the gap, and caught the tower railing. I followed, boots leaving the glass as the last panel slid away beneath me.

For a second there was only water below and my wife's hand ahead.

I caught the railing.

She caught my wrist.

"You heavy," she said through her teeth.

"That's greatness, baby."

"Greatness needs to pull its ass up."

I did.

We rolled onto the tower landing together. A guard came around the corner. Shawna put her gun on him before he finished inhaling.

"Door," she said.

The nigga pointed.

"Key."

He handed it over.

"Excellent employee," I told him.

Liora stood inside a locked room wearing a gray dress and a face full of furious patience. She was thirty-three, dark-haired, with a

gold ring on a chain around her neck. When Shawna opened the door, she looked from us to the broken bridge outside.

"Gideon finally did something?"

"Nigga did enough," I said. "Come on."

She picked up a small bag.

"I've been packed for six days."

We went down the tower stairs instead of back toward the palace. At the bottom, a boat dock opened onto the artificial lake. Tank stood on a black launch, holding a gun in one hand and the wheel in the other. Rosa sat behind him wearing his jacket over her green dress.

"Get in!" he yelled.

I looked at the boat.

"Nigga, where the Mercedes?"

"Parked! I got hobbies!"

We jumped aboard.

Tank drove away from the dock as the tower doors burst open behind us. Bullets struck the water. Rosa fired back. Shawna put Liora behind the seats, then stood beside me as the launch tore beneath the palace's pillars.

A second boat came after us.

Roland drove it.

That nigga had recovered from the fish quickly.

He fired as he came. Tank cut between two pillars. The boat leaned hard. I caught Shawna around the waist and held her against me while she fired toward Roland's windshield.

Glass burst.

He ducked but kept driving.

Ahead, a low service arch opened beneath the palace gardens. Tank aimed for it.

"How low?" I shouted.

"Lower than the last fucking tunnel!"

We ducked.

The arch scraped the top of our launch. Metal screamed. We shot through in a shower of sparks, emerged on the far side, and heard a much louder crash behind us.

Roland's boat had been taller.

Nigga, geometry finally arrested somebody for me.

We reached the western dock where Knox waited with the cars. Gideon ran to Liora before the launch had stopped moving. He caught her as she stepped up, held her so tightly she struck his back with the bag.

"I can breathe or I can marry you," she told him. "I would prefer both."

He laughed against her hair.

I watched them for a second. Shawna stood beside me, her hand warm in mine, the hem of her dress wet from the boat.

"You okay?" she asked.

"Nigga punched my mouth."

She examined my lip.

"Still pretty."

"That's what I was worried about."

She kissed the uninjured side and led me toward the car.

Behind us, the palace lights blazed over the lake. Zero remained inside, alive and furious, with his dinner cold and his prisoner gone.

At the hotel, Magnolia insisted on dessert.

"We survived an emperor's manners," she said. "We deserve sugar."

Liora refused to sit until she had seen the hotel roof. June took her upstairs. When they returned, both women were smiling in a way that made Adrian ask where he should hide his tools.

"The emperor's transport fleet crosses the city tomorrow," Liora said. "Cars, fuel tenders, aircraft parts. Everything he wants inside the fortress before he closes the outer districts."

Cassius leaned forward. "What cars?"

"His champions' collection."

"Nigga, say that with more detail," I told her.

She named three cars. Cassius put his wine down. She named two more. Inez leaned across him and asked her to repeat the last one.

"That's mine," Inez said.

The table quieted.

"Your actual car?" Shawna asked.

"My father's early championship car. Sol de Abril. Years before the White Heron. I was told it had burned after an earlier race."

Liora shook her head. "It sits in the west motor gallery. Silver with a red stripe. A little sun painted beside the driver's name."

Inez looked at Cassius. The expression on her face made all the racing jokes leave him at once. He took her hand beneath the table, quietly, without turning the gesture into anything the rest of us had to watch.

"We'll get it," he said.

"You don't know that."

"I know who's sitting here."

Nigga, the whole table looked at me.

I wiped my mouth. "Y'all give a man one bite of cake before assigning greatness."

Tank laughed. "You want the little fork or the rescue fork?"

"Nigga, both."

Liora drew the procession on the back of a menu. Not a neat little plan. A memory of where things stood, which roads went uphill, where she had seen the old race car beneath a silk cover. She stopped whenever she was uncertain. June filled in the streets she knew. Vesper named the houses overlooking them. I watched people who had met yesterday build a way through a city that had spent years telling them they were alone.

Gideon stayed silent.

I caught his eye.

"You got something?"

He swallowed. "Roland chooses the lead drivers. He will expect an attack."

"That nigga expects compliments. He gets both tomorrow."

"Captain, I am serious."

"So am I. Ask his boat."

Liora touched Gideon's face. "You got me out. You don't have to be frightened of every next minute."

He covered her hand with his own.

I wanted to believe that would be enough for the nigga. Love had made me brave and stupid in roughly equal proportions.

Sometimes it did the same for another man. Sometimes it only gave fear a name to use.

I did not know which kind Gideon was yet.

Inez stood and walked to the window. Shawna followed her.

They spoke softly beside the glass while the rest of us considered tomorrow's road. After a moment Inez laughed, short and surprised, and Shawna put an arm around her shoulders.

Cassius watched them.

"Your wife," he said, "is a remarkable woman."

"Nigga, you just now arriving at that conclusion?"

"I have been arriving repeatedly."

"Good. Parking's free."

He laughed and looked at the window again.

I knew that look. A man could own every fast car alive and still need help crossing six feet of carpet to tell the right woman something true.

"Tomorrow," I told him, "bring her car home."

He nodded.

"And then quit acting like you only came over here to borrow the bread basket."

The nigga blushed. Cassius Chrome, who had raced under a burning bridge without lifting his foot, blushed at my dinner table.

I considered that another personal achievement.

Tank sat beside Rosa with his boat keys on the table. I looked at them.

"You keep those?"

"Nigga, I stole a boat for love. I'm not giving back the keys."

I raised my glass.

"To love."

Every nigga at that table raised a glass with me.

5. The Fastest Funeral Procession in History

The next morning I stole forty-seven cars before breakfast and still got blamed for being late.

"Nigga," Tank said over the radio, "your eggs cold."

"Put them in the microwave."

"This hotel don't have one. Chef says it affects the texture."

"Then tell that nigga to warm them with respect. I'm busy."

I was hanging out of a moving Rolls-Royce at the time, trying to convince its driver to stop shooting at my wife.

That sounds like a strange place to begin a morning, but the morning had started stranger.

At seven, June and Adrian unveiled the car they had prepared for me overnight. It sat in the hotel courtyard under a white sheet.

All our people had come down to see it. Cassius held coffee.

Inez held a photograph of her father's missing race car. Shawna stood beside me in a black driving suit with a blue scarf tied around her hair.

June pulled off the sheet.

Nigga, the car looked like a thunderstorm had acquired credit.

Dark blue. Long hood. Wide shoulders. A low roof that made the windows look angry. My captain's badge shone above the

grille, and beneath it, in polished silver, June had fixed one word.

MAGNIFICENT.

I stared.

Shawna touched the cross at my chest and began laughing.

"Dante would have loved that."

"Dante had taste," I said.

Marcellus came forward, adjusting his glasses.

"The lettering is excellent."

"You did it," June told him.

"I enjoy recognizing my own work."

Everybody laughed. The old nigga looked delighted with himself.

Adrian opened the driver's door.

"We call it the Last Word."

"That nigga's car got an argument built in," Tank said.

"It should," Shawna replied. "It belongs to him."

I sat behind the wheel. The engine started with a low roar that made conversations stop all the way across the courtyard. A waiter carrying breakfast stood perfectly still. The little dog in diamonds barked once, then apparently decided to respect authority.

"How fast?" I asked.

June leaned in.

"Fast enough that I want you to remember my name when you become insufferable."

"Nigga, you met me yesterday. That deadline passed."

She grinned.

The Last Word was not magic. It would not repair itself, fly, or apologize. It was a car built by two people who had spent their lives listening to engines and had finally been given somebody else's money without a nigga leaning over them saying cheaper. That made it close enough to a miracle for me.

We drove to the motor gallery in six cars.

The city had begun preparing for Zero's final procession. Black banners hung over the boulevard. Armored escorts lined the crossroads. At the top of the hill, the fortress gates stood open like a mouth waiting for everything rich to crawl inside.

Liora's description had been right. The prize fleet stood in a long glass gallery, forty-seven cars polished beneath chandeliers. Drivers in white suits waited beside them. Roland Ruin stood at the head of the line with a bandage over his temple and the expression of a nigga whose week had become personal.

I pulled up outside the gallery.

Shawna got out beside me.

The guards saw the badge and hesitated. It happened a lot. Criminals expected the police to arrive with paperwork. Police expected criminals to arrive without the police. I enjoyed being inconvenient to both.

Roland came toward us.

"Captain. You have survived another morning."

"Nigga, you look like you slept inside a boat accident."

His bandage moved when his jaw tightened.

"This collection belongs to the emperor."

Inez stepped out of Cassius's car.

"Not all of it."

She walked past me toward the silver car beneath a half-drawn cover. A red stripe ran along its hood. The little painted sun sat beside Esteban Inferno's name. SOL DE ABRIL gleamed on a narrow plate beneath it. She stopped with one hand over her mouth.

Cassius came up beside her and said nothing.

That was the smartest shit the nigga had done all morning.

Roland moved to block them.

I stepped between.

"Don't."

"You have no authority here."

"Nigga, I keep hearing that in places where I'm doing whatever the fuck I want. Somebody ought to investigate."

Shawna folded her arms.

"Could be a police matter."

"Excellent point, baby."

I took out my badge.

Roland looked from it to the forty-seven cars.

"You cannot confiscate an imperial procession."

"Watch how educational this gets."

He laughed once, sharp and disbelieving.

Then he did something I respected.

He offered a race.

"You and I," he said. "Through the city to the fortress road. If you win, take the silver car. If I win, you kneel before the emperor in the square."

I looked at Shawna.

She looked at me.

"He wants your knees," she said.

"Popular request."

"Aiden."

"My bad."

I turned back to Roland.

"All the cars."

"One."

"All forty-seven, and the drivers leave with whoever they choose."

"You think very highly of yourself."

"Nigga, I'm the one doing the thinking. Of course it's high quality."

The drivers behind him began whispering.

"That's the Monaco nigga," one said.

"I know which nigga he is," another answered. "That's why I'm not betting my salary against him."

"Ruin knows these roads."

"Nigga, Aiden knows the gas pedal."

I heard all of it. Roland heard it too. His face changed in the particular way a proud man changes when backing down becomes more embarrassing than losing.

"Done," he said.

The city learned about the race before we reached the starting line.

People came out onto balconies. Shopkeepers rolled their shutters up. The motor-gallery drivers lined their cars behind

ours, ready to follow. Zero's procession had become my audience, and the nigga on the throne had not yet been informed he was sponsoring another event.

Roland chose a black machine with a red interior. I chose the Last Word.

Shawna leaned through my window.

"You tired?"

"From loving you? Never."

"From yesterday, you shameless motherfucker."

I flexed my hand for her. Steady now. No blue light. No need.

"I'm good."

She kissed me, then looked across at Roland.

"You should have asked to race me."

He frowned.

"Why?"

"I'd have embarrassed you more politely."

She walked away before he could answer.

Cassius dropped the flag.

We launched.

Nigga, the Last Word spoke fluent violence. The engine pulled me into the seat. The gallery vanished behind us. Roland took

the first turn tight, brushing the curb. I stayed beside him, close enough to see him clench his teeth.

We tore down the boulevard past the fountain where his emperor's statue had drowned its dignity the morning before. People screamed my name from the sidewalks. A woman on a balcony threw a scarf. It landed on Roland's windshield. He ripped it away and threw it out.

I caught it through my open window.

Nigga, don't waste a gift.

I looped it around the gear lever and took the next corner one-handed.

Roland stared.

Then he accelerated.

The road narrowed into the old quarter. Gold towers gave way to sandstone walls and hanging market awnings. Our engines bounced between the buildings like thunder trapped in a beautiful argument. Ahead, a delivery truck blocked half the street.

Roland went left.

I went right, up a shallow flight of steps and through an empty café terrace. Chairs scattered. A waiter leaped onto a table holding a tray above his head. I came off the terrace beside Roland again, the Last Word landing hard enough to make my teeth meet.

"Nigga!" the waiter yelled behind me.

"Put it on my room!" I shouted back.

We reached the canal road together.

The dry canal ran beneath the city toward the fortress. A series of stone bridges crossed it. Roland dropped down the service ramp, tires throwing dust. I followed. The cars behind us poured into the canal like jewels spilling from a broken necklace.

Then the shooting began.

A black Rolls-Royce came off a side ramp ahead of us. Its rear window lowered. A gun appeared.

I knew immediately the race had acquired an employee.

"Roland!" I shouted through my window. "Your niggas cheating!"

He looked at the Rolls, and for half a second I believed his surprise.

The gunman fired at both of us.

That settled it.

Zero had decided losing one champion was cheaper than allowing another man to win.

Roland swerved. The bullets tore into the canal wall. I swung beside him and pointed toward the next ramp.

He shook his head.

Proud nigga. Stupid nigga. Almost me on a worse day.

The Rolls slowed to block us. Behind it, an armored truck appeared on the bridge overhead. Its guards aimed down into the canal.

I grabbed the radio.

"Shawna, we got company!"

"I see them."

Her Lamborghini came down the far ramp, blue lights flashing. She cut across the Rolls's path, forcing it toward the canal wall. The gunman turned toward her.

That was his mistake.

I drove alongside, opened my door, and stepped across the narrow gap onto the Rolls's running board while both cars moved beneath the bridge.

Nigga, a man can learn some very unreasonable shit when he spends enough time refusing to let his wife get shot.

I caught the rear window frame and shoved the gun aside. The shot went into the ceiling. The gunman tried to drag me inside. I hit him with the gold badge on my fist and pulled the weapon free.

The driver looked back.

"Eyes on the fucking road!" I yelled.

He obeyed on instinct.

For one beautiful second, the nigga kidnapping me was following police instructions.

Then Roland bumped the Rolls from behind.

I slammed against the door. Shawna came close on the other side. She held the Lamborghini steady while I climbed across the Rolls's hood and jumped onto her passenger seat through the open roof.

I landed badly, one knee between the seats, my face almost in her lap.

"Nigga," she said, "we in traffic."

"I was rescuing myself!"

"Then sit up like a rescued person!"

Behind us, June caught the empty Last Word before it struck the wall. She had come up in the silver coupe, crossed into my car with Adrian holding her door, and taken its wheel like the two of them had rehearsed impossible shit in their sleep.

"You leave my car rolling again," she shouted over the radio,

"I'm charging you a babysitting fee!"

"Our car!"

"Nigga, not when you doing that!"

The Rolls crashed into a pile of road barriers. Its gunman crawled out with both hands raised. The armored truck on the bridge tried to turn after us.

Tank's Mercedes struck its rear wheel.

The truck hit the parapet and stopped sideways. Tank climbed out, pointed at the guards, and looked so personally disappointed that three of them dropped their weapons before Knox even arrived to arrest them.

"Y'all shooting at my breakfast delivery," he said. "Niggas got no home training."

I laughed so hard I nearly missed the next turn.

Roland's car limped ahead of us. Smoke came from its hood. He had taken a bullet through a tire and was fighting the wheel to keep it straight.

The finish lay at the top of the fortress road.

He could not reach it.

He tried anyway.

I watched the black car fishtail toward the ramp. Its damaged tire came apart. The car swung sideways, struck the edge of a stone drainage channel, and tipped toward the drop beyond.

Shawna braked.

I was already out.

The black car hung with one rear wheel in the air. Roland struggled with his belt. Smoke filled the cabin. Below the edge, the canal dropped into an old pumping basin deep enough to

make surviving the fall a matter for somebody else's imagination.

I caught his door.

"Nigga, move!"

"I'm stuck!"

I reached in, pulled the belt loose from the twisted seat, and grabbed his shoulder. The car shifted. Stone cracked beneath its front tire.

He looked at me.

For the first time since we'd met, the nigga did not look like a champion, or a guard, or a man rehearsing an insult. He looked like somebody who wanted another morning.

"Aiden."

"I know my fucking name. Get out!"

I hauled him through the window.

We fell backward as the car went over.

It struck the bottom with a deep crash that seemed to come up through the soles of my shoes. Smoke billowed into the canal. Roland lay beside me, coughing, one hand still gripping my jacket.

Shawna knelt beside us.

"You two finished racing?"

I looked at Roland.

"Nigga, you want a rematch on foot?"

He laughed once. Then again. A helpless, disbelieving laugh that kept turning into coughing.

"You're impossible," he said.

"And yet here I am."

June brought the Last Word to a stop beside us. Cassius and Inez arrived behind her with the fleet. The drivers got out one by one and looked down at Roland's ruined car, then at the man I had pulled out of it.

He sat up slowly.

I offered my hand.

He took it.

"The cars," I said.

Roland looked toward the fortress. At the black banners. At the guards who had fired on him as readily as they had fired on me.

Then he turned toward his drivers.

"The captain won."

Nobody argued.

Inez went to her father's car. She opened the door and sat behind the wheel. Her hands rested there for a long time before she tried the key.

Cassius stood beside her, quiet again.

The engine turned over.

She closed her eyes.

Nigga, sometimes a car is a car. Sometimes it's a room where somebody you loved is still waiting for you to remember how they laughed.

She looked up at me with tears running down her cheeks and did not bother hiding them.

"Thank you."

"Drive it," I said. "That's what it wants."

Cassius slid into the passenger seat.

She smiled at him.

Then she took off so fast the nigga's head hit the seat.

"That is my girl!" he shouted out the window.

She shouted something back that made the whole canal laugh.

We brought forty-seven cars to the hotel.

The owner came outside, counted until his lips stopped moving, and asked whether I wanted the adjoining courtyard opened.

"Nigga, open the adjoining city. We got parking needs."

Roland arrived last, riding with Knox. She had taken his gun. He had not complained. His white suit was torn and blackened, his

sunglasses gone. He stood in the courtyard looking at the people who had been his enemies an hour earlier.

Tank approached with a plate.

"Eggs?"

Roland stared.

"I tried to kill your brother."

"Nigga, everybody here knows somebody who tried that. You hungry or emotional?"

Roland took the plate.

Rosa made room at the table, not close enough to mistake him for family, but close enough to let the man eat.

Shawna sat on my lap. I held her around the waist while June argued with the hotel owner about where to put forty-seven keys. Marcellus admired the Last Word's lettering again. Victor asked whether his roundabout could have one of the cars displayed in the center.

I looked across at Roland.

"Your emperor sends you after me again," I said, "tell that nigga to come himself."

He put down his fork.

"He will not come."

"Then I'll visit."

Roland looked at the palace above the city. His face changed.

"The palace is a front room," he said. "You haven't seen where he keeps the door locked."

I kissed my wife's shoulder.

"Nigga, I been breaking doors since college."

6. The Man They Put on Every Stage

Shawna had sold out the Golden Arena before Zero could cancel her concert.

The nigga tried anyway.

At noon, a palace messenger arrived at our hotel carrying a decree. At twelve-oh-one, Rosa took it from him, read the first sentence, and handed it back folded into a paper fan.

"Tell your emperor it's hot," she said.

At twelve-oh-three, Mercedes posted a photograph of the fan beside the concert tickets.

At twelve-oh-five, the remaining seats sold out.

Nigga, even censorship was working for my wife's promotion.

I found her in the ballroom rehearsing with Sienna and her sister, the cellist, plus three musicians Seraphine had brought from Sky High. Rosa sat at the piano. The women had taken the room from champagne to music without asking any of the armed men to have an opinion. I stood in the doorway and listened until Shawna caught me.

"You hovering?"

"Nigga, I'm appreciating."

"Appreciate from over here."

She held out her hand.

I went to her.

"Sing the second line."

"Baby, you got professionals."

"I married one."

Rosa looked up from the piano.

"Don't start that modest shit. You do it twice a year and nobody enjoys it."

Tank appeared behind me holding a tray of drinks.

"This nigga modest? Where? I wanna see."

"I was being supportive," I said.

"Nigga, support the melody."

The pianist played the phrase again.

I sang it.

The room stopped.

Sienna lowered her violin. The music instructor took off his glasses. Tank looked from me to the ceiling like he expected somebody to explain why his brother had been hiding another fucking talent.

Shawna smiled.

"Again."

I sang with her this time. Her voice rose over mine, bright and fierce, and I held the lower line steady beneath it. We had sung in cars, in bedrooms, over breakfast while she stole my toast. I knew how her breath moved before a high note. I knew when she would lean forward, when she would close her eyes, when she would smile halfway through a word because something in it belonged to us.

That knowledge sounded different through a microphone.

When we finished, the Sky High instructor sat down very slowly.

"Captain," he said, "have you received formal training?"

Tank answered for me.

"Nigga doesn't attend classes. Classes attend him."

The room broke apart laughing.

Shawna kissed my hand.

"You're singing tonight."

"How many songs?"

"One."

"Nigga, I already know they gonna ask for more."

"Then learn the second verse before you become difficult."

Across the courtyard, June and Adrian were fitting stronger lights to the rescue vehicles. Liora stood with them, explaining

the airship berths above the arena. Zero housed traveling workers in locked quarters beneath the stands whenever he wanted to make sure the show finished before anybody collected their pay. There were technicians, cooks, dancers, drivers. Grown people who had come for a contract and discovered the city treated leaving as a privilege.

Tonight the arena would be full. Tonight those workers would be close to a door.

I went outside and found Roland standing over Liora's sketch. Tank stood beside him with his arms folded.

"This nigga tells us one lie," Tank said, "I'm making him eat the sketch."

Roland nodded.

"A reasonable precaution."

"Don't agree so politely. Makes me suspicious."

I leaned over the table.

"What's the problem?"

Roland pointed at the western entrance.

"Anton Atlas. Zero's arena champion. He controls the lower halls."

"He a lock?"

"He is a very large man."

"Nigga, so is Tank. I still get into the kitchen."

Tank grinned.

"Atlas will not leave his post while the workers remain inside," Roland said.

"Then I'll move his post."

Liora looked up.

"Aiden, he isn't the only guard."

"Good. Nigga would get lonely."

Shawna joined us, looked at the sketch, and listened without interrupting. When Roland finished, she pointed at the stage entrance on the opposite side.

"The musicians use this hall?"

Liora nodded.

"Then Sienna's people can bring them through during the last song. Everybody in black stage clothes. Nobody stops a crew carrying cases while the lights are down."

"The guards may," Roland said.

Shawna looked at me.

"That's why my husband is going to become distracting."

Nigga, the room had never accused me of lacking that qualification.

The Golden Arena looked like a crown laid flat on the ground. Gold arches circled a central stage. Above it, airship platforms extended from four towers. Below, a thousand doors led into corridors where Zero kept the people who made his parties possible.

We arrived at dusk.

The crowd knew my wife's name.

Not Mrs. Aiden. Shawna.

They chanted it when her car stopped. Women in blue dresses waved from the steps. Men held records and photographs. A group of singers from the old quarter had brought a banner with a painted microphone on it. Shawna looked at the crowd and went very still beside me.

"Baby?"

She swallowed.

"They came for the songs."

"Nigga, what you think you been doing all this time?"

She hit my arm lightly, laughing through the sudden shine in her eyes.

"You know what I mean."

I did.

I got out first, then opened her door.

The cheering hit us like weather.

A woman near the barrier began singing one of Shawna's songs. Somebody joined her. Then somebody else. My wife stood on the steps listening to a thousand strangers carry her words back to her, and I had never been more proud of anything I had failed to personally invent.

"That's my wife," I told a guard.

"Yes, Captain."

"Nigga, I just wanted to make sure the information was circulating."

He smiled.

"Widely."

Inside, Anton Atlas waited beside the stage doors.

Roland had not exaggerated. The nigga looked like somebody had built a second man around a first man for protection. Thirty-six, according to the fight posters. Shaved head. Black suit. Hands big enough to argue with furniture.

He held up one of those hands when I approached.

"Performers only."

I pointed at the microphone in my hand.

"What you think this is? A little flashlight?"

"You are not on the program."

Shawna took the printed program from him, found a pen in her bag, and wrote my name beneath hers.

"Now he is."

Anton looked at the page. Then at me.

"You think that settles it?"

"Nigga, I'm married. I know when something settled."

He did not move.

Tank came up beside me.

Anton looked at Tank.

Tank looked at Anton.

A whole conversation happened without words. Two very large niggas examining whether the other one was worth the trouble of taking off a jacket.

"I got this," I told Tank.

"I wanted some of it."

"Save your suit. Rosa got pictures planned."

He sighed and stepped back.

Anton smiled.

"The captain wants to fight?"

"The captain wants to sing. You the nigga making it athletic."

He took off his jacket.

So did I.

Somebody in the corridor shouted that Aiden was fighting Atlas. Within thirty seconds the arena camera crew had arrived, followed by three palace officials who all wanted to decide whether the fight counted as part of the show. They argued until Shawna took the nearest camera and pointed it at us herself.

"It counts," she said.

The big screens above the stage lit up.

The audience roared.

Anton heard them and grinned.

"They love a champion."

"Nigga, wait till they see the other one."

He swung.

I ducked under the punch and struck his side. The nigga barely moved. I hit him again. He caught my shoulder and threw me into a stack of padded equipment cases.

The crowd gasped through the speakers.

I stood, adjusted my shirt, and looked at my wife.

"Sound check."

She laughed.

Anton came forward.

This time I moved before he reached me. I stepped onto the lowest case, ran up the next two, and jumped over his reaching arm. My boot caught his shoulder. I landed behind him and drove him into the wall with every ounce of momentum I had borrowed from gravity.

The wall cracked.

The nigga laughed.

"Good!"

"Don't encourage him," Tank muttered.

Anton turned and caught me around the middle. He lifted. My feet left the floor.

I had one clear thought.

This nigga is about to make my wife watch me become furniture.

I braced my hands against the doorframe above us, pulled my knees up, and pushed off. Anton stumbled backward with me still in his arms. We hit the edge of the stage door together and burst into the arena beneath a storm of lights.

The audience stood.

Shawna walked onto the stage behind us carrying her microphone.

"Good evening," she said. "My husband is running slightly late."

Nigga, the whole arena laughed while I fought for my fucking schedule.

Anton tried to turn me over his shoulder. I twisted, landed on my feet, and caught his arm. The stage beneath us vibrated with the bass line Rosa had instructed the band to start. The musicians were scoring my fistfight like I had rehearsed it.

I hit Anton in the chest. Once. Twice. He swung again. I slipped inside the reach and drove upward with a punch that made his eyes widen.

The giant stepped back.

Another step.

Then he sat down in the chair placed for the cellist.

The chair broke.

The arena exploded.

Anton lay in the wreckage for a moment, staring up at me. I stood over him breathing hard, my shirt torn at one shoulder, my wife beside me with a hand on her hip.

"You finished?" she asked.

I looked at Anton.

He started laughing.

"Nigga," he said, "you really are that man."

I offered my hand.

"Been trying to tell people."

He took it. I hauled him up. The audience cheered louder when he raised my arm than when I had knocked him down.

Behind the stage, Tank and Liora moved through the now-unwatched corridor.

Shawna touched my face.

"Sing."

I took the microphone.

The band began.

Nigga, I sang like I had not just argued with a mountain. I sang to my wife in front of the whole city. The first line came out low and steady. The second rose. When Shawna joined me, the arena changed from a place where somebody might get killed into a room where nobody wanted the night to end.

Below us, Sienna's people began bringing workers through the stage corridor. Black clothes. Instrument cases. Heads down, then lifting as they heard the crowd. Rosa met each group at the loading doors and sent them toward the waiting cars.

I saw it from the stage in flashes.

A cook gripping a violin case he did not know how to hold. A dancer carrying a cable coil like a crown. Two drivers supporting a man with a sprained ankle. Grown people moving toward an exit that finally belonged to them.

Then a Black Mantle officer appeared at the corridor mouth.

He raised his gun.

Shawna saw him before I did.

She turned the last note into a shout.

"Down!"

I grabbed her and dropped behind the piano as the shot cracked over the stage.

The audience screamed.

Anton moved.

Nigga, that big motherfucker crossed the stage like a building had decided to change addresses. He struck the officer before a second shot could come. The gun flew. Tank caught the next guard coming through the door and drove him backward into the corridor.

I rose behind the piano with my pistol in my hand.

Shawna took the microphone.

"Stay low! Follow the lights on the left!"

Her voice cut through the panic. People listened because they had already spent the night listening to her. The crowd moved toward the open aisles. Seraphine appeared above the far entrance, wind holding a falling light rig away from the seats.

Victor stood beside her, electricity flashing between his hands in

short, controlled bursts that drove the guards off the upper walkway.

I fired toward the stage door, covering Tank and Anton as they pushed the attackers back. Shawna stayed behind the piano, guiding the audience until Knox's officers reached the aisles.

A palace truck crashed through the loading entrance.

Then the Last Word crashed through the opposite door.

June drove it onto the stage.

Nigga, my car had made its concert debut before my second verse.

"Get in!" she yelled.

"The workers!"

"Rosa has them! Get your famous ass inside!"

Anton lifted the piano's fallen side panel away from Shawna. I pulled her into the car. Tank jumped onto the rear step, holding the open door as June drove us off the stage, through the loading hall, and into the cool night beyond.

We emerged behind a line of buses full of the people we had come for.

Rosa stood through the roof of the lead bus, waving both arms.

"Everybody accounted for!"

Shawna leaned against me and laughed once, breathless and shaking.

"I didn't finish the song."

"Nigga, you sold out the building and stole the staff. That's a strong debut."

She put her forehead against mine.

Behind us, the arena glowed under emergency lights. The emperor's officers ran through corridors that no longer held the people they had expected to command.

Anton climbed onto the back of the bus beside Tank.

The two giants looked at each other.

"You hit him hard," Tank said.

"He hit me harder."

"Nigga, welcome to the experience."

At the hotel, the rescued workers filled the courtyard with noise. Some called friends. Some cried. Some went straight to the kitchen because apparently surviving captivity did not cure a cook of wanting to inspect somebody else's stove.

Shawna sat on the fountain wall. I sat beside her.

A woman from the stage crew approached carrying a cracked microphone.

"You left this," she said.

Shawna took it.

"Thank you."

"My mother watched the broadcast. She said you were magnificent."

My wife looked at me.

I touched the cross under my torn shirt.

"Runs in the family."

She laughed and leaned against my shoulder.

A moment later, the courtyard began singing her unfinished song.

One voice. Then another. Then all those niggas, all those women, all those people who had walked through a door because she kept the city listening.

She stood.

I gave her the microphone.

This time, nobody interrupted the last verse.

7. A Nigga with a Train to Catch

At four in the morning, Tank knocked on my door holding a wedding magazine and a shotgun.

"I need your opinion."

I looked from one item to the other.

"Nigga, on which?"

"Blue flowers or white?"

Shawna rolled over beside me.

"Blue," she said into the pillow.

Tank nodded solemnly.

"That's what I thought."

He stood there another second.

"Also, Zero's moving an armored train through the north quarter."

I sat up.

"You lead with flowers?"

"Nigga, the train ain't getting married."

I loved my brother so much it occasionally interfered with hating his timing.

We met downstairs while the hotel slept badly around us. Last night's rescued workers occupied the spare rooms, the ballroom, and half the couches in the lobby. The owner had stopped counting guests and started introducing himself as the man who gave Aiden a place to put everybody. He looked exhausted and rich in ways he had not anticipated.

Liora spread an old rail map across the breakfast table. Gideon stood behind her, rubbing his hands together. Roland leaned against the wall. Knox watched him from a chair with her coffee balanced on one knee.

"The train carries the fortress payroll and the command standard," Liora said. "Zero uses it when he moves the final court from the palace into the inner city."

"Command standard?" Tank asked.

"A flag," Roland said.

"Nigga, say flag."

"It is also a ceremonial—"

"A fancy flag. Got it."

I looked at the map. The railway circled the city, crossed a deep ravine, and entered the fortress through a stone gate beneath its western wall. A second track branched toward an old mining quarter that had been abandoned when Zero discovered casinos made money without requiring anybody important to become dusty.

"Who's on it?" I asked.

Roland hesitated.

"Orson Vex. Forty-five. Commander of the Black Mantle."

"He impressive?"

"Very."

"Good. Nigga deserves a memorable disappointment."

Gideon pointed at the old branch line.

"The freight stop here is still open. You can reach the train before the ravine."

Liora looked at him.

"That stop was sealed last winter."

"The lower entrance. The vehicle ramp remains."

He said it quickly. Too quickly for four in the morning.

I watched his finger on the map. Shawna watched his face.

"How you know?" she asked.

"My company serviced the line."

"When?"

"Recently."

Nigga, recently is a word people use when dates might get them punched.

I set my cup down.

"We look before we leap. June, take the ridge road with Adrian. Check what you can see."

Gideon swallowed.

"Of course."

Liora's eyes stayed on him for another moment. Then she turned back to the map. I did not like the space between them.

Yesterday the nigga had held her like losing her would end the world. This morning he stood half a step too far away from her questions.

We left in the Last Word, Tank's Mercedes, and two of the recovered fleet cars. Cassius drove one. Inez drove Sol de Abril, the little sun on its hood catching the dawn. She had called her father the previous night and held the phone in front of the running engine until both of them laughed too hard to speak.

Some niggas send flowers home.

We sent horsepower.

Shawna rode beside me, wearing a dark jacket over her driving suit. She held two cups of coffee in a carrier.

"You remember the last time?" she asked.

"Nigga sent me a coffin."

"And I saved the coffee."

"Most of it."

"You want to drive or argue?"

"Baby, I got range."

The rail line appeared beneath the cliffs as the sun rose. The train moved through a low veil of dust, black and silver, long enough to look like a road that had decided to travel. Armored cars stood on open flatbeds. Behind them came passenger coaches with dark windows. At the rear, a glass-roofed carriage held what appeared to be a garden.

"This nigga got a greenhouse on his train," Tank said over the radio.

"Maybe he likes tomatoes," I replied.

"Zero ain't watered shit in his life."

June's voice cut in.

"Aiden. Freight stop's blocked. Concrete all across the ramp."

I looked at Shawna.

She was already looking at me.

"Gideon," she said.

"Later."

Ahead, the old branch disappeared behind a hill. The main line continued toward the ravine. We had a narrow road beside it, an armored train gathering speed, and a nigga in our hotel who had just become more interesting than I wanted him to be.

"Can we get alongside?" I asked June.

"For half a mile. After that the road climbs away."

"Half a mile's generous."

"To who?"

"Niggas with ambition."

I accelerated.

The Last Word caught the rear carriage just as the train reached the straight stretch. Through the glass roof I saw palms, white chairs, and a black-uniformed guard eating breakfast beneath a lemon tree.

I looked at Shawna.

"You take the wheel."

"You take your time coming back. I'm starting to enjoy this car."

We changed places while moving slowly enough for her to curse me with accuracy. Then I climbed onto the passenger window, caught the rail beside the rear platform, and pulled myself across.

The guard beneath the lemon tree stared at me.

I straightened my jacket.

"Ticket inspection."

The nigga reached for his gun.

I threw a lemon at him.

It struck his forehead with a sound so personally insulting that Tank laughed over the radio before I had even drawn my pistol.

"Nigga got vitamin C!"

I kicked the gun under a chair and put the guard against the wall.

"Stay there."

He stayed.

Another guard came through the carriage door. I caught his wrist, turned him into the first nigga, and closed the connecting door behind both of them. Somebody began kicking it immediately.

"No running between cars," I called.

Shawna's voice came through my earpiece.

"You enjoying yourself?"

"Nigga, I paid no fare. I'm getting value."

The next carriage held uniforms hanging on racks and a table covered with medals. Zero had apparently packed enough honor to decorate every nigga who remained willing to stand near him. I took a black coat off a hook and threw it over a camera above the door.

A voice spoke from the ceiling.

"Captain Aiden."

I stopped.

"Orson?"

"You have entered a moving fortress."

"Nigga, your moving fortress has lemons."

"You will find the next carriage less accommodating."

"That's what every landlord says."

The door ahead slid open.

Four guards waited on the other side.

I dropped as they fired. Bullets tore through the hanging uniforms. Medals rang on the table. I rolled behind a trunk, fired twice toward the lights, and let the carriage plunge into strobing shadow as the damaged fixtures swung.

The train leaned into a curve.

The trunk slid.

So did I.

I hit the guards at floor level, took the nearest nigga's legs out, and rose inside their line before they could turn. My elbow struck one face. The trunk struck another. The fourth man had the good sense to throw down his weapon and raise both hands before the furniture developed further opinions.

I held him against the door.

"Driver. Which way?"

He pointed forward.

"Nigga, I worked out forward. How many cars?"

"Six."

"There you go. Specificity saves lives."

Outside, Shawna kept the Last Word beside the train. Tank's Mercedes followed close behind. Cassius and Inez took the outer road, racing ahead toward the ravine bridge.

A roof hatch opened above me.

Orson Vex dropped through it.

The nigga landed like he had been paid by the pound. Broad shoulders. Gray at the temples. Black gloves. A scar down one side of his face that somebody had probably admired before making a bad decision.

He hit me before I could lift the gun.

The pistol flew beneath a seat. I hit the wall. He came after me with a short baton, striking hard enough to split the wood beside my head when I ducked.

"You have become tiresome," he said.

"Nigga, I just got here."

I drove my shoulder into him. We crashed through the connecting door onto the narrow platform between carriages. Wind struck us. The rails flashed below. Orson grabbed my jacket and forced me toward the side.

I caught the handrail.

He hit my fingers.

Pain shot up my arm. I held on.

Nigga, I had promises waiting in Vegas. A man does not let go of a train when his brother still needs him to stand beside the altar.

I pulled Orson close and drove my forehead into his face.

He staggered.

I did it again.

The nigga let go of my jacket.

I climbed the ladder to the roof because every sensible exit was currently occupied by somebody trying to kill me. Orson followed. We came up into the dawn with the whole train stretching ahead and the ravine opening beyond it.

Below, Shawna looked up.

"Aiden!"

"Busy!"

"Bridge!"

I turned.

The railway bridge rose between two cliffs. On its far side, the fortress guns pointed toward the track.

Orson smiled through the blood on his lip.

"You should have trusted your host."

Nigga, there it was. Gideon's little freight-stop mistake had not been a mistake. The train had been waiting for me to climb aboard before taking me somewhere that would enjoy my arrival too much.

I looked down at Shawna.

She understood from my face.

"Get off!"

Orson swung at me.

I caught his arm, turned with the train's sway, and drove him onto his back. His baton skidded along the roof. He rolled, caught it, and came up again.

The road beside the train began climbing away.

My wife had seconds before the gap became too wide.

I could fight this nigga until the fortress killed both of us. I could jump and leave our people below facing a train full of guns. Or I could spend the thing I had been saving.

Blue light flashed between my fingers.

Orson saw it.

For the first time, the nigga stepped back.

"There he is," I said.

The charge ran through my body in one hard burst. The world sharpened. Wind slowed enough for me to see dust spinning

above the roof. I moved past Orson's strike, caught his shoulder, and threw him across the roof into a raised hatch.

Metal buckled.

He went down and stayed down, breathing hard, his baton gone.

I staggered.

The blue light vanished.

My hands shook.

Shawna brought the Last Word onto a rising bank beside the track. She was higher now, almost level with the carriage roof. I saw her mouth move.

Jump.

I jumped.

Nigga, the space between a train and the woman you love is long enough to reconsider every fucking decision that led to it.

I hit the passenger seat shoulder-first. Pain flashed white.

Shawna caught my collar with one hand and kept the car straight with the other.

"Inside!"

"Working on it!"

She pulled. I folded into the car. The Last Word dropped off the bank and landed on the road with a violent bounce.

Behind us, Orson's train entered the bridge.

Ahead, Cassius and Inez had reached the old signal tower. June stood beside them waving both arms. Liora's second message had come through: an emergency siding remained open before the fortress gate, leading into the abandoned quarry instead of the inner city.

We did not touch the railway machinery ourselves. A railway worker from the arena crew had come with Knox, a grown man who knew the line and had spent six years hating where it took him. He stood inside the tower now, making his own decision about which master would receive the morning train.

The points changed.

The train turned away from the fortress.

Orson saw it too late.

The locomotive thundered into the quarry, slowed against the rising track, and struck the old sand stop hard enough to throw dust over every carriage. The glass garden roof burst. Lemons flew into the dawn.

Tank stared.

"Nigga, you derailed breakfast."

"The train stopped," I said. "Breakfast made its own choices."

Knox's officers surrounded the carriages. Guards emerged coughing, their hands raised. Orson came out last with two men helping him. He looked at me sitting on the Last Word's hood with Shawna holding a cold bottle against my shoulder.

"You cannot keep winning," he said.

I looked around at my friends, the captured train, the payroll crates, the ridiculous black-and-gold flag hanging out of a broken window.

"Nigga, the evidence is getting inconvenient for you."

Knox took him away.

Tank climbed into the command carriage and returned carrying the emperor's standard. He held it up, considered the design, and turned it upside down.

"Rosa could make this into tablecloths."

"Don't disrespect the wedding," Shawna said.

He lowered it immediately.

Inside the train, we found money, weapons, food, uniforms, and people who had expected to spend the rest of the week inside Zero's last locked room. We took the prisoners back under guard. We took the workers back with breakfast. We took the money because, nigga, I had never claimed to be above a profitable rescue.

By the time we reached the hotel, my shoulder ached and my hands had steadied enough to hold a cup.

Gideon waited in the courtyard.

Liora stood beside him.

She looked at the dust on our cars, the captured guards, the way Shawna helped me out without making it look like help.

Then she looked at the man she had planned to marry.

"You told them the stop was open."

Gideon said nothing.

Tank shut the Mercedes door very softly.

Nigga, I had heard him slam it during gunfights. The soft sound worried me more.

I walked toward Gideon with my wife's hand still in mine.

"Come upstairs," I said.

"Captain—"

"Nigga. Upstairs."

The courtyard went quiet around us.

For the first time since we had entered the Last City, the danger was already inside the hotel.

8. The Night They Burned My Hotel

Gideon Gold sat in a velvet chair while Tank stood behind it, and I could see the nigga considering whether velvet might be strong enough to hide inside.

Liora stood by the window. She had taken the ring off the chain around her neck and held it in her closed hand. Shawna sat beside me. Knox waited near the door. Nobody had raised a voice yet.

That frightened Gideon more than shouting would have.

"I made a mistake," he said.

"Nigga, a mistake is ordering fish at a gas station," Tank replied.

"You put my brother on a train with a professional murderer."

Gideon looked at me.

"Zero said he would detain you."

"And you believed that nigga?"

"He promised Liora safe passage. He promised my properties would be restored."

Liora opened her hand.

The ring lay in her palm.

"Your properties."

"For us."

"Don't put me inside that sentence."

The room went still.

She set the ring on the mantel. Carefully. No dramatic throw, no glitter flying across the carpet. She placed it there like an object whose purpose had ended.

"You had me," she said. "I was here. I was standing beside you. What else did you think a palace could give you?"

Gideon's eyes filled.

I did not enjoy it. Nigga, I had watched enough people cry to know tears were not a receipt for being right.

"Who contacted you?" I asked.

He wiped his face.

"A courier. Last night. After the concert."

"What you tell him besides the train route?"

He said nothing.

Tank put one hand on the chair's back. Wood creaked beneath the velvet.

"Nigga."

"The hotel arrangements," Gideon whispered. "Which floor. The courtyard exits. Where the crown is kept."

Shawna stood.

I was already moving.

The first explosion struck the hotel's north wall before we reached the door.

The room flashed orange. Glass burst inward. Tank caught Liora and dragged her down. I pulled Shawna behind the sofa as plaster rained across the carpet. Somewhere below us, people screamed.

For one second I heard nothing but a high ringing in my ears.

Then the hotel alarm began.

Nigga, Zero had learned the wrong lesson from my rescuing people. He thought if he put enough of them in danger at once, I would have to choose which ones mattered.

I got up with my gun in my hand.

"Knox! Take Gideon. Don't let him near a fucking window!"

"Understood!"

"Tank, get everybody moving! South stairs!"

"On it!"

Shawna caught my arm.

"Marcellus."

We ran.

The corridor filled with smoke from the north wing. Guests came out in robes, evening clothes, half-packed confusion. Rosa

moved against them, guiding people toward the safe stairwell with the same voice she used to tell musicians they were playing the wrong song.

"South stairs! Keep moving! Shoes can be replaced! Your ass cannot!"

Mercedes carried the little dog under one arm and two gun cases under the other. Porsche helped a shaken violinist wrap a wet towel around her face. Magnolia came down the corridor with her cane and the hotel owner beside her.

"Bernard," she told him, "if you apologize for the inconvenience, I will strike you."

The owner shut his mouth.

I liked that woman more every time she threatened somebody.

Marcellus's door stood open.

Inside, he was putting the Crown of Midnight into its case. The old nigga had smoke around his ankles and was still handling the jewel like haste might offend its maker.

"Marcellus!"

"I am coming."

"Nigga, the hotel is actively leaving without us!"

He closed the case, picked up the small pouch containing Blue Mercy, and looked around once.

"Celeste's letter."

Shawna found it beside the lamp. She slipped it into his coat and took his arm.

"We have it. Let's go."

Another explosion shook the building.

The lights went out.

For a moment the only light came from the burning wing at the corridor's far end. Then emergency lamps flickered red along the floor.

I looked through a broken window into the courtyard.

Black Mantle trucks stood outside the gates. Men fired toward the hotel doors. Our cars were moving, one after another, drivers pulling them out of the north side before falling debris could trap them. June stood on the fountain wall directing traffic with a flare. Adrian drove a bus full of rescued workers toward the south exit.

The niggas had brought a war to a hotel full of people who had spent the last three days rehearsing survival together.

They were about to discover the difference.

Shawna took Marcellus toward the stairs.

I covered them until they reached Tank.

Then a scream came from the north corridor.

I turned.

A housekeeper stood beyond a fallen beam, holding another woman's arm. Both were grown. One had blood running from a cut above her eye. Behind them, fire licked up the curtains.

"Aiden!" Shawna called.

I looked back.

She saw them.

Then she nodded.

Nigga, she knew who she had married. Not because I was good. Because once I saw somebody reaching, I could never pretend my hands were empty.

I ran toward the beam.

Heat struck my face. The wood lay diagonally across the corridor, one end buried in a wall, the other resting on a crushed service cart. I tried lifting it. Pain tore through my shoulder. The beam moved an inch and settled back.

Blue light did not come.

I had spent it on the train. My body had nothing left to lend me.

"Nigga," I muttered, "we doing this regular."

I put my back beneath the higher end and pushed.

The wood creaked.

The women crouched.

I pushed harder. Every muscle in my legs shook. The old scar in my side pulled tight. Smoke filled my mouth. I heard one woman coughing as she crawled under, then the second.

The beam slipped.

I caught it on my shoulder and felt the whole world narrow to one bright point of pain.

Then enormous hands closed around the wood beside me.

Anton Atlas lifted.

The beam rose.

"Move," he said.

I moved.

He dropped it behind us and lifted the injured woman into his arms. I helped the other one walk. We reached the safe stairs with smoke following close behind.

"Nigga," I gasped, "you ever think about furniture delivery?"

Anton looked at me.

Then he laughed so hard he had to adjust the woman in his arms.

"Only if you stop breaking the buildings first."

At the foot of the stairs, Knox's officers formed a line across the lobby. Tank stood in the center with a shotgun. Rosa reloaded behind the reception desk. The piano had been pushed against

the doors as a barricade, and Sienna sat behind it holding a pistol like she had found a new string instrument she strongly disliked.

I looked at Tank.

"Everybody out?"

"South wing clear. June's got the buses. Victor and the dean checking the roof."

"Shawna?"

"With Marcellus. Crown's safe. Letters safe. Old nigga worried about his good shoes."

"Then he good."

A burst of gunfire shattered the lobby chandelier.

Crystal rained over the floor.

Tank ducked, then looked up at the ruined fixture.

"Niggas keep shooting the fancy shit."

I went to the doorway beside him.

Across the courtyard, a black armored car idled behind the attackers. Emperor Zero stood through its roof, watching his men fire into our hotel. At last the nigga had come himself. He wore a long black coat and no expression at all.

I stepped into view.

Our eyes met across the fountain.

He lifted one hand.

The guards aimed at me.

I fired first.

The shot struck the edge of the armored car's roof. Zero dropped inside. Tank fired beside me. Two guards fell back. Knox's officers joined, forcing the attackers behind their trucks.

Then Shawna drove the Last Word into the courtyard from the south passage.

Blue police lights cut through the smoke. June rode beside her, firing toward the trucks. My wife swung the car between the fountain and the lobby steps, putting its armored side between the doorway and Zero's men.

"Get in!" she yelled.

"The others!"

"Moving! Get in, nigga!"

Tank pushed Rosa into the back. I helped Sienna in beside her. Anton climbed onto the running board, one hand braced against the roof. The nigga made the car lean. June looked at him.

"You're affecting my suspension."

"I apologize."

"Don't be polite. It confuses me."

I got into the passenger seat as June moved to the rear. Shawna drove before I had closed the door.

We tore across the courtyard.

Zero's car backed toward the gate. I fired through the window, forcing its driver to turn sharply. The armored car struck a fountain pillar, recovered, and sped out into the street.

The emperor looked back at me through the rear glass.

I held his gaze until smoke hid him.

Nigga, there are promises a man makes out loud because people need to hear them. There are others he makes so quietly the whole world has to wait to learn what happened.

I made one then.

We regrouped at June's old garage outside the city wall.

The place was smaller than the hotel, dusty, crowded, and still standing. Adrian had brought the buses through first. Workers sat on tool chests and folding chairs, wrapped in blankets. The housekeepers I had helped were with Vega. Magnolia held Bernard's hand while he stared toward the smoke rising above his hotel.

I went to him.

"We'll rebuild it."

He shook his head.

"Forty years."

"I know."

"My wife chose the courtyard trees. She died before the second one flowered."

Nigga, I had come ready to promise money. The man had handed me something money could only stand beside.

I sat next to him on an overturned crate.

For a while neither of us spoke.

Then Shawna came over carrying a small clay pot.

Inside was a young palm shoot, its leaves dusty but green.

"June took it from the courtyard," she said. "It was by the kitchen door."

Bernard touched one leaf with his fingertip.

His face crumpled.

Magnolia put an arm around him.

I looked toward June. She stood beside Adrian pretending very hard to inspect a wheel.

"Nigga," I whispered, "that's a good mechanic."

Shawna leaned against me.

"I know."

Across the garage, Knox brought Gideon out of a locked office. His wrists were restrained. Liora stood several feet away, wearing a blanket over her shoulders. She did not go to him.

He looked at the smoke beyond the ridge.

"I didn't know."

Tank took one step forward.

I put a hand against his chest.

"I got it."

Gideon's eyes came to me.

"Captain, I swear—"

"Nigga, stop offering me your word. You spent it."

He lowered his head.

Knox took him back inside. He would leave with her officers when the road was safe. He had sold our rooms, our people, and the place where an old man remembered his wife. I did not need to shoot him to make what he had done remain true.

Liora watched the office door close.

Then she turned to June.

"You still need somebody who can fly an airship?"

June smiled.

"Nigga, we got a whole roof full of needs."

By sunset, the garage had become our last camp.

Cars stood in rows beneath the desert sky. The recovered fleet glittered beside buses and police vehicles. Sky High instructors helped mechanics hang lights. Sienna and her sister played quietly near the medical tables. Rosa handed out food. Tank sat

beside her whenever she stopped moving long enough to permit it.

Marcellus opened the Crown's case once, checked the jewel, then closed it and put it beneath his chair.

"Still beautiful?" I asked.

"Of course."

"Nigga, you could compliment me that confidently."

He looked up through his glasses.

"I engraved your car, young man. I am ahead of the conversation."

I laughed.

Roland came to stand beside me at the garage doors. Beyond the dunes, the Last City's inner fortress glowed red under the evening lights. Zero had retreated there after the hotel attack. The outer palace stood dark now, a beautiful empty shell.

"There is a ceremonial road through the western gorge," Roland said. "The emperor uses it when he wishes to be seen by his army."

"Wide enough for cars?"

"Wide enough for all of yours."

I looked at the rows behind me.

"Nigga, think carefully about that answer."

He almost smiled.

"Most of yours."

Shawna came to my side. Her dress from the emperor's dinner was gone, burned somewhere in the hotel. She wore a borrowed shirt, my ring, Dante's watch, and dust on one cheek.

She looked more like my future than any palace ever had.

"When?" she asked.

I watched the fortress lights.

"Tomorrow."

Tank joined us. Then Rosa. Then, without anybody calling them, the others came toward the garage doors. Cassius and Inez. Victor and Seraphine. Knox. Mercedes and Porsche. June and Adrian. Liora, Sienna, Magnolia, Bernard. Marcellus carrying his case.

All those people. All those lives. Nigga, every road I had driven had brought somebody here.

I turned toward them.

"Get some sleep."

Tank looked at the fortress.

"And tomorrow?"

I took my wife's hand.

"Tomorrow that nigga finds out who came to the city."

9. Every Nigga I Brought with Me

A nigga can stand alone and look magnificent. I had done it in enough mirrors to know. But that morning, when I stepped out of June's garage and saw every car waiting beneath the sunrise, I learned there was another kind of magnificent that required a whole lot of niggas to refuse to let you be alone.

Tank stood beside the Mercedes.

Cassius leaned against his racing car.

Victor sat on the hood of a police truck, eating a sandwich big enough to require faith.

Roland watched the fortress from the shade, the nigga still looking surprised that nobody had shot him during breakfast.

"Brother," Tank called, "you ready?"

"Nigga, look at me."

"That's what I'm doing. You standing there like the sun owes you money."

"The sun late."

Cassius laughed. "This nigga has an appointment with dawn."

Victor swallowed. "Dawn should apologize."

Nigga, those were my people.

Shawna came out behind me wearing white trousers, black boots, and the blue scarf around her hair. She had my spare badge pinned inside her jacket because Knox had given it to her after the arena and told every officer present that the woman was the only reason their captain remained available for duty.

I looked at the badge.

"They promoting you?"

"They supervising you."

"Nigga, you could've just bought a whistle."

She kissed me.

"I have other methods."

Tank turned away with a groan.

"Every fucking sunrise these niggas gotta remember they're married."

Rosa took his hand.

"You're next."

"I'm prepared."

"You cried over the flower photograph."

"Nigga, the shade of blue was emotional."

We laughed hard enough that the workers by the buses turned to look. Some joined in without knowing why. I liked that. I

wanted the last sound before the road to be something Zero could never order out of people.

Vega examined my shoulder one more time. The bruise had spread dark beneath the skin, ugly as a debt collector. She moved my arm, watched my face, and made a low disapproving sound.

"No hanging off trains today."

"What's the aircraft policy?"

"Aiden."

"Nigga, I'm clarifying."

She looked at Shawna.

"Don't let him be funny at the expense of having a skeleton."

My wife nodded solemnly.

"I will restrict him to ordinary greatness."

"There is no ordinary setting," Vega muttered.

I smiled. The doctor had known me long enough to make that diagnosis accurately.

Before we left, Marcellus opened the Crown's case in the garage office. Vesper stood beside him with the ledger copies.

Magnolia and Bernard watched from the door. We were not carrying the Crown into the first gunfight. The nigga who invented crowns had already made them inconvenient enough without expecting a man to wear one while driving under fire.

"It stays here until we know the road," I said.

Marcellus nodded.

"I am relieved you possess at least one sensible instinct."

"Nigga, I got several. They take shifts."

Vesper folded the pages into a waterproof folio.

"These come with me. Zero has commanders who believe their families are protected by his money. They deserve to see what he has actually promised them."

"Paper won't stop a bullet," Tank said.

"No," she replied. "But sometimes the man holding the gun stops himself."

Roland looked at her.

He did not answer. He did not need to. Yesterday the nigga had been proof of the problem. Today he was standing in our garage becoming proof of something else.

We left forty-seven prize cars behind with guards, workers, and the people who needed a safe route out. We took the cars we knew, the drivers we trusted, and enough friends to make the desert road look like an event somebody should have charged admission for.

The Last Word led.

Tank followed.

Behind him came Cassius, Inez, Knox's police convoy, and the trucks carrying our volunteers. Vesper rode with Mercedes and Porsche. Victor and Seraphine traveled with Liora toward the old airship berth on a separate road. Their job was above us. Mine was to get through the gorge without becoming its newest historical feature.

Roland sat in our rear seat.

Shawna watched him in the mirror.

"You sure about the road?"

"I led the emperor through it six times."

"Nigga, that's not the part I'm asking."

He met her eyes.

"I know."

After a moment she looked back at the road.

That was as much trust as he had earned. The nigga accepted it without asking for applause.

The gorge opened between red cliffs. A ceremonial arch marked its entrance. Above it, Zero's face had been carved into the rock, looking down at everybody who passed beneath his chin.

Tank came over the radio.

"This nigga got a mountain face."

"Bad likeness," I said.

"How?"

"Rock got more warmth."

Shawna laughed. Roland tried not to. I saw the nigga fail in the mirror and decided he was recovering nicely.

We passed beneath the arch.

Halfway through the gorge, the road widened into a circular square surrounded by statues of old rulers. A fountain stood dry in the middle. On the far side, a gold gate blocked the next stretch of road.

A woman in a black officer's coat waited before it with twenty guards.

She had close-cropped hair, dark skin, and a calm face that had not yet learned whether we were a threat or a rumor. A scar crossed one knuckle of the hand resting on her holster.

Roland leaned forward.

"Captain Noor Vale. Thirty-eight. No relation to Marcellus. She commands the gorge."

"She know you?"

"Yes."

"She like you?"

"Less lately."

"Nigga, join the club."

I stopped the car and got out.

Noor looked at my badge.

"Captain Aiden."

"Captain Noor."

Her eyes moved to Roland as he stepped out behind me.

"Ruin."

The nigga flinched like his name had acquired a blade.

"Noor."

"You alive?"

"Unexpectedly."

She looked at me again.

"Your reputation is growing tiresome. Every man I question begins by telling me what an extraordinary driver you are."

"Nigga, question better witnesses. Some of them seen me sing."

One of her guards laughed.

Noor did not turn around. The nigga stopped anyway.

"The gate remains closed."

Vesper stepped out of the black car.

"Then speak with me while it is closed."

Noor's expression changed. She knew Vesper. More than knew. I saw respect there, and an old resentment that had survived long enough to grow familiar.

"Your Majesty."

"My father knew your mother."

"My mother died waiting for his promises."

"Then you should read what his successor has promised you."

Vesper opened the folio.

Noor did not reach for it immediately. She looked at the guards, at our convoy, at the cliffs above us. A captain counting everything a wrong choice might cost.

Then she took the first page.

I stood beside Shawna while she read.

The desert wind moved through the square. Somebody's engine idled too loudly. Tank reached through his window and turned it off. For once the nigga did not need a joke to know what kind of moment we were in.

Noor read the second page.

Her face went still.

"My mother's house," she said.

Vesper nodded.

"Signed over three months ago. The pension account was emptied before that."

"He told me—"

"I know."

Nigga, I had seen men realize a lover did not love them. I had seen women discover the man they married had been keeping an exit inside his promises. This was something close to both. Noor had built her life around a place that had already sold the ground beneath her family.

She handed the pages back.

"I cannot open the gate on one document."

"Don't," I said.

She looked at me.

"Call her."

"My mother?"

"Nigga, she got a phone? Ask what happened at the house. Ask who came. Then look at the signature again."

Noor stood very still.

Then she took out her phone.

The first shot came from the cliff before the call connected.

A guard beside Noor fell against the fountain. Another shot struck the stone by Vesper's shoulder. I grabbed Shawna and

pulled her behind the Last Word. Tank was already out of the Mercedes, firing toward the ridge.

Noor stared upward.

"Those are imperial guns!"

"Nigga, your emperor impatient!" I shouted.

The gold gate began closing its smaller service door. Men on the wall above it turned their weapons toward the square.

Not just us.

Noor's guards too.

Her face changed.

She drew her pistol and fired at the wall.

"Cover the convoy!"

Her people obeyed.

Nigga, there are choices a man can write down before you understand them. There are others he writes in bullets where no loyal officer can pretend she has not read.

We fought beneath Zero's mountain face while his own captain covered my wife.

I fired toward the wall, moved behind the fountain, and helped the wounded guard crawl into cover. He was conscious, one hand pressed to his upper arm. His eyes found my badge.

"I was supposed to stop you."

"Nigga, you did. We having a whole conversation."

He laughed through clenched teeth.

Shawna reached him with a dressing from the car. I covered them while she worked. Above us, the cliff shook.

A deep crack ran through the carved emperor's face.

The gunfire had struck an old support beneath one of the decorative ledges. Stone began falling onto the road behind the convoy.

"Everybody forward!" Knox shouted.

The gold gate remained shut.

Behind us, the gorge was collapsing.

Tank looked from the gate to the falling rock.

"Brother!"

I saw the dry fountain. The sloping pedestal beneath the central statue. The low wall beside the gate. I saw June watching the same line from the passenger window of Adrian's coupe.

She shook her head.

Then she grinned.

Nigga, that was permission from the engineer of my bad ideas.

I ran back to the Last Word.

Shawna caught my sleeve.

"No lightning."

"No lightning."

"Promise."

"Baby, this one runs on gasoline and disrespect."

She let go.

I drove across the square, up the fountain's broad base, and onto the sloping pedestal. Stone scraped beneath the car. The Last Word climbed, engine roaring, then launched over the low wall beside the gate.

For one second I was above the guards.

Nigga, every man below looked up at me like the answer to a prayer he had phrased very badly.

The car landed on the other side, spun, and struck the inner gatehouse doors.

Wood burst inward.

I got out with my gun raised.

The two men inside looked at the car, then at me.

"Nigga," one said.

"Correct," I replied. "Open the gate."

They opened it.

Our convoy poured through as the carved face above the gorge cracked apart.

Zero's stone nose struck the empty fountain behind us with enough force to throw dust over the entire square.

Tank drove past me, laughing so hard Rosa had to tell him where the road was.

"You broke that nigga's nose from inside a car!"

"I didn't even touch it!"

"Your greatness got range!"

Noor brought her guards through last. Her wounded man lay in Knox's vehicle with Shawna beside him. The captain stopped in front of me and held out her hand.

"I am opening the second gate."

I shook it.

"Appreciate you."

"I have not joined your army."

"Nigga, I didn't ask you to. Just don't shoot my people."

She looked at the convoy, at Roland helping her men out of the dust, at Vesper holding the folio against her chest.

"That," Noor said, "I can promise."

The second gate opened onto a high road above the desert.

Beyond it, the inner fortress rose black against the sun. Airships moved around its towers. Guns gleamed along the walls. Zero's last city waited behind another hundred beautiful ways to die.

Shawna came back to me, dust on her face, blood on one sleeve that belonged to the guard she had helped.

"You kept the promise," she said.

"No lightning."

"Still a ridiculous amount of flying."

"Nigga, I should've read the small print."

She kissed me hard enough to make the bruised shoulder temporarily somebody else's problem.

Behind us, the convoy began cheering.

Every nigga I had brought with me was still coming.

10. My Wife Said Get Down from There

The fortress opened fire on us from the sky.

Three black aircraft came over the wall, low enough to make the road shake beneath their engines. The lead plane dipped toward the convoy. Its guns flashed.

"Spread out!" Knox shouted.

Cars swerved across the broad road. Bullets struck the stone between them. I pulled the Last Word beneath an overhanging cliff with Shawna beside me and Roland crouched in the rear. Tank's Mercedes stopped close enough for Rosa to open her window and swear directly into ours.

"These niggas brought planes to a fucking car fight!"

"Rude," Shawna agreed.

Tank looked up at the aircraft banking around for another pass.

"Brother, I can't ram that."

"Nigga, don't let limits define you."

He stared at me.

"You joking?"

"Mostly."

My radio crackled.

Liora's voice came through, clear and calm.

"Aiden. Look north."

Above the ridge, a silver airship rose into view.

Nigga, it was enormous. Not a little balloon with ambition. A whole floating palace, long as a city block, with blue fins and a glass cabin suspended beneath its belly. Along the side, workers had covered Zero's emblem with a white sheet. Somebody had painted a heart on the sheet.

Inside the heart were two names.

TANK + ROSA.

I looked at my brother.

The nigga's mouth fell open.

Rosa put a hand over hers.

"Liora," I said, "you steal us a wedding venue?"

"I borrowed the emperor's transport. The women added the rest."

Porsche's voice came from somewhere behind her.

"Nigga, love requires branding!"

Mercedes laughed.

"Tell Tank there's a dance floor!"

Tank looked at the sky like a man receiving a proposal from the weather.

"Brother."

"I see it."

"My name on a fucking airship."

"Nigga, you marrying Rosa. You thought the universe was gonna keep it small?"

The black planes turned toward the airship.

Victor Voltage dropped from its upper platform in a blaze of light.

He met the lead plane head-on, struck its wing with a burst that sent blue-white fire crawling across the metal, and rolled away before it could hit him. The plane banked sharply, smoke streaming from its engine. It turned back toward the fortress.

The second plane came after him.

Seraphine stood in the airship's open observation deck, one hand raised. Wind caught the aircraft beneath its wing and pushed it high. The pilot fought the tilt, regained control, and climbed away.

The third plane stayed low.

Its guns turned toward the road.

Shawna grabbed the wheel before I could move.

"Down."

"Baby—"

"Nigga, I mean your head."

We ducked as bullets tore across the cliff above us. Stone fragments rattled over the car's roof.

The plane vanished beyond the bend.

I looked at Roland.

"Where those niggas landing?"

"Eastern runway. It connects to the outer fortress court."

"Can Liora get over it?"

"She can. Getting you there is another question."

Nigga, I had become famous by refusing to admire a question without trying something unreasonable near it.

"Liora," I said into the radio, "bring that big beautiful thing low."

Shawna turned toward me slowly.

"Aiden."

"Hear me out."

"That phrase has cost us several vehicles."

"Only several? I'm improving."

The airship descended toward a broad turnout ahead of us. Beneath its cabin hung a vehicle cradle, an open platform meant for carrying the emperor's luxury cars from one palace to another. Liora brought it low enough for the support wheels to touch the road.

June looked at it from her car.

"No."

I smiled.

"Nigga, you don't even know what I'm thinking."

"I built the car you're thinking with. No."

Shawna took a long breath.

Then she opened her door.

"I'm coming."

"Baby—"

"Either I'm coming, or we're both staying here and you can explain to every nigga on the road why your wife grounded you."

Roland climbed out of the rear seat without being asked.

"I will remain with the conventional battle."

"Nigga got wisdom now," Tank said.

I drove the Last Word onto the cradle.

Shawna sat beside me, fastening her belt with the concentrated annoyance of a woman who loved me enough to participate and planned to mention it for the rest of my fucking life.

Liora lifted us.

The road fell away.

Tank stood below with Rosa's hand in his, looking up at his name on the airship and my car hanging beneath it.

"Brother!"

"What?"

"Don't scratch the wedding!"

We rose above the ridge.

The fortress spread beneath us: black walls, gold roofs, courtyards full of armored vehicles, fountains, runways, towers. Zero had built a city inside a city because apparently one level of owning everybody had failed to keep the nigga relaxed.

Shawna pressed her palm against the window.

"Aiden. Look."

At the far end of the runway stood a row of buses. People waited beside them under guard, carrying bags and small cases. The remaining palace staff. Musicians, cooks, drivers, housekeepers. Zero was taking the useful people inside and leaving everyone else where the next battle would find them.

I took the radio.

"Knox, east court. More people."

"We see the road. Noor is bringing her guards around."

"Liora, put us down there."

The third black plane came back over the wall.

It headed straight toward the airship.

Victor saw it from above and dived. The pilot turned sharply, forcing him away from the wing. Gunfire flashed along the plane's nose. Victor rolled beneath it, light flickering unevenly around his hands.

He had been fighting since the airship appeared. The nigga was strong, but strength spent itself when you asked enough of it.

Seraphine turned the wind again. The airship rocked. Our cradle swung beneath it.

Shawna caught the dashboard.

"Nigga!"

"I agree!"

The plane's wing struck one of the cradle's suspension arms.

Metal screamed.

The platform tilted.

Our car slid toward the edge.

Shawna hit the brake. I grabbed the side rail through my open window. The Last Word stopped with one wheel hanging over the air.

Nigga, there are views a man pays for and views a man should absolutely receive a refund for.

The desert was very far below.

"Aiden," Liora said, her voice tighter now, "I can lower you toward the runway. Hold position."

"Nigga, I wasn't planning to stroll."

The plane turned for another pass.

Victor rose to meet it.

This time I saw his face. Exhausted. Furious. My friend had enough charge for one more good hit and not enough room to miss.

"Victor!" I shouted.

He looked down.

I pointed at the runway.

Then at the plane.

Then at the airship's shadow crossing the ground.

The nigga understood. We had spent enough time being impossible together that a whole plan could fit between a finger and a bad smile.

Victor dropped low instead of charging high.

The pilot followed him.

Liora brought the cradle down.

We approached the runway at an angle, the damaged platform shaking beneath the Last Word. Shawna held the wheel while I

kept one arm braced against the door and watched the ground rise.

"Now?" she asked.

"Little more."

"Now?"

"Baby, I love how thorough you are."

"Nigga, answer the question."

The cradle's wheels struck the runway.

"Now."

She drove.

The Last Word shot off the platform just as the black plane came low behind Victor. My wife swung across the runway. I leaned out and fired at the empty maintenance carts lining the far edge. The carts rolled into the plane's approach as Victor climbed sharply.

The pilot pulled up to avoid them.

Too late to keep his landing gear from striking the highest cart.

The plane lurched, its wheels tearing free. It skidded onto the runway, sparks spraying beneath its belly, and came to a grinding stop against the far sand bank. The pilot crawled out, alive and waving both hands.

Victor landed beside him, breathing hard.

The pilot stared.

"You saved me."

Victor pointed at our car.

"That nigga taught me."

I heard him through the open window and smiled so hard
Shawna shook her head.

"You don't need more encouragement."

"Nigga, that's between me and my public."

We reached the buses under fire from the outer court.

The guards beside them looked at the police lights, the wrecked
plane, the airship descending above us, and the woman stepping
out of my car with a badge inside her jacket.

Shawna raised her pistol.

"Put them down."

One guard hesitated.

Then Mercedes leaned out of the airship cabin with a
loudspeaker.

"Nigga, she means the guns! This is not a difficult
conversation!"

The weapons hit the ground.

Porsche applauded from the window.

"Excellent listening!"

Noor's vehicles arrived through a service gate at the same moment. Her guards surrounded the buses. She spoke to the palace men by name, one after another, telling them the emperor had ordered fire on her unit and that anybody still interested in surviving should stop being impressed by his curtains.

Some believed her.

Some needed to see Roland step out of the next car with his torn white suit and no imperial gun.

One young guard looked at him.

"Commander?"

"Not anymore," Roland said.

The guard lowered his head. Then his weapon.

Nigga, that was how an army changed. Not all at once. Not because a crown shone at it. One tired man watching another tired man decide he had given enough of his life to the wrong motherfucker.

We got the buses moving toward the gorge.

Liora landed the airship in the outer court. Tank and Rosa arrived in the Mercedes as the cabin door opened. The two women who had painted the heart came down first, covered in white paint and laughing.

Rosa looked up at the enormous names on the airship's side.

"You spelled mine right."

"We value our lives," Porsche said.

Tank walked beneath the heart, tilted his head back, and put both hands on his hips.

"Nigga," he whispered.

Rosa stood beside him.

"Too much?"

He looked at her.

"Not even close."

She kissed him in the shadow of a stolen airship while police and criminals escorted people out of the emperor's fortress behind them.

I would have framed that picture if I had not been busy trying to keep the fucking building from shooting us.

A heavy door opened in the inner wall.

Three armored vehicles rolled out.

The lead turret turned toward the airship.

Tank broke the kiss and looked at the gun.

"Oh, these niggas not shooting my wedding."

He ran to the Mercedes.

Rosa ran with him.

I got behind the Last Word's wheel again. Shawna fastened her belt, looked at the armored line, then at the scraped blue hood of our car.

"June is going to yell."

"Nigga, June loves me."

"Those two things are becoming closely related."

We drove forward together, my wife beside me, my brother on my right, the whole sky full of friends who had come too far to let one emperor decide what happened next.

11. The Traffic Stop Heard Around the World

I pulled over an armored vehicle for obstructing my brother's wedding.

Nigga, I know what that sounds like. I was there when it sounded like that.

The thing rolled out of the inner fortress with a gun on top and enough steel around it to make a bank vault feel underdressed. Two more followed. Their engines shook the courtyard. Behind us, Liora's airship stood full of rescued people, wedding musicians, and one enormous sample cake that Tank had refused to abandon during the hotel fire.

There was no room for those vehicles to fire without hitting somebody I knew.

So I drove straight at the first one.

Shawna looked at me.

"Aiden."

"I got a badge."

"Nigga, it has a cannon."

"Then it's overcompensating."

I hit the siren.

Blue lights flashed across black armor. The driver looked down through the thick front window and saw a police car approaching him with all the confidence of a man who had never been told a law could lose an argument to a larger object.

I leaned out with the loudspeaker Knox had left under my seat.

"Driver! Pull to the side!"

The turret turned.

"Nigga, that is not the side!"

Shawna laughed once, sharp and terrified, as I swerved under the barrel. The gun fired over us. The blast struck an empty tower at the courtyard's edge, blowing stone into the air.

Tank came through the dust on our right.

Rosa leaned out his window.

"You almost hit my fucking cake!"

Nigga, the woman had found the correct moral center of the battle.

We split around the lead vehicle. Cassius and Inez crossed behind it, drawing the second one's attention away from the airship. Knox's officers moved the buses through the service gate while Noor's guards covered the road. Everybody had a job. Mine was making the largest object in the courtyard regret noticing me.

I circled the armored vehicle, close enough to see its driver struggling to turn inside the narrow space between two stone planters. The nigga had steel, firepower, and a terrible turning circle. I had a car June had built angry and a wife who knew exactly when to stop telling me something was stupid because she needed both hands free to help.

"Ramp," Shawna said.

Ahead of us, a broad ceremonial stair rose toward the palace terrace. Beside it stood a sloping display plinth where Zero had intended to exhibit a gold racing car. The car was gone. The ramp remained.

I looked at the armored vehicle.

Then at the ramp.

"Baby."

"I know."

"You mad?"

"Ask when we're horizontal again."

I accelerated.

The Last Word climbed the plinth, launched over the armored vehicle's front corner, and landed on its rear deck with a crash that knocked every thought out of my head except the one still yelling drive.

Nigga, we were on top of the motherfucker.

The turret could not lower far enough to hit us. The driver braked. I braked with him. The car shuddered against the steel beneath it, one rear wheel hanging near the edge.

Shawna looked through her window at the courtyard below.

"You have parked worse."

I kissed her cheek.

"Watch the door."

I climbed out onto the armored roof.

A hatch opened in front of me. A man emerged with a pistol in his hand.

I kicked the pistol away, caught his collar, and pulled him onto the deck beside the car.

"License and registration."

The nigga stared at me.

"You're insane."

"That's not a license."

Below us, Tank laughed so loudly I heard it over both engines.

The man reached for my shoulder. I hit him once, hard enough to settle the discussion, then held my gun toward the open hatch.

"Everybody inside! Hands where I can see them!"

Three sets of hands appeared.

Nigga, sometimes policing is mostly conviction.

The second armored vehicle turned toward us.

Its gun lifted.

I saw the barrel come level with my chest.

Then Anton Atlas dropped onto its roof from the palace terrace.

The whole machine rocked.

The nigga had jumped from a second-floor balcony because apparently after you fight me onstage, architecture begins to look optional. He tore the hatch open and shouted something into it that I could not hear but immediately respected.

The turret stopped moving.

The third vehicle tried to reverse toward the inner gate.

Cassius and Inez blocked its path with two racing cars angled across the opening. The driver hesitated, unwilling to crush machines worth more than his annual loyalty.

Inez leaned out.

"Nigga, choose carefully! That's my father's car!"

The driver raised both hands behind the glass.

Cassius bowed from his seat.

"Excellent appreciation of automotive history."

In less than three minutes, the emperor's armored line had become the most expensive traffic stop ever conducted by a nigga with coffee stains still hidden somewhere in his wardrobe.

Knox walked up beneath my vehicle.

She looked at the Last Word perched on top of it.

Then she looked at me.

"Captain."

"Chief."

"I am struggling to choose which part of this to commend."

"Nigga, start with efficiency."

She smiled so broadly I thought she might promote me on the spot and make somebody else deal with the paperwork.

Noor's guards escorted the crews away. One of the drivers kept looking back at me.

"What?" I asked.

"My brother said you won the World Championship."

"Yeah."

"Everything?"

"Nigga, they kept adding events. I kept having afternoons."

He shook his head, amazed, and let Knox's officer lead him away.

June arrived five minutes later.

She stopped beneath the armored vehicle and looked up at her car.

Nobody spoke.

Adrian stood beside her with both hands on his head.

Finally June said, "Aiden."

"Nigga, before you start—"

"You put my car on a tank."

"Armored vehicle."

"You correcting me from on top of a tank?"

Shawna opened the passenger door and looked down.

"He used the siren first."

June stared at her.

Then she started laughing. Adrian joined her. The niggas laughed until the anger ran out of the shape of it, and I knew the Last Word would survive because its makers were already deciding which part of the story they would tell first.

They got the car down using the fortress's own maintenance equipment. I did not offer to help. I had learned that when a mechanic is rescuing something you parked on military hardware, suggestions are just another way to get hit with a wrench.

We moved the rescued people into the outer court's guest houses. Liora prepared the airship to carry the first group beyond the fighting. The heart on its side had a bullet hole through one

corner. Rosa inspected it and declared the damage acceptable as long as nobody touched her name.

Tank stood beneath the airship with me while our people worked.

For a while the nigga said nothing.

I watched him watching Rosa.

"You thinking about flowers again?"

"No."

"Cake?"

"No."

"Nigga, you running out of subjects."

He smiled, then let it fade.

"I keep seeing her in that hotel hallway. Smoke everywhere. She was telling everybody where to go, and I thought, if I lose this woman now, after all that shit, after we finally got a date—"

He stopped.

I knew the rest. I had built a whole life out of refusing to say the rest until it became a gun in my hand.

"You ain't losing her today."

"You don't know that."

Nigga, the words landed harder because Tank never asked me to admit I did not know something. He was my brother. He had

watched me become ridiculous enough that the world sometimes cooperated. But he still knew there were nights a man could not bully into a promise.

I looked at Rosa. She was laughing with Liora, one hand pressed over the bullet hole in the painted heart.

"No," I said. "I don't."

Tank nodded once, like the truth had steadied him more than the lie would have.

"I know what I'm doing about it, though," I added.

"What?"

"Same as you. Staying close. Shooting straight. Making sure the nigga who keeps bringing us this shit runs out of places to stand."

Tank looked toward the inner fortress.

"Then we go home."

"Then we go home."

He held out his fist.

I touched it with mine.

My brother's hands were scarred, broad, warm. I had seen those hands hurt people and carry people and hold a pair of green shoes under a ballroom piano. Nigga, there was no simple story about a man like Tank. That was why I wanted him beside me when the complicated part finally ended.

Rosa called us over.

"You two done being tragic? I need measurements."

Tank blinked.

"For what?"

"The suits. The tailor's on the phone."

"Baby, we in a fortress."

"And your shoulders will still be that size in Vegas. Come here."

I laughed.

Tank looked at me.

"Nigga, don't enjoy this alone. She needs yours too."

We stood beside an airship full of rescued palace staff while Rosa gave our measurements to a tailor an ocean away. Every time Tank tried to shift, she slapped his arm. Every time I made a joke, Shawna corrected a number Rosa had guessed from memory.

"You know my measurements like that?" I asked.

My wife looked at me.

"Aiden."

"Nigga, excellent point."

The tailor asked what kind of ceremony required two men with our measurements and that much blue silk.

Rosa looked at Tank.

Shawna looked at me.

"A very good one," they said together.

Behind us, the fortress's inner bell began ringing.

The sound rolled through the courts, deep and slow.

Roland came out of the command building with Vesper beside him.

"Zero has called the remaining captains inside," he said. "He is closing the inner palace."

Noor joined them, her face hard.

"My sister serves in that guard. I cannot reach her."

Vesper held the folio against her chest.

"Then we go before the doors close."

I looked at Tank.

He put the phone back in Rosa's hand, kissed her forehead, and picked up his gun.

"Save my measurements," he said. "Nigga's coming back to use them."

I took Shawna's hand.

The bell rang again.

We walked toward it together.

12. The Captain Who Wouldn't Kneel

Noor's sister stopped us at the inner palace with a gun pointed at my chest.

She was thirty-four, wore the same black coat as Noor, and had the same steady eyes. The difference was that Noor had spent the morning watching her emperor try to kill her. Her sister had spent it inside a beautiful building being told a very different story.

"Salma," Noor said.

"You brought him here."

I looked at the gun.

"Nigga, I'm popular, but you can say my name."

Salma did not smile.

"Captain Aiden. Murderer, thief, foreign officer."

"Singer," Shawna added.

"My wife likes a complete introduction."

Behind Salma, a line of guards held the palace doors. Beyond them stood a hall of mirrors and marble, bright enough to make every armed nigga appear to have several equally bad ideas at once.

Noor stepped forward.

Salma's gun moved toward her.

That hurt the older sister. I saw it before she hid it.

"Call Mother," Noor said.

"I have orders not to use outside lines."

"Then break one."

"You ask me to betray my post."

"I'm asking you to speak to your mother."

Nigga, the words hung between them like something too ordinary for the room to know how to defend against.

Salma glanced at the guards behind her. One looked away. Another tightened his grip. They all knew this was bigger than a checkpoint and smaller than the empire at the same time.

Vesper held out the ledger copies.

"Read these."

Salma shook her head.

"Forged."

"You haven't looked."

"The emperor warned us."

Shawna stepped beside Noor.

"Did he warn you about the hotel?"

"A rebel stronghold."

"There was a man inside who planted trees with his wife. There were women who'd spent the day making music. There was a cook who had just escaped your arena. If you want to call them something else, you should at least meet them first."

Salma's jaw tightened.

"And the guns?"

"Nigga," I said, "those were mine. You can have a problem with me. Leave the cook out of it."

A guard behind her laughed once before remembering where he stood.

Salma looked at me. Really looked. At the bruised shoulder beneath my torn shirt, the badge, the sword at my hip, my wife's hand resting against my arm. Maybe she expected a monster to arrive more neatly separated from the people who loved him.

Then the doors behind her locked.

A heavy bolt slammed into place.

She turned.

The guards looked at one another.

Above us, a balcony door opened. A palace officer stepped out with two Black Mantle men.

"Captain Salma Vale," he called. "Your loyalty is under review."

Noor drew her gun.

"Salma, move!"

The officer fired.

I hit Salma around the waist and drove her behind a marble bench as the shot struck the place her head had occupied. Noor fired upward. Shawna pulled Vesper into cover. Tank and Anton moved in front of the younger guards, forcing them away from the open steps.

Salma lay beneath me for one second, staring at the balcony.

"He ordered me to hold this door."

"Nigga, he just updated the assignment," I said.

I got off her and fired at the balcony rail. The officer ducked. Noor reached her sister and pulled her close, one hand behind her head like she had done it a thousand times before either woman owned a gun.

"You hit?"

Salma shook her head.

"No."

"Then think while you're alive."

The younger woman swallowed.

Then she turned toward her guards.

"Cover the stairs!"

They obeyed her. Not Noor. Not me. Their own captain, choosing where the next bullet ought to go.

Nigga, I respected that so much I almost forgot the door remained a problem.

Almost.

"Tank!"

He looked at the locked doors.

Then at me.

"You want the quiet opening or the brother opening?"

"Nigga, read the room."

He grinned and called Anton.

The two giants hit the doors together.

Marble dust fell from the frame.

They hit them again.

One of Salma's guards stared.

"Those men—"

"Are on the guest list," Shawna said.

The third impact broke the lower hinge.

Tank grabbed the edge. Anton caught the other side. Together they dragged the door inward with a scream of metal that sounded like the palace reconsidering its construction standards.

I went through first.

The hall beyond was empty.

Too empty.

Mirrors reflected us from every wall. Gold lamps shone above a long carpet. At the far end, a staircase rose to another set of doors. On the carpet between stood a single black grand piano.

I stopped.

"Baby."

"I see it."

A sheet of paper rested on the piano.

FOR MRS. AIDEN. AN ENCORE.

Shawna looked at the note and shook her head.

"Nigga keeps booking shows without checking my calendar."

A curtain moved above us.

I saw the gun behind it.

"Down!"

The mirrors shattered.

Gunfire ripped across the hall from the upper galleries. Glass burst into a thousand glittering pieces. Tank kicked the piano sideways, turning it into cover. We dropped behind it while Noor and Salma pulled their guards through the damaged doorway.

Nigga, I had entered enough expensive rooms lately that I was beginning to understand why rich people insured things.

Shawna crouched beside me, her back against the piano.

"You think he has a second song request?"

"Yeah. It's called Stop Shooting My Fucking Furniture."

She laughed, then rose just enough to fire toward the nearest gallery.

I moved with her.

Tank and Anton took the left staircase. Noor and Salma took the right. Vesper stayed with the guards at the door, reading the room through the remaining mirrors, calling where she saw movement.

"Above the red curtain!"

I fired.

A gun fell from the gallery and struck the marble.

"Behind the clock!"

Shawna's shot shattered the clock face. The guard behind it vanished backward with a shout.

The women did not miss much.

I reached the central stairs as a Black Mantle fighter came down toward me. He swung a heavy pistol like a hammer. I caught his

wrist, hit his elbow, and drove him against the railing. The gun went over. He came after it until I caught the back of his coat.

For one second the nigga hung above the hall, his life attached to the hand of the man he had tried to kill.

"You done?" I asked.

He nodded frantically.

"Use words."

"I'm done!"

I pulled him back over and put him on the floor.

"Excellent progress."

Another man appeared above me with a long blade.

I drew Knox's sword.

The nigga stopped.

"Oh," he said.

"Yeah," I replied. "They gave me one too."

He attacked.

Steel rang across the staircase. I blocked, stepped back, and felt the old bruise in my shoulder send a complaint directly to my brain. The man was quick. He knew the stairs. He kept pressing me toward the broken railing.

I let him think it was working.

Then I stepped onto the narrow ledge beside the stairs, caught the hanging lamp chain with my free hand, and swung around his back.

Nigga, the look on his face when I landed above him belonged in a museum.

I struck his blade aside and drove the sword's hilt into his chest. He lost his footing and sat down hard on the steps. Before he could rise, Shawna stood below him with her pistol raised.

"Stay seated," she said.

The nigga stayed seated.

I looked down at her.

"Teamwork."

"Your shoulder."

"Complaining."

"I am going to join it."

We reached the upper landing together.

Below us, the hall's gunfire stopped one burst at a time. Tank came out of the left gallery dragging a guard by the belt. Anton carried two more by the backs of their coats. Noor and Salma stood on the right with their weapons raised over a row of surrendering men.

The younger captain looked across the hall at her sister.

For a moment both women were too far apart to touch.

Then Noor smiled.

Salma smiled back.

Nigga, there was a whole childhood in that look, and no emperor owned a minute of it.

A palace phone rang on a side table.

Everybody froze.

I walked over and answered.

"Captain Aiden's extremely busy afternoon."

Zero's voice filled my ear.

"You have destroyed a room built by kings."

I looked at the broken mirrors, the shattered clock, the piano Tank had used as a barricade.

"Nigga, send the kings my apologies."

"You think destruction proves greatness."

"No. You shooting your own captain proved something, though."

Silence.

Then the emperor spoke more quietly.

"Come to the midnight court. Bring the crown. Let us settle what you came for."

"You finally meeting me without shooting through a curtain?"

"The court will witness us."

I looked at Vesper below. She heard enough from my face to understand.

"What court?" I asked.

"The rulers you have impressed. The captains you have stolen. The people who believe you can offer them something I cannot. I have invited them to see you closely."

"Nigga, they'll need better chairs. My people travel heavy."

He disconnected.

I set down the phone.

Shawna came to my side.

"He wants an audience."

"So do I."

"Aiden."

I turned toward her.

She touched my bruised shoulder, then the cross beneath my shirt.

"Finish it."

No flourish. No speech about what kind of man I ought to become after the shooting stopped. Just my wife asking for the thing we had both carried across every road that brought us here.

I kissed her.

"I will."

Down in the hall, Salma finally called her mother.

Noor stood beside her while the phone rang.

When the older woman's voice answered, both captains closed their eyes.

I looked away and let them have it.

Then I called Marcellus.

"Bring the crown," I said. "That nigga wants to see how it looks on me."

13. Put the Crown on the Correct Nigga

Marcellus brought the Crown of Midnight into the ruined hall wearing a clean jacket and an expression of professional offense.

"You might have left me one mirror," he said.

I looked around at the broken glass.

"Nigga, you look excellent."

"That is not the same as checking."

Shawna took a compact from her pocket and held it for him. He adjusted his collar, thanked her, and opened the case on the only table we had not damaged.

The crown shone beneath the lamps.

Gold. Dark stones. Old workmanship. A thing men had spent years trying to own because they thought putting it on their heads would make the thoughts inside more valuable.

I already knew what my thoughts were worth. I wanted the crown because I had won it and because, nigga, it looked fucking expensive.

Marcellus lifted it.

"Stand still."

I stood still.

He placed it on my head.

Tank looked at me.

Then at the crown.

Then back at me.

"Nigga."

"What?"

"That's a lot of you at once."

Cassius put one hand over his heart. "My brother, I am going to need a larger painting."

Victor folded his arms. "The academy will be unbearable. They already discuss his cheekbones in meetings."

"Those niggas have standards," I said.

Shawna stepped in front of me.

She looked at the crown for a long moment, then reached up and moved it slightly to one side.

"There."

"Better?"

"More you."

I kissed her.

Behind us, a palace guard whispered to another man, "That nigga looks born in it."

The other guard nodded. "I thought the emperor was going to be the tallest thing in the room."

"Nigga, he hasn't seen this yet."

I turned toward them.

"Speak up. Confidence matters."

Both men stood straighter.

Shawna covered her face.

"You are going to be impossible all afternoon."

"Baby, I scheduled the whole evening."

The midnight court stood beyond the ruined hall, at the center of the inner palace. Its doors were black wood inlaid with stars.

Two guards opened them when Vesper approached, and for the first time since entering the fortress, nobody immediately tried to shoot us.

I appreciated a room willing to establish a little suspense.

The court was round, with a glass dome above and a floor of black marble. Seats rose in a circle around a central platform.

Men and women filled them: officers, merchants, old criminal rulers, palace favorites, people who had come because Zero ordered it and people who had stayed because they wanted to see what happened when the nigga everyone talked about finally stood in front of the man who owned the talking.

Zero waited on the platform.

A sword hung at his side.

Nigga, finally. Something honest about the invitation.

He watched me enter wearing the crown.

I saw the moment the sight hurt him.

He hid it quickly. He was good at that. But I had spent too long loving a woman with a dead man's watch on her wrist to miss the exact place a man's pride could bruise beneath a calm face.

"Captain," he said.

"Emperor."

"The crown suits your appetite."

"Nigga, everything suits me. You picked an inconvenient enemy."

A few people laughed before catching themselves.

Zero heard them.

So did I.

My people spread along the court's lower seats. Shawna stayed at my right. Tank at my left. Vesper stood behind us with the folio. Marcellus took a seat beside Magnolia, the empty crown case on his knees. Knox remained near the doors with Noor and Salma. Cassius, Inez, Victor, Seraphine, Rosa, Mercedes, Porsche, June, Adrian, Liora—everybody who had crossed a road or a sky to reach this room found a place where they could see me.

Nigga, if the emperor wanted an audience, I had brought the part that mattered.

Zero raised one hand.

The room quieted.

"You have heard stories of this man," he said. "You have watched him seize cars, command officers, entertain crowds, and name himself king. You have mistaken spectacle for permanence."

"Nigga, I been permanent all week," Tank muttered.

Rosa put a hand on his arm, smiling.

Zero continued.

"What remains after the cheering ends? What can Captain Aiden offer that an empire cannot?"

I looked around the room.

At the officers who had been ordered to fire on their own captains. At the palace workers standing near the doors because they had not yet decided they were allowed to sit. At Roland in his torn white suit, alive because I had pulled him out of the car Zero had sent men to shoot.

Then I looked at my wife.

She did not nod. She did not tell me what answer would make me good.

She waited to hear me.

"A ride home," I said.

Zero frowned.

"For who?"

"Whoever came with me. Whoever decides to leave with me. Whoever you keep telling can't go until you're finished needing them. Nigga, I got a lot of cars. It's not a complicated offer."

A murmur moved through the seats.

"And afterward?" Zero asked.

"Afterward I marry my wife again. My brother gets married. We eat too much, spend too much, and wake up somewhere you can't call to ruin the fucking morning."

"A small ambition."

"Nigga, you built all this because nobody wanted to stay for breakfast. Don't talk to me about ambition."

The room went silent.

Not polite silence.

The kind where everybody suddenly knows which sentence will be remembered if the shooting starts.

Zero's face changed. For a moment I saw the man beneath the emperor. Not wounded innocence. Not some little boy a story could excuse into a throne. A grown man who had spent years choosing to hurt people and still hated discovering they might laugh at him.

He looked at Shawna.

Then at Tank.

Then at me.

"I could have made you my heir."

"Nigga, I already inherited enough bad ideas."

"The world would have opened to us."

"It keeps opening when I knock. You the nigga hiding behind doors."

He drew his sword.

The sound ran through the court like a match being struck.

I drew mine.

Knox sat forward, looking proud enough to make every officer around her nervous.

"Excellent purchase," she whispered.

Shawna took the crown off my head.

I looked at her.

"You don't want it scratched," she said.

"Nigga, priorities."

She kissed me once, directly on the mouth, in front of the emperor and every person he had invited to watch me fail.

Then she stepped back holding the crown in both hands.

I climbed onto the platform.

Zero attacked before I reached the center.

Fast. Hard. None of the decorative bullshit I had expected from a man with that many portraits. His blade struck mine with enough force to send pain through my shoulder. I stepped back, turned the second strike, and nearly lost my footing on the polished marble.

The nigga had trained.

Good.

I was tired of men confusing money with being able to swing a sword.

He pressed forward, driving me toward the platform's edge. The court watched without breathing. I heard Tank shift in his seat. I heard Rosa catch his wrist.

"Stay," she whispered.

Zero smiled.

"Your friends are anxious."

"Nigga, they got dinner reservations."

I turned his next strike, stepped inside the reach, and hit him with my shoulder.

The bruised one.

Pain flashed white.

But Zero went backward.

I followed, striking high, then low, making the nigga work for every inch he had thought the throne would give him. His blade caught mine. We locked close enough for me to see sweat at his hairline.

"You should be exhausted," he said.

"Nigga, I'm married. I learned endurance."

I shoved him away.

The audience laughed.

That cost him more than the shove.

He came at me harder. I let him spend it. Step back. Turn. Strike. The sword in my hand felt heavy now, but I knew heavy. I had carried money, bodies, grief, guns, my wife up a fucking palace staircase. Weight had never been enough to persuade me I should put down what I wanted.

Zero cut my sleeve.

A hot line opened along my upper arm.

Shawna's fingers tightened around the crown.

I saw it.

The nigga saw me see it.

He aimed the next strike toward her side of the court, making me turn my body to block him from the edge.

That was when he understood the advantage he thought he had.

"There," he whispered.

He attacked toward the seats.

I met him before he could reach them.

Our swords rang. I pushed him back onto the platform, furious now, and the fury made me careless for half a second. He struck my wrist. My sword slipped. I caught it lower, barely, and felt the hilt bite my palm.

Zero smiled.

"Every man has a place he can be led."

"Nigga," I said, "you keep confusing love with a leash."

I stepped forward instead of back.

His eyes widened.

I caught his blade against the side of mine, turned beneath his arm, and drove my elbow into his ribs. He staggered. I struck his wrist with the hilt. The sword flew from his hand and slid across the platform.

I put my blade against his throat.

The court rose.

Every nigga in that room stood at once.

Zero held still.

For the first time, the emperor had no door between us.

I could have ended him there.

Then a gunshot cracked from the upper seats.

The glass dome shattered.

A section of the metal frame broke loose above the lower row where Marcellus sat.

I saw the old man look up.

I moved before the thought finished.

I left Zero.

I jumped from the platform, hit Marcellus's chair, and drove both of us beneath the stone lip of the lower aisle as the frame crashed down where his head had been.

Glass filled the air.

The court screamed.

Tank fired toward the upper seats. Knox's officers moved. Shawna dropped behind the bench with the crown pressed to her chest. Vesper pulled Magnolia clear of the falling frame.

Marcellus lay beside me, stunned, his glasses crooked.

"My case," he whispered.

"Nigga, your head first."

I looked back at the platform.

Zero was gone.

A door behind the throne stood open.

The nigga had ordered his own court shattered so he could escape the moment it saw him lose.

Rage moved through the room faster than the gunfire.

Noor's guards turned on the Black Mantle shooters. Salma pulled the palace workers into the lower aisle. Roland climbed the seats after a man who had fired at us, caught him by the coat, and dragged him down before he could reload.

The emperor had invited witnesses.

Now every witness had seen enough.

Shawna reached me with the crown under one arm.

"Marcellus?"

"Alive," the old man said, offended to be discussed while present.

She touched his cheek, then mine.

My arm bled through the torn sleeve.

"Aiden."

"I know."

Tank came up beside us.

"That nigga ran."

I looked at the open door behind the throne.

"Then we finish moving."

Shawna gave the crown to Marcellus.

He held it with both hands.

"I will keep this safe," he said.

I nodded.

Then I picked up my sword, took my wife's hand, and went after the man who had finally run out of beautiful rooms where somebody else could die for him.

14. The Last Road Out

Zero's private corridor ended in a garage full of black cars.

Nigga, even the man's escape plan had a showroom.

We came through the door as his last guards opened fire from behind a limousine. Tank pulled Rosa behind a pillar. Shawna and I dropped beside a low sports car. Bullets struck its hood, leaving bright scars in paint somebody had probably spent a whole family's wages polishing.

I fired toward the limousine.

"Zero!"

At the far end of the garage, the emperor turned beside a black-and-gold hypercar. He looked at my bleeding arm, my sword, my wife crouched beside me with her gun steady.

The nigga looked tired of discovering we were still real.

"You could have stayed in Vegas," he called.

"Nigga, you could have stayed out of my fucking life!"

He got into the car.

A blast door rose behind him, revealing a road that climbed through the palace gardens toward the upper launch deck. His engine roared. The car shot through the opening.

The door began closing.

Shawna looked at the nearest vehicle.

A small white electric cart stood beside the wall.

We both looked at it.

Then at each other.

"No," she said.

"Nigga, I'm flexible, not humiliating."

The Last Word crashed through the garage's opposite entrance.

June leaned out the window.

"You ordered a car?"

"Nigga, I ordered a miracle!"

"Then quit scratching it!"

She jumped out while the car still rolled slowly. Adrian caught her hand and pulled her behind cover. I slid into the driver's seat. Shawna took the other side. Tank climbed onto the rear step, then Rosa caught his jacket.

"You stay with me."

He looked at her.

"Brother needs—"

"His wife is with him. This woman is asking you to stay."

The nigga stopped.

I met his eyes through the window.

"Get our people out."

He nodded.

Then he hit the roof with one broad hand.

"Bring your ass home."

"Nigga, save me a seat."

I accelerated beneath the closing door.

The metal scraped the roof as we passed. Shawna ducked on instinct. We burst into a garden full of white statues and orange trees, Zero's taillights already climbing the road ahead.

Behind us, the blast door slammed shut.

For the first time since morning, it was just me, my wife, and the man we had crossed the world to finish.

Nigga, the world got very quiet around that fact.

Zero took the garden road fast. He knew every curve. His car hugged the stone wall, black paint flashing beneath the lights. I followed close enough to see him glance into the mirror.

Shawna held the radio.

"Liora. Where does the upper road go?"

"Launch deck. Private escape craft. There is a bridge across the canyon before the hangar."

"Can you reach it?"

"We are bringing the airship around. Victor is with me."

"Good."

She looked at me.

"No private escape craft for that nigga."

"Nigga should've booked commercial."

Zero fired through his window.

The bullet cracked the Last Word's windshield. A white star spread across the glass. I swerved, returned a shot, and heard it strike his rear panel.

He accelerated.

We climbed a spiral road around a tower. Below us, the inner courts flickered with gunfire as his remaining men fought people who had finally stopped obeying them. Above, aircraft circled the launch deck. One turned toward the airship rising beyond the wall.

Victor flashed blue across the sky.

Shawna watched him.

"Your nigga's still up."

"He's stubborn."

"Wonder where he learned that."

I smiled without taking my eyes off the road.

At the top of the spiral, Zero's car struck a gate and burst onto the launch deck.

We followed through falling ironwork.

The deck stretched over the canyon on black steel supports. A narrow bridge connected it to a hangar built into the opposite cliff. Beyond that, the desert rolled away beneath the late sun, wide enough to hide a man if the man could get there.

Zero drove toward the bridge.

A private aircraft waited at the hangar, engines turning.

The pilot saw us coming and began to move.

Then Liora's airship rose beside the hangar like a silver moon with my brother's name on it.

The pilot stopped.

Porsche's voice boomed from the loudspeaker.

"Nigga, departure is canceled!"

Mercedes added, "And keep your hands where the women can see them!"

I laughed so hard Shawna slapped my arm.

"Drive!"

Zero heard them too.

His car slowed.

For one second I thought the nigga might finally stop running.

Then he turned sharply toward a side road descending beneath the bridge.

"There another way?" I shouted into the radio.

Liora answered immediately.

"Old service road. It reaches the bottom of the canyon."

"Of course it does."

We followed.

The road narrowed against the cliff. No guardrail on the outside. Rock on the inside. The canyon fell away beside Shawna's window in a long red drop.

She looked down once.

Then she looked at me.

"You got me?"

Nigga, she did not say it like a frightened woman asking a hero to become somebody else. She said it like my wife, who had held my shaking hands after lightning, driven me out of gunfire, and watched me put every version of my life between her and a door.

"Always."

She nodded.

Then she leaned out and fired at Zero's rear tire.

The first shot struck the road.

The second struck metal.

The third made his car twitch sideways.

"Baby!"

"I told you to keep up!"

Zero fought the wheel. His car clipped the cliff, throwing sparks, then straightened on the narrow road. He had skill. I hated that nigga, but I would not lie about what my eyes saw. The man could drive when his whole life sat behind the accelerator.

So could I.

We descended toward a lower bridge spanning the canyon's narrowest point.

The bridge was old, decorative, built for ceremonial cars before Zero had discovered armored excess. Its stone arches shone in the dying light. Beneath them, dark water moved through the canyon bottom.

Zero reached it first.

Halfway across, his damaged tire failed.

The car swung sideways.

He struck the bridge wall hard enough to break the stone.

I braked.

The Last Word slid toward him.

For a moment our two cars moved together in the dust, mine still straight, his broadside across the bridge. I turned toward the gap beside him, trying to pass without pushing his wreck into the river.

Then the bridge began to break.

A deep crack opened beneath Zero's car. Stone dropped into the water. The whole middle section sagged.

Shawna grabbed my arm.

I saw the far end rising relative to us. Saw the gap opening where the road should have been. Saw Zero trying to reverse while his rear wheel spun uselessly in the air.

I had one burst left in me.

Maybe.

Nigga, maybe is a terrible word when your wife is in the passenger seat.

I put both hands on the wheel.

Blue light ran across my fingers.

Pain followed it.

The Last Word's engine surged as the charge passed through the car. The world sharpened, not slow enough to make me a god, just clear enough to show me exactly how little room remained for a man.

I drove.

The car jumped the breaking seam.

Its rear wheels struck the far edge.

Stone shattered beneath them.

We landed beyond the failing middle span and skidded into the cliff wall on the other side.

The engine died.

The blue light went out.

My hands fell off the wheel.

For a moment I could not move.

Shawna turned toward me.

"Aiden."

I tried to answer.

Breath. Pain. Nothing useful.

She unfastened my belt, caught my face between both hands, and made me look at her.

"Stay here with me."

I blinked.

Her face came back into focus. Dust on her cheek. A small cut near her eyebrow. Eyes furious and wet and alive.

"Nigga," I whispered, "I'm trying."

"Try harder."

I laughed once, weakly.

She kissed me, then opened her door and climbed out.

Across the broken bridge, Zero crawled from his car.

He was alive.

Of course the nigga was alive. Evil had purchased an excellent seat belt.

His car hung at the edge of the missing span. He climbed onto the remaining stone, drew his gun, and aimed across the gap.

Shawna fired first.

He ducked behind the broken wall.

I forced my hand toward my pistol.

My fingers shook too hard to close around it.

Nigga, I had spent everything getting us across. The strength was gone. The crown was somewhere behind me with an old man. The sword lay in the car. The whole world could have called me great and it would not have made my hand obey one second faster.

Shawna stood beside the wrecked Last Word and kept the emperor behind cover.

My wife.

My beautiful, impossible wife.

She was not waiting for greatness to recover before she decided to live.

I dragged myself toward the open door.

Above us, the airship appeared over the canyon rim.

Victor called my name.

Shawna did not look up.

"Aiden! Stay down!"

On the far side of the gap, Zero rose with his gun in both hands.

I saw his eyes settle on her.

Nigga, my hand closed around the pistol.

15. The Last Nigga Who Thought He Could

I shot him before he could shoot my wife.

No speech. No last question for the sky. Nigga, I had heard everything Emperor Zero wanted to say, and none of it mattered more than the woman standing beside my car.

My first shot struck his arm.

His gun jerked sideways.

Shawna fired.

He staggered against the broken bridge wall, one hand pressed to his chest. For a second he stayed standing. I saw the disbelief on his face, the terrible little hope that the world might still remember what he called himself and correct the mistake.

Then he lifted the gun again.

I fired twice.

Zero fell onto the stone.

The gun slipped from his hand.

He did not rise.

I watched the man die on the bridge he had broken trying to leave everybody else behind.

Emperor Zero. All those towers. All those guards. All those niggas told to kneel because one man could not bear the sound of somebody walking away.

Dead.

My arm fell against the car door.

Shawna turned.

For one second neither of us moved.

Then she ran to me.

She caught me before I could fall out of the seat, climbed halfway into the wrecked car, and held my face against her chest. I could hear her heart. Fast. Alive. Mine was trying to keep up like it had finally found a race worth winning.

"Baby," I whispered.

"I'm here."

"You hit?"

"No."

"Tell me again."

"Nigga, I'm here. I'm not hit. Look at me."

I looked.

The cut near her eyebrow had stopped bleeding. Dust streaked her face. She was crying and angry about it, which made her

look more like herself than any song, photograph, or expensive dress ever could.

"You scared the shit out of me," she said.

"I had a difficult afternoon."

She laughed through the tears and hit my good shoulder.

"Don't be funny."

"Nigga, we discussed my limited settings."

She kissed me so hard I forgot the emperor lying across the gap.

Above us, the airship lowered toward the canyon.

Victor landed on the far side first. He approached Zero carefully, moved the gun away, and looked down at the body for a long moment. Then he looked across at me.

He shook his head once.

Finished.

I closed my eyes.

The word moved through me without needing a voice.

Finished.

Not my life. Not the trouble I would undoubtedly manufacture in a grocery store before the year ended. This man. This road. This one long chain of niggas deciding they could take what I loved and expect me to become reasonable about it.

Finished.

Liora brought the rescue platform close enough for Shawna to help me onto it. Victor crossed the gap and took my other side. Between them they got me out of the Last Word while the car ticked and smoked against the cliff.

I looked back at it.

The beautiful blue hood was crumpled. One wheel pointed in a direction June had never approved. The silver MAGNIFICENT badge still shone above the grille.

"Nigga," I whispered, "you did good."

Shawna looked at the car too.

"June's going to rebuild it."

"She gonna rebuild me first with a wrench."

Victor laughed and held me more firmly.

"I will tell her it flew beautifully."

"Nigga, do not lead with flew."

We rose into the airship.

Rosa reached us at the cabin door.

Tank was right behind her.

My brother saw the blood on my arm, the way Victor held my weight, the tears on Shawna's face. The nigga stopped like somebody had put a hand through his chest.

"Brother."

I lifted my good hand.

"Nigga, don't start. I'm alive."

He came forward and held me anyway.

Carefully at first. Then not carefully at all. His arms closed around me and Victor together because apparently the nigga did not care which part of the rescue package he hugged as long as I remained inside it.

"You stupid motherfucker," he whispered.

"Accurate."

"You magnificent stupid motherfucker."

"More accurate."

He laughed against my shoulder.

Then the nigga cried.

Not a lot. Not a beautiful movie tear somebody could light from the side. Two rough breaths and his face pressed into my jacket while he held the brother he had almost lost again.

I put my hand behind his head.

"Nigga, we got a wedding."

He nodded without letting go.

"Yeah."

"Blue flowers."

"Yeah."

"You still need me to stop you dancing like a refrigerator."

He laughed, hard and sudden.

Rosa wiped her eyes.

"Both of you sit down before Vega murders the survivors."

The doctor pushed through the crowd with her bag.

"At last," she said, "somebody understands the stakes."

She made me sit on a padded bench and cut the ruined sleeve away from my arm. The wound was ugly but shallow. The shoulder hurt worse. She checked my hands, my eyes, the old scar, the new bruises, and every expression I attempted to disguise as confidence.

"No more lightning," she said.

"Today?"

"Aiden."

"Nigga, people keep making vague medical requests."

She looked at Shawna.

My wife crossed her arms.

"No more lightning until she says."

I nodded.

That was a prescription I understood.

Outside the airship windows, the fortress grew smaller beneath us. Smoke rose from the courts. Cars moved through open gates.

Buses carried people toward the desert road. The black banners still hung, but nobody below seemed interested in saluting them. Porsche stood by a camera mounted near the window. Her face was wet.

"I filmed it," she said.

I looked up.

"What part?"

"The bridge. Both of you. The whole city saw."

Shawna went very still.

"They saw him die?"

Porsche nodded.

"And they saw you get Aiden out."

Mercedes put a hand on Shawna's shoulder.

"Nigga, the comments are losing their minds."

I laughed weakly.

"What they saying?"

Shawna pointed at me without looking away from the window.

"Do not feed him while injured."

Porsche ignored her.

"One man says you are the greatest driver, officer, swordsman, husband, and airborne passenger in recorded history."

Tank sniffed and wiped his face.

"That nigga forgot singer."

"Another one included singer," Mercedes said.

"Educated nigga."

The cabin laughed.

I leaned back and let the sound hold me while Vega wrapped my arm.

We landed in the midnight court's outer garden.

Hundreds of people waited.

Noor stood at the front with Salma beside her. Vesper held the ledger folio. Magnolia supported Bernard's arm. June and Adrian stood near the Last Word's damaged transport cradle, already arguing about how to bring the car up from the canyon. Cassius and Inez waited together, her hand in his. Marcellus stood in the center holding the crown.

Nobody cheered immediately.

They watched me come down the airship steps with my wife beside me, my brother one pace behind, my arm bandaged, my coat torn, and the whole long day still shaking in my knees.

Then one of the palace workers raised a hand.

"Captain."

Another voice answered.

"Aiden."

The names moved through the crowd.

Captain.

Aiden.

King.

Nigga, I had heard people say my name because they wanted money, protection, a photograph, a song, a fight. This sounded different. Not purer. I was not about to become some saint because a crowd had found a good rhythm. It sounded like people realizing the door behind them would remain open after I left.

I liked that sound.

Marcellus approached.

He lifted the crown.

"You might sit for this," he said.

"Nigga, let me have posture."

Shawna laughed and steadied my elbow.

The old man placed the crown on my head.

This time the crowd did not whisper.

The cheering hit the garden walls and came back twice as loud.

Tank raised both fists.

Victor shouted my name like we were back at Sky High and I had just ruined somebody's prediction again. Cassius bowed with a hand over his heart. Inez whistled. Knox saluted. Noor and Salma did too, followed by guards who had spent the morning trying to decide whether I was an enemy and were now making a different choice in front of everybody.

Vesper stood beside me.

"King of Kings," someone called.

The crowd took it up.

I looked at my wife.

She smiled at me, not at the crown.

That was the part that almost broke me.

"You impressed?" I asked.

She moved closer.

"Nigga, I'm trying to remain manageable about it."

I kissed her while the whole garden shouted.

When the cheering softened enough for me to speak, I raised one hand.

"All right. Listen."

The crowd quieted.

"The emperor's dead. His roads are open. His prisoners leave. His staff gets paid. Anybody wants to keep shooting about it can find me after I take a fucking nap."

Laughter rolled through the garden.

"The captains handle their people. The workers decide where they work. The cars—"

Tank sat forward.

"—we're discussing the cars."

The crowd laughed harder.

"And nobody," I said, looking at Bernard, "is charging that man to rebuild his hotel."

The owner covered his face.

Magnolia held him.

I lowered my hand.

That was enough governing for the day.

Knox approached with a palace officer carrying a velvet cushion. On it lay Zero's ceremonial key ring, heavy with gold.

"The inner treasury," she said. "The surviving officials are requesting your direction."

I took the keys.

Nigga, some habits survive even a meaningful afternoon.

Shawna saw my expression.

"Aiden."

"Baby, the wedding ain't paying for itself."

She laughed and put her hand through my arm.

We walked into the palace together, past guards who bowed,
past workers who waved, past portraits that already looked like
they belonged to a dead man.

Behind us, the airship's painted heart moved gently in the
evening wind.

TANK + ROSA.

Ahead of us, the treasury doors opened.

And for the first time in a long time, the next thing waiting on
the other side was a future we had already chosen.

16. The Emperor Left Me a Receipt

I woke up in Zero's bed and immediately understood why the nigga had been so difficult.

The mattress was too firm.

Nigga, a man can own six hundred rooms and still spend his whole life getting bad sleep.

Shawna lay beside me with one leg over mine and the crown sitting on the bedside table. Morning light fell across the blue stones. My arm ached. My shoulder ached. My hands felt like they had spent the night arguing with a power station and lost on points.

My wife opened one eye.

"Don't move."

"I wasn't."

"You were thinking about it."

"Nigga, you policing thoughts now?"

She touched the badge she had left beside the crown.

"Promoted."

I kissed her forehead.

For a while we stayed exactly where we were. No sirens. No phone ringing from a falling plane. No nigga at the door trying to sell me a funeral. Just my wife, sunlight, and a bed we would absolutely replace if we ever chose to come back.

Then Tank knocked.

"Brother."

I closed my eyes.

Shawna laughed into my chest.

"What?" I called.

"They opened the treasury."

I sat up.

"Nigga, why you whispering?"

"Because there's a lot of it."

We got dressed.

The treasury lay beneath the palace, behind three enormous doors that had opened the previous evening only far enough for the officials to establish that the money had not learned to walk during the fighting. Now every door stood wide. Guards waited outside with the awkward politeness of men protecting wealth from the one nigga who could legally tell them to move and illegally afford to be louder about it.

Inside, gold gleamed beneath white lights.

Gold bars. Gold statues. Gold coins in glass cases. Jewels in velvet trays. Paintings, watches, antique swords, keys to properties Zero had apparently bought because a map had offended him by containing places he did not own.

Tank stood in the middle wearing a bathrobe over his trousers.

Rosa stood beside him with both hands on her head.

"Nigga," Tank said when he saw me.

"I know."

"No, brother. Nigga."

"I know louder."

Cassius emerged from a side room carrying a book of vehicle registrations.

"There is another collection."

I closed my eyes.

Shawna put a hand on my shoulder.

"Breathe."

"Nigga, I am trying to remain financially mature."

"You're failing beautifully."

A palace accountant approached, a thin man of fifty-eight with silver spectacles and the exhausted face of somebody who had spent years explaining to Zero that ownership and arithmetic remained different activities.

"Captain. The liquid holdings alone—"

"How much?"

He told me.

I looked at Tank.

Tank looked at Rosa.

Rosa sat down on a chest.

Nigga, the woman had performed in rooms where billionaires cried into champagne. She still sat down.

"That covers the flowers," Tank said finally.

Shawna laughed so hard she had to lean against me.

We did not take everything.

Before anybody gets emotional about that, nigga, we took plenty.

But the accountant had lists of wages never paid, homes seized, pensions promised, and money held for people who had spent the last decade learning the palace preferred their patience to their presence. Vesper went through those lists with Noor and Salma. Magnolia recognized names. Liora knew companies. Bernard found the record of the land beneath June's garage.

The people in that room did not need me to become a philosopher about a pile of stolen gold. They needed the nigga holding the keys to stop blocking the door.

I put the key ring on the table.

"Pay them first."

The accountant looked up.

"All verified claims?"

"Nigga, I don't know their birthdays. You got the books. Do your job."

He removed his glasses.

For a second I thought he might cry.

Then he smiled with the quiet joy of a man finally permitted to make numbers mean what they said.

"Yes, Captain."

Tank leaned toward me.

"We still rich?"

The accountant heard him.

"Extremely."

Tank relaxed.

"Good. I was supporting the community with anxiety."

We made gifts out of the things that mattered to people.

June received the deed to her garage, the adjoining workshops, and enough room to build cars without apologizing for the noise.

Adrian read the papers twice, then handed them to her like he

was afraid holding them too long might turn the whole thing back into a dream.

June looked at me.

"Nigga."

"You saved my wife on the road."

"You already said thank you."

"I got vocabulary in property now."

She hugged me carefully around the bruised shoulder.

Then she leaned back and pointed at my face.

"You are still paying for the Last Word."

"Nigga, you own half the neighborhood!"

"And you put my car on a tank."

"Armored vehicle."

"Keep talking. The invoice gets taller."

Liora received the airship.

She stared when I handed her the papers.

"The whole ship?"

"Nigga, it would be rude to give you the front and keep the ass."

Porsche clapped. Mercedes hugged her. Liora looked toward the window, where the silver hull floated above the outer court with Tank and Rosa's painted heart still on its side.

"I can run passenger routes," she said. "Cargo. Music tours. People could leave without asking anybody in this palace."

"There you go."

"What about the name?"

Tank folded his arms.

"We can negotiate."

Rosa slapped his chest.

"Let the woman name her own fucking ship."

Liora smiled.

"First Dance."

Tank looked up at the heart again.

"Nigga," he said softly. "That's good."

Sienna and her sister chose a music house in the old quarter, a beautiful building with a small stage and rooms above it.

Mercedes promised to help them find performers. Porsche promised to make the opening night impossible to ignore. Rosa promised a guest set, provided nobody expected her to organize the chairs herself.

"You will organize them anyway," Sienna said.

"Nigga, that's between me and the chairs."

Bernard received the land beside the old hotel, money to rebuild, and an apology from three officials who looked like they had

rehearsed it while wondering whether I would be present with a gun.

I was present with a gun.

But I let them finish.

Magnolia held the little palm shoot while Bernard read the rebuilding plans June had sketched on the back of a breakfast menu.

"A bigger courtyard," she said.

He nodded.

"For the tree."

"For the people," Magnolia corrected gently. "The tree will manage."

Bernard looked at her.

She looked back.

Nigga, I saw the smallest beginning of something and had the intelligence to leave it alone before Tank could ask whether we needed to order more flowers.

Marcellus wanted no new palace.

The old man walked through the jewel room slowly, looking more interested in the workmanship than the prices. He stopped at a narrow cabinet containing tools: tiny hammers, old files, jeweler's lamps, instruments made by hands that had been dead longer than any of us had been alive.

"These," he said.

"Take them."

"They belong in a workshop."

"Then put them in yours."

He smiled.

"Celeste would call you extravagant."

"Nigga, she'd be correct."

He touched the pouch containing Blue Mercy beneath his coat.

"She would also like your wife."

I looked across the room at Shawna, who was helping Liora read the airship papers while three men tried to explain the same sentence badly.

"Everybody with sense does."

Marcellus nodded.

"Yes."

There was no grief speech. No lesson. The old man had his tools, his stone, his letter, and another morning in which people wanted him around. I let that be enough.

Near noon, two men tried to leave the treasury with a chest they had not been given.

They wore palace uniforms and expressions of desperate confidence. One carried the front. The other carried the back. Neither looked at me until I stepped into their path.

"Morning."

They stopped.

The chest tilted.

"Captain."

"Niggas moving furniture?"

"Authorized transfer."

"By who?"

The front man looked at the back man.

The back man looked at the ceiling.

Nigga, a whole criminal organization collapsed between those two glances.

I set my hand on the chest.

"Open it."

Inside lay gold watches, loose stones, and a small diamond horse that Shawna had already told me she wanted because its face looked smug.

I lifted the horse.

"This one's my wife's."

The men swallowed.

"Sorry, Captain."

"The other shit is somebody else's. You niggas can explain to Knox which somebody you intended to become."

They set the chest down.

One looked at the horse in my hand.

"It does suit her."

"Nigga, don't flirt with your arrest."

Tank laughed all the way down the corridor as the officers took them away.

By evening, the treasury had become less a room full of Zero's things than a room full of other people's futures.

I still left rich enough to offend weather.

Shawna left carrying the diamond horse.

Outside, the Last City's square filled with people. The old emperor's banners came down. Nobody had agreed on the new ones yet, so the grown men with ladders argued among themselves while women on balconies told them their knots looked terrible. Somebody hung a huge blue sheet with my name on it. Somebody else added CAPTAIN above it because apparently the crown had not clarified the job title.

I watched from the palace steps.

Knox stood beside me.

"You could stay," she said.

"Nigga, you trying to get rid of me?"

"Never. I enjoy having the world's most difficult officer where I can occasionally find him."

"Then you know the answer."

She nodded.

"Vegas."

"Vegas."

Behind us, Rosa called that the wedding party's flights were being arranged and anyone who missed departure would be personally removed from her affections for at least a week.

Tank took the threat seriously.

My wife came to my side.

"Ready?"

I looked at the city one last time: the open roads, the people in the square, the fortune still being counted by a man finally enjoying his work.

Then I looked at Shawna.

"Nigga, I've been ready since the first night."

She took my hand.

We went to pack for home.

17. Vegas Had Been Practicing My Name

Las Vegas met us in the sky.

Nigga, I thought I was seeing traffic until the helicopters turned together and blue smoke spread above the city. Five aircraft flew on either side of the First Dance, their pilots holding formation around an airship with a repaired heart painted across its side. Below us, the Strip glittered in the afternoon sun. The hotels looked up like old friends pretending they had not spent the whole week waiting at the window.

Tank stood beside me in the observation cabin.

"Brother."

"I see it."

"Those niggas escorting us."

"They got taste."

"What if they escorting Rosa?"

I looked at him.

"Nigga, then smile and enjoy the relationship."

Rosa came up behind us wearing sunglasses and a yellow dress. She looked down at the city, then at the heart on the airship's side.

"We are going to be unbearable at this wedding."

"Going to?" Shawna asked.

The women laughed and hugged.

I stood with my arm in a sling Vega had forced on me for the journey. The sling was blue because my wife understood that if a nigga had to be medically inconvenienced, he should still match his vehicle. The crown sat in its case. My badge remained on my chest. I had tried wearing both during breakfast, and Shawna told me the waiter was having difficulty remembering where to put the eggs.

Below us, the airport runway cleared.

A line of dark-blue police vehicles waited along the edge. Beyond them stood cars from every year of my life since I had first learned how good a key could feel in a man's hand. My original Lamborghini waited near the front, repaired and polished. The black Mercedes had come home separately with Tank's trusted drivers. Cassius's gift car stood beside them. Even the battered Last Word rested on a transport truck, looking less dead now that June had spent the voyage threatening its damaged parts personally.

Nigga, my cars had their own reunion before I got to hug anybody.

We landed beneath a banner stretched across two airport cranes.

WELCOME HOME, CAPTAIN AIDEN.

Underneath, in a different hand, somebody had added:

AND HIS EXTREMELY IMPORTANT WIFE.

Shawna read it twice.

Then she turned to Knox.

The chief smiled.

"Your fans were insistent."

"Good," my wife said.

Tank pointed at a smaller banner near the terminal.

ROSA, PLEASE MARRY THIS MAN BEFORE HE BUYS
MORE FLOWERS.

The nigga covered his face.

Rosa laughed until she had to lean against him.

"Who told them?"

"Nigga," I said, "you sent a florist eleven voice messages about
blue. The city knows."

We came down the airship stairs into a roar.

Police officers saluted. Drivers cheered. College faculty waved
little blue flags. Musicians played from a temporary stage. Adult
students from Sky High stood near the terminal with their old
graduation jackets over their arms. Friends from Monaco had
flown in ahead of us, along with people from Isla Gloria who

apparently believed gratitude should travel with luggage and several bottles of rum.

Everybody wanted to touch somebody.

I hugged men whose names I knew and men whose faces I remembered from nights when knowing a face had been enough. Women kissed my cheeks, then embraced Shawna harder. Tank disappeared inside a crowd of old friends. Rosa watched him with the smile of a woman discovering how many people already loved the man she had chosen.

A young officer approached me holding a clipboard.

He was twenty-five, nervous, and trying very hard to remain professional while looking at the crown case Marcellus carried behind me.

"Captain. Welcome home. I need a signature for the arrival report."

I took the pen.

"Nigga, I been gone a while. You sure that's all?"

"The chief said anything else could wait until after lunch."

"Excellent department."

He watched me sign.

Then he blurted, "Sir, is it true you arrested an armored vehicle?"

I looked at Shawna.

She looked at the officer.

"He used the siren."

The young nigga's whole face changed.

"Of course."

Tank passed behind him and leaned close.

"That's the important part. Nigga respected procedure."

The officer nodded so seriously I had to turn away before laughing in his face.

Knox put a hand on my good shoulder.

"You see what you've done?"

"Inspired excellence."

"Half the academy now asks whether vehicle size affects jurisdiction."

"Tell those niggas to dream."

She laughed and led us toward the stage.

The mayor waited there with a key to the city.

I had met him before. He had already given me things to hold for photographs. This key was bigger than the previous one and shone so brightly I suspected he had measured his reelection prospects in carats.

"Captain Aiden," he began, "Las Vegas welcomes its most extraordinary citizen."

The crowd cheered.

Tank cupped his hands around his mouth.

"That nigga right there!"

Rosa tried to pull his arms down and failed because she was laughing too hard.

The mayor continued through the noise. He named the races, the rescues, the academy, the island, the people who had come home because my friends and I had refused to let an emperor decide when the road closed.

He did not mention every crime.

Nigga, a good welcome speech knows when to make room for lunch.

Then he handed me the key.

It took both hands.

My injured arm complained.

Shawna took one end before I could pretend otherwise.

The crowd cheered louder.

"Joint ownership," she said.

"Baby, you already got all the doors."

She kissed me in front of the cameras.

The mayor waited with the patient expression of a man who knew which photograph would actually appear on the news.

When it was my turn to speak, I stepped to the microphone.

The crowd quieted slowly.

I looked out at them: cops, crooks, drivers, singers, friends, people who had watched the bridge on a screen and come to see whether the man climbing out of the car still looked like himself in daylight.

"Niggas," I said warmly, "I missed my fucking city."

The airport roared.

"I missed the heat. I missed the bad decisions. I missed knowing which restaurant would feed Tank after the kitchen closed."

Tank raised a fist.

"But I brought something back."

I turned toward my people.

"Friends. A whole lot of cars. Some extremely complicated luggage. And the two best reasons I know to throw the biggest wedding this city has ever survived."

I held out my hand to Shawna.

Rosa took Tank's hand beside us.

The crowd began cheering before I finished.

I let them.

Nigga, I had earned the microphone, but I did not need every second of it.

The drive home took two hours because the city had decided every street was part of the parade.

We moved slowly behind police motorcycles. People stood outside shops waving towels, flags, shirts, anything blue. A man ran beside the Lamborghini for half a block holding a framed photograph of me that I did not remember posing for.

"Captain! Sign it!"

I took the marker through the window and signed while Shawna drove.

"Nigga, where you get this picture?"

"My aunt took it at graduation!"

I looked at the photograph.

My gown flew open. I held a diploma in one hand and something expensive appeared to be on fire behind me.

"Excellent photographer."

"She says you're her favorite graduate!"

"Tell her I accept."

The man ran away cheering.

Shawna shook her head.

"You accept being somebody's favorite?"

"Nigga, it would be rude to reject the woman."

At the next intersection, three street racers pulled up beside us in polished cars. Grown men, late twenties, wearing expressions of reverence they would absolutely deny possessing if anyone described them that way.

The driver nearest me lowered his window.

"Captain. One block. For honor."

I looked at his car.

Then at the crowded street.

"Nigga, look around."

He deflated.

"Right. Sorry."

"Tomorrow. Track. Bring a better excuse than honor."

His face lit up.

"For love?"

Shawna looked over.

"That's a much better reason."

The nigga nodded like she had knighted his accelerator.

We reached the mansion at sunset.

The gates opened before we stopped.

Our house stood beyond the palms, white walls glowing, windows open, music coming from somewhere inside. The staff waited on the steps. Flowers filled the entrance. In the garden,

the white horse lifted its head and regarded me with the grave judgment of an animal that had spent months living better than most kings without once feeling the need to own a badge.

I got out of the car.

For a moment I could not move.

The house had been a boast when I bought it. A palace for a woman I barely knew and already could not imagine leaving. Now every window held something we had lived long enough to return to.

Shawna came around the car.

"Baby."

I looked at her.

"Nigga, we actually made it."

She took my hand.

"Yes."

No bigger word.

No prettier one.

We walked up the steps together.

Inside, somebody had placed a photograph on the entrance table. Our first wedding. Me looking like I had won the world and remained suspicious it might ask for identification. Shawna

beside me, beautiful and laughing. Tank behind us, trying to stand seriously. Rosa looking at him instead of the camera.

I picked it up.

Shawna leaned against my shoulder.

"Look at those two," she said.

"Us?"

"Them."

I looked at Tank and Rosa in the photograph.

Nigga, the whole future had been standing behind us while we smiled.

Tank came through the door carrying three bags at once.

"Brother, where you want these?"

I turned the photograph toward him.

He looked.

Then he smiled so softly I almost did not recognize the expression on that big dangerous face.

Rosa came up behind him and put her chin against his shoulder.

"You were staring," she said.

"I had excellent judgment."

She kissed his cheek.

We stood there in the entrance of our house, four people who had carried too much and somehow brought the right things home.

Outside, the parade kept cheering along the road.

Inside, my wife took off her shoes.

Nigga, that was the sound I had crossed the world to hear.

18. The Valedictorian Came Back for His People

The nigga from the parade called at eight in the morning to ask whether I had meant the part about racing.

I lay in my own bed with my own wife across my chest and a doctor-approved number of reasons not to lift my arm too quickly.

"Who this?"

"Damon. We met yesterday. The blue coupe."

"Nigga, yesterday had a fleet. Narrow it down."

"You said the track. For love."

Shawna opened one eye.

"That one," she said.

I remembered his face. Late twenties. Hopeful in the way a man gets when he has spent half his life admiring somebody and finally finds the nerve to ask whether that somebody is faster than him personally.

"You got a track?" I asked.

"Las Vegas College. New driving center. I teach the adult evening group. The principal heard you might come."

I sat up too fast and immediately remembered my shoulder.

"Nigga, Mercer still crying?"

Damon went quiet for a second.

"How did you know?"

My wife started laughing before I'd finished waking up.

Dr. Vega looked at the invitation, looked at the bandage on my upper arm, and looked at me.

Nigga, she had been doing that last part for long enough to know when the first two were wasting their time.

"No Blue Thunder."

"Wasn't planning on it."

"No pretending that because the wound is shallow, your body didn't spend the last week being used as a public entrance."

"Nigga, I opened doors for people."

"With your shoulder."

Shawna put my coffee down beside me.

"I'll go with him."

Vega looked at her too.

"You are part of the problem."

"I know. I'm keeping my part supervised."

The doctor gave up on the invitation. She checked the bandage, told me again what rest meant, and left with the expression of a

woman who loved me more than she enjoyed being right about me.

I called Damon back.

"No lightning."

"Sir?"

"Nigga, I'm beating you ordinary today. Be grateful."

He sounded so happy I felt proud of him before I'd seen his car.

Las Vegas College had put my name on the driving center.

Of course the niggas had.

I came through the gate in the dark-blue police Lamborghini with Shawna beside me and Tank following in the original black Mercedes. The old Mercedes had been polished until the sun could see how many terrible decisions it had survived. Rosa rode beside Tank with a bag of breakfast pastries and the confidence of a woman who knew which ones her fiancé wasn't allowed to eat before she counted them.

Mercedes and Porsche came in the silver Chrome Special, arguing through the open windows about who had impressed more people on the way. Cassius had lent them the car with a smile that grew uncertain only after Porsche asked whether he liked it exactly the way it was.

We left Last Word with June and Adrian. That car had done enough for us to deserve people working gently around it for a while. I wasn't making every machine I loved prove it could follow me out the door.

At the college entrance, a blue banner read WELCOME HOME, CAPTAIN AIDEN.

Beneath it, in gold, somebody had written DAMN, BOY. MAGNIFICENT.

I stopped the Lamborghini directly under the words.

Shawna looked up.

"You taught them that."

"Nigga, some lessons take."

Professor Halcyon came down the steps with a folder under one arm. Silver glasses. Hair pinned up. The same precise walk she had used the morning she brought my graduation robe into a crowd of people who couldn't believe the nigga they'd seen on a speeding-car video had also corrected their final examination.

She reached my door and took my hand in both of hers.

"Home," she said.

Not a question. Not a welcome. More like she wanted to hear the word where she could trust it.

"Home," I told her.

She squeezed once, then let go before either of us made it too big to carry.

Principal Mercer followed her.

Nigga was already crying.

"Aiden."

"Principal. You saving any water for the track?"

He laughed through it and put both arms around me carefully, avoiding the bandage. Sixty-odd years old and still holding the whole college in his chest like if he let go it might forget how proud he was of the people inside it.

"You came back."

"Nigga, you keep putting my name on buildings. I got to check what I'm responsible for."

He turned toward the center.

"The academy donated the simulators. The city helped with the track. Your graduates raised the rest."

"My graduates?"

Halcyon smiled.

"They insist on the phrase."

A group stood by the fence in blue work shirts. Adults. Driving instructors, mechanics, people who'd returned to college after the rest of life refused to wait for them. I recognized Marcus

from the fountain, his friend beside him, a woman I'd seen holding her mother's cane outside the burning auditorium.

They saw me looking and straightened.

"Our nigga," Marcus said.

His friend nudged him.

"Our captain."

"Nigga, he can be both."

I pointed at Marcus.

"That one kept studying."

The whole group laughed.

Damon Lake was twenty-eight, with neat braids, a dark blue racing jacket, and hands he kept wiping on his trousers whenever he remembered who had agreed to come.

His coupe waited at the edge of the track. Blue too, though a less expensive shade of confidence than my Lamborghini. Beside it stood a woman in a green dress with a coffee cup and the expression of somebody who had heard about this race through three separate versions before leaving the house.

"Leila," Damon said. "My girlfriend. She's thirty. Works nights. I made her get up."

"Nigga, you opening with an apology," I told him. "Strong choice."

Leila shook my hand, then Shawna's.

"He has watched every clip of you driving anything. We had dinner with a video of your hearse last month."

Shawna looked at me.

"Our relationship spreading."

"Nigga, good education travels."

Damon turned red beneath his brown skin.

"I thought maybe one lap. Just so I could say—"

"Three," I said.

He blinked.

"Three?"

"One lap, a nigga can blame the coffee. Three, we know each other."

He looked at the Lamborghini.

Then at his coupe.

I knew that look. A man discovering the contest he'd dreamed about came with a number he couldn't afford.

I held out my hand.

"Keys."

He stared.

"Mine?"

"Nigga, I ain't asking for your house. Yes, the car."

He gave them to me.

I put the Lamborghini's keys into his hand.

The whole little crowd went quiet.

"Drive mine," I said. "I'll drive yours. Let your girl see you in something you been looking at all year."

Damon looked at the keys as if I had put a living bird in his palm.

"Captain—"

"Nigga, hold the wheel with both hands when you run out of thank you."

Leila covered her mouth. Shawna leaned against me and smiled without saying anything, which was somehow louder than the people by the fence beginning to cheer.

Tank looked between the two cars.

"You letting this nigga drive the Lambo?"

"Closed track."

"That has not traditionally limited you."

"Nigga, I'm lending him the car. Not the whole personality."

The first lap belonged to the engines.

Damon took the straight fast, the Lamborghini opening beneath him with a sound that made the instructors at the fence stand on their toes. I followed in his coupe, feeling the little differences through the wheel. The car was lighter than it looked. It wanted the turn a breath earlier than he usually gave it. I could feel what he'd done to make it his, and what the nigga had left waiting because he'd never met anybody who could ask properly.

I asked.

The coupe settled beneath me.

At the first bend, Damon went wide. Beautifully wide. Proudly wide. A man with an enormous new engine discovering that the road did not automatically get larger to celebrate with him.

I took the inside.

We came out side by side.

He looked over through the Lamborghini's window.

I smiled.

Nigga had such a happy face losing to me that I nearly slowed down to give him more time in it.

Nearly.

The second lap belonged to the driver.

I felt the coupe pull where it wanted to pull, let it find its balance, and took the next curve clean enough that the tires made one long sweet sound beneath me. Damon stayed close.

Better now. Learning the car instead of admiring it. I could see the moment he stopped driving a photograph and started driving the fucking machine.

"There you go," I said, though he couldn't hear me.

At the last straight he came up beside me again.

The Lamborghini had more power. His foot knew it. Mine knew his coupe still had a little turn left to win before power got to finish the conversation.

I held the line.

We crossed together close enough that the people at the fence shouted both names before they understood which one had arrived first.

Mine.

Nigga, naturally.

Damon stopped beside me and got out laughing. His hands shook around the keys. He looked at his own car, then at me, then at Leila, who was clapping so hard her coffee had become somebody else's responsibility.

"You beat me in mine."

"Nigga, you made a good car. I wanted it to know."

He stared at the coupe like I'd just complimented his whole childhood.

Professor Lorne came toward us carrying the timing sheet. He had a gray mustache now and the same stunned face he'd worn when I corrected the auditorium drawing by looking out of the window.

"Fastest lap recorded here," he said.

"Track's new," I told him.

"So was the record."

He held the paper out with both hands.

Damon read it over my shoulder. Then he threw his head back and laughed again.

"My car!"

"Nigga, your car," I said. "You keeping the paper. I got enough things framed."

Leila kissed him beside the coupe. Not because he had won. He hadn't. Because he looked like somebody who had remembered why he'd loved doing something before the world taught him to worry whether he was important enough to enjoy it.

Shawna caught my hand.

"You made his year."

"Nigga made mine letting me borrow a car that wasn't already terrified of me."

The trouble came after we finished.

Lorne had brought an old gold convertible for the ceremonial lap around the driving center. He had restored it himself over years, one little piece at a time, and spoke about it with the tenderness Marcellus used for stones other men only knew how to price.

Mercer sat beside him. Halcyon got into the back holding the ribbon for the new viewing stand. They were supposed to go around once, stop in front of the students, and let the principal say something proud into a microphone while everybody pretended not to have heard him practicing it in the hall.

We stood by the fence and watched them leave.

The gold car took the first curve easily.

Then it kept accelerating.

Lorne's hand moved. His shoulders stiffened. Mercer turned toward him, still smiling, still halfway inside the speech he wanted to give.

The car passed the place where it should have slowed.

I saw Halcyon put one hand against the seat in front of her.

"Nigga," I said.

Tank was already looking at the same thing.

"Yeah."

The convertible came into the next bend too fast. Its outside wheels ran onto the painted edge. For half a second it tilted toward the fence.

Then it came down and kept going.

Lorne looked toward us.

That was enough.

I ran for the black Mercedes.

Tank threw me the keys before I reached it. Shawna caught the radio from the nearest instructor. Porsche and Mercedes began moving people away from the fence before anybody had worked out whether the beautiful old car was part of the show anymore.

I got behind the wheel.

No blue light.

No lightning waking in my hands.

Just my old car, my bruised shoulder, three people who had been proud of me before they'd seen half the things I'd become, and a road I had promised them I knew how to use.

I drove.

The Mercedes caught the gold convertible on the next straight. Lorne had both hands locked on the wheel. His face was pale. Mercer held the dashboard with one hand and the timing sheet with the other, as if my lap record was still something the college might need rescued separately.

Halcyon saw me first.

"Aiden!"

"Nigga, I'm here!"

I came alongside. Close enough to hear Lorne trying to tell me the car wouldn't slow. Close enough to see that he was keeping it on the track with everything he'd spent his life learning about the machine he loved.

I couldn't fix the car from another car.

I could give his people somewhere else to be.

I held the Mercedes beside them as the straight narrowed toward the banked turn. The cars touched once, gently enough to make both steering wheels shiver. Halcyon looked at the open passenger window, then at the space between the doors.

"Professor," I shouted, "you trust me?"

She looked at my face.

"Unfortunately, completely."

Nigga, I would remember that answer until the day I stopped needing a world to stand in.

She climbed.

Mercer helped her over the side of the convertible. I reached across the Mercedes and caught her arm while she got one leg through the window. The road curved beneath us. My shoulder burned. She came into the seat with her glasses crooked and the ribbon still in her hand.

"Keep your head down," I told her.

"I have observed the method before."

We came out of the turn together.

Mercer was next.

Nigga brought the timing sheet in his teeth.

I saw the paper before I saw his face and nearly started laughing at a moment that didn't deserve how happy the man made me.

Halcyon caught his sleeve. I held the Mercedes steady while he came across the gap, awkward and determined, a college principal choosing to believe his valedictorian had personally negotiated with the fucking road.

He landed half on the professor, half on the seat.

The paper stayed dry.

"Lorne!" I shouted.

The man shook his head.

He couldn't let go of the wheel. The car was already pulling toward the outer bank. If he moved, it would go where all that speed had been trying to take it.

I saw his answer in his face before he said it.

"Take them!"

Nigga, no.

Not that answer. Not from a man who had come to watch me race and brought his favorite car because he wanted the day to look good enough for me.

I put the Mercedes closer.

Our sides met.

Metal shrieked along metal. The old black car took the gold one's weight against its door. I held on, kept us together, felt the pressure changing beneath my hands while the track's broad curve gave me somewhere to carry both machines without asking either to become sensible all at once.

Lorne looked over.

"Now," I said.

He came.

Halcyon and Mercer caught him between them, pulled him through the window, made room where there wasn't room because people can become very fucking good at loving each other when the alternative finally says its name out loud.

The gold convertible drifted away from us.

It crossed the empty runoff strip, struck the long safety barrier, and stopped in a cloud of dust and broken old paint.

The Mercedes kept moving until I brought it to a stop beside the instructors.

Then I put my head against the wheel.

Nigga, my shoulder had a speech ready too.

They came to the car from everywhere.

Tank opened my door. Shawna was beside him a second later. Rosa helped Halcyon out of the passenger side while Porsche and Mercedes pulled the two professors free of the greatest carpool Las Vegas College had ever fucking organized.

Nobody had died.

Nobody had even broken anything the doctor would have to name. Lorne had scraped his hand. Mercer had bitten the timing sheet in half. Halcyon had lost one shoe and kept the ribbon.

She looked down at her bare foot.

"I will be charging the college."

"Nigga, charge me," I told her. "Get two pairs."

Shawna took my face in both hands.

"No lightning?"

"No lightning."

She looked at my hands. At the bandage. At the car's scraped side.

Then she kissed me hard enough that the students by the fence started cheering again.

"Good," she whispered. "I want the whole man at the wedding."

"Nigga doing his best to remain available."

Lorne stood a little apart looking at the dust around his old convertible. I went to him once I could get out without letting my shoulder make the introduction.

"We'll fix it," I said.

He shook his head.

"It took me twelve years."

"Then the next twelve don't get to start with you missing. We fix it. You supervise the niggas touching what you love."

He looked at me.

His mouth moved once before he found the words.

"You never attended my class."

"I know."

"I have been teaching your work for years."

"Nigga, I hope it helped."

He laughed then. Wiped his face with the back of his scraped hand. Looked toward his colleagues, both alive and arguing about who had bruised whose elbow coming through my window.

"It has been an education."

Mercer came over holding the torn timing sheet.

"Your record."

I looked at it.

"Principal, you carried that through a car rescue."

"It belongs to the college."

Nigga, I hugged him. Carefully, because both my arm and his pride had been through enough for one morning.

We gave them the wedding invitations on the viewing stand.

Shawna had brought them in her handbag. Our vow renewal.

Tank and Rosa's marriage. Blue and gold on thick paper, the exact date still to come, with enough room on the back for Rosa to explain that anybody bringing a speech longer than five minutes had better also bring a gift she could resell.

Mercer read the names twice.

"You want us there?"

I looked at Halcyon. At Lorne. At the graduates by the fence, the cars, the banner with my ridiculous dead friend's boast shining in the sun above my own living name.

"Nigga, you thought I came back just to collect buildings?"

His eyes filled again.

Halcyon put a hand on his arm before the morning lost another gallon.

"We will be there," she said.

Lorne held his invitation against his chest.

"All of us?"

Shawna looked toward the graduates.

"All of you."

The cheer went up before she finished the last word.

Damon stood beside Leila, his lap record in his hand, and looked at me like I'd given him something larger than a fast morning.

"For love," he said.

I nodded.

"Nigga, you finally brought the right reason."

On the way home, Tank drove the scraped black Mercedes. I sat beside Shawna in the police Lamborghini and let her take the wheel. The car sounded beautiful under her hands. The city moved past in warm light, waiting for weddings, work, breakfast tomorrow, all the little things we'd fought our way back into having.

She glanced over at me.

"How's the shoulder?"

"Complaining."

"How's the ego?"

I looked out at a bus shelter where somebody had put up a photograph of my graduation jump.

"Nigga, thriving."

She laughed and took my hand at the next light.

I held on the whole way home.

19. Keys for Everybody I Love

June opened her Las Vegas workshop by throwing a wrench at my feet.

"There," she said. "Ceremony complete."

I looked down at the wrench.

Then at the ribbon stretched across the garage doors.

"Nigga, I bought scissors."

"You also bought a car and drove it onto a tank. We are all disappointed sometimes."

Adrian stood beside her wearing a clean shirt that had already lost an argument with engine grease. Behind them, the Last Word rested under bright lights with its hood removed. My magnificent blue car looked like a rich patient being introduced to specialists.

Shawna examined the new sign above the doors.

MERCURY & ADRIAN.

Below it, in smaller letters:

CARS WORTH COMING HOME IN.

She took June's hand.

"That's good."

June looked up at the sign and smiled in a way I had not seen when she first came down the spillway in the desert. Back then the nigga with the palace had been trying to take the ground beneath her feet. Now she owned the old garage, a Las Vegas branch, and enough equipment to make Adrian occasionally walk into a room and laugh at a lift.

"We go back after the wedding," she said. "Open the desert shop properly. Hire the men Zero kept stealing away. Then split our time."

"And my car?" I asked.

"Your car learns patience."

"Nigga, it didn't come with that feature."

"Neither did its owner. I'm expanding both."

The staff gathered around us: grown mechanics, apprentices in their twenties, drivers who had watched June bring a car out of war and wanted to learn how she listened to an engine. They stared at me with the careful excitement of people trying to look professional around a man whose worst parking choices had become their favorite videos.

One mechanic raised a hand.

"Captain, can I ask about the armored vehicle?"

June closed her eyes.

"Nigga, do not encourage the customer."

"Technically," I said, "I used its roof as temporary road surface."

The young man nodded like I had handed him a sacred engineering principle.

Adrian laughed so hard he had to sit down.

We cut the ribbon with the scissors anyway.

June let me keep the wrench.

I considered that affection.

Across town, Mercedes and Porsche were opening something louder.

Their building had once been an expensive restaurant run by a man who confused low lighting with good food. Now its windows shone red and blue. Music came through the doors. A neon sign above the entrance read TWO NAMES YOU REMEMBER.

Inside, women in silk and men in sharp suits moved between a small stage, a bar, and tables set far enough apart for people to tell outrageous stories without borrowing the next table's secrets. The place belonged to Mercedes and Porsche together. Music nights, private parties, performances, an agency upstairs for the adult entertainers who wanted to choose their own bookings and keep people they trusted nearby.

They had made it beautiful.

They had also put a framed photograph of me in the men's bathroom.

I discovered that before the ribbon ceremony.

"Niggas," I called when I came back out.

Mercedes smiled.

Porsche tried to look innocent and failed at a professional level.

"Why am I above the sinks?"

"Inspiration," Porsche said.

"For what?"

"Standards," Mercedes replied.

Shawna went to look.

When she returned, she was laughing too hard to speak.

"They chose a good photograph," she managed.

"Nigga, I look like I'm supervising handwashing."

"Public service," Knox said from the bar.

Everybody laughed.

The opening party filled the place by eight.

Sex workers I had known from the old Vegas nights came with friends, dates, husbands, girlfriends, and stories that got louder every time somebody bought another bottle. One woman told Mercedes she once charged a millionaire extra because he kept interrupting a perfectly good evening to explain his golf swing.

Another said she had left a man in a hotel lobby after he introduced his watch before introducing himself.

"What watch?" Tank asked.

Rosa stared at him.

"Nigga, that is not the moral of the story."

"I was assessing the situation."

The woman laughed.

"Ugly watch."

Tank nodded solemnly.

"Then you made the correct decision."

Shawna sat beside me, one hand on my thigh, listening as the women talked. Nobody asked them to become symbols of anything. They were funny, tired, ambitious, vain, generous, occasionally full of shit, and very good at recognizing a man who believed paying for an evening meant buying the whole person standing inside it.

Porsche raised a glass.

"To choosing the room."

Mercedes lifted hers.

"And knowing where the exits are."

I raised mine with them.

"Niggas, may the money be rude and the company worth it."

The table cheered.

Sienna played the first set with her sister. Rosa joined for two songs. Shawna joined for a third, and suddenly the room belonged to the women who had carried music out of the emperor's palace and brought it somewhere the doors opened from the inside.

Mercedes stood beside me watching the stage.

"You like it?"

"Nigga, I love it."

Her face softened before she caught herself.

"Good. Because your first table is expensive."

"I helped buy the building."

"And now you support the business. Growth."

I laughed and kissed her cheek.

"You got it."

At the track the next afternoon, Inez drove Sol de Abril with her father in the passenger seat.

Esteban had flown in for the wedding. Cassius's father, Nero, came too, walking with the measured care of a man who had survived enough captivity to value every unnecessary step he could take outside. The two old racers stood together in the pit lane before the run, inspecting the silver car like it had returned from a war they remembered in different pieces.

When the engine started, Esteban put a hand against the hood.

He did not speak for a long moment.

Inez waited.

Then he looked at her.

"You drive."

She smiled.

Nigga, the woman could make a whole grandstand nervous without moving. That smile was softer than any victory I had seen her win.

They went around the track once slowly.

Then she accelerated.

Esteban's laugh came over the open radio.

Cassius stood beside me with his arms folded, watching the car disappear into the turn.

"You look stupid," I told him.

"I am in love."

"Nigga, I recognized the condition. I was discussing the face."

He laughed without looking away.

"I am going to ask her to build a team with me."

"You already racing together."

"A real team. Our name on the garage. Our drivers. Our cars. Our choices."

"And a ring?"

He looked at me.

"Eventually."

"Nigga, you say eventually like it's a country you'll visit after the weather improves."

He rubbed his jaw.

"I don't want to make winning her feel like winning a race."

That stopped my joke before it reached my mouth.

I looked at the track. At the silver car coming back into view, Inez laughing beside her father.

"Then don't ask like a man expecting a trophy," I said. "Ask like a nigga who wants somebody beside him when the engine's off."

Cassius nodded slowly.

When Inez brought the car in, he went to her before she had taken off her gloves.

I did not hear what he said.

I saw her expression change.

Then I saw her put both hands on his face and kiss him in the middle of the pit lane while Esteban climbed out of the passenger seat pretending very hard to admire the tires.

Nero stood beside him.

"Young people," he said.

Esteban nodded.

"Terrible at discretion."

The two men smiled like niggas who had never once practiced it themselves.

That evening, Vesper came to the mansion with Magnolia and Bernard.

She wore a simple dark dress and carried no folio. For the first time since the desert, she looked like a woman arriving for dinner instead of an argument that might require cavalry.

Shawna met her at the door.

They embraced.

I watched from the stairs with the strange pleasure of seeing two women who had every reason to misunderstand each other choose not to make that anybody's entertainment.

Vesper gave me a small box.

Inside was a silver key.

"The Blue House," she said. "Bastien asked me to bring it. There will always be a room for you in Midnight City."

"Nigga, tell him make it a large room."

"He already knows your luggage habits."

I smiled.

"How is he?"

"Arguing with Madame Caron about curtains. Recovering his territory by annoying her into surrender."

"Healthy, then."

"Very."

We sat outside while the garden lights came on. Bernard talked with June about the hotel plans. Magnolia corrected both of them on the placement of benches. Vesper watched the white horse move beyond the fence.

"You could have kept the Last City," she said quietly.

"I kept enough."

She looked at me.

"That answer would once have surprised me."

I pointed toward the driveway, where three newly arrived cars waited beneath covers.

"Nigga, don't become sentimental before checking the parking."

She laughed.

Then she looked toward Shawna, who stood with Rosa by the kitchen doors, arguing lovingly about wedding music.

"You know what you want."

"Most days."

"And on the others?"

"She reminds me. Loudly."

Vesper smiled.

For a moment the evening stayed quiet around us.

"I wanted you once," she said.

No performance. No trap.

"I know."

"I thought wanting the greatest man in a room meant I understood him."

I looked at her.

She shook her head before I could answer.

"Do not turn that into a boast. I am trying to be gracious."

"Nigga, you chose difficult material."

She laughed, and whatever remained awkward between us loosened into something we could both hold without bleeding on it.

"I'm glad you're coming to the wedding," I said.

"So am I."

Shawna came down the steps carrying three glasses.

She handed one to Vesper, one to me, and kept the third.

"What are you two plotting?"

"Curtains," Vesper said.

"Cars," I said.

My wife looked between us.

"Terrible liars."

She sat beside me anyway.

Across the garden, Bernard said something that made Magnolia laugh with her whole face. June showed Adrian a sketch and he kissed the top of her head. Tank came out of the kitchen carrying a cake sample Rosa had finally permitted him to eat.

Everybody had keys now.

To garages, houses, ships, stages, rooms they wanted to return to.

Nigga, I had spent a lot of my life breaking doors.

Watching my people choose which ones to open felt expensive in a way I intended to keep affording.

20. The Bachelor Party with the Wrong Speech

Tank asked for a quiet bachelor party.

Nigga, he asked me. That was his first mistake.

His second mistake was telling Porsche the budget did not matter. His third was allowing Victor Voltage to bring a karaoke machine he had personally improved. By nine that evening, the rooftop of one of my clubs held a pool table, a stage, four musicians, enough champagne to make a divorce attorney feel hopeful, and a sign that read ONE LAST NIGHT OF FREEDOM.

Rosa saw the sign during setup.

She looked at it.

Then at Tank.

"Freedom?"

The nigga turned to Porsche with pure betrayal in his eyes.

Porsche took down the sign.

Ten minutes later it read ONE LAST NIGHT OF UNCHECKED LAUNDRY.

Rosa approved.

So did I.

We had not excluded the women. Nigga, most of the men present would have spent the evening calling them anyway. We gave Rosa and Shawna the lounge downstairs with their friends, and kept the roof for Tank's people until the two parties inevitably decided the other one had better music.

Cassius arrived wearing a white jacket and carrying a bottle so old the cork probably remembered a different government. Victor wore blue and looked dangerously pleased with the equipment onstage. Anton came with Roland, who had accepted the invitation with the bewildered gratitude of a man still adjusting to being invited somewhere without a weapon requirement.

Gideon was in prison.

Orson was in prison.

Roland was standing beside a pool table, holding a drink with a little umbrella in it.

Nigga, choices had produced very different evenings.

Tank came out of the elevator wearing black silk and the cautious expression of a man who suspected happiness might have booked entertainment.

He saw the stage.

Then the lights.

Then the drinks.

"Brother."

"Quiet," I told him.

He looked at the drummer.

The drummer waved both sticks.

"Nigga, define quiet."

"Nobody's shooting."

Tank considered that.

"Fair."

The first hour went beautifully.

We played pool. We drank. Cassius told a story about a Monaco hotel that had tried to charge him for damaging a fountain he insisted had damaged him first. Victor described the faculty meeting where my portrait had been approved and did impressions of three professors so accurate Seraphine would have expelled him from dinner if she heard.

Roland listened for a while before laughing.

When he finally did, Tank pointed at him.

"There. Nigga's becoming a person."

"I was a person before."

"You wore a white suit to shoot at my brother. That's a job description."

Roland raised his glass.

"A former job description."

We drank to that.

Downstairs, the women's party grew louder. Adult dancers came through the elevator carrying feathered costumes, bottles, and the bright, tired confidence of people who had finished working and wanted the rest of the night to belong to them. Some of the guests disappeared into private rooms with their partners. Others stayed at the bar telling stories filthy enough to make a priest develop an urgent appointment.

There was cocaine at the far end of the party. There were men acting as if cocaine had personally invented their business plans. There were women rolling their eyes at those men and choosing better company. I had a drink, a pool cue, my brother beside me, and no desire to spend the next morning explaining to Shawna why the ceiling had become interesting.

A woman in silver boots leaned against our table and looked at Tank.

"You're the groom."

He nodded.

"Yeah."

"You look nervous."

"Nigga, people keep noticing."

She smiled.

"Good. Means you know the size of what you're getting."

Tank looked toward the elevator.

Rosa's laugh floated up from below.

The nigga smiled without thinking about it.

"Yeah," he said. "I do."

At the pool table, Anton challenged me to a game.

I accepted because, nigga, a king ought to provide recreational disappointment to his friends.

He was good. Better than I expected. The big man moved around the table with delicate care, lining up shots as if he apologized to the balls before making them obey him.

Tank watched from a chair.

"This nigga got little hands hidden inside the big ones."

Anton smiled.

"Precision is not limited by size."

"That's what I tell Rosa."

The whole table groaned.

"Nigga!" I shouted.

"What? I meant dancing!"

Nobody believed him, including the nigga who had said it.

I won the game with a shot that sent the last ball cleanly into the corner while the cue ball stopped exactly where I wanted it. Anton looked at the table, then at me, and bowed with exaggerated despair.

"Is there anything?"

"Nigga, I still buy the wrong butter occasionally."

"A comforting flaw."

"Don't spread it around."

Tank laughed and reached into his jacket.

A folded paper fell out onto the chair beside him.

I saw it but thought nothing of it.

That was how the trouble started.

Porsche came upstairs looking for a list of song requests. Victor had connected his improved karaoke machine to the stage speakers and announced that he could make any man sound magnificent, a claim I found both interesting and redundant.

"Where's the new song?" Porsche asked.

Tank was at the bar.

Cassius pointed toward the folded paper on the chair.

"There, perhaps."

Perhaps.

Nigga, that word has injured more evenings than cheap tequila.

Porsche took the paper to Victor. Victor read the first line, smiled, and decided it was clearly an emotional number. He handed it to the keyboard player, who began finding chords under it.

Then the lights changed.

The stage microphone came alive.

"Ladies and gentlemen," Victor announced, "a new song from Captain Aiden, prepared especially for the groom."

I turned from the pool table.

"Nigga, what?"

The crowd cheered.

Tank looked at me from the bar, confused.

I looked at Victor.

Victor held up the paper.

Nigga, the man had the confidence of a superhero and the information of a drunk wedding guest. A dangerous combination.

Porsche pushed a microphone into my hand.

"Go. They love you."

"Those are separate issues."

The keyboard player began.

I stepped onto the stage because a nigga can only explain confusion so loudly before a crowd decides it is part of his introduction.

The first line appeared on the screen behind me.

I KNOW HOW TO STAY.

I stared.

The second line followed.

I STAYED IN ROOMS WHERE LEAVING WOULD HAVE BEEN SMARTER.

I looked at Tank.

His face changed.

Nigga, those were his vows.

His private words for Rosa, folded in his pocket while he tried to become the man who could say them out loud without shaking.

Victor had put them on a twelve-foot screen with a slow jam behind them.

Tank started toward the stage.

I lifted my hand.

Not at him.

At the keyboard player.

"Different song."

The musician blinked.

"Captain?"

"Different song, nigga. Give me something with an ass on it."

The drummer laughed and changed the beat.

I took the paper from Victor, folded it, and put it inside my jacket.

Then I turned back toward the crowd.

"Y'all know my brother?"

They cheered.

"Nigga's getting married."

Louder.

"Which means the rest of us are going to have to stop borrowing his shirts without asking Rosa where the good laundry lives."

Tank stopped halfway to the stage.

The crowd laughed.

I began talking over the beat.

Not his vows.

My own ridiculous shit.

"That's my nigga by the bar, looking like a bank vault learned to love. That nigga got a ring, got a woman, got a reason to stop pretending the sofa is a bed. Rosa said dance, the nigga said which direction. Rosa said blue, the nigga bought the ocean a sample card."

The audience howled.

Tank covered his face.

"Nigga, this man stole a boat with his girlfriend beside him and still found time to argue about cake. That's commitment. That's range. That's a nigga who knows love comes with refreshments."

Rosa appeared in the elevator doorway.

Shawna stood beside her.

Both women looked at Tank.

Then at me onstage.

The drummer gave me a flourish.

I pointed at my brother.

"He got hands like trouble and a heart like somebody left the porch light on. He'll drag a nigga out of a fire, then ask whether anybody saved his good jacket. He'll fight the world, but Rosa says sit and the nigga discovers furniture immediately."

Tank laughed despite himself.

Rosa put both hands over her mouth.

I let the beat run beneath the next words.

"That's my brother. That's the nigga. The one who came. The one who stayed. The one I'm standing beside when the whole city watches him get the best thing he ever asked for."

I raised my glass.

"To Tank."

The room rose.

Every nigga at every table stood, cheering, glasses in the air.

Tank looked at me.

The anger had not vanished. I could still see it under the embarrassment, under the love. That was fair. Something private had nearly been taken from him in a room full of people he wanted to trust.

I came off the stage and put the folded paper in his hand.

"Let's talk."

We went onto the quieter side terrace.

The city glowed below us. Music moved through the glass doors behind us. Tank held the paper between two fingers like it might bite him if he looked at it too long.

"You read it?" he asked.

"The first two lines. Same as everybody."

"I didn't give it to you."

"I know."

"Nigga, I been working on that."

"I know."

He looked at me.

"Then why—"

"Porsche thought it was the song list. Cassius guessed. Victor got enthusiastic. A whole chain of niggas with confidence and no fucking evidence."

Tank breathed out.

The explanation did not magically make the feeling leave.

I let him stand with it.

After a while he unfolded the paper.

His own handwriting filled the page, big and careful. Some words crossed out. Others written above them. A man who had never needed help making his fists understood trying to choose exactly what his heart ought to sound like.

"I don't want it to sound like you," he said.

I looked at him.

"Good."

"Everybody expects some big shit when we talk. Some line. Some thing they can yell back. I don't want to get up there and sound like a nigga trying to perform my own wife."

Nigga, that hit me cleanly.

I put my glass on the railing.

"Then don't."

He looked down at the page.

"What if I forget?"

"You know her."

"What if I can't say it?"

"She's gonna be standing right there. Talk to Rosa. Let the rest of us be furniture."

He smiled faintly.

"You gonna manage furniture?"

"Nigga, for five minutes. Because I love you. Don't exploit it."

He laughed.

The terrace door opened.

Victor stepped out with Porsche and Cassius behind him. All three looked sober in the specific way people become sober when they realize a joke nearly cost somebody something they cannot replace with a better bottle.

"Tank," Victor said, "I am sorry. I should have asked."

Porsche nodded.

"Me too."

Cassius put a hand over his heart.

"I guessed. Poorly."

Tank looked at them.

Then at the paper.

"Niggas," he said, "y'all had my wedding vows on a karaoke screen."

Nobody defended it.

For a second the city hummed beneath us.

Then Tank started laughing.

Not because it had never mattered.

Because it still mattered, and the three niggas in front of him knew that now, and nobody was asking him to pretend otherwise.

"I KNOW HOW TO STAY," he sang badly in Victor's dramatic voice.

Porsche doubled over.

Cassius covered his face.

Victor looked mortified, then began laughing too.

"The chord progression was tasteful," he said weakly.

"Nigga, the chord progression was about to get punched."

I laughed until my shoulder hurt.

Rosa came out onto the terrace.

She looked at the five of us.

"You finished?"

Tank straightened.

"Yeah."

She held out her hand.

"Good. I want to dance with the man from that song."

He looked at me.

I pointed toward her.

"Nigga, furniture time. Go."

He went.

We watched them through the doors as she pulled him into the music. He put the folded paper safely inside his jacket before taking her other hand.

Victor leaned beside me at the railing.

"You handled that well."

"Nigga, you almost made my brother marry a bass line."

He winced.

"Yes."

"Next time ask."

"There will not be a next time."

I looked at him.

He considered our history.

"Next time I will ask."

"There you go. Growth."

Inside, Shawna caught my eye and lifted her hand.

I left the niggas on the terrace and went to my wife.

"Nice song," she said.

"Freestyle."

"I noticed. You mentioned yourself less than usual."

"Nigga, it was difficult."

She laughed and put her arms around me.

We danced while Tank and Rosa moved beside us, while the band played, while the city shone below a rooftop full of grown people telling outrageous stories and trying, in their own loud ways, to be good company for the people they had chosen.

Later, Tank handed me the folded vows.

I shook my head.

"Keep them."

He smiled.

"I got what I need."

He tapped his chest once.

Then he looked across the room at Rosa.

Nigga, I believed him.

21. Something Old, Something Loud

Marcellus made our wedding rings in a room that smelled of polished wood, hot metal, and the excellent coffee he refused to let Tank touch with sugar.

"Nigga," Tank said, looking into the cup, "why it taste like a serious decision?"

"Because you drink syrup," Marcellus replied.

Rosa laughed and took the cup from her fiancé.

"Give him something sweet before he proposes to the biscuit tray."

We sat around the jeweler's worktable while morning light came through the windows. Outside, Vegas prepared for the wedding with the patience of a city that had already decided patience was somebody else's problem. Florists called. Drivers called. A man from the sound crew called to ask whether the Sky High choir required separate support for the bass section because one member could accidentally levitate equipment when enthusiastic.

Rosa said yes, then demanded to know why nobody had asked that question before ordering the stage.

My wife sat beside me, turning our original wedding ring around her finger.

"We keeping those," I said.

"Of course."

"Nigga, I survived too much for a trade-in policy."

She smiled.

"The new ones go with them."

Marcellus set two narrow bands on the velvet between us. Mine was white gold with a thin blue line through the center.

Shawna's matched it, finer at the edges, bright enough to catch the light when she moved without trying to compete with the ring she already wore.

Inside mine, tiny letters read:

I CAME BACK.

Inside hers:

I WAS HERE.

I looked at her.

She held my gaze.

Nigga, I had crossed continents looking for ways to say more, and my wife had put the whole fucking thing inside four words.

"You choose that?" I asked.

She nodded.

"You like it?"

I tried to make a joke.

Nothing came.

Shawna smiled, softer now.

"There he is."

Tank leaned forward.

"What mine say?"

Rosa covered her ring with one hand.

"You find out at the wedding."

"Nigga, I need time to prepare emotionally."

"You had months."

"I used them on flowers."

Marcellus laughed and brought out their rings. Tank's was broad, dark gold, built for a hand that had never encountered a delicate situation it could not accidentally turn into furniture. Rosa's held a small blue stone surrounded by warm gold, a ring that looked good beside both a microphone and a fist.

She stared at it.

Tank stared at her staring.

Nigga, that was his favorite part of being rich. Not the price. The second before the woman he loved found her voice again.

"Baby," she said quietly.

"Yeah?"

"You did good."

The nigga looked down at his coffee like he needed somewhere private to put his face.

I put a hand on his shoulder.

"Don't fall apart before the fitting. We need your measurements stable."

He laughed and shoved my hand away.

After they left to argue with the tailor, Shawna took Dante's watch off her wrist and laid it beside the rings.

Marcellus picked it up carefully.

"The clasp?"

"A little loose," she said. "After the bridge."

He examined it beneath the lamp.

I watched his hands move over the watch he had known in a different part of the story, before I stood inside it wearing a dead man's cross and wanting a living woman's whole heart.

The old jealousy did not rise.

That surprised me for half a breath.

Then I realized it had been quiet for a long time and I had finally stopped listening for it.

Shawna looked at me.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"Nigga, that's not your nothing face."

I touched the cross beneath my shirt.

"I was thinking about the first night. That watch on your wrist."

She smiled faintly.

"You thought it meant I was leaving."

"I thought a lot of stupid shit with excellent confidence."

"Past tense?"

"Nigga, let me grow for a minute."

She laughed.

Marcellus took the watch into the adjoining workroom, leaving us alone at the table.

Shawna rested her head against my shoulder.

"I'm wearing it tomorrow."

"I know."

"And your rings."

"I know that too."

"And a dress you're going to embarrass yourself about."

I turned toward her.

"Nigga, why you hide the important information at the end?"

She kissed me.

The watch ticked softly from the other room while Marcellus worked. It was an ordinary sound now. A little machine keeping time. No accusation. No contest. Just something a woman I loved had carried through days I could not change and into a morning where she had already chosen where to sit.

I put my arm around her.

"You think he would've liked me?" I asked.

She considered it seriously.

Then she smiled.

"He would have thought you were unbearable."

"Nigga, fair."

"And he would have laughed."

"At me?"

"With you. Eventually. After you stopped introducing yourself to every mirror."

"That's an important professional relationship."

She laughed against my chest.

I held her there until Marcellus returned.

He handed back the watch, repaired and shining.

Then he opened a small box of his own.

Blue Mercy lay inside.

The stone caught the light with that deep blue fire I had seen men lose their minds trying to own. It had crossed prisons, marriages, lies, dead hands, rich rooms. Now it rested in the palm of the man whose love had given it meaning before any of those niggas tried to put a price on it.

"You wearing it?" I asked.

He nodded.

"At the wedding."

"Good."

"I have kept it in the pouch long enough."

He slid the ring onto his finger. It fit. The old man's hand trembled slightly, then steadied.

Shawna reached across and touched it.

"Beautiful."

"She was," he said.

We did not correct him.

He took Celeste's letter from a drawer. The paper had been folded and unfolded so many times its creases seemed part of the handwriting. He looked at her name at the bottom, smiled to himself, and put it back beside a photograph.

Then he closed the drawer.

"Now," he said, "show me what you intend to wear with my work."

Nigga, the man had returned to his profession. I respected the shift.

The afternoon fitting took place at the mansion because the tailor had looked at the guest list and decided his shop was not structurally prepared.

Tank stood on a low platform in a blue suit while three people circled him with pins. He held his arms out like a dangerous angel waiting for somebody to finish making wings.

"Too tight?" the tailor asked.

Tank flexed.

A seam made a small sound.

The tailor closed his eyes.

"Please do not answer physically."

I laughed from the next platform.

"Nigga, he asked."

My own suit was midnight blue, dark enough to look black until the light found it. The jacket fit around the sling Vega still insisted I wear when I was not pretending the doctor could not see me. A narrow opening inside kept the badge where I could reach it, because Knox said she refused to attend a wedding

where her best officer had to undress before becoming a problem.

The tailor adjusted my collar.

Then he stepped back.

Then farther back.

"What?" I asked.

"I need perspective."

"Nigga, it's a suit."

"On you, Captain, it has become an event."

Tank pointed at him.

"That nigga understands the assignment."

Rosa came in to check the colors.

She saw Tank.

Stopped.

Then put both hands over her mouth.

Tank looked down at himself, alarmed.

"Baby?"

She shook her head.

The nigga stepped off the platform so fast the tailor nearly fainted.

"What's wrong?"

"Nothing," she said through her fingers. "You look—"

She could not finish.

Tank went still.

Then he smiled, slow and astonished.

I looked away before the moment became something I had stolen by watching too closely.

On the terrace, Knox and Seraphine shared a bottle of wine while discussing the logistics of putting a floating choir over a city full of fireworks enthusiasts.

"They will remain at a sensible altitude," Seraphine said.

Knox looked at me through the open doors.

"My understanding of sensible has suffered recently."

"The captain does encourage revision."

"That's one word."

They laughed together. Two women who had spent years commanding rooms found it pleasant to sit in one where nobody needed rescuing for at least twenty minutes.

Magnolia and Bernard argued over table placements. Cassius and Inez arrived with both fathers, who immediately began correcting each other's memories of old races. Mercedes and Porsche brought a guest list covered in lipstick marks and changes. Liora called from the First Dance to say the airship was ready. Sienna's musicians rehearsed in the garden. June and

Adrian arrived late, tired, and smiling like two niggas hiding a mechanical surprise.

Shawna remained upstairs.

I tried to go find her.

Rosa blocked the stairs.

"No."

"This my house."

"And that dress is none of your business until tomorrow."

"Nigga, I'm the groom."

"That's why you under restriction."

Tank came up beside me.

"We could go through the balcony."

Rosa looked at him.

He stepped backward.

"I was identifying a security concern."

I laughed so hard the tailor shouted from the other room that my shoulders were moving again.

That night, after the guests left and the house quieted, Shawna came downstairs wearing one of my shirts.

No wedding dress.

No jewels except the rings she already wore and the watch ticking on her wrist.

She sat beside me on the sofa and put her feet in my lap.

"You ready?"

I looked at her.

Nigga, I had been ready in a motel with a bullet in my side.

Ready in a hospital while pretending pain did not frighten me.

Ready on a floating school, on a racecourse, on a broken bridge with my hands refusing to work.

But that night I was ready in a quieter way.

No gun in my hand.

No door to break.

Just the woman, the house, and the next morning.

"Yeah," I said.

She smiled.

"Me too."

We stayed on the sofa until the city lights went soft beyond the windows, and for once I let tomorrow arrive without trying to beat it there.

22. Two Weddings and the Whole Fucking World

On the morning of the wedding, Tank forgot how to tie a tie.

This nigga had driven through gunfire, carried grown men out of burning rooms, stolen a boat under an emperor's palace, and stood beside me while the world repeatedly attempted to become inconvenient. Now he held a strip of blue silk like somebody had handed him a venomous snake with a dress code.

"Brother."

I looked at him.

"Nigga, you shaking."

"The fabric slippery."

"Your hands slippery?"

"Don't start."

I took the tie and fixed it around his neck.

The room was quiet except for the distant sound of musicians warming up in the garden. Sunlight came through the curtains. Our suits hung perfectly. Our shoes shone. Nobody had called to report an aircraft losing an engine.

That last fact felt like a wedding gift from the universe.

Tank looked at himself in the mirror.

Then at me standing behind him.

"We really doing this."

"Nigga, they rented chairs. We committed."

He laughed, then swallowed hard.

"I used to think getting through the night was the whole thing."

"I know."

"Then another night. Then another. You get enough of them together, you start calling it a life because nobody told you there was more."

I straightened his collar.

He watched my hands in the mirror.

"Then she looked at me like I was somebody she might want around in the morning."

Nigga, my brother's voice broke on morning.

I put both hands on his shoulders.

"She does."

He nodded.

"Yeah."

"And you ain't got to win her again every time the sun comes up. Just be there when it does."

Tank looked at me.

"That sound like something Shawna told you."

"Nigga, I cite my sources privately."

He laughed and hugged me.

Carefully. Vega had threatened everybody about the shoulder.

When he let go, I handed him his jacket.

"Come on. Your woman waiting."

The garden had become a city made of flowers.

Blue roses climbed white arches. Long tables glittered under hanging lights. Beyond them, the First Dance floated above the grounds, its painted heart renewed in gold. Sky High's choir stood on a broad platform beneath the airship, every singer firmly instructed to keep both feet where the music director could see them. Cars lined the drive in colors that made the sunset look underfunded.

The Last Word waited near the entrance.

Rebuilt.

Dark blue. Polished. Its silver letters shining.

June stood beside it with Adrian, both dressed beautifully, both looking like they had slept three hours and considered the result worth it.

I stopped.

"Nigga."

June smiled.

"Wedding gift."

"You fixed it."

"I improved it. Fixed would imply accepting the original driver behavior."

Shawna's name had been engraved on the passenger-side sill.

I ran my hand over it.

Adrian nodded.

"She brought it home as often as you did."

Nigga, I could not argue with excellence that precise.

I hugged them both.

Then Rosa's voice came from somewhere inside the house.

"If the men are crying over cars, tell them to save something for the women!"

Tank stood straighter.

"Yes, baby!"

The guests rose when we entered the garden.

Not because anybody asked them to. Because every nigga there had apparently agreed that watching us walk between those flowers deserved a standing event. Cops saluted. Drivers cheered. Professors applauded. Sex workers whistled louder than all of them and improved the occasion immediately.

Principal Mercer already had a handkerchief pressed to his face.

"He hasn't even done anything yet," Professor Halcyon whispered.

"He's arrived," Mercer said, voice breaking. "He so rarely did."

Professor Lorne nodded with grave academic pride.

"And yet, look at the outcome."

I heard every word.

"Niggas, I graduated once. Let it rest."

Mercer began crying harder.

Tank bent over laughing.

Knox stood near the front in a white uniform. Seraphine sat beside her, elegant and calm, though I saw both women watching the floating choir with the alertness of people who had learned music could become an emergency in my vicinity.

Marcellus held the rings.

Blue Mercy shone on his hand.

Magnolia and Bernard sat together under the shade of a flowering tree. Vesper sat beside them. Noor and Salma had brought their mother, who looked at the two captains, then at my suit, and declared she understood why they had both crossed a desert to attend.

"Mother," Noor murmured.

"I am old, not blind."

Shawna's friends laughed from the next row.

Nigga, everybody had brought their whole selves. I wanted it that way.

The music changed.

Tank stopped breathing.

I felt it beside me.

"Nigga," I whispered, "you need air for vows."

He did not answer.

Rosa appeared at the garden doors.

Her dress was ivory with a blue lining that flashed when she moved. No giant veil hiding her face. No attempt to make her look like a woman who had never lived before this morning. She looked like Rosa: beautiful, bold, nervous beneath the boldness, walking toward the man who had learned every version of her laugh and wanted the rest of them.

Shawna walked beside her.

My wife wore blue silk, pale at the shoulders and deepening toward the hem, with a narrow white wrap over one arm. Her wedding rings shone on one hand. Dante's watch shone on the other. She looked at me as she came down the aisle, and every room I had ever entered without her became suddenly difficult to remember.

Tank made a small sound.

I made a worse one.

The nigga turned toward me just long enough to whisper, "You too?"

"Nigga, look at them."

"I am."

"Then mind your own collapse."

We both laughed through eyes that had become inconveniently wet.

Rosa reached Tank.

He took her hands like he had been given something fragile and then remembered she would beat his ass for thinking that.

"You look—"

"I know," she whispered, smiling.

He laughed.

"Yeah."

Shawna came to my side and slipped her hand into mine.

The officiant began.

He was an older man Rosa had chosen because he could speak warmly without sounding like he was selling furniture. He looked at the crowd, the airship, the fleet of cars, the two captains in the front row, the jeweled king standing as best man,

and took one deep breath before deciding to keep the introduction short.

A wise nigga.

When it was time for Tank's vows, my brother unfolded a sheet of paper.

His hands shook.

Rosa waited.

He looked at the page.

Then folded it again.

"I wrote a lot," he said.

The crowd laughed gently.

"Aiden said some of it sounded like I was buying a refrigerator."

"Nigga, the warranty language was concerning," I said.

Rosa laughed and squeezed his hands.

Tank took a breath.

"I know how to stay," he told her. "I stayed for people who didn't deserve it. Stayed in rooms where leaving would've been smarter. Stayed because I thought leaving made a man weak."

He looked into her face.

"But with you, staying don't feel like proving something. It feels like getting something. A morning. A song. You cussing at me

because I put the wrong shirt in the wash. You standing in the kitchen eating cake with a fork you pretend you ain't using."

Rosa wiped her cheek with the back of one hand.

"I don't promise I'm gonna become smooth," Tank said. "These niggas know me. I can't lie in front of this many witnesses."

The garden laughed.

"I promise you won't have to wonder where I am when you call. I promise I will learn the dance. I promise I'm gonna be there when the music stops too."

His voice broke.

"And I promise every good thing I get, my first thought is gonna be, Rosa should have some of this."

Nigga, I looked away at the flowers and found no help there.

Rosa held his face between her hands.

"You big beautiful man," she whispered.

Then she began her vows.

"I had people listen to me sing and never hear a fucking word I said afterward. You heard me when I was tired. You heard me when I was angry. You heard me say I wanted the green shoes and came back with three pairs because you forgot which green."

Tank laughed.

"They all looked right."

"They did."

She smiled through the tears.

"I promise to tell you what I want. I promise not to make you guess when the truth would be kinder. I promise to keep dancing with you even when you try to count the steps out loud."

"That helps me."

"I know, baby."

The whole garden seemed to lean toward them.

"And I promise that when somebody asks who my husband is, I'm gonna point at you with my whole fucking hand. No little embarrassed finger. That man. That beautiful, loyal, loud, impossible man. Mine."

Tank closed his eyes.

One tear ran down his face.

Rosa kissed it away before the officiant could get to the next instruction.

Nobody objected.

The rings came from Marcellus's hands.

Tank read the words inside his.

STAY FOR THE LAST SONG.

He looked at Rosa.

Her ring read:

I'M STILL DANCING.

Nigga, that old jeweler had no respect for anybody trying to remain composed.

They exchanged the rings.

They said yes.

They kissed.

The garden erupted.

The choir rose a foot off the platform in excitement. Seraphine lifted one finger. Every singer came back down immediately without missing the note.

Knox watched, impressed.

"Excellent control."

"Practice," the dean said.

Tank lifted Rosa off the ground.

She laughed against his mouth and told him not to wrinkle the dress.

He put her down as carefully as he had ever handled anything in his life.

Then he turned toward me.

Nigga, my brother was married.

I hugged him hard enough for Vega to make a disapproving sound from the front row.

"We did it," he whispered.

"You did it."

"Nigga, you stood here. That counts."

I held him another second.

Then Shawna took my hand.

Our turn.

We did not need a second grand entrance. She removed the white wrap from her arm and let Rosa place it around her shoulders. The music softened. The guests sat. The same garden held a different quiet as my wife and I stood beneath the arch.

I looked at her.

The first wedding had felt like grabbing happiness before the world could close its fist.

This one felt like opening my hand and finding she had chosen to remain inside it.

The officiant asked whether we wished to renew the promises already made.

"Nigga," I said softly, looking only at her, "more than anything."

Shawna smiled.

"Yes."

I took both her hands.

"The first time I married you, I thought I had to promise the whole world because I didn't know what else a man could give a woman like you. Houses. Cars. Money. A city if I could find one with poor supervision."

The guests laughed.

"I still like giving you those things. I'm not about to embarrass myself by pretending I stopped enjoying being rich."

Shawna laughed, bright and familiar.

"But you met me in the parts I couldn't buy. The hospital. The car after the lightning. The bridge when my hands wouldn't work. You were there when being Aiden didn't feel like enough for Aiden."

Her eyes shone.

"And every time I got scared you might finally see all of me, you looked closer. Nigga, you looked closer and stayed."

I swallowed.

"So I promise this. When I say home, I mean where you can find me. When I say forever, I mean the next morning too. When I say I'm the greatest man alive—"

The crowd began laughing before I finished.

"—I mean I'm gonna spend every fucking day giving you new evidence."

Shawna laughed through tears.

"I knew you'd get that in."

"Baby, the vows got standards."

She squeezed my hands.

Then she spoke.

"You came into my life loudly."

Tank nodded from beside us.

"Very loudly."

"You were jealous, ridiculous, brave, and convinced a mansion could solve a conversation."

"Sometimes it helps," I said.

"Sometimes it does."

She smiled.

"You never became easy. I didn't marry you because I thought you would. I married you because beneath all that noise was a man who would hear me when I said my own name. A man who learned I could carry a past and still choose a future. A man who comes back."

She touched the new band in Marcellus's hand.

"I promise to keep choosing you on purpose. I promise to tell you when you're being unbearable."

"Nigga, that's been consistent."

"I promise to laugh when you're funny and when you're so full of yourself I need the relief. I promise to sing in the house even when you insist on joining the chorus."

"The public appreciates it."

"The public isn't married to you."

The garden laughed.

She stepped closer.

"And I promise you will never have to compete with a ghost for a place that already belongs to you. You are my husband. My living, impossible husband. I am here."

Nigga, I could not have answered if the whole world had offered me another crown.

I kissed her hands.

We exchanged the new rings beside the old.

I CAME BACK.

I WAS HERE.

Then the officiant said we could kiss, which was kind of him, given the evidence that we had never intended to wait for permission.

The choir sang.

The guests stood.

My wife put both hands on my face and kissed me beneath the blue roses while the city, the sky, and every nigga I loved made enough noise to let the dead know we were still doing all right down here.

23. Niggalicious

Tank began his wedding toast by calling me a motherfucker and immediately received a standing ovation from the people who knew me best.

"Sit down," Rosa told them, laughing. "Let the man develop his argument."

My brother stood beneath a canopy of lights with a glass in one hand and the microphone in the other. His tie had loosened. His new ring shone when he moved. Behind him, the First Dance floated against the night sky, its windows bright with guests looking down at the garden.

"I had a speech," he said.

"You had several," I called.

"Nigga, because you kept editing them."

"One of them threatened the guests."

"Only the ones who didn't bring gifts."

The tables roared.

Shawna leaned against me, laughing into my shoulder. Rosa stood beside Tank with her glass raised and the expression of a woman who had chosen exactly this man with full knowledge of the available evidence.

Tank looked around the garden.

"I been trying to figure out what you call a nigga like my brother. Captain ain't enough. King ain't enough. Husband only covers the part Shawna tolerates."

"Barely," she said.

"This nigga walks into a room and the room starts behaving like it got lucky."

People laughed and pointed toward me.

I lifted my glass.

"Architecture recognizes quality."

Tank shook his head.

"See? Nigga can't even receive a compliment without expanding it. So I had to invent a word."

Porsche stood at the next table.

"You did not invent that word."

Tank turned.

"Nigga, sit down. This my toast."

"And my word."

"What word?" Rosa asked, delighted.

Tank lifted the microphone.

"Niggalicious."

The garden exploded.

Mercedes bent over the table laughing. Victor looked at Cassius, who repeated the word slowly like a man testing whether a new engine note pleased him. Knox put her wine down before she spilled it. Principal Mercer began applauding with the solemn enthusiasm of a teacher witnessing an important contribution to language.

Porsche pointed at Tank.

"I said that on the airship!"

"You said the cake looked delicious."

"I said the nigga carrying the cake looked niggalicious."

Rosa turned toward her husband.

Tank blinked.

"Me?"

"Nigga, who else was carrying half a bakery up the stairs?"

He considered this new information.

Then smiled.

Rosa slapped his arm lightly.

"Stay married in your face."

"I am. I'm just linguistically appreciated."

I stood.

The crowd cheered before I spoke, which I considered a very efficient arrangement.

"Niggas," I said, "why y'all arguing about who invented a word for something I already am?"

Shawna covered her face.

Tank pointed at me with the microphone.

"That. That right there. That's the fucking condition."

"Niggalicious," Cassius agreed.

"Severely," Victor added.

"Possibly congenital," Vega said from her table.

The doctor had spoken so dryly that it took half the garden a second to collapse laughing.

I looked at her.

"Nigga, you finally giving me a diagnosis I enjoy."

"Do not let it interfere with wearing the sling."

Shawna stood beside me and raised her glass.

"To the men we married. Loudly, deliberately, and with every opportunity to read the warning signs."

Rosa lifted hers.

"We read them."

"We liked the font," Shawna said.

The women at the nearest tables cheered loud enough to make the choir above us turn around.

Tank raised his glass again.

"To my brother. To my wife. To every nigga who came home."

I looked around the garden.

At Victor with his arm around an old academy friend. At Cassius and Inez touching knees beneath the table. At June and Adrian, too tired to stop smiling. At Vesper laughing beside Magnolia. At Bernard looking up at the airship as if a night this beautiful might finally belong to him too. At Marcellus wearing Blue Mercy in the light.

I raised my glass.

"To coming home."

Everybody drank.

Then Rosa took the microphone from Tank.

"And now," she said, "my husband dances."

The big nigga looked at me like I might produce a legal exemption.

I shook my head.

"Nigga, jurisdiction ends at the dance floor."

She led him into the open space between the tables.

The band began softly.

Tank placed one hand at her waist. She put hers on his shoulder. For the first few steps he looked down. Rosa lifted his chin with one finger.

"Here," she whispered.

He looked at her.

The next step came easier.

Then another.

Nigga, my brother danced.

Not perfectly. Not like a man who had secretly been a professional all along. Like Tank, who had practiced because Rosa wanted it and trusted her enough to stop protecting himself from being seen trying.

She smiled at him with her whole face.

The crowd quieted around them.

I watched the big dangerous nigga turn gently beneath the lights and felt something in my chest settle into a place it had been looking for since the first night he stood beside me.

Shawna took my hand.

"Our turn."

I went with her.

She put her arms around my neck, careful of the shoulder. I held her close, the new ring against her back, the old one beside it.

Her dress moved around our feet. The band found a melody I knew because I had heard her hum it in our house when she thought nobody was listening.

"You chose this?" I asked.

"You know it."

"Nigga, I know you."

She smiled.

"That's the idea."

We moved slowly. No stunts. No need to make the whole garden discover gravity again. I could hear her breathing near my ear. I could feel the watch against my shoulder. I could see Tank and Rosa turning beside us, laughing when he stepped the wrong way and she guided him back without making it matter.

For once, being the greatest man in the room did not require me to be the loudest thing in it.

Then the song ended and Tank shouted, "Niggalicious!" directly into the quiet.

Everybody laughed.

Nigga, peace had its limits.

The party grew.

Mercedes and Porsche took over the stage for a performance involving Sienna's violin, a bass line, and enough confidence to make three millionaires forget what they had been saying.

Shawna sang with Rosa. Victor joined the choir for one song and accidentally lifted his chair off the ground during the final note. Seraphine looked at him. The chair returned immediately.

Cassius asked Inez to dance.

She told him to keep up.

The nigga looked delighted to receive a challenge he intended to spend his life losing beautifully.

Esteban and Nero stood beside the dance floor arguing over which of their children had inherited the better sense of rhythm. Neither seemed interested in the fact that both children were currently doing better than their fathers had demonstrated all evening.

Captain Lionel Graves found Knox beside the dance floor with two glasses in his hands and a blue rose between his teeth.

She looked at the flower.

"You realize everybody here is armed. They could end this embarrassment for you."

He offered her a glass and took the rose from his mouth.

"I have faced worse odds for your attention."

"Nigga," I called, "the man's consistent."

Knox looked at me over her shoulder, but she was smiling when she turned back to him. Graves tucked the rose into the ribbon at her wrist. She let him. Then she took his hand and led him into

the music like the whole department could survive ten minutes without her watching its favorite problem.

Seraphine raised her glass as they passed.

"Excellent partner selection, Chief."

"Under continuing assessment," Knox said.

Graves pulled her close. Whatever answer he whispered made her laugh against his shoulder.

At the next table, Isolde took Marcellus's hand and examined Blue Mercy in the light.

"You wore it," she said.

He nodded.

"I wanted to."

"Good. Now bring the rest of yourself onto the floor."

The old jeweler looked alarmed. "There are witnesses."

"There were witnesses thirty-five years ago. You were less cautious then."

She stood, her dress moving around her ankles, and held out her hand. Marcellus took it. They began with the old seven-turn dance, the one their younger selves had carried all the way to the island vault. He remembered the first turn. She guided the second. On the third he laughed, surprised by his own feet, and Isolde kissed his cheek without losing the rhythm.

Nigga, the ring shone on his hand while he held a living woman close. Nothing on that hand had to disappear for the music to begin.

Magnolia danced with Bernard.

Slowly at first. Her cane rested against a chair. He held her hand with the shy attention of a man who had once thought the part of his life containing new music might be finished.

She said something to him.

He laughed.

Nigga, that was enough of their conversation for me to be glad I had lived to see it.

June came to our table carrying a set of keys.

I held out my hand.

She moved them away.

"Not yours."

"Nigga, that sentence hurts."

She gave them to Professor Lorne.

The professor blinked.

"My convertible?"

"Repaired. Better steering. New paint. Try not to let the captain use it as a teaching aid again."

Lorne looked at the keys, then at me.

"It did produce an extraordinary practical lesson."

Mercer began applauding again.

Halcyon took his glass away.

"Percival, breathe between achievements."

The principal nodded, overcome.

I leaned toward Shawna.

"Nigga, I should've attended more classes. These people love me."

She kissed my cheek.

"That's probably why you remain impressive to them."

The wedding cake arrived at midnight.

It was taller than Tank.

Nigga, I wish I could tell you I had opposed this. I had not.

When the pastry chef asked how much cake we wanted, Tank said everybody, and I said make sure, which apparently constituted an architectural brief.

Nine tiers. Blue flowers made of sugar. White pillars. Two little couples on the top, both grooms rendered handsomely enough that I considered tipping the artist twice. The cake rolled into the garden on a reinforced platform while the Sky High cook walked beside it with the terrified pride of a man escorting a cathedral through traffic.

The crowd applauded.

Then one wheel struck the edge of a paving stone.

The platform tilted.

The cake began to lean.

Tank moved.

I moved.

Nigga, we had faced emperors, planes, guns, and collapsing bridges. Nothing had united us faster than seeing Rosa's cake consider the ground.

Tank caught the platform's lower edge. I caught the upper support with my good arm. Shawna and Rosa grabbed the tablecloth before it could pull the base sideways. Anton appeared behind Tank and lifted the other side like the laws of pastry had become a personal favor.

The cake steadied.

The little Aiden on top leaned forward.

I caught it before it fell.

The entire garden lost its fucking mind.

"That nigga saved himself!" Porsche shouted.

"At miniature scale!" Cassius added.

"Consistent across conditions," Professor Halcyon said, laughing so hard she had to wipe her glasses.

Vega pointed at my shoulder.

I held up the tiny groom.

"Medical emergency."

She looked at Rosa's face.

Then at the cake.

"I will allow that one."

We cut the first slices together.

Tank fed Rosa a bite with the concentration of a man handling an explosive device made of happiness. She fed him back, wiped icing from his mouth, and kissed him before he could make a joke about portion size.

Shawna held my slice up.

"Open."

I obeyed.

She smiled.

"Excellent husband. Follows instructions."

"Nigga, when the instruction is cake."

She kissed the icing from the corner of my mouth.

The fireworks began above the garden.

Blue. Gold. White.

The First Dance floated beneath them with its windows full of light. Music rose from the stage. Cars gleamed along the drive. Police and criminals danced together without anybody pretending the world had become simple because we had finally arranged a good night inside it.

Near the end, Tank found me by the fountain.

His tie hung loose. Rosa's lipstick marked his cheek. He held two glasses and handed me one.

"Brother."

"Husband."

The nigga smiled so wide I almost laughed before he spoke.

"I like how that sounds."

"Get used to it."

We stood together, watching our wives laugh beside the dance floor.

Tank lifted his glass toward them.

"We did all right."

"Nigga, we did magnificent."

He shook his head.

"Nah. New word."

I looked at him.

He looked back, completely serious for exactly half a second.

"Niggalicious."

I laughed until the water in the fountain seemed to laugh with me.

Then my wife called my name.

Rosa called his.

And both of us went.

24. Ten Toes Down, and Then Breakfast

Six months after the wedding, my wife sent me out for butter.

"Just butter," she said.

I looked at her across the kitchen.

"Nigga, why you emphasizing just?"

"Because last time I asked for lemons, you came back owning part of a restaurant."

"They had excellent lemons."

She pointed a wooden spoon at me.

"Butter."

"Salted?"

"Yes."

"Look at us communicating."

She laughed and kissed me before I could turn shopping into a speech.

The morning was warm. The house smelled of coffee. Outside, the white horse stood by the fence, watching a gardener arrange flowers with the bored authority of a nigga who had never once needed to earn his breakfast. My shoulder had healed. My arm

had healed. Vega had cleared me for ordinary activity while refusing to define ordinary in a way I could use against her later.

The Last Word waited in the drive.

Blue paint. Silver lettering. Shawna's name inside the passenger door.

I got behind the wheel, put on my sunglasses, and started the engine.

Nigga, there are men who leave the house.

Then there is the way I leave the house.

The gardener looked up and smiled.

"Morning, Captain."

"Morning. You need anything?"

"The roses are arriving this afternoon."

"Good. Get extra."

"Your wife already did."

I grinned.

The nigga had no idea how much that answer pleased me.

I drove through the gates with a grocery list containing one word and absolutely no reason to expect the city to behave itself.

Tank called before I reached the first light.

"Brother."

"Husband."

He still laughed when I called him that.

"Rosa says come by tonight. She trying a new song."

"Nigga, last time she tried a song, you cried into a bowl of pasta."

"The sauce was hot."

"Emotionally?"

"You bringing Shawna or not?"

"We'll be there."

"Good. Also, I got a new car."

"Nigga, why you hiding the news behind dinner?"

"Rosa says I'm supposed to lead with relationships."

In the background, she shouted, "I said stop introducing the car before me!"

I laughed all the way through the green light.

At the bakery, two men were robbing the register.

Nigga, two grown motherfuckers in black masks stood between me and salted butter at nine-fifteen in the morning.

One held a gun. The other held a pastry bag.

I stopped in the doorway.

The woman behind the counter looked at me.

Then at them.

Then she sighed with such relief that the nigga holding the gun turned around to see what she had discovered.

"Everybody stay—"

He stopped.

I took off my sunglasses.

His friend looked up from the pastry bag.

"Nigga."

"Yeah," I said. "Morning."

The gunman's eyes widened above the mask.

"Aiden?"

"Captain, while you doing that."

The other man lowered the bag.

"Nigga, I told you we should've gone across town."

"You told me the croissants were good!"

"They are good! That doesn't make this nigga less here!"

I looked at the baker.

"You all right?"

She nodded.

"They haven't hurt anybody."

"Good. Let's keep that little achievement intact."

I held out my hand.

The gunman stared at it.

"What?"

"Nigga, give me the gun."

His friend nodded urgently.

"Give the nigga the gun."

"Shut up."

"You shut up. That's the nigga from the bridge."

I waited.

The gunman looked at the photograph of me beside the register. The baker had put it there after I paid for a year's worth of pastries for the officers working night shifts. In the photograph I held a croissant like a man presenting an important discovery to science.

The nigga looked from the photograph back to me.

"You really live here."

"Nigga, what you think I do? Hover over the city between incidents?"

His friend began laughing nervously.

The gunman handed me the weapon.

Then a third man burst out of the back room.

Of course there was a third nigga. Bad planning loves company.

He saw me, saw his friends surrendering, and ran straight through the side door.

I looked at the two men in front of me.

"Stay."

They stayed.

The baker reached beneath the counter and brought out the butter.

"I'll hold this."

"Appreciate you."

I ran outside.

The third man jumped into a stolen delivery car and pulled away hard enough to scatter a row of empty crates. I got into the Last Word, hit the lights, and followed.

Nigga, my wife had given me one item.

One.

The delivery car turned onto the boulevard. Ahead, a slow procession of trucks moved toward the civic plaza. Workers were bringing in equipment for a public celebration I had forgotten to put on my calendar because apparently the city kept finding new reasons to honor me without checking whether I had breakfast plans.

On the largest truck stood a covered statue.

I recognized the shape beneath the sheet.

"Nigga," I muttered.

The thief swerved between the trucks.

I followed, close enough to see him looking at me in the mirror with growing spiritual concern.

He took the next turn too fast.

His car clipped the statue truck's rear corner.

The straps snapped.

The sheet flew off.

A twenty-foot bronze Aiden rolled backward onto its transport platform, one enormous arm pointing at the sky.

Nigga, I looked excellent.

The truck driver braked.

The statue slid toward the open end.

The thief's car stopped beneath its outstretched boot.

He looked up.

Then at me pulling alongside.

Then up again.

"You gotta be fucking kidding me," he said.

I lowered my window.

"Nigga, even my statue caught you."

The statue's boot settled against his hood with a deep metallic groan. The front of the delivery car folded enough to trap it in place. The thief sat frozen behind the windshield while the largest version of my shoe in existence held him politely against the road.

Nobody was hurt.

Several people were already filming.

The nigga opened his door very slowly and raised both hands.

"I surrender."

"To which one of me?"

He stared.

I pointed up at the statue.

"Nigga, jurisdiction complicated today."

The crowd began laughing.

Knox arrived in her own car five minutes later.

She looked at the bronze boot on the stolen vehicle.

Then at me.

Then at the sculptor standing nearby with both hands pressed to his head.

"Captain," she said, "I am glad to see you contributing even while stationary."

"Efficient department."

The thief looked between us.

"Y'all always like this?"

Knox put a hand on his shoulder.

"Unfortunately for your morning, yes."

She took him away.

The sculptor approached me, trembling.

"The heel may be damaged."

I looked up at my bronze face.

"Nigga, the cheekbones survived. We're ahead."

He laughed, then almost cried, then asked whether I would stand beside the statue for a photograph before the recovery crew moved it.

I did.

The crowd cheered.

Somebody shouted, "Niggalicious!"

Three other niggas shouted it back.

I pointed toward them.

"Educated citizens."

My phone rang.

Shawna.

I answered.

"Baby."

"Butter."

"I got it."

"I'm watching a twenty-foot version of you arrest a man on my phone."

"Then you understand the delay."

"Aiden."

"Salted. I remembered."

She tried not to laugh.

I heard her fail.

Nigga, that sound could still make a whole city move to the background.

I went back to the bakery.

Knox's officers had taken the first two men away. The baker stood behind the counter with the butter wrapped in paper and a bag of pastries beside it.

"For your wife," she said.

"She sent me for one thing."

"Tell her I insisted."

"Nigga, excellent witness."

The woman laughed.

I paid, left more than the bill required, and drove home without purchasing the bakery, the block, or any additional part of municipal government.

Growth, if a nigga wanted to call it that.

At the house, Shawna stood in the kitchen wearing one of my shirts and an expression she had clearly been practicing since the video appeared.

I held up the butter.

She looked at it.

Then at the pastries.

Then at me.

"You made it."

"Nigga, against all odds."

She came around the counter and kissed me.

Not because the city had cheered.

Not because a statue of me now required a new heel.

Because I had come through the door and she wanted me close.

I put the groceries down and held her until the pan on the stove reminded us breakfast still existed.

We ate on the terrace.

The garden moved in the breeze. The white horse grazed beyond the fence. Somewhere inside, my phone kept filling with photographs of bronze greatness and one very frightened thief.

I left it there.

Shawna buttered her toast and watched me over her coffee.

"What?" I asked.

"You look happy."

I considered making a joke.

Then I let the simple thing stay simple for one breath.

"I am."

She smiled.

After breakfast, we opened the messages from our friends.

Rosa sent a recording of the new song. Tank could be heard humming badly in the background until she laughed and made him start again.

Cassius and Inez sent a photograph from their racing garage, both fathers standing behind them arguing over a car nobody had asked them to fix. Their first team driver had won a race that morning. Cassius wrote that victory tasted better when the woman beside him stole his champagne afterward.

Liora sent the First Dance above the sea, full of paying passengers and musicians on their way to Sienna's opening

festival. The heart remained on the side. Tank had agreed to share the naming rights with love in general.

June sent the rebuilt Crownless Hotel's front doors. Bernard stood between the two courtyard palms with Magnolia's hand in his. Her cane leaned against his leg. The new sign gleamed behind them.

Vesper sent a photograph from the Blue House. Bastien sat beside Madame Caron, looking annoyed by the camera and pleased by everything else. Noor and Salma had come for dinner with their mother. Nobody in the picture appeared to be awaiting permission to leave.

Victor sent a picture of my academy portrait. The faculty had made it larger.

Nigga, I approved.

Marcellus sent no photograph. He called.

He had opened the workshop early. Sunlight was good at that hour, he said. Blue Mercy shone on his hand while he worked. Celeste's letter remained in the drawer where he could reach it. He had begun teaching two grown apprentices who asked good questions and held their tools badly, a combination he described with obvious delight. Isolde taught dancing in the room above the workshop and came downstairs to steal his coffee, correct his posture, and kiss him before the apprentices could pretend they had not noticed.

"Come by next week," he told us. "I have something for the house."

"Nigga, we got enough jewels."

He laughed.

"A clock. You two are always late."

Shawna took the phone to defend herself.

I listened to them argue and leaned back in my chair.

Gideon and Orson were in prison. Their cases had ended months earlier. Zero lay in a grave in the desert, named plainly, with no throne above him and no unfinished business beneath the stone. The people who had followed him had made their choices, served their sentences, changed their work, or gone home. None of them was waiting in a dark room to become the last page of my life.

The last page was here.

My wife on the terrace.

My brother calling about dinner.

My city loud beyond the walls.

Butter on the table.

Aight, my nigga. Now look at us.

That nigga Tank got a ring on his hand and a woman who makes him dance. That nigga Victor still thinks he can beat me at

something, and I love the nigga enough to let him keep trying. Cassius got Inez beside him, and if that nigga acts surprised one more time when happiness climbs into the passenger seat, I'm charging him for the lesson. Marcellus got his stone, his letter, his good light in the morning. Nigga, the old man got mornings.

Look at my people. My niggas got keys. My niggas got places to put their shoes down without wondering who might make them run. Rosa got a stage and a husband who learns the words.

Mercedes and Porsche got a room with their names over the door, and niggas better behave inside it. June got engines worth arguing with. Liora got a whole fucking sky that doesn't belong to an emperor. Vesper got friends who can tell her when she's being difficult and stay for dinner afterward.

And me?

Nigga, look at me.

I'm still the man who likes the loud car. Still the nigga who sees a crown and wants to know how it looks. Still the captain who should occasionally be supervised by somebody with better judgment and smaller ambitions for a grocery run. I got guns in the safe, money in places a nigga could get lost trying to count, and a city that put my face in bronze before asking whether bronze could handle the responsibility.

I did not become quiet. Nigga, you know me better than that.

I became somebody with a reason to hear the door open.

Because that's my wife coming out onto the terrace now. That's Shawna saying my name. Nigga, the way she says it still does something money never learned. She doesn't say king. She doesn't say captain. She says Aiden like the whole loud motherfucker fits inside a word she can carry without getting tired.

I get up.

She puts her hand in mine.

"What you smiling at?" she asks.

"Nigga," I tell her, "I'm thinking about how good your taste is."

She laughs. The same woman. The same laugh. New morning.

That's my heart, my nigga. Not somewhere precious where nobody can touch it. Right here, warm hand in my hand, telling me I bought too many pastries while eating the second one.

Ten toes down for the niggas who came when I called.

Ten toes down for the women who called me on my shit and loved me with their eyes open.

Ten toes down in the kitchen, in the driveway, beside my brother, beside my wife. Nigga, standing is easy when you finally know where you want to stay.

I came back.

She was here.

And the rest of the morning belonged to us.

Aiden.

Ten toes down. Forever, my nigga.